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# Romans

## Romans 1:1

### Section 1:1–7: Introduction

In this first section, Paul introduced himself and the gospel about Jesus. He also greeted the people to whom he was writing.

Before you begin to translate this section, consider what is the natural way to begin a letter in your language. Consider also how closely to follow that way in your translation.

Consider whether or not you want a section heading here. The GNT, for example, does not have one here. It is good to read or translate this section before you decide on a heading for it. Here are other possible headings for this section:

Paul introduced himself and the gospel about Jesus and greeted the Roman believers

Paul and His Message of Good News (CEV)

Paul began his letter to the Christians in Rome

### 1:1a

#### Paul, a servant of Christ Jesus,

- ¶ From Paul, the Christ/Messiah Jesus' slave,
- ¶ I, Paul, write this letter. I do the work of Jesus, he/who is the Deliverer whom God promised to send.
- ¶ This letter is from me, Paul. I serve Jesus, the one/person whom God appointed to save/rescue people.

**Paul:** The author of this letter is named Paul. He began this letter with his name. This was the normal way to begin a letter at that time in that region.

Paul did not use a sentence here. In some languages it is more natural to introduce the writer in a different way. For example:

From Paul, (CEV)

This letter is from Paul, (NLT)

I, Paul, am writing this letter. I am

**a servant of:** The Greek word that the BSB translates as servant refers to a slave. Here, this phrase indicates that Paul belonged to Jesus as his slave. Paul served

him and completely submitted himself to the authority of Jesus.

People often despised servants or slaves. But when someone called himself a slave of Jesus, as Paul did here, he was not ashamed of it. You may have more than one word to describe servants or slaves. Choose the one that indicates or implies the believer's good relationship to Jesus. That is why many English versions use the word servant instead of slave.

Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

a slave of (NET)

a worker of/for

If you have translated other books, see how you translated this word in Galatians 1:10, Philippians 1:1, Titus 1:1, or James 1:1.

In some languages, it will be best to translate the word servant as a verb. For example:

I serve

I completely submit to

I do the work of

**Christ Jesus:** There is a textual issue here about the order of the words Christ Jesus:

1. The correct order is Christ Jesus. (BSB, NIV, GNT, NJB, NASB, NABRE, ESV, NLT, CEV, NET, REB, NCV)
2. The correct order is Jesus Christ. (RSV, KJV, GW)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1) because the UBS Greek New Testament supports it. The UB5 says that the order Christ Jesus "is almost certain."

The order of the words Christ Jesus emphasizes that Jesus is the Christ/Messiah. However, in some languages the order Christ Jesus is not natural. If that is true in your language, emphasize, if possible, the fact that Jesus is the Christ in a natural way. For example:

Jesus, who/he is the Christ

Jesus, the Messiah,

**Christ:** This name is spelled "Christos" in the Greek language. (The Greek sound spelled 'ch' here is similar

to a 'k' but without making the air stop in the mouth.) Spell the name as people in your language say it, or use the name from the common language in your region.

The word Christ was used as a title. It was the Greek translation of the Hebrew word "Messiah." It means "the anointed one." In the Jewish culture a person was anointed by pouring oil on top of his head in a ceremony. This was done to show that God chose him for a special task/job. In the Old Testament, some were anointed to be priests, some to be kings, and some to be prophets. In the Old Testament, "the anointed one" refers to the person whom God promised would save/free his people and rule them. For example, see Isaiah 61:1 and Psalm 2.

Here are other ways to translate Christ:

- Use a title or a descriptive phrase in your language that has the same meaning as Christ. For example:

God's Anointed/Chosen One

the Messiah

Promised Deliverer

the Rescuer-King whom God appointed

- Transliterate Christ and include a phrase that explains the meaning. For example:

Karisiti, the appointed one

Cristo, the King whom God promised to send

- Transliterate Christ and indicate in some way that it is a title. For example:

the Kirisita

If you do not indicate the meaning of Christ in your translation, you may want to include a footnote to explain it. For example:

The word/title "Christ" refers to the one whom God had promised to send. He would be both king and savior.

Or you may want to explain the meaning in a glossary.

## 1:1b

### called to be an apostle,

- his appointed/authorized apostle,
- He called me, and I became his representative/apostle.
- He chose me as his special messenger/envoy.

**called to be an apostle:** The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as called to be an apostle is literally "(a) called apostle." Here the word called means "chosen to be given a special benefit or purpose." God invited Paul to do the work of an apostle (1 Timothy 1:1). Here are other ways to translate this word:

his appointed apostle

an apostle by God's call/choice

Some languages must use a verb here. For example:

called as an apostle (NASB)

called by God to be an apostle (REB)

God invited me to be an apostle

an apostle whom he/God chose

**an apostle:** The Greek word that the BSB translates as apostle means a "representative" or "messenger." It refers to a person whom someone sends with his authority. He is sent to give a message or accomplish a particular task. Here, the word apostle refers to Paul whom Jesus sent as his messenger. Paul's message was the gospel about Jesus. Here are other ways to translate apostle:

- Translate the meaning. For example:

his/Jesus' special representative

Christ's/his messenger

a man whom Jesus Christ sent (on a mission)

a person with authority from Jesus Christ to do his work

- Use the common word for the word apostle if it is already in use. For example:

apostol

Use the same term for apostle as you used in the Gospels. (See Mark 6:30 or Luke 6:13.) Be sure that the term you choose for apostle is different from your terms for prophet (1:2) and angel (8:38).

### 1:1c

#### and set apart for the gospel of God—

- and put/placed in a special position to preach the good news that is from God.
- He chose me to tell people his good message that God announced.
- He caused me to dedicate all my life in preaching/telling the joyful news about Jesus, which God proclaimed/sent.

This clause also describes Paul (1:1a). God set him apart for the preaching of the gospel. In Greek and the BSB, the sentence continues from 1:1b. But in some languages, a new sentence would be more clear. For example:

God set me apart for his gospel

**set apart for the gospel of God:** The phrase set apart indicates that God chose Paul from among a group of people to do a specific task. He chose Paul to be a messenger to tell the gospel to the non-Jews (1:5). Here are other ways to translate these words:

separated to serve the gospel of God

he/Jesus/God caused me to dedicate all my life for the gospel of God

This clause is passive. Some languages must use an active clause. For example:

God set me apart for the gospel about Jesus

See how you translated the phrase set apart in Acts 13:2 or Galatians 1:15.

**for:** Here the word for introduces a purpose clause. God set Paul apart from other work for the purpose of preaching or sharing the gospel. Here are other ways to translate for:

in order that

The reason he chose me to be an apostle was so that  
Western Bukidnon Manobo Back Translation on TW.

to speak/tell God's good news  
Otomi Back Translation on TW.

**the gospel of God:** The Greek word that the BSB translates as gospel means “good news” or “announcement of a message that people consider very good.” Here, it refers to the good news that God sent Jesus to save us from wrongdoing and reconcile us to God. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

good/sweet news from God

God's message/report that causes joy

good news about Jesus Christ that God sent

**of God:** The word of here indicates that the gospel is from God. See the examples above.

## Romans 1:2

### Section 1:1–7: Introduction

In this first section, Paul introduced himself and the gospel about Jesus. He also greeted the people to whom he was writing.

Before you begin to translate this section, consider what is the natural way to begin a letter in your language. Consider also how closely to follow that way in your translation.

Consider whether or not you want a section heading here. The GNT, for example, does not have one here. It is good to read or translate this section before you decide on a heading for it. Here are other possible headings for this section:

Paul introduced himself and the gospel about Jesus and greeted the Roman believers

Paul and His Message of Good News (CEV)

Paul began his letter to the Christians in Rome

### 1:2–4

In 1:1 Paul said that his work was to tell the gospel from God. Then in 1:2–4 he told some details about that gospel. In the Greek and the BSB, the sentence



continues from 1:1c. But in some languages, a new sentence would be more clear. For example:

He promised it beforehand...

### 1:2a–b

**the gospel He promised beforehand through His prophets in the Holy Scriptures:** The words that the BSB translates as the gospel He promised beforehand is literally “which he [previously] promised.” The BSB supplies the word gospel to clearly show that this clause further describes the gospel mentioned in 1:1c. It does not separate this gospel from other gospels. Another way to translate this phrase is to make it a separate sentence. For example:

He promised it beforehand through his prophets in the holy Scriptures.

### 1:2a

**the gospel He promised beforehand**

- He promised it long ago
- This good message he/God promised to the Jews in old times,
- Regarding this joyful news, God/he promised to his people Israel long/very long ago to show it.

**He promised beforehand:** This clause indicates that long ago God promised to send the Messiah, who the Messiah would be, what he would do, and what would happen to him. All those things are the gospel of the Messiah. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

that he promised long ago (CEV)

This good news God promised in old timesYakan  
Back Translation on TW.

### 1:2b

**through His prophets in the Holy Scriptures,**

- by means of his prophets in the holy Scriptures
- and he caused his spokesmen for God to write it in his very own, special Book.
- He told/commanded it to the Jewish prophets and they wrote it in his sacred Book.

**through His prophets:** The word through indicates that God gave messages about the gospel to the prophets for them to tell the people. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

by means of his prophets

by telling his prophets what to write

which he caused-to-be-written by the prophets through-whom-he-spokeKankanaey Back Translation on TW.

**prophets:** The word prophets refers to people who speak on behalf of God. God’s message (often called a “prophecy”) may be in words or visions. A prophet then tells the people God’s message. It may reveal something about a past, present, or future event, or it may reveal someone’s thoughts, motives, or attitudes. It is not like a sermon, prepared by the preacher’s study of the Bible, but God may inspire a preacher with a prophecy during a sermon. The person speaks the prophecy to the people or writes it down for their use. Here are other ways to translate the word prophets:

- Translate the meaning. For example:

spokespeople for God

those who speak/bring God’s message/words

God’s message-speakers

- If the translated meaning of prophets is unclear, use the major language word. For example:

porofets

It is good to use a general term that does not focus only on foretelling the future. Although prophets did foretell the future, they also gave people other messages from God. They especially told them to stop doing what is wrong and to obey God.

Be sure that the term you choose for prophet (1:2b) is different from your terms for apostle (1:1b), angel (8:38), and preach (1:15).

**the Holy Scriptures:** The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as Holy Scriptures refers to the books of the Old Testament.

Here are other ways to translate the Holy Scriptures:

the sacred writings of God

the writings which are holy

God’s special message that they wrote

**Holy:** The word Holy in this context means “sacred” or “originates from God.” Holy is used here to emphasize that these Scriptures come from God and therefore, are trustworthy and have God’s authority. See above examples.

## Romans 1:3

### Section 1:1–7: Introduction

In this first section, Paul introduced himself and the gospel about Jesus. He also greeted the people to whom he was writing.

Before you begin to translate this section, consider what is the natural way to begin a letter in your language. Consider also how closely to follow that way in your translation.

Consider whether or not you want a section heading here. The GNT, for example, does not have one here. It is good to read or translate this section before you decide on a heading for it. Here are other possible headings for this section:

Paul introduced himself and the gospel about Jesus and greeted the Roman believers

Paul and His Message of Good News (CEV)

Paul began his letter to the Christians in Rome

### 1:3a–4c

In these two verses, Paul told what the gospel from God is about. The gospel is about Jesus. Here are four things Paul said about the gospel in 1:3–4.

1. God’s Son became a human being.
2. His Son was a descendant of King David.
3. After God’s Son died, God made him alive again and appointed him to be in a position of power as the Son of God.
4. The name of God’s Son is Jesus. He is the Christ, and he is our Lord.

### 1:3a

#### regarding His Son,

- regarding his Son. (NIV)
- It is about his Son. (GNT)
- This/That good news is about his eternal/divine Son.

**regarding His Son:** This phrase connects to the word gospel in 1:1c, which the BSB repeats in 1:2a. Here this phrase does not connect to “the holy Scriptures” in 1:2b. In some languages the connection back to 1:1c will need to be made explicit. For example:

the gospel concerning his Son

In the Greek, the sentence continues from 1:2b. In some languages it would be more natural to begin a new sentence here. For example:

The/That gospel concerns his Son

**regarding:** This word indicates that this gospel is about God’s Son, Jesus. Here are other ways to translate this word:

concerning (ESV)

about (NLT)

**His Son:** The phrase His Son refers to Jesus. He is God’s Son. It indicates that the relationship between God and Jesus is similar to the relationship of human fathers and their sons. They have a Father-Son kind of relationship. They love each other, and sons obey their fathers. This term also implies that Jesus has the same nature as God.

God does not have a physical body, and he did not cause Jesus to exist the way a human father causes a son to exist. Jesus existed eternally as the Son with his Father.

In some languages a literal translation gives the wrong meaning. If that is true in your language, you may want to:

- Translate literally and explain its correct meaning in a footnote. Here is an example footnote:

This title refers to Jesus. It indicates the relationship between God and Jesus is similar to the relationship of human fathers and sons. It also implies that Jesus and God are the same kind of being. Jesus has been God’s Son for all eternity.

- Explain its meaning of an eternal relationship of a son to a father. For example:

his divine/heavenly Son

the eternal Most Beloved of God as a Son

In some languages there is no single word for Son. If that is true in your language, use a more general word, such as “child.” For example:

his Child

the Child of God

Other verses will usually make clear that Jesus was a male child. If you use a descriptive phrase such as “male child of God,” be sure that this phrase does not imply that God had another child who was female.

### General Comment on 1:2a–3a

1:2a–b is extra information about the gospel. In 1:3a he resumed his discussion about the gospel from 1:1c. In some languages the extra information must be in a separate sentence. Consider how to indicate that in your translation. For example:

<sup>1c</sup>sent out to preach his Good News. <sup>2a</sup>God promised this Good News long ago <sup>2b</sup>through his prophets in the holy Scriptures. <sup>3a</sup>The Good News is about his Son. (NLT)

### 1:3b

**who was a descendant of David according to the flesh,**

- As to his humanity, the great ruler David was his ancestor.
- As a human, he was a descendant of Israel’s King David of long ago.
- He came as a man, born in King David’s royal family line.

**who was a descendant of David:** Here the Greek clause is literally “the one having come from the seed/ semen of David.” For example:

the one born from the seed of David

the one descended from David

This clause further describes God’s Son. It does not separate this Son from other Sons. For the correct meaning in some languages, translators must avoid the word who. For example:

He was a descendant of David.

He was born of David’s line.

He descended from David.

**was a descendant of David:** Jesus was born in the family line of David many generations later (Matthew 1:2–16, Luke 3:23–31). Some languages have a term to refer to ancestors from the distant past.

**David:** The Greek spelling of this name is Daudid. David was a great king. He ruled over Israel about one thousand years before Jesus was born. Here are other ways to translate David:

King David of old

King Da’udYakan Back Translation on TW.

the great ruler David long ago

**according to:** Here, this phrase means “with regard to.” When considering Jesus’ human ancestors, he was of the line of King David. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

as to (GNT)

with reference to (NET)

in terms of (NJB)

**the flesh:** Here the word that the BSB translates as the flesh refers to the physical part of the life of people. Here it refers to the human origin of Jesus. Edwards (page 29) says, “The Greek word for ‘flesh’ (NIV, human nature) is often in Paul used pejoratively to imply human weakness, fallibility, and sin. But there are instances where Paul uses the term to mean ‘human existence’ without any negative reference, and this appears to be one of them.” Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

a man (NCV)

his humanity (GNT)

a human (CEV)

And as for this Jesus, he became a humanWestern Bukidnon Manobo Back Translation on TW.

## Romans 1:4

### Section 1:1–7: Introduction

In this first section, Paul introduced himself and the gospel about Jesus. He also greeted the people to whom he was writing.

Before you begin to translate this section, consider what is the natural way to begin a letter in your language. Consider also how closely to follow that way in your translation.

Consider whether or not you want a section heading here. The GNT, for example, does not have one here. It is good to read or translate this section before you decide on a heading for it. Here are other possible headings for this section:

Paul introduced himself and the gospel about Jesus and greeted the Roman believers

Paul and His Message of Good News (CEV)

Paul began his letter to the Christians in Rome

### 1:4a

#### and who through the Spirit of holiness was declared with power to be the Son of God

- And, with regard to the Spirit of holiness, he/Jesus was appointed by God as the Son of God in power
- But, with reference to the Holy Spirit who purifies us<sup>(incl)</sup>, God designated him/Jesus as the Son of God in a new and powerful way
- But/And, in connection with the Holy Spirit who makes us consecrated to God, God gave new power to his/Jesus' position as his Son
- (reordered) And he/Jesus was appointed by God as the Son of God in power with regard to the Spirit of holiness,
- (reordered) And God designated him/Jesus as the Son of God in a new and powerful way, with reference to the Holy Spirit who purifies us<sup>(incl)</sup>,
- (reordered) But/And he/God gave new power to his/Jesus' position as his Son, in connection with the Holy Spirit who makes us consecrated to God,

**and:** Some languages may see Jesus' status as God's Son to contrast with his status as a human. For example:

But (NCV)

**who...was declared with power to be the Son of God:** There are two issues here:

### Issue 1: Interpretation

There are three ways to interpret the Greek word that the RSV translates as was declared:

1. Here this word means appoint or designate. As his Son, God appointed Jesus to a new position of power and authority as Savior, Lord, and Judge. For example:

was appointed the Son-of-God-in-power (NET) (RSV, NJB, NIV11, NET, NABRE, NCV)

1. Here this word means declare. God made known to others who Jesus already was. For example:

who was declared the Son of God with power (NASB) (BSB, NIV, NASB, ESV, NRSV, KJV, REB, GW)

1. Here this word means show clearly or prove. God showed to others by some action who Jesus already was. For example:

he was shown with great power to be the Son of God (GNT) (GNT, CEV, NLT)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1), because the verb means “set limits” and the figurative use from that is “appoint.” Kittel (page 728). Cranfield (pages 61–62) says, “It came to be used very frequently with the meaning, ‘fix,’ ‘determine,’ ‘appoint’; and this is the sense it has in all its other occurrences in the NT. No clear example, either earlier than, or contemporary with, the NT, of its use in the sense ‘declare’ or ‘show to be’ has been adduced.” The verb does not refer to a speech act such as “declare” or an act of proving something.

### Issue 2: Connection of with power

There are several ways to interpret how the words with power connect to the rest of the sentence:

1. It connects to the words the Son of God. At the resurrection the Son of God had new power. For example:

was appointed the Son-of-God-in-powerThe NET uses hyphens (-) to show that those words with hyphens are connected to each other. (NET) (RSV, NJB, NIV11, NASB, NABRE, ESV, CEV, NET, KJV, NCV)

1. It connects to the Greek verb that means was declared. It indicates that God powerfully designated Jesus to be the Son of God. For example:

was declared with power to be the Son of God (NIV) (BSB, NIV, GNT, GW)

1. It connects to the Holy Spirit. The Holy Spirit worked powerfully when God designated Jesus to be the Son of God. For example:

he was shown to be the Son of God when he was raised from the dead by the power of the Holy Spirit (NLT) (NLT)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1), because it is the most natural connection in the Greek. Edwards (pages 29–30) says, “The resurrection, however, separates the two stages or time periods. It is a dividing line not in Jesus’ status as Son of God, but in his function as Son of God. As seed of David Jesus was the Son in humility; as Son of God in power he enters his role as exalted Lord. At the resurrection Jesus was constituted Son of God in power, whereas before the resurrection he had been Son of God in suffering. Thus, verses 3–4 are not about Jesus’ promotion or adoption as God’s Son. Both parts of the formula are **regarding** God’s **Son** (v.3), but God’s Son in two manifestations: as servant and Lord, in humiliation and exaltation, in earthly ministry and heavenly reign.” Cranfield, Fee, Fitzmyer, Hultgren, Matera, Moo, Morris, Nygren, Osborne, Schreiner, Stott, Talbert, Vanlaningham, Witherington, and Ziesler also support interpretation (1). Here are other ways to translate this phrase according to interpretation (1):

who was appointed the Son of God in a new and powerful way

was established as the empowered Son of God

**was declared:** This verb has the same subject as 1:3b: “the one” in the Greek. This clause indicates a second thing about the Son of God (1:3a). In some languages the subject must be repeated here. For example, the BSB supplies the word “who” at the beginning of 1:4a. This clause is also passive. Some languages must use an active clause here. For example:

God designated/appointed him

**the Son of God:** Here the phrase the Son of God refers to the same person as “his Son” in 1:3a. For example:

God’s Son/Child

God’s divine/heavenly Son

If you need to, see the note on “his Son” at 1:3 for more explanation.

**through:** There are two ways to interpret the Greek word that the BSB translates as through here:

1. It means according to or with regard to here. For example:

according to (RSV) (RSV, GNT, NJB, NASB, ESV, KJV, NET, REB, GW)

1. It means through or by means of here. For example:

through the Spirit of holiness (NIV) (BSB, NIV, NLT, NABRE, NCV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1) because the sense of meaning given in interpretation (2) is extremely rare and the context is not correct for it here. The only phrase in the entire Greek New Testament which interprets kata with accusative case as “through” or “by means of” occurs in Matthew 1:20, 2:12, 2:13, 2:19, 2:22, and 27:19. The same phrase “in a dream” (kat onar) occurs in each of these six verses. But the use of kata here does not involve a dream. Cranfield (page 64) says, “we are inclined to think that the most probable explanation is that which (taking kata as meaning ‘according to’) understands the phrase to refer to the Holy Spirit, who, as given by the exalted Christ, is the manifestation of His power and majesty, and so the guarantee of his having been appointed Son of God in might.” Young (pages 98–99) says, “The idea of ‘with regard to’ is expressed by kata with the accusative in Romans 1:3–4.” Young also does not include “means” as an option for any occurrence of kata. Also see Fee (pages 480–481). Here are other ways to translate the Greek word that the BSB translates as through:

as to (GNT)

with reference to

in terms of (NJB)

The same phrase “according to” is used in 1:3b. If possible, translate “according to” the same in both places.

**the Spirit of holiness:** There are four ways to interpret the phrase the Spirit of holiness here:

1. Here the word Spirit refers to God's Spirit (the Holy Spirit), and the words of holiness indicates that he causes believers to be holy (or caused Jesus to be holy while he was on earth). For example:

the Spirit of holiness (RSV) (BSB, RSV, NIV, NJB, NASB, ESV, NCV)

1. Here the word Spirit refers to God's Spirit, and the words of holiness indicates that he is holy. For example:

the Holy Spirit (NET) (NET, REB, CEV, NLT)

1. Here the word Spirit indicates that Jesus is God and the words of holiness indicates that Jesus is holy. For example:

his divine holiness (GNT) (GNT)

1. Here the word Spirit refers to Jesus' own human spirit, and the words of holiness indicates that his spirit is characterized by holiness. For example:

the spirit of holiness (NRSV) (NRSV, GW, NABRE, KJV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1), because the Greek word translated of holiness here is not the normal word used in the phrase "Holy Spirit." Something more than the normal meaning of "Holy Spirit" seems indicated here. Cranfield (page 64) says, "Paul may well have used *hagiōsunēs* in order to bring out specially the thought of sanctification." Jewett (page 107) says, "The key to the new ethic is giving oneself as a holy sacrifice for others (12:1). In this sense, the insertion of the term 'holiness' prepares the reader for a major emphasis in the letter." There are several instances in Paul's writings of the phrase "the Spirit who gives/supplies [something]." Interpretation (1) is another instance of a phrase like that. See John 15:26, Rom 8:2, Eph 1:17, 2 Tim 1:7.

**the Spirit:** Here the word Spirit refers to the Spirit of God, usually called the Holy Spirit. Use the same word for Spirit as you have in other books where you have translated "Holy Spirit" (for example: Matthew 1:18, Mark 1:8, Luke 1:15, or John 1:33).

**of:** The word of here can indicate that:

1. The Spirit causes believers to be holy. See Wallace (page 106) genitive of product [which produces]. He mentions Romans 1:5 "(perhaps)" as an example of

this genitive category. He does not list Romans 1:5 under any other genitive category. He lists "the God of hope" (Romans 15:13), "the God of peace" (Romans 15:33), and "the God of steadfastness and of encouragement" (Romans 15:5) as clear examples of the genitive of product. Therefore, it makes good sense to include "the Spirit of holiness" under this category.

2. The Spirit is characterized by holiness. See Wallace (page 79), descriptive genitive. He also says that this category should only be used when no other category fits. But the descriptive genitive is possible here.

Here the Greek language allows either interpretation, as does the English word of. If possible translate in a way that allows either interpretation. But if you must choose, choose interpretation (1). Fee (page 484) says, "the Spirit who gives/supplies holiness...anticipates much of the argument of the rest of the letter.... If Christ is both the content and therefore the source of the gospel, offering 'God's righteousness' freely to all who trust him, then the Spirit...is not simply the Holy Spirit, but the Spirit of holiness itself—the one who effects the 'righteousness of God' in the lives of the believing community, Jew and Gentile together, in terms of their individual and corporate behavior." Moo (on TW), Jewett (pages 106–107), and Wallace (pages 250–251) also support interpretation (1). For example:

he/who produces

he/who causes

**holiness:** Here the Greek word that the BSB translates as holiness refers to living a good, morally pure life and being free from sin. The Holy Spirit causes believers to live this kind of life. Moo (on TW) says that the new era is "characterized by righteousness, life, and the...gift of the Holy Spirit." Jewett (pages 106–107) says that "holiness" is about moral obligations, and that "such obligations are developed at length in Romans 5–8. In this sense, the insertion of the term 'holiness' prepares the reader for a major emphasis in the letter." Here are other ways to translate it:

be set apart from sin

spiritual purity

moral integrity in us

us to depart from evil

#### 1:4b

##### by His resurrection from the dead:

- from the resurrection of him from the dead.
- by the means of raising him to life again from the dead.
- when he/God caused him to leave the spirits of dead people and be alive again.

**by:** Here the Greek word that the BSB translates as by is literally “from.” Here it probably indicates that God raising Jesus from the dead was the way that God appointed him as the powerful Son of God. Here are other ways to translate this word:

through

by means of

It is also possible that “from” means “when” or “because” here. But by seems most likely. Fee (page 481) says, “Jesus came from the lineage of David (and) was declared Son of God with power from (=stemming from; on the basis of) his resurrection from the dead.” Also, 8:11 indicates that the Spirit is the means by which God raised Jesus from the dead (Kruse, page 46).

**His resurrection from the dead:** The BSB adds the word His here. It is implied from the context. God made Jesus alive again after he was dead. He raised Jesus back to life out from among those who are dead. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

he was raised from death (CEV)

raising him from the dead

causing him to live again after he had died

When God caused Jesus to live again, he had the same identity that he had before he died. The same thing is true for this word in the Bible when referring to other people. The Greek word “anastasis” and the English word resurrection do not imply that a person will live again as a different person or as an animal.

**from the dead:** The word from here indicates that God makes a dead person alive and takes him away from the place where the spirits of dead people live. Wallace (pages 107–109). For example:

out of the realm of the dead

Also see the examples above.

#### 1:4c

##### Jesus Christ our Lord.

- That person is Jesus, the Christ/Messiah, our<sup>(incl)</sup> Lord.
- He is our Master/Leader Jesus, the Deliverer/Rescuer!

This phrase names who the “Son of God” (1:4a) is. In the Greek and the BSB the sentence continues from 1:4b. In some languages, making that connection explicit here would be more natural or more clear. For example:

the Son of God is Jesus Christ our Lord

In the Greek and the BSB, the sentence continues from 1:4b. In some languages beginning a new sentence would be more natural or more clear. For example:

He is Jesus Christ our Lord

**Jesus Christ our Lord:** In some languages it may be more natural to use a different order for the words here. For example:

our Lord Jesus Christ (GNT)

the Messiah Jesus, he/who is our Lord

**Jesus Christ:** Remember that Christ is a title, not Jesus’ last name. See how you translated Christ in 1:1.

**our Lord:** By using the word our, Paul indicated a relationship between Jesus and Paul as well as those who believe in him.

**Lord:** This word refers to someone who has authority over people. Here it indicates that Jesus has authority over believers. Here are other ways to translate this word:

Chief/Leader

the Sovereign

#### General Comment on 1:3a–4d

Some English versions move 1:4c, “Jesus Christ our Lord” to directly after 1:3a, “concerning his Son.” They do this in order to clearly connect his name and title

to the phrase “his Son.” Consider where the best place is to put 1:4c in your language. For example:

<sup>3</sup>It is about his Son, our Lord Jesus Christ: as to his humanity, he was born a descendant of David; <sup>4</sup>as to his divine holiness, he was shown with great power to be the Son of God by being raised from death. (GNT)

<sup>3-4</sup>The Good News is about God’s Son, Jesus Christ our Lord. As a man, he was born from the family of David. But through the Spirit of holiness he was appointed to be God’s Son with great power by rising from the dead. (NCV)

If you move 1:4c to after 1:3a, then combine the verse numbering to <sup>3-4</sup>.

## Romans 1:5

### Section 1:1–7: Introduction

In this first section, Paul introduced himself and the gospel about Jesus. He also greeted the people to whom he was writing.

Before you begin to translate this section, consider what is the natural way to begin a letter in your language. Consider also how closely to follow that way in your translation.

Consider whether or not you want a section heading here. The GNT, for example, does not have one here. It is good to read or translate this section before you decide on a heading for it. Here are other possible headings for this section:

Paul introduced himself and the gospel about Jesus and greeted the Roman believers

Paul and His Message of Good News (CEV)

Paul began his letter to the Christians in Rome

### 1:5a

#### Through Him and on behalf of His name,

- Through whom/him, to make his name great,
- This will cause all people to honor Jesus Christ: through him,
- To make his name great, God enabled him

Paul talked about the gospel in 1:2a–1:4c. In 1:5a he again discussed more about himself and his work for Jesus. But he connected his next words to “Jesus

Christ our Lord” with “through Him.” In the Greek, the sentence continues. However, the BSB begins a new sentence here. In some languages, a new sentence here would be more natural or more clear. For example:

Through him we have received... (NABRE)

**Through Him and on behalf of His name:** The phrase that the BSB translates as Through Him is literally “through whom.” This clause further describes Jesus. It does not separate this Jesus from other men named Jesus. For the correct meaning in some languages, translators must avoid the word “whom.” The word Through indicates that Paul received grace and apostleship by means of Jesus. God enabled Jesus to give Paul grace and apostleship. Here are other ways to translate this word:

by the authority given to him he gave to us

God enabled him to give us

God gave power to Jesus and so he/Jesus was kind to us and gave us the work of being apostles

**on behalf of His name:** This phrase refers to helping, causing advantage for, or honoring the one named. The apostles taught others about Jesus, spread the news of Jesus, and did good deeds in his name.

In some languages it is more natural to say “him” instead of His name here. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

for the honor of his name (GW)

for him (NCV)

to benefit him

This phrase connects to the end of the clause (1:5c). For example:

...<sup>5c</sup>of winning the obedience of faith among all the nations <sup>5a</sup>for the honour of his name (NJB)

### 1:5b

#### we received grace and apostleship

- we<sup>(excl)</sup> received the grace/gift to be his apostles,



- God was kind to us by making us his apostles/representatives,
- to give us the privilege/gift of becoming his special messengers,

**we received:** In English, the word received implies someone gave what was received. The English word “take” does not imply that someone gave it. It is implied here that God graciously gave Paul and others apostleship.

Many languages have the same word for both “receive” and “take.” In some of those languages a literal translation would wrongly indicate that God did not graciously give apostleship but Paul just took it. If that is true in your language, you should use “give” here. For example:

have been given

he has given

**we:** Sometimes in NT letters, the writer referred to himself with we instead of “I.” There are two ways to interpret the word we here:

1. Paul referred to himself and others. For example:

we (NET) (BSB, RSV, NIV, NJB, NASB, NABRE, ESV, KJV, NET, GW, NLT)

1. Paul referred to himself. For example:

I (REB) (GNT, NCV, CEV, REB)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1), because Paul consistently used the first person singular to refer to his apostolic mission in the rest of Romans, but he used we here instead. So, he probably had a reason not to use “I” here. Dunn (page 16) says, “Somewhat unexpectedly (in view of v 1) Paul links others with himself—we received. He does not regard himself as the sole apostle to the Gentiles, which would in any case have been a difficult position to maintain in writing to a largely Gentile church which he had not founded.” Barrett, Cranfield, Jewett, Fitzmyer, Stott, Schreiner, and Witherington also support interpretation (1).

**grace and apostleship:** There are two ways to interpret the phrase grace and apostleship:

1. This is a figure of speech that means gracious apostleship. In kindness, God made Paul and others apostles. For example:

the privilege of being an apostle (GNT) (GNT, NABRE, REB, NCV)

1. This is not a figure of speech, but refers to two things, grace and apostleship. For example:

grace and apostleship (RSV) (BSB, RSV, NIV, NJB, NASB, ESV, KJV, NET, GW, CEV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1), because Paul was establishing his apostleship in these verses and not speaking generally of God’s grace to us. The technical word for the figure of speech in interpretation (1) is hendiadys. The American Heritage Dictionary of the English Language says, “Hendiadys is a figure of speech in which two words connected by a conjunction are used to express a single notion that would normally be expressed by an adjective and a substantive.” Many scholars support interpretation (1). For example, Cranfield (pages 65–66) says that it is not necessary for Paul to write that he has received grace in a general sense at this point in Romans. Instead Paul wrote about his authority as an apostle and that he received it not because of any merit of his own. Here are other ways to translate this phrase according to interpretation (1):

the free gift of apostleship

the grace that enabled us to be apostles

the privilege and authority as apostles (NLT)

he was kind, giving us the work of apostles

**grace:** This word refers to kindness that is given to people without requiring anything in return. This kindness is not given because they have done anything to deserve it. See the examples above.

**apostleship:** The word apostleship refers to the work that an apostle does. For example:

to be an/his apostle

becoming his special representative

See how you translated “apostle” in 1:1.

**1:5c**

**to call all those among the Gentiles to the obedience that comes from faith.**

- so that people among the non-Jews would believe the good news and therefore obey him/Christ.
- in order that people would obey him/Jesus because they believe in him, including those among all people groups who are not Jews.
- so that the Gentiles' faith causes them to obey it.

**to call...to...obedience:** The word to introduces the purpose of being an apostle: to call the Gentiles to obey the gospel of Jesus. The phrase that the BSB translates as to call...to...obedience is literally "unto/ to obedience." Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

for the obedience of those among the Gentiles

so that the people among the Gentiles would obey

to lead people...to...obey (GNT)

**all those among the Gentiles:** This phrase connects to the phrase "the obedience of faith." For example:

the obedience of faith among all the nations for the honour of his name (NJB)

There are two ways to interpret the Greek word that the BSB translates as Gentiles here:

1. It refers to all people groups, excluding the Jews. For example:

all the Gentiles (NIV) (NIV, BSB, NASB, NRSV, NABRE, NET, NLT)

1. It means all people groups, including the Jews. For example:

all the nations (RSV) (RSV, NJB, GNT, ESV, KJV, REB, NCV, GW, CEV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1), because 1:6 has "in whom you<sup>(plur)</sup>" in the Greek, which seems to indicate only some of those in "To all those in Rome" (1:7). Cranfield (page 67).

**Gentiles:** The Greek word that the BSB translates as Gentiles refers to ethnic groups or people groups rather than to political states or countries. An ethnic group is a group of people who consider themselves a group because they share the same physical appearance, language, religion, culture, and history, or

because they share two or more of these things. In modern times it is very common for borders of countries to pass directly through an area where an ethnic group lives, so that the ethnic group (in the way that Luke was using the Greek word) lives in two "nations" (using the sense of the word as used today). Here are other ways to translate this word:

tribes

peoples

peoples of one language/culture

**the obedience that comes from faith:** The phrase that the BSB translates as the obedience that comes from faith is literally "the obedience of faith." There are three main ways to interpret the words "the obedience of faith" here:

1. It indicates that faith is a basis. In this TN, "basis" refers to the situation out of which something arises. It is sometimes called "grounds." It does not indicate direct cause, as a reason-result relationship between clauses does. For the obedience, Faith produces obedience. See Wallace (pages 104–106) for his category of "Genitive of Production/ Producer." People obey because they believe. For example:

the obedience that comes from faith (NIV) (NIV, BSB)

1. It indicates that a person obeys all the teachings connected to faith. For example:

obedience to the faith (KJV) (KJV, JBP)

1. It means and faith. For example:

believe and obey (GNT) (GNT, NLT, CEV, REB, NCV)

The RSV, the NJB, and a number of English versions translate the Greek as "the obedience of faith." Both the Greek and that English translation are ambiguous, possibly meaning either interpretation (1) or (2). A number of scholars say that Paul meant several things here. Kruse (page 52) says, "care must be taken not to assume that faith consisting in obedience can be separated from faith expressing itself in obedience." Schreiner (page 35) says, "The two most likely options are...the obedience that springs from or flows from

faith...or ‘the obedience that is faith.’...Paul may have intended both ideas, and this is the most likely solution.” Garlington (1991, PhD thesis, in Kruse, page 52) says that “faith’s obedience” or “believing obedience” are better translations of this phrase and preserve the intended ambiguity. Stott also supports two interpretations. Hanna and Witherington support interpretation (1).

So if you can translate in a way that allows interpretation (1) or (2), you should do so. However, if you must make a choice, it is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). Paul did not say “and” even though he could have. So, interpretation (3) is not likely. The Greek phrase uses “faith” not “the faith,” so interpretation (2) is less likely than interpretation (1). Here are other ways to translate this phrase according to interpretation (1):

the obedience produced by faith

obedience based on faith

people obey Christ because they believe the message about him

believing obedience

faith’s obedience

**obedience:** This word means “doing as told, directed, or asked.” In some languages a verb is required or more natural here. For example:

obey him

follow him

**faith:** To have faith in a person refers to believing in him, who he is, and who he claims to be.

In some languages a verb is required or more natural here. For example:

believe the gospel

believing it

### 1:5a–c

**(reordered) so that people of all non-Jewish ethnic groups would believe in him and therefore obey him in order that his name would become great.**

- (reordered) in order that people among all tribes not Jewish would obey him/Jesus because they believe in him. This will cause them to honor him.

## Romans 1:6

### Section 1:1–7: Introduction

In this first section, Paul introduced himself and the gospel about Jesus. He also greeted the people to whom he was writing.

Before you begin to translate this section, consider what is the natural way to begin a letter in your language. Consider also how closely to follow that way in your translation.

Consider whether or not you want a section heading here. The GNT, for example, does not have one here. It is good to read or translate this section before you decide on a heading for it. Here are other possible headings for this section:

Paul introduced himself and the gospel about Jesus and greeted the Roman believers

Paul and His Message of Good News (CEV)

Paul began his letter to the Christians in Rome

### 1:6

**And you also are among those who are called to belong to Jesus Christ.**

- You also are from those groups, and you have been called to be the people of Jesus, the Christ/Messiah.
- And you yourselves are from many of those tribes, and God has summoned you to have a relationship with Jesus, the Deliverer/Savior.

**And you also are among:** Here Paul indicated that the believers in Rome were also a part of “all the Gentiles” in 1:5d. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

among whom are you<sup>(plur)</sup> also

And you are included among them

This also includes you who are in Rome (GNT)

**those who are called to belong to Jesus Christ:** The Greek phrase is literally “called (ones) of Jesus Christ.” It further describes “you,” and refers to all of the believers in Rome. It does not separate some people called “you” here from other people called “you” here. For the correct meaning in some languages, translators must avoid the word who. For example:

and you are called to belong to Jesus Christ

God has called you to belong to Jesus Christ

**those who are called:** This clause is passive. Some languages must use an active clause here. For example:

whom God called

**called:** Here the word called means “chosen to be given a special benefit or purpose.” God invited people in Rome to believe in Jesus and therefore belong to Jesus. Here are other ways to translate this word:

appointed

chosen ones

**to belong to Jesus Christ:** The Greek phrase is literally “of Jesus Christ.” Here it indicates a relationship with Jesus Christ. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

to be joined to Jesu CristoKankanaey Back Translation on TW.

to be siblings of Jesus Christ

### General Comment on 1:5a–6

In the Greek NT in 1:5a–c, the phrase “to the obedience of faith” is first, then “all those among the Gentiles,” then “on behalf of His name.” This more clearly connects “all those among the Gentiles” to “to the obedience of faith.” For example:

to bring about the obedience of faith among all the Gentiles for the sake of his name, <sup>6</sup>including you

But “all those among the Gentiles” (1:5c) also connects to “And you” in 1:6. If you do not translate “all those

among the Gentiles” last in 1:5, you may need to make the connection to 1:6 clear. For example:

to bring about the obedience of faith among all the Gentiles for the sake of his name. <sup>6</sup>Those Gentiles include you

## Romans 1:7

### Section 1:1–7: Introduction

In this first section, Paul introduced himself and the gospel about Jesus. He also greeted the people to whom he was writing.

Before you begin to translate this section, consider what is the natural way to begin a letter in your language. Consider also how closely to follow that way in your translation.

Consider whether or not you want a section heading here. The GNT, for example, does not have one here. It is good to read or translate this section before you decide on a heading for it. Here are other possible headings for this section:

Paul introduced himself and the gospel about Jesus and greeted the Roman believers

Paul and His Message of Good News (CEV)

Paul began his letter to the Christians in Rome

### 1:7a

#### To all in Rome

- ¶ This letter is to all of you<sup>(plur)</sup> in Rome,
- ¶ I write this letter to all you believers who live in the city of Rome.

**To all in Rome:** This phrase tells to whom Paul wrote this letter. Here the phrase all in Rome refers to the Christians in Rome. In some languages a literal translation would wrongly indicate the letter is for all the people in Rome, not just the believers. For example:

To all the believers in Rome

In the Greek, this phrase has no verb. In some languages, it is more natural to include a verb here. For example:

I am writing this letter to all those believers in Rome

**Rome:** This name refers to the capital city of the ancient Roman empire. Today Rome is the capital city of the country of Italy.

### 1:7b

#### who are loved by God

- people whom God loves
- God loves you

**who are loved by God:** This clause further describes the believers in Rome, and refers to all of them. It does not separate some believers from other believers. For the correct meaning in some languages, translators must avoid the word who. For example:

God loves you!

God's loved ones

**loved:** This word refers to a strong feeling of affection and concern for a person. It also refers to an attitude of actively seeking the good of another. It is the love a parent feels for his/her child. It does not refer to sexual desire. Consider how to translate that meaning in your language. Your language may have a phrase or idiom for that meaning. For example:

give heart/insides

### 1:7c

#### and called to be saints:

- and called to be his holy people.
- and appointed you to be people whom God has made holy.

**called to be saints:** The Greek word that the BSB translates as called to be here is literally "called (ones)." But many English versions translate "called (ones)" as the verb called. Here, as in 1:6, the word called means "chosen to be given a special benefit or purpose." God has called all believers to be saints. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

appointed/designated saints

called as saints (NASB)

called by God to be saints

whom he/God called to be saints

See how you translated called in 1:1 or 1:6.

**saints:** The Greek word that the BSB translates as saints is literally "holy (ones)." It can mean "holy people," "people dedicated/consecrated to God," or "people whom God has made holy." Here it probably implies all of these meanings. In the New Testament, this word refers to all Christians, not to any special group of Christians. Here are other ways to translate this word:

God's holy people

his very own people (NLT96)

those whom God has made holy

Translate this word in a way that will refer to all Christians, and that people will use to refer to themselves as Christians.

### 1:7d

#### Grace and peace to you from God our Father and the Lord Jesus Christ.

- May grace and peace come to you<sup>(plur)</sup> from God our<sup>(incl)</sup> Father and the Lord Jesus Christ.
- I pray that God our Father and the Leader/Master Jesus Christ will be kind to you and cause you to be at peace.

#### Grace and peace to you from God our Father and the Lord Jesus Christ:

The writers of the NT often greeted their readers with a phrase like Grace and peace to you. This greeting was a prayer. Paul asked God and Jesus to bless the Roman believers with grace and peace.

This greeting has no verb. In some languages, it is more natural to include a verb or verbs. For example:

May God our Father and the Lord Jesus Christ give you grace and peace. (NLT)

I pray that God our Father and our Lord Jesus Christ will be kind to you and will bless you with peace! (CEV)

**Grace:** This word refers to kindness. God is kind to people because he wants to be kind, not because they have done anything to deserve it. Here are other ways to translate this word:

kindness

help

favor

**peace:** This word refers to having no conflicts with other people or with God. The Greek word may also indicate wholeness or well-being. The BDAG (pages 287–288) lists this verse under sense (2), “a state of well-being, peace.”

**God our Father:** When we believe in Jesus, we become God’s children by adoption. Also God created us. In those ways God is our Father. Some languages must indicate that God is not a human father. For example:

God our heavenly Father

**the Lord Jesus Christ:** Some languages must say whose Lord Jesus is. For example:

our Lord Jesus Christ (CEV)

**Lord:** This word refers to someone who has authority over people. Here are other ways to translate this word:

Chief/Leader

the Sovereign over us

See how you translated this word in 1:4.

## Romans 1:8

### Section 1:8–17: Paul wanted to visit the believers at in Rome

In this section, Paul thanked God that, in many places, people had heard about the faith of the believers in Rome. He also told them that he was asking God to make a way for him to go and visit them. He expected that he and they together would strengthen each other in their faith in Jesus Christ. He told them that he had been wanting to visit them for a long time and was eager to preach the gospel to the people there.

Then Paul wrote down the main things he wanted to talk about in the rest of the letter. He spoke of the gospel and who it is for.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

Paul wanted to visit Rome

Paul hoped to visit them

### 1:8a

#### First, I thank my God through Jesus Christ for all of you,

- ¶ First of all, the deeds/work of Jesus Christ cause me to be thanking my God for all of you<sup>(plur)</sup>.
- ¶ First, my big/important talk is that I often thank my/our God for you all. I thank him because Jesus Christ has made that thanksgiving/thankfulness possible.

**First:** The word First here has a general meaning of “the first thing I want to say.” It implies that what Paul was about to say something that was important to him. See Jewett (page 117). Here are other ways to translate this word:

Let me say first that (NLT)

First of all, (NET)

So first and foremost Jewett, page 117.

**I thank:** The Greek word probably indicates that, during that time, Paul thanked God for the believers in Rome. For example:

I am thanking

I am thankful

**my God:** The word my here indicates that Paul had a relationship with God. But he did not mean “he is my God but not yours.” In some languages, my here would mean “mine and not yours.” If that is true in your language, use “our<sup>(incl)</sup>” here. For example:

our God Western Bukidnon Manobo Back Translation on TW.

Some languages do not use possessive pronouns with God. If that is true in your language, indicate the relationship in another way. For example:

God, whom I believe in,

God, whom I follow,

**through Jesus Christ:** This phrase indicates that his relationship with Jesus Christ was the basis for his thanking God for the believers in Rome. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

because of Jesu CristoKankanaey Back Translation on TW.

because of what Jesus Christ did for me

### 1:8b

**because your faith is being proclaimed all over the world.**

- I thank him because people everywhere are saying that you trust Christ.
- I thank him because the news that you believe in Christ is spreading all over the world.

**your faith is being proclaimed:** This clause is passive. Some languages must use a non-passive clause here. For example:

- Use an active clause. Some languages can use “they” in a general way, as long as it does not refer to any group in previous verses. Other languages must say who proclaimed. If that is true in your language, you should add a general word, such as “people.” For example:

they/people proclaim your faith

- Use an intransitive clause. For example:

people are talking about your faith

the whole world is hearing about your faith (GNT)

**your faith:** This phrase refers to people in Rome believing in Jesus Christ. Some languages must say who people believe in. For example:

your faith in him (NLT)

In some languages must use a verb for the meaning of faith. For example:

you believe in him

**faith:** To have faith in a person refers to believing in him, who he is, and who he claims to be. See how you translated this word in 1:5.

**is being proclaimed:** This word means “tell something in public for many people to hear.” Here it probably indicates that the news of many people of Rome becoming Christians spread far. People probably did not stand in public and announce this news. Here are other ways to translate this word:

talked about publicly

is well-knownYakan Back Translation on TW.

the news of your faith is spreading (GW)

**all over the world:** This phrase that the BSB translates as all over the world is literally “in all the world.” It is a figure of speech that exaggerates something for emphasis. The news of their faith in Jesus had spread probably to many parts of the Roman Empire. The Roman Empire was only one part of the world.

In some languages people would understand this in a literal way. If that is true in your language, you may want to:

- Moderate the exaggeration in your translation. For example:

in all the known world

everywhere in the Roman world

- Translate literally and explain the meaning in a footnote. Here is an example footnote:

This phrase exaggerates how far the news of their faith in Jesus had spread probably to indicate that the news was important or worth spreading. It had probably spread to many parts of the Roman Empire.

## Romans 1:9

### Section 1:8–17: Paul wanted to visit the believers at/in Rome

In this section, Paul thanked God that, in many places, people had heard about the faith of the believers in Rome. He also told them that he was asking God to make a way for him to go and visit them. He expected that he and they together would strengthen each other in their faith in Jesus Christ. He told them that he had been wanting to visit them for a long time and was eager to preach the gospel to the people there.

Then Paul wrote down the main things he wanted to talk about in the rest of the letter. He spoke of the gospel and who it is for.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

Paul wanted to visit Rome

Paul hoped to visit them

### 1:9a

#### **God, whom I serve with my spirit in preaching the gospel of His Son, is my witness**

- For God is able to testify about me. I do his work by means of my spirit for the good news about his Son.
- For God is my witness. I do his work regarding the gospel of his Son with my life. God knows that what I say here is true:

The Greek of 1:9a begins with a word that is often translated as “for” (as in the ESV). This word introduces support for Paul saying that he thanked God for the believers in Rome. Some languages can omit this word and imply this connection, as the BSB does.

**God...is my witness:** This clause is an oath. Paul knew that God could confirm that Paul was praying often for the believers in Rome. It also encourages the believers in Rome to believe that Paul was praying often for them and not doubt what he said here. It also emphasizes that Paul was speaking the truth about praying for them. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

God knows and can tell you

God has seen and can proclaim

**whom I serve with my spirit in preaching the gospel of His Son:** This clause further describes God. It does not separate this God from other gods. For the correct meaning in some languages, translators must avoid the word whom. Here is one way:

I serve God with my spirit in the gospel of his Son, and he is my witness

This clause also interrupts what Paul wanted the Roman believers to know (in the Greek: “God is my witness...that without ceasing I mention you always in my prayers”). In some languages, it is more natural to have this clause in a different place. For example:

For I serve God with my spirit in the gospel of his Son, and he is my witness

<sup>9-10</sup>God is my witness that without ceasing I mention you always in my prayers. I serve him with my spirit in the gospel of his Son. I am asking...

**I serve:** Here this word refers to doing things that God wants people to do. For Paul, this word would include his work as an apostle and evangelist. Here are other ways to translate this word:

I do his will

I do everything that he commands me to do

This word does not refer to giving food to God here.

**with my spirit:** There are two ways to interpret the Greek words that the BSB translates as with my spirit:

1. It indicates that Paul’s spirit was the means by which he served God. For example:

in my spirit (NASB) (BSB, RSV, NIV11, NJB, KJV, NASB, NET, NABRE, ESV)

1. It refers to the sincerity of Paul’s service. Paul was saying that he served God completely or wholeheartedly. For example:

whom I serve with my whole heart (NIV) (NIV, GNT, NLT, CEV, NCV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1), because the Greek phrase “in...spirit” does not mean “sincere” anywhere else in the NT. The BSB usually translates the Greek that means “not hypocritical” as “sincere.” Cranfield, Dunn, Jewett, Witherington, Kruse, Barrett, Lenski, Nicoll, Fitzmyer, and Moo support interpretation (1).

**my spirit:** The word spirit refers to the part of a person that is not the physical part. It includes the thinking, attitudes, emotions, and desires of that person. In some languages spirit is only used after a person has died physically. If that is true in your language, use the word with the correct meaning here. For example:

my insides

my life



**in preaching the gospel of His Son:** The phrase that the BSB translates as in preaching the gospel of His Son is literally “in the gospel of his Son.” It indicates that Paul’s service to God was in reference to sharing the good news about Jesus Christ. This included preaching, teaching, and doing miracles in the name of Jesus Christ. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

concerning the gospel of his Son

in regard to the gospel of his Son

The BSB supplies the phrase in preaching. This is not in the Greek. While that is part of Paul’s service, he did many other things in relation to the gospel. Here is a more general way to translate the idea:

in spreading the Good News about his Son

**gospel:** The Greek word that the BSB translates as gospel means “good news.” Here, it refers to the good news that God sent Jesus to rescue us from wrongdoing and reconcile us to God. See how you translated this word in 1:1.

**of:** The word of here probably indicates that the gospel informs people about Jesus. Moo (on TW) and Kruse (page 57). For example:

about (NLT)

**His Son:** The phrase His Son refers to Jesus. He is God’s Son. It indicates that the relationship between God and Jesus is similar to the relationship of human fathers and their sons. See how you translated this phrase in 1:3.

### 1:9b

#### how constantly I remember you

- He is able to testify that I speak a short talk/message/prayer to God about you continually
- I am always speaking briefly to God about you

**how constantly:** This phrase is an exaggeration for emphasis. Here it means “continually” or “all the time.” It does not mean “every minute that Paul was awake.” Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

continually (NET)

never stop (CEV)

**I remember you:** This word indicates here that Paul referred to them when he to God. It also may indicate remembering to pray for them. Paul prayed briefly but often for the Roman believers.

## Romans 1:10

### Section 1:8–17: Paul wanted to visit the believers at/in Rome

In this section, Paul thanked God that, in many places, people had heard about the faith of the believers in Rome. He also told them that he was asking God to make a way for him to go and visit them. He expected that he and they together would strengthen each other in their faith in Jesus Christ. He told them that he had been wanting to visit them for a long time and was eager to preach the gospel to the people there.

Then Paul wrote down the main things he wanted to talk about in the rest of the letter. He spoke of the gospel and who it is for.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

Paul wanted to visit Rome

Paul hoped to visit them

### 1:10a

#### in my prayers at all times, asking

- and at all times when I pray to him. I am asking him
- in my prayers every time. I am asking him

**in my prayers at all times:** In some languages it is better to use a verb for the meaning of prayers here. For example:

every time I pray (GW)

**prayers:** This word refers to talking to God, praising him, thanking him, and asking him to do something.

### 1:10b

#### that now at last by God’s will I may succeed in coming to you.

- that he may decide that in some way I may be successful after much time to finally come to you.
- somehow, if he wants it to happen, to make it possible after a long time for me to now/soon come and visit you.

**that:** The Greek word that the BSB translates as that is often translated “if.” Here, it occurs before a Greek word that is often translated as “somehow.” The BSB does not directly translate this word. Here the word

“if” indicates that Paul was uncertain whether or not he would go to Rome. For example:

if somehow Witherington, page 41, and Moo, page 55.

These words also indicate that Paul was not sure how he would get to Rome. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

if by any means (KJV)

if, in some way,

**now at last:** This phrase indicates that Paul had wanted to visit the believers in Rome for some time, and at this time might finally go. It is not clear how long he had wanted to go to Rome. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

finally (GNT)

for a long time but now

**by God’s will:** This indicates that God would decide if Paul would go or not. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

that God will decide/choose that

that God will allow

if God wants it (NCV)

**I may succeed:** The Greek word here is more literally “I may be led on a good road.” Paul hoped that God would guide him so that he would have a good way to travel to Rome. Many languages can translate the more literal Greek for the correct meaning. For example:

He might make a way that Western Bukidnon Manobo Back Translation.

he will open give a/any way to me Nalik Back Translation, draft, Papua New Guinea.

I may be granted good passage Jewett, page 117.

Note that the first two examples above change the Greek passive to an active clause.

Some English versions follow the more figurative meaning of this Greek word: “to succeed,” as the BSB does. But the more literal sense seems a better way to translate here. Jewett (page 122) says, “What Paul has regularly petitioned is that he be granted ‘good passage’ to Rome, whereby the literal meaning of εὐοδόω, ‘be on a good path,’ seems more relevant than the metaphorical meaning, ‘have success.’ ” Dunn (page 30) says, “Literally, ‘be led along a good road’ (cf. Tob 5:16), so ‘prosper, succeed’ (cf. 2 Chron 32:30; Sir 41:1; 1 Cor 16:2); but in view of the context Paul may have the original meaning in mind (Lightfoot)—cf. 1 Thess 3:11.”

## Romans 1:11

### Section 1:8–17: Paul wanted to visit the believers at/in Rome

In this section, Paul thanked God that, in many places, people had heard about the faith of the believers in Rome. He also told them that he was asking God to make a way for him to go and visit them. He expected that he and they together would strengthen each other in their faith in Jesus Christ. He told them that he had been wanting to visit them for a long time and was eager to preach the gospel to the people there.

Then Paul wrote down the main things he wanted to talk about in the rest of the letter. He spoke of the gospel and who it is for.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

Paul wanted to visit Rome

Paul hoped to visit them

### 1:11a

#### For I long to see you

- For I really am wanting to visit with you<sup>(plur)</sup>
- I want so much to see you face to face

**For:** This word introduces an explanation here. In 1:11 Paul explained why he was praying to visit the believers in Rome. Some languages may omit this word for a more natural connection.

**I long to see you:** The word long means “want very much” here. The Greek word is present tense, indicating that Paul was continuing to want very much to see the believers in Rome. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

I am wanting very much to see you

I really/truly want to see you

In some languages “want” already indicates continuing to do that, as in the above example.

**see:** Here this word implies visiting with the believers in Rome. Here are other ways to translate this word:

meetTagbanwa Back Translation on TW.

visit

comeWestern Bukidnon Manobo Back Translation on TW.

### 1:11b

**so that I may impart to you some spiritual gift**

- in order to give a gift for your spirits/insides.
- so that I might give to you a blessing/something to encourage your hearts/inner-being.

**impart:** This word means “to share or give something.” Here it refers to giving a spiritual gift or blessing (see note below). Here are other ways to translate this word:

convey (NJB)

give (NCV)

**some:** Here this word indicates that Paul did not know at this time which gift he would give to the believers in Rome. It does not indicate a plural: gifts. In some languages another word must be used. For example:

a/another

**spiritual gift:** The Greek word that the BSB translates as gift here refers to something that is given generously, without cost to the person receiving it. Calling it a spiritual gift indicates that the gift was not a physical thing (like a chair or table). This gift benefited the believers in their “spirit” (or inner being). Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

spiritual blessing (GNT)

something to encourage/bless you in your inner being

something to strengthen/benefit your insides/heart

### 1:11c

**to strengthen you,**

- I want that that gift will make you stronger in faith,
- In that way God may make you stand strong even more in your believing.

**to strengthen you:** This phrase indicates that Paul wanted the spiritual gift to make the believers in Rome more strong or firm in their faith. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

that will help you grow strong in the Lord (NLT)

Then you will grow stronger in your faith (CEV)

to make you strong in your hearts/spirits

in order that you will be strengthened moreOtomi Back Translation on TW.

Some languages must use a different word than “strong” here when referring to faith. For example:

that you may stand firm even more in your faith

so that you may be truly/more straight in your faith

**strengthen:** The Greek word that the BSB translates as strengthen is passive. It probably implies that the thing that Paul and the believers in Corinth shared would strengthen them, not that they would strengthen themselves. For example:

that it may strengthen you and me

## Romans 1:12

**Section 1:8–17: Paul wanted to visit the believers at/in Rome**

In this section, Paul thanked God that, in many places, people had heard about the faith of the believers in Rome. He also told them that he was asking God to make a way for him to go and visit them. He expected that he and they together would strengthen each other in their faith in Jesus Christ. He told them that he had been wanting to visit them for a long time and was eager to preach the gospel to the people there.

Then Paul wrote down the main things he wanted to talk about in the rest of the letter. He spoke of the gospel and who it is for.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

Paul wanted to visit Rome

Paul hoped to visit them

### 1:12a

**that is, that you and I may be mutually encouraged**

- rather/indeed, that he will encourage me and you<sup>(plur)</sup> together
- Truly, I want to come so that we will help each other to be strong in our<sup>(incl)</sup> faith

**that is:** Here the Greek phrase indicates that Paul wanted to add to what he said in 1:11. Cranfield (page 80) says that Paul “amends...what had been said by expressing a complementary truth. Some scholars say that Paul corrects himself. But that does not mean that what Paul said in 1:11 was wrong, but it was incomplete. Not only did he expect to encourage the believers in Rome (1:11) but he also expected that he and they would encourage each other (1:12). For example:

or rather (NRSV)

Look, it is like-this Yongkom Back Translation, by this author, unpublished manuscript.

Your translation should not imply that what Paul said in 1:11 was incorrect.

**that you and I may be mutually encouraged:** This clause is passive. Some languages must use an active clause. For example:

God may encourage you<sup>(plur)</sup> and I together

**mutually:** Here this word refers to being together and experiencing the same thing. See the above example.

**encouraged:** This word refers to helping someone to have more hope about something or to have more confidence to do something. Here are other ways to translate this word:

help (NCV)

strengthen Nalik Back Translation, in progress.

help in that-which-strengthens Tagbanwa Back Translation on TW.

### 1:12b

**by each other’s faith.**

- as each of us<sup>(incl)</sup> sees how the others believe in Jesus.
- by sharing about our faith, both you<sup>(plur)</sup> and me.

**by each other’s faith:** The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as by each other’s faith is literally “through the faith in one another, both yours and mine.” Paul said “both yours and mine” to be clear that he included himself when he said each other here. One of them talking about his or her faith would encourage the others, including Paul. Dunn (page 31).

**faith:** To have faith in a person refers to believing in him, who he is, and who he claims to be. See how you translated this word in 1:5.

## Romans 1:13

**Section 1:8–17: Paul wanted to visit the believers at/in Rome**

In this section, Paul thanked God that, in many places, people had heard about the faith of the believers in Rome. He also told them that he was asking God to make a way for him to go and visit them. He expected that he and they together would strengthen each other in their faith in Jesus Christ. He told them that he had been wanting to visit them for a long time and was eager to preach the gospel to the people there.

Then Paul wrote down the main things he wanted to talk about in the rest of the letter. He spoke of the gospel and who it is for.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

Paul wanted to visit Rome

Paul hoped to visit them

### 1:13a

**I do not want you to be unaware, brothers,**

- ¶ My brothers and sisters, I do not want you to be ignorant
- ¶ My fellow believers, I want you to know

**I do not want you to be unaware, brothers:** The address brothers occurs in the middle of the sentence.

In some languages, it is more natural to have the address first. For example:

Brothers and sisters, I want you to know (NCV)

**I do not want you to be unaware:** The Greek clause here is literally “I do not want you to be ignorant.” It emphasizes what he was about to say. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

I want you to know (NRSV)

my desire is that you know Yakan Back Translation on TW.

**brothers:** Here the word brothers refers to believers in Jesus, both men and women. The word indicates a close relationship because all believers are considered spiritual children of God. For example:

my fellow believers

In some languages brothers would be understood as literal brothers. If that is true in your language, you may want to translate differently. For example:

my brothers and sisters who believe in Jesus/Christ

my family of believers

my friends (CEV)

### 1:13b

#### how often I planned to come to you

- that again and again I made up my mind to come to you.
- that I often made plans to come to visit you.

**how often I planned to come to you:** The Greek word that the BSB translates as planned probably refers to Paul making plans to go to Rome. Cranfield (page 82), Dunn (page 26), Jewett (pages 127, 129), Lenski (page 65), and Moo (on TW). The word often indicates that he made those plans at various times but was unable to go for some reason.

### 1:13c

#### (but have been prevented from visiting until now),

- But so far something has always happened to hinder/block me from coming.

- But I have not been able to do it because other things have always stopped me.

#### but have been prevented from visiting until now:

This clause is passive. Here Paul implied that either God or Paul’s work among the churches that he started or something else has prevented him from going to Rome. Some languages must use a non-passive clause here. For example:

something has always kept me from doing so (GNT)

something has always blocked me

the way to come to you was closed, from earlier until today Yongkom Back Translation, by this author, unpublished manuscript.

### 1:13d

#### in order that I might have a harvest among you,

- I have wanted to come so that I might harvest some fruit for God among you,
- My purpose is to see results for the gospel among you

**in order that:** This phrase introduces the purpose for Paul’s plan to go to Rome.

**I might have a harvest among you:** The phrase have a harvest is a metaphor. It refers to there being results of his ministry in Rome. There are a number of possible results that Paul could have been thinking of. For example, the GNT says “I want to win converts among you also.” The NCV says, “I could help you grow spiritually.” Jewett (page 130) says, “Paul hopes to gain logistical and tactical support from Rome for his mission to Spain.” so your translation should indicate that Paul wanted something to occur that would build God’s kingdom but does not say what possibilities he had in mind.

Some languages must translate without part or all of the metaphor for the correct meaning. For example:

I might work as fruitfully among you (NJB)

I want to work among you and see spiritual fruit (NLT)

have some of the results of working among you

**1:13e****just as I have had among the other Gentiles.**

- just as I have harvested fruit in other non-Jewish places.
- like I saw results for the gospel among the other non-Jews in other cities.

**just as I have had among the other Gentiles:** There are two ways to interpret the Greek word that the BSB translates as just as:

1. It indicates that Paul compared his hope for a harvest in Rome to what he had already done among Gentiles in other places. For example:

as I have among other Gentiles (GNT) (BSB, NIV, GNT, NJB, NASB, KJV, NRSV, NLT, GW, CEV, NET, REB, NCV)

1. It indicates that Paul wanted to add to the harvest at Rome with a harvest among Gentiles elsewhere. For example:

as well as among the rest of the Gentiles (RSV) (RSV, ESV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1), because that is the usual meaning of the Greek word. All scholars this author consulted support interpretation (1). The BDAG (page 493–494) does not even list a meaning of “as well as” for this word.

**I have had:** The BSB adds these words, but they are clearly implied from the rest of the sentence. Here is another way to translate this:

I have (GNT)

**among the other Gentiles:** The Greek word that the BSB translates as the other indicates that Paul thought of the group of believers at Rome were mostly Gentiles, and Paul had preached among other Gentiles and some believed in Jesus. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

among the rest of the Gentiles (RSV)

among other Gentiles (GNT)

The Greek word probably implies all other Gentiles. Paul had not gone to all other Gentiles, but used this as a figure of speech to imply that he visited many Gentiles. The GNT example above avoids the exaggera-

tion in English. You should avoid indicating or implying “all” other Gentiles.

**Gentiles:** The word Gentiles refers to non-Jewish people. Here are other ways to translate this word:

**General Comment on 1:13a–e**

- Use a descriptive phrase. For example:

non-Jews

those who were not Jewish

- Use a word or phrase from another language that is well known to the people in your language. If you choose this option, you may want to add a footnote. Here is an example footnote:

The Jews considered all other people and nations to be outside of God’s plan to save them. The word used here describes all people who were not Jews.

The words “but have been prevented from visiting” (1:13c) interrupt the words “how often I planned to come to you...in order that I might have a harvest among you” (1:13b,d). The BSB indicates that by putting parentheses around the words. In some languages it is more natural to have the words of 1:13c either before or after the words of 1:13b,d. For example:

<sup>13a</sup>I do not want you to be unaware, brothers, that <sup>13c</sup>I have been prevented from visiting, but <sup>13b</sup>I often planned to come to you <sup>13d</sup>in order that I may have a harvest among you <sup>13e</sup>as well as among the rest of the Gentiles.

<sup>13a</sup>I do not want you to be unaware, brothers, <sup>13b</sup>that I often planned to come to you <sup>13d</sup>in order that I may have a harvest among you <sup>13e</sup>as well as among the rest of the Gentiles, <sup>13c</sup>but have been prevented from visiting.

**1:13a–e**

**(reordered) My brothers and sisters, I do not want you to be ignorant that again and again I planned to come to visit you. I wanted to harvest some fruit for God among you, just as I have harvested fruit in other non-Jewish places. But so far something has always happened to hinder/block me from coming.**

## Romans 1:14

### Section 1:8–17: Paul wanted to visit the believers at/ in Rome

In this section, Paul thanked God that, in many places, people had heard about the faith of the believers in Rome. He also told them that he was asking God to make a way for him to go and visit them. He expected that he and they together would strengthen each other in their faith in Jesus Christ. He told them that he had been wanting to visit them for a long time and was eager to preach the gospel to the people there.

Then Paul wrote down the main things he wanted to talk about in the rest of the letter. He spoke of the gospel and who it is for.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

Paul wanted to visit Rome

Paul hoped to visit them

### 1:14a

#### I am obligated both to Greeks and non-Greeks,

- It is my duty to preach to all people who are not Jews, to those who live according to the Greeks and to those who live wild/lawless.
- God has told me that I must tell the good news to all non-Jews. It does not matter if they think they are civilized like the Greeks or not.

**I am obligated:** The word obligated indicates that someone must do something. Jesus told Paul to go be his witness among the Gentiles, and so he needed to follow that command. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

I have a duty (NCV)

I truly must tell the good news

God requires me to preach the gospel

I really will have something to answer for to God if I don't teach people about this Good News. Tagbanwa Back Translation on TW.

**both to Greeks and non-Greeks:** Paul implied all Gentiles (non-Jews) here. Cranfield (page 83), Dunn (page 33), Witherington (page 44), Fitzmyer (page 250), Moo (on TW). In some languages a literal translation would wrongly refer to a different group of people. If that

is true in your language, include the implied information. For example:

to all Gentiles, both Greeks and barbarians

**Greeks:** This word refers to people who spoke the Greek language and lived according to the Greek culture. The Greeks thought of themselves as living in a civilized way. The Romans also thought of themselves as living in that way.

**non-Greeks:** The word that the BSB translates as non-Greeks is related to the English word “barbarians.” This word refers to people who did not speak Greek and did not follow Greek culture. The Greeks disliked non-Greeks and thought of them as wild, fierce, rude, and uncivilized. Here are other ways to translate this word:

uncivilized (CEV)

people of the jungle  
Based on Yongkom Back Translation, by this author, unpublished manuscript.

### 1:14b

#### both to the wise and the foolish.

- I must preach to all those people, either wise or fools.
- It does not matter if they are wise and educated or have no wisdom or education.

**both to the wise and the foolish:** This refers to all non-Jews, like with “Greeks and non-Greeks,” but divides them into two different groups. The first pair divides the non-Jews by language and culture, but here by wisdom and education.

This phrase should refer to the same group as in 1:14a, only divided differently. In some languages a literal translation would wrongly refer to two new groups of people. If that is true in your language, indicate it refers to the same group as in 1:14a. For example:

indeed, to the wise and the foolish

they can be wise or fools

**the wise:** The Greek word that the BSB translates as wise refers to people who had wisdom and education. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

the educated and wise people

the learned

the wise/thinking ones Tagbanwa Back Translation on TW.

**the foolish:** The Greek word that the BSB translates as foolish refers to people who did not have wisdom or education. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

the uneducated and foolish people

the stupid

the unwise/unthinking ones

## Romans 1:15

### Section 1:8–17: Paul wanted to visit the believers at/ in Rome

In this section, Paul thanked God that, in many places, people had heard about the faith of the believers in Rome. He also told them that he was asking God to make a way for him to go and visit them. He expected that he and they together would strengthen each other in their faith in Jesus Christ. He told them that he had been wanting to visit them for a long time and was eager to preach the gospel to the people there.

Then Paul wrote down the main things he wanted to talk about in the rest of the letter. He spoke of the gospel and who it is for.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

Paul wanted to visit Rome

Paul hoped to visit them

### 1:15

#### That is why I am so eager to preach the gospel also to you who are in Rome.

- Therefore, I am eager to proclaim the gospel also to you<sup>(plur)</sup> in Rome.
- And so, I want very much to soon declare the good news of Jesus Christ also with you in Rome.

**I am so eager:** The word eager refers to being interested in doing something and wanting to do it soon. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

my eagerness (REB)

I want so much (NCV)

my thinking is eager Levatbura Lamasong Back Translation, Papua New Guinea, in progress.

In some languages an idiom is used for this meaning. For example:

my insides are raised up Nalik Back Translation, Papua New Guinea, in progress.

**preach the gospel:** The Greek word here means “announce good news” or “proclaim the gospel.” Preaching is often done before a group of people. Here it refers to telling others the good news of Jesus as Savior. Here are other ways to translate this Greek word:

declare the gospel (REB)

preach the Good News (GNT)

See how you translated gospel in 1:1.

## Romans 1:16

### Section 1:8–17: Paul wanted to visit the believers at/ in Rome

In this section, Paul thanked God that, in many places, people had heard about the faith of the believers in Rome. He also told them that he was asking God to make a way for him to go and visit them. He expected that he and they together would strengthen each other in their faith in Jesus Christ. He told them that he had been wanting to visit them for a long time and was eager to preach the gospel to the people there.

Then Paul wrote down the main things he wanted to talk about in the rest of the letter. He spoke of the gospel and who it is for.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

Paul wanted to visit Rome

Paul hoped to visit them

### 1:16a

#### I am not ashamed of the gospel,

- ¶ For I am not ashamed of the good news,



- ¶ For I am not ashamed of the good message of/about Jesus Christ.

In the Greek, 1:16a begins with a word that is often translated as “for.” This word introduces an explanation for why Paul said he was so eager to preach the gospel in Rome (1:15). In some languages, it may be more natural to omit this word and leave the connection with 1:15 implicit, as the BSB does.

**I am not ashamed of the gospel:** There is a textual issue in 1:16a: (1) Some Greek manuscripts have the word gospel (BSB, RSV, NIV, GNT, NJB, NASB, NABRE, GW, CEV, NET, REB, ESV, NCV). (2) Some Greek manuscripts have the words gospel of Christ (KJV, NLT). It is recommended that you follow option (1). The NLT probably adds “about Christ” to make it clear who the gospel is about, as it normally does not follow the Byzantine text like the KJV does. The people who added “of Christ” long ago probably did it to make it clear who the gospel was about. The gospel is about a poor Jewish itinerant preacher who was crucified on a Roman cross. Some Romans would be ashamed to follow such a leader. But Paul was not ashamed of him or the message he preached, the gospel. Some scholars and English versions see “not ashamed” as a figure of speech (litotes) meaning “proud.” But Cranfield (page 86) and Jewett (page 137) say it is not litotes here. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

I do not have shame about the gospel

I am not ashamed of the good news of/about Jesus

#### 1:16b

**because it is the power of God for salvation to everyone who believes,**

- because it is God’s power to save all people who believe in him/Jesus.
- For the/that good message has God’s power so that he rescues everyone who believes it from the penalty of sin/wrongdoing.

**because:** Here this word introduces the reason for Paul saying that he was not ashamed of the gospel. Some languages have the word “therefore” and not the word because. If that is true in your language, reorder 1:16b–c and 1:16a. For example:

For <sup>16b</sup>the gospel is the power of God for salvation to everyone who believes, <sup>16c</sup>to the Jew first and also to the Greek, and therefore <sup>16a</sup>I am not ashamed of it.

**it is the power of God for salvation:** Here the word it refers to the gospel. This clause indicates that the gospel is the power that God uses to save people. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

it is the power of God that brings salvation (NIV11)

it is God’s power to save (GNT)

**salvation:** This word refers to being rescued from something harmful or dangerous. In Scripture it generally refers to rescue from God’s anger at the final judgment. Here are other ways to translate this word:

to save (GNT)

their lives will be saved Otomi Back Translation on TW.

In some languages it is necessary to say what people are saved from. If that is true in your language, refer to destruction or punishment. For example:

to save/rescue people from destruction

to save/rescue people from the final judgment

which frees them from the great punishment of God

**to everyone who believes:** One day God will judge everyone in a final judgment. He will save all people who believe the gospel about Jesus.

**believes:** To “believe” in someone means to agree to what someone stands for, to trust him, to rely on him, to be committed to him. See how your translated the word “faith” in 1:5.

In some languages it is necessary to say what these people believe in. If that is true in your language, refer to Jesus or his gospel. For example:

believes it (JBP)

believes in Jesus

#### 1:16c

**first to the Jew, then to the Greek.**

- This Good News went first for the Jew, then for the Greek.

- We Jews were the first to hear that message, and now you non-Jews also hear that message.

**first to the Jew, then to the Greek:** The word first indicates that God gave his message of salvation to the Jews first, then he gave it to the Greeks. It may also indicate that the Jews had higher status in God's sight because he chose them to be his people. Here are other ways to translate these words:

first to the Jew, then to the Greek

Jews first, but Greeks as well (NJB)

It was made known first to the Jews, after that to the Gentiles. Kankanaey Back Translation on TW. Some languages can imply both first in time and first in status, as the Greek word does. But many languages must choose one meaning or the other. If that is true in your language, translate it as first in time.

**the Jew...the Greek:** The words Jew and Greek are singular, but they refer generally to any Jew or Greek. In some languages it is more natural to use plurals, as the NJB does above.

**the Greek:** The word Greek refers to all non-Jews here. Non-Jews generally did not like the term "Gentile," because it implied that the Jews thought that they were better than the Gentiles. So Paul probably used the word Greek here to avoid bad feelings on the part of the non-Jews.

In some languages a literal translation would wrongly refer only to people from the country of Greece. If that is true in your language, you may want to:

- Translate literally and explain its meaning in a footnote. Here is an example footnote:

Here the word "Greek" refers to all non-Jews. It is a more polite word than "Gentiles."

- Use the word you normally use for "Gentile" here. You may then want to explain the situation in a footnote. Here is an example footnote:

Literally "Greek." At that time, the word "Greek" was more polite than "Gentile" when speaking to non-Jews.

## Romans 1:17

### Section 1:8–17: Paul wanted to visit the believers at/in Rome

In this section, Paul thanked God that, in many places, people had heard about the faith of the believers in Rome. He also told them that he was asking God to make a way for him to go and visit them. He expected that he and they together would strengthen each other in their faith in Jesus Christ. He told them that he had been wanting to visit them for a long time and was eager to preach the gospel to the people there.

Then Paul wrote down the main things he wanted to talk about in the rest of the letter. He spoke of the gospel and who it is for.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

Paul wanted to visit Rome

Paul hoped to visit them

#### 1:17a

#### For the gospel reveals the righteousness of God

- For God reveals his righteousness in the/that gospel
- For, by means of that Good News, God is showing his straight/upright ways/living

**For:** Here this word introduces an explanation for why the gospel is God's power to save everyone who believes (1:16).

**the gospel:** The word that the BSB translates as the gospel is literally "in/by it." When people hear the gospel, God reveals his righteousness to them. In some languages it may not be clear what "it" refers to here. If that is true in your language, use your normal word or phrase for the gospel. For example:

in/through the gospel

**reveals the righteousness of God:** The Greek word that the BSB translates as reveals is passive. The whole verse part is more literally "For the righteousness of God is revealed in it." It is likely that God (or the Holy Spirit) reveals here. The present tense indicates an ongoing action. Some languages must use an active clause here. For example:

God is revealing his righteousness

**the righteousness of God:** The Greek word that the BSB translates as righteousness refers to doing what

is right here. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

God's righteousness

the right/straight living/deeds of God

The scholars understand this phrase in several different ways here, including "God calling someone righteous" and "God's "righteous activity." But the above definition seems best here, since the gospel reveals it.

#### 1:17b

**that comes by faith from start to finish,**

- from someone's faith to another's faith,
- from their faith/believing to the faith/believing of those who hear and so believe.

**by faith from start to finish:** The phrase that the BSB translates as by faith from start to finish is literally "from faith to faith." The expression indicates that revealing God's righteousness is connected to or requires faith. The Greek word that the BSB translates as by can also mean "to" or "for." For example:

from faith to faith (NASB)

Some languages can translate these words literally. Scholars understand them in many different ways here. Here are some of the interpretations:

1. It means "from God's faithfulness to believers' faith." Dunn (pages 43–44), Longenecker (pages 178–179), and Witherington (page 55).
2. It refers to a progression, from person to person as the gospel is shared and new people believe it. Jewett (page 143) supports this interpretation. He refers to similar use of "from...to..." in Psalms 83:8, Jeremiah 9:2, 2 Corinthians 2:16, and 3:18. He calls it "the missionary expansion of the gospel."
3. It refers to a progression within a person's faith. Schreiner (page 72–73). For example:

a righteousness that is by faith from first to last (NIV)

1. It is an idiom that means "by faith alone." Cranfield (page 99–100). For example:

God accepts everyone who has faith, but only those who have faith (CEV)

The Greek seems to allow interpretation (1) or (2), and, less likely, (3) or (4). Witherington (page 55) says, "The notion that this is simply an intensified way of saying 'by faith' or 'by faith alone'...entirely ignores the usual force of the preposition ek ('from')." Scholars of one interpretation argue against other interpretations, but no one argument seems to stand out as clearly best. It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1) or (2). But if the major language version follows interpretation (3) or (4), you may want to follow that.

#### 1:17c

**just as it is written: "The righteous will live by faith."**

- as it was written long ago, "The righteous person will live according to his faith."
- It is just as the Scriptures say, "Righteous people will live following/obeying their faith."

The quote here is from Habakkuk 2:4. If you indicate the location of quotes from the Old Testament with cross-references, you may want to do so here.

**just as:** Here this word indicates a comparison between "the righteousness of God that comes by faith from start to finish" (1:17a–b) and "The righteous will live by faith" (1:17c).

**it is written:** The Greek is more literally "it has been written." Habakkuk wrote more than 600 years before Paul wrote the letter to the Romans. In some languages a literal translation would wrongly indicate the quote was written at the same time as Paul wrote here. If that is true in your language, indicate it was long before Paul wrote. For example:

it was written long ago

This clause refers to what was written in the Old Testament. Some languages must make that explicit to make that clear. For example:

As the scripture says (GNT)

The clause is passive. The prophet Habakkuk wrote what God told him to write. Some languages must use a clause that is not passive here. For example:

the prophet wrote long ago

what God caused-to-be-written which says, Kankanaey Back Translation on TW.

It is like it says in the Holy Book Otomi Back Translation on TW.

**The righteous will live by faith:** This quote is from Habakkuk 2:4. If you indicate the location of quotes from the Old Testament with cross-references, you may want to do so here.

The Greek is literally “a righteous-one from faith will live.” There are several ways to interpret how “from faith” connects to the rest of the clause. Here are the two main ones:

1. It connects to shall/will live. For example:

The righteous will live by faith (BSB) (BSB, NIV, NRSV, NASB, KJV, ESV, NCV)

1. It connects to the righteous. For example:

He who through faith is righteous shall live (RSV) (RSV, GNT, CEV, REB)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1), because it is a common way to connect such a phrase to the verb. See Jewett (page 146). Also, it is closer to the Hebrew in Habakkuk 2:4 (Lenski, page 71). But interpretation (2) is also possible, so if the major language version follows that, you may want to follow it.

Some English versions try to copy the perceived ambiguity in the Greek. For example:

The one who is righteous by faith will live (NABRE)

**The righteous:** The Greek word that the BSB translates as righteous here refers to people who do what is right. It implies doing what God says is right to do. It does not refer to people who think they are righteous according to their own power or thinking. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

Righteous people

People who do what is right

This has a similar meaning to “righteousness” in 1:17a.

**by faith:** The word by indicates that righteous people live by means of their faith. Their faith guides how they live. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

through his faith

according to their faith

In this division, Paul wrote about people sinning, God’s anger against sin, God judging all people according to what they have done, and no person being righteous before God.

Here are other possible headings for this division:

All people have sinned against God and therefore God is right to punish them

The Unrighteousness of All Mankind (NIV)

God is right to be angry with all people

## Romans 1:18

### Section 1:18-32: God is angry with people because they sin

In this section, Paul said that it is clear that God is angry about the bad things that people do. God has shown all people who he is, but they have rejected him. So they became fools and worshiped things instead of God. And so God put them under the control of sinful desires even more.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

The reason why God is angry with people

God’s Wrath on Unrighteousness (ESV)

People do what is not right in God’s sight and so God is angry

### 1:18a

#### The wrath of God is being revealed from heaven

- ¶ For God reveals his anger from heaven
- ¶ For God is showing from heaven that he is angry

This verse begins with a word that is usually translated as “for.” The BSB does not translate this word. It probably introduces support for the gospel being the power of God for salvation to all who believe (1:16). Morris (page 74), Kruse (page 86), and Fitzmyer (page 277). But it is also possible that it introduces support for God’s righteousness being revealed from faith to faith (1:17). Dunn (page 54), Witherington (page 64), and Cranfield (pages 106-108). It probably introduces the whole section (1:18-3:20) rather than just this verse. Cranfield (page 108).

**The wrath of God:** The Greek word that the BSB translates as wrath here means “strong indignation directed at wrongdoing” (BDAG, sense 2, page 720). Here it is God’s anger against people’s sins.

**is being revealed:** This phrase translates the same Greek word as in 1:17. If possible, translate in the same way here.

**from heaven:** These words emphasize that God himself is revealing his wrath.

**heaven:** Here the word heaven refers to the place where God lives.

### 1:18b–c

**men who suppress the truth by their wickedness:** There are two ways to interpret how this clause connects to “men/people”:

1. Only some people suppress the truth. In English this is indicated by not having a comma after “men/people.” (BSB, RSV, NIV, GNT, NJB, NASB, NABRE, NLT, NET, REB)
2. All people suppress the truth. In English this is indicated by having a comma after “men/people.” For example:

people, who suppress the truth by their wickedness (NIV11) (NIV11, ESV, KJV, NCV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1), because Paul was speaking about certain attitudes and behavior, not all attitudes and behavior.

### 1:18b

**against all the godlessness and wickedness of men**

- toward/upon all deeds that disrespect him/God and deeds that are not right to do.
- with all deeds and words that insult him/God and are evil to do or say.

**all the godlessness and wickedness of men:** The word men refers here generally to people. The whole phrase refers to deeds and thinking that are ungodly and unrighteous. For example:

all godlessness of people and their wickedness too

all godless and wicked deeds and thinking of people

**godlessness:** This word refers to doing or saying things that show no reverence or respect for God. Here are other ways to translate this word:

impiety

doing or saying things that dishonor/disrespect God

**wickedness:** This word refers to doing things that are not right to do. Here are other ways to translate this word:

unrighteousness (ESV)

injustice (NJB)

evil (GNT)

### 1:18c

**who suppress the truth by their wickedness.**

- They prevent others from knowing the truth by their deeds that are not right to do.
- They do bad things, and in this way they hide the truth, which they know, about God.

This clause tells the reader more about people. It does not separate some people from other people. Translate this clause so that it tells more about all people. One way to do that is to start a new sentence here. For example:

They suppress the truth by their wickedness.

**suppress the truth:** Here the word suppress refers to preventing others from knowing the truth. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

prevent the truth from being known (GNT)

hold back the truth (NJB)

**the truth:** Here this word refers to what is true about God, Jesus and the gospel. Some languages only have an adjective meaning “true” and so must add a noun. For example:

the true talk

**their wickedness:** People’s unrighteous deeds is the way that they suppress the truth. If possible, translate the word wickedness in the same way as in 1:18b.

## Romans 1:19

### Section 1:18–32: God is angry with people because they sin

In this section, Paul said that it is clear that God is angry about the bad things that people do. God has shown all people who he is, but they have rejected him. So they became fools and worshiped things instead of God. And so God put them under the control of sinful desires even more.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

The reason why God is angry with people

God's Wrath on Unrighteousness (ESV)

People do what is not right in God's sight and so God is angry

#### 1:19a

#### For what may be known about God is plain to them,

- For those things that people can know about God by just observing/looking are clear to them,
- For it is clear to people from creation what he is like,

**For:** This word introduces an explanation for why the things Paul said in 1:18 are true.

**what may be known about God:** This clause refers to things that people can see on earth and realize that God caused them and therefore understand a little what kind of God he is. Witherington (page 66) calls it "natural revelation in creation and natural knowledge of God based on this natural revelation." See Schreiner (page 85) also. It does not refer to the gospel about Jesus. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

some knowledge of him (NCV)

those things concerning God which are possible for people to know Tagbanwa Back Translation on TW.

what can be known about God from this creation

what can be known about God from looking at this world

**is plain to them:** This phrase indicates that such knowledge is clear to all people; it is not hidden. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

is evident within them (NASB)

it is clear to them Kankanaey Back Translation on TW.

**to them:** The Greek word that the BSB translates as to is often translated as "in." Here the phrase "in them" probably means "within each person's conscience or... within each cultural group." Jewett (page 153). He says it "is impossible to determine" which one. He translates with "within them" and says this translation allows both meanings (in English). Translate with either of those meanings.

#### 1:19b

#### because God has made it plain to them.

- because he has shown those things to them.

**because:** This word introduces the reason for the previous statement. Some languages need to put the reason first. If that is true in your language, reorder this verse. For example:

For God has shown to them what can be known about him, therefore it is plain to them.

**God has made it plain to them:** The tense indicates that God has already shown it to them.

## Romans 1:20

### Section 1:18–32: God is angry with people because they sin

In this section, Paul said that it is clear that God is angry about the bad things that people do. God has shown all people who he is, but they have rejected him. So they became fools and worshiped things instead of God. And so God put them under the control of sinful desires even more.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

The reason why God is angry with people

God's Wrath on Unrighteousness (ESV)

People do what is not right in God's sight and so God is angry

#### 1:20a

#### For since the creation of the world

- For from the creation of the world until now/today,

- For, from the beginning when God first made all things,

**For:** This word introduces an explanation of the idea that what can be known about God is plain to people (1:19a).

**since the creation of the world:** This phrase indicates that all people who have lived on this earth, from creation until now, perceive who God is. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

ever since the creation of the world (ESV)

from the creation of the world until now/today

**the creation of the world:** This phrase refers to God creating the world and all of the other things that people can see, the sun, moon, stars, and such things. BDAG, kosmos, sense 3 (page 561). Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

when God created/made the world/universe

when God made all that people/they can see

#### 1:20b

**God's invisible qualities, His eternal power and divine nature, have been clearly seen,**

- they see and understand the things about him that people are not able to see, his everlasting power and his divinity/god-ness,
- they all see and understand things that people cannot see, his/God's eternal power and the kind of being/god he is,

#### 1:20c

**being understood from His workmanship,**

- by the things that he has made.
- from looking at those things.

#### 1:20b–c

**God's invisible qualities:** The Greek is literally “the invisible (things) of God.” Here it refers to the kind of person God is. These are not things that someone can see directly. Immediately after this phrase Paul explained it as “his eternal power and divine nature.” Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

his invisible attributes (ESV)

There are things about him that people cannot see (NCV)

**His eternal power and divine nature:** The Greek grammar indicates that the words His eternal power and divine nature describe what Paul meant with the words “the invisible (things) of God.” Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

that is to say his everlasting power and deity (REB)

God's invisible qualities: his eternal power and divine nature,

In some languages it is not natural to speak generally of something then specifically of the same thing. If that is true in your language, omit the word “qualities” (as the BSB translates). For example:

God's eternal power and his divine nature, which people cannot see,

**His eternal power:** God's power will never end. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

his everlasting power (REB)

his strength that will not end Yongkom Back Translation, by this author, unpublished manuscript.

God has power that doesn't leave Yakan Back Translation on TW.

**divine nature:** The Greek word that the BSB translates as divine nature refers to the characteristics of God. Here are other ways to translate this Greek word:

deity (REB)

divinity (JBP)

his godhood Kankanaey Back Translation on TW.

what God is like Uma Back Translation on TW.

**have been clearly seen, being understood:** The Greek is literally “being understood are clearly seen.” This phrase indicates that people look at the world and understand that God is powerful and that he is God.

This clause is passive. Some languages must use an active clause. For example:

people see and understand his invisible qualities,  
namely, his eternal power and divine nature,

they all clearly perceive his invisible qualities,  
namely, his eternal power and divine nature,

**from His workmanship:** The word from here indicates that when people look at the things that God has made, they will realize that he has great power and that he is God. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

from what has been made (NIV)

through what has been made (NASB)

**1:20d**  
**so that men are without excuse.**

- So they have no good reason for their bad behavior.
- That is why people cannot say that God has no reason/basis to blame them for their sins.

**so that:** This phrase introduces the result of God's "invisible qualities" being clearly seen (1:20b).

**men are without excuse:** The word excuse refers to an explanation of behavior when asked about that behavior. In this case, people knew about God but still were ungodly and unrighteous (1:18). They have no good reason for that bad behavior. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

they have no defense

they have no answer for their sins

they have nothing with-which-to-answer God-  
Kankanaey Back Translation on TW, based on  
Romans 2:1.

No one is able to say to God, "I never knew about you, so why do you blame/accuse me of wrongdoing?"

**men:** The word men refers here generally to people. Specifically, it refers to the people Paul was talking about in 1:18-19.

## Romans 1:21

### Section 1:18-32: God is angry with people because they sin

In this section, Paul said that it is clear that God is angry about the bad things that people do. God has shown all people who he is, but they have rejected him. So they became fools and worshiped things instead of God. And so God put them under the control of sinful desires even more.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

The reason why God is angry with people

God's Wrath on Unrighteousness (ESV)

People do what is not right in God's sight and so  
God is angry

### 1:21a For although they knew God,

- ¶ For even though they know what God is like,
- ¶ For they know about God from what they see.

**For:** This word introduces an explanation for why people are without excuse.

**although they knew God:** The word although introduces something that is true and contrasts it with something else. Here the clause they knew God is contrasted with what Paul said in 1:21b. For example:

they knew God, but...

**they knew God:** This clause refers to what people can know about God by looking at the world. Cranfield (page 116). It does not refer to full knowledge of God. It refers to the same thing as "what may be known about God" in 1:19a. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

They knew about God (CEV)

they know that God exists  
Kankanaey Back Translation on TW.

### 1:21b they neither glorified Him as God nor gave thanks to Him,

- they did not praise him as God or say any thanks to him.



- But they did not respect him in the way people should respect God, and they did not say “Thank you” to him.

**they neither glorified Him as God:** This clause indicates that people did not praise God or show respect to him because he is God and the Creator. They did not say things like “You are God” to him. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

they did not praise him saying, “You are God”

they did not honor him as is proper for God  
Uma Back Translation on TW.

they knew that He is worthy to be honored,  
but they didn’t honor Him  
Based on the Western Bukidnon Manobo Back Translation on TW.

**nor gave thanks to Him:** In some languages it is more natural to use “said” instead of gave. People should be thankful to God, because he has given them life and all good things.

#### 1:21c

#### but they became futile in their thinking

- And/But/Instead their thinking became worth nothing,
- They began to think foolish/useless thoughts

**but:** The Greek word indicates contrast but both 1:21b and 1:21c are bad things, so some languages would not indicate contrast here. For example:

Their thoughts... (CEV)

and

**they became futile in their thinking:** The Greek word that the BSB translates as became futile means “do and think things that are worth nothing.” Here are other ways to translate this clause:

Their thinking became useless (NCV)

their thinking became foolish

#### 1:21d

#### and darkened in their foolish hearts.

- and their hearts/insides became without understanding and like a dark room/house.

- and changed their lives to be unthinking and unable to understand.

**and darkened in their foolish hearts:** This is a metaphor that means “they became unable to understand.” These people were not able to understand moral, ethical, or spiritual truth. This clause is passive. Some languages must translate it as something other than a passive clause. For example:

God/he filled their foolish minds with darkness

God made their foolish hearts unable to understand

their foolish minds became full of darkness

their foolish hearts became unable to understand

**their foolish hearts:** In some languages the word foolish cannot connect directly to hearts. If that is true in your language, translate naturally. For example:

their hearts are foolish

they are foolish and their hearts were darkened

**foolish:** The Greek word here refers to not being able to understand things well. It implies that such a person does things that do not make much sense. Here are other ways to translate this word:

senseless (RSV)

stupid (CEV)

which is without wisdom/understanding  
Tagbanwa Back Translation on TW.

**hearts:** In Greek, the word hearts refers figuratively to the inner person, which includes the mind, the emotions, and the will. In some languages, another body part is used to describe this. For example:

liver

stomach

throat

If a literal translation of hearts (or another body part) would not refer to the inner person, you should translate the meaning directly. For example:

insides

minds

## Romans 1:22

### Section 1:18–32: God is angry with people because they sin

In this section, Paul said that it is clear that God is angry about the bad things that people do. God has shown all people who he is, but they have rejected him. So they became fools and worshiped things instead of God. And so God put them under the control of sinful desires even more.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

The reason why God is angry with people

God's Wrath on Unrighteousness (ESV)

People do what is not right in God's sight and so God is angry

#### 1:22a

#### Although they claimed to be wise,

- They were declaring that they were wise.
- They said strongly/confidently that they were wise and educated people,

#### 1:22b

#### they became fools,

- But instead they became foolish,
- but in fact they turned/changed into fools.

#### 1:22a–b

**Although they claimed to be wise, they became fools:** There is no conjunction between these two clauses. The Greek grammar indicates that Although they claimed to be wise occurs at the same time as they became fools. Here are other ways to translate this connection:

While they were claiming to be wise, they became fools

They always say that they are wise, but in truth they became fools

**claimed:** The Greek word here refers to saying something with confidence that it is true. Here are other ways to translate this word:

declaring

asserting

saying confidently

**wise:** The Greek word that the BSB translates as wise refers to people who have wisdom and education. See how you translated this word in 1:14.

## Romans 1:23

### Section 1:18–32: God is angry with people because they sin

In this section, Paul said that it is clear that God is angry about the bad things that people do. God has shown all people who he is, but they have rejected him. So they became fools and worshiped things instead of God. And so God put them under the control of sinful desires even more.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

The reason why God is angry with people

God's Wrath on Unrighteousness (ESV)

People do what is not right in God's sight and so God is angry

#### 1:23a

#### and exchanged the glory of the immortal God

- and changed from honoring the great/high, imperishable God
- They also have stopped worshiping the God of majesty/splendor, whom no one will ever ruin.

**exchanged the glory of the immortal God:** The word exchanged refers to replacing something with something else. Here it indicates that people stopped honoring God and instead honored idols shaped like a man, bird, animal, or creeping thing. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

changed from honoring the glorious/great and immortal God

They traded the glory of God who lives forever  
(NCV)

they abandoned...God who has far-from-ordinary  
glory/praiseworthiness and who is alive without  
ending Tagbanwa Back Translation on TW.

**glory:** The word glory refers literally to a very bright  
light. In this context it implies power, majesty, and  
greatness. Here are other ways to translate this word:

majesty

greatness

**immortal:** The Greek word that the BSB translates as  
immortal means “not able to become bad or ruined or  
dead.” God lives forever and he will not become sick  
or die. Here are other ways to translate this word:

incorruptible (NASB)

eternal (CEV)

imperishable

not able to be ruined/destroyed

#### 1:23b

##### for images of mortal man

- to honoring the likeness of perishable people,
- Instead they worship idols that look like people,  
whom others can quite easily ruin,

**images:** This word refers to an object that someone  
makes to look like something else. Here it refers to  
idols that represent the false gods that people wor-  
ship. For example:

idols (NLT)

**of:** Here this word refers to looking like something or  
someone else. These idols looked like a person, a bird,  
an animal, or a creeping thing. For example:

look like (NIV)

resembling (ESV)

**mortal:** The Greek word that the BSB translates as  
mortal means “able to become bad or ruined or dead.”  
Here are other ways to translate this Greek word:

corruptible

perishable

able to be ruined/destroyed

**man:** Here the word man refers generally to people.

#### 1:23c

##### and birds and animals and reptiles.

- birds, animals, and reptiles.
- and that look like things/creatures that fly, walk on  
four legs or crawl on their bellies.

**birds:** This word refers to creatures that have wings  
and (usually) fly. It does not refer to insects. Some  
languages do not have a general word for birds. If that  
is true in your language, you should:

- Describe them. For example:

things/creatures that fly

flying creatures/things

- Use a specific bird that can represent birds in gen-  
eral.
- Use a specific large or strong kind of bird, such as  
eagles or vultures.

**animals:** The Greek word is “four-footed creatures.”  
These are animals that have four legs and walk on  
the ground, but are not reptiles. Examples are horses,  
bears, pigs, elephants, and dogs.

**reptiles:** The Greek word refers to any animal that  
moves with its stomach close to the ground or on it. It  
includes snakes, lizards, salamanders, and frogs. Here  
are other ways to translate this word:

crawling things (NJB)

things that crawl on their belly Nalik Back Trans-  
lation, in progress.

## Romans 1:24

### Section 1:18–32: God is angry with people because they sin

In this section, Paul said that it is clear that God is angry about the bad things that people do. God has shown all people who he is, but they have rejected him. So they became fools and worshiped things instead of God. And so God put them under the control of sinful desires even more.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

The reason why God is angry with people

God's Wrath on Unrighteousness (ESV)

People do what is not right in God's sight and so God is angry

#### 1:24a

### Therefore God gave them over in the desires of their hearts to impurity

- ¶ Therefore God put them under the rule of immorality, while they lived according to the evil desires of their heart.
- ¶ And so God caused them to follow/obey unclean/filthy ways as they lived on the road/way of their sexual/body desires.

**God gave them over...to impurity:** The Greek word that the BSB translates as gave...over refers to putting someone under the control of something or someone else. Here it indicates that God put them under the control of impurity, so that they always did impure things. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

God put them under the control of impurity

God caused them to be ruled by thoughts of impurity

God...gave them the road to do whatever evil O-tomi Back Translation on TW.

**impurity:** This word refers to deeds that are immoral to do. Here are other ways to translate this word:

uncleanness (KJV)

filthy practices (NJB)

**in the desires of their hearts:** Here the word in introduces the situation of those people's lives when God gave them over to impurity. Moo (on TW) says that this phrase "shows that those who were handed over were already immersed in sin." Cranfield (page 122) says it refers to "the character of their life." Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

living in the lusts of their hearts

in their custom of following the lusts of their hearts

**the desires of their hearts:** The Greek word that the BSB translates as desires refers to strong desires of any kind. But it implies bad desires here. Here are other ways to translate this word:

the sinful desires of their hearts (NIV)

their inmost cravings (NJB)

the evil-things their minds desire Kankanaey Back Translation on TW.

**hearts:** In Greek, the word hearts refers figuratively to the inner person, which includes the mind, the emotions, and the will. See how you translated this word in 1:21.

#### 1:24b

### for the dishonoring of their bodies with one another.

- And so those deeds are showing in their own midst no respect for their bodies.
- What I mean is this, that immorality causes them altogether to do things that are insulting/shameful to their bodies.

**for:** The word for here introduces the result of God giving them over to impurity, or explains what Paul meant when he wrote the word "impurity." Here are other ways to translate this word:

of (NJB)

so that (NASB)

to impurity, to the degrading of their bodies (NRSV)

to impurity, that is, the degrading of their bodies

**the dishonoring of their bodies:** The Greek phrase here is literally “their bodies to be dishonored.” It refers to doing things that damage it, or things that God does not allow, or not showing respect to it. Here it probably refers mostly to shameful sexual actions. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

dishonouring their own bodies (NJB)

they dishonor their bodies by sexual perversion (GW)

they shame their bodies

they cause their bodies to be full of shame

**the dishonoring:** The Greek verb that the BSB translates as dishonoring is passive. It is the people’s own impurity (1:24a) that dishonors or shames their bodies. The Greek verb is also present tense, indicating that they continue to do this. Translate it with that meaning. See the above examples.

**with one another:** Paul was talking of all of humanity. So this phrase indicates that the dishonoring happens in all of humanity. It does not focus on doing these things to or with each other. Literally it is “in/among them” rather than “in/with themselves” or “in/with one another.” but indicates that the dishonoring happens among people rather than between people and other beings. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

among them (NASB)

they altogether

## Romans 1:25

### Section 1:18–32: God is angry with people because they sin

In this section, Paul said that it is clear that God is angry about the bad things that people do. God has shown all people who he is, but they have rejected him. So they became fools and worshiped things instead of God. And so God put them under the control of sinful desires even more.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

The reason why God is angry with people

God’s Wrath on Unrighteousness (ESV)

People do what is not right in God’s sight and so God is angry

### 1:25a

#### **They exchanged the truth of God for a lie,**

- They changed from believing the truths about God to believing a lie.
- They have stopped believing what is true about God and started believing a lie.

**They:** The Greek word here is literally “who.” There are two ways to interpret it here:

1. It introduces something more that is said about these people. Here it introduces a condemnation of ungodly people that is similar to 1:23. For example:

They (BSB) (BSB, NIV, GNT, KJV, NABRE, NLT, GW, CEV, NET, REB, NCV)

1. It introduces a reason for what Paul said in 1:24. For example:

because they (RSV) (RSV, NJB, ESV, NASB)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1), because 1:25a repeats the general sense of 1:23 rather than giving a reason for anything Paul said in 1:24. Cranfield (page 123). Dunn, Jewett, Fitzmyer, and Moo also support interpretation (1).

**exchanged:** This word refers to replacing something with something else. See how you translated this word in 1:23.

**the truth of God:** This phrase refers to things that people can know about God by looking at creation (1:19–21). It does not refer to the gospel of Jesus.

**for a lie:** The Greek phrase here includes the Greek article, sometimes translated as “the.” It probably refers to the idols made in the images of man and creatures (1:23). But those idols are not explicitly called a lie there, so all the English versions on TW translate it as the BSB does.

### 1:25b

#### **and worshiped and served the creature rather than the Creator,**

- They also honored and obeyed a created being instead of the Being who created all things,

- They also praised something that someone made and followed it instead of praising the One/Person who made all things and following him.

**worshiped:** The Greek word here refers to honoring someone as God as well as having awe for that person. The Greek word includes religious acts that in English are called “worship.” Here are other ways to translate this Greek word:

offered reverence (REB)

honored and were in awe of

**served:** This word refers to doing religious duties. It includes praying, worshiping, and doing what the god required someone to do. Here are other ways to translate this word:

did the work of

obeyed/followed

**creature:** This word refers to any created being: people, animals, fish, and so on, as in 1:23. Here are other ways to translate this word:

the beings of God’s creation

the things God created (NLT)

what God has created (GNT)

**Creator:** This word refers to the one who created all things: God. Paul used this word here to compare against the word “creature.” Here are other ways to translate this word:

the One who created everything

God, he who made all things there are  
Otomi Back Translation on TW.

him who created (them)  
Tagbanwa Back Translation on TW.

### 1:25c

**who is forever worthy of praise! Amen.**

- he/who is always praised! It is true.

- His people and angels always praise him, now and for all the time. Amen/True!

**who is forever worthy of praise:** This clause tells the reader more about God. It does not separate God from other gods. For the correct meaning in some languages, translators must avoid the word who. For example:

He is blessed forever.

**is forever worthy of praise:** The Greek word that the BSB translates as worthy of praise here means “blessed” or “honored.” People and the angels and other creatures of heaven are praising and will always praise and honor God.

The phrase worthy of praise describes God. Some languages must use a verb instead. For example:

who is praised forever

whom his people and angels praise/bless always

**forever:** The Greek is literally “into the ages.” It refers to all time in the future.

**Amen:** The word Amen is a Hebrew word that means “even so” or “it is true.” It is used to agree with what was said. The Greek borrowed the Hebrew word. English borrowed this word as well.

In some languages people are not familiar with this word. If that is true in your language, you may want to:

- Translate the meaning. For example:

It is so.

True!

- Borrow this word and spell it as people in your language would say it. You may then want to explain its meaning in a footnote. Here is an example footnote:

The word “amen” means “even so” or “it is true.”

## Romans 1:26

**Section 1:18–32: God is angry with people because they sin**

In this section, Paul said that it is clear that God is angry about the bad things that people do. God has shown all people who he is, but they have rejected

him. So they became fools and worshiped things instead of God. And so God put them under the control of sinful desires even more.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

The reason why God is angry with people

God's Wrath on Unrighteousness (ESV)

People do what is not right in God's sight and so God is angry

### 1:26a

**For this reason God gave them over to dishonorable passions.**

- Therefore God put them under the rule of strong/big, shameful/dishonorable desires/lusts.
- So God caused them to follow/obey bad desires of the body that are shameful to do.

**For this reason:** This phrase has the same meaning as "therefore." Here it introduces a result of people exchanging the truth about God for a lie and worshipping and serving the creature rather than the Creator.

1:25c stands between the two connected parts. So in some languages the connection must be made more clear. For example:

They did that and so

**God gave them over:** The Greek word that the BSB translates as gave...over refers to putting someone under the control of something or someone else. See how you translated this clause in 1:24.

**dishonorable passions:** The word passions refers to strong desires. These kinds of desires are worthy of dishonor or shame. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

strong desires worthy of dishonor/shame

shameful desires (NLT)

the shameful-things their bodies desire  
Kankanaey Back Translation on TW.

### 1:26b

**Even their women exchanged natural relations**

- For their women changed from having sexual relations that are normal
- For example, some of their women stopped lying/sleeping with another in the usual/natural way

**Even:** This word introduces examples (1:26b–1:27c) of shameful passions.

**their women:** Here the word their refers to the people that Paul spoke of in 1:24a–26a. It refers generally to those women, not implying all of them.

**natural relations:** This phrase here refers to a man and a woman having sex. The word natural refers to having sex in ways that are appropriate or fitting. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

natural function (NASB)

natural sexual relations (NIV11)

the natural way to have sex (NLT)

the normal practices of sexual intercourse (JBP)

**relations:** The Greek word that the BSB translates as relations refers to any kind of deed done with the body. Here it implies sex, so the BSB has used relations, which here in English clearly implies sex. To be polite in the Bible, people of many languages will prefer a word or phrase that implies sex rather than says so explicitly. For example:

laying together

the way of marriage  
Nalik Back Translation, draft,  
Papua New Guinea.

sleep-with  
Kankanaey Back Translation on TW.

### 1:26c

**for unnatural ones.**

- to having sexual relations that are not normal.
- and started lying/sleeping with another in ways that are not usual/natural.

**unnatural ones:** This phrase here refers to a woman having sex in ways that are not appropriate or fitting. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

that which is unnatural (NASB)

something which is abnormal and unnatural (JBP)

ways that are not normal

## Romans 1:27

### Section 1:18–32: God is angry with people because they sin

In this section, Paul said that it is clear that God is angry about the bad things that people do. God has shown all people who he is, but they have rejected him. So they became fools and worshiped things instead of God. And so God put them under the control of sinful desires even more.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

The reason why God is angry with people

God's Wrath on Unrighteousness (ESV)

People do what is not right in God's sight and so God is angry

#### 1:27a

#### Likewise, the men abandoned natural relations with women

- Also in a similar way, the men stopped having sexual relations that are normal with women
- In the same way, some of the men have left completely lying/sleeping with women in the usual/natural way

**abandoned:** Here this phrase refers to completely stopping what someone was doing. Here it refers to men who stopped having sex with women. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

gave up (ESV)

leaving (KJV)

completely stopped

**natural relations with women:** As in 1:26, the phrase natural relations here to having sex, here men with women. Translate in a similar way here but speaking of men with women.

#### 1:27b

#### and burned with lust for one another.

- and burned in their hearts/insides with desire/lust for each other.
- and started to strongly desire to lie/sleep with other men.

**burned with lust:** The Greek word that the BSB literally translates as burned indicates feeling a very strong desire. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

were inflamed with lust (NIV)

burned in their desire (NASB)

had strong desires for sex (CEV)

it's their fellow men whom they exceedingly crave to sleep-with Kankanaey Back Translation on TW.

**lust:** The Greek word here refers to a strong desire that is considered bad. BDAG (pages 721–722). See the above examples.

**for one another:** Here this phrase refers to men having strong desire for other men.

#### 1:27c

#### Men committed indecent acts with other men,

- They are men who continue to do shameful things with other men
- They are continually doing indecent/filthy things with other men,

**Men committed indecent acts with other men:** This clause further describes the men Paul talked about in 1:27a–b. Some languages must make that connection explicit. For example:

They were men committing shameless acts with men

They committed shameless acts with other men

**committed indecent acts:** The Greek word that the BSB translates as indecent acts refers to deeds that cause dishonor, disgrace, embarrassment, or shame. (Here the word indecent indicates that these men should have been ashamed, but they were not.) Here it refers specifically to men having sex with other men. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

doing shameful things (NJB)



behave indecently (REB)

the filthy-things they have been doing Kankanaey  
Back Translation on TW.

The Greek tense indicates that they continued to do these things at that time. Translate with that meaning.

**committed:** Here this word means “doing.” See the examples above.

#### 1:27d

**and received in themselves the due penalty for their error.**

- and continue to be given the required punishment for their wrongs/sins.
- and God is continually paying them back with the punishment he has chosen for those evil deeds of theirs.

**and received in themselves the due penalty for their error:** There are three ways to interpret the Greek word that the BSB translates as and:

1. These men received this penalty in addition to them doing shameless things. For example:

and received... (NIV) (BSB, RSV, NIV, NJB, NASB, KJV, ESV, NET, REB, NCV)

1. The penalty is the result of these men doing shameless things. For example:

and as a result they... (GNT) (GNT, NABRE, NLT, GW)

1. The penalty is these men doing shameless things. For example:

and what has happened to them is punishment... (CEV) (CEV)

The Greek word can mean any of these things. But it is recommended that you follow interpretation (1), because the context does not seem to support interpretations (2) or (3). Fitzmyer (page 288) calls it, “the recompense suited to their deviation.” Lenski (page 116) also supports interpretation (1). It is not clear to this author why scholars support interpretation (3). Among this author’s commentaries, he found no scholar who supported interpretation (2).

**received in themselves:** Here the word received refers to God giving them the due penalty. It does not

indicate that they took it because they wanted to. In some languages some form of “give” must be used for the correct meaning. For example:

being given in their own bodies

God giving them in their own bodies

The Greek tense indicates that they continued to receive the due penalty at that time. Translate with that meaning.

**in themselves:** Here this phrase refers to the penalty being in their own bodies. For example:

in their own persons (RSV)

**the due penalty:** The Greek word that the BSB translates as due indicates that the penalty needs to be given. It is not maybe or perhaps. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

the necessary punishment

the punishment that God has chosen for those deeds

**error:** The Greek word here means “wandering” and here implies wandering from the path of truth. BDAG (page 822). It can refer to both wrong behavior and wrong thinking. Here are other ways to translate this word:

sin

wrongs (NCV)

Some languages must choose between wrong behavior and wrong thinking. If that is true in your language, translate both. For example:

wrong deeds and wrong thoughts

## Romans 1:28

### Section 1:18–32: God is angry with people because they sin

In this section, Paul said that it is clear that God is angry about the bad things that people do. God has shown all people who he is, but they have rejected him. So they became fools and worshiped things in-

stead of God. And so God put them under the control of sinful desires even more.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

The reason why God is angry with people

God's Wrath on Unrighteousness (ESV)

People do what is not right in God's sight and so God is angry

### 1:28a-c

**Furthermore:** The word that the BSB translates as Furthermore is literally "and." It indicates that Paul said more about the people he spoke about in 1:18-27.

**since they did not see fit to acknowledge God, He gave them up to a depraved mind, to do what ought not to be done:** Here the word since introduces the reason (they did not see fit to acknowledge God, 1:28a) for the result (He gave them..., 1:28b-c). It does not connect back to 1:27. In some languages using "therefore" at the end of 1:28a would indicate the right connection. For example:

<sup>28a</sup>they did not see fit to acknowledge God, therefore <sup>28b</sup>God gave them up to a depraved mind to do what ought not to be done

### 1:28a

**Furthermore, since they did not see fit to acknowledge God,**

- ¶ And just as they did not approve of continuing to believe that God exists,
- ¶ Also, like those people decided it was bad to believe that God lives,

**since:** There are two ways to interpret the Greek word that the BSB translates as since:

1. It means as here. For example:

just as (NIV11) (NIV11, NASB, KJV, NET)

1. It means since here. For example:

Because (GNT) (BSB, RSV, GNT, NJB, NABRE, ESV, NLT, GW, CEV, NCV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1), because Paul used the Greek root word that means "proved" here and in 1:28b as a point of

comparison. Moo (page 117) says, "the lack of clear evidence for a causal meaning of the word Paul uses here leads us to prefer the normal correlative sense of the word: 'Even as....' "

**they:** Here the word they refers to the people of 1:18-27, not just the men. For example:

those people (GNT)

**did not see fit:** The Greek words here are more literally "did not approve." This phrase refers to thinking about whether something is good or bad and deciding it is bad. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

refuse (GNT)

decided it was worthless

**to acknowledge God:** Here this phrase refers to continuing to believe that God exists and is involved in their lives and requires something from them. Cranfield (page 128) says the phrase refers to "acknowledging Him, reckoning with Him, taking Him into account in the practical affairs of one's life." Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

admit/confess God in their thinking Uma Back Translation on TW.

they recognize/consider that God exists

### 1:28b

**He gave them up to a depraved mind,**

- God gave to them a mind that approves no good thoughts
- God also caused them to always think that good things are bad

**He gave them up:** The Greek word that the BSB translates as gave...up refers to putting someone under the control of something or someone else. See how you translated the similar clauses in 1:24 or 1:26.

**depraved:** The Greek word that the BSB translates as depraved refers to something that was tested and found worthless. It is similar to "did not see fit" in 1:28a. Here are other ways to translate this word:

debased (NIV11)

corrupted (GNT)

**1:28c****to do what ought not to be done.**

- and thinks to do improper things.
- and do deeds which are not right for people to do.

**what ought not to be done:** This phrase refers to things that are not proper or fitting to be done. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

improper conduct (RSV)

things that should never be done (NLT)

what it is not fitting to doUma Back Translation on TW.

**Romans 1:29****Section 1:18–32: God is angry with people because they sin**

In this section, Paul said that it is clear that God is angry about the bad things that people do. God has shown all people who he is, but they have rejected him. So they became fools and worshiped things instead of God. And so God put them under the control of sinful desires even more.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

The reason why God is angry with people

God's Wrath on Unrighteousness (ESV)

People do what is not right in God's sight and so God is angry

**1:29a–31**

In this list of evil deeds, the Greek does not have a connecting word between each item. The BSB copies what the Greek does here. In some languages it is more natural to have an “and” between each item. Use the most natural way of connecting items in a list in your translation.

**1:29a–b**

**every kind of wickedness, evil, greed, and depravity:** There is a textual issue regarding the Greek word that the BSB translates as evil in 1:29b: (1) Some Greek manuscripts have the word evil (BSB, RSV, NIV, GNT, NJB, NASB, CEV, NET, NABRE, REB, ESV, NCV). (2) Some Greek manuscripts have the words immorality, evil (KJV only). It is recommended that you follow option (1). The phrase every kind of applies to all four words:

wickedness, evil, greed, and depravity. Make that clear in your language. For example:

all manner of these things: unrighteousness, evil, covetousness, and malice

all kinds of unrighteousness and all kinds of evil and all kinds of covetousness and all kinds of malice

**wickedness:** This word refers to deeds that are not right to do. Here are other ways to translate this word:

deeds that are not upright/straight

**1:29a****They have become filled with every kind of wickedness,**

- They are full of all kinds of deeds that are not upright,
- At every opportunity they do what is not right,

**They have become filled with:** The Greek tense indicates that earlier these people became full of the bad deeds listed below and at that time were still full of them. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

They are full of

Their lives became full of (NLT)

In some languages using a past tense indicates that it is no longer true in the present. Translate in a way that indicates that they were still doing these things at that time.

**have become filled with:** This is a figurative way of saying that a person thinks of something often or all the time. Some languages cannot use have become filled when referring to sins. Here are other ways to translate this meaning:

They continually are thinking of

All of...arose in their insidesYongkom Back Translation by this author, unpublished manuscript.

These kinds of bad thoughts are very much among them all the time:

**1:29b****evil, greed, and depravity.**

- as well as full of wicked deeds, greed, and hate.
- and do very bad things to other people, and are always wanting more and more, and hurt other people.

**evil:** The Greek word refers to a person having no moral values. Anything is okay to think or do if he wants to. Satan is called “the evil one” (Matthew 5:37, John 17:15, Ephesians 6:16, and other verses). He is the best example of this way of thinking. Here are other ways to translate this word:

wickedness (NASB)

sinfulness

**greed:** This word refers to always wanting to have more. It often implies more than that person needs or more than other people. Here are other ways to translate this word:

covetousness (ESV)

grab-after what is not theirsKankanaey Back Translation on TW.

They want to increasingly multiply what they ownOtomi Back Translation on TW.

**depravity:** This word refers to wanting to do things that hurt other people or hurting them on purpose when doing bad things to them. Here are other ways to translate this word:

hate (NLT)

the desire to hurt others

They are mean (GW)

**1:29c****They are full of envy, murder,**

- They are full of resentment, murder/killing,
- And they are also always jealous of other people and kill people.

**They are full of envy:** The BSB adds the words They are. In Greek the list just continues but repeats the idea of full of. For example:

full of envy (NJB)

In some languages it is more natural to add “also” when repeating the idea full of here. For example:

They are also full of envy

and also full of envy

**envy:** This word refers to being upset with someone because that person is in a better situation than him in some way. Here are other ways to translate this word:

jealous of their companionsYakan Back Translation on TW.

resentment

They want what others have (CEV)

The word here does not refer to sexual jealousy (for example, a husband upset with his wife because she talked to another man and he is worried about her liking the other man more than him).

**murder:** This word refers to killing another person. It usually implies killing someone on purpose and against the law.

**1:29d****strife, deceit, and malice.**

- quarreling/arguing, cheating people out of their things, and have a lifestyle/attitude of hate.
- And they fight, and trick people out of their things, and are always trying to hurt other people.

**strife:** This word refers to conflict of any kind: arguments, fighting over a difference of opinion, or rivalry over a job or position. Here are other ways to translate this word:

fighting (GNT)

arguing

rivalry (REB)

**deceit:** The Greek word here refers to misleading people in order to gain some benefit or advantage.BDAG (page 256). Here are other ways to translate this word:

cheat (CEV)

defraud people of their things

trickstersKankanaey Back Translation on TW.

**malice:** This word refers to an attitude of wanting to hurt other people. It is similar to the Greek word that the BSB translates as “depravity” in 1:29b, but the word here refers to an ongoing attitude. Here are other ways to translate this word:

always hateful

the attitude of hurting others

being habitually mean

In some languages one word or phrase covers both “depravity” and malice. If that is true in your language, use only that one word or phrase in this verse.

#### 1:29e

#### **They are gossips,**

- They whisper about others,
- And they say/report bad things about others

**They are gossips:** The BSB adds the words They are here. The Greek changes case from genitive, to connect to “full,” to accusative. to indicate that the next twelve items are not grouped with “full of envy, murder, strife, deceit, malice,” but in a separate group. Paul was still describing these people. For example:

deceit, malignity, they are gossips, (RSV)

They gossip (GNT)

and they also gossip

**gossips:** The Greek word here is literally “whisperers.” It refers to a person who, quietly, in the ear of someone else, says bad things about others and passes on information or rumors about them that are hurtful. Here are other ways to translate this Greek word:

whisperers-behind-doors (JBP)

talk-behind-the-backUma Back Translation on TW.

## Romans 1:30

### Section 1:18–32: God is angry with people because they sin

In this section, Paul said that it is clear that God is angry about the bad things that people do. God has shown all people who he is, but they have rejected him. So they became fools and worshiped things instead of God. And so God put them under the control of sinful desires even more.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

The reason why God is angry with people

God’s Wrath on Unrighteousness (ESV)

People do what is not right in God’s sight and so God is angry

#### 1:30a

#### **slanderers, God-haters, insolent, arrogant,**

- insult/dishonor others, hate God, are proud and violent, conceited,
- and say evil things against others. And they hate God, and are very proud of themselves, and think of themselves as better than everyone else,

**slanderers:** This word refers to someone who says something for the purpose of hurting someone else’s reputation, name, or status. The words are spoken openly, in public, rather than what gossips do. Here are other ways to translate this word:

people who speak evil of others

hurt people on purpose with what they say

**God-haters:** There are two ways to interpret the Greek word that the BSB translates as God-haters:

1. It refers to people who hate God. For example:

God-haters (BSB) (BSB, RSV, NIV, ESV, NABRE, NASB, KJV, NLT, GW, CEV, NET, NCV)

1. It indicates that God hates these people. For example:

they are hateful to God (GNT) (GNT)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1), because “God hating them” is not a deed coming from them like the rest of the words and phrases in this list. Morris (on TW). Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

They hate God (NCV)

hating God

**insolent:** The Greek word that the BSB translates as insolent refers to a person who is very proud and therefore is violent against others. Here are other ways to translate this Greek word:

violently proud

both proud and violent

**arrogant:** This word refers to a person who is very proud of himself and thinks that he is a better person than others. Here are other ways to translate this word:

haughty (ESV)

conceited (CEV)

very proud of himself

puts himself above others

#### 1:30b

**and boastful. They invent new forms of evil; they disobey their parents.**

- always bragging, looking/hunting for and finding new kinds of evil deeds, disobeying their parents.
- and praise themselves. And they are always discovering new ways to do evil, and refuse to obey their father and mother.

**boastful:** Here this word refers to praising oneself. Here are other ways to translate this word:

brag about themselves (NCV)

always praise themselves

**They invent new forms of evil:** This phrase refers to finding new kinds of evil deeds or new ways to do evil things. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

thinking of new ways to do evil

seeking/finding new kinds of evil deeds

### Romans 1:31

#### Section 1:18–32: God is angry with people because they sin

In this section, Paul said that it is clear that God is angry about the bad things that people do. God has shown all people who he is, but they have rejected him. So they became fools and worshiped things instead of God. And so God put them under the control of sinful desires even more.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

The reason why God is angry with people

God’s Wrath on Unrighteousness (ESV)

People do what is not right in God’s sight and so God is angry

#### 1:31

#### **They are senseless, faithless, heartless, merciless.**

- They are without understanding, without keeping their promises, without affection, and without pity/mercy.
- And they are unthinking, and untrustworthy, and uncaring for others, and unmerciful.

#### **They are senseless, faithless, heartless, merciless:**

The Greek words are literally “not-understanding, not-keeping-their-word, not-having-affection, not-having-mercy.” If possible, use words that show the meaning of “not” or “without” each time here. For example:

no understanding, no fidelity, no love, no mercy (NIV11)

unthinking, unfaithful to their word/promises, unaffectionate, unmerciful

**senseless:** The Greek word here refers to not being able to understand things well. It is the same word as the Greek word that the BSB translates as “foolish” in 1:21. See how you translated this word in 1:21.

**faithless:** Here this word refers to making promises but not doing as promised. Here are other ways to translate this word:

untrustworthy (NASB)

they do not keep their promises (GNT)

break their promises (NLT)

Concerning what they say they will do, they do not do (it) Otomi Back Translation on TW.

**heartless:** There is a textual issue in 1:31: (1) Some Greek manuscripts have the word heartless (BSB, RSV, NIV, GNT, NJB, NASB, CEV, NET, NABRE, REB, ESV, NCV). (2) Some Greek manuscripts have the words heartless (and) implacable (KJV only). It is recommended that you follow option (1). The Greek word here refers to not having good feelings toward others or not caring for others. Here are other ways to translate this word:

without natural affection (KJV)

hardhearted (BDAG)

**merciless:** This word means “without pity or mercy.” These people show no mercy to others. Here are other ways to translate this word:

no mercy (NIV11)

no...pity for others (GNT)

## Romans 1:32

### Section 1:18–32: God is angry with people because they sin

In this section, Paul said that it is clear that God is angry about the bad things that people do. God has shown all people who he is, but they have rejected him. So they became fools and worshiped things instead of God. And so God put them under the control of sinful desires even more.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

The reason why God is angry with people

God's Wrath on Unrighteousness (ESV)

People do what is not right in God's sight and so God is angry

### 1:32a–c

**Although they know God's righteous decree that those who do such things are worthy of death, they not only continue to do these things:** The word Although indicates that the clause they know God's righteous decree that those who do such things are worthy of death is true. It also indicates that despite that being true, these people did such things anyway (the meaning of the clause they not only continue to do these things that is important here). Here are other ways to indicate this connection:

Though they know God's righteous decree that those who practice such things deserve to die, they not only do them (ESV)

They know that God's law says that people who live in this way deserve death. Yet, not only do they continue to do these very things (GNT)

It is true that they know God's decree that those who practice such things deserve to die, but they not only do them

### 1:32a

**Although they know God's righteous decree that**

- They know full well that God has said that
- They certainly know God has made it known/clear that

**they know:** The Greek word that the BSB translates as know often implies knowing something well. These people were not unsure; they knew full well what God has commanded and that the people who do those things Paul listed in 1:29–31 are worthy of God killing them for those deeds. For example:

they fully know (NET)

It implies that people are without excuse when they do those bad things. But in many languages know clearly indicates that, without adding “fully” here.

**God's righteous decree:** The word decree here refers to people knowing such people are worthy of death and that it is God who will cause that punishment of death to be carried out. That knowledge is based on what they learned about God from looking at the world (1:20). Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

God's statement

God has said that (CEV)

The word decree probably does not refer only to the laws that God gave Moses in the Old Testament. Schreiner (page 99) says, "Gentiles, without specifically having the Mosaic law, are aware of the moral requirements contained in that law." Do not translate this phrase in any way that only indicates the Laws of Moses.

**decree:** The word decree refers to a rule of "do not do this" or "do that." See the examples above.

### 1:32b

**those who do such things are worthy of death,**

- it is fitting/proper that those wrongdoers should die for those deeds,
- he commands that those who are doing those things should/must die for them.

**do such things:** Here the Greek word that the BSB translates as do refers simply to doing something. Here are other ways to translate this word:

are doing those things/deeds

live in those ways

**such things:** This phrase refers to the evil deeds listed in 1:28–31. Moo (page 121). See the examples above.

**are worthy of death:** The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as worthy of death indicates that the right thing to happen is that the people who do those evil deeds should die because they did them. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

should die (NCV)

fit to be punished by death Uma Back Translation on TW.

God will mark them for death Yongkom Back Translation, by this author, unpublished manuscript.

God says that...they will perish Levatbura Lama-song Back Translation, Papua New Guinea, in progress.

### 1:32c

**they not only continue to do these things,**

- but they are doing them anyway.
- But they continue to do those very/same things

### 1:32c–d

**they not only continue to do these things, but also approve of those who practice them:** The words not only...but indicate that these people do both things (continue to do these things and approve of those who practice them). It also emphasizes the second thing. Some scholars think that encouraging others to sin is worse than doing the sin themselves. But Fitzmyer says, "The approval of such sins in the conduct of others is just as sinful as if one were doing them oneself." Here are other ways to translate these words:

they continue to do these things, and even more, approve of those who practice them

yet they do them anyway. Worse yet, they encourage others to do them (NLT)

But they keep on doing evil things, and they even encourage others to do them. (CEV)

they continue to do them nonetheless. And not only that, but they also praise/honor other people who do things like that. Kankanaey Back Translation on TW.

**they...continue to do these things:** The Greek word that the BSB translates as do indicates that these people do them more than once, probably many times. For example:

they...continue to do them

they still do behavior like that Uma Back Translation on TW.

### 1:32d

**but also approve of those who practice them.**

- And not only that, they also happily say that it is good when other people are doing those deeds.
- and also say that those who are doing them are right to do them.

**approve of:** Here this phrase indicates that these people agree that other people should do the same as they and say it is good. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:



they are very happy to see Tagbanwa Back Translation on TW.

happily agree with

**practice:** Here the word practice refers to doing something often, as in 1:32b.

## Romans 2:1

### Section 2:1-16: The unbelieving hypocrite must change his thinking

In all of chapter two, Paul wrote as if to someone who disagreed with him. He used the singular “you” throughout the chapter. This form of teaching is called a “diatribe.” Only one person is talking (or writing), but it is as if two people are talking back and forth, asking and answering questions, making objections and responding. Using this diatribe, Paul rebuked those who judged others improperly. The person whom Paul spoke to here was not a believer. His evil deeds store up God’s wrath against him (2:5), and his sins will cause him to perish (2:12).

In this section, Paul addressed someone who judged others as bad but did the same things (2:1). God would punish such a person (2:2-3); it is according to what a person has done (2:6-11) and according to the knowledge of God that a person has (2:12-15).

Here are other possible headings for this section:

The person who does not believe and judges other people as bad yet does the same things

Hypocritical people who do not believe in Jesus

#### 2:1a

#### **You, therefore, have no excuse, you who pass judgment on another.**

- ¶ Therefore, O man/person, every one of you<sup>(plur)</sup> who judges, you cannot defend doing that.
- ¶ But many of you<sup>(plur)</sup> condemn other people when they do wrong. But not one of you can tell God one good reason for that behavior.

Paul later described this person, whom he addresses as “O man,” as someone who did not believe in Jesus. This person’s evil deeds stored up God’s wrath against him (2:5), and his sins would cause him to perish (2:12). He was of the same group as the group Paul described in 1:18-32, people who do not believe in Jesus.

This verse starts a new chapter. Readers may not see that this person was not a believer. You may want to:

- Make the section heading clearly refer to a person who does not believe. See the current suggested section heading and the suggested alternatives.
- Add a footnote on “you” or “O man” to explain. Here is an example footnote:

Paul spoke to a person who did not believe in Jesus here. This person was an example of this kind of hypocrite.

#### **You, therefore, have no excuse, you who pass judgment on another:**

The pronoun You is singular. See description above in Section 2:1-16. Paul did not have just one person in mind here, because many people were doing this. Consider how to make that clear in your language.

In some languages a footnote to explain would be helpful to the readers. Here is an example footnote:

Paul now wrote about people who judge others as bad people yet do the same bad things.

**You, therefore, have no excuse:** The Greek phrase is more literally “Therefore, you have no excuse, O man.” The term of address (“O man”) is not at the beginning of the sentence. In some languages it is more natural to have the term of address first, as in the BSB. For example:

O man, you therefore have no excuse

**You:** The Greek word that the BSB translates as You is literally “O man” (ESV). The word Paul uses is not excluding women from what he said here. In some languages it is more natural to use a word or phrase that includes women. For example:

O person

my friend (GNT)

**therefore:** This conjunction introduces a conclusion from what Paul wrote in 1:18-32. God is angry with the evil that people do (1:18), so now Paul wrote that God is also angry with people who judge other people unfairly (2:1).

**have no excuse:** The word excuse refers to an explanation of behavior when asked about that behavior. In this case, it indicates that the judging person might give reasons why he thinks it is right to judge others in this way. But Paul knew that this person had no good

reason for his judging attitude. His judging in this way was still wrong. Here are other ways to translate this word:

you have no defence (REB)

you have no answer for this

you have nothing with-which-to-answer God-Kankanaey Back Translation on TW.

See how you translated the word excuse in 1:20.

**pass judgment:** This word refers to looking at someone's behavior and deciding whether it is good or bad and whether the person deserves to be punished for it. The people that Paul wrote to here think of themselves as the judge of others' actions, with the right to decide about their guilt. But they had no authority to do that. Here are other ways to translate this word:

says is guilty

accuse others of doing wrong (CEV)

criticizes

## 2:1b

**For on whatever grounds you judge the other, you are condemning yourself,**

- For in what you<sup>(sing)</sup> judge the other person, you declare/show that someone should punish you,
- Look, God will judge you worthy of punishment on the same basis you judge others guilty,
- Because whenever you<sup>(plur)</sup> look at what somebody else has done and say, "That person has done wrong and God should punish him," it shows/indicates that it is right for God to punish you.

**For:** This conjunction introduces the reason why the judging people had no excuse. Here is another way to translate this word:

because

Some English versions omit this conjunction (perhaps because of another "because" in 2:1c) and allow the context to indicate the connection.

**on whatever grounds you judge the other, you are condemning yourself:** The Greek is literally "in what

you judge the other, you condemn yourself." These people did the same things (2:1c) that they condemn in others, so they condemn themselves in that way. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

When you judge them, you are really judging yourself guilty (NCV)

When you say they are wicked and should be punished, you are condemning yourself (NLT)

**are condemning yourself:** The word condemning usually indicates that a judge has decided how to punish the guilty person. Here it indicates that these people, by judging others, have indicated that they themselves are worthy of punishment. Here are other ways to translate this word:

say that you yourself should be punished

declare yourself worthy to be punished

proclaim that someone should punish you

## 2:1c

**because you who pass judgment do the same things.**

- because you, a so-called judge, do exactly the same deeds.
- for you, as self-appointed judge, do the same deeds that you judge as wrong in others.
- Why is that/this? It is because you, who are behaving like a judge, are doing the same bad things as that person.

**because you who pass judgment do the same things:** The phrase you who pass judgment again describes the person that Paul addressed as you. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

you who judge practice the same things (NASB)

you, as judge, do the same deeds

Some English versions omit the phrase pass judgment because that meaning is already present in this verse and it makes 2:1c easier to read. For example:

you are guilty of doing the very same things (CEV)

you do the same things they do (NCV)

**who pass judgment:** The Greek words here are “the one judging.” The words indicate that these people often judge others. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

judging one

who judge (NASB)

who judge others as bad

**do:** Here the Greek word refers to doing something. Here are other ways to translate this word:

practice (ESV)

are doing

See how you translated this word in 1:32.

## Romans 2:2

### Section 2:1–16: The unbelieving hypocrite must change his thinking

In all of chapter two, Paul wrote as if to someone who disagreed with him. He used the singular “you” throughout the chapter. This form of teaching is called a “diatribe.” Only one person is talking (or writing), but it is as if two people are talking back and forth, asking and answering questions, making objections and responding. Using this diatribe, Paul rebuked those who judged others improperly. The person whom Paul spoke to here was not a believer. His evil deeds store up God’s wrath against him (2:5), and his sins will cause him to perish (2:12).

In this section, Paul addressed someone who judged others as bad but did the same things (2:1). God would punish such a person (2:2–3); it is according to what a person has done (2:6–11) and according to the knowledge of God that a person has (2:12–15).

Here are other possible headings for this section:

The person who does not believe and judges other people as bad yet does the same things

Hypocritical people who do not believe in Jesus

## 2:2

### And we know that God’s judgment against those who do such things is based on truth.

- We<sup>(dual,incl)</sup> know that God decides based on the truth that people who do such evil things deserve punishment.
- And we know that God punishes people who do such bad things, and his decisions are true.

**And:** This verse begins with a Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as And. It probably indicates a general connection to the previous verse. It introduces a new thought connected to what Paul had just said. Consider how to connect this verse in a natural way in your language. Many English versions omit the conjunction and allow the context to indicate the connection.

**we know:** Paul included this other person (addressed as “you”) here. In some languages a literal translation would not include him. If that is true in your language, make that clear. For example:

You and I know

**God’s judgment:** The Greek word that the BSB translates as judgment refers to a verdict pronounced by a judge. It usually implies a guilty verdict and so may refer to the punishment for that guilt. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

God’s verdict

the condemnation of God

The word judgment implies the deed of judging. Some languages may need to express this noun phrase with a verb. For example:

God condemns

God declares him/them guilty

**is based on truth:** The Greek is literally “is according to the truth/facts.” God knows everything, including a wrongdoer’s actions. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

rightly (ESV)

in accordance with truth (NET)

his decision is certainly trueUma Back Translation on TW.

## Romans 2:3

### Section 2:1–16: The unbelieving hypocrite must change his thinking

In all of chapter two, Paul wrote as if to someone who disagreed with him. He used the singular “you” throughout the chapter. This form of teaching is called a “diatribe.” Only one person is talking (or writing), but it is as if two people are talking back and forth, asking and answering questions, making objections and responding. Using this diatribe, Paul rebuked those who judged others improperly. The person whom Paul spoke to here was not a believer. His evil deeds store up God’s wrath against him (2:5), and his sins will cause him to perish (2:12).

In this section, Paul addressed someone who judged others as bad but did the same things (2:1). God would punish such a person (2:2–3); it is according to what a person has done (2:6–11) and according to the knowledge of God that a person has (2:12–15).

Here are other possible headings for this section:

The person who does not believe and judges other people as bad yet does the same things

Hypocritical people who do not believe in Jesus

### 2:3a

#### So when you, O man, pass judgment on others, yet do the same things,

- O man/person, you<sup>(sing)</sup> who judge as bad those people who do such things but do them yourself,
- You mere man/person. You condemn the deeds of others and say that God should punish them, and yet you do them yourself.
- You<sup>(plur)</sup>, you are only people and not God, yet/but you say “That person has done wrong and God should punish him;” however, you do the same things/wrongs.

**So when you, O man, pass judgment on others, yet do the same things:** In some languages it is more natural to have the term of address and description first in the clause. For example:

O man, you who judge those who practice such things and yet do them yourself

**O man:** This is the same phrase as that Greek word that the BSB translates as “You” in 2:1. Translate this phrase as you did there.

### 2:3b

#### do you think you will escape God’s judgment?

- do you think that God will not punish you too?
- You are wrong to think that God will not punish you too.
- Do not suppose/expect that God will allow you to escape his judgment against you.

**do you think you will escape God’s judgment?:** This is a rhetorical question. It emphasizes that this man should not expect to escape the judgment of God. Translate this with that meaning. Here are some ways:

- As a rhetorical question. For example:

do you think you will escape God’s condemnation?  
(NJB)

- As a statement. For example:

You are wrong to suppose/expect that you will escape the judgment of God

- As a command. For example:

Do not suppose/expect that you will escape the judgment of God

**think:** Here the Greek word that the BSB translates as think refers to thinking something to be true. Paul warned this man not to have the opinion that God will not punish those who judge others as bad yet do the same evil deeds. Here are other ways to translate this word:

suppose (ESV)

believe

expect

**escape:** This word refers to avoiding danger in some way. This man perhaps thinks that he can prevent God from punishing him. Here are other ways to translate this word:

avoid (NLT)

run away from

**God's judgment:** In some languages, the word judgment must be translated as a verb. For example:

God's judging you

on the day when God judges you

## Romans 2:4

### Section 2:1-16: The unbelieving hypocrite must change his thinking

In all of chapter two, Paul wrote as if to someone who disagreed with him. He used the singular “you” throughout the chapter. This form of teaching is called a “diatribe.” Only one person is talking (or writing), but it is as if two people are talking back and forth, asking and answering questions, making objections and responding. Using this diatribe, Paul rebuked those who judged others improperly. The person whom Paul spoke to here was not a believer. His evil deeds store up God's wrath against him (2:5), and his sins will cause him to perish (2:12).

In this section, Paul addressed someone who judged others as bad but did the same things (2:1). God would punish such a person (2:2-3); it is according to what a person has done (2:6-11) and according to the knowledge of God that a person has (2:12-15).

Here are other possible headings for this section:

The person who does not believe and judges other people as bad yet does the same things

Hypocritical people who do not believe in Jesus

### 2:4a-b

**Or do you disregard the riches of His kindness, tolerance, and patience, not realizing that God's kindness leads you to repentance?:** This is a rhetorical question. It emphasizes that this man should not expect God to be kind, forbearing, and patient with him if he continued to sin in that way. Translate this with that meaning. Here are some ways:

- As a rhetorical question. For example:

are you not disregarding his abundant goodness, tolerance and patience, failing to realise that this generosity of God is meant to bring you to repentance? (NJB)

- As a statement. For example:

you are wrong to disregard the riches of his kindness, tolerance, and patience, and you should know that God's kindness leads you to repentance.

- As a command. For example:

do not disregard the riches of his kindness, tolerance, and patience. Know that God's kindness leads you to repentance.

You should probably use the same kind of sentence (rhetorical question, statement, or command) as in 2:3.

### 2:4a

**Or do you disregard the riches of His kindness, tolerance, and patience,**

- Or, another question is: do you<sup>(sing)</sup> scorn the riches of his kind deeds to you, tolerance, and patient waiting for you,
- God has been very good to you. He tolerates your misdeeds. And he waits for you to do what is right. You are wrong to despise him for doing that.
- Do not think of God's great kindness and patience as worthless/nothing.

**Or:** In this context the word Or indicates that Paul asked a second rhetorical question related to the first rhetorical question (2:3). Both rhetorical questions are rebukes against wrong thinking. Consider how to indicate that meaning.

**disregard:** Here this phrase refers to despising something. This man should not think of God's kindness, tolerance, and patience as worthless. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

have contempt for (GW)

despise (GNT)

think nothing of (NCV)

### the riches of His kindness, tolerance, and patience:

Paul used the word riches figuratively here to indicate that God has much kindness, tolerance, and patience. Some languages cannot use the word riches figuratively here. If that is true in your language, translate the figurative meaning. For example:

his great kindness, tolerance, and patience (GNT)

his abundant goodness, tolerance and patience  
(NJB)

**kindness:** This word refers to doing good to someone because you want to. God does many good things for people.

**tolerance:** This word refers to waiting to punish someone, to give him time to stop doing bad deeds. God has delayed punishing people when they have deserved it, allowing them the opportunity to repent. Here are other ways to translate this word:

forbearance (ESV)

waiting to judge as guilty

**patience:** This word also refers to waiting for a person to either stop doing bad or to do something good. God is often endures people's bad deeds waiting for them to do good deeds. You may have an idiom that translates this meaning.

This word is similar in meaning to "tolerance" above. See the General Comment below.

#### General Comment on 2:4a

The words "tolerance" and "patience" are very similar in meaning. In some languages it is more natural to translate using one word or phrase. For example:

patient (NCV)

God is waiting for the person to separate from evil  
Otomi Back Translation on TW.

#### 2:4b

#### not realizing that God's kindness leads you to repentance?

- not realizing that the kind deeds of God lead you to repent?
- You are wrong to ignore the fact that whenever God does good to you, he wants you to turn away from your misdeeds.
- And do not ignore God calling you to leave your wrongdoing when he does kind deeds to you.

**not realizing that God's kindness leads you to repentance:** This clause is a part of the rhetorical question. It implies that the man should know that God's kindness leads to repentance but has ignored this fact. Here are some ways to indicate this implied information:

- Make this clause a separate rhetorical question. For example:

Do you not realize that God's kindness is meant to lead you to repentance? (NRSV)

Can't you see that his kindness is intended to turn you from your sin? (NLT)

- Include the implied information in the text. For example:

not thinking about the fact that God's kindness leads you to repentance

**leads you to repentance:** The Greek is literally "leads you to/toward repentance." In either case, the phrase indicates that the person is brought to a situation where he has an opportunity to repent. For example:

leads you toward repentance (NIV84)

so that you will/would repent from your bad doings  
Nalik Back Translation, draft, Papua New Guinea.

is intended to turn you from your sin (NLT)

**repentance:** When a person repents he does these three things:

1. He feels sorry and sad about his past wrongdoings.
2. He turns his back on his former ways of doing wrong.
3. He turns to God, depending on him to help him live in a new and different way which pleases God.

Here are other ways to translate this word:

turn...from your sin (NLT)

change the way you think and act (GW)

turn to him (CEV)

change your hearts and lives (NCV)

abandon your evil behavior  
Western Bukidnon Manobo Back Translation on TW.

regret your sins and change your liversYakan Back Translation on TW.

## Romans 2:5

### Section 2:1–16: The unbelieving hypocrite must change his thinking

In all of chapter two, Paul wrote as if to someone who disagreed with him. He used the singular “you” throughout the chapter. This form of teaching is called a “diatribe.” Only one person is talking (or writing), but it is as if two people are talking back and forth, asking and answering questions, making objections and responding. Using this diatribe, Paul rebuked those who judged others improperly. The person whom Paul spoke to here was not a believer. His evil deeds store up God’s wrath against him (2:5), and his sins will cause him to perish (2:12).

In this section, Paul addressed someone who judged others as bad but did the same things (2:1). God would punish such a person (2:2–3); it is according to what a person has done (2:6–11) and according to the knowledge of God that a person has (2:12–15).

Here are other possible headings for this section:

The person who does not believe and judges other people as bad yet does the same things

Hypocritical people who do not believe in Jesus

### 2:5a

#### But because of your hard and unrepentant heart,

- ¶ But through/in your stubbornness and unrepentant heart/insides/mind,
- ¶ But by stubbornly refusing to change your ways and leave your wrongdoing/sinning,

**But:** There is contrast between God’s kindness leading to repentance (2:4b) and this man not wanting to repent.

But the scholars who translated some English versions did not see contrast here and did not translate the Greek conjunction. For example:

Your stubborn refusal to repent... (NJB)

**because of:** This man’s hard and unrepentant heart is the basis for God being angry with him. Here are other ways to translate this word:

according to

In (REB)

you have a hard and stubborn heart, and so (GNT)

**your hard and unrepentant heart:** The Greek word that the BSB translates as hard means “stubbornness” here.BDAG (page 930). The man was stubborn in that he refused to change his way of thinking or behaving.

The word unrepentant indicates that the man did not want to repent. He did not feel sorry about his sins and did not want to stop doing them.

Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

you are stubborn and refuse to change (NCV)

you are stubborn and refuse to turn from your sin (NLT)

you are stubborn and don’t want to change the way you think (GW)

your heads are hard, you do not want to abandon your sinsYakan Back Translation on TW.

It is possible that this phrase is a figure of speech that means “you stubbornly refuse to repent.” For example:

your obstinate refusal to repent (JBP)

you refuse to repent because your minds are hardKankanaey Back Translation on TW.

**heart:** Here this word refers to the part of a person in which thoughts and feelings occur. In some languages people use a different part of the body, such as the mind, throat, liver, or stomach, in this way. In other languages people use a non-figurative word or phrase. For example:

insides/liver

mind

### 2:5b

#### you are storing up wrath against yourself for the day of wrath,

- you are increasing the store/amount of anger against you

- you are causing God to be more and more angry with you on the day when he will punish wrongdoers,

**you are storing up wrath against yourself:** The phrase storing up is a metaphor. Here it indicates that God continues to be ready to punish this person because he continues to refuse to repent. In some languages a literal translation would have the wrong meaning. If that is true in your language, translate the meaning of the metaphor. For example:

you are causing God to be more and more angry with you

you are adding to the anger that God will have against you (GW)

**wrath against yourself:** Here the word wrath refers to God's anger. God is angry with this person because of his hard and impenitent heart. In some languages it is more clear to explain whose anger this is. For example:

God's wrath for/against you

**for the day of wrath:** This phrase refers to God's judgment day. It will occur in the future. God is angry with wrongdoers who have refused to repent and will punish them.

This phrase is explained in 2:5c. If the meaning of this phrase is still not clear with reading 2:5c, you may want to:

- Explain it in the text. For example:

on the day of wrath and judgment of all people

- Explain it in a footnote. Here is an example footnote:

This refers to God's judgment day. It will occur in the future. God will be angry with wrongdoers who have refused to repent.

### 2:5c

**when God's righteous judgment will be revealed.**

- when God judging according to truth will be seen.
- the day when everyone will see that the way he judges people is right.

**God's righteous judgment will be revealed:** The phrase will be revealed indicates that everyone will see God's righteous judgment. This clause is passive.

Some languages must use an active clause here. For example:

On that day everyone will see God's right judgments. (NCV)

**God's righteous judgment:** This phrase refers to God rightly judging people. He will look at what a person has done and thought and then rightly reward them or punish them. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

God's just verdicts (NJB)

God will judge people fairly according to their deeds and thoughts

## Romans 2:6

**Section 2:1–16: The unbelieving hypocrite must change his thinking**

In all of chapter two, Paul wrote as if to someone who disagreed with him. He used the singular "you" throughout the chapter. This form of teaching is called a "diatribe." Only one person is talking (or writing), but it is as if two people are talking back and forth, asking and answering questions, making objections and responding. Using this diatribe, Paul rebuked those who judged others improperly. The person whom Paul spoke to here was not a believer. His evil deeds store up God's wrath against him (2:5), and his sins will cause him to perish (2:12).

In this section, Paul addressed someone who judged others as bad but did the same things (2:1). God would punish such a person (2:2–3); it is according to what a person has done (2:6–11) and according to the knowledge of God that a person has (2:12–15).

Here are other possible headings for this section:

The person who does not believe and judges other people as bad yet does the same things

Hypocritical people who do not believe in Jesus

### 2:6

**God "will repay each one according to his deeds."**

- God will pay back each person based on what his or her deeds were.
- God will reward or punish each person according to what he or she did.



Paul talked here about what will take place at God's judgment time in the future.

**God "will repay:** Here the Greek word that the BSB translates as repay means "to pay back," or "to give someone what he deserves." Here are other ways to translate this clause:

He will repay (NJB)

God will reward or punish (NCV)

**each one:** This phrase refers to every person. For example:

to each person (NIV)

**according to his deeds:** This phrase indicates that God will reward good deeds and punish bad deeds.

**deeds:** Here this word means "what someone did."

### General Comment on 2:6

Similar words are found in Psalm 62:12 and Proverbs 24:12. If you indicate the location of quotes from the Old Testament with cross-references, you may want to do so here.

## Romans 2:7

### Section 2:1-16: The unbelieving hypocrite must change his thinking

In all of chapter two, Paul wrote as if to someone who disagreed with him. He used the singular "you" throughout the chapter. This form of teaching is called a "diatribe." Only one person is talking (or writing), but it is as if two people are talking back and forth, asking and answering questions, making objections and responding. Using this diatribe, Paul rebuked those who judged others improperly. The person whom Paul spoke to here was not a believer. His evil deeds store up God's wrath against him (2:5), and his sins will cause him to perish (2:12).

In this section, Paul addressed someone who judged others as bad but did the same things (2:1). God would punish such a person (2:2-3); it is according to what a person has done (2:6-11) and according to the knowledge of God that a person has (2:12-15).

Here are other possible headings for this section:

The person who does not believe and judges other people as bad yet does the same things

Hypocritical people who do not believe in Jesus

### 2:7a-8b

Paul wrote about two groups here. He talked about the first group in 2:7a-c and the second group in 2:8a-b. The first group are those who persist in doing good deeds. The second group are those who do evil deeds.

### 2:7a-c

**To those who by perseverance in doing good seek glory, honor, and immortality, He will give eternal life:**

This clause follows the Greek order. Normally in English, the phrase To those... would come after the phrase eternal life. Having this phrase first indicates that this group is who Paul wanted to talk about now.

Some languages cannot move this phrase like that. If that is true in your language, you may want to:

- Leave it in front and make it the topic in a natural way in your language. Then refer to this group with the pronoun "them." For example:

About those who by perseverance in doing good seek, glory, honor, and immortality, he will give eternal life to them

- Put it in its normal place. For example:

he will give eternal life to those who by perseverance in doing good seek glory, honor, and immortality If possible, indicate that it is the topic.

### 2:7a

**To those who by perseverance in doing good**

- To those people who endure in doing good deeds,
- Some people keep on doing what is good

**by perseverance:** Here the word perseverance refers to consistently persevering. These people continue to do good deeds for their whole lives. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

by persistence (NIV)

always continuing (NCV)

have persisted Kankanaey Back Translation on TW.

**doing good:** The Greek phrase is literally "of good works." It refers to deeds that honor God, help others and such. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

well-doing (ESV)

behaving well

## 2:7b

### seek glory, honor, and immortality,

- seeking God to give them glory, honor, and life that cannot be damaged,
- in order that God will put them in a great situation and honor them and give to them life that is not able to become bad.

**seek glory, honor, and immortality:** The Greek grammar indicates that this group of people sought these things at the same time that they were doing good (2:7a). The word seek indicates that glory, honor, and immortality are goals for doing good deeds. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

seeking after the glory and honor and immortality (NLT)

with the goal of attaining glory, honor, and immortality

having the goal/desire of God giving them glory, honor, and immortality

**glory:** Here this word refers to the great and perfect life that these people will live. In some languages a literal translation would not have the correct meaning. If that is true in your language, indicate the correct meaning. For example:

very great situation/position/life

Also see glory, sense A3(b) in KBT.

**honor:** Here this word refers to respect. God will respect this group of people.

**immortality:** The Greek word means “not able to become bad or ruined or dead.” A person whose life is not able to become bad would live forever. But the focus of this word is that this life will never become bad in any way. Here are other ways to translate this word:

incorruptible life

life that is not able to become bad

## 2:7c

### He will give eternal life.

- he/God will give life forever.
- God will give to those people life that never ends.

**eternal life:** This phrase refers to life that never ends. It implies life that will never become bad.

## Romans 2:8

### Section 2:1–16: The unbelieving hypocrite must change his thinking

In all of chapter two, Paul wrote as if to someone who disagreed with him. He used the singular “you” throughout the chapter. This form of teaching is called a “diatribe.” Only one person is talking (or writing), but it is as if two people are talking back and forth, asking and answering questions, making objections and responding. Using this diatribe, Paul rebuked those who judged others improperly. The person whom Paul spoke to here was not a believer. His evil deeds store up God’s wrath against him (2:5), and his sins will cause him to perish (2:12).

In this section, Paul addressed someone who judged others as bad but did the same things (2:1). God would punish such a person (2:2–3); it is according to what a person has done (2:6–11) and according to the knowledge of God that a person has (2:12–15).

Here are other possible headings for this section:

The person who does not believe and judges other people as bad yet does the same things

Hypocritical people who do not believe in Jesus

## 2:8a

### But for those who are self-seeking and who reject the truth and follow wickedness,

- But for those people who are selfishly ambitious and do not obey the true words of God but rather obey evil thoughts,
- But some people are selfish. They refuse to follow what God says is true. Instead, they follow evil ways.

**But:** Paul now wrote about the second group. They are very different from the first group, so many English versions translate the Greek conjunction as But.

**are self-seeking:** The meaning of the Greek word is not entirely certain, but most scholars think it means “ambitious in a selfish way.” This kind of person does everything for his own personal benefit, not to benefit

God or other people. Here are other ways to translate this word:

selfishly ambitious (NASB)

selfish (NCV)

just think of themselves

the only thing they think about is what they want  
Western Bukidnon Manobo Back Translation on TW.

**who reject the truth:** These people do not do what they know God would want them to do. In some languages the word truth must be translated with a phrase. For example:

who do not obey the true words of God

**follow wickedness:** This is the opposite of obeying the truth. These people do what they know God would want them not to do. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

follow what is wrong (GW)

live lives of wickedness (NLT)

obey unrighteousness (ESV)

## 2:8b

### there will be wrath and anger.

- God will be very angry with them.
- God will give to them punishment full of his fury/anger.

**there will be wrath and anger:** The BSB supplies the words there will be. The context implies “he will give” from 2:7c. It indicates that God will have wrath and anger toward this second group of people. For example:

on them God will pour out his anger and fury (GNT)

God will be angry and furious

**wrath and anger:** The Greek word that the BSB translates as wrath can mean both “anger” and “punishment.” The Greek word that the BSB translates as

anger can mean both “passion” and anger. They probably have similar meanings here. Together they would indicate a great amount of anger.

Some languages have only one word for the meaning of “anger.” If that is true in your language, indicate a great amount of anger. For example:

great anger

Some scholars think this phrase is a figure of speech where one term describes the other even though they are connected with and. For example:

the fury of retribution (NJB)

## Romans 2:9

### Section 2:1–16: The unbelieving hypocrite must change his thinking

In all of chapter two, Paul wrote as if to someone who disagreed with him. He used the singular “you” throughout the chapter. This form of teaching is called a “diatribe.” Only one person is talking (or writing), but it is as if two people are talking back and forth, asking and answering questions, making objections and responding. Using this diatribe, Paul rebuked those who judged others improperly. The person whom Paul spoke to here was not a believer. His evil deeds store up God’s wrath against him (2:5), and his sins will cause him to perish (2:12).

In this section, Paul addressed someone who judged others as bad but did the same things (2:1). God would punish such a person (2:2–3); it is according to what a person has done (2:6–11) and according to the knowledge of God that a person has (2:12–15).

Here are other possible headings for this section:

The person who does not believe and judges other people as bad yet does the same things

Hypocritical people who do not believe in Jesus

## 2:9a

### There will be trouble and distress for every human being who does evil,

- God will oppress and trouble every person who does evil deeds,
- God will cause all people who live doing bad/evil deeds to suffer and feel distress/anxious.

**There will be trouble and distress for:** The Greek is literally “tribulation and distress on.” The BSB and many English versions add the words There will be to make the English natural.

The context probably implies the words “he will give” again from 2:7c. For example:

He will give trouble and suffering to (NCV)

**trouble:** The Greek word refers to oppression, suffering, or persecution. God will cause all people who do evil to suffer.

**distress:** This word refers to difficulties or troubles that people experience. God’s punishment will be very difficult for these evil people.

**who does evil:** The word does indicates doing evil often. For example:

who lives doing evil

who practices evil deeds

**does evil:** This phrase refers to bad behavior. It includes not only treating others in unfair ways but also living in morally bad ways. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

are wicked (CEV)

is a wrongdoer (REB)

do badYakan Back Translation on TW.

## 2:9b

### first for the Jew, then for the Greek;

- first priority being the Jews but also the non-Jews.
- This is true especially for Jews, but also for people who are not Jews.

**first for the Jew, then for the Greek:** This indicates that God will punish both Jews and Greeks. It also indicates that the Jews are first in status or time. The Jews are God’s people (higher status) but God will still judge them for their sins.Cranfield (page 150). Or it could mean that on the day of judgment, God will judge the Jews first.Jewett (page 208).

In some languages, a literal translation would wrongly indicate two separate judgments. If that is true in your language, you may want to:

- Translate the literal meaning and allow other verses to indicate the correct meaning.
- Translate the literal meaning and explain it in a footnote. Here is an example footnote:

These words indicate that either (1) The Jews have higher status as God’s people but God will still judge them for their sins; or (2) On the day of judgment, God will judge the Jews first.

- Translate the meaning of the figure of speech. For example:

especially the Jews but so also the GentilesKankanaey Back Translation on TW.

**Greek:** Here this word refers to people who are not Jews. For example:

Gentile (NIV)

those who are not Jews (NCV)

## Romans 2:10

### Section 2:1–16: The unbelieving hypocrite must change his thinking

In all of chapter two, Paul wrote as if to someone who disagreed with him. He used the singular “you” throughout the chapter. This form of teaching is called a “diatribe.” Only one person is talking (or writing), but it is as if two people are talking back and forth, asking and answering questions, making objections and responding. Using this diatribe, Paul rebuked those who judged others improperly. The person whom Paul spoke to here was not a believer. His evil deeds store up God’s wrath against him (2:5), and his sins will cause him to perish (2:12).

In this section, Paul addressed someone who judged others as bad but did the same things (2:1). God would punish such a person (2:2–3); it is according to what a person has done (2:6–11) and according to the knowledge of God that a person has (2:12–15).

Here are other possible headings for this section:

The person who does not believe and judges other people as bad yet does the same things

Hypocritical people who do not believe in Jesus

**2:10a**

**but glory, honor, and peace for everyone who does good,**

- But God will give glory, honor, and peace to every person who does good deeds,
- However, for people who live doing good deeds, God will put them in a great situation and honor them, and cause them to have no troubles.

**glory, honor:** Translate these words as you did in 2:7.

**peace:** Here this word refers to well-being and being free from all kinds of troubles.

**who does good:** The word does indicates doing good often. For example:

who lives doing good

who practices good deeds

**does good:** The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as good is literally “the good thing.” It refers to good behavior. It includes not only treating others in fair ways but living in morally good ways. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

do right (CEV)

does good deeds

do good Yakan Back Translation on TW.

**2:10b**

**first for the Jew, then for the Greek.**

- first priority being the Jews but also the non-Jews.
- This is true especially for Jews, but also for people who are not Jews.

**first for the Jew, then for the Greek:** Translate this as you did in 2:9b.

**Romans 2:11**

**Section 2:1–16: The unbelieving hypocrite must change his thinking**

In all of chapter two, Paul wrote as if to someone who disagreed with him. He used the singular “you” throughout the chapter. This form of teaching is called a “diatribe.” Only one person is talking (or writing), but it is as if two people are talking back and forth, asking and answering questions, making objections and responding. Using this diatribe, Paul rebuked those

who judged others improperly. The person whom Paul spoke to here was not a believer. His evil deeds store up God’s wrath against him (2:5), and his sins will cause him to perish (2:12).

In this section, Paul addressed someone who judged others as bad but did the same things (2:1). God would punish such a person (2:2–3); it is according to what a person has done (2:6–11) and according to the knowledge of God that a person has (2:12–15).

Here are other possible headings for this section:

The person who does not believe and judges other people as bad yet does the same things

Hypocritical people who do not believe in Jesus

**2:11**

**For God does not show favoritism.**

- For God does not see one person as more important/higher than another.
- Because God judges everybody in the same way.

**For:** This conjunction introduces the reason why God will judge Jew and non-Jew in the same way.

**God does not show favoritism:** This clause indicates that God treats one person or group in the same way as any other person or group. He does not look at their family, wealth, name, language, culture, or nationality and say “I like them better.” Here are other ways to translate this clause:

God shows no partiality. (ESV)

God judges everyone by the same standard. (GNT)

When God judges people, he looks at all of them as equal.

When God judges a person, he does not think, “I will not punish that person because he comes from an important family/tribe.”

**Romans 2:12**

**Section 2:1–16: The unbelieving hypocrite must change his thinking**

In all of chapter two, Paul wrote as if to someone who disagreed with him. He used the singular “you” throughout the chapter. This form of teaching is called a “diatribe.” Only one person is talking (or writing), but

it is as if two people are talking back and forth, asking and answering questions, making objections and responding. Using this diatribe, Paul rebuked those who judged others improperly. The person whom Paul spoke to here was not a believer. His evil deeds store up God's wrath against him (2:5), and his sins will cause him to perish (2:12).

In this section, Paul addressed someone who judged others as bad but did the same things (2:1). God would punish such a person (2:2-3); it is according to what a person has done (2:6-11) and according to the knowledge of God that a person has (2:12-15).

Here are other possible headings for this section:

The person who does not believe and judges other people as bad yet does the same things

Hypocritical people who do not believe in Jesus

### 2:12a

#### All who sin apart from the law

- ¶ For/Because everyone who does not know the laws/rules of Moses has sinned against God
- ¶ Truly, many people do not know the laws/rules that God gave to Moses. All of them have done wrong against God,

The Greek begins with a conjunction that is usually translated as “for.” The BSB does not translate this conjunction. It introduces a reason or an explanation of what Paul said in 2:11. If it would be more natural in your language to translate this word, here are other ways to translate it:

Because

Here's the reason: (GW)

Indeed

The fact is

**All who sin:** The word sin means “do wrong against someone,” either by breaking a law or going against what is expected to be done. Here it includes doing wrong against God.

**apart from the law:** This phrase describes people who do not use the Jewish law to rule their lives. This Jewish law is in the first five books of the Old Testament. It

is sometimes called “the Law of Moses” (for example, Luke 2:22), because God gave these laws to Moses.

In some languages a literal translation would not refer to the Jewish law. If that is true in your language, indicate clearly which law this is. For example:

do not have the Law of Moses (GNT)

don't know about God's Law (GW)

You may want a footnote to explain where these laws are. Here is an example footnote:

This refers to the laws God gave Moses. They are in the first five books of the Old Testament.

### 2:12b

#### will also perish apart from the law,

- and will also die in ruin without God judging them by those laws/rules.
- so God will also destroy them because they sinned against God according to what they knew even without God judging them by the law of Moses.

**will also perish apart from the law:** This indicates that God will judge the non-Jews by what they know about God but not by the Jewish law. He will see that they are guilty of sinning against him, so they will experience death and destruction as punishment for their sins. Here are other ways to translate these words:

will also perish without the law (ESV)

will die without reference to the Law (JBP)

will perish outside the law (REB)

In some languages a literal translation would not have the correct meaning. If that is true in your language, you may want to include some implied information to explain the text. For example:

will also perish because they were guilty before God even if he judges them without using the law of Moses

will also perish because they sinned against God even without God judging them by the law of the Jews

**perish:** Here this word refers to dying but also implies destruction or ruin. Here are other ways to translate this word:

be destroyed (NLT)

die in ruin/destruction

### 2:12c

#### and all who sin under the law

- Also,/And everyone who knows those laws/rules has sinned against God
- Also,/And other people try to follow the laws/rules that God gave to Moses. All of them have done wrong against God,

**under the law:** This phrase describes people who use the Jewish law to rule their lives. Translate the word law so that it refers to the Jewish law here. You may want to:

- Allow 2:12a-b to explain that it is the Jewish law and do not explain it again here. For example:

under that law

- Translate it here as you did in 2:12a. For example:

have the law of Moses

know about God's Law

### 2:12d

#### will be judged by the law.

- and will have God judge them as guilty according to those laws.
- and God will condemn them because they have not obeyed those laws.

**will be judged by the law:** This clause is passive. Some languages must use an active clause. For example:

God will judge them according to the law of Moses

## Romans 2:13

### Section 2:1-16: The unbelieving hypocrite must change his thinking

In all of chapter two, Paul wrote as if to someone who disagreed with him. He used the singular "you" throughout the chapter. This form of teaching is called

a "diatribe." Only one person is talking (or writing), but it is as if two people are talking back and forth, asking and answering questions, making objections and responding. Using this diatribe, Paul rebuked those who judged others improperly. The person whom Paul spoke to here was not a believer. His evil deeds store up God's wrath against him (2:5), and his sins will cause him to perish (2:12).

In this section, Paul addressed someone who judged others as bad but did the same things (2:1). God would punish such a person (2:2-3); it is according to what a person has done (2:6-11) and according to the knowledge of God that a person has (2:12-15).

Here are other possible headings for this section:

The person who does not believe and judges other people as bad yet does the same things

Hypocritical people who do not believe in Jesus

### 2:13a

#### For it is not the hearers of the law who are righteous before God,

- For/Because those who only have heard the God's laws/rules are not declared righteous/upright by God,
- Indeed/Truly, God will not say that people are in a right relationship with him just because they listened to someone reading the laws of Moses to them.

**For:** This conjunction introduces an explanation of 2:12c-d.

**the hearers of the law:** Compared to 2:13b, the word hearers refers to people who have heard the Jewish law but do not try to follow it.

In some languages a literal translation would wrongly imply that they obeyed the law as well. If that is true in your language, make it clear that they heard it but did not obey it. For example:

people who only listen to the law

those who hear the law but do not follow/obey it

**who are righteous before God:** Here the word righteous means "being in a right relation with." L&N (on TW). God has declared this person right before him. Morris (page 123) says, "It means the state of

being ‘right’ with God, of being acquitted when tried by him.” Here are other ways to translate this clause:

the ones that God will justify (NJB)

make us right with God (NLT)

whom God counts as righteous in his sight  
Kankanaey Back Translation on TW.

### 2:13b

**but it is the doers of the law who will be declared righteous.**

- but those who do as those laws/rules say will be declared righteous/upright.
- No, God will say that people are right with him only if they have obeyed his laws.

**who will be declared righteous:** This clause is passive. Some languages must use an active clause here. For example:

that God will justify (NJB)

**declared righteous:** This word indicates that God decides that a person is acceptable to him. Here are other ways to translate this word:

justified (ESV)

have God’s approval (GW)

## Romans 2:14

### Section 2:1-16: The unbelieving hypocrite must change his thinking

In all of chapter two, Paul wrote as if to someone who disagreed with him. He used the singular “you” throughout the chapter. This form of teaching is called a “diatribe.” Only one person is talking (or writing), but it is as if two people are talking back and forth, asking and answering questions, making objections and responding. Using this diatribe, Paul rebuked those who judged others improperly. The person whom Paul spoke to here was not a believer. His evil deeds store up God’s wrath against him (2:5), and his sins will cause him to perish (2:12).

In this section, Paul addressed someone who judged others as bad but did the same things (2:1). God would punish such a person (2:2-3); it is according to what a

person has done (2:6-11) and according to the knowledge of God that a person has (2:12-15).

Here are other possible headings for this section:

The person who does not believe and judges other people as bad yet does the same things

Hypocritical people who do not believe in Jesus

### 2:14-15

These two verses explain 2:12a-b. Some English versions indicate that these verses are extra information and not a part of the main collection of thoughts of Paul, but these two verses are not a change of subject or background information. You should not put these verses in parentheses.

### 2:14a

**Indeed, when Gentiles, who do not have the law, do by nature what the law requires,**

- For non-Jewish people do not have the Jewish law, but whenever they naturally/instinctively behave as that law commands,
- Indeed/Truly, whenever non-Jews innately do what the law of Moses says to do, even though they do not have those laws,

**Indeed:** This conjunction is the same one that the BSB did not translate in 2:12a and translated as “For” in 2:13. It introduces an explanation of 2:12a-b.

**Gentiles:** This word refers to people who are not Jews. Here are other ways to translate this word:

Those who are not Jews (NCV)

non-Jews (GW)

nations

**do by nature:** This phrase refers to thoughts and deeds that are considered normal in the place where the person grew up. It includes what people in that place consider to be right or wrong. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

instinctively (NASB)

naturally (CEV)

through their own innate sense (NJB)



their minds are like their law which directs them  
Kankanaey Back Translation on TW.

their own hearts teach them  
Uma Back Translation on TW.

know in themselves  
Otomi Back Translation on TW.

**what the law requires:** This indicates that the Gentiles do good deeds and avoid evil deeds. For example, they may honor their parents, which is also a Jewish law. Here are other ways to translate these words:

the deeds written in the law of Moses

as the Law commands (NJB)

the things/rules that the laws of Moses contain

in accordance with it (JBP)

some of the commands of that law  
Kankanaey Back Translation on TW.

#### 2:14c

**even though they do not have the law.**

- even if they do not have the Jewish law.
- even though they have not heard the laws of Moses.

#### 2:14b–c

**they are a law to themselves, even though they do not have the law:** The words even though indicates that it is true that the Gentiles did not have the Jewish laws to live by. But despite that, they were a law to themselves (2:14b). Here are other ways to translate this clause:

these, not having the Law, are a law to themselves (NASB)

they behave as if having a law, even without having heard the law of Moses

these who do not have the law are a law to themselves (NET)

Those who are not Jews do not have the law, but when they freely do what the law commands, they are the law for themselves (NCV)

#### 2:14b

**they are a law to themselves,**

- they know what laws/rules to follow in their own minds,
- they have a law in their hearts/insides,

**they are a law to themselves:** This indicates that the Gentiles follow a set of laws based on what they know is right and wrong. The word law here does not refer to the Jewish laws. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

they are their own law (REB)

they have made their own law to follow

their minds are like their law which directs them  
Kankanaey Back Translation on TW.

they have a law there in their hearts

it is as if they have a law in their minds/thoughts  
Yakan Back Translation on TW.

**the law:** Here the word law refers to the Jewish laws.

## Romans 2:15

**Section 2:1–16: The unbelieving hypocrite must change his thinking**

In all of chapter two, Paul wrote as if to someone who disagreed with him. He used the singular “you” throughout the chapter. This form of teaching is called a “diatribe.” Only one person is talking (or writing), but it is as if two people are talking back and forth, asking and answering questions, making objections and responding. Using this diatribe, Paul rebuked those who judged others improperly. The person whom Paul spoke to here was not a believer. His evil deeds store up God’s wrath against him (2:5), and his sins will cause him to perish (2:12).

In this section, Paul addressed someone who judged others as bad but did the same things (2:1). God would punish such a person (2:2–3); it is according to what a person has done (2:6–11) and according to the knowledge of God that a person has (2:12–15).

Here are other possible headings for this section:

The person who does not believe and judges other people as bad yet does the same things

Hypocritical people who do not believe in Jesus

## 2:15a

**So they show that the work of the law is written on their hearts,**

- Their deeds show that the principles/intentions of the law of Moses are in their hearts.
- This good behavior proves that they know the ways/ideas of God's law.

**So they:** The Greek word is literally “who” and the Greek sentence continues from 2:14. The word “who” refers back to the Gentiles (2:14a). The BSB and many English versions begin a new sentence here for more natural English and therefore translate the Greek word as So they.

But the Gentiles are not purposely going around and showing this. It is their deeds that show that the principles of God's law are in their hearts. For example:

Their conduct (GNT)

**show:** The present tense here indicates that Gentiles show this throughout their lives. Consider how to indicate that in your language. Another interpretation is that Paul was only talking here about the final judgment day (2:16). But that conflicts with the use of the present tense.

**the work of the law is written on their hearts:** This clause is passive. Some languages must use an active clause. For example:

God wrote the work of the law on their hearts

**the work of the law:** This phrase refers to doing good deeds and avoiding bad deeds, following the principles of God's law. Examples are: “honor your father and mother” (Exodus 20:12) and “do not murder” (Exodus 20:13). Gentiles did not have the exact words of the Old Testament but they behaved in similar ways. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

the requirements of the law (NIV)

the effect of the Law (NJB)

what the law requires (RSV)

what is right and wrong, just as the law commands (NCV)

the good which the law says to do Otomi Back Translation on TW.

**law:** Here this word refers to the laws that God gave to the Jews. In some languages a literal translation would wrongly refer to laws in general. If that is true in your language, explain it in the text. For example:

God's law (NLT)

the law of Moses

**is written on their hearts:** The phrase is written on is used as a metaphor here. It means “exists in.” The Gentiles often behave as if they already know how God wants them to behave. In some languages a literal translation would not be natural. If that is true in your language, translate without the metaphor. For example:

is in their hearts

they know

**their hearts:** Here the word hearts refers figuratively to the inner being, which includes the mind, the emotions, and the will. In some languages a literal translation would not refer to the inner being. If that is true in your language, you may want to use the word or phrase that has the right meaning. For example:

their insides/livers

their mind and will

## 2:15b

**their consciences also bearing witness,**

- Their consciences also show that to be true,
- Their own memory of past deeds also show that,
- Their own thoughts about what they have done also tell them about right and wrong,

**their consciences also bearing witness:** This indicates that the consciences of Gentiles also show that the principles of God's law are written on their hearts. Here are other ways to translate these words:

Their consciences also show that this is true (GNT)

to this their conscience gives supporting witness (REB)

Their minds also confirm that that is trueKankanaey Back Translation on TW.

**consciences:** The Greek word that the BSB translates as consciences refers to the record of past deeds that a person has in his mind and causes him to feel ashamed or guilty when he does something wrong. See Dunn (page 101), Schreiner (page 123), or Jewett (page 215). It also makes him feel good when he does what is right. Here are other ways to translate this word:

Their minds also confirm that that is true, because their minds are the very-thing that tells them whether what they are doing is good or bad.Kankanaey Back Translation on TW.

they say in their hearts: “That action is wrong,” or they say: “That action is good.”Uma Back Translation on TW.

They know in their minds what is good and what is bad to do.Western Bukidnon Manobo Back Translation on TW.

#### **2:15c–d and their thoughts either accusing or defending them:**

The word and indicates here that the thoughts of the Gentiles also show that the principles of God’s law are written on their hearts.

**their thoughts either accusing or defending them:** The Greek word that the BSB translates as thoughts is literally “between-one-another thoughts.” It refers to the thoughts of Gentiles, some which accuse them when they have done wrong, and some which commend them when they have done right. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

their thoughts sometimes accusing them and at other times even defending them (NIV11)

thoughts that say they did wrong or sometimes even say they did right

their minds tell them whether what they are doing is bad or good

think “That action is wrong,” or “That action is good.”

#### **2:15c and their thoughts either accusing**

- and their thoughts sometimes accuse them
- as well as thoughts which condemn their actions
- and when they think, “What I did then was wrong,”

**thoughts either accusing:** In some languages the word thoughts cannot go with the word accusing. See the above examples.

#### **2:15d or defending them**

- and even sometimes defend them.
- and thoughts which approve their actions.
- or when they think “What I did then was right,” it also proves that they know the ways/ideas of God’s law.

**or defending them:** Here the Greek includes a word that is usually translated as “even.” The BSB omits this word. It indicates that much more often the thoughts of Gentiles accuse them and their thoughts only occasionally “defend them.”

**defending:** Here the Greek word that the BSB translates as defending refers to explaining behavior so that someone else will see that that behavior was acceptable. In this case, a Gentile might give reasons why he thinks that what he did was a good deed. Here are other ways to translate this word:

excuse (ESV)

tell them they are doing right (NLT)

## **Romans 2:16**

### **Section 2:1–16: The unbelieving hypocrite must change his thinking**

In all of chapter two, Paul wrote as if to someone who disagreed with him. He used the singular “you” throughout the chapter. This form of teaching is called a “diatribe.” Only one person is talking (or writing), but it is as if two people are talking back and forth, asking and answering questions, making objections and responding. Using this diatribe, Paul rebuked those who judged others improperly. The person whom Paul spoke to here was not a believer. His evil deeds store up God’s wrath against him (2:5), and his sins will cause him to perish (2:12).

In this section, Paul addressed someone who judged others as bad but did the same things (2:1). God would punish such a person (2:2-3); it is according to what a person has done (2:6-11) and according to the knowledge of God that a person has (2:12-15).

Here are other possible headings for this section:

The person who does not believe and judges other people as bad yet does the same things

Hypocritical people who do not believe in Jesus

## 2:16a

### on the day when God will judge men's secrets through Christ Jesus,

- And this will also be true on the day when God judges the secret deeds and thoughts of people through Jesus, the Christ/Messiah,
- And they will do that at the time when God will authorize Jesus, the one/person whom God appointed to save/rescue people, and he/Jesus will judge the things that people have done secretly,

**on the day:** Paul now talked about God's final judgment day. At that time people's thoughts will also accuse them of wrongdoing and sometimes defend them of doing right. For example:

And so,...this is how it will be on that Day (GNT)

the day is coming (NLT)

So it will be on the day (REB)

**when God will judge men's secrets through Christ Jesus:** There is a textual issue here about the order of the words Christ Jesus:

1. The order of the words are Christ Jesus. This emphasizes that Jesus is the Christ. (BSB, RSV, ESV, NASB, NABRE, NLT, GW, NET, REB, NCV)
2. The order of the words are Jesus Christ. This indicates that Jesus is the Christ but does not emphasize that fact. (NIV, GNT, NJB, CEV, KJV)

It is recommended that you follow option (1), because the scholars of the UBS Greek NT believe it to be the correct text. They indicate that they had difficulty in deciding which was the correct text. Moo (on TW) supports option (1).

However, in some languages the order of the words Christ Jesus is not natural. If that is true in your

language, emphasize the fact that Jesus is the Christ in a natural way. For example:

God judges the secrets of men by Jesus, who/he is the Christ

**God will judge:** This phrase refers to a future event. Several English translations use the present tense here. Despite this, in some languages the future tense is more natural. For example:

God...will judge (GNT)

**men's:** The Greek word that the BSB translates as men's is a general word that includes both men and women. For example:

of all (GNT)

**secrets:** Here, this word refers to deeds that no one saw and words that no one else heard as well as thoughts.

**through Christ Jesus:** This phrase indicates that God gave authority to Jesus to judge everyone. Jesus will judge everyone. Here is another way to translate this phrase:

by Christ Jesus (ESV)

**Christ:** The word Christ is a title for Jesus. It means "the anointed one." The Jews used it to refer to the special person God promised to send. See how you translated this word in 1:1.

## 2:16b

### as proclaimed by my gospel.

- as my gospel about Jesus says.
- as the gospel that I preach/teach says.

**as proclaimed by my gospel:** This phrase indicates that Paul preached that God will judge everyone's secrets (2:16b). This gospel is what Paul taught about what God did through Jesus.

**my gospel:** The word my indicates that this gospel is Paul's teachings about what God did through Jesus. In some languages a literal translation would wrongly indicate that the gospel was about Paul. If that is true in your language, indicate that the gospel is about Jesus. For example:

my gospel about Jesus

the gospel that I preach/teach

**gospel:** The Greek word that the BSB translates as gospel means “good news.” Here this word refers to the good news about what God did through Jesus. Here are other ways to translate this word:

good/sweet news

good news about Jesus Christ

good news from God

message/report that causes joy

Be sure that the term you choose does not refer only to a news report or to a story that is not true.

## Romans 2:17

### Section 2:17–29: The Jews and the law of Moses

In this section, Paul talked to the Jews about themselves. He continued to use the singular “you,” as in the previous section. This form of teaching is called a “diatribe.” (See Section 2:1–16.)

Using this diatribe, Paul rebuked the Jews because they had the law of Moses but they disobeyed it.

Paul showed them that an outward sign of religion is of no use to people if they did not do what is right. He told them that God praises those whose heart is right with God.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

God praises a changed heart

Truly following God comes from the heart

### 2:17a

#### Now you, if you call yourself a Jew;

- ¶ But if you<sup>(sing)</sup> say that you are a Jew
- ¶ Now, many of you<sup>(plur)</sup> are Jewish.

**Now:** There is a textual issue in 2:17a: (1) Earlier Greek manuscripts have the words and/but if (BSB, RSV, NIV, GNT, NJB, NASB, NLT, GW, CEV, NET, NABRE, REB, ESV, NCV). (2) Some Greek manuscripts have the word look (KJV only). It is recommended that you follow option (1). The Greek word that the BSB translates as Now introduces a new part of Paul’s talk about the Jews. There is some contrast here with what he said about

the Gentiles. Here is another way to translate this word:

But (ESV)

**if:** Paul used if here to cause the Roman believers to evaluate their own lives and determine if these verses apply to them. He probably expects some of them to say that they are like what he said here. Consider how to translate that meaning for the word if.

In the Greek text, this one if affects all of 2:17a–20c. (The word “then” does not occur until 2:21a.) Consider how to include all of 2:17a–20c in the if clause in your language.

Some languages may need to repeat the word if to make this clear. The BSB repeats it once in 2:18 and again in 2:19. But in some languages it is more natural to repeat it more often. For example:

<sup>17</sup>Now if you call yourself a Jew and if you rely on the law and boast in God <sup>18</sup>and if you know his will and approve what is superior, because you are instructed from the law; <sup>19</sup>and if you are convinced that you are a guide for the blind, a light for those in darkness, <sup>20</sup>an instructor of the foolish, a teacher of infants, because you have in the law the embodiment of knowledge and truth,

<sup>17</sup>Now if you call yourself a Jew and if you rely on the law and boast in God <sup>18</sup>and if you know his will and approve what is superior, because you are instructed from the law; <sup>19</sup>and if you are convinced that you are a guide for the blind, a light for those in darkness, <sup>20</sup>an instructor of the foolish, and a teacher of infants, because you are convinced that you have in the law the embodiment of knowledge and truth,

In some languages it is more natural not to repeat the word if at all, including 2:19a. For example:

<sup>17</sup>But if you call yourself a Jew and rely on the law and boast in God <sup>18</sup>and know his will and approve what is superior, because you are instructed from the law; <sup>19</sup>and are sure that you yourself are a guide for the blind, a light for those in darkness, <sup>20</sup>an instructor of the foolish, a teacher of infants, because you have in the law the embodiment of knowledge and truth,

**you call yourself a Jew:** This clause refers to this person knowing that his parents were Jews, therefore he was a Jew. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

you say you are Jewish

you have the name “Jew”

you are of the Jewish people

**you:** This letter was for all Roman believers to read. But here Paul wrote as if he was talking to a Jew. This Jew was someone who was proud of having the Law of Moses and all the knowledge and insight that it gave him.

In some languages a footnote to explain would be helpful to the readers. Here is an example footnote:

Paul now wrote to the Roman believers as if speaking to a Jew. This Jew was proud of having the Law of Moses and all the knowledge and insight that it gave him.

## 2:17b

### if you rely on the law

- and trust in the law of Moses
- If you<sup>(plur)</sup> are sure that God accepts you because you know God’s laws,

**rely on the law:** Here the phrase rely on means “to depend on.” The Jews regarded their possession of the laws that God gave to Moses as something that made them right with God. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

depend on the Law (GNT)

trust in the law of Moses (NCV)

trust in your having the law to save you

say that God will accept you<sup>(sing)</sup> because you have the Law of Moses

## 2:17c

### and boast in God;

- and brag about your God
- and boast about how great God is,

**boast in God:** There are two ways to interpret the Greek word that the BSB translates as in:

1. It indicates that the Jews spoke proudly about God. For example:

boast about God (GNT) (BSB, ESV, NIV11, GNT, NJB, NASB, NABRE, GW, CEV, REB, KJV)

1. It indicates that the Jews spoke proudly about their relationship with God. For example:

boast of your relationship to God (NET) (RSV, NIV84, NLT, NET, NCV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1), because that is the simple meaning of the Greek word. Morris (on TW) says, “Paul is not referring to relationship to God, but to God himself.” Moo, Barrett, Nicoll, and Schreiner also support interpretation (1). Here are other ways to translate this clause:

boast about how great God is

brag about your God (GW)

## Romans 2:18

### Section 2:17–29: The Jews and the law of Moses

In this section, Paul talked to the Jews about themselves. He continued to use the singular “you,” as in the previous section. This form of teaching is called a “diatribe.” (See Section 2:1–16.)

Using this diatribe, Paul rebuked the Jews because they had the law of Moses but they disobeyed it.

Paul showed them that an outward sign of religion is of no use to people if they did not do what is right. He told them that God praises those whose heart is right with God.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

God praises a changed heart

Truly following God comes from the heart

## 2:18a

### if you know His will

- and know what God wants to happen
- and if you know what he desires to see happen,

**if:** The if from 2:17a affects this verse as well. So the BSB repeats the word here. Consider how to make that connection clear in your language. See the note on if at 2:17a.

**know His will:** This clause indicates that the Jews know what God wants to do and what he wants them and other people to do. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

know what he wants (NLT)

know what he wants you to do (NCV)

know the Lord's desireUma Back Translation on TW.

### 2:18b and approve of what is superior

- and approve the things/ideas that are best
- and call the great deeds best to do,

**approve:** There are two ways to interpret the Greek word that the BSB translates as approve:

1. It means approve here. Here the Greek word means "judge as good or genuine based on examination or testing." (BSB, ESV, RSV, NIV, NET, NASB, KJV)
2. It means evaluate. Here the Greek word means "examine" or "test." For example:

determine (NRSV) (NRSV, GNT, NJB, NABRE, NLT, GW)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1), because that fits the context best. Schreiner (page 130) says, "The two benefits in verse 18 are doubtless both to be construed positively." Moo and Morris also support interpretation (1).

**what is superior:** There are two ways to interpret the Greek word that the BSB translates as superior:

1. It means something better. For example:

excellent (NIV) (BSB, ESV, RSV, NIV, NET, NCV, REB, KJV)

1. It means right (versus wrong). For example:

what is right (GNT) (GNT, NJB, NLT, CEV, GW)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1), because that fits the context best. Moo (on TW) translates this phrase as "those things that are best." Morris and Schreiner also support interpretation (1).

### General Comment on 2:18b

Following both first interpretations above, the clause indicates that the Jews call as good those deeds that God calls good. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

approve of what is excellent (ESV)

call important deeds good

### 2:18c because you are instructed by the law;

- because someone/others has/have taught the laws of Moses to you,

**because:** This word introduces the reason for the previous statement. Some languages need to put the reason first. If that is true in your language, reorder 2:18b–c to use "therefore." For example:

<sup>18c</sup>you are instructed from the law, therefore <sup>18b</sup>you approve what is excellent

**you are instructed by the law:** There are several ways to translate the Greek word that the BSB translates as by. Here are the two main ones:

1. It means from here. The law is the source of the instruction. (GNT, NABRE, ESV, NET, NASB, KJV)
2. It means by here. This word indicates that the law itself is doing the instructing. For example:

you are instructed by the law (NIV) (BSB, NIV, NJB, REB)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1), because it seems likely that Paul would have used a different Greek word if he wanted to clearly indicate by. Paul used the Greek word ek ("out of, from"), although "by" ("impersonal means," Wallace, page 432) is possible. But typically in a passive clause the Greek word hupo ("by") or dia ("through") to indicate, in this case, who is doing the instructing. Dunn, Witherington, and Lenski translate the Greek word as "from," and Cranfield, Jewett, Alford, and Nicoll translate it as "out of."

This clause is passive. Some languages must use an active clause here. For example:

others have instructed you from the law

someone has instructed you from the law

**the law:** This refers to the first five books of the Bible, but implies the rest of the Old Testament.

## Romans 2:19

### Section 2:17–29: The Jews and the law of Moses

In this section, Paul talked to the Jews about themselves. He continued to use the singular “you,” as in the previous section. This form of teaching is called a “diatribe.” (See Section 2:1–16.)

Using this diatribe, Paul rebuked the Jews because they had the law of Moses but they disobeyed it.

Paul showed them that an outward sign of religion is of no use to people if they did not do what is right. He told them that God praises those whose heart is right with God.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

God praises a changed heart

Truly following God comes from the heart

### 2:19a

**if you are convinced that you are a guide for the blind,**

- and are confident that you are a guide to those who need to know about God,
- and if you<sup>(plur)</sup> are certain that you guide the non-Jews, people who are like blind people because they do not know God’s ways,

**if you are convinced:** The Greek is literally “having confidence.” The BSB supplies the phrase if you to make the connection to the “if” in 2:17 clear. Consider how to make that connection clear in your language.

**a guide for the blind:** This is a metaphor. A person who does not know about God and his ways is like a blind person. The Jews thought of non-Jews in that way. And they thought of themselves as those who could show non-Jews how to live in God’s ways.

In some languages a literal translation would wrongly refer only to actual blind people. If that is true in

your language, translate the correct meaning. You may want to:

- Make the point of reference of the metaphor explicit in the text. For example:

a religious teacher who is like a guide for the blind

- Translate the meaning of the metaphor in the text. For example:

a religious teacher to those who know nothing of God

- Translate the literal meaning and explain it in a footnote. Here is an example footnote:

This is a metaphor. A person who does not know about God and his ways is like a blind person. Jews teaching Gentiles about God would help them “see” who God is.

### 2:19b

**a light for those in darkness,**

- like a light shining for those in darkness,
- and are certain that you guide them like a light for people wandering in the darkness without God,

**a light for those in darkness:** This is also a metaphor. The meaning is similar to the “guide for the blind.” Here the phrase addresses the Jews. And they thought of themselves as those who could show non-Jews how to live in God’s ways.

In some languages a literal translation would wrongly refer only to people walking in actual darkness. If that is true in your language, translate the correct meaning. You may want to:

- Make the point of reference of the metaphor explicit in the text. For example:

a religious teacher who is like a light to those who are in darkness

- Translate the meaning of the metaphor in the text. For example:

and shows God’s ways to them

- Translate the literal meaning and explain it in a footnote. Here is an example footnote:



This is a metaphor. Jews considered Gentiles like people walking in darkness. Jews teaching them about God would help them “see” who God is.

## Romans 2:20

### Section 2:17–29: The Jews and the law of Moses

In this section, Paul talked to the Jews about themselves. He continued to use the singular “you,” as in the previous section. This form of teaching is called a “diatribe.” (See Section 2:1–16.)

Using this diatribe, Paul rebuked the Jews because they had the law of Moses but they disobeyed it.

Paul showed them that an outward sign of religion is of no use to people if they did not do what is right. He told them that God praises those whose heart is right with God.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

God praises a changed heart

Truly following God comes from the heart

### 2:20a

#### an instructor of the foolish,

- a corrector of the foolish (NRSV)
- and if you<sup>(plur)</sup> teach God’s ways to people who are foolish

The “if” from 2:17a in the Greek affects this verse as well. Consider how to make that connection clear in your language. See the note on “if” at 2:17a.

**an instructor of the foolish:** This phrase probably refers to teaching someone who is foolish. The Jews generally considered Gentiles to be foolish.

The word foolish means “lacking good sense” or “without understanding.” Some people lack good sense regarding spiritual matters; they chose to do deeds that are morally wrong. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

instruct those who have no spiritual wisdom (JBP)

show foolish people what is right (NCV)

### 2:20b

#### a teacher of infants,

- and someone who teaches children,

**a teacher of infants:** There are two ways to interpret Greek word that the BSB translates as infants:

1. It has the literal meaning of infants or “children” here. (BSB, RSV, NIV, ESV, KJV, NLT, GW, CEV, NET)
2. It has the figurative meaning of people immature in understanding or faith. The Jews sometimes referred to converts to Judaism with this word. For example:

immature (NASB) (GNT, NJB, NASB, REB, NABRE, NCV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1), because many English versions support it. In English it is also possible to understand the word infants in the sense of interpretation (2). But if the major language version in your area follows interpretation (2), you may want to follow that.

**infants:** The Greek word that the BSB translates as infants refers to children approximately one to four years old.

### 2:20c

#### because you have in the law the embodiment of knowledge and truth—

- having the law of Moses, which represents knowledge and truth,
- because the law of Moses enables you to know about God and to know what is true,

**the embodiment of knowledge and truth:** The Greek word that the BSB translates as embodiment refers to the structure and shape of something. The laws that God gave to the Jews show his knowledge and the truth of all he spoke of. God’s truth is contained within the law. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

the Law embodies all knowledge and all truth (NJB)

God’s law which is the location of what is correct and trueKankanaey Back Translation on TW.

true knowledge/teaching is only in the law of Moses

**knowledge and truth:** In some languages these two words cannot be translated as nouns. If that is true in your language, translate the meaning using the proper kinds of words. For example:

knowing about God and those teachings are true

truly knowing about God

## Romans 2:21

### Section 2:17–29: The Jews and the law of Moses

In this section, Paul talked to the Jews about themselves. He continued to use the singular “you,” as in the previous section. This form of teaching is called a “diatribe.” (See Section 2:1–16.)

Using this diatribe, Paul rebuked the Jews because they had the law of Moses but they disobeyed it.

Paul showed them that an outward sign of religion is of no use to people if they did not do what is right. He told them that God praises those whose heart is right with God.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

God praises a changed heart

Truly following God comes from the heart

### 2:21a–23b

These verses are the then-clause of the if-clause in 2:17–20. In this case, the if-clause has multiple clauses in it, and the then-clause does too. But since there is only one “if” and one “then,” the singular “if-clause” and “then-clause” is used. Paul probably expected any religious Jew or Jewish Christian to agree that he or she is like the person described in the if-clause. Now he asked if they follow that religion properly. Or were they hypocritical, saying what was good but doing evil?

Paul used four rhetorical questions and an accusation to point out possible ways of being hypocritical. If they were being hypocritical, these rhetorical questions and accusation were a rebuke to them to stop doing those evil deeds. Consider how to translate that meaning here.

### 2:21a

#### you, then, who teach others,

- then, although you<sup>(sing)</sup> teach others the ways/teachings of God,
- then, what about yourselves? You teach other people about God,

**you, then, who teach others:** The word then connects to the if-clause of 2:17–20. See the above note.

In some languages the word then must be first in the clause. For example:

then you who teach others

### General Comment on 2:17a–2:21a

The if-clause begins in 2:17a and continues to 2:20c. Such a long if-clause may not be natural or easy to follow in some languages. If that is true in your language, you may want to use grammar or words that indicate the possibility of 2:17a–20c and put the if-clause at the beginning of 2:21a. For example:

<sup>17a</sup>But you may call yourself a Jew.... <sup>19a</sup>and you may be convinced that you are a guide for the blind...<sup>20c</sup>having in the law the embodiment of knowledge and truth. <sup>21a</sup>If you think like that, then you who teach others...

### 2:21b

#### do you not teach yourself?

- do you not follow/obey what you teach?
- but you do not follow/obey what you teach.

**do you not teach yourself?:** This is a rhetorical question. It emphasizes that this person should teach himself. That is, he should follow or obey what he teaches. Translate this clause with that meaning. Here are some ways:

- As a rhetorical question. For example:

why don't you teach yourself? (GNT)

do you obey/follow what you teach?

- As a statement. For example:

you do not obey/follow what you teach

maybe you do not teach yourself

### 2:21c

#### You who preach against stealing,

- You preach that stealing is evil/bad,
- You proclaim, “It is not right to steal.”

**preach:** The Greek word that the BSB translates as preach means “announce important information or news in public.” Here are other ways to translate this word:

announce

proclaim (REB)

**stealing:** This refers to taking other people's possessions when they do not want you to. It usually implies taking them secretly.

## 2:21d

### do you steal?

- but do you steal?
- So do not steal other people's things!

**do you steal?:** This is a rhetorical question. It emphasizes that this person should not steal. Translate this clause with that meaning. Here are some ways:

- As a rhetorical question. For example:

but do you yourself steal? (GNT)

- As a statement. For example:

you yourself steal

maybe it is you who steals things

## Romans 2:22

### Section 2:17–29: The Jews and the law of Moses

In this section, Paul talked to the Jews about themselves. He continued to use the singular “you,” as in the previous section. This form of teaching is called a “diatribe.” (See Section 2:1–16.)

Using this diatribe, Paul rebuked the Jews because they had the law of Moses but they disobeyed it.

Paul showed them that an outward sign of religion is of no use to people if they did not do what is right. He told them that God praises those whose heart is right with God.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

God praises a changed heart

Truly following God comes from the heart

## 2:22a

### You who forbid adultery,

- You say not to have sex with someone who is not your spouse,

- You say to other people, “It is not right for anyone to have sexual relations with someone to whom you are not married.”

**You who forbid adultery:** The Greek is literally “not to commit adultery.” It indicates a general command for people not to commit adultery.

**adultery:** This word refers to having sex with someone to whom you are not married.

In some languages people will want to use the polite expression to refer to this deed in this book. This might be an idiom. For example:

lie/sleep with someone who is not your wife or husband

## 2:22b

### do you commit adultery?

- but do you have sex with someone who is not your spouse?
- So do not sleep/lie with a person to whom you are not married!

**do you commit adultery?:** This is a rhetorical question. It emphasizes that this person should not commit adultery. Translate this clause with that meaning. Here are some ways:

- As a rhetorical question. For example:

but do you commit adultery? (GNT)

- As a statement. For example:

you yourself commit adultery

maybe it is you who commits adultery

## 2:22c

### You who abhor idols,

- You<sup>(sing)</sup> are disgusted by idols,
- You detest objects representing pagan gods.

**You who abhor idols:** The word abhor means to hate and turn away from something, because it is so bad. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

You detest idols (GNT)

you treat idols with disgust (GW)

You hate idols (NCV)

**idols:** An “idol” is a statue or other physical representation of a god. It is something before which someone could worship that god.

#### 2:22d

#### do you rob temples?

- but do you to steal from the houses where people go to honor their gods?
- So do not steal valuable things from the idol houses of the non-Jews?

**do you rob temples?:** This is a rhetorical question. It emphasizes that this person should not rob temples. Translate this clause with that meaning. Here are some ways:

- As a rhetorical question. For example:

but do you rob temples? (GNT)

- As a statement. For example:

you yourself rob temples

maybe it is you who rob temples

It is likely that Paul meant this literally, since there are a few stories about Jews going and stealing valuable things from temples of pagan gods. But Gentiles thought this was a really bad crime, as bad as killing people. It may be that some carried off the images of the gods, since there was a lot of gold and silver and valuable stones on them (Deuteronomy 7:25). Non-Jews also used the temples of their gods like banks, storing up their money there, thinking that the god of that temple would protect their money.

**temples:** Here the Greek word that the BSB translates as temples refers to buildings where a god is worshipped. Greek temples usually had a statue of the god and an altar. Some languages do not have a word for this meaning. If that is true in your language, explain the meaning in the text. For example:

houses of/for worship

pagan worship houses/places

## Romans 2:23

### Section 2:17–29: The Jews and the law of Moses

In this section, Paul talked to the Jews about themselves. He continued to use the singular “you,” as in the previous section. This form of teaching is called a “diatribe.” (See Section 2:1–16.)

Using this diatribe, Paul rebuked the Jews because they had the law of Moses but they disobeyed it.

Paul showed them that an outward sign of religion is of no use to people if they did not do what is right. He told them that God praises those whose heart is right with God.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

God praises a changed heart

Truly following God comes from the heart

#### 2:23a

#### You who boast in the law,

- You<sup>(sing)</sup> brag about Jewish law,
- You<sup>(sing)</sup> are proud about having the laws of Moses.

**boast in the law:** The Jews boasted that God gave his law to them and to no other nation/people-group. Having God’s law made them special. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

brag about the law (NIV84)

boast about having God’s law (GNT)

**the law:** This refers to the law that God gave to Moses. See how you translated it in 2:12 or 2:20.

#### 2:23b

#### do you dishonor God by breaking the law?

- but you disrespect God because you disobey that law.
- But you disobey those laws, and so insult God.

**do you dishonor God by breaking the law?:** There are two ways to interpret this clause:

1. It states that this person has broken the law of Moses. It accuses him of doing that. For example:

you dishonor God by breaking it (NLT) (ESV, NJB, NLT, CEV, NET, REB, NCV)

1. It is a rhetorical question. It emphasizes that this person should not break the law of Moses. For example:

do you dishonor God by breaking the law? (NIV)  
(BSB, RSV, NIV, GNT, NASB, NABRE, GW, KJV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1), but both interpretations are a rebuke for breaking the law. Nicoll (page 600) says, “probably the use of the relative instead of the participle suggests that the sentence is to be read not as an interrogative, but as declaratory.” Moo, Barrett, and Schreiner also support interpretation (1). Translate with that meaning.

**dishonor God:** The Greek word that the BSB translates as dishonor means “to disrespect” or “to insult.”

**breaking the law:** The Greek word that the BSB translates as breaking means literally “to step across a boundary.” Here it refers to someone doing something that God told him not to do. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

you disobey it (NJB)

they do not do according to the words which the law says  
Otomi Back Translation on TW.

not following his commands  
Uma Back Translation on TW.

## Romans 2:24

### Section 2:17–29: The Jews and the law of Moses

In this section, Paul talked to the Jews about themselves. He continued to use the singular “you,” as in the previous section. This form of teaching is called a “diatribe.” (See Section 2:1–16.)

Using this diatribe, Paul rebuked the Jews because they had the law of Moses but they disobeyed it.

Paul showed them that an outward sign of religion is of no use to people if they did not do what is right. He told them that God praises those whose heart is right with God.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

God praises a changed heart

Truly following God comes from the heart

## 2:24a

### As it is written:

- For/Because, as they/someone wrote in Scripture,
- About that, what the prophet wrote in God’s Word/Book long ago is true. He said this:

The Greek begins with a word that it usually translated as “for.” It introduces an explanation for what Paul said in 2:23. The BSB does not translate this word, and it may not be necessary in some languages to translate it. However, if it would be more natural in your language to translate this word, here are other ways to translate it:

Because

That is written...

And concerning this, Western Bukidnon Manobo  
Back Translation on TW.

**As it is written:** This introduces Scripture. In some languages a literal translation would not clearly refer to Scripture. If that is true in your language, explain it in the text. For example:

As it is written in God’s Word

As scripture says (NJB)

See how you translated this phrase in 1:17.

## 2:24b

### “God’s name is blasphemed among the Gentiles because of you.”

- “The non-Jewish people say bad things about God because of the wrong things they see you doing.”
- “You Jews do bad things, and so non-Jews say, ‘That God of theirs is no good.’”

This phrase is similar to the words of Isaiah 52:5 as translated in the Septuagint (LXX).

**God’s name is blasphemed among the Gentiles because of you:** This clause is passive. Some languages must use an active clause here. For example:

Gentiles blaspheme God’s name because of you

**God’s name:** This phrase refers to his character and reputation. Here it is more natural in some languages to refer directly to God. For example:

God

**is blasphemed:** This word refers to hurting someone's reputation. Here it refers to saying something that dishonors God. Non-Jews were dishonoring God and despising him because of the way Jews were behaving. Here are other ways to translate this word:

said evil things about

cursed (GW)

spoke against

**Gentiles:** This word refers to people who are not Jews. Here are other ways to translate this word:

Those who are not Jews (NCV)

non-Jews

nations (GW)

See how you translated this word in 2:14.

**because of you:** Here this phrase indicates that some Jews did evil deeds. The Gentiles saw them and blamed God for their bad behavior. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

Your evil deeds have caused

on account of you JewsKankanaey Back Translation on TW.

It is your fault that (NJB)

### General Comment on 2:24b

Similar words are found in Isaiah 52:5. If you cross-reference the location of connections to Old Testament verses, you may want to do so here. Here is an example footnote:

This is similar to Isaiah 52:5.

## Romans 2:25

### Section 2:17–29: The Jews and the law of Moses

In this section, Paul talked to the Jews about themselves. He continued to use the singular “you,” as in

the previous section. This form of teaching is called a “diatribe.” (See Section 2:1–16.)

Using this diatribe, Paul rebuked the Jews because they had the law of Moses but they disobeyed it.

Paul showed them that an outward sign of religion is of no use to people if they did not do what is right. He told them that God praises those whose heart is right with God.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

God praises a changed heart

Truly following God comes from the heart

### 2:25a

#### Circumcision has value if you observe the law,

- ¶ For being circumcised is valuable/worthwhile for you if you obey Jewish law,
- ¶ If you obey the law of Moses, it is good/beneficial for you to be circumcised.

The Greek begins with a word that is usually translated as “For.” This word introduces an example of breaking the law, or a further point about breaking the law. The BSB does not translate this word and it may not be necessary in some languages to translate it. However, if it would be more natural in your language to translate this word, here are other ways to translate it:

For example (GW)

In the same wayAlford (page 335).

**Circumcision has value if you observe the law:** Here the if-clause comes after the then-clause. This makes the then-clause the topic. In some languages the if-clause must come first. For example:

if you obey the law, then circumcision indeed is of value

**Circumcision:** The word “circumcise” means to cut off the loose skin at the end of a boy's penis. The father or a man who specialized in doing circumcision would do that. Among the Jews, Circumcision is a religious ritual which serves as a sign that they have a covenant with God (Genesis 17:9–14).

In some cultures, it is acceptable to translate explicitly the meaning “cut off the loose skin at the end of a boy's penis.” In other cultures, it is necessary to speak

more generally or use a euphemism to describe this event. Here are some examples:

Cutting the skin

Marking the body to show he belongs to God

Receiving the mark

In some cultures people do not circumcise babies, and in some cultures they do not circumcise any males. In other cultures circumcision is done for different reasons than Jewish circumcision. If that is true in your culture, you may want to include a footnote to explain the Jewish custom. For example:

Circumcision is the cutting off of the skin at the end of the penis. Every male Jew was required to be circumcised. Circumcision was the sign that he was a member of the community with whom God had made a covenant.

But if you have already included a footnote in other books of the Bible (for instance Luke 1:59), you may want to refer your readers there. Here is an example footnote:

See footnote on circumcision at Luke 1:59.

**has value:** God gave circumcision to Abraham and his descendants as a sign of his covenant with them. It showed that they were a member of his people. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

is valuable (NLT)

is worthwhile (CEV)

There is...a use/benefitKankanaey Back Translation on TW.

is goodYakan Back Translation on TW.

**the law:** This phrase refers to the law that God gave to Moses. See how you translated it in 2:12 or 2:23.

#### 2:25b

**but if you break the law,**

- but if you break Jewish law,
- But if you disobey the law of Moses,

**you break the law:** See how you translated a similar clause (“breaking the law”) in 2:23.

#### 2:25c

**your circumcision has become uncircumcision.**

- then you being circumcised has no value/worth.
- then in God’s eyes you have become like people who are not circumcised.

**your circumcision has become uncircumcision:** This indicates that if a Jew disobeys the law, the fact that he has been circumcised is no use to him. In God’s eyes he is no better off than a non-Jew. Here are other ways to translate these words:

you have become as though you had not been circumcised (NIV)

you are no more circumcised than the uncircumcised (NJB)

circumcision is of no valueYakan Back Translation on TW.

we are just like those people who aren’t Jews who have never been circumcisedWestern Bukidnon Manobo Back Translation on TW.

**uncircumcision:** This word refers to not being circumcised.

## Romans 2:26

### Section 2:17–29: The Jews and the law of Moses

In this section, Paul talked to the Jews about themselves. He continued to use the singular “you,” as in the previous section. This form of teaching is called a “diatribe.” (See Section 2:1–16.)

Using this diatribe, Paul rebuked the Jews because they had the law of Moses but they disobeyed it.

Paul showed them that an outward sign of religion is of no use to people if they did not do what is right. He told them that God praises those whose heart is right with God.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

God praises a changed heart

Truly following God comes from the heart

**2:26a****If a man who is not circumcised keeps the requirements of the law,**

- Therefore, if an uncircumcised man obeys the requirements of the Jewish law,
- So then, if people who have not been circumcised obey/follow what the law of Moses says people should do,

This verse begins with a word that is often translated as “therefore.” This word introduces a conclusion from what Paul said in 2:25. The BSB has left this word untranslated. It may be natural in your language to make the relationship with the previous verse explicit. For example:

So (ESV)

**a man who is not circumcised:** This phrase refers to a non-Jew. No one has cut off the foreskin of his penis.

**keeps:** Here this word means “obeys.”

**requirements:** The Greek word that the BSB translates as requirements refers to rules for right behavior. Here are other ways to translate this word:

precepts (ESV)

commands (NJB)

**2:26b****will not his uncircumcision be regarded as circumcision?**

- will not God say that he belongs to him as though he had been circumcised?
- God will surely consider them to be his people as much as those who had been circumcised.

**will not his uncircumcision be regarded as circumcision?:** If a non-Jew does the right things according to God’s law, God considers him as if he had a covenant with him, like the covenant he has with the Jews. There are two issues:

Issue 1: Passive

This clause is passive. Some languages must use an active clause here. For example:

will not God regard him as though he were circumcised? (GNT)

Issue 2: Rhetorical Question

This question is rhetorical. It emphasizes that this man will be regarded as someone circumcised. Translate it with that meaning. Here are some ways:

- As a rhetorical question. See the example above.
- As a statement. For example:

they will be regarded as though they were circumcised.

God will regard him as though he were circumcised.

**be regarded as:** The more literal sense of the Greek word that the BSB translates as be regarded as refers to counting something, often as in business costs and sales. Here it refers to counting or considering an uncircumcised person to be the same as a circumcised one, and therefore treating him in that way. Here are other ways to translate this Greek word:

counted as (NJB)

be considered (NABRE)

**Romans 2:27****Section 2:17–29: The Jews and the law of Moses**

In this section, Paul talked to the Jews about themselves. He continued to use the singular “you,” as in the previous section. This form of teaching is called a “diatribe.” (See Section 2:1–16.)

Using this diatribe, Paul rebuked the Jews because they had the law of Moses but they disobeyed it.

Paul showed them that an outward sign of religion is of no use to people if they did not do what is right. He told them that God praises those whose heart is right with God.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

God praises a changed heart

Truly following God comes from the heart

**2:27a****The one who is physically uncircumcised yet keeps the law**

- And the man who obeys the Jewish law but by nature/heritage is not circumcised



- If someone has not been circumcised but obeys/ follows the law of Moses,

The Greek word that begins this sentence is usually translated as “and.” The BSB omits this word. Paul had something more to say about the non-Jew who does what is right in God’s eyes. Translate this word in a way that would be most natural in your language or omit it and leave the connection with 2:26 implicit, as the BSB does.

**who is physically uncircumcised:** The Greek word that the BSB translates as physically is literally “by nature.” Here it indicates that this person has not been circumcised. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

uncircumcised Gentiles (NLT)

he who is from a group that does not circumcise

## 2:27b

**will condemn you who, even though you have the written code and circumcision, are a lawbreaker.**

- will judge you as a wrongdoer because you have the sign of circumcision and the written Jewish law but break it.
- he will call you guilty/bad because you have disobeyed God’s law, even though it is written down for you and you have been circumcised.

**will condemn you:** This phrase refers to deciding that someone is guilty of wrongdoing. Here it probably refers generally to doing this, not as a judge in court. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

will judge you as guilty

will call you an evildoer

**the written code:** The Greek is literally “letter.” Here it refers to the laws that God told Moses to write down.

## Romans 2:28

### Section 2:17–29: The Jews and the law of Moses

In this section, Paul talked to the Jews about themselves. He continued to use the singular “you,” as in the previous section. This form of teaching is called a “diatribe.” (See Section 2:1–16.)

Using this diatribe, Paul rebuked the Jews because they had the law of Moses but they disobeyed it.

Paul showed them that an outward sign of religion is of no use to people if they did not do what is right. He told them that God praises those whose heart is right with God.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

God praises a changed heart

Truly following God comes from the heart

## 2:28a–29a

**Jew...Jew:** Paul now used the word Jew in a figurative sense. Here it means “a person with a special relationship to God” or “God’s people.” He did not mean being a Jew because your ancestors were Jews.

In many languages, a literal translation would not have the correct meaning. If that is true in your language, you may want to:

- Explain the word Jew in the text. For example:

Jew (and here I mean God’s people)...Jew

the true Jew, I mean to say, the true person of God,...the personKankanaey Back Translation on TW.

It is said that the Jew is God’s people. But it is not true that one is God’s people just because he was born of Jews...Otomi Back Translation on TW.

- Translate the meaning of “God’s people” here. You may then want a footnote to indicate the literal word. Here is an example footnote:

Literally “Jew.”

- Translate the word Jew as you always do but explain it here in a footnote. Here is an example footnote:

Paul now used the word “Jews” in the sense of “people with a special relationship to God” or “God’s people.” He was not talking about being a Jew because your ancestors were Jews.

## 2:28a

**A man is not a Jew because he is one outwardly,**

- For/Because a true/real Jew is not someone who only appears to be a Jew,

- For even when a person lives like a Jew, that does not mean that he is a true Jew.

The Greek begins with a conjunction that is usually translated as “for.” The BSB omits this word. The conjunction introduces an explanation of what Paul said in 2:27.

**outwardly:** The word outwardly refers to what people can see about someone. How a person appears to look or behave may not be the same as what he truly thinks or feels. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

on the outside (GNT)

in appearance and in custom only Kankanaey Back Translation on TW.

in what is seen

in the things people see him do or wear

## 2:28b

**nor is circumcision only outward and physical.**

- and true circumcision is not a visible sign on the body.
- Similarly, even when they/someone circumcises a man, that is not a sign that he really belongs to God.

**nor is circumcision only outward and physical:** The word nor means “and not.” For example:

and circumcision is not outward and physical

**circumcision:** Paul now used the word circumcision in a figurative sense. Here it means “the mark of a relationship with God.” Jewish circumcision indicates that the Jew is a member of the people who have a covenant with God. This figurative circumcision refers to right attitudes and thinking (2:29b).

In many languages, a literal translation would not have the correct meaning. If that is true in your language, you may want to:

- Explain the word circumcision in the text. For example:

circumcision (and here I mean the mark/sign that he is one of God’s people)

the true circumcision, I mean to say, the true mark/sign that a person belongs to God

It is said that Jewish circumcision is the mark/sign of God’s people. But the true mark/sign is not outward and physical

- Translate the meaning of “the mark of a relationship with God” here. You may then want a footnote to indicate the literal word. Here is an example footnote:

Literally “circumcision.”

- Translate the word circumcision as you always do but explain it here in a footnote. Here is an example footnote:

Paul now used the word “circumcision” in a figurative sense. Here it means “the mark of a relationship with God.”

## Romans 2:29

### Section 2:17–29: The Jews and the law of Moses

In this section, Paul talked to the Jews about themselves. He continued to use the singular “you,” as in the previous section. This form of teaching is called a “diatribe.” (See Section 2:1–16.)

Using this diatribe, Paul rebuked the Jews because they had the law of Moses but they disobeyed it.

Paul showed them that an outward sign of religion is of no use to people if they did not do what is right. He told them that God praises those whose heart is right with God.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

God praises a changed heart

Truly following God comes from the heart

## 2:29a

**No, a man is a Jew because he is one inwardly,**

- However, a true/real Jew is someone who thinks in godly ways,
- Indeed, the person who is a true Jew must/will think according to God.

**No:** This word indicates contrast between outward appearances and thoughts. But 2:28 says it is not about outward appearances, and 2:29 says it is about thoughts.

In some languages it is more natural to allow the context to indicate the connection and not translate the conjunction. For example:

True,

Indeed,

**a Jew:** See the note at 2:28a-29a above.

**inwardly:** Here this word means “the inner being.” It refers to what a person thinks. Here are other ways to translate this word:

on the inside (GNT)

thoughtsKankanaey Back Translation on TW.

in what is not seen

in what he thinks

## 2:29b

**and circumcision is a matter of the heart, by the Spirit, not by the written code.**

- and true circumcision is something that happens in the inner person, by the Holy Spirit and not by the words of the law of Moses.
- Similarly, true circumcision occurs in a person’s heart/liver/insides. The Holy Spirit causes it. Following rules does not cause it.

**circumcision is a matter of the heart:** Here Paul used the word circumcision and heart in a figurative sense. This clause means “the mark of a relationship with God is found in the inner being of a person.” If a person has turned to God, God makes his inner being new and that marks him as having a relationship with God.

In many languages, a literal translation would not have the correct meaning. If that is true in your language, you may want to:

- Explain the clause in the text. For example:

circumcision (and here I mean the mark/sign that he is one of God’s people) is a matter of the heart But since you added this implied information in 2:28b, you may not need to repeat it here.

- Translate the meaning of “the mark of a relationship with God is found in the inner being of a person” here. You may then want a footnote to indicate the literal word. Here is an example footnote:

Literally “circumcision is a matter of the heart.”

- Translate the literal meaning of the clause but explain it here in a footnote. Here is an example footnote:

Here this clause means “the mark of a relationship with God is found in the heart of a person.”

**by the Spirit, not by the written code:** There are four ways to interpret the word Spirit here:

1. It refers to the Holy Spirit, as in the BSB. (BSB, ESV, NIV, GNT, NASB, NLT, NET, NCV)
2. It refers to the intent and purpose of the law of Moses. It contrasts to the letter (the literal words) of that law. For example:

in the spirit, [and] not in the letter (KJV) (KJV, NABRE)

1. It indicates that this circumcision is spiritual. For example:

spiritual and not literal (RSV) (RSV, GW, CEV, REB)

1. It refers to a person’s spirit. For example:

a thing not of the letter but of the spirit (NJB) (NJB)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1), because many scholars support it. Including Moo, Morris, and Schreiner. But Alford and Nicoll present good arguments for interpretation (2).

## 2:29c

**Such a man’s praise does not come from men, but from God.**

- God praises him, even if no person does.
- That person’s praise will come from God, not from people. (GW)

**Such a man’s praise does not come from men, but from God:** This clause refers to the man who has a relationship with God. The Holy Spirit has “circumcised” his heart.

In some languages this clause would refer to the person of the “written code,” because it is the last word of 2:29b. If that is true in your language, you may want to:

- Make “Spirit” the last word in 2:29b. For example:

<sup>29b</sup>and circumcision is a matter of the heart, not by the written code but by the Spirit. <sup>29c</sup>Such a man's praise does not come from men, but from God.

- Explain the correct meaning in the text. For example:

The man whose circumcision is by the Spirit, such a man's praise does not come from men, but from God.

**praise:** This word refers to God commending this person. God says that he has done good and approves him.

Some languages must use a verb here. For example:

God, rather than men, praises such a person.

**men:** Here this word is general and refers to people. For example:

He may not be praised by any human being, but he will be praised by God. (NJB)

Nobody might praise him, but God praises him.

### General Comment on 2:28a–29c

These verses say what a true person of God is not, then says what he is. In some languages it is more natural to say what he is first. For example:

<sup>28–29</sup>For a Jew is one inwardly, and circumcision is a matter of the heart, by the Spirit, not by the written code. Such a man's praise does not come from men, but from God. A man is not a Jew because he is one outwardly, nor is circumcision only outward and physical.

## Romans 3:1

### Section 3:1–8: God is faithful and righteous

In chapter two, Paul spoke about some wrong ideas that the Jews had. In this section, Paul spoke to someone, probably a Jew, who might think that Paul implied that God was unfaithful to his covenant with the Jews. Paul showed that regardless of how God's people had behaved, God was always faithful to what he said.

Keep in mind that Paul himself was a Jew. He knew how Jews thought, and he knew how to answer their objections.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

God is faithful to his covenant even if his people are not

God keeps his word and does what is right

### 3:1a

#### What, then, is the advantage of being a Jew?

- ¶ So, what added benefit does a Jew have?
- ¶ Then what privilege/bonus is there in being a Jew rather than being a Gentile/non-Jew?

**What, then, is the advantage of being a Jew?:** This is a rhetorical question. It causes the reader to think about what the answer might be. Paul answered this question in 3:2.

**then:** This conjunction introduces something more that Paul wanted to say about circumcision (2:25–29). Based on what he said there, he now has another question for his readers. For example:

So (NCV)

But the connection is not introducing a logical conclusion. Your translation should not introduce a logical conclusion here. Additionally, the BSB places this word after “What.” Place this connecting word in a place that is natural for your language.

**advantage:** The Greek word that the BSB translates as advantage means “something greater.” Jews have their covenant with God and his words. This is more than what the Gentiles have. Here are other ways to translate this word:

benefit (NJB)

privilege/bonus

### 3:1b

#### Or what is the value of circumcision?

- Or/Also, what value/worth is there for someone who is circumcised?
- And does the fact that someone is circumcised benefit him?

**Or:** This word introduces another question similar in meaning to the question in 3:1a.

**what is the value of circumcision?:** In 2:25 Paul wrote “circumcision...is of value.” Here the clause is a what question. If possible, translate it using similar words to that verse. For example:

is circumcision valuable?

There are all kinds of advantages. (GW)

what is the worth of circumcision?

It is good in a lot of ways! (CEV)

what is the use/benefit of being circumcised?

### 3:2b

#### First of all,

- The most important benefit is this:

**First of all:** There is a textual issue in 3:2b: (1) Some Greek manuscripts do not have the word for (BSB, RSV, NIV, GNT, NJB, NASB, NLT, GW, CEV, NET, REB, ESV, NCV). (2) Some Greek manuscripts have the word for (KJV, NRSV). It is recommended that you follow option (1). There are two interpretations of the Greek phrase that the BSB translates as First of all:

1. It means first in a list. But Paul did not continue his list. However, he does make such a list in 9:4–5. For example:

In the first place (GNT) (BSB, ESV, RSV, GNT, NABRE, REB)

1. It means first in importance. The meaning is similar to Mark 12:28: “Which is the first of all the commandments?” For example:

The most important thing is this: (NCV) (KJV, NCV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1), because the Greek grammar supports it. Schreiner (page 148) says, “the presence of *mèn* and *polù katà pánta trópon* indicates that it refers to the first item in a list (cf. 1:8).” Barrett, Moo, Alford, Nicoll, and Morris also support interpretation (1).

### 3:2c

#### they have been entrusted with the very words of God.

- they were given the messages of God to use and protect.
- God spoke his words/messages to us<sup>(excl)</sup> Jews so that we would follow them and respect them.

#### they have been entrusted with the very words of God:

The word that the BSB translates as they refers to the Jews. This phrase indicates that God gave his words to the ancestors of the Jews. They were to watch over and guard it. They were to prevent anyone from changing it. They were also to follow it and teach it.

This clause is passive. Some languages must translate it as an active clause. For example:

## Romans 3:2

### Section 3:1–8: God is faithful and righteous

In chapter two, Paul spoke about some wrong ideas that the Jews had. In this section, Paul spoke to someone, probably a Jew, who might think that Paul implied that God was unfaithful to his covenant with the Jews. Paul showed that regardless of how God’s people had behaved, God was always faithful to what he said.

Keep in mind that Paul himself was a Jew. He knew how Jews thought, and he knew how to answer their objections.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

God is faithful to his covenant even if his people are not

God keeps his word and does what is right

### 3:2a

#### Much in every way.

- Yes, many benefits in many ways.
- There are many big privileges/bonuses in being a Jew.
- The benefits/bonuses are great and many!

**Much in every way:** Paul answered the two rhetorical questions of 3:1 here. This answer indicates that the Jews have great advantages and that circumcision has value. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

Great in every respect. (NASB)

Yes, great benefits!

These words are not a full sentence. In some languages this must be a full sentence. For example:

Yes, there are great benefits! (NLT)

God entrusted them with his word (GW)

God gave his word to the Jews to watch over

**the very words of God:** The Greek word that the BSB translates as the very words means “sayings,” “spoken messages,” or “messages that a divine being speaks.” These words would include things that God said to Abraham, Moses, the prophets and others in the Old Testament. The Jews themselves think that in his words to them, God entrusted all his wisdom to them; so what Paul says here is very important to them. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

the things that God said/promised

God’s message

## Romans 3:3

### Section 3:1–8: God is faithful and righteous

In chapter two, Paul spoke about some wrong ideas that the Jews had. In this section, Paul spoke to someone, probably a Jew, who might think that Paul implied that God was unfaithful to his covenant with the Jews. Paul showed that regardless of how God’s people had behaved, God was always faithful to what he said.

Keep in mind that Paul himself was a Jew. He knew how Jews thought, and he knew how to answer their objections.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

God is faithful to his covenant even if his people are not

God keeps his word and does what is right

### 3:3a–b

**What if some did not have faith? Will their lack of faith nullify God’s faithfulness?:** The Greek New Testament punctuates this verse so that it reads: “What then? If some were unfaithful, will their unfaithfulness nullify the faithfulness of God?” The beginning two words are the same as in Philippians 1:18. Many scholars support this punctuation, but few English versions do. Many English versions support the punctuation as in the BSB.

### 3:3a

**What if some did not have faith?**

- What if some of them did not keep their agreement with God?
- Some Jews broke their promise to God, what about them/that?

**What if some did not have faith?:** This is a rhetorical question. It introduces the fact that some Jews were unfaithful. Paul’s readers knew that. But it causes the readers to think about that fact. Translate it with that meaning. Here are some ways:

- As a rhetorical question. For example:

But what if some of them were not faithful? (GNT)

- As a statement. For example:

some of them were unfaithful (NLT)

**did not have faith:** There are two ways to interpret the Greek word that the BSB translates as did not have faith:

1. It means be unfaithful or fail to act in a loyal way here. The Jews made a covenant with God but some of them later broke that promise and stopped following it. For example:

were not faithful (GNT) (ESV, RSV, NIV11, GNT, NJB, NABRE, NLT, GW, REB, NCV)

1. It means do not believe. Some Jews refused to believe in God’s message (3:2c). For example:

did not believe (NASB) (BSB, NIV84, NASB, CEV, NET, KJV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1), because the contrast in 3:3–4 is between God being faithful to his promises, and the Jews not being faithful to theirs. Moo, Schreiner, and Morris support interpretation (1).

### 3:3b–4a

**Will their lack of faith nullify God’s faithfulness?**

**Certainly not!:** This is a rhetorical question and its answer. The rhetorical question causes the reader to think of what might be the answer. Paul then told what the answer was. Here are some ways to translate this:

- As a rhetorical question and its answer. For example:

Will their lack of faith cancel the faithfulness of God? <sup>4</sup>Certainly not! (REB)

- As a statement. You will need to combine 3:3 and 3:4. For example:

<sup>3-4</sup>What if some lacked faith? Their lack of faith certainly does not cancel/nullify the faithfulness of God....

### 3:3b

#### Will their lack of faith nullify God's faithfulness?

- Will their unfaithfulness cancel God's faithfulness?
- Them breaking their promise to God does not cause God to break his promises.

**Will their lack of faith:** The word that the BSB translates as lack of faith is the noun form of the word translated "did not have faith" in 3:3a. You should follow the same interpretation choice here as in 3:3a. For example:

Does the fact that they were not faithful

**nullify:** This word means "to make ineffective/useless." Some Jews broke their promises, but that did not make God break his promises. Here are other ways to translate this word:

cancel (NJB)

destroy/ruin

But even so, God nonetheless stayed/remained keeping his word/promise. Uma Back Translation on TW.

## Romans 3:4

### Section 3:1-8: God is faithful and righteous

In chapter two, Paul spoke about some wrong ideas that the Jews had. In this section, Paul spoke to someone, probably a Jew, who might think that Paul implied that God was unfaithful to his covenant with the Jews. Paul showed that regardless of how God's people had behaved, God was always faithful to what he said.

Keep in mind that Paul himself was a Jew. He knew how Jews thought, and he knew how to answer their objections.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

God is faithful to his covenant even if his people are not

God keeps his word and does what is right

### 3:4a

#### Certainly not!

- Certainly not!
- No indeed!

**Certainly not!:** The Greek is literally "May it not be." This clause indicates a very strong "no." Consider how to translate that meaning. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

Not at all! (NIV)

Of course not! (NLT)

No, indeed! (CEV)

Note that "certainly" in the As a statement example in 3:3b-4a translate the words Certainly not! here. If you used "certainly" there, do not translate these words here.

### 3:4b

#### Let God be true and every man a liar.

- May God always be truthful even though every person lies,
- Rather, all human beings are liars, but God's messages are always true.

**Let God be true:** This clause is a command that others acknowledge that God is truthful. It does not express doubt that God is truthful. God always says things that are true. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

God must be true (GNT)

Let us think of God as true (JBP)

it is absolutely not possible that God would tell-a-lie Kankanaey Back Translation on TW.

God never lies Otomi Back Translation on TW.

Some languages do not have words like "let" or "may." Instead they use the future or other tense. For example:

God will always be true (NJB)

God is honest (GW)

**and every man a liar:** The Greek is literally “and/but (let) man (be) a liar.” The verb “let...be” is implied from 3:4b. Even if every person lies, God is truthful. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

even though all human beings are liars (GNT)

even if every living man be proved a liar (JBP)

even if all people tell-liesKankanaey Back Translation on TW.

### General Comment on 3:4b

In some languages it is more natural to have the clause about people first. For example:

Let every man be a liar and let God be true

Although all men lie, God never lies.

### 3:4c

#### As it is written:

- as it is written in Scripture to God,
- It is like what King David wrote to God in his/God's holy book,

**As it is written:** Paul quoted what King David said to God in Psalm 51:4. In some languages a literal translation would not clearly indicate that 3:4d-e are Scripture. If that is true in your language, you may want to explain it in the text. For example:

As it is written in God's Word

In some languages a literal translation would not clearly indicate that someone spoke 3:4d-e to God. If that is true in your language, you may want to explain it in the text. Use your usual translation for “Scripture.” For example:

As it is written saying to God in his Word

As it is written in God's Word, saying to him/God

This clause is passive. Some languages must use an active clause here. For example:

As King David wrote

See how you translated the words As it is written in 1:17, except if you mention the author as in the example above, use the correct author here.

The lines in Psalm 51:4 before this quote are “Against you, you only, have I sinned and done what is evil in your sight.” David was thinking of his own wrongdoing, and how God is always right when he speaks. In some languages a footnote to explain the context would be helpful to the reader. Here is an example footnote:

The lines in Psalm 51:4 before this quote are “Against you, you only, have I sinned and done what is evil in your sight.” David was thinking of his own wrongdoing, and how God is always right when he speaks.

### 3:4d

#### “So that You may be proved right when You speak

- “So that you may be shown to be correct/right/true in what you have said,
- “The purpose is that all that happens will show that your words are true,

**So that:** These words probably introduces purpose. Consider how to translate that meaning.

**You may be proved right when You speak:** This clause is passive. Some languages must use an active clause here. For example:

history will prove you right in your words

all that happens prove that your words are true

**proved right:** Here this word means “shown to be right.” In the case of King David, God sent a prophet to tell him he had sinned with Bathsheba and then had her husband killed. Both events were true and God revealed those secrets of David. Here the word refers more generally to God's words. Events will show them to be true. See the examples above.

### 3:4e

#### and victorious when You judge.”

- and you will win when you are judged.”
- and when people judge you as wrong, no one can change your decision/mind.”

**victorious when You judge:** There are three ways to interpret the Greek word that the BSB translates as judge:



1. It means you are judged here. This interpretation sees the Greek word as passive voice. For example:

you must win your case when you are being tried (GNT) (RSV, GNT, NASB, ESV, NABRE, NET, REB, KJV)

1. It means you contend in court with someone here. This interpretation sees the Greek word as middle voice. For example:

you will win your case in court (NLT) (NLT, GW, CEV, NCV)

1. It means you judge here. This follows the meaning in the Hebrew of Psalm 51:4. For example:

prevail when you judge (NIV) (BSB, NIV, NJB, NRSV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1), because that is the plain reading of the Greek word. Alford (page 338), Barrett (page 63) and Lenski (page 213) support interpretation (1). The Greek verb *krinō*, “judge” is never considered “deponent,” meaning that the passive ending really has an active meaning.

**victorious:** This word refers to winning a fight or contest. When God judges, no one will be able to change his mind or avoid what God says is his punishment. For example:

win (NLT)

### General Comment on 3:4d–e

These words are a quote found in Psalm 51:4. If you indicate the location of quotes from the Old Testament with cross-references, you may want to do so here.

## Romans 3:5

### Section 3:1–8: God is faithful and righteous

In chapter two, Paul spoke about some wrong ideas that the Jews had. In this section, Paul spoke to someone, probably a Jew, who might think that Paul implied that God was unfaithful to his covenant with the Jews. Paul showed that regardless of how God’s people had behaved, God was always faithful to what he said.

Keep in mind that Paul himself was a Jew. He knew how Jews thought, and he knew how to answer their objections.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

God is faithful to his covenant even if his people are not

God keeps his word and does what is right

### 3:5a–c

**if our unrighteousness highlights the righteousness of God, what shall we say? That God is unjust to inflict His wrath on us?:** The second question answers the first question. The clause what shall we say is also the then-clause after the if-clause. In some languages it might be more natural to combine these two questions into one question. For example:

if our unrighteousness highlights the righteousness of God, then might we ask this: “Is God unjust to inflict his wrath on us?”

if our unrighteousness highlights the righteousness of God, then we might ask this: “Is God unjust to inflict his wrath on us?”

### 3:5a

**But if our unrighteousness highlights the righteousness of God,**

- ¶ But if our<sup>(incl)</sup> evil deeds show that God is righteous more clearly,
- ¶ When we do evil things/deeds, that shows more clearly that what God does is right.

**But:** There is some contrast between God judging rightly (3:4) and people’s evil deeds showing that God is righteous (3:5a). Many English versions begin this verse with But. However, in some languages it is more natural not to indicate contrast here. For example:

If our evil deeds show... (CEV)

**if our unrighteousness highlights the righteousness of God:** Here the word if introduces a situation that is true. If this first part is true, that supports the second part (“what shall we say?”).

In some languages, using an if-clause would have a different meaning. If that is true in your language, translate the correct meaning. For example:

since our unrighteousness highlights the righteousness of God

our unrighteousness highlights the righteousness of God. True? So...

Would you agree that our unrighteousness highlights the righteousness of God? So...

You would agree that our unrighteousness highlights the righteousness of God. So...

### **our unrighteousness highlights the righteousness**

**of God:** The Greek word that the BSB translates as highlights is literally “demonstrates.” It means that our sins are in contrast to God’s righteous deeds. People seeing our sins will see that God’s deeds are very different. Greek gods often did the same kinds of wicked deeds as people. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

our unrighteousness demonstrates the righteousness of God (NASB)

our evil deeds show how right God is (CEV)

When we do wrong, that shows more clearly that God is right. (NCV)

**unrighteousness:** Here this word means “wrongdoing.” Here are other ways to translate this word:

wickedness (RSV)

doing wrong (GNT)

**the righteousness of God:** This phrase indicates that God does what is right. See the examples above in the note on “our unrighteousness serves to show the righteousness of God.”

### **3:5b**

#### **what shall we say?**

- what shall we say/conclude?
- So, what shall we say about that?

### **3:5b–c**

**what shall we say? That God is unjust to inflict His wrath on us?:** The Greek is literally “what will we say? God is surely not unrighteous to inflict wrath on us, (is he)?” The last question answers the first question. The last question expects an answer of “no, he is righteous to do that.”

The words what shall we say? introduces what someone might say based on “our unrighteousness serves to show the righteousness of God.” Paul showed that he did not agree that we should say that God is unjust to inflict His wrath on us, when he said “Certainly not!”

in 3:6a. Your translation should indicate or imply that Paul was not agreeing that God is unrighteous here. A literal translation in some languages may not do that. If that is true in your language, you should indicate or imply that Paul was not agreeing That God is unjust to inflict His wrath on us. For example:

shall we say, as some do, that God is unjust to inflict his wrath on us?

what shall we say? Should we say, as some do, that God is unjust to inflict his wrath on us?

### **3:5c**

#### **That God is unjust to inflict His wrath on us?**

- Is it wrong for God to become angry and punish us? (CEV)
- Shall we say that it is not right for God to be angry and punish us?

**That:** This word introduces indirect speech. In many languages this word with this meaning here cannot begin a sentence. If that is true in your language, introduce the indirect speech in a natural way in your language. For example:

Shall we say that

**to inflict His wrath on us:** This phrase refers to punishing in anger. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

to become angry and punish us (CEV)

to punish us in/with his anger

### **3:5d**

#### **I am speaking in human terms.**

- (I speak here as a mere man.)
- (Some people talk like that.)

**I am speaking in human terms:** The Greek grammar indicate that this clause is extra information. It is not a part of Paul’s main thought. But he wanted to explain the source of his last question (3:5c). Some translates place this phrase in parenthesis. Consider how to indicate that this clause is extra information.

This clause indicates here that what Paul wrote in 3:5c is only human kind of thinking, as someone without the Holy Spirit’s guidance. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

I am using a human argument (NIV)

to use human terms (NJB)

I speak only as a man

This is merely a human point of view. (NLT)

I am talking as people might talk. (NCV)

## Romans 3:6

### Section 3:1–8: God is faithful and righteous

In chapter two, Paul spoke about some wrong ideas that the Jews had. In this section, Paul spoke to someone, probably a Jew, who might think that Paul implied that God was unfaithful to his covenant with the Jews. Paul showed that regardless of how God's people had behaved, God was always faithful to what he said.

Keep in mind that Paul himself was a Jew. He knew how Jews thought, and he knew how to answer their objections.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

God is faithful to his covenant even if his people are not

God keeps his word and does what is right

### 3:6a

#### Certainly not!

- Certainly not!
- No indeed, we should not think that!

**Certainly not!:** These are the same Greek phrase as in 3:4a. Translate it as you did there.

But this phrase answers the question in 3:5c. It does not connect to 3:5d. In some languages a literal translation would wrongly indicate Paul disagreed with what he said in 3:5d. If that is true in your language, you may want to repeat some of 3:5c here. For example:

By no means should we say that God is unrighteous!

### 3:6b

#### In that case, how could God judge the world?

- Otherwise, how will God judge all the people of the world?
- If God were not righteous/just, then he would not judge people properly!

**In that case:** The Greek word that the BSB translates as In that case introduces a different conclusion than what was said before. The meaning of 3:6a is “By no means should we say that God is unrighteous,” and now the meaning of 3:6b is “for, if God was unrighteous, how could he judge the world justly?” Translate this conjunction with that meaning. Here are other ways to translate this word:

Otherwise, (NASB)

If that were so, (NIV)

If God is not just, (GNT)

**how could God judge the world?:** This is a rhetorical question. It expects the answer “if God was not righteous, he could not judge people justly.” Translate this clause with that meaning. Here are some ways to do that:

- As a rhetorical question. For example:

how can he judge the world? (GNT)

how will God judge the world? (NASB)

how would he be qualified to judge the world? (NLT)

- As a statement. For example:

It would mean that God could not be the judge of the world. (NJB)

**how could God judge:** Many scholars say that this question is about how, not ability. For example, Morris (page 159) says, “Some understand the question as ‘If God is not just, how can he judge the world?’ (GNT), but this does not seem to be what the Greek means and it is not convincing. There is no theoretical reason why an unjust deity should not preside in an unjust judgment. Paul’s point is rather that, assuming as all do that God will judge the world, some must be punished. Unless this happens, what occurs will not be judgment. It is the exercise of wrath, not the character of God, that is the point of it all.” It asks, “If God is not

righteous, by what standard would he use to judge?"  
For example:

how will God judge (NASB)

The English words "can" or could have a similar meaning here.

**the world:** Here this phrase refers to all people whoever lived. In some languages a literal translation would wrongly refer only to the earth. If that is true in your language, translate this as:

all people

## Romans 3:7

### Section 3:1–8: God is faithful and righteous

In chapter two, Paul spoke about some wrong ideas that the Jews had. In this section, Paul spoke to someone, probably a Jew, who might think that Paul implied that God was unfaithful to his covenant with the Jews. Paul showed that regardless of how God's people had behaved, God was always faithful to what he said.

Keep in mind that Paul himself was a Jew. He knew how Jews thought, and he knew how to answer their objections.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

God is faithful to his covenant even if his people are not

God keeps his word and does what is right

### 3:7a–b

**However, if my falsehood accentuates God's truthfulness, to the increase of His glory, why am I still condemned as a sinner?:** This verse is similar to 3:5. Paul was speaking generally of lying making God's truth more clear. He said my falsehood, but was referring generally to lying. He is probably not confessing a specific sin here. Morris says, "It is essentially the same argument as that in v. 5, but stated this time in terms of falsehood and truthfulness (or 'truth')."

In some languages a literal translation would wrongly indicate that Paul was confessing that he was lying about something. If that is true in your language, translate in a way that indicates that the meaning is more general. For example:

But if through our falsehood God's truthfulness is accentuated to the increase of his glory, why are we still being condemned as sinners?

Someone might argue, "If my falsehood enhances God's truthfulness and so increases his glory, why am I still condemned as a sinner?" (NIV)

### 3:7a

**However, if my falsehood accentuates God's truthfulness, to the increase of His glory,**

- But, if the true words of God are more clear because of my lie, and as a result, he is honored more,
- Our<sup>(incl)</sup> lies show even more that God's words/message is true, and so, people honor him more.

**However:** There is a textual issue in 3:7a: (1) Some Greek manuscripts have the word and/but (BSB, RSV, GNT, NJB, NASB, NLT, REB, ESV). (2) Some Greek manuscripts have the word for (KJV, NET). It is recommended that you follow option (1). There is some contrast here to 3:6b. So some English versions translate the Greek conjunction as However. However, some English versions do not see contrast here and so omit the conjunction. For example:

If my lie increases... (GW)

**if my falsehood accentuates God's truthfulness, to the increase of His glory:** Here the word if introduces a situation that is true. If this first part is true, that supports the second part ("why am I still condemned as a sinner?").

In some languages, using an if-clause would have a different meaning. If that is true in your language, translate the correct meaning. For example:

my falsehood accentuates God's truthfulness, to the increase of his glory. True? So...

Would you agree that my falsehood accentuates God's truthfulness, to the increase of his glory? So...

You would agree that my falsehood accentuates God's truthfulness, to the increase of his glory. So...

**my falsehood accentuates God's truthfulness, to the increase of His glory:** The phrase that the BSB translates as my falsehood accentuates God's truth-

fulness is literally “the truthfulness of God is much in my falsehood.” The BSB put the phrase my falsehood before the subject God’s truthfulness, probably for emphasis. But the phrase in the Greek is not emphasized in that way. Follow normal phrase order in your language here. In English here is a more normal word order:

God’s truthfulness abounds to the increase of his glory through/in my falsehood

The Greek tense on this verb usually is translated as past tense. But many English versions use the present tense, because the English present tense is used to indicate a general statement. The lie could refer to being unfaithful to promises (3:3), but here it probably is general, referring to any sin. Consider how to translate this word so that it indicates a general statement.

**my falsehood:** This phrase is literally “in/through my falsehood.” It indicates that this falsehood caused God’s “truthfulness” to more clearly be seen. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

by means of my falsehood

my falsehood makes God’s truth abundantly clear

my lie increases the glory that God receives by showing that God is truthful (GW)

on account of my lies, the trueness of God’s word is increasingly seenKankanaey Back Translation on TW.

**accentuates:** This word means “be much.” Here it refers to God’s truth being more clearly shown. Here are other ways to translate this word:

making his truth stand out more clearly (GNT)

highlights (NLT)

abounds (ESV)

In some languages one cannot speak of truthfulness being “accentuated.” If that is true in your language, indicate that people see more and more of God’s truth. For example:

is increasingly seenKankanaey Back Translation on TW.

being more apparentUma Back Translation on TW.

makes it apparent that God’s word is true

**God’s truthfulness:** Here this phrase refers to God’s words; they are true. Whenever God speaks, he says what is true. In some languages a literal translation is not possible. If that is true in your language, refer to his words being true. For example:

God’s truth (ESV)

showing that God is truthful

the trueness of God’s wordKankanaey Back Translation on TW.

**glory:** Here this word refers to people praising and honoring God because they recognize his greatness and majesty. Here are other ways to translate this word:

great honor (CEV)

he is honored/praisedKankanaey Back Translation on TW.

See also glory, sense A3(a) in the KBT.

### 3:7b

#### why am I still condemned as a sinner?

- why should God still judge me as guilty for being a sinner?
- Let us not say, “Then he should not continue to punish us as wrongdoers!”

**why am I still condemned as a sinner?:** This is a rhetorical question based on what Paul said in 3:7a. Paul implied here that it was wrong to think that an excuse for sin would be that it increases God’s truth and therefore his glory. Translate this with that meaning. Here are some ways:

- As a rhetorical question. For example:

Why should I still be condemned as a sinner?  
(GNT)

- As a statement. For example:

then I should not be judged to be a sinner at all.  
(NJB)

**why am I still condemned:** The Greek is literally “why still am even I being judged/condemned.” The Greek word that means “even I” indicates emphasis on the meaning of I. If possible translate this emphasis. For example:

why is it I who is still being condemned

This clause is passive. Some languages must use an active clause here. For example:

why is God/he still condemning me

**still:** Here this word indicates that God condemned this person even though his lie caused God’s truth to be shown more clearly and more people honor him (3:7a).

**sinner:** This word refers to a person who sins.

## Romans 3:8

### Section 3:1–8: God is faithful and righteous

In chapter two, Paul spoke about some wrong ideas that the Jews had. In this section, Paul spoke to someone, probably a Jew, who might think that Paul implied that God was unfaithful to his covenant with the Jews. Paul showed that regardless of how God’s people had behaved, God was always faithful to what he said.

Keep in mind that Paul himself was a Jew. He knew how Jews thought, and he knew how to answer their objections.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

God is faithful to his covenant even if his people are not

God keeps his word and does what is right

### 3:8a

#### Why not say,

- We should not say
- Should we say

### 3:8a–c

**Why not say,...“Let us do evil that good may result”?:** The Greek word that the BSB translates as Why not say is literally just the word not. There are

several ways to interpret what is implied for the correct meaning:

1. The word Why is implied from 3:7b and the word say is implied from 3:8b. For example:

Why not say...“Let us do evil that good may result”? (NET) (BSB, NIV, GNT, NABRE, NRSV, NASB, NET)The GW, NCV, and CEV add the word “say,” do not add “why,” and omit “not.” It seems that the NCV and CEV would be following this interpretation but they have translated the rhetorical question as a statement. The GW adds “can,” probably for the same reason.

1. Only the word Why is implied from 3:7b. For example:

And why not do evil that good may come? (RSV) (RSV, ESV, REB)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1), because many scholars support it as well. For example, Cranfield, Dunn, and Longenecker.

This is a rhetorical question. It emphasizes that people should not say “Let us do evil that good may result.” Translate this with that meaning. Here are some ways:

- As a rhetorical question, as in the BSB. But such a question in some languages might expect a “yes, let’s do that” for an answer. If that is true in your language, indicate that the saying is wrong to think or say. For example:

is it right to say,...“Let us do evil that good may result”? No!

- As a statement. For example:

it is wrong to say,...“Let us do evil that good may result.”

- As a command. For example:

Do not say,...“Let us do evil that good may result.”

### 3:8b

#### as some slanderously claim that we say,

- what some people, trying to ruin our name/reputation, claim we<sup>(excl)</sup> say.
- what some people wrongly accuse us of saying? No! They are trying to hurt our good name

- what some people say that we say? No, for they are wanting to ridicule us

**as some slanderously claim that we say:** The Greek is literally “as we are slanderously charged and some affirm us to say.” For example:

as we are being slanderously reported as saying  
and as some claim that we say (NIV84)

In some languages it is more natural to combine these two clauses into one clause. For example:

as some slanderously charge us with saying (ESV)

some people even slander us by claiming that we say (NLT)

**some slanderously claim that we say:** Here the word slanderously refers to saying things that are not true in order to cause hurt. Here the slander may be directed at hurting Paul or the gospel of Jesus. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

slander us by claiming that (NLT)

claim for the purpose of ruining our name/reputation

trying to give us a bad name, falsely say

### 3:8c

#### “Let us do evil that good may result”?

- They claim that we say, “Let us<sup>(incl)</sup> do evil deeds so that we might get good things.”
- by claiming that we ask why we should not do evil deeds so that good things will happen.

**Let us do evil that good may result:** This clause says that people should do evil because then God would show more grace to them or, more generally, more good things would happen. They should not. This is wrong thinking. (See the note on 3:8a–c.) Here are other ways to translate these words:

Let us do evil so that good may come of it (NET)

Let us do bad deeds so that good things may happen to us

The phrase that the BSB translates as that good may result indicates that doing evil would lead to a good outcome. Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

so that good will appearUma Back Translation on TW.

in order that the result will be goodKankanaey Back Translation on TW.

### 3:8d

#### Their condemnation is deserved!

- When people says such things, it is right for God to punish them.

**Their condemnation is deserved:** The word condemnation refers to the verdict or sentence that a judge gives to a guilty person. Here it probably refers to God condemning them. The author found five scholars who spoke to this. Four said it refers to God’s condemnation. Morris said that perhaps it was both men’s and God’s condemnation. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

such people are justly condemned (NJB)

God is right to judge those people as guilty/wrong

**Their:** The Greek word is literally “whose.” It probably refers to the people saying or thinking “if through my lie God’s truth abounds to his glory, why am I still being condemned as a sinner?” or “Let us do evil so that good may come of it.”

**deserved:** This word means “right.” Paul said it is right for God to say that these people are guilty and will be punished.

## Romans 3:9

### Section 3:9–20: The Jews also are sinners

In this section, Paul used quotations from the Old Testament to show that the Jews sin against God. They are not better than the Gentiles. God will hold them responsible for their sins. Paul also said that when someone follows the law of Moses, that does not make God say he is righteous.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

Both Jews and Gentiles sin

No One is Righteous (NIV)

Everyone has sinned

### 3:9a-b

**Are we any better? Not at all:** This is a rhetorical question and its answer. The rhetorical question causes the reader to think of what might be the answer. Paul then told what the answer was. Here are some ways to translate this:

- As a rhetorical question and its answer. For example:

Do we have any advantage? Not at all! (NIV11)

are we Jews better than others? No! (NCV)

Is the status of the Jews in God's estimation better than that of the Gentiles? No! Kankanaey Back Translation on TW.

- As a statement. For example:

We Jews are not better off, no, not at all.

We Jews have no advantage over the Gentiles. No none at all.

The status of the Jews in God's estimation is no better than that of the Gentiles. No.

Many Jews thought that they were better than the Gentiles/Greeks because they had God's word and God chose them to be his people. Paul asked this question and answered "no" to show that Jews also were sinners.

### 3:9a

**What then? Are we any better?**

- ¶ So then, what does this mean? Are we<sup>(excl)</sup> Jews better/superior than others?
- ¶ So what shall we say? We Jews have no advantage over non-Jews.

**What then?:** This is a rhetorical question. It causes the reader to think about what the answer might be. Paul used it to introduce the next question. Here are other ways to translate this question:

What does all this mean? (CEV)

What shall we conclude then? (NIV)

What then will we say? Kankanaey Back Translation on TW.

**we:** Some English versions add the word "Jews" here. In 3:9c, Paul spoke of Jews and Greeks, so he would include himself with the Jews in this case.

**any better:** Here this phrase means "to have an advantage." It compares one group with another and indicates that one is better than the other. See the examples above.

### 3:9b

**Not at all.**

- Absolutely/Certainly not!
- No!

**Not at all:** The Greek words are more literally "not certainly" or "not entirely." But many English versions and scholars translate the Greek as Not at all (BSB) or "Certainly not" (NET). Some English versions add the word "No," perhaps for a more natural English expression. Here are other ways to translate these words:

By no means!

Certainly not! (NET)

### 3:9c

**For we have already made the charge that Jews and Greeks alike are all under sin.**

- For/Because we/I have already accused all people, both Jews and Gentiles, of being sinners,
- I have already said that all of us, whether we are Jews or non-Jews, are to blame for sinning.

**For:** This conjunction introduces an explanation of "Are we any better? Not at all!" in 3:9a-b. In some languages it is more natural to omit this conjunction and allow the context to imply that connection. For example:

we have already... (NJB)

**we:** This pronoun refers to Paul as the writer of this letter (1:1). The style of using we when only one person is speaking or writing occurs in Greek literature and in the Bible.

It does not refer to the same people as "we" in 3:9a. You may want to use "I" to indicate that Paul was not including Jews here. For example:



I (GNT)

**have already made the charge:** This phrase means “accused beforehand.” Paul said earlier in this letter that Jews and non-Jews are sinners. Now he reminded his readers that he said that. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

have already accused (GW)

said before that they were to blame

already said that...are all guilty (NCV)

already said that...all have sin  
Otomi Back Translation on TW.

**Greeks:** The basic meaning of this word is “people who are from Greece.” But in the New Testament the word usually refers to anyone who is not a Jew. So it includes Romans and other non-Jewish peoples. In some languages a literal translation would wrongly refer only to people from Greece. If that is true in your language, you may want to:

- Use a more general word. For example:

Gentiles (CEV)

- Translate the literal meaning and explain it in a footnote. Here is an example footnote:

This word in the New Testament usually refers to anyone who is not a Jew.

**under sin:** There are two ways to interpret the Greek phrase that the BSB translates as under sin:

1. It means that all people are sinners. For example:

guilty of sin (NCV) (NCV)

1. It means that all people are under the power of sin. For example:

under the dominion of sin (NJB) (RSV, NIV11, GNT, NJB, NABRE, NLT, GW, CEV, REB)

The BSB, NIV84, ESV, NASB, KJV, and NET translate literally, but the phrase under sin is not clear as to its exact meaning in English. It could mean interpretation

(1) or (2). If a literal translation in your language allows for interpretation (1), you may want to translate that way.

But if a literal translation in your language will only follow interpretation (2), it is recommended that you follow interpretation (1), because the examples of under sin in 3:10–18 clearly refer to people responsible for their sin and not to sin controlling them. Longenecker, Lenski, and Alford support interpretation (1). Some scholars refer to 7:14 to support “under the power of sin” here, but this author feels the context is too different to be a good parallel. Also, interpretation (1) fits better with the Greek word that the BSB translates as “we have already made the charge,” as those responsible rather than being victims.

Here are other ways to translate this phrase according to interpretation (1):

are sinners  
Uma Back Translation on TW.

sin habitually  
Yakan Back Translation on TW.

**sin:** This word refers to doing something that God said is wrong to do, or not doing something that God said they should do.

## Romans 3:10

### Section 3:9–20: The Jews also are sinners

In this section, Paul used quotations from the Old Testament to show that the Jews sin against God. They are not better than the Gentiles. God will hold them responsible for their sins. Paul also said that when someone follows the law of Moses, that does not make God say he is righteous.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

Both Jews and Gentiles sin

No One is Righteous (NIV)

Everyone has sinned

### 3:10–18

In these verses Paul quoted parts of the Old Testament. He did that to show that God also considers everyone a wrongdoer.

### 3:10a

#### As it is written:

- as these words are written in Scripture,

- It is like what they wrote in God's holy book. It says:

**As it is written:** This phrase indicates that the following words are from Scripture. In some languages a literal translation would not clearly indicate that 3:4d-e are Scripture. If that is true in your language, you may want to explain it in the text. For example:

As it is written in God's Word

As scripture says (NJB)

See how you translated this phrase in 1:17 or 2:24.

### 3:10b

**"There is no one righteous, not even one.**

- "Not one person is upright, not one,
- "Nobody is right before/with God, not even one person.

**no one:** Here the phrase no one means "not one person."

**righteous:** Here the word righteous refers to people whom God considers to be right in their standing before him. Here are other ways to translate this word:

is whom God regards as right

is right before God

In some languages, people use an idiom to express this meaning. For example:

are on a straight path

is upright

See how you translated this word in 2:13.

## Romans 3:11

### Section 3:9-20: The Jews also are sinners

In this section, Paul used quotations from the Old Testament to show that the Jews sin against God. They are not better than the Gentiles. God will hold them responsible for their sins. Paul also said that when someone follows the law of Moses, that does not make God say he is righteous.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

Both Jews and Gentiles sin

No One is Righteous (NIV)

Everyone has sinned

### 3:11a

**There is no one who understands,**

- not one person understands right and wrong,
- Nobody knows God's ways/character.

**who understands:** Here this word probably refers to understanding of right and wrong. Exegetical Helps on TW quotes D.D. Whedon: "The Old Testament speaks of wisdom, folly, and understanding not so much from the intellectual as from the moral standpoint. To be wicked is to be a fool; to be righteous was to understand." In some languages a literal translation would be too general. If that is true in your language, explain what it refers to here. For example:

who understands right and wrong

who discerns right from wrong

But it is also possible that the quoted poetic Hebrew line is meant to have a similar meaning to "no one seeks for God" (3:11b). In that case this verb refers to understanding who God is. For example:

Not one of them understands or even searches for God. (CEV)

who understands God's character

### 3:11b

**no one who seeks God.**

- and not one person seeks God.
- Nobody desires to know God.

**no one who seeks God:** This clause indicates that no one wants to know God, or have anything to do with God. The word seeks does not mean that God is lost. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

no one seeks to discover who God is

no one who seeks to know him Kankanaey Back Translation on TW.

there is also no person who seeks for the true way going to God Western Bukidnon Manobo Back Translation on TW.

## Romans 3:12

### Section 3:9–20: The Jews also are sinners

In this section, Paul used quotations from the Old Testament to show that the Jews sin against God. They are not better than the Gentiles. God will hold them responsible for their sins. Paul also said that when someone follows the law of Moses, that does not make God say he is righteous.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

Both Jews and Gentiles sin

No One is Righteous (NIV)

Everyone has sinned

### 3:12a

#### All have turned away,

- All people have turned away from the righteous/ good path,
- All people have turned away from following God.

**turned away:** This phrase refers to leaving the correct path. It is figurative language and refers to no longer living in a way that honors God. In some languages a literal translation would not have the correct meaning. If that is true in your language, explain the correct meaning in the text. For example:

turned aside from God's ways

turned aside to walk a bad path

turned-their-backs on God  
Kankanaey Back Translation on TW.

### 3:12b

#### they have together become worthless;

- as a group, they have become completely bad,
- They have all become people full of bad morals.

**together:** Here this word refers to the “all” of 3:12a. It does not indicate that they all became worthless at the same time. In some languages a literal translation would indicate the wrong meaning. For a clearer indication of the correct meaning in English, the NABRE just repeats “all” from 3:12a. It says:

<sup>12a</sup>All have gone astray; <sup>12b</sup>all alike are worthless

**become worthless:** The Greek word here refers to becoming good for nothing because of always doing bad things. The L&N says it means: “to engage in behavior which is totally wrong and harmful.” The BDAG (sense 2) says it means here: “becoming a liability to society because of moral depravity.” Here are other ways to translate this Greek word:

have become debased (REB)

are completely bad

### 3:12c

#### there is no one who does good, not even one.”

- and no person does good deeds, no, not one.”
- Nobody is kind to another. Not even one person does that.”

**there is no one who does good:** There are two ways to interpret the Greek word that the BSB translates as does good:

1. It means goodness or kindness here. For example:

there is no one who does good (NIV) (BSB, ESV, RSV, NIV, NASB, NABRE, KJV, NLT, GW, NCV, NET, REB)

1. It means right here. For example:

no one does what is right (GNT) (GNT, NJB, CEV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1), because many Greek lexicons support it. Including Louw and Nida, Moulton and Milligan, and Kittel. Nicoll (page 607) says, “here it answers to (the) Hebrew (word) טוֹב and means “good.” Barrett, Moo, Morris and Schreiner also support interpretation (1).

**not even one:** The phrase not even one emphasizes the meaning of the phrase “no one.” Here are other ways to translate these words:

not a single one (NLT)

no, not one

### General Comment on 3:10b–12c

These words are similar to the words found in Psalms 14:1–3, 53:1–3, and Ecclesiastes 7:20.

## Romans 3:13

### Section 3:9–20: The Jews also are sinners

In this section, Paul used quotations from the Old Testament to show that the Jews sin against God. They are not better than the Gentiles. God will hold them responsible for their sins. Paul also said that when someone follows the law of Moses, that does not make God say he is righteous.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

Both Jews and Gentiles sin

No One is Righteous (NIV)

Everyone has sinned

### 3:13–15

Here Paul used verses from the Old Testament which talk about body parts: throats, tongues, lips, mouths, feet. Each of these is a figure of speech. The throat, tongue, lips, and mouth refers to speaking. The feet refers to doing. In each case consider whether the figure of speech is clear. Also consider how to make these verses poetic.

#### 3:13a

#### “Their throats are open graves;

- “Their throat is like an open grave,
- “What they say is rotten/foul, like a dead person’s body in an uncovered hole in the ground.

**Their throats are open graves:** This clause is a figure of speech. Looking down someone’s throat is to see a deep hole. An open grave is also a deep hole. It indicates that what people say is like a dead body, full of rottenness or bad things.

In some languages a literal translation would not have the correct meaning. If that is true in your language, you may want to:

- Make it a simile. For example:

Their throats are like an open grave

- Explain the connection in the text. For example:

Their throats are full of rottenness like an open grave

- Explain the meaning of throats and the connection in the text. For example:

The words coming out of their open throats are full of rottenness like an open grave

Their words are full of rottenness like an open grave

- Translate the literal meaning and explain it in a footnote. Here is an example footnote:

This saying indicates that what people say is like a dead body, full of rottenness or bad things.

**open graves:** This phrase refers to a hole with a dead body in it. The hole has not been filled with dirt.

#### 3:13b

#### their tongues practice deceit.”

- and they deceive with their tongues.”
- With their deceiving talk they try to lead people astray/off the right path.”

**their tongues practice deceit:** The Greek is literally “with their tongues they were deceiving.” It indicates that the people spoke words that deceived others. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

they use their tongue to deceive (ESV)

they use their tongues for telling lies (NCV)

In some languages it is not natural to refer to tongues deceiving. If that is true in your language, translate in a natural way. For example:

They use their words to deceive their fellows  
Kankanaey Back Translation on TW.

They are liars  
Western Bukidnon Manobo Back Translation on TW.

#### General Comment on 3:13a–b

This quote is from Psalm 5:9. If you indicate the location of quotes from the Old Testament with cross-references, you may want to do so here.

#### 3:13c

#### “The venom of vipers is on their lips.”

- “It is as if they have the venom of vipers behind their lips.”
- “Their lips speak hurtful words like the venom of vipers.”

**The venom of vipers is on their lips:** This clause is a figure of speech. These people's words are hurtful like venom of vipers. Evil talk can hurt people greatly.

In some languages a literal translation would not have the correct meaning. If that is true in your language, you may want to:

- Make it a simile. For example:

It is as if they have the venom of vipers on their lips

Their words are like snake poison (NCV)

- Explain the connection in the text. For example:

Their lips speak hurtful words like the venom of vipers hurts people

- Translate the literal meaning and explain it in a footnote. Here is an example footnote:

This saying indicates that what people say is very hurtful, like the venom of vipers.

**The venom of vipers:** The word vipers refers to several kinds of snakes, including the Egyptian cobra, the European asp, and various vipers. Their bite and venom can kill a person.

Some languages do not have a word for vipers. If that is true in your language, you may want to:

- Use the name of a kind of poisonous snake in your area. For example:

The venom of asps (ESV)

- Use the general word for snake and indicate that it is poisonous. For example:

The liquid/essence of venomous snakes

- Use the general word for snake and allow the context to indicate that it is poisonous. For example:

the venomous of snakes

**venom:** This word refers to the liquid in some snakes that is poisonous to other animals and people.

**on their lips:** The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as on their lips is literally “under the lips” (as in the ESV). It refers to the fangs containing the venom lying in the lower part of the mouth. They are concealed by the lips. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

from their lips (GNT)

behind their lips (NJB)

Their lips hide the venom of poisonous snakes (GW)

### General Comment on 3:13c

This quote is from Psalm 140:3. If you indicate the location of quotes from the Old Testament with cross-references, you may want to do so here.

## Romans 3:14

### Section 3:9–20: The Jews also are sinners

In this section, Paul used quotations from the Old Testament to show that the Jews sin against God. They are not better than the Gentiles. God will hold them responsible for their sins. Paul also said that when someone follows the law of Moses, that does not make God say he is righteous.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

Both Jews and Gentiles sin

No One is Righteous (NIV)

Everyone has sinned

### 3:14

#### “Their mouths are full of cursing and bitterness.”

- “With their mouths they are always cursing and speaking resentfully/spitefully.”
- “They always curse others and speak with hatred/spite.”

### Their mouths are full of cursing and bitterness:

The phrase full of indicates that people do something often. These people were always cursing and they were always bitter. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

their speech is full of cursing and bitterness (NJB)

They only curse and speak bitterly

**cursing:** This word refers to a person asking God or an evil spirit to cause something bad to happen to another person.

**bitterness:** This word indicates that the words of these people were resentful, angry, and spiteful. Here are other ways to translate this word:

bitter resentment (GW)

spite

### General Comment on 3:14

These words are similar to the words found in Psalm 10:7.

## Romans 3:15

### Section 3:9–20: The Jews also are sinners

In this section, Paul used quotations from the Old Testament to show that the Jews sin against God. They are not better than the Gentiles. God will hold them responsible for their sins. Paul also said that when someone follows the law of Moses, that does not make God say he is righteous.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

Both Jews and Gentiles sin

No One is Righteous (NIV)

Everyone has sinned

### 3:15

#### “Their feet are swift to shed blood;

- “Their feet are swift to find someone to hurt or kill,
- “They quickly/eagerly go and murder people.

**Their feet are swift to shed blood:** This is a figure of speech. It indicates that these people are always ready to hurt or kill others. The words Their feet are swift indicate that they are ready to run toward any opportunity to hurt or kill others. In some languages a literal translation would not have that meaning. If that is true in your language, you may want to:

- Explain in your translation the part that is unclear. For example:

Their feet are swift to find someone to hurt or kill

They are swift to shed blood

They are quick to hurt or kill someone You may then want to tell the literal saying in a footnote. Here is an example footnote:

Literally: “Their feet are swift to shed blood.”

- Translate the literal meaning and explain it in a footnote. Here is an example footnote:

This saying indicates that these people are always ready to hurt or kill others. They are ready to run to any opportunity to do so.

## Romans 3:16

### Section 3:9–20: The Jews also are sinners

In this section, Paul used quotations from the Old Testament to show that the Jews sin against God. They are not better than the Gentiles. God will hold them responsible for their sins. Paul also said that when someone follows the law of Moses, that does not make God say he is righteous.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

Both Jews and Gentiles sin

No One is Righteous (NIV)

Everyone has sinned

### 3:16

#### ruin and misery lie in their wake,

- wherever they go, they destroy people/things and make people suffer,
- All their lives, they destroy people and cause distress.

**ruin and misery lie in their wake:** This clause indicates that these people cause ruin and misery for others wherever they go. They destroy people and their things and cause them to suffer. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

they leave a path of ruin and misery

Everywhere they go they cause ruin and misery (NCV)

Wherever they go they destroy and they bring hardship  
Western Bukidnon Manobo Back Translation on TW.

their whole lives they destroy/ruin others and cause suffering

**in their wake:** Here the word wake is a figure of speech, referring to the aftermath of one's daily actions. See the examples above.

## Romans 3:17

### Section 3:9–20: The Jews also are sinners

In this section, Paul used quotations from the Old Testament to show that the Jews sin against God. They are not better than the Gentiles. God will hold them responsible for their sins. Paul also said that when someone follows the law of Moses, that does not make God say he is righteous.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

Both Jews and Gentiles sin

No One is Righteous (NIV)

Everyone has sinned

### 3:17

#### and the way of peace they have not known."

- and they have not known the path of being at peace with others."
- Also, they do not know how to live peacefully with others."

**the way of peace they have not known:** The phrase the way of peace is emphasized in this clause. In some languages it is more natural to have this phrase in its normal place. For example:

they have not known the way of peace

**the way of peace:** This phrase refers to how to live peacefully with others. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

the lifestyle of peace

the life of being at peace with others

the path which leads to harmony and peace  
Kankanaey Back Translation on TW.

to live peacefully/harmoniously  
Yakan Back Translation on TW.

Note that the Greek word that the BSB translates as way is the same Greek word translated "wake" in 3:16. It helps show the contrast between the two ways of life. If possible, use way or "path" or "road" in both places.

### General Comment on 3:15–17

These words are similar to the words found in Isaiah 59:7–8.

## Romans 3:18

### Section 3:9–20: The Jews also are sinners

In this section, Paul used quotations from the Old Testament to show that the Jews sin against God. They are not better than the Gentiles. God will hold them responsible for their sins. Paul also said that when someone follows the law of Moses, that does not make God say he is righteous.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

Both Jews and Gentiles sin

No One is Righteous (NIV)

Everyone has sinned

### 3:18

#### "There is no fear of God before their eyes."

- "It does not enter their thoughts that they should be afraid/tremble before God because of their sins."
- "They did not fear nor respect God."

**There is no fear of God before their eyes:** The Greek word that the BSB translates as fear can also mean "reverence." The meaning of "reverence" is probably implied along with the meaning of fear here. Morris says: "Fear in this Psalm is not to be understood in the sense of "reverence" but of terror." But Barnes (as quoted in EH) says: "There is no such regard or reverence for the character, authority, and honour of God as to restrain them from crime." These people are not afraid of God and do not respect him either.

But many languages do not have a word that has both Greek meanings. If that is true in your language,

translate the meaning of fear. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

They have no fear of God at all (NLT)

They are not afraid of God and his judgment

they also do not think that they should be afraid to sin against God  
Western Bukidnon Manobo  
Back Translation on TW.

**before their eyes:** This is a figure of speech. What is in front of a person's eyes that determines where he goes. So Paul indicated that the fear of God did not in any way determine how these people lived. See the above examples.

### General Comment on 3:18

These words are similar to the words found in Psalm 36:1.

## Romans 3:19

### Section 3:9–20: The Jews also are sinners

In this section, Paul used quotations from the Old Testament to show that the Jews sin against God. They are not better than the Gentiles. God will hold them responsible for their sins. Paul also said that when someone follows the law of Moses, that does not make God say he is righteous.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

Both Jews and Gentiles sin

No One is Righteous (NIV)

Everyone has sinned

### 3:19a

**Now we know that whatever the law says, it says to those who are under the law,**

- ¶ So, we<sup>(incl)</sup> know that everything in the law applies to the people who must live by it,
- ¶ We know that all that the Laws of Moses say applies to the people who live under them.

**Now:** This conjunction indicates that Paul resumed his thoughts after the quotes from Scripture. Consider how to indicate that in your language. For example:

So then

That is what the written word of God says, and-  
Kankanaey Back Translation on TW.

**whatever the law says, it says to those who are under the law:** The phrase those who are under the law refers to Jews. Moo (page 205), Morris (page 169), Cranfield (page 196), Schreiner (page 168), Jewett (page 264), and Dunn (page 152). The GNT makes this clear by capitalizing law, their way of indicating the Laws of Moses. For example:

everything in the Law applies to those who live under the Law

**whatever the law says, it says:** In some languages, it is not natural to refer to laws "saying" anything. If that is true in your language, translate the correct meaning. For example:

whatever is written in the laws, it is written

**those who are under the law:** The Greek phrase is literally "the ones in the law." It indicates that people live within boundaries set by the law, and in a way the law defines who they are. Dunn (page 152). Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

those who are subject to the Law (NJB)

the people who exist/live within/under those laws

### 3:19b

**so that every mouth may be silenced**

- so that every person's mouth may be silenced,
- This stops all excuses (NCV)

**so that every mouth may be silenced:** The phrase so that introduces a purpose clause. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

in order to silence every mouth

for the purpose of stopping every mouth

**every mouth may be silenced:** This is a figure of speech. It indicates that no one will have an excuse. They will not be able to argue with God when he judges them.

This clause is passive. Some languages must translate it as an active clause. For example:



God may silence every mouth

God may keep people from having excuses

**may:** Here this word indicates that something will possibly happen. But Paul was convinced that God would silence every mouth. The word “will,” in English, indicates something more certain than may here. Consider what word or grammar in your language would indicate that every mouth will (certainly) be stopped.

### 3:19c

**and the whole world held accountable to God.**

- and so that everyone in the world will answer to him for their sins/wrongdoing,
- and God will judge all people for the wrong things they have done and punish them.

**and the whole world held accountable to God:** This clause is the second purpose.

**the whole world:** This is a figure of speech. Here it means “all the people in the world.” In some languages a literal translation would not have the correct meaning. If that is true in your language, explain its meaning in the text. For example:

every person in the world

**held accountable:** The Greek is literally “may come under judgment.” It indicates that every person is responsible for their deeds and words, and God will judge them as guilty for every evil deed and everything said to hurt someone. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

deserves punishment

deserves for God to punish them

is/are sinful in God’s sight and God must punish them  
Yakan Back Translation on TW.

## Romans 3:20

### Section 3:9–20: The Jews also are sinners

In this section, Paul used quotations from the Old Testament to show that the Jews sin against God. They are not better than the Gentiles. God will hold them responsible for their sins. Paul also said that when someone follows the law of Moses, that does not make God say he is righteous.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

Both Jews and Gentiles sin

No One is Righteous (NIV)

Everyone has sinned

### 3:20a

**Therefore no one will be justified in His sight by works of the law.**

- because not one person will be declared right before God/him by his own efforts in following the laws of Moses,
- For God/he will not call any person righteous/upright because that person has done what those laws require.

**Therefore:** There are three ways to interpret the Greek word here:

1. It introduces an explanation or a reason here. For example:

because (NCV) (ESV, RSV, GNT, NASB, NABRE, NLT, NET, REB, NCV)

1. It introduces a result. For example:

Therefore (NIV) (BSB, NIV, KJV)

1. It introduces something loosely connected to 3:19. For example:

So then (NJB) (NJB)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). Moo (on TW) says: “This verse may give the reason why the whole world is accountable to God, or it may serve to confirm this accountability. The latter suggestion is best.” Morris (on TW) says: “Paul is not drawing a conclusion from the preceding (which would require ‘therefore’), but giving a reason for it (‘for’).” BDAG, Barrett, and Schreiner also support interpretation (1).

**no one:** The Greek is literally “not...all flesh.” Here “flesh” refers to people.

**will be justified in His sight:** This clause is passive. Some languages must use an active clause here. For example:

that God/Jesus will justify

**justified in His sight:** The word justified indicates that God decides that a person is acceptable to him. He makes their relationship right. Here are other ways to translate this word:

put right in God's sight (GNT)

made right with God (NLT)

declared righteous before him (NET)

See how you translated the word justified in 2:13, where the BSB translates it as "declared righteous."

**in His sight:** This phrase is a figure of speech that indicates here that God considers believers to be right with him. It does not refer to God looking at someone. Some languages must translate without this figure of speech or with a different figure of speech. For example:

by him/God

before him (NET)

**by works of the law:** This phrase refers to a person's own efforts to obey their laws. It probably refers to the Jews and the Laws of Moses. Moo, Morris, Cranfield, and Dunn understand it this way. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

doing what the Law requires (GNT)

with/by obeying the Laws of Moses

### 3:20b

#### **For the law merely brings awareness of sin.**

- for knowledge of sin/wrongdoing is by means of the laws.
- Indeed, we know that we are sinful because we fail so often to obey the law.

**For:** The Greek conjunction here is usually translated as For. Here it introduces information that supports what Paul said in 3:20a. As Moo states in TW. Some scholars say it introduces the reason. But knowledge of sin or the fact that it comes through the law is not the basis or reason for not being justified through the law. For example:

since (ESV)

**the law merely brings awareness of sin:** The law of Moses shows people that they are sinners because they know that they do not obey it fully. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

knowledge of sin comes by means of the law

The law...shows us how sinful we are. (NLT)

**brings:** There is no Greek verb here. A Greek clause with no verb usually implies the verb "is/be" in an English translation. Here the clause indicates that people hear or read the law and realize how many ways there are to sin. See the examples above.

In this division Paul showed that God has made a way to rescue people from being punished for wrongdoing and put them in a right relationship with himself.

Here are other possible headings for this division:

God makes his people right with him

Our relationship with God because of Jesus

### **Romans 3:21**

#### **Section 3:21–31: God makes people righteous when they believe in Jesus**

In this section Paul explained God's plan for rescuing wrongdoers and making them right with himself. God did this by sending Jesus Christ to stand in the place of every wrongdoer and take the punishment that every wrongdoer deserves. So then, when a person believes in Jesus as the one who has taken the punishment on his behalf, God makes that person right with himself. In this way God remains true to his righteous character, for wrongdoing has been punished.

Since God did that, believers cannot boast in themselves. Paul also said that this faith in Jesus supports the law of Moses.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

Righteousness Through Faith (NIV)

How We Are Put Right with God (GNT)

God Gives Us His Approval as a Gift (GW)

God's Way of Accepting People (CEV)

**3:21a**

**But now, apart from the law, the righteousness of God has been revealed,**

- ¶ But now the righteousness from God has been shown that does not depend on the law of Moses,
- ¶ But recently God has shown how he will make people right with himself. It is not the Jewish law that makes them right.

**But now:** This phrase introduces a new topic that contrasts with obeying the law of Moses. It may also indicate a new period of time. It introduces Jesus dying on the cross and God resurrecting him, which occurred about twenty-five years before Paul wrote this letter. Consider how to translate that meaning in your language. For example:

But at this time Uma Back Translation on TW.

**apart from the law:** This phrase indicates that the law of Moses does not help people get this righteousness of God that he has revealed through Jesus. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

It has nothing to do with law (GNT)

without keeping the requirements of the law (NLT)

not on the basis of obeying the laws of Moses

But we do not become straight in his sight from our following the Lord's Law. Uma Back Translation on TW.

**the righteousness of God has been revealed:** The word revealed means that, by what Jesus did, God showed people how they can be righteous before God without following the law of Moses.

This clause is passive. Some languages must translate it as an active clause. For example:

God has shown us a way to be made right with him (NLT)

God has a way to make people right with him... and he has now shown us that way (NCV)

**the righteousness of God:** There are three ways to interpret the Greek word ending that the BSB translates as of:

1. Here it indicates that God makes people right in their relationship with him. For example:

a way to be made right with him (NLT) (GNT, NJB, NLT, GW, CEV, NCV)

1. Here it indicates that God enables believers to behave in right ways. For example:

a righteousness from God (NIV84) (NIV84)

1. Here it refers to the righteousness that God has. This is the natural way to interpret the meaning of the word of in English here. For example:

the righteousness of God (REB) (BSB, ESV, RSV, NIV11, NASB, KJV, NABRE, NET, REB)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1), because many scholars and versions support it. For example, Cranfield (page 202) says it is "as...in 1:17,... a status of righteousness before God...." Morris (page 173) says it is "the right standing that comes from God."

Here are other ways to translate this phrase according to interpretation (1):

how God does make us acceptable to him (CEV)

God has a way to make people right with him (NCV)

**3:21b**

**as attested by the Law and the Prophets.**

- but the law of Moses and the prophets spoke about it.
- The books of the Laws of Moses and the Prophets tell about this way of making people right.

**as attested by the Law and the Prophets:** The Greek is literally "being testified to by the law and the prophets." The words in the Old Testament (the Law and the Prophets) do not help people get the righteousness of God. But some of those words speak about this righteousness.

There is an implied contrast in this phrase. For example:

even though the Law of Moses and the prophets gave their witness to it (GNT)

In some languages it is more natural not to translate the contrast. For example:

to which the Law and the Prophets testify (NIV)

as was promised in the Law and the Prophets

The Law and the Prophets tell of it.

**attested:** This word means “report what one saw.” The word is often used where the person is expected to be truthful and accurate. Here are other ways to translate this word:

testify (NIV)

told us about (NCV)

**the Law and the Prophets:** Here this phrase refers to the whole Old Testament. In some languages the meaning of this phrase would not be clear. If that is true in your language, you may want to explain it in the text. For example:

the books of the Laws of Moses and the books of the Prophets

the books of the Laws of Moses and the Prophets

**the Prophets:** Prophets are people who speak on behalf of God. God’s message may be in words or visions. The prophets then tell the people God’s message. See how you translated this word in 1:2.

This phrase here implies the writings of the prophets in the Old Testament. In some languages it would be more natural or more clear to indicate that. For example:

the writings of...the prophets (NLT)

the writings of the past that God caused...the prophets to write  
Tagbanwa Back Translation on TW.

## Romans 3:22

### Section 3:21–31: God makes people righteous when they believe in Jesus

In this section Paul explained God’s plan for rescuing wrongdoers and making them right with himself. God did this by sending Jesus Christ to stand in the place of every wrongdoer and take the punishment that every wrongdoer deserves. So then, when a person believes in Jesus as the one who has taken the punishment on his behalf, God makes that person right with himself. In this way God remains true to his righteous character, for wrongdoing has been punished.

Since God did that, believers cannot boast in themselves. Paul also said that this faith in Jesus supports the law of Moses.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

Righteousness Through Faith (NIV)

How We Are Put Right with God (GNT)

God Gives Us His Approval as a Gift (GW)

God’s Way of Accepting People (CEV)

### 3:22a

#### And this righteousness from God comes through faith in Jesus Christ

- This righteousness from God is/comes/occurs by means of faith in Jesus Christ,
- God makes people right with himself when they believe that Jesus is the Christ.

**this righteousness from God:** Translate this phrase as you did in 3:21.

**through faith in Jesus Christ:** The word through indicates that when a person believes in Jesus, God considers him as righteous. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

by means of faith in Jesus Christ

by placing our faith in Jesus Christ (NLT)

because they have faith in Jesus Christ

when we believe that Jesus Christ has saved us  
O-tomi Back Translation on TW.

**faith in Jesus Christ:** To have faith in a person refers to believing in him, who he is, and who he claims to be.

The word faith describes an event. In some languages a verb must be used. For example:

believing in Jesus Christ

believing that Jesus is the Christ

See how you translated the word faith in 1:5.

**Christ:** The word Christ is a title for Jesus. It means “the anointed one.” The Jews used it to refer to the special person God promised to send. See how you translated this word in 1:1 or 2:16.

### **3:22b to all who believe.**

- for all people believing in him,
- God does that to all who believe that Jesus is the Christ.

**to all who believe:** There is a textual issue in 3:22b: (1) Some Greek manuscripts have the words for all (BSB, RSV, NIV, GNT, NJB, NASB, NLT, GW, CEV, NET, NABRE, REB, ESV). (2) Some later Greek manuscripts have the words for all and upon all (KJV). It is recommended that you follow option (1). This phrase indicates that God makes all believers righteous. It does not matter what kind of person they are or were. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

for all who believe (ESV)

God does this to all who believe in Christ (GNT)

All who believe that Jesus is the Christ, God considers them righteous no matter what his group/family/nation.

**to:** The Greek word that the BSB translates as to means “toward.” It is with respect to or for the benefit of all believers that God makes them righteous.

### **3:22c There is no distinction,**

- because there is no difference among people.
- They are all equal before God,

The Greek begins with a conjunction that is usually translated as “for.” It introduces the basis for saying “all” in 3:22b. For example:

because (GNT)

In some languages it is more natural to omit this conjunction and allow the context to indicate the connection, as the BSB does. For example:

There is no difference (NIV)

**There is no distinction:** All people are sinners (3:23a), therefore, regarding righteousness, God considers everyone to be unrighteous. Also, God calls righteous all who believe, be they Jew or Gentile, or any other distinction. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

there is no difference at all (GNT)

God treats everyone alike. (CEV)

all people are the same: (NCV)

he doesn’t discriminate what kind of people they areUma Back Translation on TW.

## **Romans 3:23**

### **Section 3:21–31: God makes people righteous when they believe in Jesus**

In this section Paul explained God’s plan for rescuing wrongdoers and making them right with himself. God did this by sending Jesus Christ to stand in the place of every wrongdoer and take the punishment that every wrongdoer deserves. So then, when a person believes in Jesus as the one who has taken the punishment on his behalf, God makes that person right with himself. In this way God remains true to his righteous character, for wrongdoing has been punished.

Since God did that, believers cannot boast in themselves. Paul also said that this faith in Jesus supports the law of Moses.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

Righteousness Through Faith (NIV)

How We Are Put Right with God (GNT)

God Gives Us His Approval as a Gift (GW)

God’s Way of Accepting People (CEV)

### 3:23a for all have sinned

- I say that because everyone has done what is wrong,
- because every person has sinned against God,

**for:** This conjunction introduces the basis for saying “there is no distinction.” For example:

Because (GW)

Some English versions omit this conjunction, perhaps because of the same conjunction occurring in 3:22c. They allow the context to indicate the connection.

**all have sinned:** This clause indicates that all people have done things that God does not want people to do.

In some languages the translation of sinned is very general and can include “made a mistake.” The context implies that these deeds are sins against people and God. In some languages the implied information must be explicit for the correct meaning. For example:

all have sinned against God

all have sinned against people and God

### 3:23b and fall short of the glory of God,

- and failed to get the glory/majesty that God gives for the righteous,
- and no one gains the glory/honor from God.

**fall short of the glory of God:** Many English versions translate the literal meaning of the words of this clause. But scholars differ as to what this clause refers. Here are the two common ways to interpret this clause:

1. Adam and Eve, the first man and woman, had glory from God before they sinned. They lost that glory when they sinned. All people after them are also sinners, so they too do not have that glory. Moo (in TW) says: “the absence of glory involves a declension from the ‘image of God’ in which human beings were first made.”
2. It indicates that people have sinned, so God no longer approves or praises them. Alford (page 342) says it means “fall short of the praise which comes from God.” Nicoll (page 610) says: “it must be the approbation or praise of God...which God would give to the sinless.”

If possible translate the literal meaning. You may then want to explain it in a footnote. The first example foot-

note below follows interpretation (1) but the second example footnote explains both.

This clause probably indicates that the first man and woman had glory from God before they sinned. They lost that glory when they sinned. All people after them are also sinners, so they too do not have that glory.

This clause may mean: 1) the first man and woman had glory from God before they sinned. They lost that glory when they sinned. All people after them are also sinners, so they too do not have that glory, or 2) people have sinned, so God no longer approves or praises them.

In some languages people cannot speak of falling short of glory. If that is true in your language, explain its meaning in your translation. For example:

fall short of God’s commands and so have lost the glory that comes from God

we cannot attain/reach God’s goodness  
Kankanaey Back Translation on TW.

**fall short of:** This phrase refers to lacking something. People cannot obtain God’s glory. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

lack (NJB)

cannot obtain/get

are not fit/worth to get/obtain  
Uma Back Translation on TW.

## Romans 3:24

### Section 3:21–31: God makes people righteous when they believe in Jesus

In this section Paul explained God’s plan for rescuing wrongdoers and making them right with himself. God did this by sending Jesus Christ to stand in the place of every wrongdoer and take the punishment that every wrongdoer deserves. So then, when a person believes in Jesus as the one who has taken the punishment on his behalf, God makes that person right with himself. In this way God remains true to his righteous character, for wrongdoing has been punished.

Since God did that, believers cannot boast in themselves. Paul also said that this faith in Jesus supports the law of Moses.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

Righteousness Through Faith (NIV)

How We Are Put Right with God (GNT)

God Gives Us His Approval as a Gift (GW)

God's Way of Accepting People (CEV)

### 3:24a

#### and are justified freely by His grace

- and because everyone is called right with God by his kind deed as a free gift,
- But they are also equal before God because he/God declares each person righteous/upright because he was kind to them without requiring/demanding them to pay for that,

**and are justified freely:** This clause continues to describe how there is no distinction (3:22c). There is some contrast between all people sinning and God justifying those who have accepted his gift of grace. For example:

But...all are put right with him (GNT)

**are justified:** This verb means “declare righteous.” It indicates that God decides that a person is acceptable to him. The present tense probably indicates that when a person believes, God declares him righteous. See how you translated the word justified in 3:20.

This clause is passive. Some languages must translate it as an active clause. For example:

God has declared righteous

**freely:** This phrase means “without cost.” God does not demand payment from people for being kind to them. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

by the free gift (NJB)

as a gift (ESV)

**by His grace:** Here the word grace indicates that God did something kind. He wants to help people. People do not deserve this help. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

by an act of his kindness (GW)

with undeserved kindness (NLT)

because of God's favor to usWestern Bukidnon Manobo Back Translation on TW.

See also grace, sense A2 in KBT.

### 3:24b

#### through the redemption that is in Christ Jesus.

- by redeeming him from the punishment of sin, which Jesus, the Christ/Messiah, accomplished.
- because Jesus, the one/person whom God appointed to save/rescue people, paid the ransom to free him.

**through the redemption that is in Christ Jesus:** Here the word in indicates that Jesus is the person who accomplishes the redemption. Jesus redeemed us by his death and resurrection. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

through the price Christ Jesus paid to set us free [from sin] (GW)

He did this through Christ Jesus when he freed us from the penalty for our sins. (NLT)

by-means-of what Cristo Jesus has done to redeem usKankanaey Back Translation on TW.

because of the redeeming of Kristus YesusUma Back Translation on TW.

because Jesus Christ paid for our sinsOtomi Back Translation on TW.

**through the redemption:** The word redemption means “to set someone free,” as when a person sets a captive free by paying a price. All people are captive to sin. When we believe in Jesus, he sets us free because his death and resurrection was the payment acceptable to God. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

through being set free (NJB)

See also redeem, sense B.1(c) in KBT.

**Christ Jesus:** The order of the words emphasizes that Jesus is the Christ. However, in some languages the order of the words Christ Jesus is not natural. If that is true in your language, emphasize the fact that Jesus is the Christ in a natural way. For example:

Jesus, who/he is the Christ

## Romans 3:25

### Section 3:21–31: God makes people righteous when they believe in Jesus

In this section Paul explained God's plan for rescuing wrongdoers and making them right with himself. God did this by sending Jesus Christ to stand in the place of every wrongdoer and take the punishment that every wrongdoer deserves. So then, when a person believes in Jesus as the one who has taken the punishment on his behalf, God makes that person right with himself. In this way God remains true to his righteous character, for wrongdoing has been punished.

Since God did that, believers cannot boast in themselves. Paul also said that this faith in Jesus supports the law of Moses.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

Righteousness Through Faith (NIV)

How We Are Put Right with God (GNT)

God Gives Us His Approval as a Gift (GW)

God's Way of Accepting People (CEV)

### 3:25a

#### God presented Him as the atoning sacrifice

- God openly presented him before mankind as the way to atone for their sins
- God publicly sent him as the way to pay the penalty for people's wrongdoing

**God presented Him:** Here the word presented means "to display publicly." God had Jesus do his work openly, for everyone to see. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

whom God put forward (ESV)

whom God displayed publicly (NASB)

God sent openly

**as the atoning sacrifice:** These are two main ways to interpret the Greek word that the BSB translates as atoning sacrifice:

1. It refers to making amends for sin. Jesus' death for the sake of mankind paid the penalty for sin. God could then forgive their sins. For example:

as a sacrifice of atonement (NIV) (BSB, RSV, NIV, GNT, NABRE, NLT, CEV, REB, NCV)

1. It refers to appeasing God's anger against sin. Jesus' death for the sake of mankind allowed God to forsake his anger against the sins of people. For example:

as a means to appease his wrath (ESV, NASB, KJV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1), because BDAG supports it. Here are other ways to translate this word according to interpretation (1):

as a sacrifice for reconciliation (NJB)

as a way to forgive sin (NCV)

### 3:25b

#### through faith in His blood,

- by means of his blood in his sacrifice and made effective/true for them through their faith in him.
- through the shedding of his blood on the cross so that he would accept them if they believe in him.
- by the sacrifice of Jesus'/his own blood. Through that deed God can forgive them when they believe in him.

**through faith:** The BSB literally translates these Greek words. When we believe that God accepted the sacrifice of Jesus on the cross to atone for our sin, God forgives and accepts us. Believing in Jesus makes his work effective in our lives. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

through their faith in him (GNT)

to be received and made effective in ourselves by faith (JBP)



so that he would forgive our sins if we believe in  
JesusUma Back Translation on TW.

in order to clear the sins of all people who would  
believe in himOtomi Back Translation on TW.

**in His blood:** The Greek text is literally “an atonement through faith in his blood.” Some scholars say this word order means that people’s faith should be in his blood. But no other verse supports believing in his blood. It is possible that Paul implied believing that Christ’s blood was effective to atone for sin. But it is better to connect the phrase “in his blood” to “atone-ment” because in the Old Testament God commanded that people shed the blood of an animal in sacrifice to atone for sin. In the Old Testament God required a sacrifice of an animal to atone for sin. Here, the blood of Christ was poured out as the ultimate sacrifice to atone for people’s sins. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

through the shedding of his blood (NIV11)

by-means-of his bloodKankanaey Back Transla-  
tion on TW.

by the sacrifice of Jesus’/his own blood

### 3:25c

**in order to demonstrate His righteousness,**

- All that occurred to show his righteousness,
- Those things/deeds occurred to show that he/God does what is right,

**in order to demonstrate:** The Greek is literally “for the display of.” The Greek sentence continues from 3:25b. For example:

to demonstrate (NASB)

But in some languages it is more natural to begin a new sentence here. For example:

He did this to demonstrate (NIV)

God did that in order to showKankanaey Back  
Translation on TW.

**His righteousness:** There are two main ways to interpret the Greek word that the BSB translates as righteousness:

1. It means righteousness here. God does what is right. For example:

he is righteous (GNT) (BSB, ESV, RSV, NIV11, GNT, NJB, NASB, NABRE, KJV, NET, CEV, NCV)

1. It means justice here. God judges in a right way, according to what is right and wrong. For example:

his justice (REB) (NIV84, REB)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1), because the BDAG and L&N support it.

See how you translated this word in 1:17 or 3:5.

### 3:25d

**because in His forbearance He had passed over the sins committed beforehand.**

- because he was patient and passed by sins of the past,
- as in the past when he was patient and did not punish people for their sins. (NCV)

**because in His forbearance He had passed over the sins committed beforehand:** The Greek is literally

“because of the passing by of the previously occurred sins.” In the past God did not immediately judge and punish sins. He waited for Jesus to atone for sins for those who believed in Jesus. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

because in his forbearance he had overlooked the sins of the past (REB)

In his patience God waited to deal with sins committed in the past. (GW)

when he held back and did not punish those who sinned in times past (NLT)

**in His forbearance:** This phrase is the first phrase of 3:26 in the UBS Greek New Testament. But it connects to “he passed over former sins,” and the KJV put it in 3:25, so many English versions put it in 3:25.

The Greek is literally “in the forbearance of God.” The word forbearance means “being patient with.” God patiently waited for Jesus to atone for sins while people continued to sin. See the examples above.

**the sins committed beforehand:** These are the wrongdoings of people who lived during the time of

God's first covenant before Jesus died and God resurrected him.

## Romans 3:26

### Section 3:21–31: God makes people righteous when they believe in Jesus

In this section Paul explained God's plan for rescuing wrongdoers and making them right with himself. God did this by sending Jesus Christ to stand in the place of every wrongdoer and take the punishment that every wrongdoer deserves. So then, when a person believes in Jesus as the one who has taken the punishment on his behalf, God makes that person right with himself. In this way God remains true to his righteous character, for wrongdoing has been punished.

Since God did that, believers cannot boast in themselves. Paul also said that this faith in Jesus supports the law of Moses.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

Righteousness Through Faith (NIV)

How We Are Put Right with God (GNT)

God Gives Us His Approval as a Gift (GW)

God's Way of Accepting People (CEV)

### 3:26a

#### He did this to demonstrate His righteousness at the present time,

- and to show his righteousness in these days,
- Those things/deeds also occurred to show that he/ God does what is right today.

**He did this to demonstrate:** The Greek is literally “for the display of.” It connects to “God presented Him as the atoning sacrifice” (3:25a). It introduces a second thing that God would show from that atonement. The first thing that God showed is told in 3:25c–d. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

and to demonstrate

he did it to demonstrate (NIV)

God also did that in order to show

You should translate this phrase in a similar way to how you translated “in order to demonstrate” in 3:25c.

**His righteousness:** This is the same Greek phrase as in 3:25c. It probably has the same meaning here. Translate it as you did in 3:25c.

**at the present time:** This phrase refers to the time that Paul wrote this. But it also refers generally to the time between Jesus ascending to heaven and his return. For example:

for the present age (NJB)

### 3:26b

#### so as to be just and to justify the one who has faith in Jesus.

- in order that he is righteous/upright and that he declares people right/innocent when they believe in Jesus.
- In that way God always does what is right and also says that people who believe in Jesus are right in his sight.

**so as to:** The words so as to introduces the purpose of God patiently waiting for Jesus to atone for people's sins. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

in order to be

Thus it can-be-seen thatKankanaey Back Translation on TW.

**be just and to justify:** The Greek words for be just and to justify have the same root, *dikaio-*. The Greek word that this TN interprets to be “justice” (BSB “righteousness”) in 3:25–26 also has the same root. Here it indicates that the two words have related meanings, to be just means “to do what is right” and to justify means “to be a person who makes people right with someone.” English is able to use two words with the same root as well, just-. If possible translate using similar words for both Greek words.

**be just:** Here this word means “to do what is right.” God always does the right deed. Here are other ways to translate this word:

is righteous (RSV)

always does what is right

is a just God (JBP)

is upright

is truly straight Yakan Back Translation on TW.

**to justify:** The Greek is literally “the one putting right.” Here it means “declares people right before God.” When people believe in Jesus, God forgives them and considers them righteous. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

the one who puts right in his sight

he who makes right with himself

he declares righteous

The word “the one putting right” is the same word as “will be justified” in 3:20. See how you translated this word there.

**the one who has faith in Jesus:** The word faith means “to believe.” Some languages must use a verb for the meaning of faith. For example:

the one who believes in Jesus

## Romans 3:27

### Section 3:21–31: God makes people righteous when they believe in Jesus

In this section Paul explained God’s plan for rescuing wrongdoers and making them right with himself. God did this by sending Jesus Christ to stand in the place of every wrongdoer and take the punishment that every wrongdoer deserves. So then, when a person believes in Jesus as the one who has taken the punishment on his behalf, God makes that person right with himself. In this way God remains true to his righteous character, for wrongdoing has been punished.

Since God did that, believers cannot boast in themselves. Paul also said that this faith in Jesus supports the law of Moses.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

Righteousness Through Faith (NIV)

How We Are Put Right with God (GNT)

God Gives Us His Approval as a Gift (GW)

God’s Way of Accepting People (CEV)

### 3:27a

#### Where, then, is boasting? It is excluded.

- ¶ Therefore, is there anything for us to be proud of? No, there is nothing.
- ¶ Since that is true, it is pointless/worthless to boast about us being right with/before God.

**Where, then, is boasting? It is excluded:** This is a rhetorical question and its answer. The rhetorical question causes the reader to think of what might be the answer. Paul then told what the answer is. Here are some ways to translate this:

- As a rhetorical question and its answer. For example:

Then what becomes of our boasting? It is excluded. (ESV)

- As a statement. For example:

Therefore we cannot boast.

So God does not consider our boasts when he justifies us.

Therefore it is absolutely impossible for us to boast of our righteousness Kankanaey Back Translation on TW.

Also see examples below.

**Where...is boasting?:** The Greek is literally “where (is) the boasting?” Here this phrase refers to boasting about being righteous or good. But God does not justify someone because of what he or she has done or who he or she is or any boasts he or she says about those things. Here are other ways to translate these words:

Where...is boasting? (NET)

What occasion is there...for boasting? (NABRE)

there’s nothing that anyone can boast about. Western Bukidnon Manobo Back Translation on TW.

**then:** The Greek word that the BSB translates as then is usually translated “therefore.” But here it is more natural in English to translate it as then.

**It is excluded:** This phrase indicates that God does not allow any boasting by us to change his mind. God does not think better about us if we were to boast about being right with him. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

Bragging has been eliminated. (GW)

They are nothing.

No! (NCV)

### 3:27b–c

**On what principle? On that of works? No, but on that of faith:** The first question is a rhetorical question. It leads to the second question. The second question is also a rhetorical question. Paul answered it with No, but on that of faith. Here are some ways to translate this:

- Using questions. For example:

On what principle? On the principle of works? No, but on the principle of faith. (RSV)

- Using statements. For example:

It is not by a law/principle of works, but by the law/principle of faith.

For God does not receive us because of our good behavior. He receives us because of our faith in the Lord Jesus. Uma Back Translation on TW.

These three clauses are incomplete. “It is excluded” is implied each time. In some languages the implied words must be repeated here. For example:

It is excluded on what principle? Is it excluded on the principle of a law of works? No, it is excluded by the principle of the law of faith.

It is not excluded by a law/principle of works, but it is excluded by the law/principle of faith.

### 3:27b

**On what principle? On that of works?**

- What is the principle/basis for this? It is on the principle of doing good deeds?

- It is pointless/worthless to boast about us always doing good deeds because that does not make us right with/before God.

**On what principle?:** Here the word principle refers to any rule or law. Here are other ways to translate the Greek words:

By what kind of law? (ESV)

It/Boasting is excluded according to what rule/law?

**On that of works?:** The Greek is only “Of works?” The BSB phrase that of implies the words “a principle” from the previous question, so that the meaning is “On a principle of works?”

**works:** The word works refers to someone’s deeds. It is not limited to what one does for a paying job. God does not make people right with him because of what they do. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

On the principle of works? (RSV)

By following the rule of good deeds?

Is it/boasting excluded according to a principle/lifestyle of doing what God wants us to do?

### 3:27c

**No, but on that of faith.**

- No, it is on the principle of us believing in Jesus.
- Rather God makes us right before him when we believed in Jesus.

**but on that of faith:** God says that a person is righteous when that person believes in Christ. That is a rule/principle that God uses. That excludes us from boasting that we are righteous, because it is something God did, not we ourselves. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

but on the principle of faith (RSV)

it/boast is excluded because of the rule that God makes us righteous because we believe in Jesus

it/boasting is excluded according to a principle/rule of God makes us righteous because of our faith

## Romans 3:28

### Section 3:21–31: God makes people righteous when they believe in Jesus

In this section Paul explained God's plan for rescuing wrongdoers and making them right with himself. God did this by sending Jesus Christ to stand in the place of every wrongdoer and take the punishment that every wrongdoer deserves. So then, when a person believes in Jesus as the one who has taken the punishment on his behalf, God makes that person right with himself. In this way God remains true to his righteous character, for wrongdoing has been punished.

Since God did that, believers cannot boast in themselves. Paul also said that this faith in Jesus supports the law of Moses.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

Righteousness Through Faith (NIV)

How We Are Put Right with God (GNT)

God Gives Us His Approval as a Gift (GW)

God's Way of Accepting People (CEV)

### 3:28a

#### For we maintain that a man is justified by faith

- For we<sup>(incl)</sup> consider/believe this to be true: that a person is declared right before God because he believes in Jesus
- Indeed, we believers are convinced that when/if people believe in Jesus, God calls them righteous/upright.

**For:** There is a textual issue in 3:28a: (1) Some Greek manuscripts have the word *for* (BSB, RSV, NIV, GNT, NJB, NASB, GW, CEV, NET, NABRE, REB, ESV). (2) Some Greek manuscripts have the words *therefore* (KJV, NLT). It is recommended that you follow option (1), because the UBS GNT recommends it. This conjunction introduces an explanation of what Paul said earlier.

**maintain:** Here this word means “consider to be true.” Paul said here that Christians are convinced that God justified them because they believed in Jesus and not because of what they have done. Here are other ways to translate this word:

consider (NET)

believe

**a man is justified by faith:** This clause indicates that when someone believes in Jesus, God declares that that person is righteous.

This clause is passive. Some languages must use an active clause here. For example:

God justifies someone when he believes in Jesus

**a man:** Here the phrase *a man* refers to any person. For example:

a person (NJB)

**is justified:** The word *is justified* indicates that God declares that a person is acceptable to him. When people believe in Jesus, God declares them to be right with him. See how you translated this word in 2:13 (where the BSB translates it as “declared righteous”) or 3:24.

**faith:** This word refers to believing in Jesus as Lord and Savior. In some languages a verb must be used. For example:

believing in Jesus

### 3:28b

#### apart from works of the law.

- and not because he obeys the law of Moses.
- God never calls people righteous/upright when/if they do what the law of Moses tells them to do.

**apart from works of the law:** This phrase means “without regard to doing what the law of Moses requires people to do.” God does not justify people because they follow the law of Moses. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

not by doing what the Law tells him to do (NJB)

not through obeying the law (NCV)

without any regard to following the law of Moses

See how you translated works of the law in 3:20.

## Romans 3:29

### Section 3:21–31: God makes people righteous when they believe in Jesus

In this section Paul explained God's plan for rescuing wrongdoers and making them right with himself. God did this by sending Jesus Christ to stand in the place of every wrongdoer and take the punishment that every wrongdoer deserves. So then, when a person believes in Jesus as the one who has taken the punishment on his behalf, God makes that person right with himself. In this way God remains true to his righteous character, for wrongdoing has been punished.

Since God did that, believers cannot boast in themselves. Paul also said that this faith in Jesus supports the law of Moses.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

Righteousness Through Faith (NIV)

How We Are Put Right with God (GNT)

God Gives Us His Approval as a Gift (GW)

God's Way of Accepting People (CEV)

### 3:29a

#### Is God the God of Jews only?

- Or do you<sup>(plur)</sup> think that God is only the Jews' God?
- God is not only the God of Jews.

The Greek begins with conjunction that is usually translated as "or." It introduces a new set of questions related to who God justifies (3:22–28). In some languages it is more natural to omit this conjunction, as the BSB does. For example:

Perhaps you think-wrongly...Yakan Back Translation on TW.

**Is God the God of Jews only?:** This is a rhetorical question. It expects the answer "No." God is not the God of only the Jews. Translate this clause with that meaning. Here are some ways to do that:

- As a rhetorical question. For example:

Do you think God is the God only of the Jews...? (NJB)

Does God belong only to the Jews? (CEV)

- As a statement. For example:

God is definitely not the God of the Jews only. Kankanaey Back Translation on TW.

God does not rule only Jews

### 3:29b

#### Is He not the God of Gentiles too? Yes, of Gentiles too,

- Is he not the God of non-Jewish people also? Indeed, he is the God of them too,
- Is he also the God of the non-Jews? Yes,
- God is also the God of the non-Jews.

#### Is He not the God of Gentiles too? Yes, of Gentiles too:

This is a rhetorical question and its answer. The rhetorical question causes the reader to think about what the answer might be. It emphasizes the answer of Yes, (he is God) of Gentiles too. Translate this clause with that meaning. Here are some ways to do that:

- Using a rhetorical question. For example:

Is he not the God of the Gentiles also? Of course he is. (GNT)

Is he also the God of the non-Jews? Yes, he is God of the non-Jews. Some languages use a negative question, like the first example, to imply a positive answer. But some languages use a positive question, like the second example, to imply a positive answer.

- Using a statement. For example:

but he is also God of the Gentiles. Kankanaey Back Translation on TW.

God also rules the non-Jews.

**Gentiles:** This word refers to people who are not Jews. See how you translated this word in 1:5 or 2:24.

**Yes, of Gentiles too:** The phrase "he is God" is implied here. In some languages the implied phrase must be supplied. For example:

Yes, he is God of Gentiles too

## Romans 3:30

### Section 3:21–31: God makes people righteous when they believe in Jesus

In this section Paul explained God's plan for rescuing wrongdoers and making them right with himself. God did this by sending Jesus Christ to stand in the place of every wrongdoer and take the punishment that every wrongdoer deserves. So then, when a person believes in Jesus as the one who has taken the punishment on his behalf, God makes that person right with himself. In this way God remains true to his righteous character, for wrongdoing has been punished.

Since God did that, believers cannot boast in themselves. Paul also said that this faith in Jesus supports the law of Moses.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

Righteousness Through Faith (NIV)

How We Are Put Right with God (GNT)

God Gives Us His Approval as a Gift (GW)

God's Way of Accepting People (CEV)

### 3:30a

#### since there is only one God,

- if indeed, as we<sup>(incl)</sup> certainly believe, there is only one God,
- since only one God exists.

**since there is only one God:** The word since introduces the basis for Paul saying that God is God of the Gentiles (2:29b). For example:

because there is only one God (NCV)

**only one God:** This clause indicates that only one God exists. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

God is one (ESV)

God is just oneUma Back Translation on TW.

### 3:30b

#### who will justify the circumcised by faith

- who will declare the people to be right/innocent because of their faith if they are circumcised,

- He will call the circumcised people, that is the Jews, righteous/upright when/if they believe in Jesus.

**who will justify the circumcised by faith:** This clause tells the reader more about God. It does not separate God from other gods. For the correct meaning in some languages, translators must avoid the word who. For example:

He will justify the circumcised by faith.

**justify the circumcised:** The word justify refers to God declaring someone to be righteous or innocent. When people believe that Jesus died for their sins, God forgives them, accepts them, and calls them righteous. Here are other ways to translate this word:

declare the circumcised to be righteous

**the circumcised:** This phrase refers to the Jews, because the Bible always connects the Jews to being circumcised. In some languages a literal translation would not refer to the Jews. If that is true in your language, you may want to:

- Explain in the text. For example:

the circumcised, namely the Jews,

- Translate this phrase as referring to Jews. For example:

the Jews You may then want to indicate the literal phrase in a footnote. Here is an example footnote:

Literally "the circumcised."

- Translate the literal meaning and explain it in a footnote. Here is an example footnote:

Here this refers to the Jews.

**circumcised:** This word refers to cutting off the loose skin at the end of a boy's penis. See how you translated this word in 2:25 or 3:1.

**by faith:** This phrase indicates that God declares the circumcised to be righteous because they believe in Jesus. For example:

on the basis of their faith (GNT)

because of their faith (CEV)

### 3:30c

#### and the uncircumcised through that same faith.

- and will declare the people to be right/innocent because of their faith if they are not circumcised.
- He will also call the uncircumcised people, that is the non-Jews, righteous/upright when/if they believe in Jesus.

**and the uncircumcised through that same faith:** The phrase “who will justify” is implied from 3:30b. In some languages it is more natural to add the implied phrase. For example:

and who will justify the uncircumcised through that same faith

**the uncircumcised:** This phrase refers to the non-Jews, because the Bible always connects the non-Jews to not being circumcised. In some languages a literal translation would not refer to the non-Jews. If that is true in your language, you may want to:

- Explain in the text. For example:

the uncircumcised, namely the non-Jews,

- Translate this phrase as referring to Jews. For example:

the non-Jews You may then want to indicate the literal phrase in a footnote. Here is an example footnote:

Literally “the uncircumcised.”

- Translate the literal meaning and explain it in a footnote. Here is an example footnote:

Here this refers to the non-Jews.

**through:** Paul used a different preposition here than “by” in 3:30b, but many scholars think there is no difference in meaning between the two. Moo (on TW).

**that same faith:** This word refers to the same thing as this word in 3:30b. The BSB adds the words that same to emphasize that it is the same faith in both cases. In some languages a literal translation would wrongly imply a different faith. If that is true in your language, indicate the meaning is the same both times. For example:

the same faith (NIV)

## Romans 3:31

### Section 3:21–31: God makes people righteous when they believe in Jesus

In this section Paul explained God’s plan for rescuing wrongdoers and making them right with himself. God did this by sending Jesus Christ to stand in the place of every wrongdoer and take the punishment that every wrongdoer deserves. So then, when a person believes in Jesus as the one who has taken the punishment on his behalf, God makes that person right with himself. In this way God remains true to his righteous character, for wrongdoing has been punished.

Since God did that, believers cannot boast in themselves. Paul also said that this faith in Jesus supports the law of Moses.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

Righteousness Through Faith (NIV)

How We Are Put Right with God (GNT)

God Gives Us His Approval as a Gift (GW)

God’s Way of Accepting People (CEV)

### 3:31a

#### Do we, then, nullify the law by this faith? Certainly not!

- Therefore do we<sup>(incl)</sup> use this faith to cancel/destroy the law of Moses? No indeed.
- So, God calls people righteous/upright because they believe in Jesus, but we are certainly not saying that God’s laws are now worthless.

#### Do we, then, nullify the law by this faith? Certainly not!:

This is a rhetorical question and its answer. Some Jews probably asked this question after hearing Paul preach on this. The question and answer emphasize that we do not overthrow the law by this faith. Translate this clause with that meaning. Here are some ways to do that:

- Using a rhetorical question. For example:

Do we, then, nullify the law by this faith? Not at all! (NIV)



So do we destroy the law by following the way of faith? No! (NCV)

- Using a statement. For example:

Therefore we should certainly not say that this faith destroys the Law of Moses!

So, God makes us straight in his sight just because of our faith. But let's not say/think like this: we discard the Lord's Law. Don't! Uma Back Translation on TW.

**then:** The Greek word is literally “therefore,” but then is more natural in English here.

**nullify:** The Greek word that the BSB translates as nullify means “to make ineffective/useless.” It is the same Greek word translated “nullify” in 3:3. Here are other ways to translate this word:

cancel

made pointless (NJB)

overthrow (ESV)

destroy/ruin

**Certainly not!:** The Greek is literally “May it not be.” This phrase indicates a very strong “no.” See how you translated it in 3:4.

Note that “certainly” in the first As a statement example above translates the words Certainly not! here. If you used “certainly” there, do not translate these words here.

### 3:31b

**Instead, we uphold the law.**

- On the contrary, we support the law of Moses.
- Indeed/True, we believe/say that the law of Moses is still valid/worthy.

**Instead:** The Greek word is literally “but.” It indicates contrast and emphasis. In some languages the contrast of “but” is already indicated by the phrase “Certainly not” in 3:31a. If that is true in your language, translate without the contrast here. For example:

Indeed

**we uphold the law:** Here the word uphold indicates that Paul and the believers in Jesus supported the law of Moses as holy and good. Paul did not imply bad things about the law when he talked about righteousness by faith. He wanted people to understand its correct role in the life of a believer. This clause does not indicate that believers must follow every rule in the law of Moses, including the rules about what foods to eat and offering sacrifices. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

we support the law of Moses

we believe/say that the law of Moses is still valid/important

## Romans 4:1

### Section 4:1–12: God considers/calls people righteous like he did with Abraham

God called Abraham righteous because he believed what God told him (Genesis 15:1–6). In this section, Paul used that example to show that all people must believe in God for him to call them righteous. He did that for Abraham before Abraham was circumcised. So that shows that God makes people right with himself because they believe in him and not because they are circumcised.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

The Example of Abraham (GNT)

God called Abraham righteous because he believed

Abraham is/as an example of how to become righteous before God

The lesson/model of God calling Abraham righteous because he believed God

### 4:1a

**What then shall we say that Abraham,**

- ¶ So then, what shall we<sup>(incl)</sup> say about what Abraham discovered,
- ¶ So/Then, think about what we can say about Abraham,

### 4:1b

**our forefather, has discovered?**

- the ancestor from whom we are descended physically? (NJB)
- our<sup>(excl)</sup> ancestor of long ago according to human descent, and what he learned.

#### 4:1a-b

**What then shall we say that Abraham, our forefather, has discovered?:** This is a rhetorical question. It introduces a new subject, the example of Abraham. It causes the listener to think about what the answer might be. Translate this rhetorical question with that meaning. Here are some ways:

- As a rhetorical question. For example:

What can we say that we have discovered about our ancestor Abraham? (GW)

- As a statement. For example:

So then, here is what we can say about our ancestor Abraham according to human/natural descent:

**What then shall we say:** The word then indicates a connection to previous verses. It introduces an example of being justified by faith alone (3:28). SSA and Morris on TW.

In some languages, the conjunction must be first in the clause. For example:

Then, what shall we say

**that Abraham, our forefather, has discovered:** There are two issues here.

Issue 1: The text

There is a textual issue here.

1. Most very old Greek manuscripts have the Greek word that the BSB translates as has discovered. (BSB, ESV, NIV, GNT, NASB, NABRE, NLT, GW, NET, NRSV, NCV, KJV)
2. One very old Greek manuscript omits this word. (RSV, REB, CEV, NJB)

It is recommended that you follow option (1), because the UBS GNT recommends it.

Issue 2: Meaning

There are two ways to interpret the Greek word that the BSB translates as has discovered:

1. It means discover or learn here. For example:

Abraham...discovered in this matter (NIV) (BSB, NIV, NLT, NET, NASB, NABRE, GW, KJV, NCV)

1. It means attain here. For example:

was gained by Abraham (NRSV) (ESV, NRSV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). Moo (on TW) says, "Paul asks his readers to contemplate with him what Abraham has found to be the case with respect to the matters he is discussing." Many other commentators support interpretation (1).

The Greek is literally "Abraham to have discovered." It is not passive. Here are other ways to translate this clause according to option (1) and interpretation (1) above:

Abraham...What was his experience? (GNT)

Abraham...has found? (NASB)

Abraham...learned about faith? (NCV)

**Abraham:** Abraham was an important Jewish ancestor, the first of God's chosen people. God selected him to be the father of a great nation and established his covenant with him. He was greatly respected by the Jews and they called themselves "sons of Abraham."

**our forefather:** There is a textual issue in 4:1b: (1) Some Greek manuscripts have the word forefather (BSB, RSV, NIV, NJB, NASB, NLT, GW, CEV, NET, NABRE, REB, ESV). (2) Some Greek manuscripts have the word father (KJV, GNT, NCV). It is recommended that you follow option (1). The word forefather refers to an ancestor of long ago. Some Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

our ancestor (NET)

the father of our people (NCV)

The Greek literally says "our forefather according to the flesh." The BSB does not translate the phrase "according to the flesh," but it means "as a human being" here, as in 1:3. It emphasizes the physical rather than spiritual. Here are other ways to translate the phrase "according to the flesh":

humanly speaking, (JBP)

by natural descent (REB)

## Romans 4:2

### Section 4:1-12: God considers/calls people righteous like he did with Abraham

God called Abraham righteous because he believed what God told him (Genesis 15:1-6). In this section, Paul used that example to show that all people must believe in God for him to call them righteous. He did that for Abraham before Abraham was circumcised. So that shows that God makes people right with himself because they believe in him and not because they are circumcised.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

The Example of Abraham (GNT)

God called Abraham righteous because he believed

Abraham is/as an example of how to become righteous before God

The lesson/model of God calling Abraham righteous because he believed God

#### 4:2a-c

**If Abraham was indeed justified by works, he had something to boast about, but not before God:** Here, the word *If* introduces a situation that was not true. Abraham was not justified because of his works. But the “then” clause (he had something...) imagines what might have happened if Abraham had been justified because of his works.

Here are some ways to translate this:

- Some languages have a word or phrase that indicates this *if*-clause is a situation that was not true. For example:

if as-might-be-said it was because of his perfect obedience to the laws that this Abraham was declared righteous in God’s sight, he would of course now have something to boast about, (but not before God) Tagbanwa Back Translation on TW.

if-it-had-been,-but-was-not,-that God made Abraham righteous through what he had done, he would have been able to boast, but not before

God Based on the Yongkom Back Translation, unpublished manuscript.

- Other languages can add other words to help indicate that this *if*-clause is a situation that was not true. For example:

If for-example God counted him as righteous because of what he did, there would be something for him to boast-about, but the truth of it is that there is nothing that he could boast-about to God. Kankanaey Back Translation on TW.

if it were true that God called Abraham righteous because of what Abraham did, then Abraham could boast about that to someone, but he could not boast about it to God

- Other languages must translate without using the word *If*. For example:

we know that the reason that God regarded Abraham as righteous was not because he did good deeds, so he has nothing to boast about, and certainly could not boast before God

#### 4:2a

#### **If Abraham was indeed justified by works,**

- For if Abraham was declared right before God because of what he had done,
- If it were/was possible that God said that Abraham was righteous because he/Abraham did something,

This verse begins with a Greek conjunction that is usually translates as “for.” It introduces an explanation of why Paul asked about Abraham in 4:1. In some languages it is more natural to omit this conjunction and allow the context to imply that connection, as the BSB does. For example:

If Abraham... (NJB)

**Abraham was indeed justified by works:** This clause is passive. God justified Abraham. Some languages must use an active clause here. For example:

his good deeds had made him acceptable to God (NLT)

God declared Abraham righteous by his/ Abraham’s deeds

God considered Abraham to be just/innocent because of what he/Abraham did

**justified:** Here the Greek word that the BSB translates as justified means “called and treated as righteous.” God regarded Abraham as righteous. See the above examples. See how you translated this word in 2:13 (where the BSB translates it as “declared righteous”) or 3:30.

**by works:** Here the word works refers to a person’s own effort, or the deeds one does. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

by the things he did (GNT)

because of what he had done (NJB)

#### 4:2b

**he had something to boast about,**

- that would have been a good reason for Abraham to boast to others about himself,
- he could have praised himself for doing those good things.

**he had something to boast about:** This is still part of the statement which is not true (see note at 4:2a–c). If it was possible that his good deeds caused God to call him righteous, Abraham could boast about that.

**boast:** The word boast means “to talk about one’s own accomplishments or abilities with too much pride.” All Nations English Dictionary on TW. Here are other ways to translate boast:

brag (GW)

tell others how good he is

#### 4:2c

**but not before God.**

- but he could not boast to God about what he had done.
- But he could not praise himself before God about those deeds.

**but not before God:** The words “he had something to boast about” are implied from 4:2b. Some languages must repeat some or all of those words. For example:

but he could not boast before God

but he could not boast about it before God

### Romans 4:3

**Section 4:1–12: God considers/calls people righteous like he did with Abraham**

God called Abraham righteous because he believed what God told him (Genesis 15:1–6). In this section, Paul used that example to show that all people must believe in God for him to call them righteous. He did that for Abraham before Abraham was circumcised. So that shows that God makes people right with himself because they believe in him and not because they are circumcised.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

The Example of Abraham (GNT)

God called Abraham righteous because he believed

Abraham is/as an example of how to become righteous before God

The lesson/model of God calling Abraham righteous because he believed God

#### 4:3a

**For what does the Scripture say?**

- For what does the Holy Book say?
- Indeed, God’s Book says this:

**For:** The conjunction For introduces support for Abraham not being able to boast before God in 4:2c. For example:

because (NCV)

In some languages it is more natural to omit the conjunction and allow the context to imply the connection.

**what does the Scripture say?:** This is a rhetorical question. It functions to emphasize what God’s word says about Abraham. Here are some ways to translate this:

- As a rhetorical question. For example:

What does Scripture say? (GW)

- As a statement. For example:

Indeed, the Scriptures say

the Scriptures certainly tell us

**the Scripture:** The Greek word that the BSB translates as Scripture is literally “writing.” In the New Testament, this word always refers to something written in the Old Testament. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

the sacred writings

the writings which are holy

God’s message that they wrote

See how you translated the word Scripture in 1:2.

#### 4:3b

**“Abraham believed God,**

- “Abraham believed God,
- “Abraham believed God’s promise to him,

4:3b–c is a quote from Genesis 15:6. 4:3a does not explicitly introduce the quote from the Old Testament. In some languages it is more natural to explicitly introduce the quote. For example:

It says,...

Also see the second meaning line in the Display of 4:3a.

**Abraham believed God:** Here Paul used the word believed to refer to accepting what God said as true. This refers to Abraham believing that God would one day fulfill the promise that God told him. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

Abraham trusted God to fulfill his promise

Abraham believed God’s promise to himTagbanwa Back Translation on TW.

Abraham had faith in God to fulfill his promise

#### 4:3c

**and it was credited to him as righteousness.”**

- and by that believing God reckoned/counted him as upright.”
- and so God called him a righteous man.”

**and it was credited to him as righteousness:** The word it refers to “Abraham believed God.” Some languages need to use a different word or phrase. For example:

and that was counted to him as righteousness

and that belief was counted to him as righteousness

**it was credited to him as righteousness:** The phrase it was credited indicates that God thought about Abraham believing him and so gave him the status of righteous. God called Abraham righteous because Abraham believed what God told him. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

it was reckoned to him as righteousness (RSV)

it was counted to him as righteousness (ESV)

he was declared to be a righteous person because of that belief of hisTagbanwa Back Translation on TW.

This clause is passive. Some languages must use an active clause. For example:

God counted him as righteousKankanaey Back Translation on TW.

because of his faith God accepted him as righteous (GNT)

because of his faith God said he was straight in his sightUma Back Translation on TW.

**as righteousness:** The word righteousness refers to the status of being right. Here it indicates that a person’s relationship with God is right. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

as a just man

to be right with God

#### General Comment on 4:3b–c

These words are a quote found in Genesis 15:6. If you indicate the location of quotes from the Old Tes-

tament with cross-references, you may want to do so here.

## Romans 4:4

### Section 4:1–12: God considers/calls people righteous like he did with Abraham

God called Abraham righteous because he believed what God told him (Genesis 15:1–6). In this section, Paul used that example to show that all people must believe in God for him to call them righteous. He did that for Abraham before Abraham was circumcised. So that shows that God makes people right with himself because they believe in him and not because they are circumcised.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

The Example of Abraham (GNT)

God called Abraham righteous because he believed

Abraham is/as an example of how to become righteous before God

The lesson/model of God calling Abraham righteous because he believed God

#### 4:4a–b

#### the wages of the worker are not credited as a gift:

This clause is passive. Some languages must use an active clause. For example:

a worker does not count/consider his wages as a gift

#### 4:4a

#### Now the wages of the worker

- For example, when someone works for pay,
- It is like this: for/about the person who works to earn money,

**Now:** The word Now introduces what Paul wanted to say about this kind of “counting” (4:3c). It does not mean “at this present time” here. Here is another way to translate this word:

So thenHere “so then” introduces the next thing Paul wanted to say and indicates a general connection to the previous verse. These words are not meant to mean “therefore” here.

Some languages would omit this word to indicate a general connection to the previous verse. For example:

A person who works... (GNT)

**the wages of the worker:** The phrase the worker is a general way of referring to someone who works for pay. The worker expects to receive money for his work. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

A person who works (GNT)

when someone works (NJB)

for/about the wage/pay/money worker

#### 4:4b

#### are not credited as a gift,

- he does not reckon/think that the money he receives is a favor;
- he does not call his wages a kind deed by his boss/employer.

**credited:** The word credited has the same meaning as in 4:3c. If possible translate it in the same way here.

**as a gift:** This phrase is more literally “according to grace/kindness.” An employer does not give wages because he is kind. He gives them because he must, that is the agreement he has with the employee. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

as a favor (NJB)

from kindness

#### 4:4c

#### but as an obligation.

- instead, he reckons/knows that he deserves that money.
- No, he says, “I have earned those wages.”

**but as an obligation:** The phrase “his wages are counted” are implied from 4:4b. In some languages some or all of that implied information must be made explicit. For example:

but are counted as his due

but his wages are counted as his due

**an obligation:** This phrase is more literally “according to obligation/requirement.” It contrasts with the meaning of “as a gift” in 4:4b. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

something that has been earned (GNT)

he is owed them (Otomi Back Translation on TW)

a required payment to him

## Romans 4:5

### Section 4:1–12: God considers/calls people righteous like he did with Abraham

God called Abraham righteous because he believed what God told him (Genesis 15:1–6). In this section, Paul used that example to show that all people must believe in God for him to call them righteous. He did that for Abraham before Abraham was circumcised. So that shows that God makes people right with himself because they believe in him and not because they are circumcised.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

The Example of Abraham (GNT)

God called Abraham righteous because he believed

Abraham is/as an example of how to become righteous before God

The lesson/model of God calling Abraham righteous because he believed God

#### 4:5a

#### However, to the one who does not work,

- ¶ And/But for the person who does not try to earn his own righteousness
- ¶ But when/if people are not trying to cause God to accept them by the things/deeds they do,

**However:** The Greek word that the BSB translates as However can also be translated as “But.” There is contrast between wages being earned (4:4) and the gift of God to count someone as righteousness. For example:

But (GNT)

**to the one who does not work:** Here the word to indicates that God does something for the one who does not work. He considers that person’s faith as righteousness (4:5c). Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

for the one who does not work

when someone, without working, (NJB)

**the one who does not work:** Here the word work refers to doing things for the purpose of making God happy. This would include doing good deeds to others or following religious rules and rituals. Here are some ways to translate this phrase:

the one who does not work to earn God’s favor/acceptance

if a (person), irrespective of his work, (JBP)

people cannot do any work that will make them right with God (NCV)

In some languages the word work does not indicate the correct meaning. If that is true in your language, translate the correct meaning. For example:

those who depend on faith, not on deeds (GNT)

you cannot make God accept you because of something you do (CEV)

#### 4:5b

#### but believes in Him who justifies the wicked,

- but believes in him who makes right the people who had rejected him,
- but instead, they believe in God, the one who is able to declare godless people righteous,

**Him who justifies the wicked:** The pronoun Him here refers to God. He does not require people to be godly before he will justify them. He justifies them when they believe in him. In some languages additional information is necessary to indicate the correct meaning. You may want to explain the meaning in a footnote. Here is an example footnote:

God does not require people to be godly before he will justify them. He justifies them when they believe in him.

If possible, translate the pronoun Him literally. If you need to translate Him as “God,” consider that now who justifies the wicked is a descriptive relative clause. But some languages do not use descriptive relative clauses. In those languages, “God who justifies the wicked” would indicate that there are many gods and only this one justifies the ungodly. If that is true in your language, you may want to:

- Translate the pronoun Him literally anyway, and not as “God.”
- Translate without using a descriptive relative clause. For example:

God, he justifies the wicked

God, the only one who justifies the wicked

**justifies:** See how you translated this word in 4:2.

**the wicked:** The word wicked refers to people who reject God. Here are other ways to translate this word:

people who reject God

people who do not worship God

#### 4:5c

**his faith is credited as righteousness.**

- God sees his believing, and for that reason he declares him as upright.
- then God accepts their faith, and that makes them right with him. (NCV)

**his faith is credited as righteousness:** This clause is passive. Some languages must use an active clause here. For example:

God credits his faith as righteousness

**faith:** The word faith refers to believing in God. See how you translated faith in 1:5 or 3:31.

**credited as righteousness:** The phrase credited as righteousness has the same meaning as in 4:3c.

## Romans 4:6

### Section 4:1–12: God considers/calls people righteous like he did with Abraham

God called Abraham righteous because he believed what God told him (Genesis 15:1–6). In this section, Paul used that example to show that all people must believe in God for him to call them righteous. He did that for Abraham before Abraham was circumcised. So that shows that God makes people right with himself because they believe in him and not because they are circumcised.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

The Example of Abraham (GNT)

God called Abraham righteous because he believed

Abraham is/as an example of how to become righteous before God

The lesson/model of God calling Abraham righteous because he believed God

#### 4:6a

**And David speaks likewise**

- David also spoke of that when he spoke
- That is supported by what King David said long ago in the Scriptures

**And David speaks likewise:** This clause, along with 4:6b, introduce the quote in 4:7–8. What David wrote in Psalm 32:1–2 supports what Paul wrote in 4:1–5. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

David says the same thing (GW)

David, too, says the same (NJB)

In some languages Old Testament quotes are clearly introduced as from Scripture. For example:

just as King David also talked in the Scriptures

#### 4:6b

**of the blessedness of the man to whom God credits righteousness apart from works:**

- about God blessing a person when he declares that person as upright without him earning it:



- about someone being blessed/favored when God makes people right with himself without considering his good deeds.

**the blessedness of the man:** The Greek word that the BSB translates as blessedness describes a person who is in a good situation. In the Bible, the good situation results from God showing favor/kindness to the person. It includes the inner happiness a person feels when God forgives him and accepts him.

Some Here are other ways to translate this word:

joyful/good is the situation of the person

how good it is for the person

someone is blessed/favored

Do not use a word that only refers to material prosperity or physical health.

A similar Greek word occurs frequently in the Gospels in the form “Blessed is.” See, for example, Matthew 5:3–11 and Luke 6:20–22.

**the man:** The word man refers generally to a person here. For example:

someone (NJB)

**to whom God credits righteousness:** This clause is similar in meaning to 4:3c and 4:5c. Here the clause is active not passive. For example:

whom God counts as righteousKankanaey Back Translation on TW.

whom God accepts as righteous (GNT)

whom God declares righteousTagbanwa Back Translation on TW.

**credits righteousness:** The words credits and righteousness have the same meaning as in 4:3c and 4:5c. See how you translated them there.

**apart from works:** The word works means “deeds” here. The phrase apart from works indicates here that God counts someone as righteous without thinking about that person’s deeds. Some Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

without working for it (NLT)

apart from his achievements (JBP)

even though they don’t do anything to deserve these blessings (CEV)

the reason for it not being what he didKankanaey Back Translation on TW.

but not because of their behaviorUma Back Translation on TW.

## Romans 4:7

### Section 4:1–12: God considers/calls people righteous like he did with Abraham

God called Abraham righteous because he believed what God told him (Genesis 15:1–6). In this section, Paul used that example to show that all people must believe in God for him to call them righteous. He did that for Abraham before Abraham was circumcised. So that shows that God makes people right with himself because they believe in him and not because they are circumcised.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

The Example of Abraham (GNT)

God called Abraham righteous because he believed

Abraham is/as an example of how to become righteous before God

The lesson/model of God calling Abraham righteous because he believed God

### 4:7a

#### “Blessed are they whose lawless acts are forgiven,

- “Those people whose lawbreaking is forgiven, they are blessed,
- David said this: “When God forgives people who break laws, he has blessed/favored them,

#### Blessed are they whose lawless acts are forgiven:

This clause moves the phrase Blessed are to the beginning for poetic effect. In some languages, doing that is not natural. If that is true in your language:

- Use a poetic structure that your language has.

- Use normal word order with a passive clause. For example:

Those whose lawless deeds are forgiven are blessed

- Use normal word order with an active clause. For example:

God blesses those whose lawless deeds are forgiven

**they whose lawless acts are forgiven:** This clause is passive. Some languages must use an active clause here. For example:

those whom God/he forgives their lawless acts

**lawless acts:** This phrase refers to acts that break the law. Here the word “law” can refer to God’s laws in the OT or more generally to laws where you live. Here are some ways to translate this word:

law-breaking acts

breaking the law

#### 4:7b

##### **whose sins are covered.**

- and those people whose sins are buried, they are blessed,
- and when he removes their sins, he has blessed/favored them.

**whose sins are covered:** The phrase “blessed are those” is implied from 4:7a. In some languages this phrase must be made explicit for the correct meaning. For example:

and blessed are those whose sins are covered

This clause is passive. Some languages must use an active clause here. For example:

whom God covers their sins

**sins:** This word refers to doing something that God said is wrong to do, or not doing something that God said they should do. See how you translated this word in 3:9.

**are covered:** Here the word covered is a figure of speech. It indicates that God no longer considers those sins as a problem. They are out of his sight as if he had buried them in the ground. The meaning is similar to “forgiven.” Here are some ways to translate the figure of speech:

##### **General Comment on 4:7a–b**

- Use a figure of speech. For example:

are put out of sight (NLT)

are blotted out (REB)

- Translate without using a figure of speech. For example:

are pardoned (GNT)

are forgotten (CEV)

he is no longer bringing-to-mind Tagbanwa Back Translation on TW.

4:7b is similar in meaning to “whose lawless acts are forgiven” in 4:7a. Hebrew poetry (as here) repeats meaning to emphasize it. In some languages repeating meaning implies a different meaning, such as expressing anger. If that is true in your language, translate in a way that emphasizes the correct meaning. For example:

Blessed are those whose lawless acts and sins are indeed covered and forgiven

Also, in some languages “lawless acts” and “sins” would be translated by the same term. If that is true in your language, use only the one term. For example:

Blessed are those whose sins are indeed covered and forgiven

## **Romans 4:8**

### **Section 4:1–12: God considers/calls people righteous like he did with Abraham**

God called Abraham righteous because he believed what God told him (Genesis 15:1–6). In this section, Paul used that example to show that all people must believe in God for him to call them righteous. He did that for Abraham before Abraham was circumcised. So

that shows that God makes people right with himself because they believe in him and not because they are circumcised.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

The Example of Abraham (GNT)

God called Abraham righteous because he believed

Abraham is/as an example of how to become righteous before God

The lesson/model of God calling Abraham righteous because he believed God

#### 4:8

**Blessed is the man whose sin the Lord will never count against him.”**

- also, the person that the Lord no longer keeps a record of his sins, he is blessed.”
- And when the Leader/Master God does not consider someone’s sin, he has blessed/favored that person.”

There is an implicit connection between 4:7b and 4:8. Here, probably “and” or “also” is implied.

**whose sin the Lord will never count against him:**

The word count indicates that God will not consider those sins when he judges that person. He will not include those sins as something he is guilty of. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

whose record the Lord has cleared of sin (NLT)

whose sins the Lord will not keep account of (GNT)

who had sins and the Lord God cleared themBased on the Otomi Back Translation on TW.

whose evil behavior is no longer thought about by the Lord GodBased on the Western Bukidnon Manobo Back Translation on TW.

**sin:** This word refers to doing something that God said is wrong to do, or not doing something that God said they should do. See how you translated this word in 3:9.

**the Lord:** The word Lord means “master, one who has authority over others.” Here it refers to God. See how you translated Lord in 1:4.

In some languages the word Lord must connect to a noun. For example:

God the Lord

the Lord God

#### General Comment on 4:7a–8

These words are a quote of Psalm 32:1–2. If you indicate the location of quotes from the Old Testament with cross-references, you may want to do so here.

### Romans 4:9

**Section 4:1–12: God considers/calls people righteous like he did with Abraham**

God called Abraham righteous because he believed what God told him (Genesis 15:1–6). In this section, Paul used that example to show that all people must believe in God for him to call them righteous. He did that for Abraham before Abraham was circumcised. So that shows that God makes people right with himself because they believe in him and not because they are circumcised.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

The Example of Abraham (GNT)

God called Abraham righteous because he believed

Abraham is/as an example of how to become righteous before God

The lesson/model of God calling Abraham righteous because he believed God

#### 4:9a–b

4:9 starts with the Greek conjunction that probably introduces the next topic that Paul wanted to write about. It indicates only a general connection to the previous verses. For example:

Then (NASB)

**Is this blessing only on the circumcised, or also on the uncircumcised?:** This is a rhetorical question. It

introduces two possibilities as to whom the blessing is for. Paul wanted his readers to ponder the answer to this question before he answered it in 4:10–12. There are at least three ways to translate this meaning.

- As a rhetorical question. For example:

Now, is this blessing only for the Jews, or is it also for uncircumcised Gentiles? (NLT)

- With 4:9a as a rhetorical question and 4:9b providing the answer. For example:

Does this happiness that David spoke of belong only to those who are circumcised? No indeed! It belongs also to those who are not circumcised. (GNT)

- As a statement. For example:

This blessing is not only for the circumcised, but also for the uncircumcised.

If possible, translate 4:9a–b as a rhetorical question, because Paul answered it in 4:10–12, not here.

#### **4:9a** **Is this blessing only on the circumcised,**

- ¶ Then, the people that are blessed in this way, are they only those who are circumcised,
- ¶ God blesses people in that way, both the people who are circumcised

**the circumcised:** The word circumcised refers to cutting off the loose skin at the end of a boy's or man's penis. See how you translated this word in 2:25 or 3:30.

The word the indicates that this phrase refers to a group of people, including men, women and children, whose men and boys are circumcised. They all participate in the covenant that includes circumcision. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

the people who are circumcised

the people with their males' foreskin removed

In some languages a euphemism is adequate to explain this meaning. For example:

the people with their males' skin cut

#### **4:9b** **or also on the uncircumcised?**

- or are they also people who are not circumcised?
- and the people who are not circumcised.

**the uncircumcised:** The word uncircumcised refers to men who have not had someone cut off the loose skin at the end of their penis. See how you translated this word in 2:25 or 3:30.

The word the indicates that this phrase refers to a group of people, including the women and children, whose men are uncircumcised. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

the people who are not circumcised

the people with their males' foreskin not removed

In some languages a euphemism is adequate to explain this meaning. For example:

the people with their males' skin not cut

**4:9c–d**  
**We have been saying that Abraham's faith was credited to him as righteousness:** The BSB adds the word that to indicate indirect speech. The Greek can also be read as direct speech. For example:

We say, "Faith was counted to Abraham as righteousness"

But the Greek here differs from the words of Genesis 15:6 and its quote in Romans 4:3. So many English versions add the word that.

#### **4:9c** **We have been saying that**

- For we<sup>(incl)</sup> always say this:
- We have already said that (NCV)

4:9c begins with the Greek word that is usually translated "for." It introduces the basis for Paul saying that the blessing is also for the uncircumcised. For example:

For (GNT)

Well, (NJB)

In some languages it is more natural to imply the connection and omit this word.

**We have been saying that:** The verb have been saying here is in the present tense. This probably implies what is usually said. Paul and perhaps his readers often say that faith was counted to Abraham as righteousness (4:9d). English can use the simple present tense for that meaning, as the ESV does:

We say that (ESV)

#### 4:9d

**Abraham's faith was credited to him as righteousness.**

- God saw that Abraham believed in him and for that reason he declared him as upright.
- God accepted Abraham's faith and that faith made him right with God. (NCV)

**Abraham's faith was credited to him as righteousness:** This clause is similar to "Abraham believed God, and it was counted to him as righteousness" (4:3b-c) and "his faith is credited as righteousness" (4:5c). Translate the clause here in a similar way. For example:

Abraham's faith was counted to him as righteousness

This clause is passive. Some languages must use an active clause. For example:

God credited Abraham's faith as righteousness

## Romans 4:10

**Section 4:1-12: God considers/calls people righteous like he did with Abraham**

God called Abraham righteous because he believed what God told him (Genesis 15:1-6). In this section, Paul used that example to show that all people must believe in God for him to call them righteous. He did that for Abraham before Abraham was circumcised. So that shows that God makes people right with himself because they believe in him and not because they are circumcised.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

The Example of Abraham (GNT)

God called Abraham righteous because he believed

Abraham is/as an example of how to become righteous before God

The lesson/model of God calling Abraham righteous because he believed God

#### 4:10a

**In what context was it credited?**

- So then, how did God declare that to him?
- Now consider how God accepted Abraham's faith and called him righteous.

**In what context was it credited?:** This is a rhetorical question. Paul used this question to introduce the next question. In some languages a question is not natural here. If that is true in your language, translate it as a statement. For example:

Consider how/when it was counted to him.

Think about how/when God counted his faith as righteousness.

This verse begins with a Greek conjunction that indicates a general connection to the previous verses. The BSB leaves this word implicit. In some languages it would be natural to translate it. For example:

Then, when was it counted to him?

**was it credited:** The word it refers to Abraham's faith. Also, the phrase "as righteousness" is implied from 4:9d. In some languages it is more natural or more clear to include the implied information or explain what it means here. For example:

was his faith counted to him

was it counted to him as righteousness

was his faith counted to him as righteousness

This clause is passive. Some languages must use an active clause. For example:

did God count his faith to him

#### 4:10b

**Was it after his circumcision, or before?**

- Was he circumcised at the time, or not? (NET).

- Did God do that before someone circumcised him/ Abraham or after?

**Was it after his circumcision, or before?:** The Greek is more literally “was he in circumcision or in uncircumcision?” It asks whether he was circumcised or not at the time God counted him as righteous.

This is a rhetorical question. Paul answered it in 4:10c. The question causes the reader to think what the answer might be. You should translate it as a question, because Paul answered it in 4:10c.

**Was it after...or before:** The word it refers to the event of God counting Abraham as righteous. In some languages a word or phrase other than it must be used to clearly refer to that event. For example:

Was that event before or after

Was that deed done before or after

**his circumcision:** Here is another way to translate this phrase:

someone circumcised him

#### 4:10c

**It was not after, but before.**

- God said that to him before he was circumcised, not while he was circumcised.
- God did that before someone circumcised him/Abraham, not after!

**It was not after, but before:** These words are the answer to the question in 4:10b. The Greek is literally “not in circumcision but in uncircumcision.” It indicates that God counted Abraham righteous as an uncircumcised man. Here are other ways to translate these words:

Not when he had been circumcised, but while he was still uncircumcised (NJB)

It was not after, but before he was circumcised (ESV)

In some languages it is more natural to have the positive first. For example:

It was before, not after (GNT)

## Romans 4:11

### Section 4:1–12: God considers/calls people righteous like he did with Abraham

God called Abraham righteous because he believed what God told him (Genesis 15:1–6). In this section, Paul used that example to show that all people must believe in God for him to call them righteous. He did that for Abraham before Abraham was circumcised. So that shows that God makes people right with himself because they believe in him and not because they are circumcised.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

The Example of Abraham (GNT)

God called Abraham righteous because he believed

Abraham is/as an example of how to become righteous before God

The lesson/model of God calling Abraham righteous because he believed God

#### 4:11a–b

**And he received the sign of circumcision as a seal of the righteousness that he had by faith:** There are two ways to interpret the relationship between the word sign and the word seal:

1. The word seal further explains here what circumcision is. For example:

And he received the sign of circumcision, a seal of the righteousness that he had by faith (NIV) (BSB, NIV, NJB, NRSV, NASB, NABRE, KJV, ESV, NET, REB)

1. The word seal means the same thing as sign here. For example:

He was circumcised later, and his circumcision was a sign to show that because of his faith God had accepted him as righteous before he had been circumcised. (GNT) (RSV, GNT, CEV, NLT, NCV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1), because the word seal adds the meaning of “confirm as true.” Moo (on TW) says, “Paul uses the word to denote something that ‘confirms’ the truth or reality of something else, as in 1 Cor. 9:2.” Morris (on TW) says, “This sign is further explained as a seal.

**4:11a****And he received the sign of circumcision**

- He was given the mark/sign of circumcision,
- God gave to him the sign of circumcision.

**he received the sign of circumcision:** In English, received indicates that someone gave but the word “take” does not. In some languages there is only one word that means both “receive” and “take.” If your word would mean “take” here, translate in a way that indicates that God gave this sign. For example:

He was given the sign of circumcision

God gave the sign of circumcision to him

**sign:** This word refers to something that has a symbolic meaning. Circumcision was a sign that Abraham and his descendants had a relationship with God. Genesis 17:10–11. Here are other ways to translate this word:

mark (GW)

Abraham was marked with the sign of circumcision  
Otomi Back Translation on TW.

**4:11b****as a seal of the righteousness that he had by faith**

- which is also a seal that God had declared that he is upright because he believed
- By that sign God confirmed that he/Abraham was right with God/him when he/Abraham believed in God

**a seal of the righteousness that he had by faith:**

Here the word seal refers to a way to confirm that God had declared Abraham righteous. God told Abraham to be circumcised. That circumcision was visual evidence that God had declared Abraham righteous. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

hallmark of that righteousness which faith had given him (REB)

a guarantee that the faith which he had while still uncircumcised was reckoned to him as uprightness (NJB)

a sign which confirmed that God’s counting him as righteous was on account of his faith  
Kankanaey Back Translation on TW.

**the righteousness that he had by faith:** These words refer to Abraham believing in God and so God declared him righteous. See the examples above.

**faith:** This word refers to believing in God. In some languages, this word must be a verb. Also, in some languages, whom is believed in must be said. For example:

believing in God

**4:11c****while he was still uncircumcised.**

- at/during the time he had not been circumcised,
- before he was circumcised. (NCV)

**while he was still uncircumcised:** Here Paul made it clear that Abraham was an uncircumcised man when he believed and God declared him right in His sight.

**4:11d****So then, he is the father of all who believe but are not circumcised,**

- in order that he would become like the father of all people who believe but are not circumcised,
- And so Abraham became like the ancestor of all those who are not circumcised but who believe in God as he did,

**So then, he is:** The Greek is literally “for him to be.” It probably indicates purpose here. Here are other ways to translate these words:

In this way, Abraham was to be (NJB)

so that he would become (NET)

This purpose has become true already. In some languages a purpose clause implies that it has not yet become true. If that is true in your language, translate it as result. For example:

So Abraham is (NCV)

**the father of all:** The word father is a metaphor here. God uses Abraham as an example of an uncircumcised person who truly believed in God, and his story occurs early in the Bible. So in that way he like a father (or ancestor) to those who later believe and are not

circumcised. Abraham is not the physical ancestor of those people.

In some languages translating father literally would indicate only an actual ancestor. If that is true in your language, indicate that it has a figurative meaning. For example:

like the father of all

to be thought of as a father of all

the ancestor/leader of all Kankanaey Back Translation on TW.

we all consider Abraham as father Uma Back Translation on TW.

the spiritual father of all

#### 4:11e

**in order that righteousness might be credited to them.**

- in order that God would also declare that they are upright,
- and so God also accepts their faith and calls them righteous.

**in order that righteousness might be credited to them:** There is a textual issue in 4:11e: (1) Some Greek manuscripts have the word also (ESV, KJV, GW, NET). (2) Some Greek manuscripts do not have that word here (BSB, RSV, NIV, NJB, NASB, NLT, CEV, REB). The UBS5 includes it in brackets and indicates they had difficulty choosing. It is recommended that you follow option (1), but if an important version in your area follows option (2), you may want to follow that. Here the phrase in order that introduces the purpose of Abraham becoming the father of all believers who are not circumcised. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

so that they might be reckoned as upright (NJB)

that they too could have righteousness credited to them (NET)

However, if you translated 4:11d as a result clause, you should do the same here. For example:

and so righteousness is also counted to them

and are accepted as righteous by him (GNT)

and God declares them to be righteous also

**righteousness might be credited to them:** This clause is passive. Some languages must use an active clause. For example:

God might credit righteousness to them

## Romans 4:12

**Section 4:1–12: God considers/calls people righteous like he did with Abraham**

God called Abraham righteous because he believed what God told him (Genesis 15:1–6). In this section, Paul used that example to show that all people must believe in God for him to call them righteous. He did that for Abraham before Abraham was circumcised. So that shows that God makes people right with himself because they believe in him and not because they are circumcised.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

The Example of Abraham (GNT)

God called Abraham righteous because he believed

Abraham is/as an example of how to become righteous before God

The lesson/model of God calling Abraham righteous because he believed God

#### 4:12a–c

**the father of the circumcised who not only are circumcised, but who also walk in the footsteps of the faith:** The phrase the circumcised implies the Jews. Abraham was the ancestor of the Jews. (The word father is used to mean “ancestor” here.)

Paul limited which Jews should consider Abraham as their father regarding faith. The Jews must believe in God as Abraham did in order to truly call Abraham their father. They must not rely on circumcision to do that. Here are other ways to translate these words:

the ancestor of those of the circumcision who not only have their circumcision but who also follow



our ancestor Abraham along the path of faith... (NJB)

the father of those who are circumcised, that is, of those who, in addition to being circumcised, also live the same life of faith... (GNT)

Also Abraham became as a father to all those who have been marked with the sign of circumcision. But it wasn't just because they were marked with the sign that he became like a father to them, rather it was because they followed the faith Abraham had...Otomi Back Translation on TW.

#### 4:12a

##### **And he is also the father of the circumcised**

- and in order that he would become like the father of all the people who are circumcised,
- Also, God gave to him the sign of circumcision, so Abraham became like the ancestor of all those who are circumcised,

**And he is also:** In this verse Paul told his readers of another purpose (or result) of God giving Abraham the sign of circumcision (4:11a). In some languages it is more clear to repeat some or all of that information here. For example:

Another purpose was to make

He also received the sign of circumcision in order that he might make

**he is also:** If you translated the phrase "The purpose was to" (4:11d) as purpose, you should translate the phrase he is also as purpose as well. If you translated it as result, translate the phrase he is also as result as well. For example:

so he made

**father:** Translate this word as you did in 4:11d.

#### 4:12b

##### **who not only are circumcised,**

- who are not only circumcised,
- but not only has someone circumcised them,

**who not only are circumcised:** This clause indicates that there is something besides circumcision that is required for Abraham to be truly their father. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

who are not merely circumcised (ESV)

who, in addition to being circumcised, also... (GNT)

This clause refers to the condition of being circumcised. Some languages must use a verb for circumcision in an active clause here. For example:

whom not only has someone circumcised them

#### 4:12c

##### **but who also walk in the footsteps of the faith that our father Abraham had**

- but they also walk the same path of faith that our<sup>(incl)</sup> father/ancestor Abraham did,
- but they also believe in God like our ancestor Abraham did

**but who also walk in the footsteps of the faith:** The phrase walk in the footsteps is a figurative way of saying "to act in the same way as someone." For the Jews to truly be true descendants of Abraham, they needed to have the same faith as Abraham. Here are some ways to translate this clause:

- If the figure of speech has the correct meaning in your language, you may want to translate it that way. For example:

also are following in the footsteps of his faith (GW)

- Use a figure of speech that has the correct meaning in your language. For example:

who also follow our ancestor Abraham along the path of faith (NJB)

- Translate the meaning. For example:

who...also live the same life of faith (GNT)

if they have the same kind of faith (NLT)

#### 4:12d

##### **before he was circumcised.**

- even before he was circumcised.
- before someone circumcised him.

**he was circumcised:** This clause is passive. Translate it as you translated the similar phrase in 4:10b.

## Romans 4:13

### Section 4:13–25: God considers/calls people righteous who believe in Jesus

In this section, Paul showed that God's promise of blessing to Abraham and his descendants was made because Abraham believed God. God did not promise blessing because Abraham obeyed the law of Moses. Paul then described how Abraham believed and why God called him righteous. Paul then explained that God also calls the people who believe in God (and his Messiah, Jesus) righteous.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

God counts people as righteous through faith, not through the Law Of Moses

God also called us<sup>(incl)</sup> righteous because we believe

The lesson/model of God calling Abraham righteous applies to us/believers

#### 4:13a

**For the promise to Abraham and his offspring that he would be heir of the world was not given through the law,**

- ¶ For it is not through the law of Moses that God promised Abraham that he and his descendants would inherit/own the world,
- ¶ Long ago God promised Abraham that the world would belong to him and his descendants. But he certainly did not promise that in the laws of Moses.

**For:** This word introduces an explanation of some things Paul said in 4:11–12.

**the promise to Abraham and his offspring that he would be heir of the world was not given through the law:** The Greek begins with “not through the law.” This emphasizes that phrase. Consider how to indicate that contrast in your language. For example:

It was not through the law that Abraham and his offspring received the promise that he would be heir of the world (NIV11)

the promise to Abraham and his offspring that he would be heir of the world certainly did not come through the law

**offspring:** The Greek word here is “seed.” Here it refers to descendants. It implies the same people to whom he is called “father” in 4:12a (“of the circumcised,” that is, the Jews). For example:

descendants (RSV)

**heir of the world:** Here the word heir refers to someone whom another person gives him something as promised. The clause “that he would be heir of the world” is the content of God's promise. It is not a direct quotation of any promise by God in Genesis, but an interpretation of those promises which speak of “all families of the earth” (12:3) and “all the nations of the earth” (18:18 and 22:18). The Septuagint, a Greek translation of the Old Testament that was done before Jesus was born, uses the word “inherit” in 22:17. It does not imply here that someone received something because someone died. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

he would inherit the world (NET)

the world would belong to him (GNT)

**the law:** The word law probably refers to the Law of Moses. For example:

God's law (NLT)

the Law that God gave to Moses

#### 4:13b

**but through the righteousness that comes by faith.**

- but through being upright that is based in believing/faith.
- No, instead, God promised that because he accepted Abraham's faith and that faith made him right with God.

**the righteousness that comes by faith:** Here this phrase indicates that Abraham's faith is the way in which he became righteous. If that is true in your language, translate the correct meaning. For example:

he believed and was accepted as righteous by God (GNT)

the righteousness which had its root in faith (JBP)

God's approval of his faith (GW)

## Romans 4:14

### Section 4:13–25: God considers/calls people righteous who believe in Jesus

In this section, Paul showed that God's promise of blessing to Abraham and his descendants was made because Abraham believed God. God did not promise blessing because Abraham obeyed the law of Moses. Paul then described how Abraham believed and why God called him righteous. Paul then explained that God also calls the people who believe in God (and his Messiah, Jesus) righteous.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

God counts people as righteous through faith, not through the Law Of Moses

God also called us<sup>(incl)</sup> righteous because we believe

The lesson/model of God calling Abraham righteous applies to us/believers

### 4:14a–c

**For if those who live by the law are heirs, faith is useless and the promise is worthless:** Here the word if introduces a situation that was not true. Adhering to the law only does not make someone an heir of this promise. But the "then" clauses (faith is useless...) imagines what might have happened if the adherents of the law had been heirs. Translate this if-clause with that meaning. For example:

if, for example, those who live by the law are heirs

if it were true that it is those who live by the law are heirs

See the grammar you used for this kind of if-then construction in 4:2 ("if Abraham was justified by works, he has something to boast about...").

### 4:14a

**For if those who live by the law are heirs,**

- For if the people who have the law of Moses had inherited/owned the world,
- For if it were true that God had said, "I promise to give the world to those who possess my laws,"

**For:** This word introduces an explanation of the connection of the promise to faith and not the law.

**those who live by the law:** The Greek is more literally "the (ones) of (the) law." The word by indicates that these people are connected to the law of Moses. It refers to the Jews. They possess this law and live under its rule. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

those who are of the Law (NASB)

people who have/possess the law of Moses

**heirs:** Translate this word as you did in 4:13a, but as a plural.

### 4:14b

**faith is useless**

- then it/that would have made faith empty/useless,
- then that promise would have caused believing in God to have no power

**faith is useless:** The Greek word that the BSB translates as is useless means "has been made empty" or "has removed the power of it." If getting the inheritance is based on keeping the Law of Moses, that makes Abraham's faith useless in regards to getting that inheritance. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

it/that has made that faith empty

that has caused Abraham's believing God to be powerless/ineffective

his faith has borne no fruit

### 4:14c

**and the promise is worthless,**

- and it/that would have made the true promise void.
- and the promise that God did make to be invalid/nothing.

**the promise is worthless:** The Greek word that the BSB translates as is worthless means "has been made ineffective or powerless." If getting the inheritance is based on keeping the Law of Moses, that would have made the promise to Abraham invalid. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

it/that has made the promise invalid

that has caused the promise to be powerless/  
ineffective

The Greek word here is similar in meaning to “is useless” in 4:14b. In some languages the same word or phrase would be used in both places for the correct meaning.

**the promise:** The word promise here refers to what God actually promised to Abraham and his offspring, that Abraham would be heir of the world (4:13a). Make sure that is clear in your translation. For example:

that promise

the promise that God actually made

## Romans 4:15

### Section 4:13–25: God considers/calls people righteous who believe in Jesus

In this section, Paul showed that God’s promise of blessing to Abraham and his descendants was made because Abraham believed God. God did not promise blessing because Abraham obeyed the law of Moses. Paul then described how Abraham believed and why God called him righteous. Paul then explained that God also calls the people who believe in God (and his Messiah, Jesus) righteous.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

God counts people as righteous through faith, not through the Law Of Moses

God also called us<sup>(incl)</sup> righteous because we believe

The lesson/model of God calling Abraham righteous applies to us/believers

#### 4:15a

#### because the law brings wrath.

- For the law of Moses causes anger
- For the law makes God angry with people because they always break it.

**because:** The word because here introduces an explanation for what Paul said in 4:14a–c. Translate that meaning in a way that is natural in your language.

**the law brings wrath:** This clause implies that people cannot obey all the law of Moses all the time. When they break the law, God becomes angry.

In some languages translating literally would not have the correct meaning. If that is true in your language, you may want to:

- Translate literally and explain its meaning in a footnote. Here is an example footnote:

This clause implies that people cannot obey all the law of Moses all the time, and so God becomes angry at people when they break the law.

- Include some or all of the implied information in your translation. For example:

the law can only bring God’s anger (NCV)

God becomes angry when his Law is broken (CEV)

It is God’s anger that we get from his Law because we break it

the Law is the reason God is angry with us because we cannot obey it  
Western Bukidnon Manobo Back Translation on TW.

**the law:** The word law here refers to the law of Moses, as in 4:13–14. See how you translated it there.

**wrath:** The word wrath refers to violent anger. It implies punishment for breaking the law.

#### 4:15b

#### And where there is no law, there is no transgression.

- but where/if no law exists, then no lawbreaking exists.
- But/And people can only break a law that exists.

**And:** There is a textual issue in 4:15b: (1) Some Greek manuscripts have the word often translated as and or but (BSB, RSV, NIV, NJB, NASB, NLT, GW, CEV, NABRE, REB, ESV). (2) Some Greek manuscripts have the word for (KJV, NET). It is recommended that you follow option (1), because the UBS5 supports it. The Greek begins with a word that the BSB and many English versions literally translate as And. Many languages would see contrast between 4:15a and 4:15b. Translate it in a way that is most natural to connect 4:15b to 4:15a.

#### where there is no law, there is no transgression:

This probably refers to the time before God gave the law to Moses. Alford, page 351. Abraham could not break the law of Moses, because God gave it to Moses

hundreds of years after Abraham died. So God could not be angry with Abraham (4:15a) when he did things that would have broken the laws of Moses. Abraham would still be guilty if he did something hurtful to God or people. Here are other ways to translate these words:

where there is no law, there is no disobeying of the law (GNT)

where laws don't exist, they can't be broken (GW)

if there is no law, it cannot be disobeyed

The only (situation) in which no-one would be breaking laws is if there were no laws Tagbanwa Back Translation on TW.

In some languages it is more natural or clear to state this without using no twice. For example:

a person can only break a law that has already been put in place

**where:** Here this word refers to locations where "there is no law." It is not used to signal a question. Translate this word in a way that does not signal a question. See examples above.

**transgression:** The Greek word that the BSB translates as transgression means "to disobey a law or custom." Here it refers to knowingly disobeying or breaking a law. See examples above.

## Romans 4:16

### Section 4:13–25: God considers/calls people righteous who believe in Jesus

In this section, Paul showed that God's promise of blessing to Abraham and his descendants was made because Abraham believed God. God did not promise blessing because Abraham obeyed the law of Moses. Paul then described how Abraham believed and why God called him righteous. Paul then explained that God also calls the people who believe in God (and his Messiah, Jesus) righteous.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

God counts people as righteous through faith, not through the Law Of Moses

God also called us<sup>(incl)</sup> righteous because we believe

The lesson/model of God calling Abraham righteous applies to us/believers

### 4:16a

#### Therefore, the promise comes by faith,

- ¶ Therefore the promise requires believing/faith in God,
- ¶ And so he/God gave the promise to the people who believe in him,

**Therefore:** This word introduces a conclusion about what Paul wrote in 4:13–15. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

And so (GNT)

For this reason (NET)

**the promise comes by faith:** The Greek is more literally "of faith." There is an implied subject and verb. In English the implied subject is translated the promise and refers to God's promise, as in 4:13a. The topic of 4:13–14 is the promise. 4:14c refers to the promise and 4:15 is an aside about the law. About "(it is) of faith" in 4:16a, Nicoll (page 619) says, "the subject is the promise, considered in reference to the mode of its fulfillment." Moo (on TW) calls it "the promised inheritance." The promise was given to Abraham because of his faith. Here are some other ways to translate this:

people receive God's promise by having faith (NCV)

the promise is received by faith (NLT)

**the promise:** The word promise refers back to the same promise of 4:13–14. In some languages it is more clear to refer back to it. For example:

that promise

### 4:16b

#### so that it may rest on grace

- so that the promise is according to his/God's grace/kindness,
- so that God's promise was given because he is kind,

**so that it may rest on grace:** Faith was the basis for God making the promise to Abraham. The purpose was so that he might give it according to grace. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

so that the promise may rest on grace (ESV)

and the purpose is that the promise may rest on grace

This purpose has become true already. In some languages it must be translated as result for the correct meaning. For example:

so that the promise rests on grace

**may rest on grace:** The Greek is literally “(it may be) according to grace.” God promised to give Abraham and his descendants the world because he wanted to, not because he needed to. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

it will be based on his graceKankanaey Back Translation on TW.

it would be clear that his grace...is the origin, not their own deedsTagbanwa Back Translation on TW.

this might be possible by means of his kindness-Western Bukidnon Manobo Back Translation on TW.

It is given as a free gift (NLT)

it can be a gift (GW)

**grace:** Here the word grace indicates that God did something kind. He wants to help people. People do not deserve this help. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

as a free gift (NLT)

his great kindness (CEV)

#### 4:16c

**and may be guaranteed to all Abraham’s offspring—**

- and so that it is certain for all of his children/ descendants.
- and that God will certainly give it to all of his/ Abraham’s descendants.

**and:** Here the word and indicates that 4:16c expresses a second purpose (after the first one in 4:16b). In some languages it is more clear to introduce the clause again. For example:

and in order that it

**guaranteed:** The Greek word that the BSB translates as guaranteed means “valid, sure, legally secure.” God will certainly give the world to Abraham and those who have faith like his. Here are other ways to translate this word:

secure (NJB)

certain (NLT)

assured (CEV)

#### 4:16d–e

**not only to those who are of the law, but also to those who are of the faith of Abraham:** Paul had two groups of Abraham’s spiritual children in mind, those who are of the law (Jewish believers) and those who are of the faith of Abraham (non-Jewish believers).

The phrases not only and but also emphasizes the second group. Some Jews thought that a person had to become a Jew first (by following the Law of Moses) for God to accept him or her. But Paul emphasized here that God accepts everyone who has the same faith as Abraham, even if they do not follow the law of Moses. Consider how to translate that emphasis.

#### 4:16d

**not only to those who are of the law,**

- It is promised not only to the person who has the law of Moses and believes
- God will certainly fulfill it for not only those who possess the laws of Moses and believe in him

**those who are of the law:** The Greek is literally “the (one) of the law.” It is similar to “those who live by the law” in 4:14a. The word of indicates that this person is connected to the law of Moses. It refers to the Jews. Translate it in a similar way to the phrase in 4:14a.

This phrase refers generally to Jews. The singular emphasizes that this statement is true for each person.

In some languages it is more natural to use the plural in a general reference. For example:

to the adherent of the law (ESV)

people who have/possess the laws of Moses

The context implies that these people also believe in God. In some languages a literal translation would wrongly imply they do not believe. If that is true in your language, add the implied information. For example:

the adherent of the law who believes

someone who has the law of Moses and believes in God

#### 4:16e

**but also to those who are of the faith of Abraham.**

- but also to the person who has the same faith as Abraham,
- but also to those who believe in God as Abraham did.

**those who are of the faith of Abraham:** This phrase refers to those who believe in God as Abraham did. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

anyone who lives with faith like that of Abraham (NCV)

all who are Abraham's descendants because they have faith, just as he did (CEV)

#### 4:16f

**He is the father of us all.**

- who is like the father of all of us<sup>(incl)</sup>,
- He/Abraham is like a father to all of us in/regarding believing in God.

**He is the father of us all:** This clause tells the reader more about Abraham. In some languages a literal translation would not have the correct meaning. If that is true in your language, consider how to translate the correct meaning. One way to do that is to start a new sentence here, as the BSB does.

**the father of us all:** The word father is a figure of speech here, similar to its use in 4:11–12. God chose to bless the world through Abraham. That choice was based upon Abraham's faith in God. In that way he became the father (or ancestor) for all those who later

believe, because he was the first one to do so. So the meaning of father here is broader than just in terms of a father to child kind of descent.

In some languages translating father literally would imply a literal ancestor. If that is true in your language, indicate that it has a figurative meaning. For example:

like the father of us all

whom God made to be thought of as the father of us all

as-if the ancestor of us all Kankanaey Back Translation on TW.

whom we consider as father of us all in faith

the spiritual father of us all (GNT)

### Romans 4:17

#### Section 4:13–25: God considers/calls people righteous who believe in Jesus

In this section, Paul showed that God's promise of blessing to Abraham and his descendants was made because Abraham believed God. God did not promise blessing because Abraham obeyed the law of Moses. Paul then described how Abraham believed and why God called him righteous. Paul then explained that God also calls the people who believe in God (and his Messiah, Jesus) righteous.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

God counts people as righteous through faith, not through the Law Of Moses

God also called us<sup>(incl)</sup> righteous because we believe

The lesson/model of God calling Abraham righteous applies to us/believers

#### 4:17a

##### As it is written:

- as someone wrote in Scriptures when God said,
- That is like what is written in God's Word. Long ago God said to him/Abraham,

**As it is written:** This phrase introduces a quote from the Old Testament. Paul quoted what God said to

Abraham (Genesis 17:5). You may want to include some or all of this implied information. For example:

As it is written in God's Word

as Scripture says (GW)

It is like what the Scriptures say when God told him

See how you translated this phrase in 1:17 or 3:4.

#### 4:17b-c

**"I have made you a father of many nations." He is our father in the presence of God, in whom he believed:** There are several ways to interpret the connection of in the presence of God, in whom he believed to the rest of the Greek text:

1. It connects to Abraham being the father of us all (4:16f). For example:

"I have made you the father of many nations"). He is our father in the presence of God whom he believed (NET) (BSB, NIV, NJB, NET, NASB, KJV, NABRE)

1. It connects to the faith of Abraham (4:16e). For example:

the faith of Abraham (for he is the father of all of us, <sup>17</sup>as it is written, "I have made you the father of many nations")—in the presence of the God in whom he believed (NRSV) (NRSV, REB, GW)

1. It connects to the promise to Abraham (4:16a). For example:

"I have made you father of many nations." So the promise is good in the sight of God, in whom Abraham believed (GNT) (RSV, GNT, ESV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1), because that is the closest connection and seems the most natural. Moo, Longenecker, and Cranfield support interpretation (1).

**I have made you a father of many nations:** These words are a quote found in Genesis 17:5. If you indicate the location of quotes from the Old Testament with cross-references, you may want to do so here.

#### 4:17b

**"I have made you a father of many nations."**

- "I have made you<sup>(sing)</sup> a father of many people-groups"
- "I have made you father of many culture/language groups."

**I have made you a father of many nations:** This quote is from Genesis 17:5. In Abraham's story in the book of Genesis, God caused Abraham to have many descendants. Many of them became the founders of new nations.

I have appointed you to be father of many nations (REB)

I will make you the ancestor of many kinds of people  
Western Bukidnon Manobo Back Translation on TW.

You should translate this clause with its meaning in Genesis 17:5. You should not explicitly translate Paul's figurative use of father (4:11-16) here.

**a father:** The Greek refers generally to being a father or ancestor. But it does not imply one of many "fathers." Consider how to translate that meaning. For example:

the father (ESV)

father (GNT)

the ancestor (CEV)

**nations:** Here the word nations refers to people grouped by language and culture. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

people-groups

language-groups

#### 4:17c

**He is our father in the presence of God, in whom he believed,**

- before him, in whom he/Abraham believed.
- He is our father in the sight of God. Indeed, he believed in him.

**in the presence of God:** This phrase probably connects to "the father of many nations" (4:17b). It indicates that God considered Abraham to be the father



of many nations. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

This is true before God (NCV)

in the sight/eyes of God

It is also possible that this phrase connects to “the father of us all” in 4:16f. Some commentators take the quote from Scripture in 4:17a–b as a separate comment on “the father of us all” in 4:16f. Therefore 4:17c further describes Abraham as “the father of us all.” For example:

He is our father in the sight of God (NIV)

Abraham is our father in the eyes of God (NJB)

**in whom he believed:** This clause tells the reader more about God. It does not separate God from other gods. For the correct meaning in some languages, translators must avoid the word whom. For example:

Abraham believed in him.

#### 4:17d

##### the God who gives life to the dead

- He makes dead people live again
- He causes dead people to live again

**the God who gives life to the dead:** This clause tells the reader more about God. It does not separate God from other gods. For the correct meaning in some languages, translators must avoid the word who. For example:

He gives life to the dead.

**gives life to the dead:** God has power to make people live again after they die. Here are other ways to translate these words:

raises the dead to life (CEV)

brings the dead back to life (NLT)

#### 4:17e

##### and calls into being what does not yet exist.

- and commands things that do not yet exist so that they exist.

- and speaks so that things that did not exist before now exist.

**and calls:** The word “who” is implied from 4:17d. God calls here.

**calls into being what does not yet exist:** The Greek is literally “calling the things not being as being.” There are two ways to interpret the Greek here:

1. It indicates that God speaks and things that did not exist now exist. For example:

who creates new things out of nothing (NLT) (BSB, RSV, NIV11, GNT, NJB, ESV, REB, GW, NASB, NLT, CEV, NCV)

1. It indicates that God refers to things as existing that do not yet exist. For example, when God promised Abraham in Genesis 17:5 that he would be the father of many nations, those nations did not yet exist. For example:

calls things that are not as though they were (NIV84) (NIV84, KJV)

It is recommended that you follow (1) because both Greek words “gives life” (4:17d) and calls probably refer generally to any time God chooses to do those things. Morris (on TW) says, “Calls is linked with gives life under the one article; God is the one who both gives life and calls. Both activities are characteristic of him.” Here the word calls does not refer only to calling Abraham the father of many nations. If it only referred to calling Abraham the father of many nations, Paul probably would have used the aorist tense rather than the (general/gnomic) present tense. Barrett (page 97) says, “he is the Creator, and faith means reliance upon his creative power.” Here are other ways to translate this according to interpretation (1):

calls into being things that were not (NIV11)

whose command brings into being what did not exist (GNT)

those things that do not exist that God wants to exist, he says “may they exist” and they exist

**what does not yet exist:** Here the word what refers to all that God created, including the nations. Consider how to translate with that meaning.

## Romans 4:18

### Section 4:13–25: God considers/calls people righteous who believe in Jesus

In this section, Paul showed that God's promise of blessing to Abraham and his descendants was made because Abraham believed God. God did not promise blessing because Abraham obeyed the law of Moses. Paul then described how Abraham believed and why God called him righteous. Paul then explained that God also calls the people who believe in God (and his Messiah, Jesus) righteous.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

God counts people as righteous through faith, not through the Law Of Moses

God also called us<sup>(incl)</sup> righteous because we believe

The lesson/model of God calling Abraham righteous applies to us/believers

#### 4:18a

#### Against all hope, Abraham in hope believed

- ¶ With hope in God but without hope in himself he believed.
- ¶ He had no hope in his own ability/power but believed with hope in God's ability/power,

**Against all hope, Abraham in hope believed:** The Greek is literally "who contrary to hope on/in hope believed." It implies that Abraham had no hope for a child from any human or natural power, but hoped/expected God to fulfill his promise to enable he and Sarah to have a child of their own. And he believed that God would do that.

In some languages that implied information will be clear. But in many languages it will not. If that is true in your language, you may want to:

- Make some or all of the implied information explicit. For example:

In hope he believed beyond human hope

Without hope in himself he believed with hope in God

He had no hope in his own ability to fulfill the promise but believed with hope in God's ability to fulfill it

- Translate the literal meaning and explain it in a footnote. For example:

This clause implies that Abraham had no hope for a child from any human or natural power, but hoped/expected God to fulfill his promise to enable he and Sarah to have a child of their own. And he believed that God would do that.

**hope:** This word refers to wanting something to happen or even confident expectation that something will happen. The hope in the phrase "in hope" refers to Abraham confidently expecting God to fulfill his promise. The hope in the phrase "against hope" refers to Abraham wanting children very much but after so many years of not being able to have children, he did not expect to suddenly begin by their own power. Consider how to translate this word in both places here.

#### 4:18b

#### and so became the father of many nations,

- Consequently, he did become like the father/ancestor of many people-groups,
- and so God made him the father of many culture/language groups.

**and so became the father of many nations:** The phrase and so introduces a consequence or result of Abraham believing in God's promise to him. Moo (on TW) and Morris (on TW). It could also introduce God's purpose based on Abraham's faith. Nicoll (page 620) and Hodge (page 197). It probably does not introduce what Abraham believed. Alford (page 353) says, "To... connect it with (believe)...is against Paul's usage, who never connects (it) with a neuter infinitive,—and not justified by Phil. 1.23 (or) 1 Thes. 3.10." Here are other ways to translate this clause:

As a result, he became a father of many nations (GW)

and he became the parent of many-nations/tribes Yakan Back Translation on TW.

and so God caused him to become the father of many nations

#### 4:18c

#### just as he had been told,

- just as it had been said to him, (NIV)
- It happened as what God had said to him when he said this:

**just as he had been told:** This clause is passive. Some languages must use an active clause here. For example:

God had told him

#### 4:18d

#### “So shall your offspring be.”

- “Likewise, your<sup>(sing)</sup> children/descendants will be many.”
- “Your descendants will be like that.”

**“So shall your offspring be”:** Paul did not quote the first part of what God said to Abraham in Genesis 15:5: “Look toward heaven, and number the stars, if you are able to number them.” Together with the clause So shall your offspring be, God promised Abraham that he would have many descendants. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

So numerous shall your descendants be (NRSV)

The number of your descendants will be like that number

Paul expected his readers to understand that the clause here refers to that promise. In some languages readers will not clearly understand that the clause here refers to that promise. If that is true in your language, you may want to translate the literal meaning of the clause and explain it in a footnote. Here is an example footnote:

This saying refers to Genesis 15:5 where God promised Abraham that his descendants would be as numerous as the stars.

**So:** The Greek word that the BSB translates as So means “in this way” or “like that.” It does not mean “therefore” here. Consider how to translate that meaning in your language.

**offspring:** Here the word offspring refers to descendants.

#### General Comment on 4:18d

These words are a quote of part of Genesis 15:5. If you indicate the location of quotes from the Old Tes-

tament with cross-references, you may want to do so here.

## Romans 4:19

### Section 4:13–25: God considers/calls people righteous who believe in Jesus

In this section, Paul showed that God’s promise of blessing to Abraham and his descendants was made because Abraham believed God. God did not promise blessing because Abraham obeyed the law of Moses. Paul then described how Abraham believed and why God called him righteous. Paul then explained that God also calls the people who believe in God (and his Messiah, Jesus) righteous.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

God counts people as righteous through faith, not through the Law Of Moses

God also called us<sup>(incl)</sup> righteous because we believe

The lesson/model of God calling Abraham righteous applies to us/believers

#### 4:19a

#### Without weakening in his faith,

- His believing did not weaken/fall
- He/Abraham stayed strong/well in his faith,

**Without weakening in his faith:** This clause indicates that Abraham continued believing in God well. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

his faith did not decreaseUma Back Translation on TW.

Abraham did not stop believingOtomi Back Translation on TW.

his faith was still strongWestern Bukidnon Manobo Back Translation on TW.

his believing in God did not fall/move

**his:** This word refers to Abraham here. In some languages 4:18d might imply that his here refers to God. If that is true in your language, use the name here. For example:

Abraham's

#### 4:19b

##### he acknowledged the decrepitness of his body

- when he thought about his own body and knew it was like a dead body regarding fathering children
- even though he knew that his body was too old for having children

In this verse part, Paul speaks of Abraham's body as if it were dead. The BSB translates the meaning of this metaphor with the phrase "the decrepitness of his body." In order to comment directly on the metaphor, the notes use the ESV in this verse part.

**(ESV:) when he considered his own body:** There is a textual issue in 4:19b: (1) Some Greek manuscripts have the word considered (BSB, RSV, NIV, GNT, NJB, NASB, NLT, GW, CEV, NET, NABRE, REB, ESV, NCV). (2) Some Greek manuscripts have the words considered not (KJV only). It is recommended that you follow option (1). The word considered means "thought about." For example:

he contemplated his own body (NASB)

when he thought of his body (GNT)

**(ESV:) which was as good as dead:** There is a textual issue here:

1. The Greek is having been dead. For example:

as good as dead (NIV) (RSV, NIV, NJB, ESV, NABRE, NLT, CEV, NET, REB, NCV)

1. The Greek is already having been dead. For example:

which was already as good as dead (NRSV) (GNT, NRSV, NASB, GW, KJV)

It is recommended that you follow option (1), because it is harder to find a reason for a copyist to omit it if it was originally there than finding a reason for a copyist to add it. The UBS GNT includes it but indicates the Committee had difficulty deciding. Morris (on TW) says, "The committee was divided and in the end put the word in square brackets. Not much hangs on this question, but it does seem as though the word is not original, and it is not read in most modern translations."

**(ESV:) which:** This word introduces how Paul described Abraham's body. In some languages a different

word or phrase must be used for the correct meaning. This also may require a new sentence. For example:

It was as good as dead

**(ESV:) was as good as dead:** The Greek is more literally "having been dead." It is a figure of speech here. It indicates that Abraham was too old to produce child. Here are other ways to translate these words:

as dead (NET)

it was no longer possible for him to have any children  
Western Bukidnon Manobo Back Translation on TW.

which was too old to father a child

much past the age for having children (NCV)

#### 4:19c

##### (since he was about a hundred years old)

- because he was about one hundred years old at that time,

**(since he was about a hundred years old):** This clause is background information: additional information that is not a main part of what Paul was talking about. So the BSB and some other English versions put this clause in parentheses to indicate that. It explains "good as dead" in 4:19b. Here are other ways to punctuate this clause:

—since he was about a hundred years old— (NIV)

because he was about a hundred years old, (RSV)

In some languages, it is more natural to begin a sentence with background information. See General Comment at 4:19d.

**he was about a hundred years old:** This phrase refers to how many years Abraham had lived about the time that Sarah became pregnant. Genesis 17:1–4, 16–19; 21:1–2. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

Abraham's age was close to a hundred years  
Uma Back Translation on TW.

his years were about 100Yongkom Back Translation (unpublished manuscript).

#### **4:19d and the lifelessness of Sarah's womb.**

- or when he thought about Sarah's womb and knew it was also like/as dead regarding bearing children
- He also knew that his wife Sarah had not been able to bear a child.

**the lifelessness of Sarah's womb:** The Greek word which the BSB translates as lifelessness is literally "deadness." Here it implies "unable to have children." Paul used this word instead of the usual Greek word for lifelessness to connect it to "as good as dead" in 4:19b.

In some languages a literal translation would have the correct meaning. For example:

the deadness of Sarah's womb (NASB)

that Sarah's womb was dead (NJB)

his body was as good as dead—and so was Sarah's womb (NLT)

But in some languages a literal translation would not have the correct meaning. If that is true in your language, translate the correct meaning. For example:

Sarah was unable to have children (GW)

Sara his wife was barrenKankanaey Back Translation on TW.

she could not give birthYakan Back Translation on TW.

**Sarah's womb:** This phrase refers to the place where a baby lives and grows before the mother gives birth. Some languages have a polite way to refer to this place. For example:

Sarah's tummy/stomach

Also see the examples above.

**Sarah's:** Sarah was Abraham's wife. In some languages people would not know that. If that is true in your language, you may want to explain that here. For example:

his wife Sarah's

#### **General Comment on 4:19a–d**

4:19b–d is background information to 4:19a. In some languages it is more natural to have the background information first. For example:

<sup>19b</sup>When he acknowledged his own body, which was as good as dead <sup>19c</sup>(since he was about a hundred years old), <sup>19d</sup>or when he acknowledged the lifelessness of Sarah's womb, <sup>19a</sup>he did not weaken in faith.

<sup>19b</sup>He acknowledged his own body as good as dead <sup>19c</sup>because he was about a hundred years old, <sup>19d</sup>and acknowledged Sarah's womb also as good as dead, <sup>19a</sup>but he did not weaken in faith.

#### **General Comment on 4:18a–19d**

People of some language groups are not familiar with the story of Abraham, and so the purpose of 4:18 may not be clear until reading 4:19. If that is true of people in your language, you may want to have the words of 4:19 first. For example:

<sup>19b</sup>When he acknowledged his own body, which was as good as dead <sup>19c</sup>(since he was about a hundred years old), <sup>19d</sup>or when he acknowledged the barrenness of Sarah's womb, <sup>19a</sup>he did not weaken in faith. <sup>18a</sup>In hope he believed against hope, <sup>18b</sup>that he should become the father of many nations, <sup>18c</sup>as he had been told, <sup>18d</sup>“So shall your offspring be.”

You will then need to mark these two verses as <sup>18–19</sup>.

## **Romans 4:20**

### **Section 4:13–25: God considers/calls people righteous who believe in Jesus**

In this section, Paul showed that God's promise of blessing to Abraham and his descendants was made because Abraham believed God. God did not promise blessing because Abraham obeyed the law of Moses. Paul then described how Abraham believed and why God called him righteous. Paul then explained that God also calls the people who believe in God (and his Messiah, Jesus) righteous.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

God counts people as righteous through faith, not through the Law Of Moses

God also called us<sup>(incl)</sup> righteous because we believe

The lesson/model of God calling Abraham righteous applies to us/believers

#### 4:20a–c

In this verse, Paul spoke more about Abraham's faith in relation to the promise that God told him.

#### 4:20a

**Yet he did not waver through disbelief in the promise of God,**

- But/Yet, he did not doubt God's promise in unbelief
- He also did not fall down in believing and so doubt the promise of God,

**Yet:** This Greek word indicates contrast. Some languages would naturally want to indicate contrast here to "Without weakening in his faith" (4:19a). But in some languages 4:20a does not contrast to 4:19a. Consider what is most natural in your language.

**he did not waver through disbelief in the promise of God:** The Greek is literally "toward the promise of God he did not waver/doubt in/by unbelief." Abraham lived believing God and what he said. So he was not uncertain about God's promise. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

he did not waver through unbelief regarding the promise of God (NIV)

He didn't doubt God's promise out of a lack of faith (GW)

He never doubted that God would keep his promise (NCV)

He was fully convinced that God is able to do whatever he promises (NLT)

He continued to believe that finally God's promise to him would be fulfilled. Abraham did not doubt Yakan Back Translation on TW, with Abraham's name spelled the English way.

#### 4:20b

**but was strengthened in his faith**

- but/and became stronger in his believing.
- but/and God made his/Abraham's faith bigger/stronger,

**but:** The word but here indicates a contrast. However, in some languages there is no contrast between "he did not waver" (4:20a) and "was strengthened in his faith" here. For example:

andUma Back Translation on TW.

**was strengthened in his faith:** This clause indicates that Abraham's faith in God increased. He believed in God more and more. The Greek is passive, indicating that God strengthened Abraham's faith. Morris (on TW) says, "Paul is not saying that faith, so to speak, took a weak Abraham and put strength into him. He is saying that God took a weak Abraham and put strength into him. Abraham was made strong because of his faith indeed, but it was God, not faith, that provided the strength." But Moo (on TW) says, "The translation 'grew strong' is preferable to treating it as a genuine passive." Schreiner (page 238) also says he prefers, "he became strong in faith." Here are other ways to translate this clause:

he became stronger in his faith

his faith/believing strengthened

God strengthened his/Abraham's faith

In some languages the word faith cannot be used with strengthened. If that is true in your language, consider how to translate the meaning. For example:

he believed in God in more and more ways

his faith matured

his faith continued to be great

#### 4:20c

**and gave glory to God,**

- At the same time he glorified God.
- and he/Abraham honored and praised God.

**and:** The word and indicates that Abraham gave glory to God at the same time that his faith grew strong (4:20b). Another way to translate this word is:

at-the-same-timeKankanaey Back Translation on TW.

**gave glory to God:** This clause indicates that Abraham honored and praised God. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

he also was praising GodKankanaey Back Translation on TW.

he honored and praised God

## Romans 4:21

### Section 4:13–25: God considers/calls people righteous who believe in Jesus

In this section, Paul showed that God's promise of blessing to Abraham and his descendants was made because Abraham believed God. God did not promise blessing because Abraham obeyed the law of Moses. Paul then described how Abraham believed and why God called him righteous. Paul then explained that God also calls the people who believe in God (and his Messiah, Jesus) righteous.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

God counts people as righteous through faith, not through the Law Of Moses

God also called us<sup>(incl)</sup> righteous because we believe

The lesson/model of God calling Abraham righteous applies to us/believers

## 4:21

### being fully persuaded that God was able to do what He had promised.

- He also was completely sure that God is able to do as he promised.
- Furthermore, he was certain about this: When God promises that he will do something, he will certainly do it.

In the Greek the clause in 4:21 connects to “was strengthened in his faith” (4:20b) in a similar way that 4:20c does. Consider how to connect it in your translation. For example:

He also was fully convinced...

Furthermore, he was fully convinced

and as he was fully convinced...

**being fully persuaded:** This phrase means “completely sure about something.” Abraham was completely sure that God would do what he promised. For example:

was absolutely sure (GNT)

was certain (CEV)

**God was able to do what He had promised:** The Greek is literally “what he promised he is also able to do.” The pronoun “he” refers to God here. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

what God had promised, He was able also to perform (NASB)

God was able to do what he had promised (NCV)

God could do what he had promised (CEV)

The Greek present tense indicates that God was able to do what he promised then and he is able to do what he promised now and will be able to do what he promised in the future.

## Romans 4:22

### Section 4:13–25: God considers/calls people righteous who believe in Jesus

In this section, Paul showed that God's promise of blessing to Abraham and his descendants was made because Abraham believed God. God did not promise blessing because Abraham obeyed the law of Moses. Paul then described how Abraham believed and why God called him righteous. Paul then explained that God also calls the people who believe in God (and his Messiah, Jesus) righteous.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

God counts people as righteous through faith, not through the Law Of Moses

God also called us<sup>(incl)</sup> righteous because we believe

The lesson/model of God calling Abraham righteous applies to us/believers

**4:22**

**This is why “it was credited to him as righteousness.”**

- So “by that believing God reckoned/counted him as upright.”
- For that reason, as God’s Book says, “Abraham believed God’s promise to him, and so God called him a righteous man.”

**This is why:** There is a textual issue in 4:22: (1) Some Greek manuscripts have the word therefore (BSB, RSV, NIV, GNT, NJB, NASB, GW, CEV, NABRE, ESV, NCV). (2) Some Greek manuscripts have the words therefore also (NLT, KJV, REB). It is recommended that you follow option (1). This phrase indicates that the description of Abraham’s faith (4:18–21) shows why God reckoned his faith as righteousness. For example:

Therefore (NRSV)

**“it was credited to him as righteousness”:** The Greek is literally “(it) was counted to him as righteousness.” See how you translated this clause in 4:3c.

**Romans 4:23**

**Section 4:13–25: God considers/calls people righteous who believe in Jesus**

In this section, Paul showed that God’s promise of blessing to Abraham and his descendants was made because Abraham believed God. God did not promise blessing because Abraham obeyed the law of Moses. Paul then described how Abraham believed and why God called him righteous. Paul then explained that God also calls the people who believe in God (and his Messiah, Jesus) righteous.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

God counts people as righteous through faith, not through the Law Of Moses

God also called us<sup>(incl)</sup> righteous because we believe

The lesson/model of God calling Abraham righteous applies to us/believers

**4:23a–b**

**Now the words “it was credited to him” were written:** This clause is passive. Some languages must use an active clause here. For example:

God did not tell Moses to write the words “it was counted to him”

**4:23a**

**Now the words “it was credited to him”**

- ¶ Now/Look, the words “by that believing God reckoned/counted him as upright”
- ¶ Those words,

**Now:** Paul now took the example of Abraham’s faith and applied it to all people who believe in Jesus (4:24a). In some languages, this does not indicate contrast. Consider how to introduce this teaching in your language. For example:

But (ESV)

The words... (NIV)

**the words “it was credited to him”:** This refers to the same thing as in 4:22. Paul repeated it to say something new about it in 4:23b–24a. See how you translated it was credited to him in 4:3.

In some languages it is more natural to add “as righteousness” here. For example:

the words “it was credited to him as righteousness”

In some languages repeating the words from 4:22 has a different meaning or is not natural. If that is true in your language, translate this without repeating the words from 4:22. For example:

just as we read in the Scriptures. But these words (CEV)

What is written thereUma Back Translation on TW.

**4:23b**

**were written not only for Abraham,**

- were not written only for him/Abraham,
- God did not have Moses write them regarding only him/Abraham,

**were written:** This word implies here that the words were written in the Old Testament (Genesis 15:6). In some languages this information needs to be made explicit to indicate the correct meaning. For example:



were written in Scripture

**not only for Abraham:** Here this phrase means “not only regarding him.” Moses wrote these words long after Abraham had died. Those words apply to him, but they also apply to others. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

for his sake alone (ESV)

apply not only to Abraham (REB)

## Romans 4:24

### Section 4:13–25: God considers/calls people righteous who believe in Jesus

In this section, Paul showed that God’s promise of blessing to Abraham and his descendants was made because Abraham believed God. God did not promise blessing because Abraham obeyed the law of Moses. Paul then described how Abraham believed and why God called him righteous. Paul then explained that God also calls the people who believe in God (and his Messiah, Jesus) righteous.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

God counts people as righteous through faith, not through the Law Of Moses

God also called us<sup>(incl)</sup> righteous because we believe

The lesson/model of God calling Abraham righteous applies to us/believers

### 4:24a

#### but also for us,

- but for us<sup>(incl)</sup> also,
- but God said them also regarding us.

**but also for us:** Some words from 4:23a–b are implied here. The English language can omit them yet still indicate the correct meaning. Some languages must make some or all of the implied words explicit for the correct meaning. For example:

they were written for us also

they apply to us as well

### 4:24b

#### to whom righteousness will be credited—

- whom God will reckon/count as upright.
- We also believed in God, and so God will call us righteous people.

**to whom righteousness will be credited:** This clause is passive. Some languages must use an active clause. For example:

God will count to us

**righteousness will be credited:** The Greek is literally “to whom (it) is about to be counted.” For example:

to whom God will credit righteousness (NIV)

But in some languages it is more natural to begin a new sentence here, as the ESV does:

It will be counted to us... (ESV)

**will be credited:** The Greek is literally “is about to be counted.” It indicates that soon God will certainly count believers as righteous. In English it is more clear to translate the Greek as a promise with the future tense. For example:

God will credit righteousness (NIV)

Note that the NIV also translates the Greek passive clause as an active clause.

The Greek does not imply that God has still not counted believers as righteous today (as with the present tense in 3:22 and 9:30). God declares someone righteous when they believe in Jesus (i.e. Galatians 3:11) and also at the great judgment (see Moo). Perhaps in the latter sense Paul used “about to” here. For example:

our faith too is to be ‘counted’ (REB)

### 4:24c

#### for us who believe in Him who raised Jesus our Lord from the dead.

- We believe in the one/person who raised Jesus our Lord from the dead,
- We believe in God, and he caused Jesus our Leader/Master to live again after he was dead.

**for us who believe in Him who raised Jesus our Lord from the dead:** This clause tells the reader more about the people who Paul called “us” in 4:24a. It does not separate some people called “us” from other people called “us” here. For the correct meaning in some languages, translators must avoid the word who. For example:

We believe in him who raised from the dead Jesus our Lord.

**believe in:** To believe in someone means to agree to what someone stands for, to trust him, to rely on him, to be committed to him. See how you translated the word believe in 1:16.

**Him who:** The words Him who refers to God. In many languages translating the literal meaning will clearly refer to God. In some languages it will not be clear. If that is true in your language, make it clear. For example:

God , the one who

God . He

**raised...from the dead:** This phrase refers to God making Jesus alive again after he died and was put in the tomb. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

raised...from death (GNT)

brought...back to life (GW)

who caused that our Lord Jesus Christ resurrected after he had died Otomi Back Translation on TW.

has caused to live from his death Yakan Back Translation on TW.

raised from the place of the dead

See the similar phrase “resurrection from the dead” in 1:4 or “had raised from the dead” in John 12:1.

**Jesus our Lord:** See how you translated this phrase in 1:4.

## Romans 4:25

### Section 4:13–25: God considers/calls people righteous who believe in Jesus

In this section, Paul showed that God’s promise of blessing to Abraham and his descendants was made because Abraham believed God. God did not promise blessing because Abraham obeyed the law of Moses. Paul then described how Abraham believed and why God called him righteous. Paul then explained that God also calls the people who believe in God (and his Messiah, Jesus) righteous.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

God counts people as righteous through faith, not through the Law Of Moses

God also called us<sup>(incl)</sup> righteous because we believe

The lesson/model of God calling Abraham righteous applies to us/believers

### 4:25a

#### He was delivered over to death for our trespasses

- whom<sup>(sing)</sup> God/he handed over to die/death for the sake of the evil deeds that we have done
- God gave him to people to take and kill him for our misdeeds

**He was delivered over:** This clause further describes Jesus. It does not separate this Jesus from other Jesuses. This clause is also passive. Some languages must translate it as an active clause. For example:

God gave Jesus to die (CEV)

God put Jesus in the hands of killers

God handed-Jesus -over to die Kankanaey Back Translation on TW.

**delivered over:** This verb phrase indicates here that God put Jesus into the hands of certain people so that they would kill him. See the examples above.

**for:** There are two ways to interpret the Greek word that the BSB translates as for:

1. It means on account of here. Jesus died for the sake of doing something about our sins. This is the

meaning of the English word for here. (BSB, RSV, ESV, NIV, NJB, NABRE, REB, CEV, NCV, KJV)

2. It means because of here. Jesus died because we sinned. (GNT, NLT, GW, NET, NASB)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1), because it seems a better fit here. BDAG (page 225), Alford (page 355), and Nicoll (pages 621–622) support interpretation (1). Nicoll says, “He was delivered up on account of our offences—to make atonement for them.” See also the interpretation issue on “for” in 4:25b.

**trespasses:** The Greek word that the BSB translates as trespasses means “failures” or “errors.” Here it refers to failures to do as God says, implying that there will be consequences for those failures. It is similar in meaning to “sins,” but is more general. Here are other ways to translate trespasses:

offences (KJV)

failures (GW)

misdeeds (REB)

In some languages one term is used for both “failures” and “sins.” If that is true in your language, use that term here.

#### 4:25b

**and was raised to life for our justification.**

- and raised him for the sake of making us right with him.
- and caused him to live again after he was dead for the sake of calling us righteous/upright.

**was raised:** Some languages must translate the phrase was raised as an active clause. For example:

whom he/God raised

he/God raised

**for:** There are three ways to interpret the Greek word that the BSB translates as for:

1. It means on account of here. Jesus was raised to life for the sake of justifying us. This is the meaning of the English word for here. (BSB, RSV, ESV, NIV, NJB, NABRE, NET, REB, KJV)
2. It means so that here. Jesus was raised for the purpose of justifying us. (GNT, NLT, GW, CEV, NCV)

3. It means because of here. Jesus was raised because we were justified. (NASB)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). BDAG (page 225), Alford (page 355), and Nicoll (pages 621–622) support interpretation (1). Nicoll says, “he was raised on account of our justification—that it might become an accomplished fact.” See also the interpretation issue on “for” in 4:25a. Interpretation (2) is very similar in meaning to interpretation (1), but the Greek lexicons do not say that the Greek word introduces purpose. Interpretation (3) indicates an incorrect relationship between the two events. Nicoll (page 621) says, “it is impossible to believe that (Paul) would have written—as this interpretation requires him to do—that we were justified by Christ’s death, and that Christ was therefore raised from the dead by God.”

**our justification:** The word justification indicates that God decides that a person is acceptable to him. When people believe that Jesus died for their sins, God forgives them, accepts them, and considers them as righteous. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

putting us right with God

making us right in his sight

receiving God’s approval

declaring us righteous

## Romans 5:1

### Section 5:1–11: Good fruit/things in our lives because we believe

In this section, Paul started by saying that God has made people right with him because they believed in Jesus. From that, believers have peace with God and his grace. Believers rejoice about the future blessings as well as sufferings here on earth. Suffering causes us to endure, do what is right, and have hope for a better future.

God showed how much he loves us by sending Christ to die for us when we were still rejecting him. Jesus also saves us from God’s anger and reconciled us to God, and so we can rejoice.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

Results of Justification (NRSV)

## Peace with God Through Faith (ESV)

Some things we experience because we believe in Jesus

### 5:1a

**Therefore, since we have been justified through faith,**

- ¶ God has said that we<sup>(incl)</sup> are now right with him because we believed in Jesus, and so
- ¶ As I said before, we believed in Jesus, and so God has declared us to be righteous in his sight. Therefore,

**Therefore, since we have been justified through**

**faith:** The clause we have been justified through faith summarizes what Paul was talking about in 1:18–4:25. It is not a new conclusion that Paul made here. So the word *Therefore* introduces 5:1b as a result of being justified through faith. For example:

Now that we have been put right with God through faith, (GNT)

In summary, we have been justified by faith. Therefore

**since we have been justified through faith:** The word *since* introduces the basis for having peace with God (5:1b). In many languages 5:1b must be introduced with “so” for the correct meaning. For example:

we have been justified by faith, so

**we have been justified:** This clause is passive. Some languages must use an active clause. For example:

God has justified us

**justified:** This word indicates that God decides that a person is acceptable to him. When people believe in Jesus, God declares them to be righteous. See how you translated this word in 2:13, where the BSB translates as “declared righteous.”

### 5:1b

**we have peace with God**

- we now live at peace with God
- we are at peace with God (NJB)

**peace:** This word refers to having no conflicts with other people or with God. The Greek word may also indicate wholeness or well-being. The BDAG (pages

287–288) lists this verse under sense (2), “a state of well-being, peace.” See how you translated this word in 1:7.

### 5:1c

**through our Lord Jesus Christ,**

- by means of our Lord Jesus Christ.
- Our Leader/Master Jesus Christ made that peace possible.

**through our Lord Jesus Christ:** Here this phrase indicates that when Jesus died on the cross to redeem us from our sins, it made a way for God to end his anger against us. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

by means of what our Lord Jesus Christ did  
Western Bukidnon Manobo Back Translation on TW.

because of what he has done for us (NLT)

## Romans 5:2

**Section 5:1–11: Good fruit/things in our lives because we believe**

In this section, Paul started by saying that God has made people right with him because they believed in Jesus. From that, believers have peace with God and his grace. Believers rejoice about the future blessings as well as sufferings here on earth. Suffering causes us to endure, do what is right, and have hope for a better future.

God showed how much he loves us by sending Christ to die for us when we were still rejecting him. Jesus also saves us from God’s anger and reconciled us to God, and so we can rejoice.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

Results of Justification (NRSV)

Peace with God Through Faith (ESV)

Some things we experience because we believe in Jesus

### 5:2a

**through whom we have gained access by faith**

- Also by means of what he did for us, when we<sup>(incl)</sup> believed in him, we gained the right/permission
- We believed in him, and so he also made it possible for us to be able to experience

**through whom:** Here this phrase has the same meaning as “through our Lord Jesus Christ” in 5:1c. He repeats the meaning here to introduce more about what Jesus has done for us. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

By means of what he did

He has done that for us, and so

**we have gained access:** The Greek indicates that we gained access in the past and still have that access. God gave grace to us when we believed and continues to give us grace.

In some languages a simple past tense would indicate the correct meaning. For example:

we also obtained access

In some languages both the past and present situation must be explicit to indicate the correct meaning. For example:

we also obtained access and continue to have that access

**gained access:** This phrase refers to obtaining the right to something. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

obtained access (ESV)

made it possible for God to show His favor to us  
Western Bukidnon Manobo Back Translation on TW.

we become able to experience/have

**by faith:** There is a textual issue here:

1. Some Greek manuscripts have this phrase. (BSB, NIV, GNT, NJB, NASB, ESV, NLT, NET)
2. Some Greek manuscripts omit this phrase. (RSV, NABRE, GW, REB, NCV, CEV)

It is recommended that you follow option (1) because the UBS5 supports it. But the scholars of the UBS5 did indicate they had difficulty deciding which option was best.

### 5:2b

**into this grace in which we stand.**

- to have that grace/kindness of/from God that we now live in/with,
- those kind deeds of God all the time.

**into this grace:** This phrase probably refers to the fact that God declared us righteous, of which Paul spoke in 4:25. In some languages it is more natural to use “that” instead of this here.

**grace:** Here the word grace indicates the kindness and help that God has given us. He has declared us righteous. People do not deserve this kindness from God. See how you translated this word in 1:7 or 4:16.

**in which we stand:** Here this phrase means “which we now experience.” Believers experience righteousness because of God being kind and helpful to them. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

in which we now live (GNT)

which we are currently experiencing  
Tagbanwa Back Translation on TW.

### 5:2c

**And we rejoice in the hope of the glory of God.**

- and we also boast about our hope in God’s glory.
- Also/Further, we speak with pride about God sharing his glory with us as we expectantly wait for that.

**And:** This word probably connects 5:2c to 5:1b. Cranfield (page 259). If possible, translate this in a way that indicates that it does not connect only to 5:2b. For example:

Also,

**rejoice in:** The Greek word that the BSB translates as rejoice is literally “boast.” Here it refers to having pride about the hope in one day sharing in God’s glory. For example:

boast in (NIV11)

speak with pride about

In some languages boasting is a bad deed. (But in some languages it is only boasting about oneself that is bad.) If boasting is always considered bad in your language, translate the correct meaning. For example:

speak happily about

**the hope of the glory of God:** This phrase indicates that believers confidently expect that God will share his glory with them. See Romans 8:17, 8:30, and 2 Corinthians 3:18. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

our hope of sharing the glory of God (RSV)

we confidently...look forward to sharing God's glory (NLT)

our confidence that we will receive glory from God (GW)

## Romans 5:3

### Section 5:1–11: Good fruit/things in our lives because we believe

In this section, Paul started by saying that God has made people right with him because they believed in Jesus. From that, believers have peace with God and his grace. Believers rejoice about the future blessings as well as sufferings here on earth. Suffering causes us to endure, do what is right, and have hope for a better future.

God showed how much he loves us by sending Christ to die for us when we were still rejecting him. Jesus also saves us from God's anger and reconciled us to God, and so we can rejoice.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

Results of Justification (NRSV)

Peace with God Through Faith (ESV)

Some things we experience because we believe in Jesus

#### 5:3a

#### Not only that, but we also rejoice in our sufferings,

- Not only that, but we<sup>(incl)</sup> also boast when we suffer,
- But we do not speak with pride about only that. When troubles happen in our lives because we believe in Jesus, we also speak with pride about them too,

**Not only that, but:** The Greek is literally “and not only but also.” Here it indicates that Paul wanted to talk about more things that believers rejoice in. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

More than that, but (ESV)

Not only so, but...also (NIV)

And it is not only that that we are happy-about but rather...also Kankanaey Back Translation on TW.

**we also rejoice in our sufferings:** This is the second thing that believers rejoice/boast in. We can rejoice/boast even when we suffer because we know the results will be good (5:3b–5:4b).

**rejoice:** The Greek word here is literally “boast,” as in 5:2c. Translate it in the same way here.

**in our sufferings:** Here the Greek is more literally “in the sufferings.” In the NT the word sufferings usually refers to the hardships and troubles people experience because they are believers in Jesus. So many English versions add the word *our* here. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

in our troubles

in our tribulations (NASB)

when we are suffering (GW)

#### 5:3b

#### because we know that suffering produces perseverance;

- because we know that when we suffer, that causes us to be patient,
- because we know that when troubles come, they cause us to patiently continue to do as God wants us to.

**because we know that suffering produces perseverance:** Here the Greek word that the BSB translates as *because we know* implies that 5:3b–4b are reasons for rejoicing/boasting in our sufferings.

**produces:** The word produces means “to cause.” For example:

creates (GW)

develops (NJB)

**perseverance:** This word means “patiently continuing in something.” When troubles come, believers con-

tinue to believe in Jesus. They do not give up. Here are other ways to translate this word:

endurance (ESV)

patience (NCV)

## Romans 5:4

### Section 5:1–11: Good fruit/things in our lives because we believe

In this section, Paul started by saying that God has made people right with him because they believed in Jesus. From that, believers have peace with God and his grace. Believers rejoice about the future blessings as well as sufferings here on earth. Suffering causes us to endure, do what is right, and have hope for a better future.

God showed how much he loves us by sending Christ to die for us when we were still rejecting him. Jesus also saves us from God's anger and reconciled us to God, and so we can rejoice.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

Results of Justification (NRSV)

Peace with God Through Faith (ESV)

Some things we experience because we believe in Jesus

#### 5:4a

##### perseverance, character;

- and being patient causes us to have strong character,
- And we know that when we patiently continue to do as God wants us to, we gain strength in the will to do good/right things.

**character:** This Greek word refers to a good result of being tested. Here it refers to things like moral strength, the will to do as one promised, or the intention to be kind when one is suffering. Here are other ways to translate this word:

strength of character (NLT)

proven character (NASB)

our behavior is strong to follow good ways

standing/living straightBased on the Yongkom NT.

maturity

#### 5:4b

##### and character, hope.

- and strong character causes us to hope even more.
- And we know that when we gain strength in the will to do good/right things, we grow in hope in God's promises.

**hope:** This word has the same meaning as it does in 5:2c. But the object of the hope here is probably more general than it is there. Cranfield (page 261) says, "to stand the test is to have one's hope in Him and in the fulfillment of His promises, one's hope of His glory (v. 2), strengthened and confirmed." In some languages what is hoped for must be made explicit. If that is true in your language, refer to God or his promises. For example:

hope in God

hope to receive what God has promised

## Romans 5:5

### Section 5:1–11: Good fruit/things in our lives because we believe

In this section, Paul started by saying that God has made people right with him because they believed in Jesus. From that, believers have peace with God and his grace. Believers rejoice about the future blessings as well as sufferings here on earth. Suffering causes us to endure, do what is right, and have hope for a better future.

God showed how much he loves us by sending Christ to die for us when we were still rejecting him. Jesus also saves us from God's anger and reconciled us to God, and so we can rejoice.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

Results of Justification (NRSV)

Peace with God Through Faith (ESV)

Some things we experience because we believe in Jesus

#### 5:5a

##### And hope does not disappoint us,

- And that hope does not shame us<sup>(incl)</sup>,
- And no one can shame us when we hope in God's promises,

**And hope does not disappoint us:** There are two ways to interpret the Greek word that the BSB translates as disappoint:

1. It means make ashamed here. (ESV, NIV11, KJV, GW)
2. It means make disappointed here. For example:

hope does not disappoint us (BSB) (BSB, RSV, NIV, GNT, NJB, NASB, NABRE, NLT, CEV, NET, REB, NCV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1), because it is the usual meaning of the Greek word. Louw and Kittel do not even list "make disappointed" as a meaning of this Greek word in their lexicons.

**does not disappoint us:** Our hope in God and his promises does not shame us at the present time because God loves us and has given the Holy Spirit to us (5:5b–c). Some English versions and some scholars believe that the Greek verb should be a future tense here: "hope will not put us to shame," because the full realization of that hope is in the future. But that requires changing the established marking on the verb from present tense to future tense. Witherington (page 136) says, "it is a hope which has already been partially realized in the Spirit's presence and in God's love in the life of the believer." Dunn, Cranfield, Morris, and others support the present tense reading. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

does not shame us

does not cause us to be ashamed

### 5:5b

**because God has poured out His love into our hearts through the Holy Spirit,**

- because God has abundantly put his love in our hearts/thoughts through the Holy Spirit,
- because God has caused the Holy Spirit to make us fully experience his love.

**God has poured out His love into our hearts through the Holy Spirit:** The word through indicates here that God gave the task of putting his love in our hearts to the Holy Spirit. For example:

God caused the Holy Spirit to pour his/God's love into our hearts

God commanded/told the Holy Spirit to pour his/God's love into our hearts and he did

This clause is passive. Some languages must use an active clause. For example:

God poured his love into our hearts through the Holy Spirit

**poured out:** This verb is used figuratively to refer to giving generously. God caused much love to exist in our hearts. Here are other ways to translate this word:

enables us to have much of God's love

causes us to fully experience

he causes-us-to-feel God's great love  
Kankanaey Back Translation on TW.

**His love:** This refers to the love that God has for us.

**our hearts:** The word hearts refers figuratively to the inner being of people, which includes the mind, the emotions, and the will. In some languages a literal translation would not refer to the inner being. If that is true in your language, you may want to use the word or phrase that has the right meaning. For example:

insides/liver

mind and will

**the Holy Spirit:** This phrase refers to God's Spirit. The word Spirit is used in a similar way to when a person refers to his own spirit. The word Holy here means "clean" or "sacred." But it also refers to "coming from God." Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

Sacred/Holy Spirit

Pure/Clean Spirit

the Spirit who comes from God

See how you translated this phrase in Matthew 1:18, Luke 1:15, or 1 Thessalonians 1:5.

### 5:5c

**whom He has given us.**

- whom he/God has given to us.



- God has also given the Holy Spirit to us.

**whom He has given us:** In the Greek, this clause is passive. Some languages must use an active clause. For example:

whom God/he gave to us

This clause also tells the reader more about the Holy Spirit. It does not separate the Holy Spirit from other spirits. For the correct meaning in some languages, translators must avoid the word whom. For example:

He was given to us by God.

God gave him to us.

## Romans 5:6

### Section 5:1–11: Good fruit/things in our lives because we believe

In this section, Paul started by saying that God has made people right with him because they believed in Jesus. From that, believers have peace with God and his grace. Believers rejoice about the future blessings as well as sufferings here on earth. Suffering causes us to endure, do what is right, and have hope for a better future.

God showed how much he loves us by sending Christ to die for us when we were still rejecting him. Jesus also saves us from God's anger and reconciled us to God, and so we can rejoice.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

Results of Justification (NRSV)

Peace with God Through Faith (ESV)

Some things we experience because we believe in Jesus

#### 5:6a

**For at just the right time, while we were still powerless,**

- ¶ For on the proper day for it, at the time when we<sup>(incl)</sup> were still powerless,
- ¶ For on the appropriate day, while we were still unable to reconcile with God,

**For:** Here this word introduces an explanation of how hope does not put us to shame (5:5).

It may be more natural in your language to not use a conjunction here.

**at just the right time:** The Greek word that the BSB translates as just the right time refers to an appropriate time for something to happen. God decided when the best time for Jesus to die for the ungodly was. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

at the right time (ESV)

at the appointed time (NJB)

**while we were still powerless:** Here the word still indicates that we were powerless before Jesus died for us and continued to be weak when he died for us.

**powerless:** Here this word refers to any kind of physical, moral, ethical, or spiritual weakness. Here are other ways to translate this word:

weak (ESV)

helpless (NJB)

morally and ethically weak

#### 5:6b

**Christ died for the ungodly.**

- Christ died on behalf of us, people who had rejected God.
- Christ died to help us, the godless people.

**Christ died for the ungodly:** Here the word for indicates that Christ died to benefit the ungodly. By dying, he made a way for them to be reconciled to God. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

Christ died to help the ungodly

Christ died to ransom the ungodly

Christ died in place of the ungodly Based on the Uma Back Translation on TW.

**the ungodly:** The word ungodly refers to people who reject God. Here are other ways to translate this word:

people who reject God

people who do not worship God

See how you translated this phrase in 4:5.

## Romans 5:7

### Section 5:1-11: Good fruit/things in our lives because we believe

In this section, Paul started by saying that God has made people right with him because they believed in Jesus. From that, believers have peace with God and his grace. Believers rejoice about the future blessings as well as sufferings here on earth. Suffering causes us to endure, do what is right, and have hope for a better future.

God showed how much he loves us by sending Christ to die for us when we were still rejecting him. Jesus also saves us from God's anger and reconciled us to God, and so we can rejoice.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

Results of Justification (NRSV)

Peace with God Through Faith (ESV)

Some things we experience because we believe in Jesus

### 5:7a-b

This verse has two examples of how people love in a limited way. This compares to the great love of God and Jesus for people. Some people might risk their life for a good or righteous person, but Jesus died for people who rejected him (the "ungodly").

### 5:7a

#### Very rarely will anyone die for a righteous man,

- Indeed, rarely would someone die to help a righteous person,
- Look/Listen, very few people would risk their lives to benefit an upright/honest person and die doing that.

In the Greek, 5:7a begins with a word that is usually translated as "For." It connects this verse with 5:6. Here it probably indicates explanation/clarification BDAG (page 189). or an interjection such as:

Indeed (NRSV)

Even (REB)

Now (NLT)

In some languages it is more natural to omit this word and allow the context to indicate the meaning.

**Very rarely:** The Greek word that the BSB translates as Very rarely means "not very often" or "very unlikely." Here are other ways to translate this word:

scarcely (ESV)

most people would not be willing to die (NLT)

**anyone:** Here this word refers generally to a person. For example:

someone (GNT)

**die for:** Here the word indicates that this person died to benefit this righteous person. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

give his life for (JBP)

die to save the life of (NCV)

let himself be killed in the place of Western Bukidnon Manobo Back Translation on TW.

**a righteous man:** Here the word righteous refers to a person who acts in right or straight ways toward other people. He obeys the laws and is honest with others. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

someone upright (NJB)

a person who consistently-obeyed the law Kankanaey Back Translation on TW.

See how you translated the word righteous in 1:17.

### 5:7b

#### though for a good man someone might possibly dare to die.

- and/but possibly someone would be even bold enough to die to help a good person.
- However some people might indeed be brave enough to risk their lives to benefit a good person and die doing that.

**though:** The Greek word is the same one translated "For" at the beginning of 5:7a. Often in this context the best English translation is "and," because that is the sense the second occurrence of the Greek word has

in English. But the sense between these two clauses (5:7a and 5:7b) is generally agreed to be though, as in many English versions.

**for:** Here the word for refers to dying in order to help someone, as it does in 5:7a.

**might:** This word emphasizes “dare to die.” It is more than people might expect, that someone might dare to die for a good person.

**possibly:** Here this word indicates that dying for a good person is not common but more likely than dying for a righteous person.

**dare:** This word refers to being bold enough to do something. Someone might be bold enough to risk his life to rescue someone else. Here are other ways to translate this word:

have the courage (GW)

is brave enough Western Bukidnon Manobo Back Translation on TW.

## Romans 5:8

### Section 5:1–11: Good fruit/things in our lives because we believe

In this section, Paul started by saying that God has made people right with him because they believed in Jesus. From that, believers have peace with God and his grace. Believers rejoice about the future blessings as well as sufferings here on earth. Suffering causes us to endure, do what is right, and have hope for a better future.

God showed how much he loves us by sending Christ to die for us when we were still rejecting him. Jesus also saves us from God’s anger and reconciled us to God, and so we can rejoice.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

Results of Justification (NRSV)

Peace with God Through Faith (ESV)

Some things we experience because we believe in Jesus

### 5:8a

#### But God proves His love for us in this:

- But God demonstrates his love for/to us by
- But God shows us that he always loves us like this:

**proves:** This verb is present tense because God loves people all the time.

**His love for us:** In some languages a verb must be used for the noun love here. For example:

that he loves us

**in this:** This phrase introduces how God shows his love for us. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

by (NLT)

in this way: (NCV)

### 5:8b

#### While we were still sinners, Christ died for us.

- Jesus Christ dying for us while we were yet sinners.
- During/At the time when we were still doing wrong against God, Christ died to benefit us.

**still:** Here this word means “continue to be.” Christ died for our sins before we could stop sinning. For example:

yet (RSV)

**sinners:** This word refers to people who habitually do what is against what God wants. The word can also refer to people who are outsiders to the community of the people of God. See BDAG b.β. But many English versions translate the Greek word as the BSB does.

**for:** Here the word for refers to benefiting us or in order to help us, as it does the second time it occurs in 5:7a.

## Romans 5:9

### Section 5:1–11: Good fruit/things in our lives because we believe

In this section, Paul started by saying that God has made people right with him because they believed in Jesus. From that, believers have peace with God and his grace. Believers rejoice about the future blessings as well as sufferings here on earth. Suffering causes us to endure, do what is right, and have hope for a better future.

God showed how much he loves us by sending Christ to die for us when we were still rejecting him. Jesus also saves us from God’s anger and reconciled us to God, and so we can rejoice.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

Results of Justification (NRSV)

Peace with God Through Faith (ESV)

Some things we experience because we believe in Jesus

#### 5:9a-b

**Therefore, since we have now been justified by His blood, how much more shall we be saved from wrath through Him!:** The word since introduces the basis for the comparison (introduced by much more). Some languages may need to translate in a different way to make that clear. For example:

It is true that we have now been justified by his blood. Therefore it is true indeed that we will be saved by him from the wrath of God.

Therefore, much more shall we be saved by him from the wrath of God, since/because we have now been justified by his blood.

#### 5:9a

**Therefore, since we have now been justified by His blood,**

- ¶ Therefore, having now been told that through his blood we are now right with God,
- ¶ This is true: God said that we are right with him though his Son's death. Therefore,
- ¶ God declared us righteous in his sight because Jesus died for us, and that is still true today. Therefore, it is

**we have now been justified:** The word now indicates that being justified is still true at the present time. For example:

now that we have been justified (NJB)

In some languages being justified in the past implies still being justified at the present time. So, those languages can omit the word now if it is not natural here. For example:

we have been made right in God's sight (NLT)

**we have...been justified:** See how you translated this clause in 5:1.

**by His blood:** Here the phrase His blood refers figuratively to Jesus' death. The phrase by His blood indi-

cates that Jesus' death was the way that God made believers righteous. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

by shedding his blood

by his sacrificial death

when he died for us

because of Jesus' blood who died to pay for our sinsUma Back Translation on TW.

#### 5:9b

**how much more shall we be saved from wrath through Him!**

- we<sup>(incl)</sup> will be saved much more by him from God's anger.
- this is true indeed: he will save us from the anger of God.
- even-more/truly certain that Jesus will rescue us from the anger of God against sin.

**how much more:** This phrase emphasizes what follows. Just like it is true that God justifies us by the blood of Christ, it is also true that Jesus will save us from God's wrath. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

if God has already counted us as righteous because of Cristo's blood which flowed-out at his death, we expect yet even-more that Cristo will save-us from God's judging of people.Kankanaey Back Translation on TW.

So [having-said] that, we have become straight in God's sight because of Yesus' blood who died to pay-for our sins. That's why we know even more clearly that we will be set-free from the anger of GodUma Back Translation on TW.

These two things are true. In some languages a comparison with much more is not natural or meaningful. If that is true in your language, make the emphasis clear. For example:

So through Christ we will surely be saved from God's anger, because we have been made right with God (NCV)

Christ has now died in order to clear our sins.  
Therefore now we greatly are assured that now  
he has saved us Otomi Back Translation on TW.

**shall we be saved from wrath through Him:** This clause in Greek is future tense. For example:

we will be saved through him (NET)

This clause is passive. Some languages must use an active clause. For example:

he will save us

**saved:** This word refers to being rescued from something harmful or dangerous. Here it refers to God rescuing people from his wrath.

Some languages must say what someone is saved from to make clear what kind of saving is meant. For example:

save us from the punishment Otomi Back Translation, see also verse 10.

be freed from punishment Western Bukidnon Manobo Back Translation on TW.

saved from death Yongkom Back Translation, 5:10, by this author, unpublished manuscript, Papua New Guinea.

**wrath:** This phrase refers to God's anger against sin. See how you translated this phrase in 1:18.

## Romans 5:10

### Section 5:1-11: Good fruit/things in our lives because we believe

In this section, Paul started by saying that God has made people right with him because they believed in Jesus. From that, believers have peace with God and his grace. Believers rejoice about the future blessings as well as sufferings here on earth. Suffering causes us to endure, do what is right, and have hope for a better future.

God showed how much he loves us by sending Christ to die for us when we were still rejecting him. Jesus also saves us from God's anger and reconciled us to God, and so we can rejoice.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

Results of Justification (NRSV)

Peace with God Through Faith (ESV)

Some things we experience because we believe in Jesus

### 5:10a

**For if, when we were enemies of God, we were reconciled to Him through the death of His Son,**

- For if/when we<sup>(incl)</sup> were enemies of God the death of his Son reconciled us to him/God,
- Consider this: Jesus, God's Son died for us and so reconciled us with God during the time we were enemies to/against him/God. Therefore,
- At the time we and God were enemies, his Son reconciled us to him/God by dying for us. Therefore,

**For:** Here this word introduces a sentence that has similar phrases to 5:9 but says something a little different. Moo (on TW) says, "The parallelism between this verse and v. 9 renders the differences between them all the more significant." For the correct meaning in some languages, it is better to omit this word, as some English versions do.

**if, when we were enemies of God, we were reconciled to Him through the death of His Son:** Here the word if introduces a situation that is true. If this first part is true, that supports the second part ("how much more, having been reconciled, shall we be saved through His life") to also be true.

Here the word if does not indicate that when we were enemies of God, we were reconciled to Him might not be true. In some languages a literal translation would indicate this incorrect meaning. If that is true in your language, translate the correct meaning without using if. For example:

consider this: when we were enemies, we were reconciled to him by the death of his Son, therefore

it is true that when we were enemies, we were reconciled to him by the death of his Son, therefore

when we were enemies we were reconciled to him by the death of his Son, therefore

**we were enemies of God:** The Greek is more literally "being enemies," but it clearly implies here that we

were hostile toward God and so enemies against him. Some languages will need to make that clear here, as the BSB does. For example:

we were enemies with/against God

**we were reconciled to Him through the death of His Son:** This clause is passive. Some languages must use an active clause. For example:

he reconciled us to God by his death

the death of his Son restored our relationship with God (GW)

Christ reconciled us to God by dying for us (JBP)

**reconciled:** This word means “end anger and re-establish a good relationship.” Jesus, by his death, made the way to end God’s anger against our sins and restored our relationship with him.

**through the death of His Son:** Jesus dying made the way for us to be reconciled to God, because he took the punishment for our sins. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

by the death of his Son (ESV)

because his Son died for us (CEV)

because of His son allowing Himself to be killed-  
Western Bukidnon Manobo Back Translation on TW.

because of his Child/Son having died because of us (incl)Yakan Back Translation on TW.

**the death of His Son:** The noun death describes an event. Some languages must use a verb. See the examples above.

**His Son:** This phrase refers to Jesus. See how you translated it in 1:3.

#### 5:10b

**how much more, having been reconciled, shall we be saved through His life!**

- we will be saved much more by his life because we are reconciled to him.
- his Son’s life will save us indeed, because he reconciled us to God.

- it is even more certain that he will save us from death/hell because he is alive and has reconciled us to/with God.

**how much more, having been reconciled, shall we be saved through His life!:** The comparison (how much more) emphasizes that shall/will we be saved is true, just as we have been reconciled is true. See how you translated the words how much more in 5:9.

**having been reconciled:** This clause in Greek is literally “we/us having been reconciled.” The context implies that we are still reconciled at the present time.

The clause is passive. Some languages must use an active clause. For example:

he reconciled us to God

he reconciled us and God

**shall we be saved through His life!:** This clause is passive. Some languages must use an active clause. For example:

his life will save us

This clause refers to what Christ does for us in the present and will do in the future, because he always lives to intercede for us (Hebrews 7:24-25). The Greek word that the BSB translates as through is often translated as “in.” The word “in” implies that we share in Christ’s life. Jewett (page 367) says, “While the new life shared with Christ will climax in “eternal life” (v. 21), its redemptive power is experienced by the faithful as they are enabled to boast in a transformed manner in the very midst of their tribulations.”

Paul used the word life here to contrast to “death” in 5:10a. You should keep that meaning in your translation here. But the noun life describes an event. Some languages must use a verb. For example:

he will save us because he lives

## Romans 5:11

**Section 5:1-11: Good fruit/things in our lives because we believe**

In this section, Paul started by saying that God has made people right with him because they believed in Jesus. From that, believers have peace with God and his grace. Believers rejoice about the future blessings as well as sufferings here on earth. Suffering causes

us to endure, do what is right, and have hope for a better future.

God showed how much he loves us by sending Christ to die for us when we were still rejecting him. Jesus also saves us from God's anger and reconciled us to God, and so we can rejoice.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

Results of Justification (NRSV)

Peace with God Through Faith (ESV)

Some things we experience because we believe in Jesus

#### 5:11a

#### **Not only that, but we also rejoice in God**

- And not only that, we boast/exult in God
- But that is not all. We rejoice in who God is

**Not only that, but...also:** The Greek is literally “and not only but also.” Here it indicates that Paul wanted to talk more about the things that he had already talked about. For example:

More than that...also (ESV)

Not only is this so, but...also (NIV)

But that's not the only-thing that we expectKankanaey Back Translation on TW.

See how you translated this phrase in 5:3.

**we also rejoice in God:** The Greek word that the BSB translates as rejoice refers to speaking proudly about God. Some examples are: “God is great,” “He loves all people,” “He is all-powerful,” and “He sent his Son to die for our sins.” Here are other ways to translate this clause:

we also exult in God (NASB)

we also boast in God's greatness

we praise God before others

#### 5:11b

#### **through our Lord Jesus Christ,**

- by the things/deeds that our Lord Jesus Christ has done,
- because of what our Leader/Master Jesus Christ has done for us,

**through our Lord Jesus Christ:** The word through indicates here that we can rejoice in God because of what Jesus did (and is doing) for us.

#### 5:11c

#### **through whom we have now received reconciliation.**

- by whom at this time we have been reconciled to God.
- now that he caused us to be at peace with God.

**through whom we have now received reconciliation:** This refers to Jesus reconciling us to God, as in 5:10. In some languages “receive” and “take” are translated by the same word. If that is true in your language, you should probably avoid translating “receive/take” literally here. Also some languages must translate reconciliation as a verb. For example:

who has reconciled us to God

This clause tells the reader more about Jesus. It does not separate Jesus from other Jesuses. For the correct meaning in some languages, translators must avoid the word whom. For example:

Through him we have now received reconciliation.

He has now reconciled us to God.

**we have now received reconciliation:** The word now indicates that being reconciled with God is still true at the present time. It has the same meaning here as in 5:9. For example:

now that we have received reconciliation

Now that he has reconciled us to God.

**reconciliation:** This word refers to causing two people or two groups of people, who have been enemies, to be at peace with one another. Jesus, by his death and resurrection, has made a way for God to be reconciled to people who believe in Jesus as Savior. Some languages use a phrase for this meaning. For example:

he made peace

he brought back us to be God's friends

their connection with God to become goodUma  
Back Translation on TW.

to become one with peopleWestern Bukidnon  
Manobo Back Translation on TW.

## Romans 5:12

### Section 5:12–21: We die because of Adam but live because of Jesus

In this section Paul compared the result of Adam's sin in the Garden of Eden with the result of Jesus Christ's sacrifice. Through the sin of Adam, the punishment of death came to all people whether they sinned like him or not. But through the sacrifice of Jesus, the gift of righteousness was given to all who believe.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

Adam and Christ (CEV)

Paul compared Adam and/with Jesus

The Results Of What Adam Did And What Jesus  
DidBased on Kankanaey Back Translation on TW.

### 5:12a

#### Therefore, just as sin entered the world through one man,

- ¶ So then, just as it was one man who sinned and so caused sin to be in this world
- ¶ The first man disobeyed God, therefore the ways of sin began in the world.

**Therefore:** The scholars have many opinions as to what connection Paul indicated here. The best opinion seems to be that God justified, reconciled, and saved us through Jesus (5:1–11), therefore it is God's purpose for grace, not law, to rule our lives (5:20–21). Morris (on TW) says, "He is linking this new section to the preceding. It is because of the reconciliation Christ has brought about that the evil Adam introduced into the world has been overcome, and more than overcome (cf. v. 20)." Here are other ways to translate the Greek phrase:

So then (NET)

On account of thisJewett, page 369.

### just as sin entered the world through one man:

Paul began here to compare the entrance of sin into the world through Adam to something, but Paul did not complete the comparison. Instead he decided he needed to explain more about the result of sin entering the world (5:13–14). Then in 5:15–19 he began a slightly different comparison, contrasting the result of Adam's sin with the result of Jesus' righteous deed.

In some languages it would not be natural to begin a comparison and not complete it. If that is true in your language, omit the comparing word here. For example:

Sin came into the world through one man (GNT)

**sin entered the world:** This clause speaks of sin as if it were a force that entered the world. When Adam sinned, sin became the normal condition of people because that force affected all of them. Some languages can translate the figure of speech literally and people will understand the correct meaning.

But some languages must:

- Use a different verb for the correct meaning. For example:

sin arrived to the worldNalik NT, Papua New Guinea, in progress.

Sin is in the world because of one personUma  
Back Translation on TW.

sin has covered the worldBased on Tagbanwa  
Back Translation on TW.

- Explain the meaning of the figure of speech. For example:

sin came into the world like a force/power

the ways of sin began in the world

**sin:** This word refers to doing something that God said is wrong to do, or not doing something that God said they should do. See how you translated this word in 3:9 or 4:8.

**through one man:** The one man is Adam (5:14). In some languages it is more natural to name him here. For example:

When Adam sinned, sin entered the world (NLT)



Also, this phrase is emphasized in the Greek clause by being first in the clause.

#### 5:12b

##### and death through sin,

- and sin caused death to be/exist in this world,
- Also, the ways of dying began in the world because he sinned.

**death through sin:** This phrase implies “entered the world” from 5:12a. In some languages the implied phrase must be included. For example:

death came into the world through sin

This clause also speaks of death as if it were a force. When Adam sinned, death became the normal condition of people because that force affected all of them. See how you translated “entered the world” in 5:12a.

**death:** Some languages must use a verb for the word death. For example:

dying

he died

#### 5:12c

##### so also death was passed on to all men, because all sinned.

- so all people would die, because they all sin.
- And all people sin, so they all will die.

**so also:** The conjunction so introduces a result of Adam’s sin.

**death was passed on to all men:** This clause indicates that each person would die. Alford (page 360) quoting De Wette, says that it is like “going from house to house.” It is also a figure of speech. Some languages can translate the figure of speech literally and people will understand the correct meaning.

But some languages must:

- use a different verb for the correct meaning. For example:

death came to all people (NIV11)

death arrived to all people

there is death in the world Uma Back Translation on TW.

- translate the meaning of the figure of speech. For example:

that was the beginning of people dying

everyone would die

### Romans 5:13

#### Section 5:12–21: We die because of Adam but live because of Jesus

In this section Paul compared the result of Adam’s sin in the Garden of Eden with the result of Jesus Christ’s sacrifice. Through the sin of Adam, the punishment of death came to all people whether they sinned like him or not. But through the sacrifice of Jesus, the gift of righteousness was given to all who believe.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

Adam and Christ (CEV)

Paul compared Adam and/with Jesus

The Results Of What Adam Did And What Jesus Did Based on Kankanaey Back Translation on TW.

#### 5:13a

##### For sin was in the world before the law was given;

- For before the law of Moses was given, sin was in the world,
- For the ways of sin were in the world before God gave the/his laws to Moses,

**For:** This word introduces an explanation. The explanation is about something in the clause “death was passed on to all men, because all sinned” (5:12c).

**sin was in the world before the law was given:** This clause indicates that people did things that God did not want before he gave the law to Moses. This would be deeds like murder, stealing, and hurting others.

The phrase sin was in the world is a figure of speech. Some languages can translate the figure of speech literally and people will understand the correct meaning. But some languages must explain the meaning of the figure of speech. For example:

the ways of sin were in the world before the law was given

sin was like a force/power that existed in the world before the law was given

The Greek of this clause can be translated literally as “before the law sin was in the world.” The phrase before the law is emphasized in the Greek. Here are other ways to translate that emphasis:

indeed, before the law was given, sin was in the world

sin was in the world, and that before the law!

**the law was given:** This clause is passive. Some languages must use an active clause. For example:

God gave the law

**the law:** This refers to the laws that God gave to Moses. In some languages this implied information must be explicit for the correct meaning. For example:

the law through Moses

**5:13b**  
**but sin is not taken into account when there is no law.**

- but when that law did not exist, God did not count their sin.
- but when God had not yet given the law, he did not charge people with those sins.

**sin is not taken into account:** This clause is passive. Some languages must use an active clause. For example:

God did not count sin

**taken into account:** The Greek word here refers to writing in a book what someone has done. Sins that were committed before the law existed were not recorded as breaking that law. Here are other ways to translate this word:

it was not counted as sin (NLT)

sin is not charged against anyone's account where there is no law (NIV11)

## Romans 5:14

### Section 5:12–21: We die because of Adam but live because of Jesus

In this section Paul compared the result of Adam's sin in the Garden of Eden with the result of Jesus Christ's sacrifice. Through the sin of Adam, the punishment of death came to all people whether they sinned like him or not. But through the sacrifice of Jesus, the gift of righteousness was given to all who believe.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

Adam and Christ (CEV)

Paul compared Adam and/with Jesus

The Results Of What Adam Did And What Jesus Did  
Based on Kankanaey Back Translation on TW.

#### 5:14a

**Nevertheless, death reigned from Adam until Moses,**

- But death ruled people's lives from Adam to Moses,
- However, for all the people who lived between Adam and Moses, everyone sinned and therefore had to die.

**Nevertheless:** This word indicates that 5:14a contrasts with 5:13b. For example:

But (GNT)

**death reigned:** This clause speaks of death as if it were a person. It indicates that all the people who lived between Adam and Moses died, because they all sinned. Some languages can translate the figure of speech literally and people will understand the correct meaning. For example:

death ruled (GNT)

But some languages must translate the meaning of the figure of speech. For example:

death still had power over all who lived (CEV)

everyone had to die (NCV)

#### 5:14b

**even over those who did not sin in the way that Adam transgressed.**

- including the people who had not sinned in the same way that Adam did;
- Even though they did not disobey a specific/direct command of God like Adam did, they still sinned and therefore had to die.

**even over those who did not sin in the way that Adam transgressed:** God told Adam to not eat the fruit of the tree of the knowledge of good and evil. Adam disobeyed God and later died as a result. Everyone else after Adam also died, even those who did not disobey God in the way Adam did. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

even over those who did not sin by breaking a command, as did Adam (NIV)

even over those who did not sin in the same way that Adam did when he disobeyed God's command (GNT)

**even over:** Here the word even indicates that Paul included people who sinned in ways that were different than Adam's sin. Here are other ways to translate this word:

including

as well as

**sin:** This word in Greek refers to doing something wrong or bad. It is a more general word than "transgression."

**transgressed:** This word in Greek refers to breaking a law, rule, or command. See the examples above.

#### 5:14c

**He is a pattern of the One to come.**

- he/Adam is an example of the man/person who would come after him.
- He/Adam is in one way like he who would come later.

**He is a pattern of the One to come:** The phrase He is a pattern of the One to come refers to Jesus. The word pattern indicates here that Adam did something that was like Jesus: they both did something that affected all people. But their deeds were very different. Adam introduced sin and death. Jesus introduced salvation. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

who was a type of the one who was to come (ESV)

he is like a picture/shadow of the man/person who was to come later Based on the Tok Pisin Bible.

he is like the one who came later in one way

You should avoid translations that indicate that Adam was generally like or the same as Jesus.

**He is a pattern:** This clause tells the reader more about Adam. It does not separate this Adam from other Adams.

**is a pattern:** The Greek verb has the present tense ending and so means is. It indicates that this statement is true then and now. Consider how to translate that meaning.

## Romans 5:15

**Section 5:12–21: We die because of Adam but live because of Jesus**

In this section Paul compared the result of Adam's sin in the Garden of Eden with the result of Jesus Christ's sacrifice. Through the sin of Adam, the punishment of death came to all people whether they sinned like him or not. But through the sacrifice of Jesus, the gift of righteousness was given to all who believe.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

Adam and Christ (CEV)

Paul compared Adam and/with Jesus

The Results Of What Adam Did And What Jesus Did Based on Kankanaey Back Translation on TW.

#### 5:15a

**But the gift is not like the trespass.**

- ¶ But the gift of what Jesus did for us is indeed not like the sin of Adam.
- ¶ But the failure/fall of Adam is very different from the gift from Christ.

**But the gift is not like the trespass:** The Greek is more literally "but not as the trespass so also the gift." The word is implied from the Greek grammar. For example:

But not as the offence, so also [is] the free gift (KJV)

But also the gift is indeed not like the trespass

**the gift:** The Greek word that the BSB translates as gift refers to salvation or reconciliation (5:8–11). The opportunity to be saved and reconciled to God is given to us for free. We cannot earn that opportunity.

In some languages what the gift is must be explained. For example:

the gift of salvation/reconciliation

the gift of Jesus saving/reconciling us

**trespass:** This word in Greek generally refers to falling because you did something wrong. Here it has a more figurative sense and means “a violation of moral standards.” BDAG (page 770). Here are other ways to translate this word:

failure (GW)

wrongdoing (REB)

This word is similar in meaning to “sin” here. In some languages “sin” is the best translation of this word. For example:

sin (GNT)

### 5:15b

**For if the many died by the trespass of the one man,**

- For if all those people died because of that one man’s sin,
- Consider this: one man failed to follow God’s command, therefore many, many people sinned and died. Therefore,

**For:** This word introduces an explanation of how the gift is not like the trespass (5:15a).

**if the many died by the trespass of the one man:** Here the word if introduces a situation that is true. If this first part is true, that supports the second part (“how much more did God’s grace and the gift that came by the grace of the one man, Jesus Christ, abound to the many!”) (5:15c) to also be true.

Here the word if does not indicate that the many died by the trespass of the one man might not be true. In some languages a literal translation would indicate this incorrect meaning. If that is true in your language, translate the correct meaning. For example:

consider this: many died through one man’s trespass, therefore

it is true that many died through one man’s trespass, therefore

many died through one man’s trespass, therefore

**the many:** Here this phrase refers to a large number of people. Here it refers to “all men” (5:12c). For that reason, many English versions translate the article as well, as the BSB does. Other translations do not translate the article. For example:

many (ESV)

**by the trespass of the one man:** The word by indicates that Adam’s sin caused sin to enter the world and so all people sin and therefore die (5:12). Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

because of the sin of that one man (GNT)

the sin of this one man, Adam, brought death to many (NLT)

From the transgression of that one person, all mankind die. Uma Back Translation on TW.

### 5:15c

**how much more did God’s grace and the gift that came by the grace of the one man, Jesus Christ, abound to the many!**

- then the grace/kindness of God and the gift that another man, Jesus Christ, gave in his grace/kindness overflowed much more to all people.
- God was much more kind to many, many people, and in the same way another man, Jesus Christ, kindly gave them a great gift.

**how much more did God’s grace and the gift... abound to the many!:** Here are other ways to translate this clause:

much more did the grace of God and the gift... abound to the many (NASB)

But God’s grace is much greater, and so is his free gift to so many people (GNT)

the grace of God and the gift...have had a much greater effect

**how much more:** This phrase is emphasized in the Greek and the BSB. In some languages the meaning is more clear by not emphasizing this phrase. For example:

the grace of God and the free gift...have abounded for many people much more

This phrase emphasizes what follows. See how you translated this phrase in 5:9-10.

**abound:** This word refers to having much of something, even having more than enough. Believers have no lack of the grace of God and the free gift of Jesus Christ. Here are other ways to translate this Greek word:

overflow (NIV)

been given fully

**the gift that came by the grace of the one man, Jesus Christ:** The word by indicates that the grace of Jesus caused the free gift to be available to all people. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

the gift that came by the grace of the one man, Jesus Christ (NIV)

the gift given through the kindness of one person, Jesus Christ (GW)

**the gift:** The word here in Greek is a different word than “gift” in 5:15a. Probably “the grace of God” and the gift are parts of “the gift” of 5:15a. Some scholars think the Greek word here refers to the Holy Spirit, but others think it refers to something else. You should not say what the gift is here.

## Romans 5:16

### Section 5:12–21: We die because of Adam but live because of Jesus

In this section Paul compared the result of Adam’s sin in the Garden of Eden with the result of Jesus Christ’s sacrifice. Through the sin of Adam, the punishment of death came to all people whether they sinned like him or not. But through the sacrifice of Jesus, the gift of righteousness was given to all who believe.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

Adam and Christ (CEV)

Paul compared Adam and/with Jesus

The Results Of What Adam Did And What Jesus DidBased on Kankanaey Back Translation on TW.

### 5:16a

#### Again, the gift is not like the result of the one man’s sin:

- And this/that gift is not like what came through the one man’s sin.
- Also, that great gift is not like what that one man’s sin caused.

#### the gift is not like the result of the one man’s sin:

This clause in Greek is literally “the gift (is) not as through the one man having sinned.” There are three ways to interpret this clause:

1. The word “through” means the results or effects of. Paul said that the gift is not like what Adam’s sin caused to happen. For example:

the free gift is not like the effect of that one man’s sin (RSV) (BSB, RSV, NIV, ESV, NABRE, NASB)

1. The word “through” is to be omitted. It does not contribute to the meaning here. For example:

there is a difference between God’s gift and the sin of one man (GNT) (GNT, NJB, GW, CEV, NET, NCV)

1. The word “through” means the results or effects of, and is also implied for the gift. For example:

the result of God’s gracious gift is very different from the result of that one man’s sin (NLT) (NLT, REB)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1), because it is most consistent with the Greek text here. Cranfield, Kruse, Fitzmyer, Barrett, Stott, and Alford support interpretation (1). Moo (on TW) supports interpretation (2) in his translation, but supports interpretation (1) in his prose: “Since ‘the one who sinned’ does not make an adequate contrast with ‘the gift,’ we have to assume the point of contrast from the context; and perhaps the ‘condemnation’ from the

following verse is the best alternative. We might then paraphrase, ‘and the gift is not like the condemnation that came through the one who sinned.’” Here are other ways to translate this clause according to interpretation (1):

The gift is not like that which came through the one who sinned (NASB) The NASB uses italicized words to indicate that words they have added to give the English the correct meaning.

Another distinction between God’s gift and the result of one man’s sin is this. Kankanaey Back Translation on TW.

And here is another difference between this gift of God and that not good result of the sin of Adam. Based on the Tagbanwa Back Translation on TW.

**the gift:** The word here in Greek is the same word as in 5:15c. Translate it in the same way here.

#### 5:16b–c

**The judgment that followed one sin brought condemnation, but the gift that followed many trespasses brought justification:** There are two Greek words that combined can be translated using the English idiom “on one hand” and “on the other hand.” They contrast the two clauses. For example:

on the one hand the judgment arose from one transgression resulting in condemnation, but on the other hand the free gift arose from many transgressions resulting in justification (NASB)

A simple translation in English is but, as in the BSB.

#### 5:16b

**The judgment that followed one sin brought condemnation,**

- For that one man’s sin caused God to judge him, which then caused God to punish him,
- For God judged the one man’s one sin and said he was guilty and named/told the punishment.

In the Greek, 5:16b begins with a word that is usually translated as “for.” It introduces an explanation of 5:16a. It does not introduce a reason here. The BSB does not translate this word, but many English versions do. For example:

For (ESV)

**The judgment that followed one sin:** This refers to God judging Adam guilty of sin after Adam disobeyed God’s command. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

after the one sin, God judged him guilty

Adam sinned and then God said that he did wrong

**judgment:** This word refers to God deciding that Adam had sinned. It does not refer to punishing Adam here. For that, see the note on “condemnation.”

**one sin:** Translate the word sin as you did in 5:13b. The word one indicates that this phrase refers to the sin in the Garden of Eden when Adam disobeyed God’s command.

**brought:** Here this word means “caused.” For example:

After the one sin, came the judgment of “Guilty” (GNT)

resulting in (NASB)

**condemnation:** This word refers to how someone is punished. Adam sinned and God punished him by saying that he would die.

#### 5:16c

**but the gift that followed many trespasses brought justification.**

- but after many people’s sins the gift of what Jesus did for us caused God to make us right with him.
- But the gift of Jesus came after many sins of many people, and so God called us/people righteous/up-right.

**the gift that followed many trespasses brought justification:** This clause indicates that after many people sinned many times, Jesus reconciled us to God (the gift), which caused God to decide that a person is acceptable to him. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

the free gift arose from many transgressions resulting in justification (NASB)

God’s free gift leads to our being made right with God, even though we are guilty of many sins (NLT)

God's free gift came after many sins, and it makes people right with God (NCV)

**the gift:** The word here in Greek is the same word as in 5:15a. Translate it as you did in 5:15a.

**trespasses:** Translate this word as you did in 5:15.

**justification:** This word indicates that God decides that a person is acceptable to him. Translate this word as you did in 4:25.

### General Comment on 5:16b–c

Paul used the Greek words “from” (“followed” in the BSB) and “to” (“brought” in the BSB) in both 5:16b and 5:16c. This helps to make the differences between the two clauses more clear. If possible, use similar words in both clauses. For example:

the judicial action, following on the one offence, **resulted in** a verdict of condemnation, but the act of grace, following on so many misdeeds, **resulted in** a verdict of acquittal (REB)

After that one man sinned once, it **caused** God to judge him guilty. But after many sins God's free gift came, and it **caused** God to make people right with him

But in some languages it is better to not have exactly the same words in both places. For example:

judgment, resulting from the one transgression, **led** to condemnation, but the gracious gift from the many failures **led** to justification (NET)

following the one sin, God judged and put a burden, but following the sin of many, God's gift came and took many people and made them righteousBased on the Yongkom Back Translation, unpublished manuscript.

## Romans 5:17

### Section 5:12–21: We die because of Adam but live because of Jesus

In this section Paul compared the result of Adam's sin in the Garden of Eden with the result of Jesus Christ's sacrifice. Through the sin of Adam, the punishment of death came to all people whether they sinned like him or not. But through the sacrifice of Jesus, the gift of righteousness was given to all who believe.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

Adam and Christ (CEV)

Paul compared Adam and/with Jesus

The Results Of What Adam Did And What Jesus DidBased on Kankanaey Back Translation on TW.

### 5:17a

**For if, by the trespass of the one man, death reigned through that one man,**

- For if death ruled people's lives through that one man's sin,
- Consider this: through that one person disobeying God all people have to die. Therefore,

**For:** This word introduces an explanation of 5:16. It does not introduce a reason here.

**if, by the trespass of the one man, death reigned through that one man:** Here the word if introduces a situation that is true. If this first part is true, that supports the second part (“how much more will those who receive an abundance of grace and of the gift of righteousness reign in life through the one man, Jesus Christ”) (5:17b–c) to also be true.

Here the word if does not indicate that by the trespass of the one man, death reigned through that one man might not be true. In some languages a literal translation would indicate this incorrect meaning. If that is true in your language, translate the correct meaning without using if. For example:

consider this: death reigned through one man by that one man's trespass, therefore

it is true that death reigned through one man by that one man's trespass, therefore

death reigned through one man by that one man's trespass, therefore

**by the trespass of the one man:** There are three ways to interpret the Greek word that the BSB translates as by:

1. It introduces the way/means in which death reigned. Death rules all people by way of that one man sinning. For example:

through the sin of one man (GNT) (GNT)

1. It introduces the instrument in which death reigned. Death rules all people by that one sin of that one man. For example:

by the trespass of the one man (NIV) (BSB, NIV, NJB, NASB, KJV, NET, REB, NABRE)

1. It introduces the cause of death reigning. For example:

because of one man's trespass (ESV) (RSV, ESV, NLT, CEV, GW, NCV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1), because it fits the context best and agrees with “through” later. Moo, Cranfield, and Witherington translate it as “through.” Very few scholars discuss this and some scholars categorize their choice of English word differently than this author does. I see “means” as indicating that this act of sin by Adam making the way for death to gain power over all people. But “instrument” implies an enduring reality of that particular sin as the tool death used to gain power over all people.

**death reigned:** This phrase indicates that everyone dies. See how you translated it in 5:14.

#### 5:17b–c

**how much more will those who receive an abundance of grace and of the gift of righteousness reign in life through the one man, Jesus Christ!:** Paul first described what the word those referred to. It referred to believers. They have received an abundance of grace and of the gift of righteousness. Then Paul described what they would do: they will...reign in life.

Some languages must present this information differently to make the meaning clear. For example:

much more will believers, they receive the abundance of grace and the gift of righteousness, reign in life through the one man Jesus Christ

much more will believers reign in life through the one man Jesus Christ. They receive the abundance of grace and the gift of righteousness.

#### 5:17b

**how much more will those who receive an abundance of grace and of the gift of righteousness reign in life**

- then the people whom God gave plenty of grace and the gift of being righteous before God will much more rule in life
- believers will rule in life much more. God has given them a great amount of grace and a great gift of being upright before God.

**how much more:** Translate this phrase as you did in 5:9 or 5:15.

**will...reign in life:** This clause contrasts to “death reigned” in 5:17a. Some scholars think that this clause refers only to after God’s great judgment when believers will reign (Rev 20:4, 22:5). But some scholars think that believers reign now in a figurative way by living victorious lives. If possible translate this clause in a way that allows one or both interpretations.

Here are other ways to translate this clause:

will rule in life (GNT)

will be leaders in life with Jesus

**those who receive:** Here the word receive implies that God gave the grace and the gift. In some languages receive and “take” are translated by the same word. If a literal translation would mean “take,” use “give” instead. For example:

those whom God gave

**an abundance of grace and of the gift of righteousness:** In Greek the word abundance applies to both grace and the gift of righteousness. There will always be plenty of grace and the gift of righteousness for the believer. For example:

God’s abundant provision of grace and of the gift of righteousness (NIV)

the abundant amount of grace and the abundant amount of the free gift of righteousness

God’s abundant grace and are freely put right with him (GNT)

God’s full grace and the great gift of being made right with him (NCV)



**the gift of righteousness:** Here the word righteousness indicates that a person's relationship with God is right. See how you translated this word in 4:3.

### 5:17c

#### through the one man, Jesus Christ!

- through what one person, Jesus Christ, has done for them.
- Through what one man, Jesus Christ, did for them, they will rule.

**through the one man, Jesus Christ:** This phrase indicates that Jesus made the way to reign in life.

## Romans 5:18

### Section 5:12–21: We die because of Adam but live because of Jesus

In this section Paul compared the result of Adam's sin in the Garden of Eden with the result of Jesus Christ's sacrifice. Through the sin of Adam, the punishment of death came to all people whether they sinned like him or not. But through the sacrifice of Jesus, the gift of righteousness was given to all who believe.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

Adam and Christ (CEV)

Paul compared Adam and/with Jesus

The Results Of What Adam Did And What Jesus Did  
Based on Kankanaey Back Translation on TW.

### 5:18a–b

**just as one trespass brought condemnation for all men, so also one act of righteousness brought justification and life for all men:** The phrases just as and so also indicate that the second clause is similar to the first clause in some way. Both clauses talk of one deed that affects all people. Here are other ways to translate that meaning:

as one trespass led to condemnation for all men, so one act of righteousness leads to justification and life for all men (ESV)

as the one sin condemned all people, in the same way the one righteous act sets all people free and gives them life (GNT)

### 5:18a

**So then, just as one trespass brought condemnation for all men,**

- ¶ Therefore, as/like from one sin came condemnation/punishment for all people,
- ¶ Therefore, as God condemned all people to die because of that one sin of Adam,
- ¶ So, one sin caused all people to come under the punishment of death,

### one trespass brought condemnation for all men:

The Greek is literally “through one trespass to/for all men to/for condemnation.” For natural English a verb must be used. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

Adam's one sin brings condemnation for everyone (NLT)

condemnation for all people came through one transgression (NET)

the one sin condemned all people (GNT)

**one trespass:** Translate this phrase as you did in 5:16, where the BSB translates it as “one sin.”

**all men:** Here the word men refers to all people, men and women. See the examples above.

### 5:18b

**so also one act of righteousness brought justification and life for all men.**

- in the same way, from one righteous deed came the way to make all people right before God and have life in him.
- similarly, God calls all people who believe righteous/right and gives them life because of that one upright deed.
- and in the same way one righteous deed makes it possible for all people to be declared righteous and be given eternal life.

**one act of righteousness brought justification and life for all men:** The Greek is literally “through one act of righteousness to/for all men to/for justification and life.” For natural English a verb must be used. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

Christ's one act of righteousness brings a right relationship with God and new life for everyone (NLT)

through the one righteous act came righteousness leading to life for all people (NET)

the one righteous act sets all people free and gives them life (GNT)

**justification:** This word indicates that God decides that a person is acceptable to him. When people believe that Jesus died for their sins, God forgives them, accepts them, and considers them as righteous. See how you translated this word in 4:25.

**life:** Here this word implies eternal life and life in God while here on earth.

**all men:** Here the word men refers to all people, men and women.

## Romans 5:19

### Section 5:12–21: We die because of Adam but live because of Jesus

In this section Paul compared the result of Adam's sin in the Garden of Eden with the result of Jesus Christ's sacrifice. Through the sin of Adam, the punishment of death came to all people whether they sinned like him or not. But through the sacrifice of Jesus, the gift of righteousness was given to all who believe.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

Adam and Christ (CEV)

Paul compared Adam and/with Jesus

The Results Of What Adam Did And What Jesus Did  
Based on Kankanaey Back Translation on TW.

### 5:19a

#### For just as through the disobedience of the one man the many were made sinners,

- For as/like one man disobeyed, which caused many people to become sinners,
- For as God called all people sinners because one man disobeyed him,
- For one man disobeyed God, and so he named the many people who have lived sinners,

**For:** This word introduces an explanation of 5:18.

**through the disobedience of the one man the many were made sinners:** This clause indicates that Adam disobeyed God and that deed caused God to consider all people as sinners. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

many were made sinners because just one person disobeyed

one man disobeyed God and so God called the many people who came after that man sinners

Adam, he did not submit to God's command, with the result that many people became sinners  
Uma Back Translation on TW.

Paul also used were made to be consistent with "will be made" in 5:19b to help show the difference in the meaning between the two clauses. If possible use the same word or phrase in both clauses.

**the many:** Here this phrase refers to a large number of people. Here it refers to "all men" (5:18a, b). The same issue occurs in 5:15. Here again the BSB has translated the Greek article that means the.

### 5:19b

#### so also through the obedience of the one man the many will be made righteous.

- in the same way one man obeyed, which will cause many people to become right with God.
- similarly, God will call many people righteous because one man obeyed him.
- and in the same way one man obeyed God, and so he/God will declare many people righteous.

**through the obedience of the one man the many will be made righteous:** This clause indicates that Jesus obeyed God even to death on a cross and that deed caused God to consider all believers as righteous. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

many were made righteous because just one person obeyed

one man obeyed God and so God called many people righteous

Jesus, he submitted to God's command, with the result that many people became righteous

**the many:** See how you translated this in 5:19a.

## Romans 5:20

### Section 5:12–21: We die because of Adam but live because of Jesus

In this section Paul compared the result of Adam's sin in the Garden of Eden with the result of Jesus Christ's sacrifice. Through the sin of Adam, the punishment of death came to all people whether they sinned like him or not. But through the sacrifice of Jesus, the gift of righteousness was given to all who believe.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

Adam and Christ (CEV)

Paul compared Adam and/with Jesus

The Results Of What Adam Did And What Jesus Did  
Based on Kankanaey Back Translation on TW.

#### 5:20a

**The law came in so that the trespass would increase;**

- ¶ And/But law intruded in order that sin would increase,
- ¶ God gave the law so that people would sin even more,

In the Greek, 5:20a begins with a word that is usually translated as “but.” Here it introduces a new topic. In some languages it is best to omit this word, as the BSB does.

**The law:** This phrase refers to the Jewish laws, including the ten commandments. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

The Law (CEV)

God’s law (NLT)

**came in:** The Greek word is literally “entered alongside” or “intruded.” Dunn (page 286) says this Greek word has a “negative overtone.” Moo (on TW) says it does not indicate “evil purpose” but is not “a completely neutral significance either.” God added the Law to people’s lives. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

entered people’s lives

was added (NIV)

was introduced (GNT)

**so that the trespass would increase:** The words so that introduces a purpose for the law coming. This clause indicates that the awareness and seriousness of sin increased. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

to increase the trespass (ESV)

when sin grew worse (NCV)

**the trespass:** Translate this word as you did in 5:18.

#### 5:20b

**but where sin increased,**

- but when people sinned more and more,
- but as people sinned more,

**but where sin increased:** The word where connects this clause to the clause in 5:20c. It indicates that as the awareness and seriousness of sin increased, grace increased even more. In some languages a different word is used for this meaning. For example:

as sins increased

however much sin increased (NJB)

**sin:** Here this word means the same thing as “trespass” in 5:20a. In some languages using two different words would indicate two different things. If that is true in your language, use the same word here as in 5:20a. For example:

trespasses/sins

Some languages may need to use the plural here too.

#### 5:20c

**grace increased all the more,**

- grace increased even more than that,
- God was still more kind, even beyond the sin.

**grace increased:** This clause indicates that God was kind even more as the awareness and seriousness of sin increased. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

grace abounded (ESV)

God’s kindness increased (GW)

**all the more:** As people sinned, God was even more kind to them. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

much more (GNT)

even more (GW)

exceeded it (REV)

## Romans 5:21

### Section 5:12–21: We die because of Adam but live because of Jesus

In this section Paul compared the result of Adam's sin in the Garden of Eden with the result of Jesus Christ's sacrifice. Through the sin of Adam, the punishment of death came to all people whether they sinned like him or not. But through the sacrifice of Jesus, the gift of righteousness was given to all who believe.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

Adam and Christ (CEV)

Paul compared Adam and/with Jesus

The Results Of What Adam Did And What Jesus Did  
Based on Kankanaey Back Translation on TW.

#### 5:21a–b

**so that, just as sin reigned in death, so also grace might reign through righteousness:** The phrase so that introduces the purpose of grace abounding all the more (5:20c). The purpose is that grace will reign.

Paul included a comparison to sin reigning in this purpose clause. In some languages it is more clear or more natural to have the comparison to sin after. For example:

so that grace might reign through righteousness,  
like/as sin reigned in death,

#### 5:21a

**so that, just as sin reigned in death,**

- in order that, just like sin ruled in this world of death,
- God is more kind so that, as sin ruled people's lives under the power of death,

**sin reigned:** This clause speaks of sin as if it were a person. It indicates that all people sin. Some languages can translate the figure of speech literally and people will understand the correct meaning. For example:

sin ruled (GNT)

But some languages must translate the meaning of the figure of speech. For example:

sin had power over all who lived

See how you translated reigned in 5:14.

**in death:** Here this phrase is a figure of speech. It indicates that sin was like a king in the land of death. Moo (on TW) says: "Death has its own dominion: humanity as determined, and dominated, by Adam. And in this dominion, sin is in control." Schreiner (page 296) says, "Death is portrayed as a power that rules over all ('death reigned from Adam to Moses,' v. 14...)." Some languages can translate the figure of speech literally and people will understand the correct meaning.

But some languages must translate the meaning of the figure of speech. For example:

in the land of death

in this world of death

#### 5:21b

**so also grace might reign through righteousness**

- grace will also rule by means of righteousness,
- so too God's kindness will rule people's lives

**grace might reign:** This clause speaks of grace as if it were a person. It indicates that God is kind to all people. Some languages can translate the figure of speech literally and people will understand the correct meaning. For example:

grace will/might rule

But some languages must translate the meaning of the figure of speech. For example:

grace will have power over all who lived

**through righteousness:** This phrase refers to God making believers righteous. Dunn (page 287) says, "Here again the sense should not be forcibly confined to the sense 'status of righteousness' (Cranfield), but must at least include the sense of God's action." Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

by means of righteousness (GNT)

by making people right with him (NCV)

#### 5:21c

**to bring eternal life through Jesus Christ our Lord.**

- and that leads to life forever by means of what our Lord Jesus Christ did.
- through all that Jesus Christ our Leader/Master did. This results in life that never ends.

**to bring eternal life:** When God declares believers righteous, the result is eternal life. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

and resulting in eternal life (NLT)

This means that we will have eternal life (CEV)

**through Jesus Christ our Lord:** Believers receive righteousness and eternal life because of what Jesus did for them.

In this division Paul showed that God has made a way to rescue people from being punished for wrongdoing and put them in a right relationship with himself.

Here are other possible headings for this division:

We must live as dead to sin and the Laws of Moses and live in the Holy Spirit

Living free from sin and the law and living in the Holy Spirit

## Romans 6:1

### Section 6:1–14: We must live for God because we died to sin

In this section, Paul told the believers in Rome that they should not continue to sin, because baptism symbolizes death to sin. Jesus' resurrection symbolizes the new life that believers can live in. The believers' old way of life is crucified on the cross of Jesus so that they have no need to follow the desires to sin. Believers will live new lives for God and death no longer rules them, because Jesus died and was raised for them. Therefore believers should consider themselves dead to sin and do the good deeds that God wants them to do. God's grace removes believers from the rule of sin in their lives.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

Believers are dead to sin, so they must live for God

Dead to Sin, Alive in Christ (NIV)

We are no longer slaves to sin, but God's servants

### 6:1a

#### What then shall we say?

- ¶ So then, should we<sup>(incl)</sup> ask this question?
- ¶ Therefore, is it right to say that
- ¶ And so, let's not ask this,

**What then shall we say?:** The word then indicates a connection to previous verses. Here it introduces the question "What shall we say?" In some languages, it is more natural to have the word then first. For example:

Then/Therefore, what shall we say?

This is a rhetorical question. It introduces the next question (6:1b–c). Paul did not expect the readers to answer this question. Here are other ways to translate this question:

Shall we say this?

What then are we to say? (NRSV)

In some languages, it is more natural to avoid this kind of question. For example:

So do you think we should continue sinning...?  
(NCV)

Well now, is it good ifTagbanwa Back Translation on TW.

But let's not say/think like this:Uma Back Translation on TW.

Maybe we might say this:

there is perhaps a person who will say thatWestern Bukidnon Manobo Back Translation on TW.

**shall we say:** The Greek tense is the future tense ("will we say"). Here it indicates what someone might say. See the examples above.

### 6:1b–c

**Shall we continue in sin so that grace may increase?:** In 5:20 Paul said that an increase in sin resulted in an abundance of grace. Someone might misunderstand Paul's words and think that he should continue sinning in order to receive more grace from God. Here Paul referred to that thinking with this

question. He showed that this thinking was clearly wrong with the words “Certainly not” in 6:2.

This is a rhetorical question. But Paul answered it himself in 6:2. So you should translate these words as a question here. Here are other ways to translate this question:

Shall we go on sinning so that grace may increase? (NIV)

Is it possible that we continue to commit sin in order that God will all the more give us his grace?  
Otomí Back Translation on TW.

is it good if we continue to do sin just so that this grace/mercy of God will continue to be abundant toward us? Tagbanwa Back Translation on TW.

Paul expected that his readers would agree that it is wrong for anyone to think he should continue sinning to receive more grace. In some languages indicating that this thinking is wrong must be done another way. For example:

Is it right to say that we should continue to sin so that grace might increase?

It is wrong to say that we should continue to sin so that grace might increase.

### 6:1b

#### Shall we continue in sin

- Maybe we<sup>(incl)</sup> will continually sin
- we should never stop sinning
- “Perhaps we believers should continue doing evil,

**continue in sin:** This phrase refers to continuing to sin, instead of trying to do the things that God wants believers to do. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

remain in sin (NJB)

persist in sin (REB)

do not abandon doing evil Western Bukidnon Manobo Back Translation on TW.

### 6:1c

#### so that grace may increase?

- in order that God will be more and more kind to us?
- so that God’s grace/kindness to us may grow?
- so that there will be more and more times when God will be kind to us.”

**so that:** Here this word introduces the purpose for continuing to sin.

**grace:** Here the word grace indicates that God does something kind or helpful. People do not deserve this help. See how you translated this word in 1:7 or 5:2.

**may increase:** Here the word increase refers to grace getting larger/more abundant. See how you translated this word in 5:20 (“increased,” “abounded”).

## Romans 6:2

### Section 6:1–14: We must live for God because we died to sin

In this section, Paul told the believers in Rome that they should not continue to sin, because baptism symbolizes death to sin. Jesus’ resurrection symbolizes the new life that believers can live in. The believers’ old way of life is crucified on the cross of Jesus so that they have no need to follow the desires to sin. Believers will live new lives for God and death no longer rules them, because Jesus died and was raised for them. Therefore believers should consider themselves dead to sin and do the good deeds that God wants them to do. God’s grace removes believers from the rule of sin in their lives.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

Believers are dead to sin, so they must live for God

Dead to Sin, Alive in Christ (NIV)

We are no longer slaves to sin, but God’s servants

### 6:2a

#### Certainly not!

- By no means! (ESV)
- No indeed!

**Certainly not!:** The Greek is literally “May it not be.” It indicates a very strong “no.” Believers are not to continue sinning so that God will be more gracious to them. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

Not at all!

By no means! (ESV)

Of course not! (NLT)

No, indeed!

The words you use here should support that believers are not to continue sinning so that God will be more gracious to them. See how you translated this phrase in 3:4 or 3:31.

### 6:2b

#### How can we who died to sin live in it any longer?

- We<sup>(incl)</sup> have died to sin! So how should we be living in it?
- Regarding sin, we have become as/like dead to it, and we must not live under the authority of sin.
- We are no longer under the power/authority of sin. So should we continue to live as if we still were under that power/authority? No!

#### How can we who died to sin live in it any longer?:

The Greek word that the BSB translates as can is literally the future tense. There are two ways to interpret it:

1. It indicates that believers must not still live in sin. For example:

We have died to sin; how could we go on living in it? (NJB) (NJB, KJV)

1. It indicates that believers are unable to still live in sin. For example:

How is it possible that we who died to sin still live in it? (BSB, RSV, NIV, GNT, ESV, NABRE, NLT, GW, CEV, NET, REB, NCV)

It is difficult to decide which interpretation is best. It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1), because 6:3–4 seems to be an exhortation to live in the new way of life as a Christian, which allows that living in sin might be possible for Christians. Wallace (page 570) says Paul “is asking the rightness...of such a lifestyle,” but adds “even the possibility of (it).” Moo (on TW) says that interpretation (1) “appears to be closer to the truth.” A number of scholars translate as “How shall we,” which to this author implies interpretation (1), but say that to live that way is impossible (interpretation (2)).

**How can we...live in it any longer?:** This is a rhetorical question. It emphasizes that believers cannot or should not still live in sin. Translate this clause with that meaning. Here are some ways:

- As a rhetorical question. For example:

how could we go on living in it? (NJB)

- As a statement. For example:

It is wrong to suppose/expect that we should still live in it/sin.

- As a command. For example:

Do not suppose/expect that we should still live in it/sin.

**live in it any longer:** This figure of speech speaks of sin as if it were a place to live. By living in this place, it indicates that we are controlled by sin.

Some languages can translate this figure of speech literally and the meaning of the translation is correct. But in some languages the correct meaning must be translated in another way. For example:

still live under sin’s influence (GW)

still obey/follow it

go on sinning (CEV)

**we who died to sin:** The clause we who died to sin refers to all believers. In some languages the word who would wrongly indicate that only some believers have died to sin. If that is true in your language, translate in a way that refers to all believers. For example:

We have died to sin, so how can we still live in it?

Also, the words “we have died to sin” is a true statement. Those words are not being questioned. In some languages they must be separated from the question. For example:

We have died to sin. So how can we still live in it?

**died to sin:** This figure of speech indicates that sin no longer has power over us. Some languages must change this metaphor into a simile. For example:

became as a dead person to sin

became as if dead to sin telling us what to do

became as if dead to the commands to sin

**sin:** The singular word sin refers to sin as a concept. Here its power to make people sin is implied. In some languages, a different translation is necessary to make that clear. For example:

sins

the power of sin

## Romans 6:3

### Section 6:1–14: We must live for God because we died to sin

In this section, Paul told the believers in Rome that they should not continue to sin, because baptism symbolizes death to sin. Jesus' resurrection symbolizes the new life that believers can live in. The believers' old way of life is crucified on the cross of Jesus so that they have no need to follow the desires to sin. Believers will live new lives for God and death no longer rules them, because Jesus died and was raised for them. Therefore believers should consider themselves dead to sin and do the good deeds that God wants them to do. God's grace removes believers from the rule of sin in their lives.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

Believers are dead to sin, so they must live for God

Dead to Sin, Alive in Christ (NIV)

We are no longer slaves to sin, but God's servants

#### 6:3a

#### Or aren't you aware that

- Or are you<sup>(plur)</sup> ignorant of the fact that
- Or maybe you do not know that
- Know this:

#### 6:3a–c

**Or:** This word probably introduces another way (after 6:2) to strengthen Paul's point about not continuing in sin (6:1).

#### aren't you aware that all of us who were baptized into Christ Jesus were baptized into His death?:

This is a rhetorical question. It emphasizes that the believers in Rome know that all believers are baptized

into his death or that they should easily agree with Paul's words here. Cranfield (page 300) says, "the Christians in Rome are likely to know." But Dunn (page 308) says, "The parallel with 7:1...suggests that some element of further or fuller teaching is in view—either a point that is obvious (as soon as one thinks about it) rather than a point already familiar, or that Paul deduces an obvious corollary ('baptized into his death') from... 'baptized into Christ,' or that he draws attention to an aspect of a familiar teaching which has been overlooked or neglected." Schreiner (page 306) says something similar to what Cranfield says, and Jewett (page 396) says something similar to Dunn. It is impossible to be certain about either option. It is not a rebuke. Translate this clause with that meaning. Here are some ways:

- As a rhetorical question. For example:

Have you forgotten that when we were baptized into union with Christ Jesus we were baptized into his death? (REB)

Maybe you do not know that all of us who have been baptized into Christ Jesus were baptized into his death?

- As a statement. For example:

You cannot have forgotten that all of us, when we were baptised into Christ Jesus, were baptised into his death. (NJB)

Maybe you do not know that all of us who have been baptized into Christ Jesus were baptized into his death.

- As a command. For example:

Do not forget that all of us, when we were baptized into Christ Jesus, were baptized into his death.

You must remember that all of us who have been baptized into Christ Jesus were baptized into his death.

#### 6:3b

#### all of us who were baptized into Christ Jesus

- we<sup>(incl)</sup> all have been baptized, and therefore we have a relationship with Jesus, the Christ/Messiah,



- when/When someone baptized each of us, God joined us with Jesus, the one/person whom God appointed to save/rescue people,

**all of us who were baptized into Christ Jesus:** Here the word who introduces something more that Paul wanted to say about the phrase all of us. It does not separate some believers from other believers. For the correct meaning in some languages, translators must avoid the word who. For example:

All of us have been baptized into Christ Jesus.  
Do you not know that we were baptized into his death?

**who were baptized:** This clause is passive. Some languages must use an active clause. Refer generally to other believers baptizing them. For example:

whom someone/they baptized

**into Christ Jesus:** Usually, the phrase after “baptized” is “in the name of Jesus Christ.” Here it is likely that Paul meant something different than “in the name of,” which refers to his authority. Here into probably indicates that believers have a strong relationship with Jesus. Moo (on TW), Stott (page 173), and Morris (on TW) say it means “into union with,” indicating a strong relationship. Lenski (page 390) says it means “in connection with.” But Jewett (page 397) says, “points metaphorically to a mystical and corporate reality of the new community ‘in Christ.’ ” And Cranfield and Barrett say it is equivalent to “in the name of.” Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

into union with Christ Jesus (GNT)

joined with Christ Jesus (NLT)

united/tied-together with Jesu-CristoTagbanwa  
Back Translation on TW.

in our connection with Kristus YesusUma Back  
Translation on TW.

**Christ Jesus:** The order of the words Christ Jesus emphasizes that Jesus is the Christ/Messiah. See how you translated this phrase in 1:1.

### 6:3c

#### **were baptized into His death?**

- and that baptism also caused us to die with him?

- and in that baptism God has also joined us to him in death.
- and he/God has also caused us to share in his/Jesus’ death.

**were baptized into His death:** This refers to the same baptism as in 6:3b. It is not a separate baptism. In some languages this clause must be translated differently to indicate that. For example:

it/they baptized us into his death

that baptism also baptized us into his death

**were baptized:** This clause is passive. Some languages must use an active clause. See the examples above.

**into His death:** Here into probably indicates that believers have a strong connection with Jesus’ death. Moo (on TW) says it “joins him or her with the death of Christ.” Morris (on TW) says it indicates that believers are “united with him in his death.” Lenski (page 390) says it means “in connection with.” It implies that believers are dead to sin’s rule in their lives. Jewett (page 398) and Witherington (page 158). Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

into union with his death (GNT)

joined him in his death (NLT)

united/tied-together with him in his death

died together with HimUma Back Translation on  
TW.

## **Romans 6:4**

### **Section 6:1–14: We must live for God because we died to sin**

In this section, Paul told the believers in Rome that they should not continue to sin, because baptism symbolizes death to sin. Jesus’ resurrection symbolizes the new life that believers can live in. The believers’ old way of life is crucified on the cross of Jesus so that they have no need to follow the desires to sin. Believers will live new lives for God and death no longer rules them, because Jesus died and was raised for them. Therefore believers should consider themselves dead to sin and do the good deeds that God wants them to do. God’s grace removes believers from the rule of sin in their lives.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

Believers are dead to sin, so they must live for God

Dead to Sin, Alive in Christ (NIV)

We are no longer slaves to sin, but God's servants

#### 6:4a

**We were therefore buried with Him through baptism into death,**

- Therefore we<sup>(incl)</sup> were also buried with him through that baptism that caused us to die,
- Therefore, when someone baptized us, God has joined us to him/Jesus in death and has also joined us to him in his burial,
- In that baptism and sharing in his/Jesus' death, God has also caused us to share in his/Jesus burial,

**We were therefore buried with Him:** It is natural in English to put the word therefore in the middle of the clause. In many languages it is more natural to put it at the beginning of the clause. For example:

Therefore, we were buried with him

**We were...buried with Him:** This clause is passive. Some languages must use an active clause here. For example:

God buried us with him

**were...buried:** Baptism is a symbol for burial. In some languages a simile must be used. For example:

were like someone who had been buried

**through baptism into death:** The word through indicates that baptism is the way that believers are "buried with him." Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

by baptism into death (ESV)

by means of our being baptized...it was like we were the ones who died  
Western Bukidnon Manobo Back Translation on TW.

we have become as if dead and buried with him when we were baptized

and it is as if that baptism caused us to die

**into death:** Here this phrase refers to being dead-Witherington (page 158). to the old way of life on this earth, Kruse (page 261). characterized by sin. It contrasts to "walk in newness of life" (6:4d). See the examples above.

#### 6:4b,d

**in order that,...we too may walk in newness of life.**

- so that we may/should walk according to the new life,
- so that we will live a new kind/way of life,

#### 6:4b,d (reordered)

This author has reordered this verse to put the purpose clause immediately after the words that introduce it.

**in order that:** This phrase introduces a purpose. We, as believers, are like dead people in regard to a life of sin on this earth, so we are to live a new kind of life as followers of Jesus. For example:

so that (NJB)

**we...may walk in newness of life:** The word walk is a metaphor for how someone behaves over a period of time. Here it refers to living according to the new life that God gives to believers. Some languages must translate the meaning without the metaphor. For example:

we might live according to the new life

we also may live new lives (NLT)

**may:** Here this word helps to indicate that walking in this way is a purpose of being buried through baptism into death (6:4a). It suggests that it would be good if we walked in newness of life. Here are other ways to translate this word:

might (ESV)

would

to walk in newness of life

**newness of life:** This phrase refers to a new way of life. Cranfield (page 305) and Schreiner (page 311). Jewett (page 399) calls it "a new lifestyle." Here it refers to the new way of life that the Holy Spirit gives to

believers and is characterized by righteousness (8:9–11). Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

a new life (NIV)

a new kind of life (NLT)

a new way-of-lifeKankanaey Back Translation on TW.

The Greek does not have the word “the” here, but Paul only had one kind of new life in mind: the new life as a believer. Your translation should indicate that Paul had only one kind of new life in mind.

**too:** Here this word compares “we might walk in newness of life” with “Christ was raised from the dead by the glory of the Father.” In the reordered sentence, this meaning is not needed here. The phrase “just as” in 6:4c indicates that meaning.

#### 6:4c

**just as Christ was raised from the dead through the glory of the Father,**

- just like Jesus Christ was raised to life again from the dead by/through the glorious power of the Father.
- in the same way as God caused the Christ/Messiah to leave the spirits of dead people and be alive again with/using his awesome/amazing power.

**just as Christ was raised from the dead through the glory of the Father:** The words just as indicate that Paul compared “walking in newness of life” to Jesus being raised from the dead through the glory of the Father.

**Christ was raised from the dead through the glory of the Father:** This clause is passive. It is implied that God raised Jesus by means of his glory. In a Greek passive clause, the person who actually did it is in a phrase that begins with hupo. There is no hupo phrase here. Here the word that the BSB translates as “through” is the Greek word dia. This word indicates the means in which something is done. See Wallace (page 164). Some languages must use an active clause here. For example:

God the Father raised Christ from the dead by his glory

**raised from the dead:** This phrase refers to God making Jesus alive again after he died and was put in the tomb. See how you translated this phrase in 4:24.

**the glory of the Father:** The word glory refers literally to a very bright light. In this context it implies power that is glorious, majestic, or great in some way. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

the Father’s glorious power (NJB)

the wonderful power of the Father (NCV)

## Romans 6:5

### Section 6:1–14: We must live for God because we died to sin

In this section, Paul told the believers in Rome that they should not continue to sin, because baptism symbolizes death to sin. Jesus’ resurrection symbolizes the new life that believers can live in. The believers’ old way of life is crucified on the cross of Jesus so that they have no need to follow the desires to sin. Believers will live new lives for God and death no longer rules them, because Jesus died and was raised for them. Therefore believers should consider themselves dead to sin and do the good deeds that God wants them to do. God’s grace removes believers from the rule of sin in their lives.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

Believers are dead to sin, so they must live for God

Dead to Sin, Alive in Christ (NIV)

We are no longer slaves to sin, but God’s servants

#### 6:5a–b

**if we have been united with Him like this in His death, we will certainly also be united with Him in His resurrection:** Here, the word if introduces a situation that is true. If this first part is true, that supports the second part (we will certainly also be united with Him in His resurrection).

Here the word if does not indicate that we have been united with Him like this in His death might not be true. In some languages a literal translation would indicate this incorrect meaning. If that is true in your language, translate the correct meaning without using if. For example:

consider this: we have been united with him like this in his death, therefore we will also certainly be united with him in his resurrection

it is true that we have been united with him like this in his death, therefore we will also certainly be united with him in his resurrection

we have been united with him like this in his death, therefore we will also certainly be united with him in his resurrection

#### 6:5a

**For if we have been united with Him like this in His death,**

- ¶ For if/since we<sup>(incl)</sup> have been joined with him/Christ when we experienced a death like his,
- ¶ For God has made us one with him/Christ when we died to a/our life of sin, which was like his death,

**For:** This word introduces support for what Paul said in 6:4 and also an explanation of it. Schreiner (page 311). Some languages can omit this word and the connection is still clear.

**we have been united with Him:** This clause is passive. Some languages must use an active clause here. For example:

God has united us with him

**united with Him:** Here this phrase refers to symbolically/mystically sharing with Jesus in his experience of death. We are joined to Jesus in some way. We have not yet died physically like he did. But something about his death is true for us now as well. Here are other ways to translate this word:

joined (NJB)

become one (GNT)

connected

**like this in His death:** Here the word in indicates that His death was the situation in which God united us with Jesus. We share some of the characteristics of his death.

**like this:** Here the words like this indicate that the death that believers share is in many ways like the death of Jesus, but is not the same in all ways.

#### 6:5b

**we will certainly also be united with Him in His resurrection.**

- we will certainly be joined with him when we are raised to life again from the dead like he was.
- therefore God will certainly make us one with him/Christ when he will raise us from death to be alive again like he/Christ was.

**we will certainly also be united with Him in His resurrection:** The BSB adds the words united with Him. They are clearly implied from 6:5a. Moo (on TW). This clause is what Paul said is also true based on what he said in 6:5a. For example:

then we will also certainly be united with him in his resurrection

in the same way we... (GNT)

so we... (NJB)

**in His resurrection:** The word resurrection refers to God making Jesus alive again after he was dead. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

in being raised from death like he was

when God raises us from the dead like he raised him/Jesus/Christ

when God causes us to live again after we die, like he did with him/Jesus

See how you translated the word resurrection in 1:4 or 4:24 ("raised from the dead").

## Romans 6:6

**Section 6:1–14: We must live for God because we died to sin**

In this section, Paul told the believers in Rome that they should not continue to sin, because baptism symbolizes death to sin. Jesus' resurrection symbolizes the new life that believers can live in. The believers' old way of life is crucified on the cross of Jesus so that they have no need to follow the desires to sin. Believers will live new lives for God and death no longer rules them, because Jesus died and was raised for them. Therefore believers should consider themselves dead to sin and do the good deeds that God wants them to do. God's grace removes believers from the rule of sin in their lives.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

Believers are dead to sin, so they must live for God

Dead to Sin, Alive in Christ (NIV)

We are no longer slaves to sin, but God's servants

### 6:6a

#### **We know that our old self was crucified with Him**

- ¶ We<sup>(incl)</sup> realize this: the kind of people we used to be was nailed to the cross with him,
- ¶ And it is clear to us that God ended/destroyed our former bad/sinful way of life when the Christ/Messiah was crucified,
- ¶ For we know that when people nailed him to the cross, God also put our old bad character/life there as if to die with him/Jesus,

The Greek here has no conjunction. Paul continued to support what he said in 6:4. Some languages would use “and” to indicate that kind of connection. Some languages would repeat “for” from 6:5. For example:

And (GNT)

For (NIV)

**We know that our old self:** The Greek is literally “knowing this that our old person.” The word “this” introduces the words that follow. The word that also introduces those words. For example:

We know this: that our old self...

In many languages it is more natural to translate only “this” or that. For example:

We know this: our old self...

We know that our old self...

**We know:** This introduces something that Paul knew, and perhaps others of his co-workers knew also. He wanted his readers to know it, so he included them in knowing this, whether they actually did or not. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

realizing (NJB)

now it is clear to us

**our old self was crucified with Him:** This clause is passive. Some languages must use an active clause here. It is hard to know what these words imply about who did the crucifying. Scholars mention that this occurred at our baptism but not who did it.

If you cannot use a passive clause, you may want to:

- Add a general reference that does not refer to anyone in particular. For example:

they crucified our old self with him/Jesus

- Use the words “die on a cross,” or similar. For example:

our old self died on the cross with him/Jesus

**our old self:** This phrase refers to the kind of people that believers were before they started believing in Jesus. We all lived according to the ways of this world and lived a life of sin. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

our old being (GNT)

the person we used to be (GW)

our old humanity (REB)

our former lifeKankanaey Back Translation on TW.

our former sinful nature/waysTagbanwa Back Translation on TW.

**crucified with Him:** The word crucified refers to being nailed to a cross and hanging there until dead. Here it is a metaphor for the destruction of our old self. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

put to death with Christ on his cross (GNT)

nailed to the cross with him

was included in his being nailed to the crossKankanaey Back Translation on TW.

Some languages must translate the metaphor as a simile to make the meaning clear. For example:

like nailed along with Cristo on the crossTag-banwa Back Translation on TW.

as if it was nailed along with Christ on the cross so that it might dieWestern Bukidnon Manobo Back Translation on TW.

### 6:6b

**so that the body of sin might be rendered powerless,**

- so that the existence that was ruled by sin would be destroyed,
- and so God/he destroyed that life of sin,

**(NIV:) so that the body of sin might be done away with:** The phrase so that introduces a purpose for crucifying the old self. God has already done away with the body of sin. In some languages a purpose clause would indicate that this has not happened yet. If that is true in your language, use a result clause. For example:

and so the body of sin has been done away with

**(NIV:) the body of sin might be done away with:** This clause is passive. Some languages must use an active clause. As with “was crucified” above, it is not clear who did this action (done away). For example:

they might do away with the body of sin

the body of sin might become nothing

**(NIV:) the body of sin:** The Greek word that the NIV translates as body refers here to the whole person.Cranfield (page 309) and Schreiner (page 316). It refers to all of what we are as human beings. The words of sin indicate that sin rules the lives of people.

In many languages a literal translation would not have the correct meaning. If that is true in your language, translate the meaning. For example:

the self which belonged to sin (NJB)

sin...in our lives (NLT)

our always having to sin was removedWestern Bukidnon Manobo Back Translation on TW.

**(NIV:) might be done away with:** There are two ways to interpret the Greek word here:

1. It means destroy here. For example:

might be destroyed (RSV) (RSV, NIV, GNT, NJB, NASB, NABRE, KJV, GW, REB)

1. It means lose its power here. For example:

might lose its power (NLT) (BSB, ESV, NLT, NET, NCV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1), because the BDAG and other scholars support it.

### 6:6c

**that we should no longer be slaves to sin.**

- and so that we would no longer under the rule of sin.
- and so also sin no longer rules/leads us.

**that we should no longer be slaves to sin:** The word that introduces a second purpose for crucifying the old self. For example:

so that the sinful body might be destroyed, and we might no longer be enslaved to sin (RSV)

In some languages a purpose clause would indicate that this has not happened yet. If that is true in your language, use a result clause. For example:

and also so we are no longer enslaved to sin

**we should no longer be slaves to sin:** The words be slaves is a metaphor. It indicates that we would no longer be like a slave to sin, obeying every sinful thought. Some languages must translate the meaning another way. For example:

we would no longer be like slaves to sin

no longer does sin rule us as though it were our bossesOtomi Back Translation on TW.

**be slaves to sin:** The phrase be slaves refers to being made a slave, someone owned by another person, to do his/her will all day long. They worked for their owner/master without receiving pay, but the owner gave them food, clothing, and shelter. They had very few rights of their own.

In some cultures, slaves may not be known. In other cultures, the word for slave may imply different customs than in biblical culture. If that is true in your language, here are some ways to translate this:

made a person who belonged to sin

caused to be an owned person of sin

made a person who serves sin

made a worker/servant of sin

The words be slaves is a metaphor for being completely under the rule of someone or something. Some languages may need to avoid the metaphor to make the meaning clear. For example:

made to be under the rule of sin

made a person lead by sin

## Romans 6:7

### Section 6:1–14: We must live for God because we died to sin

In this section, Paul told the believers in Rome that they should not continue to sin, because baptism symbolizes death to sin. Jesus' resurrection symbolizes the new life that believers can live in. The believers' old way of life is crucified on the cross of Jesus so that they have no need to follow the desires to sin. Believers will live new lives for God and death no longer rules them, because Jesus died and was raised for them. Therefore believers should consider themselves dead to sin and do the good deeds that God wants them to do. God's grace removes believers from the rule of sin in their lives.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

Believers are dead to sin, so they must live for God

Dead to Sin, Alive in Christ (NIV)

We are no longer slaves to sin, but God's servants

## 6:7

**For anyone who has died has been freed from sin.**

- For someone who has died is free from the rule of sin
- For when a person dies, God frees him so that sins no longer rule him.

**For:** This word introduces a clause that supports what Paul said in 6:6c.

**anyone who has died has been freed from sin:** This clause is passive. Some languages must use an active clause here. For example:

God has set free from sin the one who has died

**anyone who has died:** Some scholars think this clause refers to believers, connecting to 6:5, but others think it refers generally to people. A literal translation allows for either interpretation. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

one who has died (ESV)

Someone who has died (NJB)

**freed from sin:** These words refer to no longer being under the power of sin. Some languages use an idiom for this meaning. For example:

untied from sin

**sin:** The singular word sin refers to sin as a concept. Here its power to make people sin is implied. In some languages, a different translation is necessary to make that clear. For example:

sins

the power of sin

See how you translated this word in 6:2.

### General Comment on 6:7

Paul used the singular here. In some languages a plural would be more natural. For example:

For those who have died have been set free from sin

## Romans 6:8

### Section 6:1–14: We must live for God because we died to sin

In this section, Paul told the believers in Rome that they should not continue to sin, because baptism symbolizes death to sin. Jesus' resurrection symbolizes the new life that believers can live in. The believers' old way of life is crucified on the cross of Jesus so that they have no need to follow the desires to sin. Believers will live new lives for God and death no longer rules them, because Jesus died and was raised for them. Therefore believers should consider themselves dead to sin and do the good deeds that God wants them to do. God's grace removes believers from the rule of sin in their lives.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

Believers are dead to sin, so they must live for God

Dead to Sin, Alive in Christ (NIV)

We are no longer slaves to sin, but God's servants

#### 6:8a–b

**if we died with Christ, we believe that we will also live with Him:** Here, the word *if* introduces a situation that is true. If this first part is true, that supports the second part (we believe that we will also live with Him).

Here the word *if* does not indicate that we died with Christ might not be true. In some languages a literal translation would indicate this incorrect meaning. If that is true in your language, translate the correct meaning without using *if*. For example:

consider this: we died with Christ, therefore we believe that we will also live with him

it is true that we have been united with him in a death like his, therefore we believe that we will also live with him

we have been united with him in a death like his, therefore we believe that we will also live with him

#### 6:8a

#### Now if we died with Christ,

- ¶ And if/since we<sup>(incl)</sup> have become dead with Christ,

- ¶ We are as if dead, sharing the Christ's/Messiah's death,

**Now:** The Greek word that the BSB translates as *Now* indicates that Paul added something new to his discussion here. In English the word *Now* does something similar. It does not mean “at the present time” here. Some languages would use “And,” some languages would omit this word, and some languages would use another word or phrase for that meaning.

**we died with Christ:** This is a metaphor for part of what happens when we first believe in Jesus as the Christ. In some languages a literal translation would wrongly refer to our physical body dying. If that is true in your language, translate the correct meaning. For example:

we have become as if dead, sharing in the death of Christ

we were included/joined in dying in Cristo's deathKankanaey Back Translation on TW.

as for our former evil nature/ways, (they were) included along with Cristo in being killedTagbanwa Back Translation on TW.

#### 6:8b

#### we believe that we will also live with Him.

- then we believe/say it is true that we will also live with him.
- therefore we say that the words/saying “We will also continue to live with him” is true.

**we believe that:** The word that indicates that “we will also live with him” is what believers believe to be true. The word *believe* does not refer to believing in Jesus here. In some languages *believe* is only used in the sense of “believing in someone.” If that is true in your language, translate the correct meaning. For example:

we say it is true that

**we will also live with Him:** Some scholars think this refers to living with Jesus in the future, renewed world. For example Dunn (page 322) and Schreiner (page 320). Others think it refers to our time on earth. For example Jewett (page 406) and Cranfield (page 312). And others think it is both. For example Moo (on TW) and Morris (on TW). If possible, allow the future to refer to or imply both.



## Romans 6:9

### Section 6:1–14: We must live for God because we died to sin

In this section, Paul told the believers in Rome that they should not continue to sin, because baptism symbolizes death to sin. Jesus' resurrection symbolizes the new life that believers can live in. The believers' old way of life is crucified on the cross of Jesus so that they have no need to follow the desires to sin. Believers will live new lives for God and death no longer rules them, because Jesus died and was raised for them. Therefore believers should consider themselves dead to sin and do the good deeds that God wants them to do. God's grace removes believers from the rule of sin in their lives.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

Believers are dead to sin, so they must live for God

Dead to Sin, Alive in Christ (NIV)

We are no longer slaves to sin, but God's servants

#### 6:9a–b

**since Christ was raised from the dead, He cannot die again:** The clause since Christ was raised from the dead is the basis by which Paul said that He cannot die again. Some languages must translate it in a different way. For example:

Christ was raised from the dead, and so will never die again

#### 6:9a

**For we know that since Christ was raised from the dead,**

- For we<sup>(incl)</sup> know that the Christ/Messiah, who was raised to life again from the dead,
- We know this: God caused Jesus, the one/person whom God appointed to save/rescue people, to leave the spirits of dead people and be alive again,

**For we know:** The Greek is literally “knowing.” Some scholars call it causal (“because (we) know”) and other scholars say it introduces an explanation or clarification. Some English versions translate in a way that allows both interpretations, as the BSB does.

**Christ was raised from the dead:** This clause refers to God making Jesus alive again. See how you translated a similar clause in 6:4 (“was raised from the dead”).

#### 6:9b

**He cannot die again;**

- will not die again; therefore,
- and he/Jesus will certainly not die again, and so

**He cannot die again:** In English the semi-colon (;) at the end of this clause indicates that there is a connection to the words that come next. But it does not say which kind of connection. Here it implies a grounds-conclusion relationship. For example:

will never die again, so

**cannot...again:** The words cannot...again means “not at any time.”

#### 6:9c

**death no longer has dominion over Him.**

- death does not rule over him any more.
- the power of death cannot affect/influence him again.

**death no longer has dominion over Him:** The Greek word that the BSB translates as has dominion refers to having great authority over someone. This clause indicates that while Jesus lived on this earth, death ruled over him, meaning that he would one day die. It also indicates that now death has no effect on him. Death does not rule over him or influence him. Jesus does as he himself chooses, without worrying about death or being afraid of it. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

death no longer rules him

Death has no power over him any more. (NJB)

dying has no authority over him any more

## Romans 6:10

### Section 6:1–14: We must live for God because we died to sin

In this section, Paul told the believers in Rome that they should not continue to sin, because baptism symbolizes death to sin. Jesus' resurrection symbolizes the new life that believers can live in. The believers' old way of life is crucified on the cross of Jesus so that they have no need to follow the desires to sin. Believers will live new lives for God and death no longer rules them, because Jesus died and was raised for them. Therefore believers should consider themselves dead to sin and do the good deeds that God wants

them to do. God's grace removes believers from the rule of sin in their lives.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

Believers are dead to sin, so they must live for God

Dead to Sin, Alive in Christ (NIV)

We are no longer slaves to sin, but God's servants

#### 6:10a

##### **The death He died, He died to sin once for all;**

- For, about his death/dying, he died leaving sin, and he did this only once,
- For when he died, he died once, never to die again, and the power of sin no longer had any authority over him.

The Greek of 6:10a begins with a word that is usually translated as "For." It introduces an explanation of what Paul said in 6:9. In some languages, it may be more natural to omit this word, as the BSB does.

**The death He died:** These words refer to Jesus' death in particular. Here are other ways to translate these words:

the death that he died

When he died, (NLT)

About his dying Yongkom Back Translation, by this author, unpublished manuscript.

**He died to sin:** This phrase indicates that sin no longer has power over Jesus. While he lived on the earth sin and death ruled over him just as it does for everyone else (even though he remained sinless). When he died, his death released him from that power and now it can no longer rule over him.

In some languages a literal translation would imply a wrong meaning or may be unclear. If that is true in your language, you may want to:

- Translate literally and explain the meaning in a footnote. Here is an example footnote:

Jesus dying "to sin" means that when he died, sin no longer had any authority over him.

- Explain the meaning in your translation. For example:

he died and so the power of sin could no longer try to influence him

he died and the power of sin no longer had any authority over him

**once for all:** Here this phrase means "once and never again." BDAG (page 417), Louw and Nida (on TW), and Kruse (page 266). The phrase does not mean "once for all people." Alford (page 439) says it means "not to be repeated." Jesus died once and will not die again. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

only once ever

once and only once

never to die again

#### 6:10b

##### **but the life He lives, He lives to God.**

- but/and about his living today, he lives for God.
- But/And now that he lives, he lives in order to honor/glorify God.

**but:** This word indicates that Jesus living to God contrasts to him dying to sin (6:10a). But some languages would not see contrast here. For example:

and (NJB)

**the life He lives:** These words refer to Jesus' life in particular. It refers to his life in heaven at this time, not his life on earth long ago. Here are other ways to translate these words:

the life that he lives

now that he lives, (NLT)

about his living Yongkom Back Translation, by this author, unpublished manuscript.

**He lives to God:** Here the word to indicates that Jesus lives to honor and glorify God, and to do as God wants him to. Stott (page 178), Moo (on TW), and Morris (on TW). Here are other ways to translate this clause:

he lives for God (GW)

he lives for the glory of God (NLT)

his living now/today is so that he will serve God-Kankanaey Back Translation on TW.

he is living to do the will of GodOtomi Back Translation on TW.

you must see yourselves as (NJB)

consider yourselves (ESV)

**dead to sin:** Here, this figure of speech refers to completely ignoring the temptation of sin. Some languages must change this metaphor into a simile. For example:

as a dead person to sin

as if dead to sin telling us what to do

as if dead to the commands to sin

See how you translated a similar phrase (“died to sin”) in 6:2.

#### 6:11b

#### but alive to God in Christ Jesus.

- and as living for God based on our relationship/union with Jesus, the Christ/Messiah.
- and/but you must see yourselves as living to honor God because of our being united/connected with Jesus, the one/person whom God appointed to save/rescue people.

**alive to God:** Here the word to indicates that believers must live to honor and glorify God, and to do as God wants them to. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

living for God (GW)

living for the glory of God

as being alive where our serving God is concernedKankanaey Back Translation on TW.

We now live to do the will of GodOtomi Back Translation on TW.

See how you translated a similar phrase (“lives to God”) in 6:10.

**in Christ Jesus:** Here the word in indicates that believers are joined with Jesus in a close relationship. Alford (page 369), Fitzmyer (page 439), Moo (on TW), and Morris (on TW). Alford says the Greek word does not mean “through.” Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

## Romans 6:11

### Section 6:1–14: We must live for God because we died to sin

In this section, Paul told the believers in Rome that they should not continue to sin, because baptism symbolizes death to sin. Jesus’ resurrection symbolizes the new life that believers can live in. The believers’ old way of life is crucified on the cross of Jesus so that they have no need to follow the desires to sin. Believers will live new lives for God and death no longer rules them, because Jesus died and was raised for them. Therefore believers should consider themselves dead to sin and do the good deeds that God wants them to do. God’s grace removes believers from the rule of sin in their lives.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

Believers are dead to sin, so they must live for God

Dead to Sin, Alive in Christ (NIV)

We are no longer slaves to sin, but God’s servants

#### 6:11a

#### So you too must count yourselves dead to sin,

- Therefore also think<sup>(plur)</sup> of yourselves as being dead to the temptations of sin
- Therefore you also must see yourselves as people who are dead to the power/authority of sin,

**So you too must count yourselves:** The Greek word that the BSB translates as count refers to thinking about something and deciding it is true. It implies doing as was decided. Paul wanted the believers in Rome to think of themselves as dead to sin and alive to God. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

you must think of yourselves as (CEV)

in union with Christ Jesus (REB)

because of our being-united-with Cristo JesusKankanaey Back Translation on TW.

because we are walking with ChristOtomi Back Translation on TW.

because of my connection with Kristus YesusUma Back Translation on TW.

**Christ Jesus:** There is a textual issue in 6:11b: (1) Some Greek manuscripts have the words Christ Jesus (BSB, RSV, NIV, NJB, NASB, NABRE, NLT, GW, CEV, NET, REB, ESV). (2) Some Greek manuscripts have the words Christ Jesus our Lord (KJV). It is recommended that you follow option (1). The order of the words Christ Jesus emphasizes that Jesus is the Christ/Messiah. See how you translated this phrase in 1:1 or 6:3.

## Romans 6:12

### Section 6:1–14: We must live for God because we died to sin

In this section, Paul told the believers in Rome that they should not continue to sin, because baptism symbolizes death to sin. Jesus' resurrection symbolizes the new life that believers can live in. The believers' old way of life is crucified on the cross of Jesus so that they have no need to follow the desires to sin. Believers will live new lives for God and death no longer rules them, because Jesus died and was raised for them. Therefore believers should consider themselves dead to sin and do the good deeds that God wants them to do. God's grace removes believers from the rule of sin in their lives.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

Believers are dead to sin, so they must live for God

Dead to Sin, Alive in Christ (NIV)

We are no longer slaves to sin, but God's servants

### 6:12a

#### Therefore do not let sin reign in your mortal body

- ¶ And so, do not allow sin to command your bodies, which will die, to do evil,
- ¶ Therefore do not let sin lead you<sup>(plur)</sup> while you live on this earth but will one day die.

#### Therefore do not let sin reign in your mortal body:

In some English versions, the word Therefore is in the middle of the clause. For example:

Let not sin therefore reign in your mortal body (ESV)

In some languages, it may be more natural to put the word Therefore at the beginning of the sentence, as the BSB does.

**do not let sin reign:** There are two ways to interpret the Greek words here:

1. It is a command to not do something. For example:

do not let sin reign (BSB) (BSB, RSV, NIV, NJB, KJV, ESV, NLT, NASB, GW, CEV, NET, NCV, NABRE)

1. It is a command to stop doing something. For example:

sin must no longer reign in your mortal body (REB) (GNT, REB)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1), because many scholars support it as well.

This clause refers to not following the temptations of sin. The figure of speech speaks of sin as a ruler/king over someone. In some languages a literal translation would have the wrong meaning or not be clear as to its meaning. If that is true in your language, you may want to:

- Use "like/as" to indicate the comparison. For example:

Do not let sin control you like a ruler/king

- Translate the meaning without the figure of speech. For example:

Do not let sin control you

- Translate literally and explain the meaning in a footnote. Here is an example footnote:

This clause refers to not following/obeying the temptations of sin.

The present tense refers to the ongoing effort of the believer to not follow the temptations of sin. Each

time a believer is tempted, he must reject that temptation. For example:

Always be stopping sin from reigning/controlling you

**in your mortal body:** Here the word body implies the things someone does. The power of sin should not control what we do. In some languages a literal translation would imply that.

But in some languages a literal translation would wrongly refer only to sins internal to the physical body. If that is true in your language, refer to what we do. For example:

do not let sin control your life here on earth (NCV)

**mortal body:** The word mortal refers to something being able to die. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

the body which dies

your bodies are a thing for dyingYongkom Back Translation, by this author, unpublished manuscript.

during the time we live here on earthOtomi Back Translation on TW.

## 6:12b

### so that you obey its desires.

- so that you obey sinful desires.
- Sin tries to make you obey its evil desires.

**so that you obey its desires:** There is a textual issue in 6:12b: (1) Some Greek manuscripts have the words its desires (BSB, RSV, NIV, NJB, NASB, NLT, GW, CEV, NET, NABRE, REB, ESV). (2) Some Greek manuscripts have the words it in its desires (KJV only). It is recommended that you follow option (1). Here the phrase so that introduces the purpose of sin reigning in believers' lives. It does not connect to "Do not let." Make that clear in your translation. For example:

and make you obey its evil desires

Let not sin therefore reign in your mortal body. It/ Sin wants to make you obey its passions.

**desires:** Here this word means "strong urge to do something." It refers here to anything that sin might try to make believers want that they should not. It does not refer here to only desires of having sex. Other ways to translate it are:

evil desires (NIV)

passions (ESV)

## Romans 6:13

### Section 6:1–14: We must live for God because we died to sin

In this section, Paul told the believers in Rome that they should not continue to sin, because baptism symbolizes death to sin. Jesus' resurrection symbolizes the new life that believers can live in. The believers' old way of life is crucified on the cross of Jesus so that they have no need to follow the desires to sin. Believers will live new lives for God and death no longer rules them, because Jesus died and was raised for them. Therefore believers should consider themselves dead to sin and do the good deeds that God wants them to do. God's grace removes believers from the rule of sin in their lives.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

Believers are dead to sin, so they must live for God

Dead to Sin, Alive in Christ (NIV)

We are no longer slaves to sin, but God's servants

## 6:13a

### Do not present the parts of your body to sin as instruments of wickedness,

- Do not offer/give parts of your<sup>(plur)</sup> body to sin's reign/rule as tools to do deeds/things that are not right to do,
- And do not put any part of yourselves under the control of sin, as if they were something for doing things that are not upright/straight to do.

## 6:13b

### but present yourselves to God

- but rather offer/give yourselves to God for him to rule,
- Instead, put yourselves under God for him to lead you,

**6:13a-b**

**Do not present the parts of your body to sin:** This phrase refers to not giving something to someone for him to control. Believers are not to allow themselves to be controlled by sin. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

Do not give parts of your body to sin

Do not allow your members to come under the control of sin

**the parts of your body:** Here the word parts refers to parts of the body. Here it implies deeds done with those parts. Cranfield (page 317) says it refers to any natural ability. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

your members (ESV)

yourselves Yakan Back Translation on TW.

**as instruments of wickedness:** Here the word instruments refers to tools. Here it is a metaphor. Like someone uses a screwdriver to tighten a screw, believers are not to use parts of their bodies to do unrighteous or evil deeds. The Greek word can also mean “weapons.” Weapons are tools that have the purpose of hurting others. But that specific purpose does not seem to be in focus here. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

as tools for doing things that are not right to do

to be something used to do unrighteous deeds

**wickedness:** This word refers to deeds that God says are not right to do. See the examples above.

**6:13c**

**as those who have been brought from death to life;**

- according to you being people once dead but now alive,
- for you have left the rule of death and now live the new life.

**as those who have been brought from death to life:** Here the word as indicates that believers are to present themselves to God in accord with the fact that they are those who have been brought from death to life. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

in accordance with being those who have been brought from death to life

because you are those who have been brought from death to life

The word as does not mean “like” here, as if believers were only to copy others who have been brought from death to life.

**who have been brought from death to life:** The Greek words are literally “out-from dead (one)s you<sup>(plur)</sup>-are-living.” Here are some fairly literal translations:

those alive from the dead (NASB)

people who have come back from death and are now alive (GW)

a person who comes out of death to life

The Greek words indicate that, earlier, God has brought believers from the death they died to sin to the new life in Christ. Jewett (page 411) says it refers to “the reality of believers who have been given new life in Christ.”

In some languages a literal translation would wrongly refer to believers being actually dead earlier. If that is true in your language, you may want to:

- Translate literally and explain the meaning in a footnote. Here is an example footnote:

These words indicate that, earlier, God has brought believers from the death they died to sin to the new life in Christ.

- Explain the meaning in your translation. For example:

you have new life after you died to sin

you now live the new life but earlier you died to sin

**6:13d**

**and present the parts of your body to Him as instruments of righteousness.**

- and offer/give all parts of your bodies to God as tools to do deeds/things that are right to do.

- And also put every part of yourselves under God, as if they were something for doing things that are upright/straight to do.

**and present the parts of your body to Him as instruments of righteousness:** Here the BSB adds the word present that is implied here from 6:13b. In some languages repeating that word is more natural or more clear. However, some languages may not need to repeat this word. For example:

and your members to God as instruments for righteousness (ESV)

**righteousness:** This word refers to deeds that God says are right to do. It is the opposite of “wickedness” in 6:13a.

## Romans 6:14

### Section 6:1–14: We must live for God because we died to sin

In this section, Paul told the believers in Rome that they should not continue to sin, because baptism symbolizes death to sin. Jesus’ resurrection symbolizes the new life that believers can live in. The believers’ old way of life is crucified on the cross of Jesus so that they have no need to follow the desires to sin. Believers will live new lives for God and death no longer rules them, because Jesus died and was raised for them. Therefore believers should consider themselves dead to sin and do the good deeds that God wants them to do. God’s grace removes believers from the rule of sin in their lives.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

Believers are dead to sin, so they must live for God

Dead to Sin, Alive in Christ (NIV)

We are no longer slaves to sin, but God’s servants

### 6:14a

#### For sin shall not be your master,

- For sin will not rule your<sup>(plur)</sup> lives,
- For the power of sin no longer has control over you,

**For:** Here this word introduces an explanation (Jewett (page 411). of why believers must not let sin reign (6:12) and must not present their bodies to sin (6:13).

**sin shall not be your master:** There are several ways to interpret the Greek future tense here:

1. It means will and indicates that after becoming believers in Jesus, sin no longer rules our lives. For example:

Sin will not be your master (NCV) (BSB, RSV, NIV, NJB, NASB, KJV, ESV, NET, REB, NCV)

1. It means must and indicates that believers are not to allow sin to rule their lives. For example:

Sin must not be your master (GNT) (GNT, NABRE, CEV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1) or (2), but be careful of your choice of words, because it is unlikely that Paul would start a command with “For” (Cranfield (page 319) and Jewett (page 411). They support interpretation (1), and Dunn (page 339) and Schreiner (page 325) support interpretation (2)..

**shall not be your master:** The Greek word that the BSB translates as shall...be your master refers to having great authority over someone. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

will no longer have any power over you (NJB)

will not rule you

### 6:14b

#### because you are not under law, but under grace.

- because you are ruled by kindness, not by the law of Moses.
- because the Law of Moses does not rule your life following Christ, no, the kindness of God rules/guides it.

**you are not under law:** This clause indicates that the Laws of Moses do not have authority over believers. Believers may look at the Law for guidance on how to live, but they do not need to follow every rule in it. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

you are living not under law (NJB)

You are ruled by God’s kindness and not by the Law (CEV)

the Law of Moses does not sit over you

This clause does not imply that we are free from following any laws. In some languages a literal translation would wrongly imply that. If that is true in your language, explain that in your translation. For example:

your life in Christ is not ruled by the Law of Moses

**under grace:** This clause indicates that grace has authority over believers. Here it indicates that God is kind to them. But unlike the laws of Moses, grace does not require them to follow certain rules. The words “you are” are implied here. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

you are living under grace

the principle of grace sits over you

**grace:** This word refers to kindness that is given to people without requiring anything in return. This kindness is not given because they have done anything to deserve it. See how you translated this word in 1:5 or 6:1.

#### General Comment on 6:14b

In some languages it is more natural to have “under grace” before “not under law.” For example:

since you are under grace, not under law

## Romans 6:15

### Section 6:15–23: Become as slaves to righteousness

In this section, Paul told the believers in Rome that they must not sin even if they are not under the Laws of Moses. He told them that if they obey sin then they are slaves to sin. Instead, they must become slaves of righteousness, that is, doing things that God says are right to do. This command includes all parts of their lives.

Paul further explained that when they were always obeying the desires of sin, they were free from doing things that God says are right to do. He reminded them that they were now ashamed of those sins and the consequences. The final consequence of those sins is death. God had set them free from a life of sin and they had become like slaves of God. The consequences of that is becoming holy and receiving eternal life. For sinning earns a person death, but when that person believes in Jesus, God gives him eternal life.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

We must be slaves of God doing righteous deeds

We must always do what God says is right to do

We are servants of straight/upright behavior

#### 6:15a

##### What then?

- ¶ So, what are we to think/do about that?
- ¶ So then,

**What then?:** This is a rhetorical question. Paul used this question to introduce the next question. It also indicates a connection to what Paul just said with the Greek word often translated “therefore.” Here are other ways to translate this question:

So what should we do? (NCV)

So, what then shall we say/think?

In some languages a question is not natural here. If that is true in your language, translate it as a statement. For example:

Well then, (NLT)

Therefore, think about this:

#### 6:15b–c

**Shall we sin because we are not under law, but under grace? Certainly not!:** The question is rhetorical. By asking it, Paul wanted the readers to think about what the answer might be. He also answered it himself here. Here are some ways to translate this:

- As a rhetorical question and its answer. For example:

Shall we sin because we are not under law but under grace? By no means! (NIV)

We are not under law but under grace, and so should we sin? Of course not!

- As a statement. For example:

We are certainly not to sin because we are under grace, not under law.



We are under grace, not under law, but we are certainly not to sin because of that.

### 6:15b

#### **Shall we sin because we are not under law, but under grace?**

- Are we allowed to sin because we are under the authority of grace rather than the laws of Moses?
- the grace of God rules our lives, not the laws of Moses. So shall we sin?

**we are not under law:** This clause refers to believers not being under the authority of the laws of Moses. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

we are not under the authority of the laws of Moses

the laws of Moses do not sit over us

See how you translated under law in 6:14.

**under grace:** The words “we are” are implied here. Believers are under the authority of grace. The grace of God affects our lives in all ways. Here are other ways to translate these words:

we are under the authority of the grace of God

the grace of God sits over us

See how you translated under grace in 6:14.

### 6:15c

#### **Certainly not!**

- By no means! (ESV)
- No indeed!

**Certainly not!:** The Greek is literally “May it not be.” It indicates a very strong “no.” Here are other ways to translate this clause:

Not at all!

By no means! (ESV)

No, indeed!

See how you translated these words in 3:4 or 6:2. Note that “certainly” in the As a statement examples in 6:15b–c translate the words Certainly not! here. If you

used “certainly” there, do not translate these words here.

## **Romans 6:16**

### **Section 6:15–23: Become as slaves to righteousness**

In this section, Paul told the believers in Rome that they must not sin even if they are not under the Laws of Moses. He told them that if they obey sin then they are slaves to sin. Instead, they must become slaves of righteousness, that is, doing things that God says are right to do. This command includes all parts of their lives.

Paul further explained that when they were always obeying the desires of sin, they were free from doing things that God says are right to do. He reminded them that they were now ashamed of those sins and the consequences. The final consequence of those sins is death. God had set them free from a life of sin and they had become like slaves of God. The consequences of that is becoming holy and receiving eternal life. For sinning earns a person death, but when that person believes in Jesus, God gives him eternal life.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

We must be slaves of God doing righteous deeds

We must always do what God says is right to do

We are servants of straight/upright behavior

### 6:16a

#### **Do you not know that**

- Do you know that
- Surely you know this:

### 6:16a–e

#### **Do you not know that when you offer yourselves as obedient slaves, you are slaves to the one you obey, whether you are slaves to sin leading to death, or to obedience leading to righteousness?:**

This is a rhetorical question. It emphasizes that the believers in Rome should already know this, Moo (on TW) and Fitzmyer (page 448). or reminds them that all of them would likely agree with this. Kruse (page 288) and Barrett (page 131).

In some languages the form of question here would not have either of those meanings. If that is true in your language, you may want to translate it as a statement. For example:

Surely/Certainly you know that when you offer yourselves as obedient slaves, you are slaves to the one you obey, whether you are slaves to sin leading to death, or to obedience leading to righteousness!

Or it may be more natural or clear to put the question about knowing at the end. For example:

When you offers yourselves as obedient slaves, you are slaves to the one you obey, whether you are slaves to sin leading to death, or to obedience leading to righteousness! Do you not know that? Certainly you do!

When you offer yourselves as obedient slaves, you are slaves to the one you obey, whether to sin leading to death, or to obedience leading to righteousness! Surely/Certainly you know that!

**6:16b**  
**when you offer yourselves as obedient slaves,**

- if you<sup>(plur)</sup> offer/give yourselves to someone as a slave who always obeys,
- If you put yourselves under someone like a slave/servant who obeys his master,

**6:16c**  
**you are slaves to the one you obey,**

- then you are slaves of that person you obey,
- then you are that person's slaves/servants and you obey him.

**6:16b–c**  
**when you offer yourselves:** The word offer here refers to giving something to someone for him to control. See how you translated this word in 6:13, where the BSB translates it as “present.”

**slaves:** This word refers to people who are owned by someone. Their choices in life were completely controlled by their master. They followed their master's will/desires rather than their own.

In some cultures, slaves may not be known. In other cultures, the word for slave may imply different customs than what is described above. If that is true in your language, here are some ways to translate this:

person who belonged to someone else

owned person

person who serves someone

worker/servant

See how you translated this Greek word in 1:1 (“servant”) or the verbal phrase “be slaves” at 6:6.

**6:16d**  
**whether you are slaves to sin leading to death,**

- and you are either like slaves to sins, which results in death,
- You either allow sinning to rule your life, and that sinning causes you to die,

**whether:** This word introduces two possible outcomes. Here one outcome is being a slave of sin. The other outcome is being a slave of obedience. Here is another possible word:

either (ESV)

**you are slaves to sin:** The words you are slaves are not in the Greek text, but they are implied here from 6:16c.

Here the word slaves is a figure of speech. It refers to believers allowing sin to rule their lives, like a master rules the lives of his slaves. Some languages must indicate that this is a figure of speech. For example:

you are like slaves to sin

you allow the power of sin to rule you

**leading to death:** The Greek words are literally “into death.” It indicates that the end result of sin is death. Here are other ways to translate these words:

resulting in death (NET)

and therefore die

**death:** Here the word death is in contrast with “life.” It refers to a person's ultimate destruction.

**6:16e**  
**or to obedience leading to righteousness?**

- or you are like slaves of obedience to God, which results in you becoming righteous?
- or you allow the thinking of obeying God to rule your life, and that obeying causes you to become upright.

**to obedience:** The words “you are slaves” is implied here. For example:

you are slaves to obedience

Here the word “slaves” is a figure of speech. Some languages must indicate that this is a figure of speech. For example:

you are like slaves to obedience

you allow the ways of obedience to rule you

**obedience:** It is implied here that these people obey God. Some languages need to say what is obeyed. For example:

obedience to God

In some languages a verb must be used. For example:

obeying God

you obey God

**leading to righteousness:** The Greek words are literally “into righteousness.” Obeying results in righteousness. Here are other ways to translate these words:

resulting in righteousness (NET)

and therefore become more and more righteous

**righteousness:** Some commentators think this word means “living an upright life” here. For example, Jewett (417) and Fitzmyer (page 448). and some commentators think it means “being made fully righteous at the final judgment.” For example, Cranfield (page 322) and Kruse (page 281). Many others think it means both things. For example, Dunn (page 342), who says, “the flexibility of Paul’s concept of ‘righteousness’ should be observed and not squeezed to fit a particular dogmatic scheme.” Alford (page 372) says, “righteousness in its most general sense as the contrast to death,—the state of blessedness induced by holiness.” Translate in a way that allows for one or both interpretations. For example:

the deeds that are right/straight to do

the life doing upright deeds

Many English versions translate simply righteousness, which does not interpret the meaning.

## Romans 6:17

### Section 6:15–23: Become as slaves to righteousness

In this section, Paul told the believers in Rome that they must not sin even if they are not under the Laws of Moses. He told them that if they obey sin then they are slaves to sin. Instead, they must become slaves of righteousness, that is, doing things that God says are right to do. This command includes all parts of their lives.

Paul further explained that when they were always obeying the desires of sin, they were free from doing things that God says are right to do. He reminded them that they were now ashamed of those sins and the consequences. The final consequence of those sins is death. God had set them free from a life of sin and they had become like slaves of God. The consequences of that is becoming holy and receiving eternal life. For sinning earns a person death, but when that person believes in Jesus, God gives him eternal life.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

We must be slaves of God doing righteous deeds

We must always do what God says is right to do

We are servants of straight/upright behavior

### 6:17a

**But thanks be to God that, though you once were slaves to sin,**

- But God is to be thanked that, even though you<sup>(plur)</sup> were formerly slaves of sin,
- Earlier you were like/as slaves to/of sin, but I thank God that

**But:** This word indicates contrast from being slaves of sin (6:16c–d, 17a) to being obedient to the teaching in the gospel (6:17b–c). But some languages will not see this connection as contrast. For example:

I thank God because...Kankanaey Back Translation on TW. Several other back translations on TW omit “but” here.

**thanks be to God:** This clause indicates generally that God should be thanked. It implies that Paul thanked God. It also implies that the readers should thank God too.

In some languages a literal translation would not have the correct meaning. If that is true in your language, refer to Paul or to Paul and his readers. For example:

I thank God (GW)

Let us<sup>(incl)</sup> thank God

**though you once were slaves to sin:** The Greek is more literally “you were being slaves to sin but.” It implies that they were slaves to sin before the believers became obedient (6:17b) and were no longer slaves to sin after they became obedient. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

you were once slaves of sin but

though at one time you were slaves to sin (GNT)

#### General Comment on 6:17a

As several scholars point out, See Cranfield (page 323) or Schreiner (page 334). Paul was not thankful that the believers in Rome were once slaves of sin, but he was thankful that they were now obedient to the gospel. It may be more clear to move this clause before Paul saying thanks. For example:

Once you were slaves of sin, but now, thank God (REB)

#### 6:17b

##### you wholeheartedly obeyed the form of teaching

- you have been obedient from your insides/inner-being to the kinds of teaching in the gospel.
- you are completely obeying the kinds of teaching in the gospel,

**you wholeheartedly obeyed:** The Greek verb here is past tense. But unlike the English simple past tense, the Greek aorist “tense” does not imply that they have stopped obeying. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

you obeyed (NET)

you began obeying

you have been obeying

**wholeheartedly:** This word indicates that the believers were sincere. They felt it was right to be obedient. The word wholeheartedly refers here to doing something from the inner being of people. Some languages have a different way to translate that meaning. For example:

with all your heart (GNT)

from your insides/liver/stomach

completely/truly

**the form of teaching:** The Greek word that the BSB translates as form has several meanings:

1. It means form or pattern here. It indicates that the teaching is good Christian teaching but may not be exactly what Paul taught. He did not know exactly what they were taught because he had not yet gone to Rome and talked to them about it. (Perhaps he had reports of some of the things they had been taught or were teaching.) For example:

the pattern of teaching (NABRE) (BSB, NIV, NJB, NRSV, NASB, KJV, NET, REB)

1. It means standard here. It indicates that the teaching met the criteria of good Christian teaching. For example:

the standard of teaching (RSV) (RSV, ESV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1), because that is the meaning that the BDAG supports.

#### 6:17c

##### to which you were committed.

- You were put in submission to follow/obey those ideals.
- to which God put you under its care/instruction.

**to which you were committed:** This clause indicates that someone put the believers under the teaching of the gospel of Jesus. This happened at the time they began believing in Jesus. Kruse (page 282). It indicates that they were to learn the gospel and obey the commands in it. Paul may have been thinking of God committing them or perhaps the person who helped them to believe.

This clause is passive. Some languages must use an active clause here. For example:

to which God committed you

**committed:** The Greek word here is often translated “handed over.” God put the new believers under the rule of the gospel of Jesus. They were to obey it. Here are other ways to translate this word:

entrusted (NIV)

handed over to obey it

## Romans 6:18

### Section 6:15–23: Become as slaves to righteousness

In this section, Paul told the believers in Rome that they must not sin even if they are not under the Laws of Moses. He told them that if they obey sin then they are slaves to sin. Instead, they must become slaves of righteousness, that is, doing things that God says are right to do. This command includes all parts of their lives.

Paul further explained that when they were always obeying the desires of sin, they were free from doing things that God says are right to do. He reminded them that they were now ashamed of those sins and the consequences. The final consequence of those sins is death. God had set them free from a life of sin and they had become like slaves of God. The consequences of that is becoming holy and receiving eternal life. For sinning earns a person death, but when that person believes in Jesus, God gives him eternal life.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

We must be slaves of God doing righteous deeds

We must always do what God says is right to do

We are servants of straight/upright behavior

### 6:18a

#### You have been set free from sin

- And you<sup>(plur)</sup> were released from the authority of sin,
- God removed you from your previous/old master/leader, sin,

**You have been set free from sin:** This clause is passive. The Greek clause refers generally to a past event. Some languages must use an active clause here. For example:

God set you free from sin

**set free from sin:** This phrase indicates that God has removed believers from being under the control of the power of sin, like a slave is removed from his owner. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

You were made free from sin (NCV)

You have now been released from the authority of sin  
Tagbanwa Back Translation on TW.

### 6:18b

#### and have become slaves to righteousness.

- and you were made slaves under the authority of righteousness.
- and he put you under a new master, uprightness.
- and he made you to be under the leading/rule of deeds and thoughts that he says are right to do or think.

**have become slaves to righteousness:** This indicates that believers came under the control of righteousness, like a slave is given to a new master.

The subject is still “you<sup>(plur)</sup>.” For example:

you have become slaves of righteousness  
(NABRE)

**slaves to righteousness:** The word slaves is a figure of speech. It refers to believers allowing righteousness to rule their lives, like a master rules the lives of his slaves. Some languages cannot translate literally for the correct meaning. If that is true in your language, you may want to:

- Add “like/as” here. For example:

as slaves of righteousness

you have become like enslaved to the doing of righteousness

God has put you as though righteousness was your ruler

- Translate the meaning without the figure of speech. For example:

God has put you under the direction/guide of righteousness

you are under the authority of righteousness

**righteousness:** Here this word refers to deeds and thoughts that God says are right to do or think. See how you translated this word in 6:13.

## Romans 6:19

### Section 6:15–23: Become as slaves to righteousness

In this section, Paul told the believers in Rome that they must not sin even if they are not under the Laws of Moses. He told them that if they obey sin then they are slaves to sin. Instead, they must become slaves of righteousness, that is, doing things that God says are right to do. This command includes all parts of their lives.

Paul further explained that when they were always obeying the desires of sin, they were free from doing things that God says are right to do. He reminded them that they were now ashamed of those sins and the consequences. The final consequence of those sins is death. God had set them free from a life of sin and they had become like slaves of God. The consequences of that is becoming holy and receiving eternal life. For sinning earns a person death, but when that person believes in Jesus, God gives him eternal life.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

We must be slaves of God doing righteous deeds

We must always do what God says is right to do

We are servants of straight/upright behavior

### 6:19a

**I am speaking in human terms because of the weakness of your flesh.**

- I speak with that example from everyday life, because your<sup>(plur)</sup> human nature is too weak to understand the truth easily.
- It is hard for you to understand things beyond your life on this world, and so I speak with metaphors/illustrations from daily life.

**I am speaking in human terms:** This clause refers to Paul using words that refer to things that are familiar to people's experience. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

I am using an example from everyday life (NIV11)

I am now using an illustration that people can easily understandKankanaey Back Translation on TW.

**the weakness of your flesh:** The BSB literally translates the Greek words here. Here the weakness of... flesh refers generally to people not always understanding things. The word your indicates that the believers in Rome also do not always understand things. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

you are weak in your natural selves (NIV)

you are still weak human beings (NJB)

according to ways of your bodies your understanding of things is weak

you still think as people of this world and not as mature believers

### 6:19b–d

**Just as you used to offer the parts of your body in slavery to impurity and to escalating wickedness, so now offer them in slavery to righteousness:** The phrase Just as introduces something to be compared. Paul compared what the believers used to do (6:19b–c) to what they must now do (6:19d–e).

Some languages do not introduce the thing to be compared as Paul did here. For example:

you used to offer the parts of your body in slavery to impurity and to escalating wickedness, so, in the same way, now offer them in slavery to righteousness

### 6:19b

**Just as you used to offer the parts of your body in slavery to impurity**

- For just as you offered/gave parts of your body in the past to be like/as slaves to the evil desires of the heart
- Previously/Earlier you put parts of yourselves under the control of your sexual/body desires

The Greek of 6:19b begins with a word that is usually translated as “For” (as in the ESV). This word introduces the reason that Paul spoke in human terms because of the believers' natural limitations (6:19a). He spoke that way because the believers had at an earlier time presented their members as slaves to

impurity and lawlessness (6:19b–c). Some English versions omit this word, as the BSB does, allowing the context to imply that connection.

**you used to offer:** The word offer refers to giving something to someone for him to control. Believers used to allow themselves to be controlled by sin. See how you translated the word “present” in 6:13.

**used to:** Here this phrase refers to what believers did at one time before they believed in Jesus. It does not refer to only doing something one time.

**the parts of your body:** Here the word parts refers to parts of the human body and implies deeds done with those parts. See how you translated parts in 6:13.

**in slavery to impurity:** Here the word slavery is a figure of speech. It refers to believers allowing impurity to rule their lives, like a master rules the lives of his slaves. See how you translated the similar phrase in 6:17 (“slaves to sin”).

**impurity:** This word refers to deeds that are immoral to do. Here are other ways to translate this word:

uncleanness (KJV)

filthy practices

See how you translated this word in 1:24.

#### **6:19c and to escalating wickedness,**

- and to deeds of breaking the law leading to a life of breaking the law,
- and under the control of lawbreaking resulting in complete lawlessness.

**and:** Here this word indicates another thing to which the believers in Rome used to present their members as slaves.

**to escalating wickedness:** The Greek phrase is literally “to lawlessness into lawlessness.” It indicates that a person does things that ignore the law or disobeys it. Jewett (page 420) says it refers to “the general condition which results from such acts.” Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

to lawlessness for lawlessness (NABRE)

lawlessness for a life of lawlessness Cranfield (page 321).

to lawlessness resulting in anarchy Jewett (page 413).

Some other English versions add the word escalating or “increasing” (NIV: “ever-increasing”). But it is not clear to this author how the Greek words support that meaning. Cranfield (page 327) and Morris speak against any meaning of “more” here.

#### **6:19d**

#### **so now offer them in slavery to righteousness**

- so offer/give<sup>(plur)</sup> the parts of your body now to be like/as slaves to deeds of righteousness
- In the same way you must now put the parts of yourselves under the control of deeds that are right before God to do,

**so:** The Greek word here introduces what is compared to the words in 6:19b–c. In some languages the word or phrase of comparison is put here. For example:

In the same way (GNT)

**now:** Here this word means “at this time.” It refers to the time that Paul was writing, but can imply now for any reader of this verse.

**righteousness:** Here this word refers to deeds and thoughts that God says are right to do or think, as in 6:18.

#### **6:19e leading to holiness.**

- leading you to become more and more holy.
- resulting in you becoming increasingly holy.

**leading to:** The Greek word is literally “to,” as in 6:19c. Living a life of righteousness causes the person to become more and more holy. For example:

for (NABRE)

for a life of

resulting in (NASB)

**holiness:** There are several ways to interpret the Greek word that the BSB translates as holiness. Here are the two main ways:

1. It means being made holy here. Every righteous deed makes believers more holy. For example:

you will become holy (NLT) (RSV, NJB, NASB, NABRE, ESV, NET, NLT)

1. It means already having been made holy and remaining holy here. For example:

holiness (NIV) (BSB, NIV, KJV, GW, REB)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1), because Greek words with this particular Greek ending usually refer to a process of becoming something. See Morris (on TW), Cranfield (page 327), or Lenski (page 432).

## Romans 6:20

### Section 6:15–23: Become as slaves to righteousness

In this section, Paul told the believers in Rome that they must not sin even if they are not under the Laws of Moses. He told them that if they obey sin then they are slaves to sin. Instead, they must become slaves of righteousness, that is, doing things that God says are right to do. This command includes all parts of their lives.

Paul further explained that when they were always obeying the desires of sin, they were free from doing things that God says are right to do. He reminded them that they were now ashamed of those sins and the consequences. The final consequence of those sins is death. God had set them free from a life of sin and they had become like slaves of God. The consequences of that is becoming holy and receiving eternal life. For sinning earns a person death, but when that person believes in Jesus, God gives him eternal life.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

We must be slaves of God doing righteous deeds

We must always do what God says is right to do

We are servants of straight/upright behavior

### 6:20a

#### For when you were slaves to sin,

- ¶ For when you were like slaves to sins,
- ¶ For when you allowed sinning to rule your life,

**For:** Here this word introduces an explanation or the basis for what Paul said in 6:19b–e. It introduces 6:20–21 or 6:20–23. Cranfield (page 327) and Schreiner (page 338), respectively.

**slaves to sin:** Here the word slaves is a figure of speech. It refers to believers allowing sin to rule their lives, like a master rules the lives of his slaves. If you added “slaves” before “of sin” in 6:16, see how you translated this phrase there.

### 6:20b

#### you were free of obligation to righteousness.

- you were free from doing what God says is right to do.
- righteousness had no part/control of your life.

**you were free of obligation to righteousness:** This clause indicates that the believers, before they believed in Jesus, were not concerned about doing what was right before God. They did what they wanted to, not what God wanted them to do. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

you were free from righteousness (NABRE)

you felt no obligation to uprightness (NJB)

you had no need to do righteous deeds

righteousness was not ruling you Kankanaey Back Translation on TW.

## Romans 6:21

### Section 6:15–23: Become as slaves to righteousness

In this section, Paul told the believers in Rome that they must not sin even if they are not under the Laws of Moses. He told them that if they obey sin then they are slaves to sin. Instead, they must become slaves of righteousness, that is, doing things that God says are right to do. This command includes all parts of their lives.

Paul further explained that when they were always obeying the desires of sin, they were free from doing things that God says are right to do. He reminded them that they were now ashamed of those sins and the consequences. The final consequence of those sins is death. God had set them free from a life of sin and they had become like slaves of God. The consequences of that is becoming holy and receiving eternal life. For sinning earns a person death, but when that person believes in Jesus, God gives him eternal life.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

We must be slaves of God doing righteous deeds



We must always do what God says is right to do

We are servants of straight/upright behavior

### 6:21a-b

**What fruit did you reap at that time from the things of which you are now ashamed?:** There are two ways to interpret where the question mark goes:

1. It should occur after the word ashamed. For example:

What benefit did you reap at that time from the things you are now ashamed of? (NIV) (BSB, RSV, NIV, GNT, NASB, KJV, NABRE, NET, GNT3)

1. It should occur after the phrase at that time. For example:

and what did you gain from living like that? Experiences of which you are now ashamed (NJB) (NJB, NLT, GW, CEV, REB, GNT4,5)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1), because interpretation (2) forces the plural Greek relative pronoun to connect to the singular fruit, but that is not good Greek grammar. Lenski (page 433). Schreiner (page 399) also supports interpretation (1). Other scholars support interpretation (2), but their arguments for it seem weak and their objections to interpretation (1) are easily answered. Many of the major English versions support interpretation (1). But, for this author, the main argument for interpretation (1) is to take *ef' hois* as meaning “about which things” and not connect it the singular “fruit” as interpretation (2) requires, even though fruit is a mass noun implying plural fruits. The word fruit is still technically singular in the Greek.

This is a rhetorical question. It emphasizes that those deeds that the believers were now ashamed of did not benefit them. Translate this clause with that meaning. Here are some ways:

- As a rhetorical question. For example:

what benefit were you then deriving from the things of which you are now ashamed? (NASB)

- As a statement. For example:

you were getting no good fruit from the things you did then that you are now ashamed of

### 6:21a

#### What fruit did you reap at that time

- At that time what benefits were you<sup>(plur)</sup> receiving
- And certainly no good things came to you at that time

The Greek of 6:21a begins with a word that is usually translated as “but.” Here, it probably does not indicate contrast. Rather, it was likely used to show that Paul continued to speak about the same kinds of things as he had before this verse. Some languages will not see contrast here to 6:20. For example:

What... (BSB, NIV)

And what... (REB)

**What fruit:** Here the word fruit is a metaphor that refers to the results of people’s deeds. Paul questioned what good result could have possibly come from the things they were now ashamed of. Some languages do not use the word fruit to refer to the results of deeds. For example:

what did you gain Kankanaey Back Translation on TW.

good thing/way Kamula Back Translation, unpublished manuscript, Papua New Guinea.

**did you reap:** Like harvesting fruit, this phrase asks what benefit the believers received from those evil deeds. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

were you gaining

were you receiving

The Greek tense indicates that they were doing those things over a period of time. But in some languages it is more natural to refer generally to that time, only implying that this occurred over a period of time. For example:

did you gain Kankanaey Back Translation on TW.

did you receive Uma Back Translation on TW.

**at that time:** Here this phrase refers to the time before the believers in Rome believed in Jesus, when they were enslaved to sin (6:20).

#### 6:21b

##### **from the things of which you are now ashamed?**

- from your behavior which now makes you feel ashamed?
- from deeds you did then, which now you are ashamed about!

**the things of which you are now ashamed:** The word things here refers to deeds of impurity, lawlessness and other kinds of sin. The believers in Rome were now ashamed of those deeds.

**now:** Here this word refers to the time that Paul wrote to the believers in Rome.

**ashamed:** The word ashamed refers to feeling humiliation, moral discomfort, or loss of self-respect when that person has done something wrong.

#### 6:21c

##### **The outcome of those things is death.**

- For such behavior results in death.
- For those deeds cause you to die.

The Greek of 6:21c begins with a word that is usually translated as “for.” Here this word introduces why the believers were ashamed. Some languages can omit this word and still connect 6:21c to 6:21b with the right meaning.

**The outcome of those things is death:** Here the word outcome refers to the end or result of those deeds that the believers were now ashamed of. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

Those things result in death! (NIV)

the result of those things is death! (ESV)

they lead to death

## Romans 6:22

### **Section 6:15–23: Become as slaves to righteousness**

In this section, Paul told the believers in Rome that they must not sin even if they are not under the Laws of Moses. He told them that if they obey sin then they are slaves to sin. Instead, they must become slaves of righteousness, that is, doing things that God says are right to do. This command includes all parts of their lives.

Paul further explained that when they were always obeying the desires of sin, they were free from doing things that God says are right to do. He reminded them that they were now ashamed of those sins and the consequences. The final consequence of those sins is death. God had set them free from a life of sin and they had become like slaves of God. The consequences of that is becoming holy and receiving eternal life. For sinning earns a person death, but when that person believes in Jesus, God gives him eternal life.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

We must be slaves of God doing righteous deeds

We must always do what God says is right to do

We are servants of straight/upright behavior

#### 6:22a–c

##### **But now that you have been set free from sin and have become slaves to God, the fruit you reap leads to holiness:**

A person is set free from sin and becomes a slave of God when he believes in Jesus. So the word now refers to the present time in the life of the believer. Some languages will need to connect the word now with the words you reap. For example:

But now, freed from sin and enslaved to God, you have your benefit leading to sanctification (NET)

But you have been set free from sin and have become slaves to God and now the fruit you reap leads to holiness

#### 6:22a

##### **But now that you have been set free from sin**

- But now, you<sup>(plur)</sup> have been released from the authority of sin
- God has removed you from your previous/old master/leader, sin,

**But:** Many languages will see contrast between the fruit of deeds of someone before he believes in Jesus (6:21) and the fruit of his deeds now that he believes (6:22c–d). But it may be more natural in some languages to omit this word here for the correct meaning.

**that you have been set free from sin:** This clause indicates that God had earlier removed believers from being under the control of the power of sin, like a slave is removed from his owner. See how your translated the phrase set free from sin in 6:18.

**6:22b****and have become slaves to God,**

- and have been made as/like slaves of God,
- and he has made you to be submitted to him,

**have become slaves to God:** As with the other uses of slaves and “slavery” in these verses, the word slaves here is a figure of speech referring to submission and obedience to God. In some languages it is more natural to indicate that it is a figure of speech. For example:

have become as/like slaves of God

have been made as those submitted to God like slaves

**6:22c****the fruit you reap leads to holiness,**

- and the benefits you are receiving lead you to become more and more holy
- and now good things are coming to you that result in you becoming increasingly holy

**the fruit you reap:** Like harvesting fruit, this phrase refers to the benefit the believers received from good deeds from their faith in Jesus.

**leads to holiness:** The Greek phrase is literally “into sanctification.” It indicates that a life obeying God causes the person to become more and more holy. See how you translated the same Greek phrase (BSB: “leading to holiness”) in 6:19.

**6:22d****and the outcome is eternal life.**

- and result in you living forever.
- and that give to you life that never ends.

**the outcome:** Here the word outcome refers to the outcome or result of the fruit of the deeds that the believers do. The meaning of the word outcome is the same as in 6:21c. See how you translated it there.

**eternal life:** This phrase refers to life that never ends. It implies life that will never become bad. See how you translated it in 2:7 or 5:21.

**Romans 6:23****Section 6:15–23: Become as slaves to righteousness**

In this section, Paul told the believers in Rome that they must not sin even if they are not under the Laws of Moses. He told them that if they obey sin then they are slaves to sin. Instead, they must become slaves of

righteousness, that is, doing things that God says are right to do. This command includes all parts of their lives.

Paul further explained that when they were always obeying the desires of sin, they were free from doing things that God says are right to do. He reminded them that they were now ashamed of those sins and the consequences. The final consequence of those sins is death. God had set them free from a life of sin and they had become like slaves of God. The consequences of that is becoming holy and receiving eternal life. For sinning earns a person death, but when that person believes in Jesus, God gives him eternal life.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

We must be slaves of God doing righteous deeds

We must always do what God says is right to do

We are servants of straight/upright behavior

**6:23a****For the wages of sin is death,**

- For what is earned from sinning is death,
- Hey/Look, the reward/penalty for the person who sins is that you die.

**For:** This word introduces an explanation of the two outcomes. The verse also finishes Paul’s talk about living under the power of sin (6:1–22) and the final thing Paul wanted to say about it.

Some languages may have a word that introduces that kind of thing. For example:

Look/HeyBased on the Yongkom NT. It is not the verb “to look,” but a word used to put attention on what follows.

In some languages it is more natural to omit this word.

**the wages of sin is death:** This a figure of speech. This clause indicates that a person receives death as a result of being a slave of sin. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

When people sin, they earn what sin pays—death.  
(NCV)

the payback of the work of sin is deathYongkom Back Translation, unpublished manuscript, Papua New Guinea.

Anyone who does sin receives a salary, and that salary is death that separates us from God.Uma Back Translation on TW.

death is the outcome of sin

the person who sins, the reward/penalty is death without end

### 6:23b

#### but the gift of God is eternal life

- but the gift that God gives is life forever
- But God gives a gift, and the gift is life that never ends,

**the gift of God is eternal life:** The word gift means that God gives eternal life to us without putting any obligation on us. We cannot earn that gift, unlike the wages in 6:23a. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

God gives us a free gift—life forever (NCV)

God's giving for-free thing is life all daysLiteral rendering of the Yongkom NT, 2004, Papua New Guinea.

### 6:23c

#### in Christ Jesus our Lord.

- in relationship/union with Jesus, the Christ/Messiah, and our Lord.
- being united/connected with our Leader/Master Jesus, the one/person whom God appointed to save/rescue people.

**in Christ Jesus:** Here the word in indicates that believers are joined with Jesus in a close relationship. That relationship will continue in eternal life. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

in union with Christ Jesus (REB)

being united with Christ Jesus

walking with Christ Jesus

See how you translated this phrase in 6:11.

**Christ Jesus:** The order of the words Christ Jesus emphasizes that Jesus is the Christ/Messiah. See how you translated this phrase in 1:1 or 6:11.

**our Lord:** The word Lord refers to someone who has authority over people. Here it indicates that Jesus has authority over believers. See how you translated this phrase in 1:4 or 5:21.

## Romans 7:1

### Section 7:1–6: Believers must follow the new way of the Holy Spirit

In this section, Paul used the example of marriage and the husband dying to show that believers are no longer under the laws of Moses. They are under the new covenant with Jesus. We have died to sin and God has released us from the law of Moses so that we can serve God as the Holy Spirit guides and empowers us.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

We were released from the Law of Moses to serve God in the new way of the Holy Spirit

Dead to the Law, Alive to Serve in the Spirit

Serve<sup>(plur)</sup> God in the new way of the Holy Spirit

### 7:1a–b

**Do you not know, brothers (for I am speaking to those who know the law), that the law has authority over a man only as long as he lives?:** The clause for I am speaking to those who know the law occurs in the middle of the question that Paul asked. It explains to whom he was speaking in this verse. In many languages, it is better to put this clause before or after the question. For example:

Or, brothers, I am speaking to those who know the law, do you not know that the law has authority over a man only as long as he lives?

Or, brothers, do you not know that the law has authority over a man only as long as he lives? I am speaking to those who know the law.

**Do you not know, brothers...that the law has authority over a man only as long as he lives?:** This is a rhetorical question. It emphasizes that the believers in Rome know that the law is binding only as long as a person lives. It also tells them to be thinking of this

principle as Paul talked further. Translate this clause with that meaning. Here are some ways:

- As a rhetorical question. For example:

do you not know...that the law is lord over a person as long as he lives? (NET)

Don't you realize...that laws have power over people only as long as they are alive? (GW)

- As a statement. For example:

you cannot have forgotten that the law can control a person only during that person's lifetime. (NJB)

you surely understand...that laws only have power over people who are alive. (CEV)

### 7:1a

**Do you not know, brothers (for I am speaking to those who know the law),**

- ¶ Or, my brothers and sisters, and I speak to all of you for you know the law, do you not know
- ¶ My fellow believers, you know about the Laws of Moses. I write/speak to you. Another question is this: Are you aware
- ¶ Brothers and sisters in Christ, I speak/write to you, and you know the Law/Laws. Surely you know

The Greek of 7:1a begins with a word that is usually translated as "or." The BSB does not translate this word, but leaves the connection between 7:1 and 6:23 implicit. This word introduces something connected but different and not contrasting.

**Do you not know, brothers:** The word brothers occurs in the middle of the question. In many languages it is more natural to have this word before the question. For example:

Or, brothers, do you not know

**brothers:** Here the word brothers refers to believers in Jesus, both men and women. The word indicates a close relationship because all believers are considered spiritual children of God. For example:

my fellow believers

In some languages brothers would be understood as literal brothers. If that is true in your language, you may want to translate differently. For example:

our brothers and sisters who believe in Jesus/Christ

my family of believers

my friends (CEV)

See how you translated this word in 1:13.

**(for I am speaking to those who know the law):**

The word for introduces an explanation. Here Paul explained that he knew that the believers in Rome know the law. Some people might think that Paul's question here implies that he thought that the believers did not know the law. So Paul made it clear that he knew that they did know it. See also the examples in the Notes on 7:1a-b.

**I am speaking:** Paul wrote this letter. But in effect he was talking to the believers in Rome, so he used the verb "speak" here. Also this letter would have been read aloud in the gatherings of believers in Rome, so "speak" would also be appropriate in that way. Use whatever is most natural here.

**those who know the law:** This phrase indicates in general that the believers in Rome know the law. It does not indicate that only some of the believers there know it. In some languages to translate the correct meaning, one must avoid using who. For example:

Or brothers, you know the law, do you not know...

Brothers, you know the law, I speak to you. So another question is this: do you not know...

**the law:** The Greek is only law here. It probably refers to the laws of Moses here. Moo (on TW). For example:

the Law (NJB)

the law of Moses (NJB)

### 7:1b

**that the law has authority over a man only as long as he lives?**

- that the law rules over someone while he is alive?

- that those laws have great authority over him until he dies?
- that the law/laws of this earth says/say what a person can and cannot do during his lifetime.

**that:** Here this word introduces what Paul questioned that they know.

**the law has authority over a man:** The Greek word that the BSB translates as has authority refers to having great power over someone. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

the law rules a person

the law has power over a person

the law is binding on a person (ESV)

See how you translated the same Greek word that the BSB translates as has authority in 6:9 (“has dominion”) or 6:14 (“have...dominion”).

**the law:** This refers to the same law (or laws) as in 7:1a.

**only as long as he lives:** This indicates that the laws apply while the person is alive. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

over people who are alive (CEV)

while that person is alive

## Romans 7:2

### Section 7:1–6: Believers must follow the new way of the Holy Spirit

In this section, Paul used the example of marriage and the husband dying to show that believers are no longer under the laws of Moses. They are under the new covenant with Jesus. We have died to sin and God has released us from the law of Moses so that we can serve God as the Holy Spirit guides and empowers us.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

We were released from the Law of Moses to serve God in the new way of the Holy Spirit

Dead to the Law, Alive to Serve in the Spirit

Serve<sup>(plur)</sup> God in the new way of the Holy Spirit

### 7:2a

**For instance, a married woman is bound by law to her husband as long as he lives.**

- For the law binds/ties a married woman to her husband during the time that he lives,
- For example, the law of marriage says a wife remains with her husband as long as he lives,

**For instance:** These words introduce an example of the law binding a person (7:1b). For example:

For example, (NIV)

**a married woman is bound by law to her husband as long as he lives:** Here the words bound by law refers to the law requiring the woman to remain married to her husband. She must behave as a woman married to a man. She is not free to marry another man. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

a married woman is tied to her husband by the law

a married woman is required by law to behave as married to her husband

This clause is passive. The law binds her to her husband. Some languages must use an active clause. For example:

the law binds/ties a married woman to her husband

when a woman marries, the law binds her to her husband (NLT)

the law says that she must/ought to be one with her husbandYakan Back Translation on TW.

### 7:2b

**But if her husband dies, she is released from the law of marriage.**

- but if he dies, then that law about marriage frees her from him.
- but that law says that the wife is free from her husband if he dies.

**she is released from the law of marriage:** Here the word released indicates that the law no longer requires the woman to remain married to her husband.

She is free to marry another man. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

she is untied from the law to be married to her husband

she is no longer required by the law of marriage to behave as married to him

This clause is passive. The law frees her from her marriage to her husband. Some languages must use an active clause. For example:

the law of marriage unties her

the laws of marriage no longer apply to her (NLT)

that law no longer has authority over her Yakan Back Translation on TW.

## Romans 7:3

### Section 7:1–6: Believers must follow the new way of the Holy Spirit

In this section, Paul used the example of marriage and the husband dying to show that believers are no longer under the laws of Moses. They are under the new covenant with Jesus. We have died to sin and God has released us from the law of Moses so that we can serve God as the Holy Spirit guides and empowers us.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

We were released from the Law of Moses to serve God in the new way of the Holy Spirit

Dead to the Law, Alive to Serve in the Spirit

Serve<sup>(plur)</sup> God in the new way of the Holy Spirit

#### 7:3a–d

**she is joined to another man...marries another man:** The phrase joined to and the word marries translate the same Greek word. There are several ways to interpret this word in the two places:

1. The word refers to marrying both times. For example:

married another man...remarries (NLT) (NIV, KJV, NASB, NLT, NET, GW, REB, NCV)

1. The word refers to adultery the first time and marrying the second time. For example:

lives with another man...marries another man (RSV) (BSB, RSV, GNT, NIV11, CEV, ESV)

1. The word refers to adultery both times. For example:

have relations with another man...has relations with another man (NJB) (NJB, NABRE)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1), because the Greek word is unlikely to mean two different things in this verse (interpretation (2))Barrett, Fitzmyer, Schreiner, Witherington, Lenski, Moo, Cranfield, Dunn, and Alford all translate the Greek word in the same way both times. Jewett does too, although he supports interpretation (3). and 7:2 refers to a woman remarrying after her first husband dies, so 7:3d is most likely referring to remarrying also. 7:2 clearly states that the woman is released from her marriage to her husband when he dies, and 7:3c repeats that she is free from that law. But if she was sinning with another man she was not married to, she is committing adultery regardless of whether her first husband is dead or not. So it is clear that the Greek word refers to marrying in 7:3d, as it does in 7:3b. Paul was talking about the law (or covenant) of marriage in both cases, whether it stands (7:2a) or has ended (7:3c). Also, Paul was talking about when the law of marriage is in effect, so interpretation (1) fits that discussion best.

#### 7:3a

**So then, if she is joined to another man while her husband is still alive,**

- So, if she becomes another man's wife while her first husband is still living,
- So then, if she marries another man and her husband is still alive,

**So then:** This Greek phrase introduces a result. Here are other ways to translate this word:

Accordingly (ESV)

So (NJB)

#### 7:3b

**she is called an adulteress;**

- she will be named a woman of adultery.
- people will say that she is an adulterer.

**she is called:** Here the Greek word that the BSB translates as is called is more literally “bear/take a name/title.” Here are other ways to translate this clause:

she will bear the name/title of

she will have the label of

**adulteress:** This word refers to a woman who has sexual intercourse with a man who is not her husband. Here are other ways to translate this word:

she is committing-adulteryKankanaey Back Translation on TW.

an adultery doing womanLiteral rendering of the Yongkom, 2004, © Bible Society Papua New Guinea.

### General Comment on 7:3a–b

Here the if-clause (7:3a) comes after its consequence (7:3b). In some languages the if-clause may come second. For example:

Accordingly, she will be called an adulteress if she lives with another man while her husband is alive (ESV)

### 7:3c

#### but if her husband dies, she is free from that law

- But if her husband dies, then the law no longer applies to her about that marriage,
- But if her husband has died, she is no longer tied/bound by what the law of marriage says about that man.

**she is free from that law:** The phrase that law refers to the law of marriage in 7:2b. Her husband has died, so the law no longer calls her married. She is free to marry someone else. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

the authority of that law over her also ceases-to-existKankanaey Back Translation on TW.

she is no longer bound by what the law says about thisTagbanwa Back Translation on TW.

### 7:3d

**and is not an adulteress, even if she marries another man.**

- and if she becomes another man’s wife after that, she is not a woman of adultery.
- And if she then marries another man, she is not an adulterer regarding the second marriage.

**and is not an adulteress, even if she marries another man:** This clause is still connected to “if her husband dies.” In some languages this phrase must be repeated for the correct meaning. For example:

and if she marries another man after he has died, she is not an adulteress

**marries:** For the interpretation issue about this word, see the note at 7:3a–d above.

## Romans 7:4

### Section 7:1–6: Believers must follow the new way of the Holy Spirit

In this section, Paul used the example of marriage and the husband dying to show that believers are no longer under the laws of Moses. They are under the new covenant with Jesus. We have died to sin and God has released us from the law of Moses so that we can serve God as the Holy Spirit guides and empowers us.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

We were released from the Law of Moses to serve God in the new way of the Holy Spirit

Dead to the Law, Alive to Serve in the Spirit

Serve<sup>(plur)</sup> God in the new way of the Holy Spirit

### 7:4a

#### Therefore, my brothers, you also died to the law

- ¶ Therefore, my brothers and sisters, you yourselves have also been made dead to the law
- ¶ So then, my fellow believers, as for you, God has made you as dead people regarding the need to obey the laws of Moses

**Therefore:** There are two ways to interpret the Greek word that the BSB translates as Therefore:

1. It means therefore here. For example:

So (NIV) (BSB, NIV, NASB, KJV, NLT, NET, REB)

1. It means in the same way here. For example:



Likewise (RSV) (RSV, GNT, NJB, ESV, CEV, NABRE, GW, NCV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1), because in 7:4-6 Paul gave his conclusion about dying to the Laws of Moses based on the analogy of the law of the husband (7:2-3). The BDAG lists “therefore” as the meaning here and does not list “likewise” as a sense for this word. The Louw and Nida lexicon, as well as the Liddell and Scott lexicon, also list “therefore” as a possible meaning but not “likewise.”

**brothers:** Here the word brothers refers to believers in Jesus, both men and women. The word indicates a close relationship because all believers are considered spiritual children of God. See how you translated this word in 7:1.

**you also died to the law:** The phrase died to is a figure of speech that indicates that the law no longer has any power over us. Some languages must change this metaphor into a simile. For example:

you have become as a dead person to the law

you became as if dead to the Laws of Moses

See how you translated the words died to in 6:2.

**you also died:** The Greek word that the BSB translates as died is literally “were caused to die.” It implies that God caused believers to be like dead people to the law. They are only to follow Jesus and the Holy Spirit. So Paul used the metaphor of death to make that clear. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

you also were put to death (NABRE)

God made you as if dead

**you:** Here the word you is emphatic in the Greek. Here are other ways to translate this word:

as for you

you yourselves

**also:** Here this word indicates that Paul said something more about the believers, probably connected to what he said in 7:1. Dunn (page 361).

**to the law:** Here the word law probably refers to the law of Moses. For example:

to the power of the Law (CEV)

to the Laws of Moses

#### 7:4b through the body of Christ,

- by joining you together with Christ when he died,
- when Christ died on the cross and it was as if you also died there with him.

**through the body of Christ:** Here the phrase the body of Christ refers to Jesus dying on the cross. Cranfield (page 336), Dunn (page 362), and Jewett (page 434). The word through indicates that Jesus dying on the cross enabled God to cause us to be dead to the law (7:4a). Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

because when Christ died in our place, it's as if we also died  
Western Bukidnon Manobo Back Translation on TW.

because of your being included/joined in dying in Cristo's death  
Kankanaey Back Translation on TW.

The phrase the body of Christ does not refer figuratively to believers being members of his body (as in 12:4-5 and other verses in the NT) here.

#### 7:4c that you might belong to another,

- and so you belong to someone else other than sin,
- And so you do not belong to the power of sin but you do belong to someone else.

**that you might belong to another:** This is a purpose clause. In this case believers already belong to another. In some languages a fulfilled purpose clause must be translated as a result clause. For example:

and so you belong to another

**belong to another:** The same Greek phrase here is translated as “joined to another” (BSB) in 7:3a and “marries” in 7:3d. But it means “be to/for another” here and implies a close relationship. It does not imply marriage here as it did in 7:3. Do not translate it as “join to” or “marry” here.

**another:** Here this word refers to someone other than (the power of) sin (chapter 6). It does not refer to someone other than Jesus (7:4b). In fact, 7:4d makes it clear that believers belong to Jesus.

In some languages a literal translation would indicate the wrong meaning. If that is true in your language, explain the proper meaning in your translation. For example:

another, someone other than the power of sin

#### 7:4d

#### to Him who was raised from the dead,

- and that person is Jesus, who was raised to life again from the dead,
- You belong to the person whom God caused to leave the spirits of dead people and be alive again.

**to Him who was raised from the dead:** This phrase explains who the other person (“another”) in 7:4c is. This describes Jesus. Believers belong to him. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

and that person/one has been raised from the dead

who is Jesus, who has risen from death

If you explain the word Him as Jesus, some languages need to translate the clause who was raised from the dead without the word who for the correct meaning. For example:

who is Jesus, the one has risen from death

who is Jesus, the person God raised from death

**who was raised from the dead:** This clause is passive. Some languages must use an active clause. For example:

whom God raised from the dead

**raised from the dead:** This phrase refers to God making Jesus alive again after he died and was put in the tomb. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

raised...from death (GNT)

brought...back to life (GW)

See how you translated this phrase in 4:24 or 6:9.

#### 7:4e

#### in order that we might bear fruit to God.

- and we<sup>(incl)</sup> belong to him so that we<sup>(incl)</sup> will/might bear fruit for God.
- And you<sup>(plur)</sup> and I belong to him to do good things/deeds that benefit God.

**in order that we might bear fruit to God:** This phrase connects to “belong to another” (7:4c), not “raised from the dead” (7:4d). The purpose of us belonging to Jesus is to bear fruit to God. In some languages the correct connection must be explained in the translation. For example:

and you<sup>(plur)</sup> and I belong to him in order that we might bear fruit to God

**we might bear fruit to God:** The phrase bear fruit is a metaphor that means “doing good deeds that produce good results.” These good results benefit God or his kingdom. In some languages a literal translation would not have the correct meaning. If that is true in your language, you may want to:

- Use a simile. For example:

be like plants that produce fruit for God

- Make the meaning more explicit. For example:

we might produce good results that honor God

- Translate without the figure of speech. For example:

we might serve God

we can do the work of God  
Otomi Back Translation on TW.

we will now live righteous lives to the glory of God  
Tagbanwa Back Translation on TW.

**we:** Paul changed from “you<sup>(plur)</sup>” to we. He now includes himself with the believers about bearing fruit for God. See the example above.

## Romans 7:5

### Section 7:1–6: Believers must follow the new way of the Holy Spirit

In this section, Paul used the example of marriage and the husband dying to show that believers are no longer under the laws of Moses. They are under the new covenant with Jesus. We have died to sin and God

has released us from the law of Moses so that we can serve God as the Holy Spirit guides and empowers us. Here are other possible headings for this section:

We were released from the Law of Moses to serve God in the new way of the Holy Spirit

Dead to the Law, Alive to Serve in the Spirit

Serve<sup>(plur)</sup> God in the new way of the Holy Spirit

### 7:5a

#### **For when we lived according to the flesh,**

- For when we<sup>(incl)</sup> earlier lived according to our physical life,
- When our physical being was guiding us, before we believed,

**For:** Here this word introduces an explanation for what Paul said in 7:4. In some languages it is more natural to omit this word and let the context imply that connection.

**when we lived according to the flesh:** This clause refers to how believers lived before they believed in Jesus. Cranfield (page 337), Dunn (page 363), and Moo (on TW). Here are other ways to translate this clause:

when we lived according to our human nature (GNT)

While we were still living by our natural inclinations (NJB)

When we were controlled by our old nature (NLT)

when we were still obeying our own desire Western Bukidnon Manobo Back Translation on TW.

Here this clause refers in general to the way all people live, without focusing on sin, although that is implied. Paul made the idea of sin clear in 7:5b.

### 7:5b

#### **the sinful passions aroused by the law were at work in our bodies,**

- sinful desires, through the laws of Moses, were working in the parts of our bodies,
- the laws of Moses stirred up our thinking and our desires to do evil caused various parts of our bodies.

**the sinful passions...were at work:** Paul spoke of these passions as if they were people working. In some languages it is not natural to speak of passions in that way. If that is true in your language, translate the meaning in a natural way. For example:

our sinful passions...were like someone working

our sinful desires...were causing us to be working

**the sinful passions:** The Greek word that the BSB translates as passions refers to any kind of desire. Here Paul referred to only those desires that are sinful.

**were at work:** The Greek word that the BSB translates as were at work refers to doing something that produces the desired result. It does not imply that the work is difficult.

This phrase indicates that the sinful passions worked over a period of time. Here it refers to the whole time before a believer started believing in Jesus. Here is another way to translate this phrase:

were working

**aroused by the law:** This phrase is literally “through the law.” It indicates that the Laws of Moses helped the sinful passions to be at work in our members. The Laws of Moses pointed out what deeds were bad to do, and our sinful passions then wanted to do them. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

stirred up by the Law (GNT)

the sinful desires, which the Law stirred up, were at work

through the Laws of Moses saying what deeds were evil

**our bodies:** Here the Greek word that the BSB translates as bodies refers to parts of the body. Here it implies deeds done with the parts of the body. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

any part of yourselves (GNT)

yourselves Yakan Back Translation on TW.

See how you translated “parts” in 6:13.

### 7:5c bearing fruit for death.

- and so we bore fruit for death.
- And our evil deeds benefited/honored death.

**bearing fruit for death:** Here the phrase bearing fruit is a metaphor that means “doing evil deeds that produce evil results.” These evil results benefit death and the power that death has over people. In some languages a literal translation would not have the correct meaning. If that is true in your language, you may want to:

- Use a simile. For example:

being like plants that produce fruit for death

- Make the meaning more explicit. For example:

producing evil results that honor death

- Translate without the figure of speech of bearing fruit. For example:

serving death

doing the work of death

living evil lives that glorified death

**for death:** Here this phrase is used in a similar way as “to God” was in 7:4. It is a figure of speech that speaks of death as if it were a person who benefits from the evil deeds that people do. See the above examples.

## Romans 7:6

### Section 7:1–6: Believers must follow the new way of the Holy Spirit

In this section, Paul used the example of marriage and the husband dying to show that believers are no longer under the laws of Moses. They are under the new covenant with Jesus. We have died to sin and God has released us from the law of Moses so that we can serve God as the Holy Spirit guides and empowers us.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

We were released from the Law of Moses to serve God in the new way of the Holy Spirit

Dead to the Law, Alive to Serve in the Spirit

Serve<sup>(plur)</sup> God in the new way of the Holy Spirit

### 7:6a But now, having died to what bound us,

- But now, because we have died to those things that had held us captive,
- But now, we have become as/like dead to them. Before we believed, they were like a prison for us.

**But now:** There is contrast to the old life where the law stirred our thinking to sin to now God having set us free from that way of life.

**having died to what bound us:** The phrase died to is a figure of speech that indicates that the law no longer has any power over us. When we began believing in Jesus, we were no longer under the laws of Moses. Some languages must change this metaphor into a simile. For example:

having become as a dead person to what bound us

became as if dead to what bound us by telling us what to do

became as if dead to the commands that bound us

See how you translated the words died to in 6:2.

**having died:** This clause tells the reason or means for being released from the law. For example:

because we died (GNT)

by dying (NIV)

**to what bound us:** This phrase further describes the laws of Moses. It does not separate these laws of Moses from other laws of Moses. For the correct meaning in some languages, translators must avoid the word what. For example:

now we are released from the law, having died to it. It bound us. We are released so that...

**what bound us:** The Greek word that the BSB translates as bound refers to holding something so that it cannot leave. Being in prison is one example of the meaning here, but the meaning is more general than that. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

to that which held us captive (ESV)

the law held us like prisoners (NCV)

### 7:6b

#### **we have been released from the law,**

- we<sup>(incl)</sup> are free from the rule of the laws of Moses,
- God has freed us from the control of the laws that he gave to Moses.

**we have been released from the law:** In contrast to what was true before (7:5), we have been released from the law is true in the present. Translate this word with that meaning.

**released from the law:** Here the word released indicates that the laws of Moses no longer rule over us. We are free to follow the Holy Spirit. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

untied from the law

no longer required to submit ourselves to the law

The clause is passive. Some languages must use an active clause. For example:

God has released us from the law

See how you translated released from in 7:2.

**the law:** Here the law refers to the laws of Moses.

#### **General Comment on 7:6a–b**

In some languages it is more natural to have the main clause (7:6b) before the reason clause (7:6a). For example:

But now we are released from the law, having died to that which held us captive (ESV)

But the Law no longer rules over us. We are like dead people, and it cannot have any power over us (CEV)

### 7:6c

#### **so that we serve in the new way of the Spirit,**

- and so we are serving God in a new way that is produced by the Holy Spirit
- Therefore we do the work of God in a new way by means of his Spirit helping us,

**so that we serve:** The phrase so that introduces the purpose of being released from the laws of Moses (7:6b). It does not connect to being bound (7:6a). In some languages that connection will need to be made clear. For example:

we were released so that we serve

This purpose has already begun. In some languages a result clause must be used for that meaning. For example:

and so we serve

we were released therefore we serve

**we serve:** Paul implied here that we serve God. Some languages must add who is served. For example:

we can serve God (NLT)

**serve:** Here this word refers to doing things that God wants people to do. This includes worship, praying, giving tithes, helping others, and doing whatever work that God has given to that person. Here are other ways to translate this word:

do his will

do the things that he commands us to do

See how you translated this word in 1:9.

**in the new way:** As believers, we serve God in a new way. That new way comes from the Holy Spirit. He leads us so we can serve God in that new way. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

in the new way of living in the Spirit (NLT)

based on the new way-of-life that comes from the Holy Spirit  
Kankanaey Back Translation on TW.

**the Spirit:** There are two ways to interpret the Greek word that the BSB translates as Spirit:

1. It refers to the Holy Spirit. The BSB and other English versions indicate that meaning by capitalizing the word. (BSB, RSV, NIV, GNT, NASB, ESV, NLT, CEV, NET, NCV)
2. It refers to the believer's spirit. For example:

the spirit (NJB) (NJB, KJV, NABRE, GW, REB)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1), but it is difficult to choose, as scholars on both sides make good points about why they choose their interpretation. Witherington (page 177), who supports interpretation (1), says it refers to the new covenant, which is connected with the Holy Spirit, and the old covenant, which is connected with the Law and letter of it. Lenski (page 455), who supports interpretation (2), says this verse is in contrast to the “flesh” (7:5) and so it should refer to the spirit of a person. Morris (on TW) says it means both. Many scholars do not explain their choice.

#### 7:6d

**and not in the old way of the written code.**

- and not in the old/obsolete letters.
- and we do not do the work of God in an old way by means of the/those written laws.

**and not in the old way of the written code:** The phrase “we serve (God)” is implied here. In some languages it is more natural to repeat it here. For example:

we do not serve God in the old way of the written code

**the old way of the written code:** The Greek word that the BSB translates as old way refers to something that is old and no longer useful. The laws of Moses belong to the old covenant, but Jesus has given us a new covenant. The word of indicates that the written code described that old way to serve God. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

the old way of obeying the letter of the law (NLT)

an old way dictated by written words (GW)

the obsolete way described in the written Law

**the written code:** The Greek word is literally “letter.” It can refer to a single letter of the alphabet or a long written document like the book of Romans. Here it refers to the Old Testament. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

the letter (NASB)

a written law (GNT)

the letter of the law (NLT)

## Romans 7:7

### Section 7:7-12: It is sin that is bad, not the laws

In the last section Paul said that believers died to the law of Moses (7:4), that it is obsolete (7:6), and that it arouses sinful passions (7:5). In this section Paul answered a possible wrong conclusion that someone might make from what he just said. Someone might think that Paul meant that the law is sinful. But Paul clearly indicated that he did not think that. The laws of Moses point out what is sin, and sin causes people to want to do the things that the law says are sin. Sinning leads to death. The laws of Moses are holy and good. But the commandments make it clear what sin is and at the same time arouse sinful passions. Those passions lead to death.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

What about the Laws of Moses and sin?

God’s Law Reveals Our Sin (NLT)

Sin deceives us but the law is holy

### General Comment on 7:7-25

Paul used the word “I” in this section and 7:13-25 too. There are at least seven different ways See Cranfield (pages 342-344). that scholars think what Paul meant by “I” here. Here are the five main ones:

1. Paul was referring to himself as a Christian, See Schreiner (pages 359-364). implying all believers think the same way and have the same struggles.
2. Paul, as a believer, spoke of his experience before he believed. He spoke generally enough so that other people can see that they had similar struggles. See Jewett (pages 441-444). Paul then spoke about where we stand as believers regarding these struggles in chapter 8.
3. It refers generally to anyone who is not a believer but wants to be a good person by following the law. Paul used “I” to make the struggles in these verses more personal. Chapter 8 then explains the victory that believers have in contrast to the person of 7:7-25.
4. Paul was referring to Adam and from that all people.
5. Paul was referring to the history of Israel.

It is recommended that you use “I” in these verses. The English versions also use “I” and do not explain it in their translations.

### 7:7a

#### What then shall we say?

- ¶ So then, should we<sup>(incl)</sup> say this:
- ¶ Therefore, is it right to say that
- ¶ And so, let’s not ask this,

**What then shall we say?:** The word then indicates a connection to previous verses. Here it introduces the question “What shall we say?” In some languages it is more natural to have the word then first. For example:

Then/Therefore, what shall we say?

This is a rhetorical question. It draws attention to what Paul said next. See how you translated this clause in 6:1.

### 7:7b

#### Is the law sin? Certainly not!

- “Maybe the law is sin?” Certainly not!
- the Law is sinful? No indeed!
- “Is the law bad?” No, that is not true at all!

**Is the law sin? Certainly not!:** This is a rhetorical question and its answer. It emphasizes that the law is not sin. Translate these words with that meaning. Here are some ways:

- As a rhetorical question and its answer. See the examples in the notes below.
- As a statement. For example:

Surely we should not say that the law is sin.

We should not say that the law is sin. No way!

**Is the law sin?:** At the beginning of this question the words “Shall we say” are implied from 7:7a. In some languages it is natural to leave those words off, since they were just said in 7:7a. In other languages these words must be added here for a natural question. For example:

Shall we say that the law is sin?

In 7:5 Paul said that the law aroused our sinful passions. Someone might misunderstand Paul’s words and then think that the law is bad. Here Paul referred to that thinking with this question. He showed that this thinking was clearly wrong with the words “By

no means” after this question. Here are other ways to translate this question:

Is the law itself sinful?

do you think that I say that God’s law is bad? Otomi Back Translation on TW.

is it right to say/think that the law is evil?

**the law:** This probably refers to the Law of Moses here. For example:

the Law (GNT)

Moses’ laws (GW)

**Certainly not!:** The Greek is literally “May it not be.” It indicates a very strong “no.” The law is not sin. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

Not at all!

By no means! (ESV)

Of course not! (NLT)

No, indeed!

See how you translated this phrase in 3:4 or 6:2. Note that “Surely” and “No way” in the As a statement examples in the first note of 7:7b translate the words Certainly not! here. If you used “Surely” or “No way” there, do not translate these words here.

### 7:7c

#### Indeed, I would not have been mindful of sin if not for the law.

- But I did not know what sin was except by hearing what the laws said that I shouldn’t do.
- I only knew what sins were because of the laws saying what was wrong.

**Indeed:** This word indicates that in Greek “I would not have been mindful of sin if not for the law” is connected with Paul saying that the law is not sin (7:7b). In some languages this connection can be implied. For example:

If there were no law,...Yakan Back Translation on TW.

**I would not have been mindful of sin if not for the law:** The Greek is literally “I did not know sin except through law.” It indicates that only through law did Paul know what sin was. But after he heard the law he knew what things were wrong to do. In some languages it is easier to understand the meaning without using the word not twice. For example:

I only knew what sin was through hearing the law

**I:** Paul used himself as an example of anyone in this connection of law to sin.

#### 7:7d-e

**(reordered) For if, contrary to fact, the law had not said, “You must not covet,” then, contrary to fact, I would not have known coveting.**

**For I would not have been aware of coveting if the law had not said, “Do not covet.”:** These words refer to a situation that did not happen, but which Paul spoke of to make his point about the law and sin clear. Some languages have a word, phrase, or special grammar to indicate that. For example:

Had-it-been-that the law had not said, “Do not covet,” it would-have-been-that I would not have been aware of coveting

if, contrary-to-fact, the law had not said, “Do not covet,” then, contrary-to-fact, I would not have been aware of coveting

#### 7:7d

**For I would not have been aware of coveting**

- Indeed, for example, I would not have known desiring to take for myself the things of someone else
- Look/Hey, here is an example. I learned what it is to desire other people’s things only

**For:** Here this word introduces an example. Morris (on TW). Some scholars say it introduces an explanation. But that would imply that coveting is the root cause of all sin. For example:

For example, (GW)

The Greek here is actually two words: “and for.” The word “and” here indicates emphasis. For example:

Indeed, for example

**coveting:** This word refers to desiring to possess for oneself something that belongs to someone else.

#### 7:7e

**if the law had not said, “Do not covet.”**

- if the Laws had not said: “Do<sup>(sing)</sup> not desire to take for yourself the things of someone else.”
- because the law in the Scriptures said: “Do not desire other people’s things.”

**the law had not said:** Paul made law the subject of “speak.” In some languages it is more natural to refer to God speaking here. For example:

God in his laws had not said

**Do not covet:** This is one of the Ten Commandments (Exodus 20:17). It is a command to not covet. In some languages it may be helpful to explain that it is from the Old Testament. For example:

the law in the Scriptures had not said: “Do not covet.”

These words are a quote of Exodus 20:17. If you indicate the location of quotes from the Old Testament with cross-references, you may want to do so here.

## Romans 7:8

### Section 7:7-12: It is sin that is bad, not the laws

In the last section Paul said that believers died to the law of Moses (7:4), that it is obsolete (7:6), and that it arouses sinful passions (7:5). In this section Paul answered a possible wrong conclusion that someone might make from what he just said. Someone might think that Paul meant that the law is sinful. But Paul clearly indicated that he did not think that. The laws of Moses point out what is sin, and sin causes people to want to do the things that the law says are sin. Sinning leads to death. The laws of Moses are holy and good. But the commandments make it clear what sin is and at the same time arouse sinful passions. Those passions lead to death.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

What about the Laws of Moses and sin?

God’s Law Reveals Our Sin (NLT)



Sin deceives us but the law is holy

### General Comment on 7:7–25

Paul used the word “I” in this section and 7:13–25 too. There are at least seven different ways See Cranfield (pages 342–344). that scholars think what Paul meant by “I” here. Here are the five main ones:

1. Paul was referring to himself as a Christian, See Schreiner (pages 359–364). implying all believers think the same way and have the same struggles.
2. Paul, as a believer, spoke of his experience before he believed. He spoke generally enough so that other people can see that they had similar struggles. See Jewett (pages 441–444). Paul then spoke about where we stand as believers regarding these struggles in chapter 8.
3. It refers generally to anyone who is not a believer but wants to be a good person by following the law. Paul used “I” to make the struggles in these verses more personal. Chapter 8 then explains the victory that believers have in contrast to the person of 7:7–25.
4. Paul was referring to Adam and from that all people.
5. Paul was referring to the history of Israel.

It is recommended that you use “I” in these verses. The English versions also use “I” and do not explain it in their translations.

### 7:8a–b

**But sin, seizing its opportunity through the commandment, produced in me:** The figure of speech here speaks of sin as a person that seized its opportunity. Some languages must translate the meaning without the figure of speech. For example:

through the existence of the commandment, the power of sin caused me to have

sin was like a bad/evil person, who seeing an opportunity because of what the commandment said, caused/pulled me into

### 7:8a

**But sin, seizing its opportunity through the commandment,**

- And sin took the opportunities/openings by using the command
- With that law/command as/like a tool, sin took any chance/occasion

**But:** There is contrast of “Do not covet” (7:7e) with sin producing all kinds of coveting (7:8a–b). But there is

no contrast to the main point of 7:7 (“if it had not been for the law, I would not have known sin”). Some languages will not see the connection as contrast here. For example:

When...Otomi Back Translation on TW.

And (NCV)

**seizing its opportunity:** The Greek word that the BSB translates as seizing is literally “having taken.” Sin, as if it were a person, saw an opportunity to cause Paul to covet. That opportunity came about because the law said “do not covet,” and Paul (and anyone for that matter) then wanted what did not belong to him. Here are other ways to translate these words:

finding an opportunity (NABRE)

took the opportunity (GW)

**its opportunity:** The word opportunity refers to a situation that someone can use to their benefit. Paul may have seen a nice house or nice clothing that belonged to someone else, and sin took that situation and tempted Paul to covet those things. Here are other ways to translate this word:

a chance

a road/way

possibility

**through the commandment:** Here the word through refers to something being used as a tool to do something. Dunn (page 380) calls it the “instrument” of sin. Here it indicates that the commandment was like a tool that sin used to influence Paul. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

in the commandment (NABRE)

using this commandment

**the commandment:** This refers to the words of someone in authority saying what should be done or what should not be done.

The word commandment is singular and a different Greek word that the word translated as “law” in 7:7. So it probably refers to the one law Paul mentioned in 7:7: “You shall not covet.” Jewett (pages 449–450), Witherington (page 189), Moo (on TW).

Some languages use the same word for “law” and commandment. If that is true in your language, refer to the law in 7:7e. For example:

that law

### 7:8b

#### **produced in me every kind of covetous desire.**

- and created in me every kind of desire to take for myself the things of someone else,
- and caused inside me to desire all kinds of other people’s things.

**produced in me:** The Greek word that the BSB translates as produced refers to causing something to exist BDAG (page 531). and focuses on the result rather than the action itself. Moulton and Milligan (page 335). Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

making me have (CEV)

work in my heart with the result that Uma Back Translation on TW.

The Greek tense is a simple past. It is not clear if Paul implied whether this action had stopped or continued at the time he wrote this letter. Later he talked about his feelings at the time using the present tense. But here you should use the past tense.

**every kind of covetous desire:** The phrase covetous desire refers to desiring to possess for oneself something that belongs to someone else, like “covet” in 7:7. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

all kinds of coveting

all ways to covet

### 7:8c

#### **For apart from the law, sin is dead.**

- because without the Laws, sin is like something dead.
- For if the laws of Moses did not exist, sinning would have no power.

**For:** This conjunction introduces the basis for Paul saying that sin used the law like a tool to cause Paul to covet. Here is another way to translate this word:

because

**apart from the law:** This phrase supposes there is no law for the sake of what Paul said next. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

without the law (KJV)

If there were no law (NLT)

**the law:** Here the word law refers to the laws of Moses.

**sin is dead:** The Greek has no verb here. In English usually a form of “be/is” can be added. Another way to translate this expression is:

sin lies dead (ESV)

The word dead is figurative here. It refers to sin being without power. Some languages will need to:

- Change it to a simile. For example:

sin is like a dead thing

- Translate without the figure of speech. For example:

sin has no power (NCV)

## **Romans 7:9**

### **Section 7:7–12: It is sin that is bad, not the laws**

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What about the Laws of Moses and sin?

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### General Comment on 7:7–25

Paul used the word “I” in this section and 7:13–25 too. There are at least seven different waysSee Cranfield (pages 342–344). that scholars think what Paul meant by “I” here. Here are the five main ones:

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4. Paul was referring to Adam and from that all people.
5. Paul was referring to the history of Israel.

It is recommended that you use “I” in these verses.The English versions also use “I” and do not explain it in their translations.

### 7:9a

**Once I was alive apart from the law;**

- Before/Earlier I lived without laws,
- At one time in the past, I was living without connection to law.

This verse begins with a Greek conjunction that probably indicates a general connection to the previous verse. It introduces a new thought connected to what Paul had just said. For example:

And... (NET)

Many English versions omit the conjunction and allow the context to indicate the connection.

**Once I was alive apart from the law:** The word Once indicates a time prior to the time Paul wrote this letter. For example:

At one time I was alive without any laws (GW)

Earlier I lived apart from laws

**apart from:** This phrase indicates that Paul lived separated from the laws of Moses. He did not know them, or they did not affect his life. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

without (KJV)

in the absence of (REB)

### 7:9b

**but when the commandment came,**

- but when the command arrived,
- But when the law/command became obvious to me,

**but when the commandment came:** Here the word when indicates that at a time in the past, the commandment came. That ended the time of Paul living apart from the law. It began the time when sin was alive in his life (7:9c).

**the commandment came:** Paul spoke of the commandment as if it were a person who came to Paul. Some languages cannot use the word came here. For example:

the commandment became clear to me

**commandment:** This word is singular. It probably refers to the law to not covet. See how you translated this word in 7:8.

### 7:9c

**sin sprang to life and I died.**

- sin became like something alive to me and I died.
- sin became powerful in my life and I came under God's sentence of death.

**sin sprang to life:** This is a figure of speech. It indicates that sin, which had been like something dead (7:8c), is now like something alive. It was influencing Paul and causing him to sin.

In some languages it is not natural to speak of sin as if it sprang to life. If that is true in your language, you may want to:

- Change it to a simile. For example:

sin became like an alive thing in my life

- Translate without the figure of speech. For example:

sin became powerful

**and I died:** There is an issue with the verse numbers here:

1. Verse 10 starts with these words. For example:

<sup>9</sup>...sin came to life <sup>10</sup>and I died. (NJB) (GNT, NJB, NABRE, NRSV, NLT, GW, CEV, NET, NCV)

1. Verse 10 starts after these words. For example:

<sup>9</sup>sin came alive and I died. <sup>10</sup>... (ESV) (BSB, RSV, NIV, NASB, KJV, ESV, REB)

It is recommended that you put the verse number where the major language version puts it. If there is no major language version in your area, you should follow option (1), because the UBS Greek New Testament 5th edition follows the tradition of having these words in verse 10.

**I died:** This is a figure of speech. The words “sin came alive” implies that Paul sinned. God’s penalty for sin is death (6:23). So even though Paul continued to live while he sinned, God had marked him for death because of that sin.

In some languages a literal translation would wrongly indicate that Paul actually died at that time. If that is true in your language, you may want to:

- Change it to a simile. For example:

I became like a dead thing/person in my life

- Explain the figure of speech in your translation. For example:

I came under God’s judgment of death

- Translate literally and explain the figure of speech in a footnote. Here is an example footnote:

This is a figure of speech. Paul sinned and God judged him worthy of death. See 6:20–23.

## Romans 7:10

### Section 7:7–12: It is sin that is bad, not the laws

In the last section Paul said that believers died to the law of Moses (7:4), that it is obsolete (7:6), and that

it arouses sinful passions (7:5). In this section Paul answered a possible wrong conclusion that someone might make from what he just said. Someone might think that Paul meant that the law is sinful. But Paul clearly indicated that he did not think that. The laws of Moses point out what is sin, and sin causes people to want to do the things that the law says are sin. Sinning leads to death. The laws of Moses are holy and good. But the commandments make it clear what sin is and at the same time arouse sinful passions. Those passions lead to death.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

What about the Laws of Moses and sin?

God’s Law Reveals Our Sin (NLT)

Sin deceives us but the law is holy

### General Comment on 7:7–25

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1. Paul was referring to himself as a Christian,See Schreiner (pages 359–364). implying all believers think the same way and have the same struggles.
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3. It refers generally to anyone who is not a believer but wants to be a good person by following the law. Paul used “I” to make the struggles in these verses more personal. Chapter 8 then explains the victory that believers have in contrast to the person of 7:7–25.
4. Paul was referring to Adam and from that all people.
5. Paul was referring to the history of Israel.

It is recommended that you use “I” in these verses.The English versions also use “I” and do not explain it in their translations.

### 7:10a–b

**So I discovered that the very commandment that was meant to bring life actually brought death:** The Greek begins with the word often translated “and.” The BSB translates this word as So. Here it indicates

that Paul said something more about the commandment, life, and death. For example:

And the commandment... (GNT)

#### 7:10a

##### **So I discovered that**

- And I realized that
- But it occurred to me that

**I discovered that:** The Greek is literally “was found to/for me.” It indicates that as he lived he realized that trying to obey the commandment caused him to want to break it even more. It does not indicate that Paul was looking for the purpose of the commandment. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

it occurred to me that

proved in my experience (REB)

#### 7:10b

##### **the very commandment that was meant to bring life actually brought death.**

- the goal of that commandment was life, but for me the goal was changed to death.
- although the purpose of that commandment was so that I would live well, it destined/marked me for death instead.

**the very commandment:** Here the word very indicates that the commandment connected to life is the same commandment connected to death. It emphasizes that it is the same commandment. For example:

the commandment which was intended to bring me life actually brought me death (GW)

concerning the law..., it is the very law that...  
Otomí Back Translation on TW.

**that was meant to bring life:** The Greek is literally “to/for life.” It indicates that the goal or intention of the commandment is life. The BDAG does not list this verse for eis “to/for,” but the two senses that are appropriate to this context both refer to goal. Here are other ways to translate this Greek phrase:

that was for life (NABRE)

which was meant to be a direction to life (JBP)

which should have led to life (REB)

was given in order that people would know the path that leads to life  
Kankanaey Back Translation on TW.

**actually brought death:** The Greek is literally “this (was) for death.” Instead of a goal of life, the commandment not to covet caused the goal to be death, because Paul wanted to break the commandment. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

it was for death

was a direction to death

to lead to death (REB)

put me on the path that leads to death

## Romans 7:11

### **Section 7:7–12: It is sin that is bad, not the laws**

In the last section Paul said that believers died to the law of Moses (7:4), that it is obsolete (7:6), and that it arouses sinful passions (7:5). In this section Paul answered a possible wrong conclusion that someone might make from what he just said. Someone might think that Paul meant that the law is sinful. But Paul clearly indicated that he did not think that. The laws of Moses point out what is sin, and sin causes people to want to do the things that the law says are sin. Sinning leads to death. The laws of Moses are holy and good. But the commandments make it clear what sin is and at the same time arouse sinful passions. Those passions lead to death.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

What about the Laws of Moses and sin?

God’s Law Reveals Our Sin (NLT)

Sin deceives us but the law is holy

### **General Comment on 7:7–25**

Paul used the word “I” in this section and 7:13–25 too. There are at least seven different ways  
See Cranfield (pages 342–344). that scholars think what Paul meant by “I” here. Here are the five main ones:

1. Paul was referring to himself as a Christian, See Schreiner (pages 359–364). implying all believers think the same way and have the same struggles.
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3. It refers generally to anyone who is not a believer but wants to be a good person by following the law. Paul used “I” to make the struggles in these verses more personal. Chapter 8 then explains the victory that believers have in contrast to the person of 7:25.
4. Paul was referring to Adam and from that all people.
5. Paul was referring to the history of Israel.

It is recommended that you use “I” in these verses. The English versions also use “I” and do not explain it in their translations.

#### 7:11a–b

**sin, seizing its opportunity through the commandment, deceived me:** There are three ways to interpret what the phrase through the commandment connects to:

1. It connects to the phrase seizing an opportunity, as in the BSB. (BSB, RSV, NIV, NJB, ESV, NABRE, NLT, GW, CEV, NET)
2. It connects to the phrase deceived me. For example:

Sin found its chance, and by means of the commandment it deceived me (GNT) (GNT)

1. It connects to sin or the whole clause. For example:

in the commandment sin found its opportunity to seduce me (REB) (REB)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1), because it is unlikely that Paul would imply that the commandment had a part in deceiving him, as interpretation (2) implies.

#### 7:11a

**For sin, seizing its opportunity through the commandment,**

- ¶ For sin took the opportunities/openings by using the command
- ¶ With that law/command as/like a tool, sin took any chance/opportunity,

**For:** This word introduces an explanation of how the commandment now leads to death for Paul. Some languages, for a natural connection, will omit this word.

**seizing its opportunity through the commandment:** See how you translated these words in 7:8.

#### 7:11b

**deceived me**

- and tricked me
- and it caused me to do wrong.

**deceived me:** Here Paul continued to speak of sin as a person. Some languages cannot speak of sin in that way. If that is true in your language, you may want to:

- Make it a simile. For example:

like someone who deceived me

- Translate without the figure of speech. For example:

caused me to sin

#### 7:11c

**and through the commandment put me to death.**

- and killed me by using it.
- And it used that law/command to mark/destine me for death without end.

**through the commandment put me to death:** Here the word that the BSB translates as the commandment is literally “it.” For example:

through it killed me (ESV)

**put me to death:** Here Paul continued to speak of sin as a person. Some languages cannot speak of sin in that way. If that is true in your language, you may want to:

- Make it a simile. For example:

like someone who killed me

- Translate without the figure of speech. For example:

caused me to die

**put...to death:** Here this phrase refers to being marked for death.

In some languages a literal translation would wrongly refer only to physical death. If that is true in your lan-

guage, you may want to explain it in your translation. For example:

marked/destined me for death

caused me to have God's verdict of death

## Romans 7:12

### Section 7:7–12: It is sin that is bad, not the laws

In the last section Paul said that believers died to the law of Moses (7:4), that it is obsolete (7:6), and that it arouses sinful passions (7:5). In this section Paul answered a possible wrong conclusion that someone might make from what he just said. Someone might think that Paul meant that the law is sinful. But Paul clearly indicated that he did not think that. The laws of Moses point out what is sin, and sin causes people to want to do the things that the law says are sin. Sinning leads to death. The laws of Moses are holy and good. But the commandments make it clear what sin is and at the same time arouse sinful passions. Those passions lead to death.

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3. It refers generally to anyone who is not a believer but wants to be a good person by following the law. Paul used "I" to make the struggles in these verses more personal. Chapter 8 then explains the victory that believers have in contrast to the person of 7:7–25.

4. Paul was referring to Adam and from that all people.
5. Paul was referring to the history of Israel.

It is recommended that you use "I" in these verses. The English versions also use "I" and do not explain it in their translations.

### 7:12a

#### So then, the law is holy,

- So then, the laws of God are holy,
- In conclusion, the law is from God and perfect,

**So then:** This introduces Paul's conclusion and final answer to "is the law sin?" (7:7).

**law:** Here this word refers to God's laws in the Old Testament.

**holy:** Here this word indicates that the laws come to us from God, KBT lists this verse under sense A.2. and they have the same character as God. KBT sense A.4 is also appropriate here. There is nothing wrong in God's laws.

### 7:12b

#### and the commandment is holy, righteous, and good.

- and the law/command is holy, right, and good.
- and every law/command is from God and perfect, and right/correct, and good.

**the commandment:** This phrase probably refers to the individual commands within the laws of God Cranfield (page 353). or of the command to not covet (7:7) representing all the laws. Moo (on TW). Translate this phrase as you have in 7:8–11.

**holy:** Translate this word as you did in 7:12a.

**righteous:** This word indicates that the commandment expresses the right command.

**good:** Like God is good (Mark 10:18), so also his commandment is good.

## Romans 7:13

### Section 7:13–25: Sin prevents us from doing what is right

In this section Paul answered another possible wrong conclusion about the law. In 7:12 Paul said that the law is good. Now he asked if it is right to think that the law brought death. The answer is no. Sin brought death and this shows that sin is very bad. Paul then talked about his own struggle with sinning even though he agrees that the law is good. He felt he was captive to sin. But God can rescue us from that captivity.

For the use of “I” in this section, see the General Comment in the summary of Section 7:7-12.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

The way that Paul struggled to stop sinning

The power of sin

### 7:13a-b

**Did that which is good...become death to me?**

**Certainly not!:** This is a rhetorical question and its answer. It emphasizes that the believers in Rome should not think that the law, called here that which is good, caused Paul to be marked for death. Translate this clause with that meaning. Here are some ways:

- As a rhetorical question. For example:

Do you think that the/that good thing become death to me?

Don't you realize that the laws, which/they are good, did not cause me to be marked/destined for death?

- As a statement. For example:

Indeed, that which is good did not become death to me.

Surely you understand that the laws, which/they are good, did not cause me to be marked/destined for death.

- As a command. For example:

Do not think that which is good became death to me

Understand this: the laws, which/they are good, did not cause me to be marked/destined for death.

**that which is good:** This phrase refers to God's laws (7:12). In some languages it will be much clearer to make that explicit. For example:

that which is good, namely the laws,

the laws, and we already said that they are good

See also examples in the previous note.

**become death to me:** The Greek literally translates these words. They indicate that when Paul broke the law, it became as a verdict/judgment of death for him. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

bring death to me (ESV)

resulted in my dying (NJB)

cause my death (NLT)

### 7:13a

**Did that which is good, then, become death to me?**

- ¶ So then, do you think that that good thing became as death to/for me?
- ¶ So, it is not right to say that a good thing, namely, the law from God, became the penalty of death without end for me.

**Did that which is good, then, become death to me?:**

The word then occurs in the middle of the clause. In some languages it is more natural to be first. For example:

So then, did that which is good bring death to me?

### 7:13b

**Certainly not!**

- By no means! (ESV)
- No indeed!

**Certainly not!:** The Greek is literally “May it not be.” It indicates a very strong “no.” The law did not bring death to Paul. See how you translated this phrase in 3:4 or 7:7. Note that “Indeed” and “Surely” in the As a statement examples in 7:13a-b translate the words Certainly not! here. If you used those words there (or something similar), do not translate these words here.

### 7:13c

**But in order that sin might be exposed as sin,**

- Instead, so that sin would be revealed truly as sin,
- Rather, in order that I saw that sin was clearly sin/bad,

**But:** This word indicates that the law did not become death to Paul, But sin did. In some languages it is natural to begin this sentence with But.

However, 7:13b says “Certainly not!” In many languages that phrase already implies contrast and so it is more natural to omit But here.



**in order that sin might be exposed as sin:** The phrase in order that introduces a purpose clause. In some languages a purpose clause indicates that something has not happened yet. If that is true in your language, translate this as a result clause. For example:

and so sin has been shown to be sin

**sin might be exposed as sin:** The phrase be exposed indicates that people will see that sin is clearly sin. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

sin might be recognized as sin (NIV)

its true nature as sin might be revealed (GNT)

This clause is passive. Some languages must translate without a passive clause. For example:

sin would clearly appear to be sin

sin might reveal itself to be sin

#### 7:13d

**it produced death in me through what was good,**

- sin caused me to have a sentence/penalty of death by using that good thing,
- with that good thing sin produced in me the judgment of death without end,

**it produced death in me:** Here Paul continued to speak of sin as a person. Some languages cannot speak of sin in that way. If that is true in your language, you may want to make it a simile. For example:

sin was like someone who produced death in me

**produced death in me:** The word produced refers to causing something to exist. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

caused my death (NJB)

bring about my condemnation to death (NLT)

It was sin that killed me (CEV)

See how you translated “produced” in 7:8.

**through what was good:** Here the word through refers to something being used as a tool to do some-

thing. Here it indicates that the commandment was like a tool that sin used to influence Paul. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

using what is good (GNT)

by that good thing

**what was good:** This phrase refers to the laws, like “that which is good” does in 7:13a.

#### 7:13e

**so that through the commandment sin might become utterly sinful.**

- so that by means of knowing the commandment sin would also be exceedingly very bad.
- and sin, using the commandment, has become very, very bad to me, more than anything.

**so that through the commandment sin might become utterly sinful:** This clause is a second purpose for why sin produced death in Paul (7:13d). In some languages, the word sin must be repeated here, as the BSB does. If you changed the purpose clause in 7:13c to a result clause, you should do the same here. For example:

and through the commandment sin has become utterly sinful

**through the commandment:** Here the word through refers to something being used as a tool to do something. Here it indicates that the commandment was like a tool that made sin to be very bad beyond measure.

**the commandment:** The word commandment is singular and probably refers to the one law Paul mentioned in 7:7: “You shall not covet.” But it is probably used as an example of any of the laws in a general way.

**sin might become utterly sinful:** The Greek words that the BSB translates as utterly are literally “exceedingly far more.” It indicates that the sin of coveting is very bad. And as an example, these words indicate that all sin is very bad. Here are other ways to translate these words:

might become exceeding sinful (KJV)

So we can see how terrible sin really is. (NLT)

to show that sin is very evil (NCV)

it became clear that sin is really very-very bad  
Yakan Back Translation on TW.

## Romans 7:14

### Section 7:13–25: Sin prevents us from doing what is right

In this section Paul answered another possible wrong conclusion about the law. In 7:12 Paul said that the law is good. Now he asked if it is right to think that the law brought death. The answer is no. Sin brought death and this shows that sin is very bad. Paul then talked about his own struggle with sinning even though he agrees that the law is good. He felt he was captive to sin. But God can rescue us from that captivity.

For the use of “I” in this section, see the General Comment in the summary of Section 7:7–12.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

The way that Paul struggled to stop sinning

The power of sin

### 7:14a

#### We know that the law is spiritual;

- For we<sup>(incl)</sup> know that the law is from/of the Holy Spirit,
- We know this: the laws of God connect to the Holy Spirit,

In Greek, 7:14a begins with a word that is usually translated as “for.” This word introduces a sentence that supports 7:12–13. Cranfield (page 355). The law is good and it is also from the Holy Spirit. In some languages, it may be more natural to omit this word, as the BSB does.

**the law is spiritual:** Here the word spiritual indicates that God, through the Holy Spirit, gave the law. It contrasts with “unspiritual” in 7:14b. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

the law...comes from God’s Spirit  
Kankanaey Back Translation on TW.

the Holy Spirit is the source of the law

the laws of God are the things of the/our spirit

### 7:14b

#### but I am unspiritual,

- but I am like all other people:
- but I am a person of this world,

**I am unspiritual:** Here the Greek word that the BSB translates as unspiritual refers to being of the physical side of life. Morris (on TW) calls it “his own unaided human nature.” It is “unaided” in that it is human nature that God does not help to do good. It often opposes what God wants. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

I am carnal (RSV)

I am a creature of this world

I am merely a human (CEV)

I am just a weak human  
Uma Back Translation on TW.

See how you translated the word “flesh” in 7:5.

### 7:14c

#### sold as a slave to sin.

- I am a slave put under the control of sin.
- and someone/they has/have caused me to be as if they sold me to be mastered/ruled by sin.

**sold as a slave to sin:** This clause further describes Paul (“I”). The words “I am” are implied from 7:14b. Some languages may need “and” in front of this clause. For example:

and I am sold as a slave to sin

This clause is passive. Some languages must use an active clause. For example:

and I am like a slave whom someone/they have sold to be under sin

This is a figure of speech. Because the word sold implies being sold as a slave, the BSB supplies the words as a slave. The word to indicates that Paul’s new master is sin. He is required to do as sin tells him. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

and I am like a slave who has been sold to a new master, namely, sin

## Romans 7:15

### Section 7:13–25: Sin prevents us from doing what is right

In this section Paul answered another possible wrong conclusion about the law. In 7:12 Paul said that the law is good. Now he asked if it is right to think that the law brought death. The answer is no. Sin brought death and this shows that sin is very bad. Paul then talked about his own struggle with sinning even though he agrees that the law is good. He felt he was captive to sin. But God can rescue us from that captivity.

For the use of “I” in this section, see the General Comment in the summary of Section 7:7–12.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

The way that Paul struggled to stop sinning

The power of sin

#### 7:15a

##### I do not understand what I do.

- For, the things that I do, I do not understand why I do them.
- When I do bad/evil things, I do not know the reason why I do them.

In the Greek, 7:15a also begins with a word that is usually translated as “For.” This word introduces an explanation of Paul being “sold under sin” (7:14c). In some languages, it may be more natural to omit this word and leave the connection implicit, as the BSB does.

**I do not understand what I do:** The Greek is literally “What I do, I do not understand.” Paul did not understand why he sinned, when he knew better.

#### 7:15b

##### For what I want to do, I do not do.

- For what I want to do, I do not do it/them,
- I do not do the things/deeds that I would like to do,

**For:** This word introduces an explanation of Paul not understanding his own actions (7:15a).

**what I want to do, I do not do:** The Greek is literally “not what I want this I do.” Many English versions and scholars connect the word not with do, as in the BSB. That makes more sense of the contrasting connection that follows this clause in the Greek. No scholar that this author has discusses his choice. Jewett’s translation (page 454), “what I don’t want—this I practice, but

what I hate—this I do” seems clumsy with the “but” and the words that follow.

#### 7:15c

##### But what I hate, I do.

- but/and what I hate, I do.
- and I do the things/deeds that I detest/despise doing.

**But:** Some languages will not see the connection here as contrast. For example:

and at-the-same-timeKankanaey Back Translation on TW.

That which I...Otomi Back Translation on TW.

**what I hate, I do:** The Greek is literally “what I hate this I do.” The words what I hate are emphasized.

**hate:** This word refers to a very strong dislike. Here it includes Paul despising those things that he was doing. Here are other ways to translate this word:

detest (REB)

am disgusted withTagbanwa Back Translation on TW.

## Romans 7:16

### Section 7:13–25: Sin prevents us from doing what is right

In this section Paul answered another possible wrong conclusion about the law. In 7:12 Paul said that the law is good. Now he asked if it is right to think that the law brought death. The answer is no. Sin brought death and this shows that sin is very bad. Paul then talked about his own struggle with sinning even though he agrees that the law is good. He felt he was captive to sin. But God can rescue us from that captivity.

For the use of “I” in this section, see the General Comment in the summary of Section 7:7–12.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

The way that Paul struggled to stop sinning

The power of sin

#### 7:16a

##### And if I do what I do not want to do,

- And/But if I do what I do not want to do,

- So then, since I do the bad things I would like not to do,

**And:** The Greek word here is often translated “but” or even “now” (as in the ESV). It introduces something more that Paul said about himself and the law.

**if I do what I do not want to do:** Here the word if introduces a situation that is true. If this first part is true, that supports the second part (“I admit that the law is good”) to also be true.

In some languages, using an if-clause would have a different meaning. If that is true in your language, translate the correct meaning. For example:

I do what I do not want to do. True? So...

Would you agree that I do what I do not want to do? So...

You would agree that I do what I do not want to do. So...

#### 7:16b

##### **I admit that the law is good.**

- I agree with what the law says, that it is good.
- I agree with the laws of God when they say that they are good.

**I admit that the law is good:** There are two ways to interpret the Greek words here:

1. There is agreement with the Laws of Moses. For example:

I agree with the Law, confessing that the Law is good (NASB) (ESV, NASB, REB)

1. There is agreement about the Laws of Moses. For example:

I agree that the law is good (NIV) (BSB, RSV, NIV, GNT, NJB, NLT, GW, CEV, NET, NCV, NABRE)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1), because the Greek grammar does not support interpretation (2). Moo, Cranfield, Dunn, Jewett, and other scholars support interpretation (1).

**good:** This word indicates that the laws are good and therefore it is good that people follow them.

## Romans 7:17

### Section 7:13–25: Sin prevents us from doing what is right

In this section Paul answered another possible wrong conclusion about the law. In 7:12 Paul said that the law is good. Now he asked if it is right to think that the law brought death. The answer is no. Sin brought death and this shows that sin is very bad. Paul then talked about his own struggle with sinning even though he agrees that the law is good. He felt he was captive to sin. But God can rescue us from that captivity.

For the use of “I” in this section, see the General Comment in the summary of Section 7:7–12.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

The way that Paul struggled to stop sinning

The power of sin

#### 7:17a

##### **In that case, it is no longer I who do it,**

- And at this time I myself am no longer doing it,
- But now I am no longer the one doing those bad things.

This verse begins with a Greek conjunction that is often translated as “and” or “but.” This conjunction introduces something more that Paul wanted to say. Some languages will see “it is no longer I who do it” contrasting with “I do what I do not want.” For example:

But (NET)

Other languages will not see contrast with “I do what I do not want.” For example:

And Western Bukidnon Manobo Back Translation on TW.

**In that case:** The phrase In that case here refers to generally “at this time.” It goes with the present tense of the verb “do.” It refers to the current time and situation in Paul’s life.

**it is no longer I who do it:** The word I is emphasized here. The words here indicate that the situation is different than it was before.

**it:** This word refers to “what I do not want to do” in 7:16. In some languages the plural word would be more natural here. For example:

them

### 7:17b

**but it is sin living in me that does it.**

- but it is sin that lives in me doing it.
- No, instead, my sinfulness causes me to do those bad things.

**sin living in me that does it:** The words “do it” are implied from 7:17a. In some languages these words must be explicit. For this reason, the BSB adds the words that does it.

Again, Paul spoke of sin as if it were a living thing that lived inside him. Some languages cannot speak of sin in that way. If that is true in your language, you may want to make it a simile. For example:

it was sin which is like someone who lives in me  
and does those things/deeds

**living in me that does it:** The word living indicates that sin is always present in Paul’s life. He is never free of sin’s influence. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

but sin that dwells in me (ESV)

it is my sinfulnessKankanaey Back Translation on TW.

sin that is residing in me, that’s the underlying-cause of the evil that I doTagbanwa Back Translation on TW.

## Romans 7:18

**Section 7:13–25: Sin prevents us from doing what is right**

In this section Paul answered another possible wrong conclusion about the law. In 7:12 Paul said that the law is good. Now he asked if it is right to think that the law brought death. The answer is no. Sin brought death and this shows that sin is very bad. Paul then talked about his own struggle with sinning even though he agrees that the law is good. He felt he was captive to sin. But God can rescue us from that captivity.

For the use of “I” in this section, see the General Comment in the summary of Section 7:7–12.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

The way that Paul struggled to stop sinning

The power of sin

### 7:18a

**I know that nothing good lives in me,**

- For I know that anything good does not live in me,
- For I know this: There is nothing good inside me.

In the Greek, 7:18a begins with a word that is usually translated as “For.” This word introduces a sentence that explains or confirms what Paul said (“sin living in me”) in 7:17. In some languages, it may be more natural to omit this word and leave the connection with 7:17 implicit, as the BSB does.

**nothing good lives in me:** Paul again referred to himself as a house/place inside which living things can live. The word lives has the same meaning as in 7:17.

### 7:18b

**that is, in my flesh;**

- namely, in my human nature.
- By that I mean: There is nothing good inside my way of life of this world.

**that is, in my flesh:** The words that is introduce a clarification. When Paul wrote “in me” in 7:18a, he specifically meant in my flesh.

**my flesh:** Here the word flesh refers to the physical side of life. See how you translated the word flesh in 7:14, where the BSB translates it as “unspiritual.”

### 7:18c

**for I have the desire to do what is good,**

- For the will to do right things is available to me,
- For the will to do good is ready for me to take/use,

**for:** This word introduces a sentence that explains “nothing good dwells in me.”

**I have the desire to do what is good:** The Greek is literally “the to-will/desire is present with me.” This indicates that in Paul’s situation, the will or desire was available for him to take. Here are other ways to translate this Greek clause:

the desire to do good is in me (GNT)

the will to do what is good is in me (NJB)

the wanting to do good is present/available to me

The Greek words “the good” (BSB: what is good) appear in the next clause, but apply here as well, so many English versions move it here.

**7:18d****but I cannot carry it out.**

- but the power to do them is not.
- but to make the effort to do it is not ready for me.

**but I cannot carry it out:** There is a textual issue in 7:18d: (1) Some Greek manuscripts have the word not, implying “cannot” (BSB, RSV, NIV, NJB, NASB, NABRE, NLT, GW, CEV, NET, REB, ESV). (2) Some Greek manuscripts have the words not I find (KJV only). It is recommended that you follow option (1). The Greek is literally “the to-work the good not.” The words “is present with me” from the Greek in 7:18c are implied here and go with “not.” This indicates that in Paul’s situation, the effort to produce good results was not available within him. Here are other ways to translate this Greek clause:

the power to do it is not (NJB)

but doing the good is not (NABRE)

**Romans 7:19****Section 7:13–25: Sin prevents us from doing what is right**

In this section Paul answered another possible wrong conclusion about the law. In 7:12 Paul said that the law is good. Now he asked if it is right to think that the law brought death. The answer is no. Sin brought death and this shows that sin is very bad. Paul then talked about his own struggle with sinning even though he agrees that the law is good. He felt he was captive to sin. But God can rescue us from that captivity.

For the use of “I” in this section, see the General Comment in the summary of Section 7:7–12.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

The way that Paul struggled to stop sinning

The power of sin

**7:19a****For I do not do the good I want to do.**

- For the good things/deeds I want to do I do not do them,
- I do not do the good things/deeds that I would like to do.

**For:** This word introduces an explanation of what Paul has said in 7:18b.

**I do not do the good I want to do:** This clause is similar to 7:15b but here the Greek also has the word good after the word the (translated appropriately as “what” in 7:15b).

Some languages must have a noun such as “things” or “deeds” to go with the good. For example:

I do not do the good things/deeds I want

Some languages must introduce the words I want with “that.” Some languages must add to do at the end for a natural clause, as the BSB does. For example:

I do not do the good things/deeds that I want to do

**7:19b****Instead, I keep on doing the evil I do not want to do.**

- but/and I do the evil things/deeds I do not want to do.
- Instead, I do the evil things/deeds that I do not like to do.

**Instead:** Both “I do not do the good I want” (7:19a) and “I keep on doing the evil I do not want” (7:19b) are bad things to do. So in some languages connecting these two thoughts with “and” would indicate the correct connection. For example:

andKankanaey Back Translation on TW.

**I keep on doing:** The Greek word that the BSB translates as I keep on doing is present tense like it is in 7:15c (“I do”). Translate it in a similar way here.

**the evil I do not want to do:** This phrase refer to evil deeds. For example:

I don’t want to do what is wrong (NLT)

**Romans 7:20****Section 7:13–25: Sin prevents us from doing what is right**

In this section Paul answered another possible wrong conclusion about the law. In 7:12 Paul said that the law is good. Now he asked if it is right to think that the law brought death. The answer is no. Sin brought death and this shows that sin is very bad. Paul then talked about his own struggle with sinning even though he agrees that the law is good. He felt he was captive to sin. But God can rescue us from that captivity.

For the use of “I” in this section, see the General Comment in the summary of Section 7:7-12.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

The way that Paul struggled to stop sinning

The power of sin

#### 7:20a

**And if I do what I do not want,**

- And if I do what I do not want to do,
- Since I do the bad things I would like not to do,

**And:** The Greek word that the BSB translates as And is often translated as “but.” It often introduces a new thought, but here Paul repeated some of what he said in 7:16-17 but in a slightly different way.

**if I do what I do not want:** See how you translated this clause in 7:16a.

#### 7:20b

**it is no longer I who do it,**

- then I myself am no longer doing it,
- then I am no longer the one doing those bad things,

#### 7:20c

**but it is sin living in me that does it.**

- but it is sin that lives in me doing it.
- No, instead, my sinfulness causes me to do those bad things.

#### 7:20b-c

**it is no longer I who do it, but it is sin living in me that does it:** See how you translated these clauses in 7:17.

### Romans 7:21

**Section 7:13-25: Sin prevents us from doing what is right**

In this section Paul answered another possible wrong conclusion about the law. In 7:12 Paul said that the law is good. Now he asked if it is right to think that the law brought death. The answer is no. Sin brought death and this shows that sin is very bad. Paul then talked about his own struggle with sinning even though he agrees that the law is good. He felt he was captive to sin. But God can rescue us from that captivity.

For the use of “I” in this section, see the General Comment in the summary of Section 7:7-12.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

The way that Paul struggled to stop sinning

The power of sin

#### 7:21a-c

**So this is the principle I have discovered: When I want to do good, evil is right there with me:** The Greek is literally “So I find the law/principle to/regarding the I-wanting to/for me to do the good, that to/for me the evil is present.” It indicates that Paul found that a law or rule in his life was this: He wanted to do the good thing, but evil was always there to influence him to do the bad thing. Here are other ways to translate these words:

I find then a law, that, when I would do good, evil is present with me (KJV)

this is now what I have observed, as soon as I want to do something good, it is immediately blocked by the evil residing within me Tagbanwa Back Translation on TW.

#### 7:21a

**So this is the principle I have discovered:**

- ¶ Therefore I find this law/principle to be true:
- ¶ So I see that my experience/life follows this rule:

**So:** This word introduces a conclusion about what Paul said earlier.

**this is the principle:** Here the word principle refers to a principle: a general statement about the way something is. Paul then stated the principle: “When I want to do good, evil is right there with me (7:21b-c).” The word does not refer to the law of Moses here. Some scholars (for example, Schreiner and Jewett) think that the word refers to the laws of Moses. But only the CEV clearly goes with that interpretation. The BSB, RSV, ESV, KJV, NIV, GNT, NJB, NCV, NASB, NABRE, NLT, REB, and GW clearly indicate something other than the laws of Moses here. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

this law (NIV)

a law (ESV)

**I have discovered:** The word that the BSB translates as discovered indicates that Paul looked at the facts of the situation and discovered a truth that he then told us in the words that follow.

In some languages a literal translation would not indicate the meaning above. If that is true in your language, translate the correct meaning. For example:

find (ESV)

experiencedKankanaey Back Translation on TW.

see

### 7:21b

#### **When I want to do good,**

- I want to do the good thing/deed,
- I want to do good things/deeds,

**When I want to do good:** The Greek words that the BSB translates as When I want is literally “when the wanting to do good is with me.” It refers generally to any time or even all the time. It does not limit it to only some of the time. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

Although I want to do good (NIV11)

I want to do good things/deeds

**good:** This word is translated as “good” in 7:16. It refers to deeds that God considers are good to do.

### 7:21c

#### **evil is right there with me.**

- but evil is present inside me.
- but evil desires influence/pull me to do evil things/deeds.

**evil is right there with me:** The Greek word that the BSB translates as right there with me is literally “present and ready for some purpose or action.” BDAG (page 766). Evil was ready to influence Paul to do something wrong. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

evil is present in me (NASB)

evil lies close at hand (ESV)

This clause speaks of evil as if it were a physical thing. Some languages may have to translate in a different way. For example:

the thought to do evil is always there in me

evil desires are there, ready to influence me to do evil

## **Romans 7:22**

### **Section 7:13–25: Sin prevents us from doing what is right**

In this section Paul answered another possible wrong conclusion about the law. In 7:12 Paul said that the law is good. Now he asked if it is right to think that the law brought death. The answer is no. Sin brought death and this shows that sin is very bad. Paul then talked about his own struggle with sinning even though he agrees that the law is good. He felt he was captive to sin. But God can rescue us from that captivity.

For the use of “I” in this section, see the General Comment in the summary of Section 7:7–12.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

The way that Paul struggled to stop sinning

The power of sin

### **7:22**

#### **For in my inner being I delight in God’s law.**

- For in my mind I rejoice in the laws of God,
- In my heart/thoughts I am happy with God’s laws,

**For:** This word introduces an explanation of what Paul had said in 7:21a–c.

**in my inner being:** This phrase refers to the mind Moo (on TW) and Schreiner (page 377). or more generally to the inner part of a person that includes the thinking and emotions. The BSB adds the word my. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

in the inner man (NASB)

in my inner self (NABRE)

In my mind (NCV)

In my heart/liver/stomach

**I delight in God’s law:** Here the word delight refers to being happy. Paul was happy with the law of God.

**God’s law:** This phrase refers to all of God’s commands, written in what is now called the Old Testament (the Hebrew Bible). In some languages the plural



for law is more natural, since there is more than one law. For example:

the laws of God

You should not translate this phrase as “the laws of Moses.”

## Romans 7:23

### Section 7:13–25: Sin prevents us from doing what is right

In this section Paul answered another possible wrong conclusion about the law. In 7:12 Paul said that the law is good. Now he asked if it is right to think that the law brought death. The answer is no. Sin brought death and this shows that sin is very bad. Paul then talked about his own struggle with sinning even though he agrees that the law is good. He felt he was captive to sin. But God can rescue us from that captivity.

For the use of “I” in this section, see the General Comment in the summary of Section 7:7–12.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

The way that Paul struggled to stop sinning

The power of sin

#### 7:23a

#### But I see another law at work in my body,

- but I see another principle in the parts of my body
- but I observe that another rule works/operates in my body,

**But I see another law at work in my body:** Here the word law refers to a principle, as in 7:21a. Some scholars (for example, Cranfield and Dunn) think that “another law” refers to “the law of sin” (7:23c). But in 7:23c, the Greek says that this other law captures Paul “in the law of sin.” So the two things must be separate in Paul’s thinking. For example:

I see in my members another principle (NABRE)

Paul saw a law at work in his members. The words at work are implied here, but supplied by the BSB. For example:

I see, operating in my members, another principle

I see a different law at work in my body—a law that (GNT)

**my body:** Here the Greek word that the BSB translates as body refers to parts of the body. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

the parts of my body

my members (ESV)

my outward actions (REB)

#### 7:23b

#### warring against the law of my mind

- that fights greatly/much with/against the principle of my mind/thinking
- and it strongly opposes/blocks the rule that works/operates in my mind,

**warring against the law of my mind:** The word warring refers to fighting a war. Paul used this metaphor to indicate that the conflict or struggle was great. Here are other ways to translate these words:

fighting hard against the law of my mind

which battles against the law in my mind (NJB)

Some languages must translate the metaphor of making war in a different way. For example:

opposes the law of my mind

oppresses/blocks the law of my mind

**the law of my mind:** Here the word law probably refers to a controlling principle, telling Paul, in his thinking, to do this or that.

#### 7:23c

#### and holding me captive to the law of sin that dwells within me.

- and makes me a prisoner in/of the principle of sinning that exists in the parts of my body.
- and it puts me under the control of sinfulness that is there in my body.

**holding me captive to the law of sin:** The Greek is more literally “capturing me in the law of sin.” It sees the law of sin as a place where Paul was held as a captive.

This figurative use of “in” is difficult to understand. So many English versions translate it as to or “of.” For example:

making me a prisoner of the law of sin (NIV)

**holding me captive:** The phrase holding...captive is another metaphor of war. It refers to capturing enemy soldiers. Some would be killed but some would be made slaves. Here it refers to Paul being put under the law of sin. The words “another law” are implied at the beginning of this clause from 7:23a. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

making me a prisoner (NIV)

bringing me into captivity (KJV)

Some languages must translate the metaphor of taking captives in a different way. For example:

making me a slave

causing me to be like a slave

**the law of sin:** Here the word law probably refers to a controlling principle, telling Paul, in his thinking, to do this or that. See how you translated the word law in 7:23b.

**that dwells within me:** This clause further describes “the law of sin.” It does not separate this law of sin from other laws of sin. For the correct meaning in some languages, translators must avoid the word that. For example:

the law of sin, it dwells within me

the law of sin, and it dwells within me

**dwells:** The Greek word here is “be-ing.” It indicates that the law of sin exists in Paul’s members. Here are other ways to translate this word:

lives (NJB)

is

## Romans 7:24

### Section 7:13–25: Sin prevents us from doing what is right

In this section Paul answered another possible wrong conclusion about the law. In 7:12 Paul said that the law is good. Now he asked if it is right to think that the law brought death. The answer is no. Sin brought death and this shows that sin is very bad. Paul then talked about his own struggle with sinning even though he agrees that the law is good. He felt he was captive to sin. But God can rescue us from that captivity.

For the use of “I” in this section, see the General Comment in the summary of Section 7:7–12.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

The way that Paul struggled to stop sinning

The power of sin

### 7:24a

#### What a wretched man I am!

- I am a very miserable man/person.
- A man of misery/unhappiness, that is me!

**What a wretched man I am!:** The Greek is literally “I (a) miserable/wretched man,” with the word “miserable/wretched” first to emphasize it. Here Paul considered himself very unhappy and distressed about the terrible situation he was in (wanting to do right but always sinning). Here are other ways to translate this clause:

I am such a miserable man!

A man of unhappiness/distress, that is me.

### 7:24b

#### Who will rescue me from this body of death?

- Who will rescue me from this body that is under the sentence/punishment of death?
- Who will rescue me from this body that will cause me to die?

**Who will rescue me from this body of death?:** Here the word rescue means “deliver.” This question is a rhetorical question. Paul wanted his readers to think about the answer before he told them the answer in 7:25a. Translate this clause in that meaning. Here are some ways:

- As a rhetorical question. For example:

Who will rescue me from this body of death? (NIV)

Who will rescue me from this body doomed to death? (NJB)

- As a statement. For example:

There is only one person who will rescue me from this body destined to die.

**this body of death:** 7:23 says that the law of sin dwelt in the parts of Paul's body. 6:23 says that the wages of sin is death. So in that way Paul here referred to his body as connected to death. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

this body that is subject to death (NIV11)

this body that brings me death

Also see the ways this phrase was translated in the previous note.

## Romans 7:25

### Section 7:13–25: Sin prevents us from doing what is right

In this section Paul answered another possible wrong conclusion about the law. In 7:12 Paul said that the law is good. Now he asked if it is right to think that the law brought death. The answer is no. Sin brought death and this shows that sin is very bad. Paul then talked about his own struggle with sinning even though he agrees that the law is good. He felt he was captive to sin. But God can rescue us from that captivity.

For the use of "I" in this section, see the General Comment in the summary of Section 7:7–12.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

The way that Paul struggled to stop sinning

The power of sin

#### 7:25a

#### Thanks be to God, through Jesus Christ our Lord!

- Thank God that he can because of what Jesus Christ our Lord did.
- I thank God because he can do that by the things/deeds Jesus Christ our Leader/Master did.

This verse begins with the conjunction that is often translated as "and" or "but." Here it introduces something more that Paul said about who saves people (7:24). Some languages will see contrast to the question of who in that verse. For example:

ButYakan Back Translation on TW.

Other languages will need to indicate that 7:25a answers the question in 7:24b in a different way. For example:

Hey,Yongkom Back Translation, by this author, unpublished manuscript, Papua New Guinea.

Look/Listen!

But for the connection to 7:24 here, it is more natural in many languages to omit this conjunction.

**Thanks be to God:** There is a textual issue in 7:25a: (1) Some Greek manuscripts have the word thanks (BSB, RSV, NIV, NJB, NASB, NABRE, NLT, GW, CEV, NET, REB, ESV). (2) Some Greek manuscripts have the words I thank (KJV). It is recommended that you follow option (1). This clause implies that the answer to Paul's question of "who will deliver me from this body of death" is God. In some languages a literal translation would not imply that. If that is true in your language, make that meaning explicit. For example:

Thanks be to God, it is he

It is God who will rescue me, thanks to him

**Thanks be:** The BSB adds the verb be. This is a general thanksgiving. Paul thanked God, but the phrase allows others to join in that thanksgiving. Some languages must translate with a verb other than be. For example:

I thank GodOtomi Back Translation on TW.

We should thank GodMengen Back Translation, unpublished manuscript, SIL PNG, Papua New Guinea.

**through Jesus Christ:** Here the word through indicates that God will rescue Paul because of what Jesus did in his death and resurrection.

**our Lord:** The word Lord refers to someone who has authority over people. Here it indicates that Jesus has

authority over believers. See how you translated this phrase in 1:4 or 6:23.

### 7:25b

**So then, with my mind I serve the law of God,**

- Therefore, in my thinking I myself am like a slave to the law of God,
- Based on all those things, I conclude that I myself obey the laws of God in my mind,

**So then:** Here this phrase introduces Paul's conclusion of all that he said in 7:7–25. For example:

Therefore (NABRE)

**with my mind I serve the law of God:** The phrase with my mind is emphasized by being in front of the verb in the Greek clause. The BSB reflects this. Another way to translate this is:

I myself, with my mind, serve the law of God

In some languages it is more natural to have the phrase with my mind after the phrase the law of God. For example:

I myself serve the law of God with my mind (ESV)

**serve the law of God:** Here the word serve refers to doing as the law of God says. The Greek word that the BSB translates as serve can also refer to acting like a slave to his or her master. A slave always does what the master tells him to do. For example:

am a slave to God's law (NIV)

This is a figure of speech. In some languages it is not natural to speak of people being a slave to laws. For example:

am like a slave to God's law

obey the law of God (NJB)

**the law of God:** See how you translated this phrase in 7:22.

### 7:25c

**but with my flesh I serve the law of sin.**

- but in my human nature I am like a slave to the principle of sinning.

- but at the same time I obey sinfulness in my way of life of this world.

**with my flesh I serve the law of sin:** The phrase with my flesh is emphasized by being in front of the verb in the Greek clause. In some languages it is more natural to have this phrase in its normal place. For example:

I serve the law of sin with my flesh

**my flesh:** Here the word flesh refers to human nature. See how you translated this phrase in 7:18.

**the law of sin:** Here the word law again refers to a principle. Here it is the principle that sin bosses people, telling them to do evil things. See how you translated this phrase in 7:23.

### General Comment on 7:25b–c

Both serving the law of God with the mind (7:25b) and serving the law of sin with the flesh (7:25c) occurred in Paul's life. In some languages it is necessary to make explicit that both things were happening. For example:

I myself serve the law of God with my mind, but it is also true that with my flesh I serve the law of sin.

## Romans 8:1

### Section 8:1–17: Believers live by the Holy Spirit

In this section Paul reminded the believers in Rome that God does not condemn them, because the Holy Spirit has set them free from sin and death. Jesus became like an Old Testament sin offering to remove the consequences of our sin. The laws of Moses demanded a righteous life, and in the Holy Spirit we can live that way.

The people who live according to the sinful nature seek to do things that are in accord with that nature. Also, they cannot please God, cannot follow his laws, are hostile to him, and will be punished with death forever. The people who live according to the Holy Spirit seek to do things that are in accord with his desire.

Christians allow the Holy Spirit to work in them. When they do that, they are as if dead to sin and God will give them life. Those without the Holy Spirit do not belong to Jesus Christ.

We put to death the deeds of the sinful nature. We do that by the power of the Holy Spirit. We are God's children and can do as he does (again, by the power

of the Holy Spirit). If we suffer as Jesus suffered, God will give to us his promised inheritance in heaven.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

We must live according to the Holy Spirit, not according to sinfulness

Be Ruled by the Spirit (NCV)

Living by the Power of God's Spirit (CEV)

### 8:1

**Therefore, there is now no condemnation for those who are in Christ Jesus.**

- ¶ So then, now no one who has a relationship/union with Jesus, the Christ/Messiah, is condemned.
- ¶ Based on all those things, in this age or ever God does not give the punishment of death to those who are united/connected with Jesus, the one/person whom God appointed to save/rescue people.

**Therefore, there is now no condemnation:** In many English versions, the word Therefore is in the middle of the clause. For example:

There is therefore now no condemnation (ESV)

In some languages it must be at the beginning of the clause. Place the word where it is most natural in your language.

**Therefore:** This conjunction connects to 7:24b–25a. See Schreiner (pages 398–399). or more generally to the themes in 5:21–7:25a. See Moo (on TW). It does not connect to “with my flesh I serve the law of sin” (7:25c).

In some languages a literal translation would connect this verse only to 7:25c. If that is true in your language, you may want to:

- Explain the connection in your translation. For example:

Based on all that,

Considering all those things,

God will deliver his people, so

- Omit the conjunction. For example:

There is no condemnation now... (GNT)

**there is now no condemnation:** The word condemnation refers to how someone is punished. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

If you belong to Christ Jesus, you won't be punished (CEV)

those who are in Christ Jesus are not judged guilty (NCV)

This clause refers to the time Paul wrote this and to today. It also implies God will not condemn believers on the great day of judgment when he judges everyone. It does not promise that believers will escape condemnation by government authorities if they commit a crime. In some languages a literal translation would wrongly promise escape from all condemnation. If that is true in your language, indicate the correct meaning here. For example:

God does not condemn

See how you translated the word condemnation in 5:16 or 5:18.

**now:** This word refers in general to the era of salvation in Christ. See Moo (on TW). Here are other ways to translate this word:

at this time

there is no longer God's punishment for us Western Bukidnon Manobo Back Translation on TW.

**for those who are in Christ Jesus:** There is a textual issue in 8:1: (1) Some Greek manuscripts have the words in Christ Jesus (BSB, RSV, NIV, NJB, NASB, NABRE, NLT, GW, CEV, NET, REB, ESV). (2) Some Greek manuscripts have the words in Christ Jesus, they do not walk according to the flesh but according to the Spirit (KJV). It is recommended that you follow option (1). Here the word for indicates that “no condemnation” applies to those who are in Christ Jesus. God does not now condemn them (and he will not condemn them later).

**those who are in Christ Jesus:** Here the word in indicates that believers are joined with Jesus in a close relationship. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

those who are united with Christ Jesus (REB)

we walk with Jesus Christ Otomi Back Translation on TW.

us who are connected with Kristus Yesus Uma Back Translation on TW.

See how you translated in Christ Jesus in 6:11 or 6:23.

**Christ Jesus:** The order of the words Christ Jesus emphasizes that Jesus is the Christ/Messiah. See how you translated this phrase in 1:1 or 6:23.

## Romans 8:2

### Section 8:1–17: Believers live by the Holy Spirit

In this section Paul reminded the believers in Rome that God does not condemn them, because the Holy Spirit has set them free from sin and death. Jesus became like an Old Testament sin offering to remove the consequences of our sin. The laws of Moses demanded a righteous life, and in the Holy Spirit we can live that way.

The people who live according to the sinful nature seek to do things that are in accord with that nature. Also, they cannot please God, cannot follow his laws, are hostile to him, and will be punished with death forever. The people who live according to the Holy Spirit seek to do things that are in accord with his desire.

Christians allow the Holy Spirit to work in them. When they do that, they are as if dead to sin and God will give them life. Those without the Holy Spirit do not belong to Jesus Christ.

We put to death the deeds of the sinful nature. We do that by the power of the Holy Spirit. We are God's children and can do as he does (again, by the power of the Holy Spirit). If we suffer as Jesus suffered, God will give to us his promised inheritance in heaven.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

We must live according to the Holy Spirit, not according to sinfulness

Be Ruled by the Spirit (NCV)

Living by the Power of God's Spirit (CEV)

### 8:2a

#### For in Christ Jesus the law of the Spirit of life set you free

- For the power of the Spirit that gives life has freed you<sup>(sing/plur)</sup> in Jesus, the Christ/Messiah,
- For the authority of the Holy Spirit, who causes you to live, has released/untied you, because you believe in Jesus, the one/person whom God appointed to save/rescue people.

**For:** Here this word introduces the basis for Paul saying that God does not condemn believers. Moo (on TW).

**in Christ Jesus:** The word in here indicates that the Holy Spirit has freed us because we believed that Jesus is the Christ.

**Christ Jesus:** The order of the words Christ Jesus emphasizes that Jesus is the Christ/Messiah. See how you translated this phrase in 8:1.

**the law of the Spirit of life:** Here the word law probably refers to a controlling principle, telling Paul, in his thinking, to do this or that, as it does in 7:23 in the phrase “the law of my mind.” See Moo (page 474). Some scholars (for example, Schreiner (page 400) and Jewett (page 481)) think the word here refers to the laws of Moses, but then Paul would be disagreeing with what he says in the very next verse (Moo, page 474). See how you translated the word law in “the law of my mind” in 7:23.

**the Spirit of life:** This phrase refers to the Holy Spirit. The words of life indicate here that the Holy Spirit is the source of life. Moo (on TW) says it refers to “the Spirit who confers life.” Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

the Spirit, who gives life (GW)

the Spirit that brings life (NCV)

**set you free:** There is a textual issue here.

1. Some Greek manuscripts have the word you<sup>(sing)</sup>. (BSB, ESV, NIV11, NJB, NASB, NRSV, NABRE, NLT, GW, CEV, NET, REB, NCV2005)
2. Some Greek manuscripts have the word me. (RSV, NIV84, GNT, KJV, NCV91)

It is recommended that you follow option (1), because the UBS Greek NT 5 supports it. Some of the English versions support option (2) perhaps because they are older translations and an earlier version of the UBS Greek New Testament supported it.

**set...free:** The verb here is in the past tense. The Holy Spirit frees a person when he or she begins believing in Jesus.

### 8:2b

#### from the law of sin and death.

- from the principle/rule that people always sin and die.
- He has released/untied you from sinfulness and death.

**the law of sin:** See how you translated the phrase the law of sin in 7:25.

## Romans 8:3

### Section 8:1–17: Believers live by the Holy Spirit

In this section Paul reminded the believers in Rome that God does not condemn them, because the Holy Spirit has set them free from sin and death. Jesus became like an Old Testament sin offering to remove the consequences of our sin. The laws of Moses demanded a righteous life, and in the Holy Spirit we can live that way.

The people who live according to the sinful nature seek to do things that are in accord with that nature. Also, they cannot please God, cannot follow his laws, are hostile to him, and will be punished with death forever. The people who live according to the Holy Spirit seek to do things that are in accord with his desire.

Christians allow the Holy Spirit to work in them. When they do that, they are as if dead to sin and God will give them life. Those without the Holy Spirit do not belong to Jesus Christ.

We put to death the deeds of the sinful nature. We do that by the power of the Holy Spirit. We are God's children and can do as he does (again, by the power of the Holy Spirit). If we suffer as Jesus suffered, God will give to us his promised inheritance in heaven.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

We must live according to the Holy Spirit, not according to sinfulness

Be Ruled by the Spirit (NCV)

Living by the Power of God's Spirit (CEV)

### 8:3a

**For what the law was powerless to do in that it was weakened by the flesh, God did**

- For the law of Moses was weak in people's lives by the desires of the body, and did not have the power to free anyone from sin and death. Only God was able to do that.
- For the laws of Moses cannot set anyone free like that, because it is weak in our bodies. But God

**For:** This word introduces the basis for God setting us free from sin and death (8:2).

**what the law was powerless to do in that it was weakened by the flesh, God did:** Here the law refers to the laws that God gave to Moses. The law of Moses was not able to free people from sin (8:2). God did that. For example:

The Law of Moses cannot do this (CEV)

Paul spoke of the law as if it were a person. Some languages cannot speak of the law as doing things. If that is true in your language, translate the correct meaning. For example:

For no one, obeying the law of Moses can become free like that, because the law operates through our weak human nature. But God condemned sin in the flesh (interpretation 1)

For God condemned sin in the flesh. No one, obeying the laws of Moses, is able to do that, because people are weak regarding obeying them. (interpretation 2)

**the law was powerless to do in that it was weakened by the flesh:** These words indicate that the law was unable to accomplish what God intended for it to do, because people are unable to obey it completely.

**flesh:** This word refers to people living according to their natural way of thinking, the human nature. Here are other ways to translate this word:

human nature (GNT)

our natural inclinations

our old nature

our own desires

See how you translated this word in 7:5 or 7:25.

**8:3b****by sending His own Son in the likeness of sinful man,**

- He/God sent his very own Son in a body and nature that was like the normal human body
- sent his own Son, and he became like us<sup>(incl)</sup> sinful people,

**by sending His own Son:** The word by here indicates that God sending His own Son was how God condemned sin in the flesh. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

God sent his Son.... That way God condemned sin (GW)

He sent his Child.... And that's how GodKankanaey Back Translation on TW.

**His own Son:** This phrase is a title for Jesus. This title indicates that Jesus has the same nature and character as God. It also indicates that the relationship between God the Father and Jesus, his Son, is similar in some way to the relationship of human fathers and sons. God the Father does not have a physical body. He did not have a sexual relationship that resulted in Mary becoming pregnant and giving birth to Jesus. See how you translated the phrase "His Son" at 1:3.

**in the likeness of sinful man:** The word likeness here probably indicates that Jesus became a human being yet still remained who he was before he did that, Cranfield (page 379). so he had all the characteristics of a human being except that he was sinless. Morris (on TW) and Kittel (686). But all the above information comes from many verses, not just this verse. Translate in a way that implies or allows the above meaning. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

in a body like the bodies we sinners have (NLT)

to be like us sinners (CEV)

he became as sinful peopleYongkom Back Translation, by this author, unpublished manuscript, Papua New Guinea.

In some languages it is helpful to explain in the translation how Jesus is the same and different from us. For example:

having a human body and his customs (were) like our (incl) customs but he was not influenced/ carried to sinYakan Back Translation on TW.

he became a human being like us, but there was no sinfulness in him

**sinful man:** The word man refers to the physical body here but also includes the human nature as in 8:3a. When Jesus came to earth he took on a physical body as well as human nature. In our human nature while living in this physical body that we have, it is easy for us to sin. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

our sinful nature (REB)

with the same human life that others use for sin (NCV)

**8:3c****as an offering for sin.**

- and for the sake of sin,
- and he sent him to do something about people's sins.

**as an offering for sin:** There are several ways to interpret the Greek words that the BSB translates as as an offering for sin:

1. It means with regard to sin here. God also sent his Son to do something about sin. For example:

and concerning sin (NET) (RSV, GNT, KJV, ESV, NET, NABRE, REB, GW)

1. It means as a sin offering here. For example:

to be a sin offering (NIV) (BSB, NIV, NJB, NASB, CEV, NCV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1), because this phrase is not in the context of the Old Testament system of animal sacrifice, as it is in Hebrews 13:11, where the same Greek phrase is correctly translated "sin offering."

The words here refer to taking our sins upon himself, paying the penalty for sin by his death, and setting us free from sin. Lenski (pages 500–501) speaks of "atonement for sin and also our liberation from sin." Fitzmyer (page 485–486) says it means "to deal with sin...or to conquer sin...or to take away...sin." Here are



other ways to translate the Greek words according to interpretation (1):

and for the sake of sin (NABRE)

and to deal with sin (REB)

### 8:3d

#### He thus condemned sin in the flesh,

- and so he/God broke/ended the power of sin in the human body,
- He punished this thing called sinning by ending its power in our<sup>(incl)</sup> bodies.

**He thus condemned sin in the flesh:** In the death of Jesus on the cross, God broke the power of sin. People have the same body and human nature as Jesus. So God has broken the power of sin for all people. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

he condemned the power of sin in human nature

God removed the power of sin to rule us people  
Kankanaey Back Translation on TW.

he really broke the control of sin over us  
Tagbanwa Back Translation on TW.

**condemned:** Here this word refers to a judge saying someone is guilty and giving the punishment. Referring to condemning sin, some languages must use a different word here. See the above examples.

**sin:** Here sin is spoken of as if it were a person. Some languages must speak of sin in a different way. For example:

sinning

the power of sin

**in the flesh:** Here this phrase refers to the place where God condemned sin.

**flesh:** Here this word refers to the human body.

## Romans 8:4

### Section 8:1–17: Believers live by the Holy Spirit

In this section Paul reminded the believers in Rome that God does not condemn them, because the Holy Spirit has set them free from sin and death. Jesus be-

came like an Old Testament sin offering to remove the consequences of our sin. The laws of Moses demanded a righteous life, and in the Holy Spirit we can live that way.

The people who live according to the sinful nature seek to do things that are in accord with that nature. Also, they cannot please God, cannot follow his laws, are hostile to him, and will be punished with death forever. The people who live according to the Holy Spirit seek to do things that are in accord with his desire.

Christians allow the Holy Spirit to work in them. When they do that, they are as if dead to sin and God will give them life. Those without the Holy Spirit do not belong to Jesus Christ.

We put to death the deeds of the sinful nature. We do that by the power of the Holy Spirit. We are God's children and can do as he does (again, by the power of the Holy Spirit). If we suffer as Jesus suffered, God will give to us his promised inheritance in heaven.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

We must live according to the Holy Spirit, not according to sinfulness

Be Ruled by the Spirit (NCV)

Living by the Power of God's Spirit (CEV)

### 8:4a

#### so that the righteous standard of the law might be fulfilled in us,

- so that the thing that God demands of all those who follow the law might be fulfilled in us<sup>(incl)</sup>,
- Therefore God has caused living righteously, as the laws of Moses command, to have become true in our lives.

#### so that the righteous standard of the law might be fulfilled in us:

The phrase so that introduces a purpose clause. The righteous standard of the law has already been fulfilled in us. Cranfield (page 383) and Morris (on TW). In some languages a purpose clause indicates something that has not yet happened. If that is true in your language, introduce this as a result clause. For example:

and so the righteous standard of the law has been fulfilled in us

**the righteous standard of the law might be fulfilled in us:** This clause is passive. Some languages cannot use a passive clause. For example:

the righteous standard of the law might become true in us

**the righteous standard of the law:** The word standard is singular, so refers to something that the whole of the law of Moses demands that people be. It probably refers to living righteously as a result of fulfilling this requirement through the sacrificial death of God's Son, Jesus. See Barrett (page 157) and Nicoll (page 646). Moo (on TW) says it must be a summary of the law. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

being righteous as the law/Law demands

our deeds would be truly upright as the Law of Moses commands us

**fulfilled:** The Greek tense indicates that this is a complete event. It refers to God declaring us righteous when we believed in Jesus. Sometimes the word "justify" (as in 2:13, where the BSB translates it as "declared righteous") describes God doing that. God declared us righteous and that fulfilled the righteous requirement of the law in us.

**in us:** Here the word in refers to what God does in our lives. He enables us to live righteously.

#### 8:4b

**who do not walk according to the flesh but according to the Spirit.**

- as we are the people who do not live according to the physical life but according to the Spirit.
- The Holy Spirit leads us and the ways/desires of this world do not lead us.

**who do not walk according to the flesh but according to the Spirit:** These words further describe the word "us" in 8:4a. It does not separate some people referred to by "us" from other people referred to by "us." For the correct meaning in some languages, translators must avoid the word who. For example:

as those who walk not according to the flesh but according to the Spirit

and we walk not according to the flesh but according to the Spirit

as we direct our lives not by our natural inclinations but by the Spirit (NJB)

**do not walk according to the flesh but according to the Spirit:** In some languages it is more natural to repeat the verb walk in the second part. For example:

walk not according to the flesh but walk according to the Spirit

walk according to the Spirit and do not walk according to the flesh

In some languages it is more natural to have according to the Spirit before not...according to the flesh. For example:

walk according to the Spirit and not according to the flesh

**walk:** This is a figure of speech. It refers to living. Believers live as the Holy Spirit directs them. In some languages a literal translation would not have the correct meaning. If that is true in your language, translate the correct meaning. For example:

live (NIV)

direct our lives (NJB)

**flesh:** Here this word refers to having a body, with its needs and passions. See how you translated this word in 7:14 or the first occurrence in 8:3.

**the Spirit:** This implies the Holy Spirit here.

## Romans 8:5

### Section 8:1–17: Believers live by the Holy Spirit

In this section Paul reminded the believers in Rome that God does not condemn them, because the Holy Spirit has set them free from sin and death. Jesus became like an Old Testament sin offering to remove the consequences of our sin. The laws of Moses demanded a righteous life, and in the Holy Spirit we can live that way.

The people who live according to the sinful nature seek to do things that are in accord with that nature. Also, they cannot please God, cannot follow his laws, are hostile to him, and will be punished with death forever. The people who live according to the Holy

Spirit seek to do things that are in accord with his desire.

Christians allow the Holy Spirit to work in them. When they do that, they are as if dead to sin and God will give them life. Those without the Holy Spirit do not belong to Jesus Christ.

We put to death the deeds of the sinful nature. We do that by the power of the Holy Spirit. We are God's children and can do as he does (again, by the power of the Holy Spirit). If we suffer as Jesus suffered, God will give to us his promised inheritance in heaven.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

We must live according to the Holy Spirit, not according to sinfulness

Be Ruled by the Spirit (NCV)

Living by the Power of God's Spirit (CEV)

#### 8:5a-d

This verse describes two groups of people: those who do not believe in Jesus (8:5a-b) and those who believe in him (8:5c-d).

#### 8:5a

##### Those who live according to the flesh

- ¶ For the ones living following the physical life
- ¶ Some people exist confined to the ways of the body

The Greek of 8:5a begins with a word that is usually translated as "For." This word introduces a sentence that explains something about what Paul said in 8:4. See Cranfield (page 385) or Jewett (page 487). In some languages, it may be most natural to omit this word and leave the connection to 8:4 implicit, as the BSB does.

**Those who live according to the flesh:** The Greek is literally "the ones being according to flesh." It indicates that this group of people always follow human nature. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

the ones/people who exist only according to human nature

Those who live as their human nature tells them to (GNT)

whoever live according to the desires of the bodyYongkom Back Translation, by author, corrected.

**flesh:** This word refers to having a body, with its needs and passions. See how you translated this word in 8:4.

#### 8:5b

##### set their minds on the things of the flesh;

- are always thinking about how to satisfy that body,
- and think only those thoughts and desires from the body.

**set their minds on the things of the flesh:** The Greek word that the BSB translates as set their minds on refers to thinking a certain way about, or having a strong opinion about, or supporting a cause. L&S II.2.a, L&N (c), and BDAG 2.b, respectively. Here it probably refers to being focused on things related to the body. This includes such things as food, drink, sex, survival, and power over others. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

are concerned with the things of the flesh (NABRE)

are thinking only of the deeds of the human nature

think only about things of the natural self

#### 8:5c

##### but those who live according to the Spirit

- but the ones living following the Spirit
- But the other people exist confined to how the Holy Spirit wants them to live

**those who live according to the Spirit:** The Greek is literally "the ones according to spirit/Spirit." The verb live is implied from 8:5a. It indicates that this group of people follow the Holy Spirit. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

the ones/people who exist according to the Holy Spirit

Those who live as the Spirit tells them to (GNT)

whoever live according to the SpiritYongkom Back Translation, by author.

**8:5d****set their minds on the things of the Spirit.**

- are always thinking about the things the Spirit wants them to do.
- and think of those thoughts and desires of the Holy Spirit.

**set their minds on the things of the Spirit:** Here the word Spirit refers to the Holy Spirit. This group of people are focused on the thoughts and deeds that the Holy Spirit wants us to think or do. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

are concerned with the things of the Spirit

are thinking of the thoughts and deeds that please the Holy Spirit

think only about things that the Holy Spirit wants

**Romans 8:6****Section 8:1–17: Believers live by the Holy Spirit**

In this section Paul reminded the believers in Rome that God does not condemn them, because the Holy Spirit has set them free from sin and death. Jesus became like an Old Testament sin offering to remove the consequences of our sin. The laws of Moses demanded a righteous life, and in the Holy Spirit we can live that way.

The people who live according to the sinful nature seek to do things that are in accord with that nature. Also, they cannot please God, cannot follow his laws, are hostile to him, and will be punished with death forever. The people who live according to the Holy Spirit seek to do things that are in accord with his desire.

Christians allow the Holy Spirit to work in them. When they do that, they are as if dead to sin and God will give them life. Those without the Holy Spirit do not belong to Jesus Christ.

We put to death the deeds of the sinful nature. We do that by the power of the Holy Spirit. We are God's children and can do as he does (again, by the power of the Holy Spirit). If we suffer as Jesus suffered, God will give to us his promised inheritance in heaven.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

We must live according to the Holy Spirit, not according to sinfulness

Be Ruled by the Spirit (NCV)

Living by the Power of God's Spirit (CEV)

**8:6a****The mind of the flesh is death,**

- And/Also, a mind full of the physical life results in death,
- People whose thinking follows only thoughts and desires from the body will only die.

In the Greek, 8:6a begins with a word that is usually translated as "For." Here this word probably indicates a continuation of the same connection as the "For" in 8:5a. See Moo (on TW), Schreiner (page 412). Cranfield (page 386) says it explains 8:5 and Jewett (page 487) says it introduces a consequence of 8:5. In some languages another word would be used for that meaning. For example:

And (NJB)

Also

In some languages, it may be most natural to omit this word and leave the connection to 8:4 implicit, as the BSB does.

**The mind of the flesh is death:** The Greek is literally "the mind of the flesh death." The verb is was not written in the Greek because the Greek does not use it in these cases, but it is necessary for natural English. The Greek indicates here that a mind set on the flesh results in death. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

a mind set on the desires of the body results in death

a mind focused on the deeds of the body leads to death

**The mind of the flesh:** The Greek word that the BSB translates as The mind here refers to the ability to focus one's mind on something. It is similar in meaning to "set their minds on" in 8:5b. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

mind governed by the flesh (NIV11)

the mind set on human nature

the mind full of the natural self

### 8:6b

**but the mind of the Spirit is life and peace,**

- but a mind full of the Spirit results in life and peace.
- But people whose thinking follows the thoughts and desires of the Holy Spirit will live the new life and will have peace.

**life:** Here this word refers to the new life we have in Christ while here on this earth as well as eternal life with God. See Moo (on TW). Some scholars (i.e., Dunn (page 426) and Schreiner (page 412)) say it refers only or primarily to the future eternal life, but Paul does not limit the word here. Jewett (page 488) says a mind set on the Spirit “produces a new kind of life.” Your translation should allow or indicate that meaning.

**peace:** Here this word refers to well-being and being free from troubles. See how you translated this word in 2:10 or 3:17.

## Romans 8:7

### Section 8:1–17: Believers live by the Holy Spirit

In this section Paul reminded the believers in Rome that God does not condemn them, because the Holy Spirit has set them free from sin and death. Jesus became like an Old Testament sin offering to remove the consequences of our sin. The laws of Moses demanded a righteous life, and in the Holy Spirit we can live that way.

The people who live according to the sinful nature seek to do things that are in accord with that nature. Also, they cannot please God, cannot follow his laws, are hostile to him, and will be punished with death forever. The people who live according to the Holy Spirit seek to do things that are in accord with his desire.

Christians allow the Holy Spirit to work in them. When they do that, they are as if dead to sin and God will give them life. Those without the Holy Spirit do not belong to Jesus Christ.

We put to death the deeds of the sinful nature. We do that by the power of the Holy Spirit. We are God’s children and can do as he does (again, by the power of the Holy Spirit). If we suffer as Jesus suffered, God will give to us his promised inheritance in heaven.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

We must live according to the Holy Spirit, not according to sinfulness

Be Ruled by the Spirit (NCV)

Living by the Power of God’s Spirit (CEV)

### 8:7a

**because the mind of the flesh is hostile to God:**

- That is true because a mind full of the physical life is an enemy to God,
- People whose thinking follows only thoughts and desires from the body hate God

**because:** The Greek begins with a word that the BSB literally translates as because. If it would be natural in your language to start a sentence here, but your language does not start sentences with because, consider introducing the because like this:

I say that because

Many English versions omit this word and allow the context to indicate this connection. Other English versions translate this word as “For” and begin a new sentence here. For example:

For... (ESV)

**the mind of the flesh:** This is the same Greek phrase as “the mind of the flesh” in 8:6.

**is hostile to God:** The Greek word that the BSB translates as hostile refers to be an enemy to someone. People who are set on following their natural ways are enemies to God. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

are enemies of God

opposes God Kankanaey Back Translation on TW.

### 8:7b

**It does not submit to God’s law,**

- for that mind does not put itself under the laws of God,
- and do not let God’s rules lead them.

In the Greek, 8:7b begins with a word that is usually translated as “for.” It gives an explanation of the statements that Paul made in 8:6–7a. However, some English versions omit this word and replace it with a semi-colon, as the BSB does. If this would not be natural in your language, consider translating the word “for,” as the ESV does:

for it does not submit (ESV)

**It does not submit to God's law:** The word submit refers to putting oneself under the leadership of someone. The mind set on the human nature will not let God's law lead them. For example:

It refuses to place itself under the authority of God's standards (GW)

**It does not submit:** Here the word It refers to "the mind of the flesh" in 8:7a. In some languages the people or person of that mind in 8:7a must be referred to. For example:

he does not submit

they do not submit

**God's law:** This phrase refers to all of God's commands, written in what is now called the Old Testament (the Hebrew Bible). In some languages the plural for law is more natural, since there is more than one law. For example:

God's laws

You should not translate this phrase as "the laws of Moses."

**8:7c**  
**nor can it do so.**

- because it is not even able to do so/that.
- Indeed/Hey, they are not at all able to let God's rules lead them.

**nor can it do so:** A more literal translation of the Greek here is "for it is not able to" or "for it is not even able to." It indicates or emphasizes that the mind set on following the needs and desires of the body is unable to submit to God's laws. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

for it is not even able to do so (NASB)

and it never will (NLT)

because it cannot

## Romans 8:8

### Section 8:1–17: Believers live by the Holy Spirit

In this section Paul reminded the believers in Rome that God does not condemn them, because the Holy Spirit has set them free from sin and death. Jesus became like an Old Testament sin offering to remove the consequences of our sin. The laws of Moses demanded a righteous life, and in the Holy Spirit we can live that way.

The people who live according to the sinful nature seek to do things that are in accord with that nature. Also, they cannot please God, cannot follow his laws, are hostile to him, and will be punished with death forever. The people who live according to the Holy Spirit seek to do things that are in accord with his desire.

Christians allow the Holy Spirit to work in them. When they do that, they are as if dead to sin and God will give them life. Those without the Holy Spirit do not belong to Jesus Christ.

We put to death the deeds of the sinful nature. We do that by the power of the Holy Spirit. We are God's children and can do as he does (again, by the power of the Holy Spirit). If we suffer as Jesus suffered, God will give to us his promised inheritance in heaven.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

We must live according to the Holy Spirit, not according to sinfulness

Be Ruled by the Spirit (NCV)

Living by the Power of God's Spirit (CEV)

### 8:8

#### Those controlled by the flesh cannot please God.

- And the ones who always follow the physical life are unable to make God happy.
- The group of people who dwell on thoughts and desires from the body, they are not able to do the things that please God.

The Greek begins with a word that is often translated "and" or "but." Here it indicates that the topic from 8:7 continues and there is new information about pleasing God. For example, the NJB begins this verse with:

and (NJB)

**Those controlled by the flesh:** The phrase by the flesh indicates that these people's whole life is oriented toward the needs and wants that govern their physical lives. They think and behave only according to it, and think it normal to think and behave that way. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

Those who obey their human nature (GNT)

those who live according to the needs and desires of the body

whoever has the desires of the body rule their lives

See how you translated the phrase “according to the flesh” in 7:5.

## Romans 8:9

### Section 8:1–17: Believers live by the Holy Spirit

In this section Paul reminded the believers in Rome that God does not condemn them, because the Holy Spirit has set them free from sin and death. Jesus became like an Old Testament sin offering to remove the consequences of our sin. The laws of Moses demanded a righteous life, and in the Holy Spirit we can live that way.

The people who live according to the sinful nature seek to do things that are in accord with that nature. Also, they cannot please God, cannot follow his laws, are hostile to him, and will be punished with death forever. The people who live according to the Holy Spirit seek to do things that are in accord with his desire.

Christians allow the Holy Spirit to work in them. When they do that, they are as if dead to sin and God will give them life. Those without the Holy Spirit do not belong to Jesus Christ.

We put to death the deeds of the sinful nature. We do that by the power of the Holy Spirit. We are God's children and can do as he does (again, by the power of the Holy Spirit). If we suffer as Jesus suffered, God will give to us his promised inheritance in heaven.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

We must live according to the Holy Spirit, not according to sinfulness

Be Ruled by the Spirit (NCV)

Living by the Power of God's Spirit (CEV)

### 8:9a

**You, however, are controlled not by the flesh, but by the Spirit,**

- ¶ But you yourselves belong to the Spirit and not to the human body,
- ¶ But, as for you, you have new life in the Holy Spirit and no longer belong to the thoughts and desires from the body,

**You:** In the Greek the meaning of You is emphasized. For example:

as for you Tagbanwa Back Translation on TW.

**however:** There is contrast between “those controlled by the flesh” (8:8) and “you are controlled not by the flesh, but by the Spirit.” For example:

But (NABRE)

But some languages will not see contrast here. For example:

And Western Bukidnon Manobo Back Translation on TW.

**are controlled not by the flesh, but by the Spirit:** In some languages it is more natural to put the negated part last. For example:

are in the Spirit and not in the flesh

**by the flesh:** Translate this phrase as you did in 8:8.

**by the Spirit:** The word by here indicates a focus upon and an allegiance to something. Here it indicates that believers live with a focus upon and an allegiance to the Spirit. In this case the person controlled by the Spirit is oriented toward the desires of the Spirit and allows himself to be led by him. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

have a relationship with the Holy Spirit

are connected to the Spirit

**the Spirit:** This refers to the Holy Spirit here.

### 8:9b

**if the Spirit of God lives in you.**

- if, indeed/truly, God's Spirit remains/lives in you.
- since the Holy Spirit of God resides in your hearts/inner-beings.
- should the Spirit of God inhabit you.

**if the Spirit of God lives in you:** Here the word if introduces a situation that is true. If this first part is true, that supports the then-clause ("You...are controlled not by the flesh, but by the Spirit," 8:9a).

In some languages, using an if-clause would have a different meaning. If that is true in your language, translate the correct meaning. For example:

since the Spirit of God dwells in you (NRSV)

should the Spirit of God live in you

if you agree that the Spirit of God lives in you and I know that you do

**the Spirit of God lives in you:** The word lives indicates that the Holy Spirit is always present in the life of a believer. He counsels the believer as to what to do. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

you have the Spirit of God living in you (NLT)

the Holy Spirit remains in youKankanaey Back Translation on TW.

the Spirit of God dwells in your hearts/liver/insides

If you have translated 1 Corinthians 3:16, see how you translated this clause there.

### 8:9c

**And if anyone does not have the Spirit of Christ, he does not belong to Christ.**

- And if someone does not have the Spirit of Jesus Christ remaining/living in him, he is not his person.
- But, if a person does not have a relationship with the Holy Spirit of Christ and God, then that person is not of him/Christ.

**And:** This Greek word indicates that the topic from 8:7 continues and there is new information about people who do not have the Holy Spirit living in them. There is possibly contrast between those who have the Holy Spirit (8:9b) and those who do not (8:9c). For example:

And (NIV, BSB)

But (NCV)

**if anyone does not have the Spirit of Christ:** This refers to people who do not believe in Jesus. The word have here refers to being in a relationship with the Spirit of Christ. It is similar in meaning to "the Spirit of God dwells in you," but looks at that relationship from the side of the believer. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

the person who does not have the Spirit of Christ living in him

the person in whom the Holy Spirit is not stayingKankanaey Back Translation on TW.

**the Spirit of Christ:** This phrase also refers to the Holy Spirit. In some languages a literal translation would wrongly refer to a different spirit. If that is true in your language, indicate that this phrase refers again to the Holy Spirit. For example:

that Spirit of Jesus Christ

that Spirit, he/who is also the Spirit of Christ

If you have translated 1 Peter 1:11, see how you translated this phrase there.

**he does not belong to Christ:** The people who do not believe in Jesus, they do not have the Holy Spirit living in them and they are not Jesus' people. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

he is not of him

he is not Cristo's personKankanaey Back Translation on TW.

## Romans 8:10

### Section 8:1-17: Believers live by the Holy Spirit

In this section Paul reminded the believers in Rome that God does not condemn them, because the Holy Spirit has set them free from sin and death. Jesus became like an Old Testament sin offering to remove the consequences of our sin. The laws of Moses demanded a righteous life, and in the Holy Spirit we can live that way.

The people who live according to the sinful nature seek to do things that are in accord with that nature. Also, they cannot please God, cannot follow his laws,



are hostile to him, and will be punished with death forever. The people who live according to the Holy Spirit seek to do things that are in accord with his desire.

Christians allow the Holy Spirit to work in them. When they do that, they are as if dead to sin and God will give them life. Those without the Holy Spirit do not belong to Jesus Christ.

We put to death the deeds of the sinful nature. We do that by the power of the Holy Spirit. We are God's children and can do as he does (again, by the power of the Holy Spirit). If we suffer as Jesus suffered, God will give to us his promised inheritance in heaven.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

We must live according to the Holy Spirit, not according to sinfulness

Be Ruled by the Spirit (NCV)

Living by the Power of God's Spirit (CEV)

#### 8:10a

##### **But if Christ is in you,**

- But if Christ/Messiah lives in you<sup>(plur)</sup>,
- But the one/person whom God appointed to save/rescue people dwells/remains in you, and so

**But:** There is contrast between “anyone who does not have the Spirit of Christ” (8:9c) and “Christ is in you” here. For that reason many English versions translate the Greek word here as But.

**if Christ is in you:** Here the word if introduces a situation that is true. If this first part is true, that supports the second part (“your spirit is alive because of righteousness...your body is dead because of sin” 8:10c,b).

In some languages, using an if-clause would have a different meaning. If that is true in your language, translate the correct meaning. For example:

Christ lives within you, so (NLT)

should Jesus Christ be in you

if you agree that Christ is in you and I know that you do, then you should also agree that

**Christ is in you:** There is no verb in the Greek, but is is clearly implied (for natural English). Here are other ways to translate this clause:

Cristo remains in you Kankanaey Back Translation on TW.

Christ lives in your hearts/insides

#### 8:10b

##### **your body is dead because of sin,**

- then the physical body is as if dead because of sins,
- your bodies are destined/marked to someday die because you sin,

**your body is dead:** There is no verb in the Greek here. Many English versions add is, in accord with adding “is” in 8:10a. But here the clause needs to be understood in a figurative sense, because Paul was speaking of believers who were still alive. They do not live according to human nature, so in that way their human nature (or body) is dead. Other English versions add a different word or phrase to avoid the figurative use of is. For example:

is subject to death (NIV11)

your body will die (NLT)

**body:** This word refers to the physical body of a human being. Some languages must add a possessive pronoun. For example:

your bodies

**because of sin:** Sin leads to death (5:12 and 6:23). In some languages it is more natural to add a possessive pronoun to the word sin. In some languages it is more natural to make the word sin plural. For example:

because of your sins (CEV)

#### 8:10c

##### **yet your spirit is alive because of righteousness.**

- and yet the Spirit gives life because of our righteousness in Christ.
- but the Holy Spirit gives life to you because you believed and God made you righteous.

**your spirit is alive:** There are three ways to interpret this clause:

1. It indicates that the Holy Spirit provides life to believers here. For example:

the Spirit is life for you (GNT) (NIV11, GNT, NLT, NET, REB, NCV)

1. It indicates that the human spirit of believers is alive here. For example:

your spirits are alive (GW) (BSB, RSV, NIV84, NJB, NABRE, NASB, GW, CEV)

1. It indicates that the Holy Spirit is life in some general way. For example:

the Spirit is life (KJV) (KJV, NRSV, ESV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1), because these verses are talking about the relationship of the Holy Spirit to believers. See Moo (page 491) or Cranfield (page 390).

**is alive:** Again, the Greek does not have a verb here. Many English versions add *is*, in accord with adding “*is*” in 8:10a and 8:10b. However, here the implied connection is probably that the Holy Spirit gives life, Cranfield (page 390), Kruse (page 333), and Barrett (page 159). implying new life. For example:

gives life (NIV11)

**because of righteousness:** God has declared believers to be righteous (3:21). The Holy Spirit then indwells them and gives them life (8:11).

## Romans 8:11

### Section 8:1–17: Believers live by the Holy Spirit

In this section Paul reminded the believers in Rome that God does not condemn them, because the Holy Spirit has set them free from sin and death. Jesus became like an Old Testament sin offering to remove the consequences of our sin. The laws of Moses demanded a righteous life, and in the Holy Spirit we can live that way.

The people who live according to the sinful nature seek to do things that are in accord with that nature. Also, they cannot please God, cannot follow his laws, are hostile to him, and will be punished with death forever. The people who live according to the Holy Spirit seek to do things that are in accord with his desire.

Christians allow the Holy Spirit to work in them. When they do that, they are as if dead to sin and God will give them life. Those without the Holy Spirit do not belong to Jesus Christ.

We put to death the deeds of the sinful nature. We do that by the power of the Holy Spirit. We are God’s children and can do as he does (again, by the power of the Holy Spirit). If we suffer as Jesus suffered, God will give to us his promised inheritance in heaven.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

We must live according to the Holy Spirit, not according to sinfulness

Be Ruled by the Spirit (NCV)

Living by the Power of God’s Spirit (CEV)

### 8:11a

**And if the Spirit of Him who raised Jesus from the dead is living in you,**

- And/But if the Spirit of the one who raised Jesus to life again from the dead lives in you<sup>(plur)</sup>,
- Also, God caused Jesus to leave the spirits of dead people and be alive again, and his Spirit resides in your hearts/inner-beings. So

**And:** This Greek word indicates that the topic from 8:10 continues and there is new information about the Holy Spirit and believers. There is possibly contrast between the Holy Spirit giving new life (8:10c) and God also giving life to the believer’s body in the future (8:11c). For example:

And (NIV, BSB)

But (NASB)

**if the Spirit of Him who raised Jesus from the dead is living in you:** Here the word *if* introduces a situation that is true. If this first part is true, that supports the then-clause (“He who raised Christ Jesus from the dead will also give life to your mortal bodies through His Spirit, who lives in you” 8:11b–d).

In some languages, using an *if*-clause would have a different meaning. If that is true in your language, translate the correct meaning. For example:

the Spirit of him who raised Jesus from the dead dwells in you, so

should the Spirit of him who raised Jesus from the dead dwell in you

if you agree that the Spirit of him who raised Jesus from the dead dwells in you, and I know that you do, then you should also agree that

The word Spirit refers to the Holy Spirit. The word Him refers to God. In some languages, if you translate Him as “God,” you will also need to translate the word who in another way. By specifying “him” as God, it turns the who-clause into a descriptive relative clause, and some languages do not use that kind of relative clause. For example:

God raised Jesus from the dead, and if his Spirit dwells in you,

God raised Jesus from the dead, and should that Spirit of God dwell in you,

God raised Jesus from the dead, if you agree that his Holy Spirit dwells in you, and I know that you do, then you should also agree that

**raised...from the dead:** This phrase refers to God making Jesus alive again after he died and was put in the tomb. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

raised...from death (GNT)

brought...back to life (GW)

### 8:11b

#### He who raised Christ Jesus from the dead

- then the one who raised Christ/Messiah from the dead
- God (he raised Jesus, the one/person whom God appointed to save/rescue people)

**He who raised Christ Jesus from the dead:** Paul repeated what he has said about God raising Jesus for emphasis. In some languages it is not natural to repeat these words. If that is true in your language, indicate the emphasis in a natural way. For example:

that one

this same God

**Christ Jesus:** There is a textual issue here:

1. Some Greek manuscripts have Christ, and the NIV and other English versions follow those. (NIV, GNT, NABRE, NRSV, KJV, GW, NET, NCV)
2. Some Greek manuscripts have Christ Jesus, as in the BSB. (BSB, RSV, ESV, NJB, NASB, NLT, REB)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1), because the Greek NT 5 has decided it is the best reading.

The order of the words Christ Jesus emphasizes that Jesus is the Christ/Messiah. If you choose the reading Christ Jesus, it is not natural in some languages to have Christ before Jesus. See how you translated this phrase in 8:1.

### 8:11c

#### will also give life to your mortal bodies

- will also make your bodies, which/they are certain to die, live again after you die
- will also put life in your earthly bodies which die.

**will also give life to your mortal bodies:** Many scholars. For example, see Moo (on TW), Morris (on TW), Kruse (page 334), or Cranfield (page 391). Jewett (page 492) thinks it has the same meaning as “life” in 8:10c (ESV: “the Spirit is life”). And Alford (page 390) thinks it refers to building up believers in heaven after their resurrection. think that the words will...give life refer to when God resurrects believers. It probably does not refer to the new life that we have as believers here on earth.

**your mortal bodies:** The word mortal indicates that earthly bodies die. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

your bodies that will die

your bodies will dieYongkom Back Translation, by this author, unpublished manuscript.

your bodies that dieKankanaey Back Translation on TW.

See how you translated the word mortal in 6:12.

### 8:11d

#### through His Spirit, who lives in you.

- by his Spirit who/he lives in you.
- He will do that by means of his Holy Spirit, and this Spirit resides in your hearts/inner-beings.

**through His Spirit:** There is a textual issue here about the Greek phrase:

1. It means through his Spirit here, as in the BSB. (BSB, RSV, NIV, GNT, NJB, NASB, KJV, ESV, NABRE, NLT, GW, CEV, NET, REB, NCV)
2. It means because of his Spirit here. For example:

because of his Spirit (NIV11) (NIV2011)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1), because the Greek NT 5 has decided it was the best reading.

**through:** Here this word indicates that God will give the task of giving life to believers to the Holy Spirit and he (the Holy Spirit) will do it.

**His Spirit, who lives in you:** The words who lives in you further describe the Holy Spirit. It does not separate this Holy Spirit from other spirits. For the correct meaning in some languages, translators must avoid the word who. For example:

his Spirit, he dwells in you

## Romans 8:12

### Section 8:1-17: Believers live by the Holy Spirit

In this section Paul reminded the believers in Rome that God does not condemn them, because the Holy Spirit has set them free from sin and death. Jesus became like an Old Testament sin offering to remove the consequences of our sin. The laws of Moses demanded a righteous life, and in the Holy Spirit we can live that way.

The people who live according to the sinful nature seek to do things that are in accord with that nature. Also, they cannot please God, cannot follow his laws, are hostile to him, and will be punished with death forever. The people who live according to the Holy Spirit seek to do things that are in accord with his desire.

Christians allow the Holy Spirit to work in them. When they do that, they are as if dead to sin and God will give them life. Those without the Holy Spirit do not belong to Jesus Christ.

We put to death the deeds of the sinful nature. We do that by the power of the Holy Spirit. We are God's children and can do as he does (again, by the power of the Holy Spirit). If we suffer as Jesus suffered, God will give to us his promised inheritance in heaven.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

We must live according to the Holy Spirit, not according to sinfulness

Be Ruled by the Spirit (NCV)

Living by the Power of God's Spirit (CEV)

### 8:12a

**Therefore, brothers, we have an obligation, but it is not to the flesh,**

- ¶ So then, my brothers and sisters, we<sup>(incl)</sup> are obligated/responsible, not to obey the desires of the human body,
- ¶ Therefore, my fellow believers, we have a duty, but it is not to follow thoughts and desires from the body.

**Therefore:** This word introduces a statement resulting (often called "a conclusion") from what Paul said in 8:1-11. See Cranfield (page 394), where he calls it a "conclusion." Dunn (page 447) also calls it a "conclusion." Morris (on TW) calls it "consequences." But Jewett (page 493) says it introduces the fourth set of supporting statements to his main point in 8:1. Here are other ways to translate this word:

So then (ESV)

Consequently (NABRE)

**brothers:** Here this word refers to believers in Jesus, both men and women. The word indicates a close relationship between believers because God has made them his (adopted) children. See how you translated this word in 1:13 or 7:1.

**we have an obligation, but it is not to the flesh:**

These words indicate that believers are debtors, but we are not debtors to live according to the flesh (human nature). Here are other ways to translate these words:

we are debtors, but it is not to the flesh

we are in debt, but we are not in debt to human nature

**we have an obligation, but it is not to:** The Greek word that the BSB translates as obligation refers to being required to do something. Here the word does not refer to owing money to someone. Here are other ways to translate these words:

we have no obligation to (NJB)

there is that which we have a duty to obey, but it is not  
Kankanaey Back Translation on TW.

we are not required to obey

**flesh:** This word refers to how we normally behaved before we believed in Jesus. See how you translated this word in 8:4 or 8:9.

#### **8:12b** **to live according to it.**

- that is, not to live following the physical life.
- No, our duty is not to live guided by thoughts and desires from the body.

**to live according to it:** This phrase explains “to the flesh” in 8:12a. It refers to living as human nature says someone should live. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

to live as our human nature wants us to (GNT)

to live ruled by human nature

## **Romans 8:13**

### **Section 8:1–17: Believers live by the Holy Spirit**

In this section Paul reminded the believers in Rome that God does not condemn them, because the Holy Spirit has set them free from sin and death. Jesus became like an Old Testament sin offering to remove the consequences of our sin. The laws of Moses demanded a righteous life, and in the Holy Spirit we can live that way.

The people who live according to the sinful nature seek to do things that are in accord with that nature. Also, they cannot please God, cannot follow his laws, are hostile to him, and will be punished with death forever. The people who live according to the Holy Spirit seek to do things that are in accord with his desire.

Christians allow the Holy Spirit to work in them. When they do that, they are as if dead to sin and God will give them life. Those without the Holy Spirit do not belong to Jesus Christ.

We put to death the deeds of the sinful nature. We do that by the power of the Holy Spirit. We are God’s children and can do as he does (again, by the power of the Holy Spirit). If we suffer as Jesus suffered, God will give to us his promised inheritance in heaven.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

We must live according to the Holy Spirit, not according to sinfulness

Be Ruled by the Spirit (NCV)

Living by the Power of God’s Spirit (CEV)

### **8:13a**

#### **For if you live according to the flesh,**

- For if you<sup>(plur)</sup> are living following the desires of the body,
- Now, if you might be living guided by thoughts and desires of the body,

**For:** Here this word introduces a sentence in support of believers having no obligation to live according to the flesh (8:12). Jewett (page 494).

**if you live according to the flesh:** Here Paul spoke about the possibility that the believers in Rome might be living according to the flesh. He did not expect it to be true. But if it was true, 8:13b tells the result of such a life.

The if caused the believers in Rome to examine their lives to see how they are living.

**if you live:** The verb is present tense. Previous verses imply that Paul did not expect this to be true. Translate in a way that makes it clear that Paul did not expect that the believers in Rome were living this way. For example:

should you live

if you might be living

**you:** This is a letter to the believers in Rome, so the you here primarily applies to them. But the you here also allows a general application to anyone.

### **8:13b**

#### **you will die;**

- you will certainly die,
- then you will indeed die.

**you will die:** The Greek expresses certainty here. For example:

you will certainly die

you are destined/doomed to die

### 8:13c

**but if by the Spirit you put to death the deeds of the body,**

- but if by/through his Spirit's power you are killing the deeds of the body,
- But if you are causing the deeds of the desires of your bodies to end with the help of the Holy Spirit,

**but if:** Here Paul spoke about the possibility that the believers in Rome might be living by the Spirit. He expected this to be true. 8:13d tells the result of such a life. The if caused the believers in Rome, and causes all believers since this is Scripture, to examine their lives to see how they are living.

**by the Spirit you put to death the deeds of the body:**

Here the word by indicates that the Holy Spirit enables believers to put to death the deeds of the body. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

by/through the power of the Holy Spirit you put to death the deeds of the body

with the help of the Holy Spirit you put to death the deeds of the body

The phrase by the Spirit is emphasized by being first in the clause. In some languages it must be in its normal place. It may be possible to emphasize the phrase in some other way. For example:

you put to death the deeds of the body by the power of the Holy Spirit

you put to death the deeds of the body in this way alone: with the help of the Holy Spirit

**you put to death the deeds of the body:** This is a metaphor. The metaphor indicates that believers are to work at ending the deeds of the body. The verb is present tense, which here indicates an ongoing effort. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

you are killing the deeds of the body

you are causing the deeds of the body to die

Some languages must translate without this metaphor for the correct meaning. For example:

you are ending/abandoning the deeds of the body

you are turning your backs to the deeds of the body

**the deeds of the body:** The word body refers to our physical being and implies its desires. In some languages a literal translation would be too general. If that is true in your language, indicate the correct meaning. For example:

the deeds of the desires of the body

### 8:13d

**you will live.**

- you will live.
- then you will have life.

**you will live:** Here the word live is in contrast to “die” in 8:13b. Just as the body “dies” (8:10), we live by the Holy Spirit when we believe (8:11). For example:

you will have true life (NCV)

you will definitely obtain life which has no ending Tagbanwa Back Translation on TW.

## Romans 8:14

### Section 8:1–17: Believers live by the Holy Spirit

In this section Paul reminded the believers in Rome that God does not condemn them, because the Holy Spirit has set them free from sin and death. Jesus became like an Old Testament sin offering to remove the consequences of our sin. The laws of Moses demanded a righteous life, and in the Holy Spirit we can live that way.

The people who live according to the sinful nature seek to do things that are in accord with that nature. Also, they cannot please God, cannot follow his laws, are hostile to him, and will be punished with death forever. The people who live according to the Holy Spirit seek to do things that are in accord with his desire.

Christians allow the Holy Spirit to work in them. When they do that, they are as if dead to sin and God will give them life. Those without the Holy Spirit do not belong to Jesus Christ.

We put to death the deeds of the sinful nature. We do that by the power of the Holy Spirit. We are God's children and can do as he does (again, by the power

of the Holy Spirit). If we suffer as Jesus suffered, God will give to us his promised inheritance in heaven.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

We must live according to the Holy Spirit, not according to sinfulness

Be Ruled by the Spirit (NCV)

Living by the Power of God's Spirit (CEV)

#### 8:14

**For all who are led by the Spirit of God are sons of God.**

- For all those led by the Spirit of God are the children of God.
- And/Indeed, the people whom God's Spirit guides are God's children.

Some English versions and some scholars have a new section heading here. 8:14-17 talk about believers being God's children, but the topic in these verses is also connected to the topic in 8:1-13. If the major language version in your area has a section heading here, consider whether to have one here or not. For example:

Children of God (NJB)

Children of God Through Adoption (NABRE)

God Has Adopted Us As His Children

**For:** This word introduces a basis, explanation, or reason for being able to put to death the deeds of the body (8:13c). See Morris (on TW), Moo (on TW) and Jewett (page 496), respectively. It is not clear to this author which is most likely.

**all who are led by the Spirit of God:** This clause is passive. Some languages must use an active clause. For example:

all whom the Spirit of God leads

**sons of God:** The word sons refers to men and women, as well as boys and girls here. For example:

the children of God (NIV11)

## Romans 8:15

### Section 8:1-17: Believers live by the Holy Spirit

In this section Paul reminded the believers in Rome that God does not condemn them, because the Holy Spirit has set them free from sin and death. Jesus became like an Old Testament sin offering to remove the consequences of our sin. The laws of Moses demanded a righteous life, and in the Holy Spirit we can live that way.

The people who live according to the sinful nature seek to do things that are in accord with that nature. Also, they cannot please God, cannot follow his laws, are hostile to him, and will be punished with death forever. The people who live according to the Holy Spirit seek to do things that are in accord with his desire.

Christians allow the Holy Spirit to work in them. When they do that, they are as if dead to sin and God will give them life. Those without the Holy Spirit do not belong to Jesus Christ.

We put to death the deeds of the sinful nature. We do that by the power of the Holy Spirit. We are God's children and can do as he does (again, by the power of the Holy Spirit). If we suffer as Jesus suffered, God will give to us his promised inheritance in heaven.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

We must live according to the Holy Spirit, not according to sinfulness

Be Ruled by the Spirit (NCV)

Living by the Power of God's Spirit (CEV)

#### 8:15a

**For you did not receive a spirit of slavery that returns you to fear,**

- For you<sup>(plur)</sup> received the Spirit who does not give to you the attitude/mindset of slaves/slavery to live again in fear,
- And God gave the Holy Spirit to you, and that Spirit does not make you slaves and cause you to be fearful/afraid again.

**For:** Here this word introduces an explanation of 8:14. Moo (on TW) and Jewett (page 497).

**you did not receive a spirit of slavery:** There are two ways to interpret the Greek word that the BSB translates as spirit:

1. It refers to an attitude or mindset of slavery. As believers in our new life, we do not have the feeling of being oppressed, of having no say about our own life, of being required to do things that we may not want to do, and other things of the life of a slave. For example:

you did not receive a spirit of slavery (NABRE) (BSB, RSV, NIV, NJB, NASB, NLT, NABRE, ESV, KJV, GW, NET)

1. It refers to the Holy Spirit. For example:

The Spirit we received does not make us slaves (NCV) (NIV11, GNT, CEV, REB, NCV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1), because it seems unlikely that the Holy Spirit would be connected to slavery with the connection of of Moo (page 500) says, "In Gal. 4:1-7 the idea of slavery is specifically tied to the situation of being 'under the law' (see also the contrast in Heb. 12:18-24, cited by Calvin). But it may be questioned whether Paul would speak of this effect of the law as brought about by God's Spirit, in light of the contrast between 'letter' and 'Spirit' in 7:6 and 2 Cor. 3:6-18. This makes it unlikely that 'spirit of slavery' refers directly to the Holy Spirit."

**you did not receive:** In English, receive indicates that someone gave, but the word "take" does not. In some languages there is only one word that means both receive and "take." If your word here would indicate that God did not give the Holy Spirit but that the believers just took him, translate in a way that indicates that God gave the Spirit. For example:

God did not give to you

**that returns you to fear:** This phrase refers to the result of being made slaves or having the attitude of a slave. Moo (page 500) says, "The Spirit that believers have received does not bring about 'again' that anxiety and fear of judgment which they suffered in their pre-Christian state (compare Gal. 4:8-10)."

These words in the Greek are literally "again to fear." The Holy Spirit does not cause us to be fearful. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

so that you live in fear again (NIV11)

and cause you to be afraid again

## 8:15b

### but you received the Spirit of sonship,

- but you received the Spirit who made you God's adopted children.
- Instead, the Spirit whom God gave to you made the way for God to adopt you as his children.

**but you received:** As in 8:15a, God gave the Holy Spirit.

**the Spirit of sonship:** Here the word of indicates that the Holy Spirit causes believers to be adopted as God's children. Jewett (page 498) says "a Spirit producing sonship," Witherington (page 217) says the Holy Spirit "brings sonship," and Morris (on TW) says, "The Spirit does not make people slaves but sons." Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

the Spirit you received brought about your adoption to sonship (NIV11)

the Spirit made you God's children

**sonship:** The word sonship refers to taking someone who is not your child and making them legally your child. Here it refers to the Holy Spirit making a believer God's adopted child when he or she becomes a believer. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

adopted as God's children

caused you to become God's adopted children

## General Comment on 8:15a-b

What the Holy Spirit does do (8:15b) comes after what the Holy Spirit does not do (8:15a). In some languages it is more natural to have 8:15b first. For example:

For you received the Spirit and he made you God's adopted children. This Spirit does not give to you the attitude/mindset of slaves/slavery to live again in fear.

## 8:15c

### by whom we cry, "Abba! Father!"

- And through the power of the Spirit we<sup>(incl)</sup> call out to God, "Abba, Dad/Father."
- And the Spirit gives us the power to call God our Father.

**by whom we cry, "Abba! Father!":** The words by whom indicate that the Holy Spirit makes us able to



call out to God as a son calls out to his father. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

and with his strength we can cry/shout to God,  
“Abba! Father!”

**we cry:** Here the Greek word that the BSB translates as cry refers to speaking with strong emotion. It could be just about any emotion, including being sad, desperate, happy, enthusiastic, or afraid of something. In many languages a literal translation would wrongly refer only to being in pain with tears in the eyes, or wailing. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

we call out (GW)

say strongly

**Abba! Father:** Abba is the word in the Aramaic language. This was the language spoken by most of the Jews in Palestine at that time. That means “father.” At that time it was used by both children and adults for their fathers. Here it would remind readers that Jesus used it when praying to God. So it would imply a similar relationship for believers to God.

In some languages people will not know what Abba means. If that is true in your language, you may want to explain its meaning in a footnote. Here is an example footnote:

The word “Abba” means “father” in Aramaic. Jesus used this word (Mark 14:36).

Some languages must indicate whose father this is. For example:

Abba, my-father!

## Romans 8:16

### Section 8:1-17: Believers live by the Holy Spirit

In this section Paul reminded the believers in Rome that God does not condemn them, because the Holy Spirit has set them free from sin and death. Jesus became like an Old Testament sin offering to remove the consequences of our sin. The laws of Moses demanded a righteous life, and in the Holy Spirit we can live that way.

The people who live according to the sinful nature seek to do things that are in accord with that nature. Also, they cannot please God, cannot follow his laws,

are hostile to him, and will be punished with death forever. The people who live according to the Holy Spirit seek to do things that are in accord with his desire.

Christians allow the Holy Spirit to work in them. When they do that, they are as if dead to sin and God will give them life. Those without the Holy Spirit do not belong to Jesus Christ.

We put to death the deeds of the sinful nature. We do that by the power of the Holy Spirit. We are God’s children and can do as he does (again, by the power of the Holy Spirit). If we suffer as Jesus suffered, God will give to us his promised inheritance in heaven.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

We must live according to the Holy Spirit, not according to sinfulness

Be Ruled by the Spirit (NCV)

Living by the Power of God’s Spirit (CEV)

### 8:16a

#### The Spirit Himself testifies with our spirit

- It is that same Spirit that speaks in truth, along with our spirits/hearts,
- The Spirit himself, together with our own insides, truthfully speaks out

**The Spirit Himself:** This phrase refers to the Holy Spirit. The word Himself emphasizes that it is the Holy Spirit that bears witness.

**testifies with our spirit:** The word testifies means “reports what one saw.” The phrase is often used where the person is expected to be truthful and accurate. Here the Holy Spirit, along with our spirit, report truthfully that we are God’s children. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

bears witness with our spirit (ESV)

together with our spirit speaks out

**our spirit:** Here the word spirit refers to the inner part of a person. In some languages the word spirit refers only to the part of a person that still lives after the body dies. If that is true in your language, translate the meaning of the inner part of a person while he is still alive. For example:

our insides/hearts/livers

### 8:16b

#### that we are God's children.

- that we<sup>(incl)</sup> are God's children,
- that God has adopted us as his children.

**God's children:** The Greek word that the BSB translates as children refers to boys and girls and men and women who have a parent. It is different from the Greek word that is translated "sons" in 8:14, but in these verses the meaning is the same.

In some languages it is more clear or more natural to repeat that believers are adopted children of God (from 8:15). For example:

adopted children of God

## Romans 8:17

### Section 8:1-17: Believers live by the Holy Spirit

In this section Paul reminded the believers in Rome that God does not condemn them, because the Holy Spirit has set them free from sin and death. Jesus became like an Old Testament sin offering to remove the consequences of our sin. The laws of Moses demanded a righteous life, and in the Holy Spirit we can live that way.

The people who live according to the sinful nature seek to do things that are in accord with that nature. Also, they cannot please God, cannot follow his laws, are hostile to him, and will be punished with death forever. The people who live according to the Holy Spirit seek to do things that are in accord with his desire.

Christians allow the Holy Spirit to work in them. When they do that, they are as if dead to sin and God will give them life. Those without the Holy Spirit do not belong to Jesus Christ.

We put to death the deeds of the sinful nature. We do that by the power of the Holy Spirit. We are God's children and can do as he does (again, by the power of the Holy Spirit). If we suffer as Jesus suffered, God will give to us his promised inheritance in heaven.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

We must live according to the Holy Spirit, not according to sinfulness

Be Ruled by the Spirit (NCV)

Living by the Power of God's Spirit (CEV)

### 8:17a

#### And if we are children, then we are heirs:

- and if we<sup>(incl)</sup> are his children, then we are also people who will receive something in the future,
- God has indeed adopted us as his children, so he will give future things/blessings in heaven to us.

**And if we are children:** Here the word "his" is implied before the word children. Here the word if introduces a situation that is true. If this first part is true, that supports the second part ("then we are heirs") to also be true.

In some languages, using an if-clause would have a different meaning, or be confusing after just saying clearly that we are God's adopted children. If that is true in your language, translate the correct meaning. For example:

we are his adopted children, true? So...

Would you agree that we are his adopted children? So...

we are his adopted children, so...

**then we are heirs:** The Greek here is more literally "also heirs." The BSB and many English versions add the word then to make the connection to "if children" clear. For example:

then we are also heirs

The word "his" is implied before the word heirs. In some languages it is more natural to add these implied words. For example:

then we are also his heirs

**heirs:** Here this word indicates that God has chosen things for us to receive once we get to the new Jerusalem. It does not imply that God will one day die. In some languages a different word or phrase must be used for the correct meaning. For example:

ones who will receive an inheritance

people who will receive blessings/gifts up in the future, renewed world

8:17b explains that we are heirs of God.

### 8:17b

#### heirs of God and co-heirs with Christ—

- namely, people who will receive something from God, and Christ will share with us the things he received in heaven,
- God himself will give them to us, and we will share in the things/blessings that Jesus Christ received when he went to heaven,

**heirs of God and co-heirs with Christ:** These words further describe what kind of heirs we are. Here are other ways to translate that connection:

that is, heirs of God and also fellow heirs with Christ

furthermore we are heirs of God and also fellow heirs with Christ

it is like this: we are heirs of God and also fellow heirs with Christ

The Greek connecting words indicate that heirs of God and co-heirs with Christ are connected but different things. An English idiom that is sometimes used for the Greek connecting words is “on the one hand...on the other hand.”

**heirs of God:** Paul here explained whose heir we are. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

it is God who gives it

the blessings/gifts that God will give

**co-heirs with Christ:** This phrase indicates that we will share in some of the things that Jesus received when he went to heaven. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

Jesus Christ will share his inheritance with us

Christ's blessings that we will share

### 8:17c

#### if indeed we suffer with Him,

- if indeed we experience hardship/pain with him,
- supposing it is true that we, together with him, endure troubles/difficulties for his sake,

**if indeed we suffer with Him:** The Greek word that the BSB translates as if indeed introduces a possibility for the readers to consider and indicates emphasis. For example:

provided we suffer with him (ESV)

if we suffer like Jesus Christ did

**we suffer with Him:** Jesus suffered, died, and went to heaven long before Paul wrote this. But Jesus lives in us (1 John 3:24), and our sufferings are connected to his sufferings (Philippians 3:10). In that way we suffer with Him.

**suffer:** This word refers to experiencing physical or emotional pain because of something happening to us.

### 8:17d

#### so that we may also be glorified with Him.

- with the result that we will also be given glory with him.
- and then God will also honor us and allow us to share in his/Christ's glory/greatness/honor.

**so that we may also be glorified with Him:** This is a result clause. This result will occur at the end of this age and is certain, like a promise, if we suffer for Jesus' sake. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

and the result will be that we will also be glorified with him

we will also share his glory (GNT)

**we may also be glorified with Him:** This clause is passive. Some languages must use an active clause. For example:

God may/will also glorify us together with him

**be glorified with Him:** These words refer to the greatness/splendor and blessings of God that he will give to us believers. The splendor and blessings are shared with Jesus. It may also refer to being highly honored. Here are other ways to translate this Greek word:

be made/allowed to share in his glory

we will also be included in his greatness (lit. highness)Kankanaey Back Translation on TW.

we (incl) will also be honored/made-great together with him Yakan Back Translation on TW.

See how you translated the word “glory” in 1:23 or 6:4.

## Romans 8:18

### Section 8:18–30: God promises to us help today and glory later

In this section Paul said that the things that cause us suffering are only small compared to the glory that God will give us in the future, renewed world. The created world waits for God to reveal us, his adopted children, in our new bodies, because he will also renew the created world at that time. We and the created world groan waiting for that renewal. Paul then described what hope is.

The Holy Spirit helps us where we are weak. He also helps us to pray and intercedes for us. God causes all things to work for our good. He chose us to become like Jesus in word and deed, and become like him like a brother is like his brother. He chose us before the creation of the world, called us, made us righteous, and has glorified us.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

We wait for God to give glory to us

Later we will be together with God in his glory

The Holy Spirit helps us today and God will glorify us in the future

### 8:18a

#### I consider that

- ¶ Indeed I believe/know that
- ¶ I am sure/certain that

The Greek of 8:18a begins with a word that is usually translated as “For.” Here this word introduces a sentence that says more about suffering and glory. Moo (on TW). It is not clearly introducing an explanation or a result, so many English versions omit this word here, as the BSB does.

**I consider:** The Greek word here indicates that Paul thought about the sufferings of this present time and decided that what he said in 8:18b–c is true. Here are other ways to translate this word:

In my estimation (NJB)

I think Kankanaey Back Translation on TW.

I know Western Bukidnon Manobo Back Translation on TW.

I am assured Yakan Back Translation on TW.

### 8:18b

#### our present sufferings are not comparable to

- the things/pains we suffer in this time on earth are nothing compared to/with
- the hardships/troubles that come to us during this present age are small and do not measure at all to

**our...sufferings:** Here this word refers to things that cause us trouble or pain (physical or emotional). Some scholars think it refers here to all troubles of this life, including those that come to us because we are believers in Jesus. See Moo (on TW) or Morris (on TW). Other scholars think it refers only to the troubles that come to us because we are believers in Jesus. Cranfield (page 409), Jewett (page 510). Translate in a way that allows for either interpretation.

**present:** This phrase refers to life here on earth before Jesus returns. See Moo (on TW) or Schreiner (page 433). Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

during this time here on earth

that we experience on this earth Kankanaey Back Translation on TW.

**are not comparable to:** Here this phrase indicates that our suffering might be very bad, but the benefits of the glory to come will greatly exceed the difficulty of that suffering. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

are as nothing compared to (NABRE)

be as if it were just nothing when we (incl) think of Yakan Back Translation on TW.

are extremely small if we should compare them to

is a small thing, it cannot be measured against Y-ongkom Back Translation, by this author, unpublished manuscript, Papua New Guinea.

**8:18c****the glory that will be revealed in us.**

- that glory, which will be shown to us what it is.
- that glory/greatness/honor. God will reveal it to us.

**the glory that will be revealed in us:** The glory referred to here is the same as in 8:17, where God will give glory to us. Here Paul spoke of God revealing to us exactly what that glory is. In some languages a literal translation would wrongly refer to a glory different than that of 8:17. If that is true in your language, clearly refer to the glory of 8:17. For example:

that glory, which is to be revealed to us

that glory, and it will be revealed to us at that time

**that will be revealed:** The words will be revealed is passive. Some languages must use an active clause. For example:

that God will reveal

**Romans 8:19****Section 8:18–30: God promises to us help today and glory later**

In this section Paul said that the things that cause us suffering are only small compared to the glory that God will give us in the future, renewed world. The created world waits for God to reveal us, his adopted children, in our new bodies, because he will also renew the created world at that time. We and the created world groan waiting for that renewal. Paul then described what hope is.

The Holy Spirit helps us where we are weak. He also helps us to pray and intercedes for us. God causes all things to work for our good. He chose us to become like Jesus in word and deed, and become like him like a brother is like his brother. He chose us before the creation of the world, called us, made us righteous, and has glorified us.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

We wait for God to give glory to us

Later we will be together with God in his glory

The Holy Spirit helps us today and God will glorify us in the future

**8:19a****The creation waits in eager expectation**

- For creation waits with eager desire
- In fact, all things that God made/created are like a person wanting very much and waiting eagerly

The Greek of 8:19a begins with the same word that the BSB omitted in 8:18a, which is usually translated as “For.” This word introduces a sentence that supports what Paul said in 8:18. Moo (on TW) and Cranfield (page 410). In some languages, it may be more natural to omit this word and leave the connection with 8:18c implicit, as the BSB does.

**The creation waits in eager expectation:** These words are a figure of speech. Some languages cannot speak of creation waiting like a person waits. If that is true in your language, add the word “like.” For example:

the creation is like a person waiting in eager expectation

**The creation:** This phrase refers to all that God made. Here it probably implies not counting people or angels. See how you translated this word in 1:20.

**eager:** This word refers to being interested in something happening and wanting it to happen soon. See how you translated this word in 1:15.

**expectation:** Here this word refers to wanting something to happen.

**8:19b****for the revelation of the sons of God.**

- for the day when the children of God will be revealed.
- for the time when God will show how his children will be glorified.

**the revelation of the sons of God:** This refers to believers being glorified (8:17). It probably implies when believers get glorified bodies. What the glorified bodies are is not known, but will be revealed at this time.

In some languages it is more natural to translate the revelation of as a clause with a verb. For example:

when God will reveal the glorified sons of God

**the sons of God:** The word sons refers to all believers, men and women, boys and girls, as it did in 8:15. 8:16 has “children of God.”

## Romans 8:20

### Section 8:18–30: God promises to us help today and glory later

In this section Paul said that the things that cause us suffering are only small compared to the glory that God will give us in the future, renewed world. The created world waits for God to reveal us, his adopted children, in our new bodies, because he will also renew the created world at that time. We and the created world groan waiting for that renewal. Paul then described what hope is.

The Holy Spirit helps us where we are weak. He also helps us to pray and intercedes for us. God causes all things to work for our good. He chose us to become like Jesus in word and deed, and become like him like a brother is like his brother. He chose us before the creation of the world, called us, made us righteous, and has glorified us.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

We wait for God to give glory to us

Later we will be together with God in his glory

The Holy Spirit helps us today and God will glorify us in the future

#### 8:20a–c

**For the creation was subjected to futility, not by its own will, but because of the One who subjected it, in hope:** The phrase in hope connects to was subjected to futility. Therefore, creation has this hope. For example:

Creation was subjected to frustration but not by its own choice. The one who subjected it to frustration did so in the hope (GW)

#### 8:20a

**For the creation was subjected to futility,**

- For creation was changed so that the things that happen in it are futile,
- And God caused all things that he made/created to be frustrated.

**For:** Here this word introduces a reason Moo (on TW). or an explanation. Cranfield (page 413) and Schreiner (page 435).

**the creation was subjected to futility:** This clause is passive. Some languages must use an active clause. For example:

God subjected the creation to futility

**subjected to:** The word subjected refers to causing to be under the authority of someone or something. Here it indicates that God caused creation to be characterized by futility. Here are other ways to translate this word:

submitted to

placed under to rule of

make captive to

**futility:** This word refers to being of no use or purpose. BDAG (page 621). Here are other ways to translate this word:

frustration (NIV)

lose its purpose (GNT)

#### 8:20b

**not by its own will, but because of the One who subjected it,**

- not because it wanted to be that way but because of the one who made it that way,
- God himself caused them to be like that. They did not choose/want to be like that.

**not by its own will:** This phrase refers to creation as if it were a person who did not want to be subjected to futility. In some languages it is more natural to add “like someone” here. For example:

like someone not willing

In some languages it is more natural to repeat some of the words from 8:20a. For example:

like someone not willing to be subjected to it

**but because of the One who subjected it:** Here the words the One refer to God. See Moo (on TW). Morris (on TW) and Cranfield (page 414) also say it is God here.

He said that creation must be subject to futility. Here are other ways to translate these words:

but by the will of the one who subjected it (NIV)

but because God willed it to be so (GNT)

but for the purposes of him who imposed it (NJB)

### 8:20c in hope

- in the hope
- But there is this hope/expectation for creation:

**in hope:** The word hope means “the looking forward to something happening with some reason for confidence that it will indeed happen.” See BDAG (page 319–320). God knows that one day creation will no longer be subjected to futility. It is hope because it has not happened yet, but is awaiting the right time for God’s promise to be fulfilled.

The hope is explained in 8:21. For example:

there was this hope: (NCV)

This phrase is connected to “the creation was subjected to futility” (8:20a). In some languages some words must be repeated or added to make the connection clear. For example:

It was subjected like that in hope

It is frustrated now in hope

## Romans 8:21

### Section 8:18–30: God promises to us help today and glory later

In this section Paul said that the things that cause us suffering are only small compared to the glory that God will give us in the future, renewed world. The created world waits for God to reveal us, his adopted children, in our new bodies, because he will also renew the created world at that time. We and the created world groan waiting for that renewal. Paul then described what hope is.

The Holy Spirit helps us where we are weak. He also helps us to pray and intercedes for us. God causes all things to work for our good. He chose us to become like Jesus in word and deed, and become like him like a brother is like his brother. He chose us before the

creation of the world, called us, made us righteous, and has glorified us.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

We wait for God to give glory to us

Later we will be together with God in his glory

The Holy Spirit helps us today and God will glorify us in the future

### 8:21a that the creation itself will be set free from its bondage to decay

- that creation itself will also be freed/untied from being a slave to decay
- God will one day liberate/change all the things he made/created so that they will no longer rot/spoil like they always do now,

**that:** There are two ways to interpret the Greek word that the BSB translates as that:

1. It means that here. It introduces what the hope (8:20) is. (BSB, NIV, GNT, NJB, NASB, NRSV, ESV, GW, CEV, NET, NABRE, REB, NCV)
2. It means because here. It introduces the reason for the hope. For example:

because (RSV) (RSV, KJV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1), because that seems to fit the context best. As in Moo (on TW) and Schreiner (page 433).

**the creation itself will be set free from its bondage to decay:** This clause speaks of creation as if it were a person who is a slave. It indicates that all things of this creation corrupt or decay. It cannot produce things that last forever.

Some languages cannot use this figure of speech. If that is true in your language, translate without the figure of speech. For example:

all that was created will be-set-free in-the-future from the power of decay and death  
Kankanaey Back Translation on TW.

the creation itself will be changed so that the things of it will no longer corrupt/decay

**the creation itself will be set free:** This clause is passive. Some languages must translate with an active clause. For example:

God will set creation itself free

the creation itself, God will set it free

**the creation itself:** The word itself emphasizes the words the creation.

**will be set free:** The Greek has the word that means “also” here. For example:

also will be set free (NASB)

**set free:** Here these words refer to removing creation from being like a slave to corruption. Here are other ways to translate these words:

liberated (NIV)

freed (NJB)

**bondage:** The Greek word refers to being a slave to someone or something. A slave must do what the master says. Here the creation always follows the way of corruption and so all the things of this creation corrupt or decay. Here are other ways to translate this word:

slavery (NJB)

being tied

**decay:** This Greek word refers to what happens to things when they go bad, for example, meat spoils and wood rots. Here are other ways to translate this word:

corruption (ESV)

spoil

#### 8:21b

**and brought into the glorious freedom of the children of God.**

- and will enter into the freedom connected to the glory of God’s children.
- and they will have the glorious freedom of God’s/his children.

**and brought into:** The Greek word here is literally just into. It indicates that when God frees creation from slavery to corruption, it will also enter into the freedom that exists in the future glory of God’s adopted children. Creation will be free from corruption and be eternal. Here are other ways to translate this word:

and obtain (ESV)

and share in (NABRE)

**the glorious freedom:** The Greek words that the BSB translated as the glorious freedom is literally “the freedom of glory.” Here scholars understand the Greek grammar of the word “of” in a number of ways. A few scholars and many English versions think it means “described by” (as in the BSB). Other scholars think it means “belonging to” or “is associated with.” That would be the usual way to understand the use of the word “of” as in the ESV:

the freedom of the glory... (ESV)

## Romans 8:22

**Section 8:18–30: God promises to us help today and glory later**

In this section Paul said that the things that cause us suffering are only small compared to the glory that God will give us in the future, renewed world. The created world waits for God to reveal us, his adopted children, in our new bodies, because he will also renew the created world at that time. We and the created world groan waiting for that renewal. Paul then described what hope is.

The Holy Spirit helps us where we are weak. He also helps us to pray and intercedes for us. God causes all things to work for our good. He chose us to become like Jesus in word and deed, and become like him like a brother is like his brother. He chose us before the creation of the world, called us, made us righteous, and has glorified us.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

We wait for God to give glory to us

Later we will be together with God in his glory

The Holy Spirit helps us today and God will glorify us in the future



**8:22a****We know that the whole creation**

- For/And we<sup>(incl)</sup> know that all of creation
- We know that all the things that God made

The Greek of 8:22a begins with a word that is usually translated as “For.” Here this word continues the reason or explanation started in 8:20. Morris (on TW) says it continues the sequence of Paul’s logic. In some languages “and” would be better. In other languages, it may be more natural to omit this word and leave the connection with 8:21b implicit, as the BSB does.

**the whole creation:** Here the word whole refers to all the parts of creation as one group. Here is another way to translate this phrase:

all of creation (GNT)

**8:22b****has been groaning together in the pains of childbirth until the present time.**

- groans together and feels the pain of childbirth together even today.
- have been like someone groaning and having the pain of a woman bearing/birthing a child, and this/that continues today.

**has been groaning together in the pains of childbirth:** The Greek is more literally “groans-together and feels-the-pain-of-childbirth-together.” Here together refers to all the things of creation groaning and feeling this pain all at the same time. The Greek present tense indicates here that creation is groaning at the present time. For example:

the whole creation groans and suffers the pains of childbirth together (NASB)

all the parts/things of creation groan together and feel the pain of childbirth

This clause speaks of creation as if it were a person who is groaning and feeling pain. In some languages cannot use this figure of speech. If that is true in your language, translate without the figure of speech. For example:

is together like someone groaning and feeling the pain of childbirth

**groaning:** This word refers to the sound someone makes when in pain.

**until the present time:** This phrase indicates that the groaning and pain began in the past and continues until today. It does not imply that the groaning and pain stopped when Paul wrote this letter. The groaning and pain continues to today and will continue until the day when God will glorify believers. Your translation should not indicate or imply that the groaning and pain has stopped. For example:

and continues today

**Romans 8:23****Section 8:18–30: God promises to us help today and glory later**

In this section Paul said that the things that cause us suffering are only small compared to the glory that God will give us in the future, renewed world. The created world waits for God to reveal us, his adopted children, in our new bodies, because he will also renew the created world at that time. We and the created world groan waiting for that renewal. Paul then described what hope is.

The Holy Spirit helps us where we are weak. He also helps us to pray and intercedes for us. God causes all things to work for our good. He chose us to become like Jesus in word and deed, and become like him like a brother is like his brother. He chose us before the creation of the world, called us, made us righteous, and has glorified us.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

We wait for God to give glory to us

Later we will be together with God in his glory

The Holy Spirit helps us today and God will glorify us in the future

**8:23a****Not only that, but we ourselves,**

- And not only that, but we<sup>(incl)</sup> too, we
- And someone else is also like that. We ourselves
- And another group also groans. It is us,

**Not only that, but we ourselves:** The Greek is literally “and not only (so) but also ourselves.” These words emphasize the fact that believers also groan as we wait for the redemption of our bodies. In some languages the first part must have a verb. In some languages adding “also” in the last part is more natural. For example:

not only the creation groans, but we ourselves also

**Not only that:** Some languages add the words “the creation.” These words are clearly implied in the Greek. For example:

And not only the creation (ESV)

**we ourselves:** The word ourselves emphasizes the word we here. The Greek also has the word that means “also” here. For example:

also we ourselves (NASB)

#### 8:23b

**who have the firstfruits of the Spirit,**

- are the ones who have the first part of the harvest of the Spirit,
- we have the first part of the good things that the Holy Spirit will give to us,

**who have the firstfruits of the Spirit:** This clause describes all believers. It does not indicate that only some believers have the firstfruits of the Spirit. Some languages must translate with something other than who for the correct meaning. For example:

and we have the firstfruits of the Spirit

God gave to us the firstfruits of the Spirit

**the firstfruits of the Spirit:** The word firstfruits is often used to refer to a small portion of the first harvest of a crop. It was given as an offering to God as a way of thanking him for the whole harvest. But here it refers to something God has given believers. The Spirit is his pledge to us that we will receive the redemption of our bodies from the corruption of this world (8:23e). Here is another way to translate this phrase:

the Spirit as a pledge

**the Spirit:** This refers to the Holy Spirit.

#### 8:23c

**groan inwardly**

- and we too, we groan in our hearts/insides
- and indeed we also groan inside our own inner beings

**groan inwardly:** The Greek is more literally “we ourselves also groan within ourselves.” It indicates that

we groan in our hearts, not out loud. The Greek word translated “we” is repeated for emphasis. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

even we ourselves groan within ourselves (NASB)

we ourselves also groan in our hearts/insides

In some languages it is not natural to repeat “we ourselves also” here. For example:

groan inside ourselves (NJB)

#### 8:23d

**as we wait eagerly for our adoption as sons,**

- while we wait with eager desire for when God will adopt us as his children,
- while we wait wanting very much for the time when the Spirit will finalize our adoption as God’s children.

**as we wait eagerly for our adoption as sons:** Here the first as indicates that waiting eagerly for our adoption as sons occurs at the same time as groaning inwardly (8:23c). Here are other ways to translate these words:

at the same time that we wait eagerly for adoption as sons

while we wait eagerly for adoption as sons

**we wait eagerly:** This phrase indicates that believers wait interested in our future adoption and wanting it to happen.

The same Greek word occurs in 8:19. See how you translated “waits in eager expectation” in 8:19.

**our adoption as sons:** The BSB adds the words as sons. The word adoption refers to taking someone who is not your child and making them legally your child. See how you translated this phrase in 8:15, where the BSB translates it as “sonship.”

This is a future event, unlike in 8:15. Here this is the final part of becoming God adopted children, as 8:23e explains. In some languages that will need to be made clear to avoid confusion. For example:

the final step of adoption as his/God’s children

the last part of God adopting us as his children

### 8:23e the redemption of our bodies.

- namely, when God will redeem our bodies.
- This/That final step of adoption is the Spirit changing our bodies from corruptible to incorruptible.

**the redemption of our bodies:** This explains what Paul meant here by “adoption as sons.” In some languages connecting words must be used to clearly indicate that connection. For example:

that is, the redemption of our bodies

it is this: the redemption of our bodies

**redemption:** A slave was a person who was owned by someone else. The word redemption refers to the act of purchasing a slave in order to set him or her free. Here Christ’s death and resurrection paid the price so that our own corruptible bodies will be set free from corruption and be changed into incorruptible and glorified bodies. Here are other ways to translate this word:

to be set free (NJB)

to be released from sin and suffering (NLT)

redeemed from corruption

See how you translated this word in 3:24.

## Romans 8:24

### Section 8:18–30: God promises to us help today and glory later

In this section Paul said that the things that cause us suffering are only small compared to the glory that God will give us in the future, renewed world. The created world waits for God to reveal us, his adopted children, in our new bodies, because he will also renew the created world at that time. We and the created world groan waiting for that renewal. Paul then described what hope is.

The Holy Spirit helps us where we are weak. He also helps us to pray and intercedes for us. God causes all things to work for our good. He chose us to become like Jesus in word and deed, and become like him like a brother is like his brother. He chose us before the creation of the world, called us, made us righteous, and has glorified us.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

We wait for God to give glory to us

Later we will be together with God in his glory

The Holy Spirit helps us today and God will glorify us in the future

### 8:24a For in this hope we were saved;

- ¶ For we were saved with a hope that came with it.
- ¶ For God saved us, and we have had hope ever since.

**For:** Here this word introduces an explanation of 8:23.

**in this hope:** The word in indicates that the salvation we are waiting for includes the redemption of our bodies. We hope in that redemption and that hope is based on God’s promises that now belong to the new believer. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

with an accompanying hope

We were given this hope when we were saved (NLT)

this is what we have been hoping for since the time we were saved  
Kankanaey Back Translation on TW.

**we were saved:** This clause is passive. Some languages must use an active clause. For example:

God saved us

**saved:** This word refers to being rescued from something harmful or dangerous. Here it refers to God rescuing people from going to hell for their sins. See how you translated this word in 5:10.

### General Comment on 8:24a

In some languages putting “in this hope” first would make the hope the basis for being saved, or another possibly wrong meaning. If that is true in your language, put that phrase in its usual place. For example:

For we were saved in/with hope

### 8:24b but hope that is seen is no hope at all.

- But hope, once one/someone sees/has the thing hoped for, has ended.
- If someone has already received what he was expecting, then he no longer needs to wait for it.

**but:** The Greek word here often introduces something that contrasts with 8:24a, as does the word but here. The word can also introduce something new. For example:

Now (ESV)

Some languages can omit this word for the correct connection.

**hope that is seen is no hope at all:** This clause indicates that if we already have something we hoped for, then we are no longer hoping for it. In many languages a literal translation would not have the correct meaning. If that is true in your language, translate the correct meaning. For example:

if it had already happened then no longer would we be waiting for it then  
Otomi Back Translation on TW.

if we say we are hoping, that means we have not yet received what we are hoping for  
Uma Back Translation on TW.

whoever, from his hoping has seen and received it, he holds it so it is not a thing for hope  
Yongkom Back Translation, by this author, unpublished manuscript, Papua New Guinea.

If someone is waiting for anything, and has taken it already, he will not wait for it again/more/  
further  
Nalik Back Translation, draft, Papua New Guinea.

**that is seen:** Here this word indicates that the hope is fulfilled. Some languages must use a different word to clearly indicate that meaning here. See the above examples.

#### 8:24c

#### Who hopes for what he can already see?

- If a person has already received something, why should he continue to wait for it?
- Nobody waits for what he has already received.

The Greek of 8:24c begins with the Greek word that is usually translated as “for.” Here this word introduces

something that supports what Paul said in 8:24b. Some languages can omit this word for the correct connection, as the BSB does.

**Who hopes for what he can already see?:** This is a rhetorical question. It emphasizes that no one hopes for what he already sees or has. Translate this clause with that meaning. Here are some ways:

- As a rhetorical question. For example:

Who hopes for what they already have? (NIV11)

Who hopes for something that he holds? No way!  
Yongkom Back Translation, by this author, unpublished manuscript, Papua New Guinea.

- As a statement. For example:

Certainly no one hopes for something he already sees/has

People do not hope for something they already have (NCV)

no one hopes for something he has already received  
Uma Back Translation on TW.

## Romans 8:25

### Section 8:18–30: God promises to us help today and glory later

In this section Paul said that the things that cause us suffering are only small compared to the glory that God will give us in the future, renewed world. The created world waits for God to reveal us, his adopted children, in our new bodies, because he will also renew the created world at that time. We and the created world groan waiting for that renewal. Paul then described what hope is.

The Holy Spirit helps us where we are weak. He also helps us to pray and intercedes for us. God causes all things to work for our good. He chose us to become like Jesus in word and deed, and become like him like a brother is like his brother. He chose us before the creation of the world, called us, made us righteous, and has glorified us.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

We wait for God to give glory to us

Later we will be together with God in his glory

The Holy Spirit helps us today and God will glorify us in the future

### 8:25a

**But if we hope for what we do not yet see,**

- But if we hope for things we do not see/have,
- And if we are waiting for something we have not already received,

**But:** This word introduces having hope, which contrasts to something that is not hope in 8:24b.

**if we hope for what we do not yet see:** Here the word if introduces a situation that Paul wanted the readers to evaluate in their own lives. You should translate the if literally.

**what we do not yet see:** Here the words do not yet see indicates that the hope is not yet fulfilled. Translate the word see as you did in 8:24b and c (“is seen” and “see”).

### 8:25b

**we wait for it patiently.**

- we wait for those things with endurance.
- we persevere as we wait for God to give it to us.

**patiently:** This Greek word means “the capacity to continue to believe or do as planned in the midst of opposition or difficulty.” See BDAG (page 1039). Here are other ways to translate this word:

endurance (NABRE)

persevering confidence (NJB)

## Romans 8:26

**Section 8:18–30: God promises to us help today and glory later**

In this section Paul said that the things that cause us suffering are only small compared to the glory that God will give us in the future, renewed world. The created world waits for God to reveal us, his adopted children, in our new bodies, because he will also renew the created world at that time. We and the created world groan waiting for that renewal. Paul then described what hope is.

The Holy Spirit helps us where we are weak. He also helps us to pray and intercedes for us. God causes all things to work for our good. He chose us to become like Jesus in word and deed, and become like him like

a brother is like his brother. He chose us before the creation of the world, called us, made us righteous, and has glorified us.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

We wait for God to give glory to us

Later we will be together with God in his glory

The Holy Spirit helps us today and God will glorify us in the future

### 8:26a

**In the same way, the Spirit helps us in our weakness.**

- ¶ In the same way, the Spirit also helps/aids us<sup>(incl)</sup> when we are weak,
- ¶ Similarly, the Holy Spirit also helps/assists us when we do not stand strong in our faith/life.

**In the same way:** It is not clear what this phrase connects to. Some scholars connect it to our waiting with patience/endurance in 8:25, for example, Jewett (page 521). Some connect it to our hope in 8:24–25, for example, Moo (on TW). Some connect it to our groaning in 8:23, for example, Cranfield (page 420–421). and some connect it to the Spirit testifying in 8:16, for example, Kruse (page 351). You should translate this word without saying what it connects to. Here is another way to translate this:

Likewise (ESV)

There is another Greek word after this word, that in this case probably means “also.” For example:

In the same way, the Spirit too (NABRE)

**the Spirit:** This refers to the Holy Spirit here. In some languages it would be more clear to translate this phrase as you usually translate the phrase “the Holy Spirit.”

**helps:** This word refers to assisting in a task. Here is another way to translate this word:

aids

**in our weakness:** This refers to a lack of strength in our thoughts, deeds, and inner beings regarding our

life of faith in Jesus. It does not refer to physical weakness. For example:

when our (incl) trusting in God is weakYakan Back Translation on TW.

Some languages must use a word other than weakness here. For example:

when we do not stand strong

when we are inadequate

### 8:26b

**For we do not know how we ought to pray,**

- because we do not know what things we should pray as is fitting/proper for us to pray for,
- For we do not know like we should what to pray to God.

**For:** This word here introduces a reasonLanski (page 545) and possibly Nicoll (page 651). or an explanation.Morris (on TW) and Alford (page 396) say it introduces an example, but this seems less likely. Translate this connection with either of those meanings. For example:

because (GW)

**how we ought to pray:** This phrase refers to what things we should pray. For example, I may be experiencing persecution, and the Holy Spirit takes what I pray in that regard and intercedes for me. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

the things we should pray for

the things we should pray

**how we ought:** The Greek is more literally “as is necessary” or “as is fitting/proper.” We do not know every need and we sometimes do not know what best to pray for the needs we know of. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

properly (NJB)

as we should (NASB)

### 8:26c

**but the Spirit Himself intercedes for us**

- but the Spirit himself speaks to God about our prayers
- But the Holy Spirit talks to God on our behalf regarding what we pray for

**intercedes for us:** The word intercedes refers to speaking to someone on behalf of someone else. Here the Holy Spirit speaks to God on our behalf when we pray. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

speaks to God on our behalf

speaks-with God for usKankanaey Back Translation on TW.

### 8:26d

**with groans too deep for words.**

- with groans that words cannot express/explain the meaning of them.
- with groans of deep/strong feelings that we<sup>(incl)</sup> cannot say/speak in words.

**groans too deep for words:** This phrase indicates that the groans cannot be expressed or translated into words. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

groans that words cannot express (NIV)

deep feelings that words cannot explain (NCV)

crying-out that is beyond the ability of human languageUma Back Translation on TW.

**groans:** This word usually refers to low-pitched, wordless sound that indicates suffering, pain, or grief. The Holy Spirit feels our suffering, pain, and grief, and then speaks to God with those feelings. See the above examples.

## Romans 8:27

**Section 8:18–30: God promises to us help today and glory later**

In this section Paul said that the things that cause us suffering are only small compared to the glory that God will give us in the future, renewed world. The created world waits for God to reveal us, his adopted children, in our new bodies, because he will also renew the created world at that time. We and the created world groan waiting for that renewal. Paul then described what hope is.

The Holy Spirit helps us where we are weak. He also helps us to pray and intercedes for us. God causes all things to work for our good. He chose us to become like Jesus in word and deed, and become like him like a brother is like his brother. He chose us before the creation of the world, called us, made us righteous, and has glorified us.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

We wait for God to give glory to us

Later we will be together with God in his glory

The Holy Spirit helps us today and God will glorify us in the future

### 8:27a

#### **And He who searches our hearts**

- And the one who examines every inside of people
- God knows/sees everything in the inner-being of people and

**He who searches our hearts:** This refers to God. In some languages this will not be clear. If that is true in your language, you may want to explain in the text. For example:

God, who searches our hearts

This change makes who searches our hearts describe God rather than define to whom the word he refers. Some languages must avoid who in this case for the correct meaning. For example:

God searches our hearts and

**searches:** Here this word indicates that God carefully examines hearts. It does not refer to looking for something that is lost. Here are other ways to translate this word:

sees into (GNT)

knows (NLT)

**hearts:** This refers to generally to the hearts of all people. For example:

all hearts (NLT)

The word hearts refers here to the inner being of people, which includes the mind, the emotions, and the will. Use your usual word for that meaning. For example:

insides/liver

mind and will

See how you translated this word in 1:21 or 6:17.

### 8:27b

#### **knows the mind of the Spirit,**

- knows the thinking of the Spirit,
- also knows what the Holy Spirit is thinking,

**mind:** The Greek word here is translated as “the mind” in 8:6 and 8:7. Here it probably refers to the mind generally, as many English versions and scholars translate. God knows what the Holy Spirit is thinking when he groans on our behalf.

### 8:27c

#### **because the Spirit intercedes for the saints**

- because the Spirit speaks to God for his holy people
- for the Holy Spirit talks to God on behalf of the people he/God has made holy

**saints:** The Greek word can mean “holy people,” “people dedicated/consecrated to God,” or “people whom God has made holy.” Here it probably implies all of these meanings. In the New Testament, this word refers to all Christians, not to any special group of Christians. See how you translated this word in 1:7.

### 8:27d

#### **according to the will of God.**

- according to what God wants to happen.
- as God desires him to.

**the will of God:** Here the word will refers to what God wants to happen. See how you translated this word in 2:18.

## **Romans 8:28**

### **Section 8:18–30: God promises to us help today and glory later**

In this section Paul said that the things that cause us suffering are only small compared to the glory that God will give us in the future, renewed world. The created world waits for God to reveal us, his adopted children, in our new bodies, because he will also renew the created world at that time. We and the created world groan waiting for that renewal. Paul then described what hope is.

The Holy Spirit helps us where we are weak. He also helps us to pray and intercedes for us. God causes all things to work for our good. He chose us to become like Jesus in word and deed, and become like him like a brother is like his brother. He chose us before the creation of the world, called us, made us righteous, and has glorified us.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

We wait for God to give glory to us

Later we will be together with God in his glory

The Holy Spirit helps us today and God will glorify us in the future

### 8:28a

#### And we know that

- ¶ And we<sup>(incl)</sup> know this:

### 8:28b

#### God works all things together for the good of those who love Him,

- all things work to benefit those who love God,
- all of the things that happen to the people who love God bring good to them.

### 8:28a–b

**God works all things:** There are several ways to interpret who or what is working here. Here are the two main ones:

1. It is all things that work here. (NRSV, ESV, NABRE, KJV, GW, NET)
2. It is God who works here. For example:

in all things God works (NIV) (BSB, RSV, NIV, GNT, NJB, CEV, NCV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). But if the major language version follows interpretation (2), you may want to follow that.

**for the good of those who love Him:** Here the word for introduces who benefits from the good. For example:

...the good of those who love him (NIV)

**for the good:** This phrase indicates that all things that happen in a believer's life, whether good or bad, ultimately result in benefit for him or her. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

to their good (NJB)

**those who love Him:** This phrase refers to all believers. Your translation should indicate or imply that meaning.

### 8:28c

#### who are called according to His purpose.

- and they are called according to his plan for them.
- He chose/appointed those people, because he planned it that way.

**who are called according to His purpose:** Here the word who introduces who benefits from the good. This group is all believers, like “those who love Him” in 8:28b. To make it clear this is the same group as in 8:28b, some languages must introduce it differently. For example:

namely, those who are called according to his purpose

I refer to those who are called according to his purpose

those who love him, those who have been called in accordance with his purpose (NJB)

and he called them according to his purpose

**are called:** Here the word called means “chosen to be given a special benefit or purpose.” God designated people in Rome to believe in Jesus and become his people. His call was the means by which he chose them.

See how you translated this word in 1:6.

**according to His purpose:** The word purpose refers to what the goal or expected result is for God calling people to believe in Jesus. There are many aspects or parts to that purpose. Two parts of that purpose are in 8:30: to justify and to glorify believers. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

according to his plan (GW)

because that was his plan (NCV)

**His purpose:** The BSB and many English versions add the word His here, because it is God's plan to call them.



## Romans 8:29

### Section 8:18–30: God promises to us help today and glory later

In this section Paul said that the things that cause us suffering are only small compared to the glory that God will give us in the future, renewed world. The created world waits for God to reveal us, his adopted children, in our new bodies, because he will also renew the created world at that time. We and the created world groan waiting for that renewal. Paul then described what hope is.

The Holy Spirit helps us where we are weak. He also helps us to pray and intercedes for us. God causes all things to work for our good. He chose us to become like Jesus in word and deed, and become like him like a brother is like his brother. He chose us before the creation of the world, called us, made us righteous, and has glorified us.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

We wait for God to give glory to us

Later we will be together with God in his glory

The Holy Spirit helps us today and God will glorify us in the future

#### 8:29a

##### For those God foreknew,

- For the people whom he knew before they existed
- For God knew his people ahead of time, and

**For:** The Greek is more literally “because.” It introduces a reason or explanation for what was said in 8:28. But the BSB starts a new sentence here, so “because” would not have the correct meaning in English. The word “because,” when it starts a sentence in English, indicates that the result clause comes after the reason clause, not before it. So it and many English versions use For here.

**those God foreknew:** There are two ways to interpret the Greek word that the BSB translates as foreknew:

1. It means know before a certain time here. God knew us before the creation of the world (Ephesians 1:4). The word implies a complete knowledge rather than just knowing about someone. For example:

knew his people in advance (NLT) (BSB, RSV, NIV, NASB, KJV, NLT, GW, ESV, NABRE, NET, REB, CEV)

1. It means choose before a certain time here. For example:

Those whom God had already chosen (GNT) (GNT)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1), because many scholars follow it as well. For example, Moo, Longenecker, Cranfield, Dunn, Schreiner, and Jewett. Here are other ways to translate this clause according to interpretation (1):

those whom God knew before ever they were (REB)

God knew them before he made the world (NCV)

#### 8:29b

##### He also predestined to be conformed to the image of His Son,

- he also planned at that time that they would be like his Son,
- he also planned then that he would cause them to be like his Son.

**predestined:** This word means “determine ahead of time.” Before the creation of the world God made a plan that his people would become like his Son. Here are other ways to translate this word:

determined beforehand

appointed (GW)

**to be conformed:** The Greek word here refers to being similar in form or nature. BDAG (page 958) and Louw and Nida (on TW). We do not start this life being similar to Jesus, so here this word implies that God changes us so that we are like his Son. Therefore the BSB and many English versions use the word conformed. Here are other ways to translate this Greek word:

to be like (NCV)

to share (REB)

**the image of His Son:** Here the word image indicates that God will make us like Jesus in many ways. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

the likeness of his Son (NIV)

become like his Son (GNT)

**His Son:** See how you translated this phrase at 1:3.

**8:29c**

**so that He would be the firstborn among many brothers.**

- so that he will be the firstborn/eldest of his many brothers and sisters.
- This will result in his Son becoming the oldest/eldest brother to many younger siblings in God's family.

**He would be:** Here the Greek word is literally "to be." Here it indicates that being the firstborn among many brothers will happen in the future, because God has not yet given glorified bodies to believers. For example:

the Son would be (GNT)

**the firstborn among many brothers:** This phrase indicates that Jesus is like his brothers, that is, all believers, but that he is special, like a firstborn Jew was special. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

the eldest among a large family of brothers (REB)

the praiseworthy oldest-sibling of all of us who are siblinged-together who have been adopted by GodTagbanwa Back Translation on TW.

**firstborn:** In Hebrew and Greek culture (and probably other cultures of that time and area), the firstborn was given special privileges. In some languages groups people treat the firstborn like all the other siblings. If that is true in your language, you may want to indicate that the firstborn is special. For example:

special/leader firstborn

the one who is prominent before all those believers who are brothers with himOtomi Back Translation on TW.

## Romans 8:30

### Section 8:18–30: God promises to us help today and glory later

In this section Paul said that the things that cause us suffering are only small compared to the glory that God will give us in the future, renewed world. The created world waits for God to reveal us, his adopted children, in our new bodies, because he will also renew the created world at that time. We and the created world groan waiting for that renewal. Paul then described what hope is.

The Holy Spirit helps us where we are weak. He also helps us to pray and intercedes for us. God causes all things to work for our good. He chose us to become like Jesus in word and deed, and become like him like a brother is like his brother. He chose us before the creation of the world, called us, made us righteous, and has glorified us.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

We wait for God to give glory to us

Later we will be together with God in his glory

The Holy Spirit helps us today and God will glorify us in the future

**8:30a**

**And those He predestined, He also called;**

- And they whom he chose long ago, he also called them and they accepted,
- Also/Furthermore, he/God decided ahead of time that these people would be his people, and he chose/appointed them to become his people.

**those He predestined, He also called:** This clause refers to all believers. The word those is first in the clause because that is what Paul wanted to talk about. Some languages have a more strict word order. For example:

he also called those whom he predestined

some/these people, he predestined them and he also called them

**called:** See how you translated this word in 8:28.

**8:30b**

**those He called, He also justified;**

- and these people whom he called, he also judged that they are right,
- And he not only called these people, but he declared them to be righteous in his sight.

**those He called:** This refers to the same group as the people in 8:30a. This should be clear in your translation.

**justified:** Here this word means “be found in the right, be free of charges.”BDAG, sense 2.β. Here are other ways to translate this word:

declared right

judged that they are now righteous

See how you translated justified in 3:24 or 5:9.

### 8:30c

**those He justified, He also glorified.**

- and these people whom he said are now right with him, he also gave glory to them.
- And he not only declared these people to be righteous in his sight, but he caused them to have glory/greatness/honor.

**glorified:** This word refers to the greatness/splendor and blessings of God that he will give to us believers. Here it implies God giving glorified bodies to us as a part of this glorification. See how you translated this word in 8:17.

The Greek word here has the form that usually indicates past tense. This may be to indicate that:

1. the future glorification is certain, Morris (page 333) and Schreiner (page 454).
2. the process of glorification has already begun and will finish when we stand before God in heaven. Jewett (page 530).

You should translate this word with your usual way to indicate past tense.

## Romans 8:31

**Section 8:31–39: Nothing can separate us from God’s love**

In this section, Paul asked a number of rhetorical questions. In asking them he expected the believers in Rome to agree with him in these ways: God is for us and no one has greater power than him when they stand against us. God has made us right with him, so no one can accuse us of wrongdoing that God has not already forgiven. Jesus died for our sins and rose again, so no one can say we are worthy of God

punishing us. Nothing of this earth or of the demons and spirits can separate us from God’s love. With God’s power we can overcome all those things.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

God’s love for us because of Jesus Christ

The love of God will not abandon/leave us

### 8:31a

**What then shall we say in response to these things?**

- ¶ Therefore, what will we<sup>(incl)</sup> say about all those things about/of God?
- ¶ So, concerning all those things I have said to you<sup>(plur)</sup>, let us say this:

**What then shall we say in response to these things?:** The word then introduces what Paul concluded from what he said in 8:18–30, or possibly chapters 6–8, or even the whole letter to this point. See Dunn (page 499) and Morris (pages 334–335). The question “What shall we say?” also introduces what Paul concluded. In some languages it is more natural to have the word then first. For example:

Therefore, what shall we say to these things?

**What...shall we say in response to these things?:**

This is a rhetorical question. It draws attention to what Paul said next. Paul did not expect the readers to answer this question. Here are other ways to translate this question:

How shall we respond to these/those things?

what will we say about those things that God did?

In some languages the correct meaning is indicated by using a statement instead of a question. For example:

Let us think about what to say about those things.

Here is something we can say about those things:

**shall we say:** The Greek tense is the future tense (“will we say”). Here it indicates what someone might say. See the examples above.

**these things:** Some scholars see this phrase referring to 5:1–8:30, for example, Moo (page 539), Longenecker (page 751), and Jewett (page 535). and some see it

referring to all of the letter of Romans to this point. for example, Cranfield (page 435) and Dunn (page 499). Translate in a way that allows for this phrase to include many verses back. For example:

all those things

### 8:31b

#### **If God is for us, who can be against us?**

- If God does things for our benefit, can anyone oppose us and stop God from doing those things?
- God is on our side, so nobody has the power to overcome us.

**If God is for us:** Here the word If introduces a situation that is true. If this first part is true, that supports the second part (“who can be against us?”).

In some languages, using an if-clause would have a different meaning. If that is true in your language, translate the correct meaning. For example:

God is for us, so

you would agree that God is for us, so

**God is for us:** The BSB and many English versions add the word is here for natural English.

**who can be against us:** This is a rhetorical question. It emphasizes that no one can be against us, in the sense of no one can stop God from being for us or defeat God’s efforts for us. Translate this clause with that meaning. Here are some ways:

- As a rhetorical question. For example:

who can ever be against us? (NLT)

who will come against us and gain victory over us?  
Yongkom Back Translation, by this author, unpublished manuscript, Papua New Guinea.

- As a statement. For example:

no one can defeat us (NCV)

it does not matter who opposes us

**can be:** There is no verb in the Greek. The BSB and some English versions add the words can be. Some

English versions add the same word they added in “if God...for us.” For example:

is (RSV)

Here the word can indicates ability. People or Satan may stand against us, but no one can block God’s plan for us.

## **Romans 8:32**

### **Section 8:31–39: Nothing can separate us from God’s love**

In this section, Paul asked a number of rhetorical questions. In asking them he expected the believers in Rome to agree with him in these ways: God is for us and no one has greater power than him when they stand against us. God has made us right with him, so no one can accuse us of wrongdoing that God has not already forgiven. Jesus died for our sins and rose again, so no one can say we are worthy of God punishing us. Nothing of this earth or of the demons and spirits can separate us from God’s love. With God’s power we can overcome all those things.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

God’s love for us because of Jesus Christ

The love of God will not abandon/leave us

### **8:32a**

#### **He who did not spare His own Son**

- Indeed, he did not protect his own Son from harm
- He even allowed his own Son to suffer,

**He who did not spare His own Son:** After the word who in the Greek is the word that means “indeed” or “even” here. It emphasizes His own Son in the Greek. For example:

he did not spare even his own Son (NLT)

who, indeed, did not spare his own Son

**He who:** The Greek is just who. It refers to God (8:31b). The English versions add He for natural English. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

It is he who did not spare his own Son...

He did not spare his own Son but gave him up for us all, so how will he not also with him graciously give us all things?

**did not spare:** The word spare refers to preventing harm or trouble coming to someone. Here this phrase indicates that God allowed Jesus to suffer and die. He did not protect him from that suffering and death. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

did not hold back from harm

did not protect

**His own Son:** This phrase is emphasized in the Greek. If possible, emphasize this phrase in your language.

See how you translated this phrase at 8:3.

#### 8:32b

**but gave Him up for us all,**

- but handed him over so that all of us believers would benefit,
- and he gave him to those who would kill him for the sake of us all.

**but:** This indicates contrast to “spare” in 8:32a. But some languages will not see contrast here to “not spare” here.

**gave Him up:** The Greek word that the BSB translates as gave...up refers to putting someone under the control of something or someone else. Here it indicates that God put Jesus under the control of men who then killed him. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

delivered Him over (NASB)

handed him over to death (GW)

See how you translated the similar phrases in 1:24 (“gave...over”) or 4:25 (“delivered up”).

**for us all:** Here the word for means “to benefit.” For example:

for the sake of all of us (NJB)

#### 8:32c

**how will He not also, along with Him, freely give us all things?**

- so will he also gift/give to us all things as he gave his Son to us? Surely/True!

- So he will certainly give to us all things as gifts, including his Son.

**how will He not also, along with Him, freely give us all things?:** This is a rhetorical question. It emphasizes that God will also graciously give all things, including Jesus, to us. Translate this clause with that meaning. Here are some ways:

- As a rhetorical question. For example:

how will he not also give us everything else along with him? (NABRE)

is it even possible that he will not freely give to us all things together with his Son?

- As a statement. For example:

So he will also give us everything along with him. (GW)

It is certain that he will also freely gift us with all things, including his Son.

**along with Him:** This phrase goes with “all things,” not “he.” It indicates that God gives Jesus to us as well as giving all things to us.

**freely give:** The Greek word here refers to giving generously without obligating the other person to give in return. Here are other ways to translate this Greek word:

graciously give (ESV)

give as giftsYongkom Back Translation, by this author, unpublished manuscript, Papua New Guinea.

**all things:** In some languages this phrase may imply both good and bad things. If that is true in your language, indicate only good things. For example:

all good things

## Romans 8:33

**Section 8:31–39: Nothing can separate us from God’s love**

In this section, Paul asked a number of rhetorical questions. In asking them he expected the believers in Rome to agree with him in these ways: God is for us and no one has greater power than him when

they stand against us. God has made us right with him, so no one can accuse us of wrongdoing that God has not already forgiven. Jesus died for our sins and rose again, so no one can say we are worthy of God punishing us. Nothing of this earth or of the demons and spirits can separate us from God's love. With God's power we can overcome all those things.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

God's love for us because of Jesus Christ

The love of God will not abandon/leave us

### 8:33a

#### Who will bring any charge against God's elect?

- Who will accuse God's chosen people of breaking his laws?
- At the final judgment, will someone blame us, <sup>(incl)</sup> the people whom God chose, of doing wrong? No.

**Who will bring any charge against God's elect?:** This is a rhetorical question. It emphasizes that no one will be able to accuse God's elect of wrongdoing. The Greek is in the future tense. It implies that at no time will anyone be able to stand before God as judge and accuse believers of wrongdoing. See Lenski (page 567), Kruse (page 361), or Stott (page 255). Translate this clause with that meaning. Here are some ways:

- As a rhetorical question. For example:

Who will accuse those whom God has chosen?  
(GW)

Who can accuse the people God has chosen?  
(NCV)

- As a statement. For example:

No one will bring any charge against those whom God has chosen.

No one can bring any charge against the people God has chosen!

**bring any charge against:** This phrase refers to accusing someone of wrongdoing before a judge. See the examples above.

**God's elect:** The word elect refers to people whom someone has chosen. God chose people to be his children. They are the believers. See the examples above.

### 8:33b

#### It is God who justifies.

- God is the justifier of them!
- For God himself says that we are right/innocent in his sight.
- For God declares us not guilty.

**It is God who justifies:** The Greek is literally "God (is) the one justifying." As a response to the rhetorical question of 8:33a, it indicates that God has forgiven believers and declared them right with him and not guilty regarding all their sins. Translate with that meaning. For example:

God is the one who justifies (NASB)

No one—for God himself has given us right standing with himself (NLT)

Because God is the one who counts us as righteous. Kankanaey Back Translation on TW.

**justifies:** Here this word indicates that God decides that a person is not guilty of any wrongdoing and is in a right relationship with him. Here are other ways to translate this word:

declares righteous/innocent

gives the verdict of not guilty to us

See how you translated this word in 2:13 or 8:30.

## Romans 8:34

### Section 8:31–39: Nothing can separate us from God's love

In this section, Paul asked a number of rhetorical questions. In asking them he expected the believers in Rome to agree with him in these ways: God is for us and no one has greater power than him when they stand against us. God has made us right with him, so no one can accuse us of wrongdoing that God has not already forgiven. Jesus died for our sins and rose again, so no one can say we are worthy of God punishing us. Nothing of this earth or of the demons and spirits can separate us from God's love. With God's power we can overcome all those things.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

God's love for us because of Jesus Christ

The love of God will not abandon/leave us

### 8:34a

#### Who is there to condemn us?

- Who is the person who will judge them as guilty?
- No one will be able to say that God must punish us<sup>(incl)</sup>.

**Who is there to condemn us?:** This is a rhetorical question. It emphasizes that no one will be able to condemn God's elect, that is, declare them guilty of wrongdoing and saying how they should be punished. Translate this clause with that meaning. Here are some ways:

- As a rhetorical question. For example:

Who will condemn them? (GW)

Who can say God's people are guilty? (NCV)

- As a statement. For example:

No one will condemn them.

No one can say his people are guilty of sin!

**to condemn us:** The Greek word here is in the future tense, again referring to any time in our future. See the examples above.

**condemn:** For the meaning of this word, see the note on "condemned" in 8:3.

### 8:34b-e

**For Christ Jesus, who died, and more than that was raised to life, is at the right hand of God—and He is interceding for us:** There are two ways to interpret how to punctuate this verse:

1. It is a statement, as in the BSB. (BSB, NIV, GNT, NASB, KJV, ESV, NABRE, NLT, GW, CEV, NET, REB, NCV)
2. It is a question. For example:

Is it Christ Jesus, who died, yes, who was raised from the dead, who is at the right hand of God, who indeed intercedes for us? (RSV) (RSV, NJB)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1), because it parallels the question and answer in 8:33a-b.

### 8:34b

#### For Christ Jesus, who died,

- No one. The Christ/Messiah Jesus is the person who died,
- Jesus, the one/person whom God appointed to save/rescue people, died.

**Christ Jesus, who died:** As an answer to the rhetorical question of 8:34a, this clause implies that Jesus will not condemn us. For example:

No one. Christ Jesus who died... (NIV11)

**Christ Jesus:** There is a textual issue here:

1. The text is Christ Jesus, as in the BSB. (BSB, RSV, NIV, GNT, NJB, NASB, NABRE, NLT, ESV)
2. The text is Christ. For example:

Christ (CEV) (KJV, NLT, GW, CEV, NET, REB)

It is recommended that you follow option (1), because the UBS5 supports it, although they say they had difficulty in deciding. If the major language version follows option (2), you may want to follow that.

The order of the words Christ Jesus emphasizes that Jesus is the Christ/Messiah. However, in some languages the order Christ Jesus is not natural. See how you translated this phrase in 1:1 or 8:1.

### 8:34c

#### and more than that was raised to life,

- and not only that, was raised to life again,
- And another thing is that God caused him to leave the spirits of dead people and be alive again,

**and more than that:** These words indicate that Paul had more to say about Jesus here. Jesus' resurrection is also an important part of his work as Savior. These words imply that Jesus' resurrection is more important than his death. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

yes and more, (NJB)

but he was also raised (NCV)

He did not do that only, but Nalik Back Translation, draft, Papua New Guinea.

and beyond that Yongkom Back Translation, by this author, unpublished manuscript, Papua New Guinea.

and what is more is that

**was raised to life:** This clause is passive. Some languages must use an active clause. For example:

whom God raised

In some languages the words “from the dead” must be added to make the meaning clear. For example:

who was raised from the dead (NJB)

whom God raised from death

See how you translated the words was raised in 6:4.

#### **8:34d is at the right hand of God—**

- and is/sits on God’s right side,
- and he is also at the place of greatest honor to the right of God,

**is at the right hand of God:** The Greek has the word that can mean “and” or “also” here. For example:

and is at God’s right hand (NJB)

who also is at the right hand of God (NABRE)

**at the right hand:** To sit at the right hand of a ruler is a figure of speech that indicates that the ruler gave the place of greatest honor to that person.

If the words at the right hand do not imply highest honor under the leader in your culture, you may want to:

- Include some implied information. For example:

in the place of honor at the right hand

in the position of highest honor at the right side

- Include a footnote. For example:

To be at God’s right hand is the position of highest honor under God.

#### **8:34e and He is interceding for us.**

- and is speaking to God for our benefit.
- and he is also talking to God on our behalf.

**and He:** The Greek word that the BSB translates as and is often translated as “also.” Here it introduces the last thing that Paul wanted to add to the fact that Jesus died (for us). For example:

and who (NJB)

and is also (NIV)

**is interceding:** The word interceding refers to speaking to someone on behalf of someone else. Here Jesus speaks to God on our behalf. See how you translated this word in 8:26.

### **Romans 8:35**

#### **Section 8:31–39: Nothing can separate us from God’s love**

In this section, Paul asked a number of rhetorical questions. In asking them he expected the believers in Rome to agree with him in these ways: God is for us and no one has greater power than him when they stand against us. God has made us right with him, so no one can accuse us of wrongdoing that God has not already forgiven. Jesus died for our sins and rose again, so no one can say we are worthy of God punishing us. Nothing of this earth or of the demons and spirits can separate us from God’s love. With God’s power we can overcome all those things.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

God’s love for us because of Jesus Christ

The love of God will not abandon/leave us

#### **8:35a Who shall separate us from the love of Christ?**

- ¶ Who will separate/isolate us<sup>(incl)</sup> from Christ and his love for us? No one!
- ¶ No person or thing can come between us and Christ and make him stop loving us.

**Who shall separate us from the love of Christ?:** This is a rhetorical question. It emphasizes that no one or no situation will be able to separate believers from the love that Christ has for them. Translate this clause with that meaning. Here are some ways:

- As a rhetorical question. For example:

What will separate us from the love of Christ?  
(NABRE)



Who...can separate us from the love of Christ?  
(GNT)

- As a statement. For example:

No one/thing will/can separate us from the love of Christ.

**Who:** In Greek, the word translated Who can refer to either people or things. Paul listed seven things below, some of which are caused by people. In some languages “what” would be the general question word to use here, as in the NABRE above.

**shall:** In Greek this is the normal future. This word means “will” here.

**separate us from the love of Christ:** Here the word separate is used figuratively. It indicates that something prevents Christ from loving us or makes that love ineffective. Some languages cannot use the word separate when referring to love. If that is true in your language, translate the correct meaning. For example:

separate us from Christ and his love

make Christ stop loving us

block Christ’s love to us

**us:** In the Greek, this word is emphasized by being before the verb. Some languages can do that kind of emphasis.

**the love of Christ:** This refers to Christ loving us. Here it does not refer to us loving him.

#### 8:35b–c

**Shall trouble or distress or persecution or famine or nakedness or danger or sword?:** In the Greek, there is no verb in this question, but Shall is implied from 8:35a. For a natural English question this implied word must be explicit here.

This is a rhetorical question. It emphasizes that trouble or distress or persecution or famine or nakedness or danger or sword will not separate us from the love of Christ. Translate this clause with that meaning. Here are some ways:

- As a rhetorical question. For example:

Will anguish, or distress, or persecution, or famine, or nakedness, or peril, or the sword?  
(NABRE)

Can trouble, or distress, or persecution, or famine, or nakedness, or danger, or sword separate us from his love?

- As a statement. For example:

Trouble, or distress, or persecution, or famine, or nakedness, or danger, or sword will/can not separate us from the love of Christ.

#### 8:35b

##### Shall trouble or distress or persecution

- Will trouble or things that cause us worry/stress or suffering because we believe
- People will cause us to have hardships/difficulties or stressful situations or cause us to suffer as believers,

**trouble:** The Greek word here refers to any kind of trouble or suffering. In some languages the plural would be more natural. Here are other ways to translate this word:

tribulation (ESV)

hardships (NJB)

difficultyKankanaey Back Translation on TW.

**distress:** This refers to bad situations or circumstances which cause stress to the people in them. Here are other ways to translate this word:

stressful/difficult times/things

terrible situations/circumstances

See how you translated this word in 2:9.

**persecution:** Here this word refers to people causing trouble or suffering for a believer because he or she follows Jesus. Dunn (page 505) says that this word, “always means persecution for religious reasons.” Here are other ways to translate this word:

people harming us because we believe in Jesus

pains because of our<sup>(inc)</sup> faithLevatbura Lamasong Back Translation, draft, Papua New Guinea.

they cause us who believe to suffer

**8:35c****or famine or nakedness or danger or sword?**

- or starving times or having no/little clothes or situations of harm or death by sword separate/isolate us? No!
- or times of famine/hunger may come, or we may be so poor as to not have enough clothes to wear, or we may experience dangerous situations, or people may violently kill us, but those things will not make him stop loving us.

**famine:** This word refers to an extreme shortage of food. During a famine, people die from a lack of food. Here are other ways to translate this word:

starvation

hunger (NCV)

**nakedness:** The Greek word can refer to wearing no clothes at all, but here probably refers to not having enough clothes to wear, or having only ragged clothes to wear. BDAG (page 208) lists this verse under sense 2: “being without adequate clothing, with connotation of destitution”; and Louw&Nida (§49.23) says it means, “the state of being naked or only scantily clothed.” For example:

lack of...clothing (NJB)

**danger:** This word refers to circumstances that may cause harm or death. Here are other ways to translate this word:

peril (RSV)

if we are harmed or killed

life threatening situations  
Tagbanwa Back Translation on TW.

**sword:** Here this is a figure of speech. It refers to violent death, for example, by murder, war or execution. In some languages this figure of speech will not be clear. If that is true in your language, translate the meaning clearly. For example:

violent death (GW)

killing by sword

**Romans 8:36****Section 8:31–39: Nothing can separate us from God’s love**

In this section, Paul asked a number of rhetorical questions. In asking them he expected the believers in Rome to agree with him in these ways: God is for us and no one has greater power than him when they stand against us. God has made us right with him, so no one can accuse us of wrongdoing that God has not already forgiven. Jesus died for our sins and rose again, so no one can say we are worthy of God punishing us. Nothing of this earth or of the demons and spirits can separate us from God’s love. With God’s power we can overcome all those things.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

God’s love for us because of Jesus Christ

The love of God will not abandon/leave us

**8:36a****As it is written:**

- It is like the words written in Scripture,
- These things happen to God’s people, like the psalm writer said to him/God in his/God’s Word/Book,

**As:** Here this word indicates a comparison between experiencing any of tribulation, distress, persecution, famine, nakedness, danger, or death by sword (8:35b–c) and “for Your sake we face death all day long; we are considered as sheep to be slaughtered” (8:36b–c). The Scripture supports Paul’s implied statement that believers experience tribulation, distress, persecution, famine, nakedness, danger, and death by sword. In some languages it is more clear to make the implied statement explicit. For example:

We experience those/such things, as

Hardships like these are exactly what that which God caused-to-be-written is talking about which says  
Kankanaey Back Translation on TW.

We are like this written talk of God  
Yongkom Back Translation, by this author, unpublished manuscript, Papua New Guinea.

**it is written:** This Psalm was written more than 500 years before Paul wrote the letter to the Romans. In some languages a literal translation would wrongly indicate the quote was written at the same time as

Paul wrote here. If that is true in your language, indicate it was long before Paul wrote. For example:

it was written long ago

This clause refers to what was written in the Old Testament. Some languages must explicitly say that to make that clear. For example:

as scripture says (GNT)

it says in the Holy Book

See how you translated this phrase in 1:17 or 4:17.

In 8:36b, the word “Your” refers to God. In some languages it would be more clear to indicate to whom the writer is writing. For example:

someone wrote to God in Scripture

### 8:36b

#### “For Your sake we face death all day long;

- “We<sup>(excl)</sup> follow/obey you, and so we are being killed at all times of the day.
- “Morning, afternoon, and night, people are killing us because we are your people.

**For Your sake we face death all day long:** The phrase For Your sake is emphasized by being first in the clause. Some languages must have this phrase in its normal place. For example:

We are being killed all the day long for your sake

**For Your sake:** This is a quote from Psalm 44:22. The writer spoke on behalf of himself and his fellow Jews. They willingly faced danger in order to stand strong for God. Paul used it here to refer to himself and his fellow believers who did the same thing. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

For you (CEV)

because we believe in you Otomi Back Translation on TW.

You should not refer explicitly to Jews or believers to explain “we” here.

**we face death:** The Greek verb here is more literally “we are killed.” This clause is passive. Some languages must use an active clause here. For example:

others are killing us

The present tense indicates that the killing continues.

**all day long:** This phrase indicates that the killers kill at any time of day (or night). Here the words all day long are general and refer to any day. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

at all times (GNT)

all the day (NABRE)

### 8:36c

#### we are considered as sheep to be slaughtered.”

- We are considered to be like sheep to be killed.”
- They think that they can kill us like people kill sheep.”

#### we are considered as sheep to be slaughtered:

There is no connecting word at the beginning of 8:36c to connect it to 8:36b, but the context implies a connection between the two. Both sentences refer to the same event: enemies of God killing his people. So languages need to make the connection explicit. For example:

It is also like this: we are regarded as sheep to be slaughtered

**we are considered:** This clause is passive. Some languages must use an active clause. For example:

they/people consider us

**sheep to be slaughtered:** This clause is passive. Some languages must use an active clause. For example:

sheep for them to slaughter

**sheep:** The animals called sheep are tame. They usually stay in groups. They weigh 40 to 60 kilograms. They eat plants. Here the writer of this psalm referred to sheep because they are easy to kill. They do not run away or fight back.

In some languages people are not familiar with sheep. If that is true in your language, you may want to:

- Explain the word in your translation. For example:

animals called sheep

- Use the major language word. If people are not familiar with this word, you may want to explain it in a footnote. Here is an example footnote:

Sheep refers to a medium-sized tame animal.  
They were easy to kill.

**slaughtered:** This word refers to killing animals for food. But the idea of eating is not important here. For example:

killed (NCV)

### General Comment on 8:36b–c

These words are a quote found in Psalm 44:22. If you indicate the location of quotes from the Old Testament with cross-references, you may want to do so here.

## Romans 8:37

### Section 8:31–39: Nothing can separate us from God’s love

In this section, Paul asked a number of rhetorical questions. In asking them he expected the believers in Rome to agree with him in these ways: God is for us and no one has greater power than him when they stand against us. God has made us right with him, so no one can accuse us of wrongdoing that God has not already forgiven. Jesus died for our sins and rose again, so no one can say we are worthy of God punishing us. Nothing of this earth or of the demons and spirits can separate us from God’s love. With God’s power we can overcome all those things.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

God’s love for us because of Jesus Christ

The love of God will not abandon/leave us

#### 8:37a

### No, in all these things we are more than conquerors

- But when we<sup>(incl)</sup> experience any of those things/situations, we are gaining complete victory
- No/But, we win a complete victory over any/all of those things

**No:** The Greek word is literally “but.” For example:

But (NASB)

However, in contrast to 8:36, many English versions prefer No here.

### (GNT:) in all these things we have complete victory:

The phrase in all these things is emphasized by being first in the clause. In some languages it must be in its usual place. For example:

we have complete victory in all these things

**(GNT:) in all these things:** The words these things refer to the situations in 8:35. In some languages “those” would be more clear. For example:

in all those things

The word in indicates that believers experience those situations. For example:

when we experience any of those things/situations

**(GNT:) we have complete victory:** There are two ways to interpret the Greek word that the GNT translates as we have complete victory:

1. It means we overwhelmingly conquer. For example:

we conquer overwhelmingly (NABRE) (GNT, NABRE, NASB, NLT, GW, NET, REB, NCV)

1. It means we conquer and gain something else. For example:

we have won more than a victory (CEV) (BSB, RSV, NIV, ESV, KJV, CEV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1), because the Greek prefix indicates completeness rather than something more than just conquering. BDAG, L&N, and L&S.

#### 8:37b

### through Him who loved us.

- by the power of the one who loved us.
- because of him who loved us then and now.

**through Him who loved us:** Here the word through indicates that Jesus enables us to be more than conquerors. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

by the power of him who loved us (NJB)

because of him who loved us

**Him:** It is likely that Paul meant Jesus here (8:35). Cranfield, Schreiner, Jewett, Kruse, Lenski, Alford, Nicoll, and Fitzmyer say it refers to Jesus. Morris (page 340) says it could be either God or Jesus. But you should translate this word as “he” or “him” here.

**loved:** The Greek tense usually refers to a past event. Here it probably refers to the love that Jesus showed to us by dying on the cross for us. Morris (page 340), Lenski (page 575), and Nicoll (page 654). The past tense here does not imply that Jesus no longer loves us.

In some languages using the past tense would clearly indicate that Jesus no longer loves us. If that is true in your language, use the present tense. For example:

loves (CEV)

## Romans 8:38

### Section 8:31–39: Nothing can separate us from God’s love

In this section, Paul asked a number of rhetorical questions. In asking them he expected the believers in Rome to agree with him in these ways: God is for us and no one has greater power than him when they stand against us. God has made us right with him, so no one can accuse us of wrongdoing that God has not already forgiven. Jesus died for our sins and rose again, so no one can say we are worthy of God punishing us. Nothing of this earth or of the demons and spirits can separate us from God’s love. With God’s power we can overcome all those things.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

God’s love for us because of Jesus Christ

The love of God will not abandon/leave us

### 8:38a–39c

**neither death nor life, neither angels nor principalities, neither the present nor the future, nor any powers, neither height nor depth, nor anything else in all creation, will be able to separate us from the love of God that is in Christ Jesus our Lord:** The word neither means “not” and introduces a list of things that are introduced with nor. The word nor means “and

not.” Many languages will use “and” and “not” here. For example:

not death and not life, and not angels and not principalities, and not the present and not the future, and not any powers, and not height and not depth, and not anything else in all creation, will be able to separate us from the love of God

death and life, and angels and principalities, and the present and the future, and any powers, and height and depth, and anything else in all creation, cannot separate us from the love of God cannot

not death or life, or angels or principalities, or the present or the future, or any powers, or height or depth, or anything else in all creation, is able to separate us from the love of God

Some English versions group together pairs of terms (for example, the BSB says death nor life) by not using a comma inside each pair.

### 8:38a

**For I am convinced that neither death nor life,**

- For I am certain that death or life,
- For I am convinced that nothing, either death or life,

**For:** This word introduces an explanation Lenski (page 576). about conquering in all those situations (8:37).

**I am convinced:** This clause indicates that Paul was certain about what he was about to say. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

I am sure (ESV)

I am certain (GNT)

**death:** Here this word refers to physical death.

**life:** Here this word refers to life here on earth.

### 8:38b

**neither angels nor principalities,**

- or evil angels or leaders,
- or demons or earthly leaders,

**angels:** The Greek word that the BSB translates as angels means “messengers.” It refers here to spirit beings whom God made to serve him. Some angels rebelled against God, and the Bible sometimes calls these angels “demons” or “evil spirits.” Only

demons would try to separate believers from Christ's love. Jewett (page 552). If the word or phrase you use for angels only refers to good spirit beings, you may want to:

- Explain the meaning in your translation. For example:

evil angels

- Use the word "demons" or the phrase "evil spirits." For example:

demons

**principalities:** Some scholars think this word refers here to demons who are leaders. Other scholars think this word refers here to people who are leaders. If possible, translate this word in a way that it could refer to either group. If you must refer either to people or demons, refer to people who are leaders here, because of the meaning of "angels" above and "powers" in 8:38b–c. Jewett (page 552) says that this word refers to leaders who are "political," meaning earthly leaders.

### 8:38c

**neither the present nor the future, nor any powers,**

- or anything that exists today or anything that will someday exist, or those with power,
- or whatever happens now or whatever will/might happen in the future, or anyone having power,

**the present:** There are two ways to translate the Greek word that the BSB translates as the present:

1. It refers to things that exist at the time called now for the reader of this verse. For example:

anything in the present (GW) (RSV, NJB, NASB, KJV, NABRE, ESV, GW, NET, REB, NCV)

1. It refers to the time called "the present" for the reader of this verse. For example:

the present (BSB) (BSB, NIV, GNT, CEV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1), because Paul spoke of objects or events that can possibly separate us from Christ. So speaking about a time we call the present doesn't seem to fit here. Moo, Longenecker, Cranfield, Dunn, Schreiner, Jewett, Witherington, Barrett, Lenski, and Alford support interpretation (1). Fitzmyer supports interpretation (2). None

of them explain their choice. Here are other ways to translate this phrase according to interpretation (1):

things that exist now

what happens today Kankanaey Back Translation on TW.

**the future:** There are two ways to translate the Greek word that the BSB translates as the future:

1. It refers to things that will exist later for the reader of this verse. For example:

anything in the future (GW) (RSV, NJB, NASB, KJV, NABRE, ESV, GW, NET, REB, NCV)

1. It refers to the time called "the future" for the reader of this verse. For example:

the future (BSB) (BSB, NIV, GNT, CEV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1), because Paul spoke of objects or events that can possibly separate us from Christ. So speaking about a time we call the future doesn't seem to fit here. Here are other ways to translate this phrase according to interpretation (1):

things that will exist later

what has not yet happened Kankanaey Back Translation on TW.

**any powers:** There is a textual issue in 8:34: (1) Some Greek manuscripts have words in this order nor things present nor things in the future nor powers (BSB, RSV, NIV, NJB, NASB, NABRE, NLT, GW, NET, REB, ESV). (2) Some Greek manuscripts have the words in this order nor powers nor things present nor things in the future (KJV). It is recommended that you follow option (1). The UBS Handbook says, "The GNT has slightly reordered the list, placing the present and the future together, so as to make the list sound more natural to the English reader," and seems to always follow the UBS Greek New Testament (option (1) here, which they consider certain). This word can refer to any being that has power of any kind. But here it refers to any powerful being that might try to separate believers from Christ's love for them. Here are other ways to translate this word:

those with power

others that have powerKankanaey Back Translation on TW, which moves it to after “angels nor leaders” to make a clearer connection to those beings.

## Romans 8:39

### Section 8:31–39: Nothing can separate us from God’s love

In this section, Paul asked a number of rhetorical questions. In asking them he expected the believers in Rome to agree with him in these ways: God is for us and no one has greater power than him when they stand against us. God has made us right with him, so no one can accuse us of wrongdoing that God has not already forgiven. Jesus died for our sins and rose again, so no one can say we are worthy of God punishing us. Nothing of this earth or of the demons and spirits can separate us from God’s love. With God’s power we can overcome all those things.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

God’s love for us because of Jesus Christ

The love of God will not abandon/leave us

#### 8:39a

#### neither height nor depth, nor anything else in all creation,

- or anything high or anything deep, or any other thing created by God
- or whatever is high above us or whatever is deep down below us, or whatever thing that God has ever made,

**height...depth:** There are several ways to interpret the Greek words that the BSB translates as height and depth:

1. Interpret these words as relating to something connected to the literal sense of these words. For example:

the heights...the depths (NJB) (BSB, RSV, NIV, NJB, NASB, KJV, ESV, NABRE, NET, REB)

1. It refers to powerful spirits high in the sky and in the earth or sea below. For example:

powers above...powers below (CEV) (NLT, GW, CEV)

1. It refers to a world high in the sky and a world in the earth below. For example:

the world above...the world below (GNT) (GNT)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1), because it is not clear exactly what Paul was thinking of here. Moo, Longenecker, Cranfield, Dunn, Schreiner, Jewett, and Witherington support interpretation (1) in their translations. Many have conjectures about astronomy, astrology, space, and other things. Schreiner (page 465) says, “The terms are spatial but should be interpreted metaphorically in light of the poetic cast of the passage (cf. Ps. 139:8–9; Eph. 3:18...). There is nothing, neither high nor low, in all the created order that can separate believers from the love of God in Christ Jesus.”

These words, height and depth, probably refers to things or beings that are high or deep (without being specific like interpretation (2) or (3)). Here are other ways to translate these words:

things high above...things deep down

nothing above us, nothing below us (NCV)

**anything else in all creation:** The Greek is more literally “any other created-thing.” It refers to any thing or being that God created. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

any created thing (NJB)

any other creature (NABRE)

#### 8:38–39

**(reordered) For I am sure that nothing will be able to separate us from the love of God in Christ Jesus our Lord, not death or life, or angels or rulers, or things present or things to come, or powers, or height or depth, or anything else in all creation.**

#### 8:39b

**will be able to separate us from the love of God**

- does not have the power to separate/isolate us from God’s love for us
- will ever be able to come between us and God and make him stop loving us.

**separate:** Here the word separate is used figuratively. It indicates that something prevents God from loving

us or makes that love ineffective. See how you translated this word in 8:35.

**the love of God:** This refers to God loving us. Here it does not refer to us loving him.

### 8:39c

**that is in Christ Jesus our Lord.**

- seen in our Lord, Jesus, the Christ/Messiah.
- Our Leader/Master Jesus, the one/person whom God appointed to save/rescue people, demonstrated/showed that love to us.

**in Christ Jesus our Lord:** The word in here indicates that God showed his love for us by sending Jesus to die on the cross for us (see 5:8). It is in relationship to Jesus that we experience God's love for us. See Moo (page 547). Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

which we experience because of Cristo Jesus our Lord  
Kankanaey Back Translation on TW.

through this Lord of ours Cristo Jesus  
Tagbanwa Back Translation on TW.

which he gives us in our relationship to Jesus  
Christ, our Lord

**Christ Jesus:** The order of the words Christ Jesus emphasizes that Jesus is the Christ/Messiah. However, in some languages the order Christ Jesus is not natural. See how you translated this phrase in 8:34.

**our Lord:** The word Lord refers to someone who has authority over people. Here it indicates that Jesus has authority over believers. See how you translated this phrase in 1:4 or 7:25.

In chapters 9-11 Paul spoke about the fact that most Jews had not accepted Jesus as their promised Messiah at that time. He explained how throughout their history God had always preserved a small portion of them as believers. He also talked about the possibility that their salvation was still close at hand in the gospel.

The fact that many did not believe did not mean that God completely rejected them. Also, it was important that the non-Jewish believers not look down on those Jews, or think too highly of themselves.

Paul described the unbelieving Jews as branches broken off a tree so that different branches, the non-Jewish believers, could be grafted in. But this grafting-in was all based on faith, not on any special qualities

of those believers. God hardened the Jews' hearts in part so that non-Jews would be able to come into the family. That will be true until the full number of non-Jews come in. And in that way all Israel will be saved.

Here are other possible headings for this division:

The plan of God for Jews and Gentiles (Stott)

God's Justice and Israel's Future (Witherington)

Israel and the Purposes of God (Kruse)

## Romans 9:1

### Section 9:1-5: Paul was very sad about the Jews

In this section, Paul said that he was very sad about his fellow Jews. He was not specific about the cause of his sadness in these verses, only that God had given them many advantages as Israelites. Paul implied that they did not follow through on those advantages, and that made him sad.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

The unbelief of Israel and God's choices

God chooses only according to his plan regarding the Jews

### 9:1a-2a

In 9:1 Paul strongly indicated in three different ways that he spoke truthfully in 9:2-3. By using three ways, Paul wanted the believers in Rome to be very clear that he spoke the truth in those verses.

**I speak the truth in Christ; I am not lying, as confirmed by my conscience in the Holy Spirit. I have**

**deep sorrow:** The truth that Paul spoke of here is introduced with the new sentence in 9:2. In the Greek the word truth is first in the clause. This emphasizes it and makes it the topic. Then he said what particular truth he was thinking of in 9:2-3. The BSB uses a comma in 9:1 and a period with a new sentence in 9:2 to indicate the connection of the truth to 9:2-3. Here are other ways to translate this connection:

<sup>1</sup>This truth, I speak in Christ, and I am not lying, as confirmed by my conscience in the Holy Spirit, is <sup>2</sup>that I have great sorrow



Here is a truth I speak in Christ and I am not lying about, as confirmed by my conscience in the Holy Spirit. It is <sup>2</sup>that I have great sorrow

I am not lying, the Holy Spirit has spoken to me in support of my thought and mind ways [conscience], and I through Christ speak this truth here. <sup>2</sup>I have in my insides great unhappinessY-ongkom Back Translation, by this author, unpublished manuscript, Papua New Guinea.

### 9:1a

#### I speak the truth in Christ;

- ¶ This truth I speak because I belong to Christ/Messiah.
- ¶ Here is a truth I speak through Jesus, the one/person whom God appointed to save/rescue people.

**I speak the truth:** The Greek present tense indicates that Paul wanted to reassure the believers in Rome that what he was about to say is true. The Greek present tense does not indicate that Paul would continue to speak for some time. Here is another way to translate this clause:

I am speaking the truth (ESV)

**in Christ:** Here the word in refers to the relationship between Paul and Christ. Jesus is Paul's lord and made him his apostle. So Paul spoke here based on that relationship and being his apostle.

This phrase connects to the verb "speak" or to "I speak the truth" as a whole. See the examples above.

### 9:1b

#### I am not lying,

- I do not lie with what I am about to say,
- I do not speak/tell a lie here.

**I am not lying:** This clause also refers to the truth that Paul was about to speak in 9:2-3. It also reinforced to the believers in Rome that what he was about to say is true. For example:

I am not about to lie

I do not lie when I say it

### 9:1c

#### as confirmed by my conscience in the Holy Spirit.

- and my own memory also testifies through the Holy Spirit:

- The Holy Spirit knows my thoughts about what I have done. He knows that I am speaking the truth. It is

**as confirmed by my conscience:** This phrase indicates that Paul's conscience also told him that he was not lying. The word confirmed is used where one is expected to tell the truth accurately. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

my conscience testifies for me (NJB)

tells me I am not lying (NCV)

**conscience:** The Greek word that the BSB translates as conscience refers to the record of past deeds that a person has in his mind. Thinking of past wrong deeds can cause him to feel ashamed or guilty. See how you translated this word in 2:15.

**in the Holy Spirit:** Here the word in indicates that the Holy Spirit helped Paul's conscience to bear truthful witness. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

through the Holy Spirit (NIV11)

enlightened by the Holy Spirit (REB)

**the Holy Spirit:** This phrase refers to God's Spirit. The word Spirit is used in a similar way to when a person refers to his own spirit. The word Holy here means "clean" or "sacred." But it also refers to "coming from God." See how you translated this phrase in 5:5.

## Romans 9:2

### Section 9:1-5: Paul was very sad about the Jews

In this section, Paul said that he was very sad about his fellow Jews. He was not specific about the cause of his sadness in these verses, only that God had given them many advantages as Israelites. Paul implied that they did not follow through on those advantages, and that made him sad.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

The unbelief of Israel and God's choices

God chooses only according to his plan regarding the Jews

**9:2**

**I have deep sorrow and unceasing anguish in my heart.**

- I am very sad and have grief in my heart/insides that will not stop.
- that I am full of grief and my heart/liver pains me all the time.

**deep sorrow and unceasing anguish:** The two Greek words here both refer to emotional/mental pain. BDAG (pages 604, 692) defines the first Greek word as “pain of mind or spirit” and the second as “mental pain.” Many languages have two words or phrases similar in meaning like that. For example:

I am exceedingly burdened (lit. heavied), also  
I am always sad (lit. my thoughts are  
pained) Kankanaey Back Translation on TW.

my grief is very severe and my mind/inner-being  
cries-over-it Tagbanwa Back Translation on TW.

But in some languages it is more natural to use only one word or phrase. For example:

I see very much sadness Kamula Back Translation,  
unpublished manuscript, Papua New Guinea.

**heart:** Here this word refers to the part of a person in which thoughts and feelings occur. In some languages people use a different part of the body, such as the mind, throat, liver, or stomach, in this way. See how you translated this word in 1:21 or 8:27.

**Romans 9:3****Section 9:1–5: Paul was very sad about the Jews**

In this section, Paul said that he was very sad about his fellow Jews. He was not specific about the cause of his sadness in these verses, only that God had given them many advantages as Israelites. Paul implied that they did not follow through on those advantages, and that made him sad.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

The unbelief of Israel and God’s choices

God chooses only according to his plan regarding the Jews

**9:3a**

**For I could wish that I myself were cursed and cut off from Christ**

- For if I could, I would wish that I myself were under God’s curse and separated from Jesus Christ/the-Messiah
- For if it were possible, I would desire that God condemn me to eternal punishment and separate me from Jesus, the one/person whom God appointed to save/rescue people.

**For:** Here this word introduces an explanation Morris (page 347) and Cranfield (page 454). of what Paul said in 9:2.

**I could wish:** There are two ways to interpret the Greek word that the BSB translates as wish:

1. It means wish here. (BSB, RSV, NIV, GNT, NASB, KJV, NABRE, ESV, GW, NET)
2. It means pray here. For example:

I could pray (NJB) (NJB, REB)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1), because the context does not indicate or imply that this action is directed to God. Also, it might be appropriate for Paul to wish that he was accursed for the sake of the Jews, but it would not be appropriate for him to pray for God to make him accursed and cut off from Christ.

Here are other ways to translate this clause:

if it were possible, I would like Kankanaey Back Translation on TW.

If I could save my fellow Jews I would do it even if it meant Otomi Back Translation on TW.

If it were possible, I really would not refuse to Tagbanwa Back Translation on TW.

**could wish:** Here the word could indicates that Paul had a true desire to see the Jews saved but stopped short of actually wishing that to happen. See the above examples.

**were cursed:** Here these words refer to something that is marked for destruction. All people who reject Jesus as the Christ are cursed. Here are other ways to translate this word:

were under a curse

be placed under God's curse (CEV)

be put in eternal punishment

**and cut off from Christ:** The BSB and some English versions add the phrase and cut off. It explains the Greek word that the BSB translates as from. Here this word indicates separation from Christ forever. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

separated from Christ (NASB)

remove me from my life in Christ

### 9:3b

**for the sake of my brothers, my own flesh and blood,**

- to benefit my brothers and sisters, that is, those who are my fellow tribe/people-group according to natural descent.
- I would desire that if it would help my fellow Jews, my natural kinsmen, to believe in him/Christ.

**for the sake of my brothers, my own flesh and blood:** This refers to the Jews who do not believe in Jesus. It refers to some benefit for these Jews related to the possibility of Paul being cut off from Christ. Paul explained clearly in 10:1, but did not say here what he might expect from a wish to be accursed for the sake of these Jews. You may want to explain in a footnote. Here is an example footnote:

10:1 explains that Paul wanted very much for the Jews who do not believe in Jesus to believe in him.

**for the sake of:** This phrase refers to helping or causing advantage for someone. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

to help

for

to benefit

See how you translated the phrase "on behalf of" in 1:5.

**my brothers, my own flesh and blood:** Here the phrase my brothers refers to Jews, because Paul was a Jew. The phrase my own flesh and blood explains

the phrase my brothers, because the word brothers is often used to refer to fellow Christians. Connect the second phrase to the first in a way that it explains the first phrase. For example:

my brothers, my kinsfolk by natural descent (REB)

my fellow Jews who are related-to-me-by-blood-  
Kankanaey Back Translation on TW, 9:2.

my fellow Jews, they are my true tribesmen

**my own flesh and blood:** This phrase refers to people of the same tribe or people group as Paul according to natural descent. The Jews and Paul all descended from Jacob, whose other name was Israel. This phrase makes it clear that Paul was talking specifically about people who were related to him by birth. See the above examples.

## Romans 9:4

### Section 9:1–5: Paul was very sad about the Jews

In this section, Paul said that he was very sad about his fellow Jews. He was not specific about the cause of his sadness in these verses, only that God had given them many advantages as Israelites. Paul implied that they did not follow through on those advantages, and that made him sad.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

The unbelief of Israel and God's choices

God chooses only according to his plan regarding the Jews

### 9:4a

**the people of Israel. Theirs is the adoption as sons;**

- They are the people of Israel, and they have the adoption from God,
- They are the Israel nation and have a relationship with God, and God adopted them as his children.

**the people of Israel:** The Greek is literally "who are Israelites." It describes "my brothers, my own flesh and blood" in 9:3b. The word "who" does not imply here that only some of Paul's "flesh and blood" are Israelites. The Greek grammar clearly indicates that all of Paul's "flesh and blood" were Israelites.

God gave the name Israel to Jacob. The words people of can also be indicated by the “-ites” ending in English. For example:

the Israelites

If people in your language group are not familiar with the name Israel, you may want to translate literally and explain its meaning in a footnote. Here is an example footnote:

Israel is another name for the Jews. God gave their ancestor Jacob the name Israel (Genesis 32:28).

**Theirs is the adoption as sons:** The Greek is literally “of whom the adoption.” God made a covenant with Israel and considers them his adopted children. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

theirs the adoption (NABRE)

who were adopted as God’s children

whom God adopted as his children

they have the adoption

they are adopted by God, and they have

Some languages must translate the adoption with a verb. For example:

God adopted them and they have

#### 9:4b–c

**theirs the divine glory and the covenants; theirs the giving of the law, the temple worship, and the promises:** The word “theirs” that the BSB repeats three times in 9:4a and 9:4b connects each of these terms. Also, some languages need to put the word and between each term. For example:

and the divine glory and the covenants and the giving of the law and the temple worship and the promises

the adoption as sons and the divine glory and the covenants and the giving of the law and the temple worship and the promises belong to them

#### 9:4b

**theirs the divine glory and the covenants; theirs the giving of the law,**

- the glory/majesty of God, the agreements with God, the law given by God,
- They have seen the splendor/greatness of God and have contracts with him. He gave/told them his laws

**the divine glory:** The word that the BSB translates as divine glory refers literally to a very bright light. In this context it implies power, majesty, and greatness. Here are other ways to translate this word:

majesty

greatness

Some languages must translate this word as describing something or someone, as the BSB does. For example:

the glory of God

See how you translated the word glory in 1:23 or 5:2.

**the covenants:** The word covenants refers to an agreement or contract. God made several covenants with the people of Israel. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

the pledges (GW)

He made agreements with them (CEV)

**the giving of the law:** This refers to God giving the laws to Moses for the people of Israel to follow. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

he...gave them the Law (GNT)

to them were given the Law (NJB)

#### 9:4c

**the temple worship, and the promises.**

- the worship of God, and the promises from God.
- and the rules he gave them to worship him and the promises that he made to them.

**the temple worship:** This refers to the pattern of worshipping God that he gave to the Jews to follow. This includes the sacrifice of animals and all that was done at the temple in Jerusalem. It may also include

worship in the synagogues. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

their way of worship

They were told the way they were to worship  
—tomorrow Back Translation on TW.

**the promises:** This refers to the promises that God made to the patriarchs, Abraham, Isaac, and Jacob, as well as others such as Moses and David.

## Romans 9:5

### Section 9:1–5: Paul was very sad about the Jews

In this section, Paul said that he was very sad about his fellow Jews. He was not specific about the cause of his sadness in these verses, only that God had given them many advantages as Israelites. Paul implied that they did not follow through on those advantages, and that made him sad.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

The unbelief of Israel and God's choices

God chooses only according to his plan regarding the Jews

### 9:5a

#### Theirs are the patriarchs,

- And they are connected/related to the forefathers,
- They are also descended from our ancestors of long ago.

**Theirs are the patriarchs:** The Greek is literally “of whom the fathers.” It indicates that they are connected to Abraham, Isaac (son of Abraham), and Jacob (son of Isaac). Those three were the main ancestors of the Israelites. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

To them belong the patriarchs (ESV)

who are connected to the founders

whose ancestors are Abraham, Isaac, and Jacob

Abraham, Isaac, and Jacob lived more than 1,800 years before Paul wrote this letter. In some translations, the translator may need to make it clear that they had died long ago. For example:

of whom are the forefathers of long ago

### 9:5b

#### and from them proceeds the human descent of Christ,

- and from them, by natural descent, is the Christ,
- And Jesus the Messiah is also an Israelite in regard to his human ancestors.
- And Jesus, the one/person whom God appointed to save/rescue people, is from the Israelite nation/people-group because of his mother.

#### from them proceeds the human descent of Christ:

The Greek is literally “from whom the Christ according to the flesh.” It indicates that Jesus is a person of the people of Israel, a Jew, when we look at his human descent through King David. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

from them, according to the flesh, is the Messiah (NABRE)

out of them, so far as physical descent is concerned, came Christ (NJB)

Christ himself was an Israelite as far as his human nature is concerned (NLT)

They have those famous ancestors, who were also the ancestors of Jesus Christ (CEV)

**the human descent:** Here the words that the BSB translates as human descent are literally “according to the flesh.” They refer to natural/human descent, as in 9:3. See the examples above.

**Christ:** Here this word refers to Jesus as the Messiah, the one God sent to save people. It is not used as another name for Jesus. For example:

the Christ/Messiah

the one/person whom God appointed to save/rescue people

See how you translated this word in 1:1.

### 9:5c

#### who is God over all, forever worthy of praise! Amen.

- who/he is lord over all things, and he is God blessed/praised forever. It is true.

- He rules everything and he is divine/God. His people and angels always praise him, now and for all the time. Amen/True!

**who is God over all, forever worthy of praise:** The Greek is literally “the (one) being over all God blessed into the ages.” There are three main ways to interpret these words:

1. The words God over all, forever worthy of praise describe “the Christ” (9:5b). This verse says that Jesus the Christ is lord over all things and he is also God and is blessed forever. For example:

who is above all, God, blessed for ever (NJB) (BSB, NIV, NJB, ESV, NLT, GW, NET, NCV)

1. The phrase God...forever worthy of praise describes “the (one) being over all,” and all of these words describe “the Christ” (9:5b). This verse says that Jesus the Christ is lord over all things and God blesses him forever. For example:

who is over all, God blessed forever (NASB) (NASB, NRSV, KJV)

1. The whole phrase is separate from the words “the Christ.” It is a blessing to God. For example:

...the Christ. God who is over all be blessed for ever. (RSV) (RSV, GNT, NABRE, CEV, REB)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1), because a number of scholars say it is the most natural way to read the Greek. For example, Jewett (page 568). Moo, Morris, Longenecker, Cranfield, and Schreiner also support interpretation (1). They each describe the issue in detail. Interpretation (2) is mainly driven by the claim that Paul never refers to Jesus as God. But other Bible authors do and Paul probably does in Titus 2:13.

**who is God over all:** These words introduce a description of Jesus the Christ (9:5b). In some languages a literal translation would wrongly indicate that there are many Christs and only this one is over all. If that is true in your language, translate in a way that introduces a description of Jesus the Christ. For example:

he is God over all

and he is God over all

Here this phrase indicates that Jesus the Christ is lord of all things, including animals and people, and he is also God. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

he is God, the one rules over everything (NLT)

he is God who rules over all that exists Kankanaey Back Translation on TW.

He is the God that surpasses and is above all Yongkom Back Translation, unpublished manuscript, Papua New Guinea.

**forever:** The Greek is literally “into the ages.” It refers to all time in the future.

**worthy of praise:** The Greek word that the BSB translates as worthy of praise here means “blessed” or “honored.” People and the angels and other creatures of heaven are and will always praise and honor God. See how you translated it in 1:25.

**Amen:** This word indicates that Paul approved and confirmed as true what he just said. In many languages people will already be familiar with it and so it is possible to transliterate it. See how you translated it in 1:25.

## Romans 9:6

### Section 9:6–13: The choices of God follow his purposes

In this section, Paul told the Romans that God’s word has not failed. In the history of the Jews God had chosen some of them and not others. Paul gave some examples of this.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

God’s promises do not fail

No one can change what God has chosen to do

#### 9:6a

#### It is not as though God’s word has failed.

- ¶ But regarding my kinsmen, God’s word has certainly not fallen down.
- ¶ But the holy word of God has not failed to be fulfilled for my fellow Jews.

**It is not as though God’s word has failed:** This connects to the Jews (9:3b). In some languages a literal translation would not connect to the Jews. If that is

true in your language, you may want to add implied information to your translation. For example:

It is not as though God's word has failed regarding my kinsmen

**It is not as though:** The Greek phrase here is a mixture of two phrases that mean "by no means" and "not as if." BAGD (page 701). Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

It is certainly not that

It cannot be that (REB)

Don't think that Tagbanwa Back Translation on TW.

**God's word has failed:** This clause refers to the promises in God's word not being fulfilled when people thought they should have been. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

God's word was not fulfilled

God's word failed to be fulfilled

God's word was not able to become true

**God's word:** Here this phrase refers to God's promises to the Jews in the Old Testament. Do not translate it so that it means "the gospel." In many languages a literal translation would have the correct meaning. But in some languages the meaning will need to be explained. For example:

the talks/things that God told the Jews

#### 9:6b

**For not all who are descended from Israel are Israel.**

- For not all of the people who descended from the man Israel are the true Israel people.
- For only some of the descendants of Israel are the Israel nation/group of faith.

**For:** Here this word introduces an explanation of what Paul said in 9:6a.

**not all who are descended from Israel are Israel:** Paul used the name Israel in two different ways here. The first way that Paul used it refers to the people who descended from the man who God named Israel.

The second way refers to those who have faith like Abraham, Isaac, and Israel. Paul expected the reader to figure out what he meant.

In some languages a literal translation would not clearly indicate the correct meaning. If that is true in your language, you may want to:

- Translate literally and explain the meaning in a footnote. Here are example footnotes:

The second name Israel refers to those who have faith like Abraham did.

This means that not all the descendants of Israel had faith in God like Abraham did.

- Explain the meaning in your translation. For example:

not all who are descended from the man Israel belong to the Israel of faith

not all the people of Israel are the people of God (GNT)

## Romans 9:7

### Section 9:6–13: The choices of God follow his purposes

In this section, Paul told the Romans that God's word has not failed. In the history of the Jews God had chosen some of them and not others. Paul gave some examples of this.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

God's promises do not fail

No one can change what God has chosen to do

#### 9:7a

**Nor because they are Abraham's descendants are they all his children.**

- For not all of Abraham's children are considered his seed/descendants,
- For only some of Abraham's children are his descendants in faith.

**(NET:) nor are all the children Abraham's true descendants:** The Greek is literally "neither that (they) are seed of Abraham all children." There are two issues of interpretation.

### Issue 1: Interpretation of the Greek word *hoti*

There are several ways to interpret the Greek word that is often translated as “that.” Here are the main ones:

1. The Greek word introduces an explanation. But 9:6b is already an explanation, so some versions translate this connection with “and.” For example:

and not all the descendants of Abraham count as his children (NJB) (NJB, GNT, NLT, GW, NET, NCV)

1. The Greek word means “because” and connects “seed” to children, rather than back to 9:6b. For example:

Nor because they are his descendants are they all Abraham’s children (NIV) (BSB, RSV, NIV, NASB, KJV, ESV, NABRE)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1), Moo (page 574) says that 9:7–13 explain the basis for what Paul said in 9:6b. He translates the first two Greek words as “Neither is it the case that.” Jewett (page 575) says that 9:7a is “substantiating the claim in v. 6b.” He translates the first two Greek words as “nor [is it] that.” because the Greek word probably has the same meaning as in 9:6 (where the BSB leaves it implicit).

Issue 2: Interpretation of what the subject of the Greek verb translated are is

The Greek verb has the ending that indicates third person plural (“they” or a group mentioned in the clause). It is not clear whether to take “they” as referring to “seed” or children. (In Greek, the singular “seed” can refer to either a singular seed or plural seeds, so it is grammatical for “seed” here to take the plural verb ending.) There are a number of interpretations. Here are the three main ones:

1. The subject is children. For example:

nor are all the children Abraham’s true descendants (NRSV) (NRSV, NET)

1. The subject is seed/descendants. For example:

and not all the descendants of Abraham count as his children (NJB) (GNT, NIV, NJB, KJV, NASB, NLT, REB, NABRE)

1. The subject is all. For example:

and not all are children of Abraham because they are his descendants (RSV) (BSB, RSV, ESV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1), because it fits better with 9:7b and 9:8. But you may want to follow what the major language version does here.

#### 9:7b

**On the contrary, “Through Isaac your offspring will be reckoned.”**

- but/for it is as God said, “Only Isaac’s descendants will be counted/considered as your descendants.”
- In the Holy Book God told him, “It is only Isaac’s descendants whom I will name as your descendants.”

**On the contrary:** This indicates contrast to “all of the descendants of Abraham,” only part of 9:7a. Some languages would not consider “Through Isaac shall your offspring be named” to contrast to “not all the descendants of Abraham count as his children” (9:7a). For example:

becauseKankanaey Back Translation on TW.

God told him

Just like what God said to AbrahamTagbanwa Back Translation on TW.

**“Through Isaac your offspring will be reckoned”:**

This quote is from Genesis 21:12. In some languages a quote from the Old Testament must be clearly introduced as such. For example:

but as the Scriptures say, “Through Isaac your offspring will be reckoned.”

If you indicate the location of quotes from the Old Testament with cross-references, you may want to do so here.

Of Abraham’s children, God only chose Isaac to inherit the promises of God to Abraham. Isaac and then Jacob became the founders of the people of Israel, and God named them his people. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

It is through Isaac that descendants shall bear your name (NABRE)

Isaac is the son through whom your descendants will be counted (NLT)



It is only the descendants of Isaac who will be counted as your grandchildren/descendantsKankanaey Back Translation on TW.

This clause is passive. Some languages must use an active clause. For example:

God said, "Through Isaac shall I reckon your offspring."

The phrase Through Isaac is put in the front of the clause to emphasize it. In some languages, the phrase must be in its usual place. If possible emphasize it in another way. For example:

Of your (sg) children, only just the descendants of Isahak will I regard/consider your (sg) descendantsYakan Back Translation on TW.

The descendants I promised you will be from Isaac (NCV)

## Romans 9:8

### Section 9:6–13: The choices of God follow his purposes

In this section, Paul told the Romans that God's word has not failed. In the history of the Jews God had chosen some of them and not others. Paul gave some examples of this.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

God's promises do not fail

No one can change what God has chosen to do

#### 9:8a So

- That is,
- Here is what that means:
- The meaning of it is this:

**So:** The Greek is literally "that is." It introduces an explanation of "Through Isaac shall your offspring be named." Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

That is to say, (REB)

Here is the meaning of that,Tagbanwa Back Translation on TW.

#### 9:8b

**it is not the children of the flesh who are God's children,**

- being born by natural means does not make anyone a child of God,
- Not all the people born in Abraham's blood line become God's chosen children.

**it is not the children of the flesh who are God's children:** The phrase children of the flesh here refers to people related to Abraham through physical descent. The phrase God's children refers to the people chosen by God to be his people. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

it is not by being children through physical descent that people become children of God (NJB)

it is not the children of Abraham by natural descent who are children of God (REB)

**God's children:** This refers to those whom God has chosen. In some languages the implied word "chosen" must be used for the correct meaning. For example:

the chosen children of God

the children whom God chose

#### 9:8c

**but it is the children of the promise who are regarded as offspring.**

- but the children of the promise of God are regarded as his/Abraham's offspring.
- No. God considers only the people who have his promise as Abraham's descendants.

**it is the children of the promise who are regarded as offspring:** This clause is passive. Some languages must use an active clause. For example:

God regards the children of the promise as offspring

**the children of the promise:** This phrase refers to children born in Isaac's line of descent, because Isaac was born according to God's promise. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

the children of God's promise

those who are children because of God's promise

**regarded:** The Greek word here can also be translated as "consider" (8:18, 36).

**offspring:** Here this word refers only to those descendants of Abraham whom God chose to begin the people group called Israel. He first chose Isaac and then his son Jacob. These are the descendants of Abraham as God intended. For example:

Abraham's descendants (REB)

## Romans 9:9

### Section 9:6–13: The choices of God follow his purposes

In this section, Paul told the Romans that God's word has not failed. In the history of the Jews God had chosen some of them and not others. Paul gave some examples of this.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

God's promises do not fail

No one can change what God has chosen to do

#### 9:9a

##### For this is what the promise stated:

- For the/that promise of God is this:
- God promised Abraham like this:

**For:** This word introduces an explanation of how it was that Isaac was born according to a promise.

**this is what the promise stated:** This clause introduces what God told Abraham. Some languages introduce quotes from the Old Testament with a standard phrase. For example:

this is what God promised in the Holy Book

The Greek is literally "of-(the)-promise the word (is) this." It emphasizes the word promise. If possible, emphasize the word promise in your translation. For example:

the promise that God made/said to Abraham stated:

#### 9:9b–c

**"At the appointed time I will return, and Sarah will have a son":** These words are based on Genesis 18:10

and 18:14. If you indicate the location of quotes from the Old Testament with cross-references, you may want to do so here.

#### 9:9b

##### "At the appointed time I will return,

- "Next year at this time, I will come,

**At the appointed time:** The Greek is literally "according to this time/season." There are several ways to interpret this Greek phrase. Here are the main ones:

1. It implies about 12 months from now. For example:

At this time next year (CEV) (ESV, NJB, NASB, NLT, KJV, CEV, NET)

1. It refers to a time when it is proper for something to happen. For example:

At the right time (GNT) (GNT, GW, REB, NCV)

1. It refers to a time in the future that God has chosen. For example:

At the appointed time (NIV) (BSB, NIV) Longenecker and Fitzmyer also support this interpretation.

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1), because the BDAG supports it. BDAG (page 498) translates this phrase as "at this time." Sarah, of course, cannot conceive, go through 9 months of pregnancy and give birth all in a day or two. So the expression must refer to the same time of the year as at this time, but next year.

**I will return:** The Greek is literally "I will come." Many English versions translate it as in Genesis 18:10: I will return. But Paul, for his own reasons, used the verb "come" here. The KJV, NASB, and REB say:

I will come

#### 9:9c

##### and Sarah will have a son."

- and there will be a baby boy for Sarah."
- and your wife Sarah will then already have given birth to a/your son."

**Sarah will have a son:** The Greek is literally "(there) will be to Sarah a son." It implies that Sarah will become pregnant and give birth to a son. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

To Sarah will be a baby boy

Your wife Sarah will have given birth to a son

The Greek and the BSB translation indicate that Sarah will have already given birth before God visits Abraham again.

## Romans 9:10

### Section 9:6–13: The choices of God follow his purposes

In this section, Paul told the Romans that God's word has not failed. In the history of the Jews God had chosen some of them and not others. Paul gave some examples of this.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

God's promises do not fail

No one can change what God has chosen to do

#### 9:10a

#### Not only that, but

- And it is not only this/that.
- But that kind of thing/event happened again

**Not only that, but:** These words connect to Paul's statement in 9:6 that God's word has not failed. He first illustrated that fact by showing that the true descendants of Abraham are the children of the promise rather than of the flesh (9:7–9). This is now another illustration of how his word has not failed. Here are other ways to translate these words:

And not only that, but also (NABRE)

But not that thing/event alone, there is also

#### 9:10b

#### Rebecca's children were conceived by one man, our father Isaac.

- Rebekah became pregnant with twin/two babies/fetuses by/from one man, our<sup>(excl)</sup> ancestor Isaac.
- when one day our ancestor Isaac slept/lay with his wife Rebekah, and she conceived twin/two sons.

**Rebecca's children were conceived by one man:** The Greek word that the BSB translates as were conceived is literally "had-bed." It is an idiom that refers to sexual relations. It implies here that Jacob was conceived at the same time as Esau. That single sex act produced

two children. See Dunn (page 538, 542), Cranfield (page 470, 477), or Moo (page 570, 579). Here are other ways to translate this clause:

she had conceived twins by one man (NASB)

she was pregnant with two children by the one man (JBP)

one man fathered twins with/by Rebekah

## Romans 9:11

### Section 9:6–13: The choices of God follow his purposes

In this section, Paul told the Romans that God's word has not failed. In the history of the Jews God had chosen some of them and not others. Paul gave some examples of this.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

God's promises do not fail

No one can change what God has chosen to do

#### 9:11a

#### Yet before the twins were born

- And before they were born
- Before she gave birth to them,

**Yet before the twins were born:** The Greek is literally "for though having not yet been born." The word "for" introduces an explanation, but it is an explanation of something that is only implied. That is, in 9:10a Paul implied that what follows is another illustration of how God's word had not failed (9:6). The "for" connects to that implied statement and introduces an explanation. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

for, before they were born

for though the twins were not yet born (NASB)

In some languages it may be clearer to omit the conjunction and imply the connection. For example:

Even before they had been born (NRSV)

When Ribka was about to give birth Uma Back Translation on TW.

**the twins:** This refers to the two sons of Rebekah, Esau and Jacob.

#### 9:11b

**or had done anything good or bad,**

- and had not done anything good or worthless,
- and before they had done anything good or bad,

**bad:** The Greek word here often refers to something being worthless. It is different from the Greek word that is often translated “bad.” It refers to something not morally right.

#### 9:11c

**in order that God’s plan of election might stand,**

- so that God’s purpose would remain/stay as his choice only,
- the purpose of choosing one child and not the other stood according to how he chose.

**in order that God’s plan of election might stand:**

This is a purpose clause. God called Jacob before he and his brother were born so that it would be clear the choosing was not based on the deeds of either of them.

**God’s plan of election:** The Greek is more literally “the according-to-election purpose of God.” It indicates that God’s purpose was worked out through his own choice rather than for any other reason. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

God’s purpose according to His choice (NASB)

God’s purpose in election (NIV)

so that God’s plan would remain a matter of his choice (GW)

**election:** This word refers to God choosing the younger brother Jacob over the older brother. He chose him to be the founder of the nation of Israel. Here are other ways to translate this word:

choice (NJB)

God chooses (NLT)

**might stand:** Here the word might refers to something that should or will happen. The Greek word that the BSB translates as stand refers to something that stays and does not end. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

would stand (NASB)

would remain (GW)

## Romans 9:12

**Section 9:6–13: The choices of God follow his purposes**

In this section, Paul told the Romans that God’s word has not failed. In the history of the Jews God had chosen some of them and not others. Paul gave some examples of this.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

God’s promises do not fail

No one can change what God has chosen to do

### 9:12a

**not by works but by Him who calls,**

- because of him who calls and not because of someone’s deeds,
- His purpose was not based on a person’s deeds but on himself, the one who calls people to do his will.
- What he chooses does not depend on the actions of anyone. Instead, it depends on the one who chooses, God himself.

Some English versions place the words of 9:12a at the end of 9:11c. However, the Greek NT 5 has the words of 9:12a at the beginning of 9:12. The BSB follows this guidance. If the major language translation has it there, you may want to put your translation of 9:12a there.

**not by works but by Him who calls:** In some languages it is more natural to have the by part of this phrase before the not by reason. And some languages will use “and” instead of but. For example:

by him who calls and not by works

**works:** Here this word refers to actions or deeds, not things produced by a job or paid work. Here it refers to the actions or deeds of people, not God’s.

**calls:** Here the word calls means “chooses to be given a special benefit or purpose.” God chose Jacob to begin the nation of Israel. See how you translated this word in 1:6 or 8:28.

### 9:11–12

**(reordered) And although they were not yet born and had done nothing either good or bad, she was**

**told, “The older will serve the younger,” in order that God’s purpose of election might continue, not because of works but because of him who calls.**

- (reordered) She was told, “The older will serve the younger,” though they were not yet born and had done nothing either good or bad. God said that so that his purpose of election might continue, because of him who calls and not because of works.

#### **9:12b**

**she was told, “The older will serve the younger.”**

- as the Scripture says, she was told, “The older brother will be the servant of the younger brother.”
- In the Holy Book God said to her: “The first child will work for the second child.”

**she was told:** This clause is passive. God spoke to her. Some languages must use an active clause here. For example:

God/he told her

This clause introduces a quote from Scripture. Some language translations always introduce quotes from Scripture in their translations. For example:

In the Holy Book, she was told

In Scripture, God/he told her

**The older will serve the younger:** This sentence is found in Genesis 25:23. In the Hebrew culture (and many other cultures) the older sibling ruled the younger siblings. But God, to show his choice, would have the older sibling, Esau, serve the younger sibling, Jacob, instead.

If you indicate the location of quotes from the Old Testament with cross-references, you may want to do so here.

**serve:** Here this word refers to doing the work of someone else because he or she was told to do it. Jacob’s descendants would make Esau’s descendants their servants. Morris (page 356). Here are other ways to translate this word:

be servant (REB)

the younger one would rule his brother  
Otomi Back Translation on TW.

#### **General Comment on 9:11a–12b**

It may be clearer in some languages to have the choice (9:12b) before the circumstances (9:11a–b) and purpose of the timing (9:11c–12:a). For example:

<sup>11-12</sup>she was told, “The older will serve the younger,” in order that God’s plan of election might stand, not by works but by him who calls, even though the twins were not yet born and had done nothing either good or bad

<sup>11-12</sup>she was told, “The older will serve the younger,” in order that God’s plan of election might stand. That choice was not made by works but by him who calls, even though the twins were not yet born and had done nothing either good or bad.

Note that if you do this, you will need to combine the verse references into one reference.

### **Romans 9:13**

#### **Section 9:6–13: The choices of God follow his purposes**

In this section, Paul told the Romans that God’s word has not failed. In the history of the Jews God had chosen some of them and not others. Paul gave some examples of this.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

God’s promises do not fail

No one can change what God has chosen to do

#### **9:13**

**So it is written: “Jacob I loved, but Esau I hated.”**

- As someone wrote in Scriptures when God said, “It was Jacob whom I loved, but Esau, I hated him.”
- That is like what is written in God’s Word. Long ago God said, “I loved Jacob and hated Esau.”

**So it is written:** This phrase introduces a quote from the Old Testament. Paul quoted what God said to the nation of Israel (Malachi 1:2–3). See how you translated this phrase in 1:17 or 4:17.

**Jacob I loved:** The name Jacob is put before I loved in an English poetic grammar. In some languages it must be put in its normal position. In English this would be after the word loved.

**Esau I hated:** The name Esau is put before I hated in an English poetic grammar, as above with “Jacob I loved.”

## Romans 9:14

### Section 9:14–29: God always does what is right

In this section, Paul began by asking if God acts unjustly when he chooses some people and not others. Paul answered his own question with a strong “No!” All God’s choices depend on his mercy and not on anything about the people he chooses. God made Pharaoh the way he was when he wanted the Jews to leave Egypt.

Paul spoke to a possible complaint about no one ultimately being able to resist God’s will. He said that complaining to God about that is futile.

God shows his anger and power against people he has hardened. He does this to show how great his mercy is to other people. Both Jews and Gentiles are eligible to receive his mercy.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

God’s choices/will are/is sovereign/supreme

God chooses whom he wants for both Jews and Gentiles

### 9:14a

#### What then shall we say?

- ¶ So then, should we<sup>(incl)</sup> say this:
- ¶ And so, let’s not say that

**What then shall we say?:** The word then indicates a connection to previous verses. Here it introduces the question “What shall we say?” In some languages it is more natural to have the word then first. For example:

Then/Therefore, what shall we say?

**What...shall we say?:** This is a rhetorical question. It draws attention to what Paul said next. Paul did not expect the readers to answer this question. And he did not expect the readers to agree with what he said next. Here are other ways to translate this question:

Shall we say this?

What...are we to say? (NRSV)

what should we say about this? (NCV)

In some languages the correct meaning is indicated by using a statement instead of a question. For example:

Maybe we might say this:

See how you translated this question in 6:1 or 7:7.

### 9:14b

#### Is God unjust? Certainly not!

- Does God do things/deeds that are not right? Certainly not!
- God does wrong things. No indeed!

**Is God unjust?:** Since God chose Jacob over Esau before they were even born, Paul felt it was possible that someone could accuse God of not being just. That is the issue he raised with this question, but he went on to answer it with the strong words: “Certainly not!”

The Greek is literally “Not unrighteousness with God?” It asks if God might have been unfair to Esau (or any other example like him). The Greek expects a “No, he is not unfair” for an answer. If possible, translate in a way that expects a no answer. (Not all the questions below expect a no answer in English, but they might in your language.) Here are other ways to translate this question:

Is there injustice on God’s part? (ESV)

Is it possible that God might have been unfair?

Is it good to think that God was not right?

God is not unjust, is he?

It is wrong to think that God was not right!

**Certainly not!:** The Greek is literally “May it not be.” It indicates a very strong “no.” People are not to think that God was wrong about rejecting Esau. See how you translated this phrase in 3:4 or 7:13.

## Romans 9:15

### Section 9:14–29: God always does what is right

In this section, Paul began by asking if God acts unjustly when he chooses some people and not others. Paul answered his own question with a strong “No!” All God’s choices depend on his mercy and not on anything about the people he chooses. God made Pharaoh the way he was when he wanted the Jews to leave Egypt.

Paul spoke to a possible complaint about no one ultimately being able to resist God's will. He said that complaining to God about that is futile.

God shows his anger and power against people he has hardened. He does this to show how great his mercy is to other people. Both Jews and Gentiles are eligible to receive his mercy.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

God's choices/will are/is sovereign/supreme

God chooses whom he wants for both Jews and Gentiles

### 9:15a

#### For He says to Moses:

- For in the Scriptures he said to Moses,
- For in God's Word he said to Moses,

**For:** Here this word introduces a quote from the Old Testament that supports what Paul said in 9:14b.Cranfield (page 483).

**He says to Moses:** The Greek and the BSB use the present tense here. Greek scholars call it the historical present.They usually say it indicates vividness or prominence. In many languages the normal way of referring to a past event must be used. In English, this is the past tense. For example:

he said to Moses (GNT)

This clause introduces a quote from Scripture. Some language translations always note that in their translations. For example:

In Scripture he said to Moses

### 9:15b

#### "I will have mercy on whom I have mercy,

- "I will have mercy on whoever I choose to have mercy upon,
- "If I chose to be merciful to someone, I will be merciful to him/them.

### 9:15c

#### and I will have compassion on whom I have compassion."

- and I will have pity on whoever I choose to have pity upon."
- And if I want to show pity to someone, I will show pity to him/them."

### 9:15b-c

#### "I will have mercy on whom I have mercy, and I will have compassion on whom I have compassion":

The Hebrew language repeats a similar meaning for emphasis. It is a poetic form in Hebrew.

The Greek word that the BSB translates as have mercy refers to being concerned for someone in a bad situation and helping him in some way. This includes even forgiving him for something bad he did. The Greek word that the BSB translates as have compassion refers to being concerned or sad for someone in a bad situation. It may or may not imply helping the person.

Some languages will have two words, one for have mercy and one for have compassion. For example:

"I will show mercy to whom I will, I will take pity on whom I will." (NABRE)

"I am the one who rules/governs whom I will pity/ have mercy on. I am the one who rules as to whom I will have compassion for (lit. emotionally-stirred liver)."Yakan Back Translation on TW.

But it will be difficult in some languages to find two words that have such similar meanings. If that is true in your language, you may want to use just one word and use some other way than repetition to emphasize the words here. For example:

I will have mercy/pity on whom I chose to have mercy/pity on. Very true!

**I will have mercy on whom I have mercy:** This clause indicates that God chooses whom he will have mercy on. For example:

I will show mercy to anyone I choose (NLT)

I will be merciful to anyone I want to (GW)

**mercy:** This word refers to being concerned for someone in a bad situation and helping him in some way, including even forgiving him for something bad he did.

### General Comment on 9:15b-c

This quote is from Exodus 33:19. If you indicate the location of quotes from the Old Testament with cross-references, you may want to do so here.

## Romans 9:16

### Section 9:14–29: God always does what is right

In this section, Paul began by asking if God acts unjustly when he chooses some people and not others. Paul answered his own question with a strong “No!” All God’s choices depend on his mercy and not on anything about the people he chooses. God made Pharaoh the way he was when he wanted the Jews to leave Egypt.

Paul spoke to a possible complaint about no one ultimately being able to resist God’s will. He said that complaining to God about that is futile.

God shows his anger and power against people he has hardened. He does this to show how great his mercy is to other people. Both Jews and Gentiles are eligible to receive his mercy.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

God’s choices/will are/is sovereign/supreme

God chooses whom he wants for both Jews and Gentiles

### 9:16a

**So then, it does not depend on man’s desire or effort,**

- Therefore, it is not because some person decides God should do something or works hard to make God do it.
- So, people cannot make God show pity/mercy, either by their strength of will/thoughts or by their own labor.

**So then:** These words introduce a result that Paul wrote of based on what he wrote in 9:14–15. For example:

therefore (NIV)

**it does not depend on man’s desire or effort:** The Greek is literally “not of the one desiring/willing nor of the one running.” This clause refers to the question of who receives God’s mercy. Which person receives it is not determined by what people want or what they do. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

it is not a matter of what any person wants or what any person does (NJB)

God’s choice does not depend on a person’s desire or effort (GW)

it is God who decides to show mercy. We can neither choose it nor work for it. (NLT)

### 9:16b

**but on God’s mercy.**

- No, it is because the one/One who has mercy decides, namely, God.
- Instead, it is God; he chooses to whom he will be merciful.

**but on God’s mercy:** The Greek is literally “but of the one having mercy, God.” The word God makes clear who “the one having mercy” is. Like in 9:16a, these words connect to God’s mercy or God’s choosing to have mercy. Only God chooses upon whom he will have mercy. Here are other ways to translate these words:

it is only a matter of what the one/One having mercy decides, and he is God

but on God, the one who is merciful

it is the one who shows mercy to people, that is, God decides this/that

## Romans 9:17

### Section 9:14–29: God always does what is right

In this section, Paul began by asking if God acts unjustly when he chooses some people and not others. Paul answered his own question with a strong “No!” All God’s choices depend on his mercy and not on anything about the people he chooses. God made Pharaoh the way he was when he wanted the Jews to leave Egypt.

Paul spoke to a possible complaint about no one ultimately being able to resist God’s will. He said that complaining to God about that is futile.

God shows his anger and power against people he has hardened. He does this to show how great his mercy is to other people. Both Jews and Gentiles are eligible to receive his mercy.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

God’s choices/will are/is sovereign/supreme



God chooses whom he wants for both Jews and Gentiles

### 9:17a

#### For the Scripture says to Pharaoh:

- For in Scripture God said to Pharaoh,
- For in God's Word he said to the ruler of Egypt,

**For:** Here this word introduces a quote from the Old Testament that supports what Paul said in 9:16. Dunn (page 553) says, "The γάρ may introduce a second explanation of v 14 (Cranfield, Wilckens).... The use of γάρ suggests rather that Paul feels able to treat vv 17-18 as a development of v 16 (cf. Piper, 138-39)."

**the Scripture says to Pharaoh:** The Greek and the BSB use the present tense here, as in 9:15. In many languages the normal way of referring to a past event must be used. For example:

the Scripture said to Pharaoh

**the Scripture says:** In some languages it is not natural for a book to "say" anything. If that is true in your language, refer to God speaking and his words are found in Scripture. For example:

in the Scripture God says/said

**Pharaoh:** This title refers to the rulers over Egypt. Here it refers to the Pharaoh who ruled during the time of Exodus 9.

### 9:17b-d

**"I raised you up for this very purpose, that I might display My power in you, and that My name might be proclaimed in all the earth.":** This is a quote from Exodus 9:16, with small differences. The English versions put quote marks on these words. If you indicate the location of quotes from the Old Testament with cross-references, you may want to do so here.

### 9:17b

#### "I raised you up for this very purpose,

- "For this one purpose I caused you to be great,
- "I gave you authority to rule for one purpose only.

**I raised you up for this very purpose:** In the Greek, the phrase that the BSB translates as for this very purpose is in front of the main clause to emphasize it. In some language, this might be normal. For example:

For this very purpose I have raised you up (ESV)

However, other languages may need to place the words for this very purpose after up, as the BSB does.

**I raised you up:** Here the words raised...up refer to God causing this man to be king (Pharaoh) over the Egyptians. God also chose him to be hardhearted against the Israelites. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

I made you king (GNT)

I appointed you to rule Otomi Back Translation on TW.

**for this very purpose:** The Greek is literally "to/for this (thing) itself." Here it indicates that the purpose is stated in 9:17c-d. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

This is why (NABRE)

This is why I raised you up, namely, that...

That is the reason I raised you up. It is this: so that...

### 9:17c

#### that I might display My power in you,

- and it is that I will show my power through you,
- That purpose is that I will cause you to be the way I show people my power,

**that:** Here this word introduces a purpose clause. Here are other ways to translate this word:

to (NJB)

so that (CEV)

**I might display My power in you:** Here the word in indicates that God would show his power by means of what Pharaoh did. Pharaoh refused to let the Israelites go, and so God did a number of miracles to show his great power. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

show my power through you (NABRE)

use you to show my power (GNT)

**9:17d**

**and that My name might be proclaimed in all the earth.”**

- and that my name and who I am will be told throughout the earth.”
- and that people will spread my name and deeds in all places on earth.”

**My name might be proclaimed:** This clause is passive. Some languages must use an active clause. For example:

people might proclaim my name

The Greek word that the BSB translates as proclaimed refers to telling many people publicly so that the news spreads far. Here are other ways to translate this word:

spread my fame (GNT)

my name will become known in the many-towns/  
countriesKankanaey Back Translation on TW.

**My name:** This refers to God but also implies the quality of person he is and what he has done. In some languages that must be made explicit for the correct meaning. For example:

my name and who I am

**Romans 9:18****Section 9:14–29: God always does what is right**

In this section, Paul began by asking if God acts unjustly when he chooses some people and not others. Paul answered his own question with a strong “No!” All God’s choices depend on his mercy and not on anything about the people he chooses. God made Pharaoh the way he was when he wanted the Jews to leave Egypt.

Paul spoke to a possible complaint about no one ultimately being able to resist God’s will. He said that complaining to God about that is futile.

God shows his anger and power against people he has hardened. He does this to show how great his mercy is to other people. Both Jews and Gentiles are eligible to receive his mercy.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

God’s choices/will are/is sovereign/supreme

God chooses whom he wants for both Jews and Gentiles

**9:18a**

**Therefore God has mercy on whom He wants to have mercy,**

- Therefore, he has mercy on whoever he chooses to have mercy on,
- So, if he/God chooses to be merciful to someone, he will be merciful to him/them.

**Therefore:** These words introduce what Paul concluded from what he said in 9:17. For example:

So then, (ESV)

**God has mercy on whom He wants to have mercy:**

Here the word wants refers to God choosing someone. This clause says that God chooses those to whom he will have mercy. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

he has mercy on whomever he wills (ESV)

he has mercy on whomever he chooses (NRSV)

**9:18b**

**and He hardens whom He wants to harden.**

- and he makes stubborn whoever he chooses to make stubborn.
- And if he chooses to make someone’s heart/thinking unchangeable to the truth, he will do that to him/them.

**He hardens whom He wants to harden:** Here the word wants refers to God choosing someone. This clause says that God chooses those whom he will make hard/stubborn.

**hardens:** Here this word refers to causing someone to be stubborn, especially against what is true. Here are other ways to translate this word:

makes stubborn (GNT)

harden the hearts...so they refuse to listen (NLT)

**Romans 9:19****Section 9:14–29: God always does what is right**

In this section, Paul began by asking if God acts unjustly when he chooses some people and not others. Paul answered his own question with a strong “No!”

All God's choices depend on his mercy and not on anything about the people he chooses. God made Pharaoh the way he was when he wanted the Jews to leave Egypt.

Paul spoke to a possible complaint about no one ultimately being able to resist God's will. He said that complaining to God about that is futile.

God shows his anger and power against people he has hardened. He does this to show how great his mercy is to other people. Both Jews and Gentiles are eligible to receive his mercy.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

God's choices/will are/is sovereign/supreme

God chooses whom he wants for both Jews and Gentiles

#### 9:19a

##### **One of you will say to me,**

- ¶ So, you<sup>(sing)</sup> will/might ask me,
- ¶ And/Now/But certainly someone will ask me,

**One of you will say to me:** In the Greek, a word that is usually translated as "then" or "therefore" connects One of you will say to me to what Paul said in 9:14–18. The BSB omits this word. However, many English versions include it. For example:

You will say to me then... (ESV)

In many languages this word must be first in the clause. For example:

Then you will say...

So, you will say...

Some languages will use a different word to connect "You will say to me" to 9:18 in a natural way. For example:

And you will say...

Now you will say...

**One of you:** The word you is singular in the Greek. This letter is addressed to the whole church in Rome. So, here the singular you refers to someone in a general

way. Moo (page 600) says, "We need not identify a specific opponent." It does not accuse the whole church in Rome of asking the following questions of Paul. Jewett (page 590). Some languages must translate differently for the correct meaning. For example:

certainly there will some person who  
Uma Back  
Translation on TW.

maybe someone

**will say to me:** 9:19b–c are questions. In some languages the word "ask" will be more natural. For example:

ask me (NJB)

#### 9:19b

##### **"Then why does God still find fault?"**

- "Why does he then blame us for doing bad things?"
- "Why does he/God still accuse people of wrongdoing?"

**Then why does God still find fault?:** There is a textual issue here. The Greek word that the BSB translates as Then means "then, therefore." It occurs in some Greek manuscripts after the word translated why. There are two options:

1. It should be included. For example:

How then can he ever blame anyone...? (NJB) (BSB, NIV, GNT, NJB, NRSV, NABRE, REB, NCV)

1. It should be omitted. For example:

Why does he still find fault? (RSV) (RSV, NASB, KJV, ESV, NLT, CEV, GW, NET)

It is recommended that you follow option (1), because the Greek NT 5 includes it. They put it in brackets, indicating that they are not certain. But they did decide to include it.

This is a rhetorical question. It emphasizes the meaning of "God should not find fault (with anyone)." This hypothetical person thinks that God should not find fault with any person. Translate this clause with that meaning. Here are some ways:

- As a rhetorical question. For example:

Then why does God blame us for our sins? (NCV)

- As a statement. For example:

He should not blame is for our sins.

All the English versions in Translator's Workplace and all the commentators consulted translate this as a question.

**find fault:** This phrase refers to accusing someone of wrongdoing. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

blame (NJB)

accuse people of sin

### 9:19c

#### For who can resist His will?"

- For who opposes his desire/plan?"
- For no one overturns anything he plans to do."

**For:** This word introduces an explanation for the question in 9:19b, Jewett (page 591). or gives a basis for that question.

**who can resist His will?:** This is a rhetorical question. It emphasizes that no one can resist God's will. Translate this clause with that meaning. Here are some ways:

- As a rhetorical question. For example:

who can oppose his will? (NABRE)

- As a statement. For example:

no one can oppose his will (NJB)

**who can resist:** The Greek word that the BSB translates as can resist uses the perfect tense in the Greek. Here it indicates an ongoing situation. For example:

who resists his will (NIV)

It indicates that when God decides something, no one has ever changed what he decides into something else. It implies that no one is able to change his decisions, so some translations use can resist.

**resist:** This word refers to opposing something. Here it implies successfully gaining victory over it. For example, if God decided someone will die, no one can

change that outcome. Here are other ways to translate this word:

oppose (NJB)

fight (NCV)

**His will:** Here the word will refers to making a decision. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

what God wants Kankanaey Back Translation on TW.

his determined-plan Tagbanwa Back Translation on TW.

#### General Comment on 9:19b–c

The basis (9:19c) occurs after the conclusion (9:19b). In some languages it is more natural to have the conclusion last. For example:

No one can resist his will. Then why does God still find fault?

No one can resist his will. Then God should not still find fault!

### 9:19b–c

#### (reordered) "Who can resist his will, so why does he still find fault?"

- (reordered) "No one overturns anything he/God plans to do. So why does he still accuse people of wrongdoing?"

## Romans 9:20

### Section 9:14–29: God always does what is right

In this section, Paul began by asking if God acts unjustly when he chooses some people and not others. Paul answered his own question with a strong "No!" All God's choices depend on his mercy and not on anything about the people he chooses. God made Pharaoh the way he was when he wanted the Jews to leave Egypt.

Paul spoke to a possible complaint about no one ultimately being able to resist God's will. He said that complaining to God about that is futile.

God shows his anger and power against people he has hardened. He does this to show how great his mercy

is to other people. Both Jews and Gentiles are eligible to receive his mercy.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

God's choices/will are/is sovereign/supreme

God chooses whom he wants for both Jews and Gentiles

### 9:20a

#### **But who are you, O man, to talk back to God?**

- But, O/you<sup>(sing)</sup> human being, who are you to talk back to God?
- But you are only a person/human, and you should not criticize God.

**But who are you, O man, to talk back to God?:** This is also a rhetorical question. It emphasizes that no one is worthy enough to answer back to God. Translate this clause with that meaning. Here are some ways:

- As a rhetorical question. For example:

But who indeed are you, a human being, to talk back to God? (NABRE)

- As a statement. For example:

You are only human, and human beings have no right to question God. (NCV)

**But who are you, O man:** There are two ways to interpret the Greek words that the BSB translates as O man:

1. It is a direct address to the person or persons to whom Paul spoke as you. For example:

On the contrary, who are you, O man (NASB) (BSB, NIV, GNT, ESV, NASB, KJV, CEV)

1. It is a description of the person or persons to whom Paul spoke as you. For example:

But you—who do you think you, a human being, are (NJB) (RSV, NIV11, NJB, NABRE, NET, NLT, NCV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1), because these words are in the emphatic position in the Greek rather than after the Greek word that means you as a description of you. But if the major language

version follow interpretation (2), you may want to follow that.

The phrase of address, O man, can refer to either a man or a woman. It occurs in the middle of the clause. In many languages it must be first in the clause. For example:

But, O/you person/human, who are you

**But:** The Greek word here indicates strong contrast. For example:

But...indeed (NABRE)

On the contrary, (NASB)

**talk back to God:** The Greek word that the BSB translates as talk back here implies that this person speaks to God to criticize or argue. L&N (on TW) and L&S (page 458), respectively. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

argue back to God (ESV)

criticize God

argue-with God Kankanaey Back Translation on TW.

### 9:20b

#### **Shall what is formed say to Him who formed it,**

- Should the thing that someone created say to the one who created it,
- It is not right for something to criticize the one who made it by asking,

### 9:20c

#### **“Why did You make me like this?”**

- “Why did you make me in this way?”

### 9:20b–c

**Shall what is formed say to Him who formed it, “Why did You make me like this?”:** There are two issues here:

Issue 1: Partial quotation

The first part (Shall what is formed say to Him who formed it) occurs in Isaiah 29:16. The second part (“Why did You make me like this?”) takes the general idea of questioning the maker as found in the questions in Isaiah 29:16. It is reworded to connect more

clearly to what Paul had been saying. See Dunn (page 556). So many translations, like the BSB, do not punctuate it like a quote from Isaiah. Paul did not introduce these words with the usual introduction of a quote from Scripture, for example, “as it is written.”

The BSB, the ESV, and the CEV still put in a footnote to refer to Isaiah 29:16 (and 45:9). Isaiah 45:9 has the molded asking questions of the molder as in 29:16, but does not have the words “Will what is molded say to its molder.” This author would recommend making the cross reference only to Isaiah 29:16. But the NLT and the GW do not. But other translations punctuate it like a quote from the Old Testament. For example:

“Shall what is formed say to him who formed it,  
“Why did you make me like this?” ” (NIV)

The NIV also references this as a quote from Isaiah 29:16 (and 45:9). See what the major language version in your area does. Or, follow the example of the BSB.

#### Issue 2: Rhetorical question

This is a rhetorical question. It indicates that the created thing should not ask the one who created it, “Why have you made me like this?” It implies that people should not criticize God, who made them, asking why he made them that way. Translate this clause with that meaning. Here are some ways:

- As a rhetorical question. For example:

Should the thing that was created say to the one who created it, “Why have you made me like this?” (NLT)

- As a statement. For example:

An object should not ask the person who made it,  
“Why did you make me like this?” (NCV)

#### **Shall what is formed say to Him who formed it:**

This is a metaphor that is explained in 9:21. Here the words what is formed refers to something made of clay. The words Him who formed it refers to the person who forms a lump of clay into the shape he wants, specifically, in this case, God. In this metaphor the thing made of clay complains to the person who made it. The metaphor refers figuratively to a person, whom God made, who complains to God about why he made him that way. It implies that it is wrong for people to complain to God like that. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

Will what is molded say to its molder (ESV)

Will what is made say to its maker (NABRE)

Should the thing that was created say to the one who created it (NLT)

Can the pot say to the potter (REB)

In some languages it is unnatural or confusing for something not alive, like a clay pot, to speak. If that is true in your language, translate the meaning without the figurative language. For example:

Can we who are just made, ask Him who made us, saying Western Bukidnon Manobo Back Translation on TW.

## **Romans 9:21**

### **Section 9:14–29: God always does what is right**

In this section, Paul began by asking if God acts unjustly when he chooses some people and not others. Paul answered his own question with a strong “No!” All God’s choices depend on his mercy and not on anything about the people he chooses. God made Pharaoh the way he was when he wanted the Jews to leave Egypt.

Paul spoke to a possible complaint about no one ultimately being able to resist God’s will. He said that complaining to God about that is futile.

God shows his anger and power against people he has hardened. He does this to show how great his mercy is to other people. Both Jews and Gentiles are eligible to receive his mercy.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

God’s choices/will are/is sovereign/supreme

God chooses whom he wants for both Jews and Gentiles

#### **9:21a–c**

This verse illustrates that it is right for God to decide as he wants, even regarding people. It uses the example of someone who makes things with clay. He can choose as he wants what he will use each thing for.

**Does not the potter have the right to make from the same lump of clay one vessel for special occasions and another for common use?:** This is a rhetorical

question. It emphasizes that the potter has the right to make some things for honorable use and some things for dishonorable use from the same lump of clay. Translate this clause with that meaning. Here are some ways:

- As a rhetorical question. For example:

Doesn't a potter have the right to make a fancy bowl and a plain bowl out of the same lump of clay? (CEV)

- As a statement. For example:

Surely the potter has the right to make from the same lump of clay one vessel for special occasions and another for common/regular use.

He can make something for a special occasion or something for everyday use from the same lump of clay. (GW)

#### 9:21a

##### **Does not the potter have the right**

- Does not the person who makes things from clay have the authority/power over them
- Surely the clay pot maker has the right to use the clay as he wants.

#### 9:21a-b

**potter...clay:** The word potter refers to someone who makes things with clay. Often he made clay pots, thus the name potter. Some languages will not have a single word for this kind of person. For example:

The one who makes plates and such from clayYongkom Back Translation, unpublished manuscript, Papua New Guinea.

the person who makes cups and things from earthMengen Back Translation, unpublished manuscript, Papua New Guinea.

In some languages people are unfamiliar with clay. If that is true in your language, you may want to:

- Explain it in your translation. For example:

the person who makes hard things with sticky/pliable earth/soil and then bakes them

the person who makes things with sticky/pliable earth/soil and then bakes them to make them hard

- Use major language word for clay.

the one who makes things with kleiUsing the Dutch word for clay.

- Use a familiar substitute. For example:

The man that makes the basketAmanab Back Translation, unpublished manuscript, Papua New Guinea.

the woman who makes a woven-bag

**right:** Here this word refers to having the authority and power to do as one chooses. Here are other ways to translate this word:

power (KJV)

can do what he likes (REB)

#### 9:21b

##### **to make from the same lump of clay**

- to make from one chunk of it/clay
- From one amount/piece he can make

**lump of clay:** Here this word refers to an amount of something solid, of one piece, and of no particular size or shape. Here are other ways to translate this word:

clumpYakan Back Translation on TW.

hunk

If you used a substitute for clay in 9:21a, you should use an appropriate word for a group of the material used. For example:

(basket)...bundle

(woven-bag)...bark

#### 9:21c

##### **one vessel for special occasions and another for common use?**

- one container for deeds of honor and another one for shameful deeds?
- something to use for deeds that honor someone and something else to use for disreputable/vulgar deeds.

**vessel:** Here this word refers to any kind of container or thing that people use to put things in or on, including plates, cups, baskets, pots, jars, and so on. Here is another English word:

container

Some languages must use a more specific word or a more general word here. For example:

jar/pot/bowl

thing

**for special occasions:** This clay vessel brings honor, for example, someone may give one to guests for them to use at a feast, or it might be something a priest uses at the temple to honor God. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

for noble purposes (NIV)

for valuable uses Kankanaey Back Translation on TW.

**for common use:** There are two main ways to interpret the Greek word that the BSB translates as common use:

1. It means dishonorable here. For example:

for an ignoble one (NABRE) (KJV, ESV, NABRE, NLT)

1. It means ordinary here. For example:

for menial use (RSV) (BSB, NIV, GNT, NJB, NASB, REB, NET, GW, NCV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1), because it is the much more common meaning of the word.

## Romans 9:22

### Section 9:14–29: God always does what is right

In this section, Paul began by asking if God acts unjustly when he chooses some people and not others. Paul answered his own question with a strong “No!” All God’s choices depend on his mercy and not on anything about the people he chooses. God made Pharaoh the way he was when he wanted the Jews to leave Egypt.

Paul spoke to a possible complaint about no one ultimately being able to resist God’s will. He said that complaining to God about that is futile.

God shows his anger and power against people he has hardened. He does this to show how great his mercy is to other people. Both Jews and Gentiles are eligible to receive his mercy.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

God’s choices/will are/is sovereign/supreme

God chooses whom he wants for both Jews and Gentiles

### 9:22a–24b

The words of 9:22–24 are all a part of a long question in the Greek. Some scholars end the question at the end of 9:23. But 9:24 begins with “and whom,” which probably indicates a continuation from the “vessels of mercy” in 9:23. Some English versions end the question at the end of 9:22. But 9:23 begins with “and that,” which probably indicates that the third purpose clause continues from the two purpose clauses in 9:22. But these English versions may be just breaking up the long question into several questions and/or sentences to make it easier to read, as the NIV makes clear by repeating “what if” and adding “he did this” at the beginning of 9:23 to show the continuation. The main part of the question is: “What if God has endured with much patience vessels of wrath?” There are three purposes introduced with the word “desiring”: (1) to show his wrath, (2) to make known his power, and (3) to make known the riches of his glory for vessels of mercy. The phrase “prepared for destruction” describes the vessels of wrath. The words “whom He prepared in advance for glory—including us, whom He has called not only from the Jews, but also from the Gentiles” describe the vessels of mercy. Paul was not questioning these purposes and descriptions.



In some languages it is more clear to have the question separate from the purposes and the long description of the vessels of mercy. For example:

Intending to show his wrath and make his power known, what if God bore with great patience the vessels of his wrath, prepared for destruction?<sup>23</sup>He did that in order to make the riches of his glory known to vessels of his mercy, whom he prepared in advance for glory—<sup>24</sup>including us, whom he has called not only from the Jews, but also from the Gentiles.

What if God bore with great patience the vessels of his wrath, prepared for destruction? He did that because he intended to show his wrath and make his power known,<sup>23</sup>and in order to make the riches of his glory known to vessels of his mercy, whom he prepared in advance for glory—<sup>24</sup>including us, whom he has called not from the Jews, but also from the Gentiles.

**What if God...bore with great patience the vessels of His wrath, prepared for destruction...to make the riches of His glory known to the vessels of His mercy:** The Greek does not have a “then” clause to go with the if-clause. Moo (page 604) says, “Such a construction is not unusual in Greek (cf. LSJ, 481) and is found in the NT (Luke 19:42; John 6:62; Acts 23:9).” So the BSB and many English versions add the word What to give the sentence the right meaning in English. Here is another way to translate this:

But suppose that God... (NJB)

This is a rhetorical question. Here the word if introduces a situation that is true. If this first part is true, that supports the second part (“to make known the riches of his glory”) to also be true. Together they emphasize that God does endure with much patience the vessels of wrath. Translate this with that meaning. Here are some ways:

- As a rhetorical question. For example:

What if God...has endured with much patience the vessels of wrath made for destruction? This was to make known the riches of his glory to the vessels of mercy.... (NABRE)

- As a statement. For example:

But/And God...bore with great patience the vessels of his wrath...to make the riches of his glory known to vessels of his mercy...

#### 9:22a

##### **What if God, intending to show His wrath**

- ¶ But what if God, wanting to show his anger
- ¶ But suppose God wants to show that he is angry with some people

**show His wrath:** The word wrath refers to anger. This word is a noun. In some languages a different kind of word must be used. For example:

show that he is angry

show-anger-atUma Back Translation on TW.

#### 9:22b

##### **and make His power known,**

- and to reveal his power,
- and to make people understand how powerful he is.

**make His power known:** These words indicate that God wants people to understand that he is powerful. Here are other ways to translate these words:

to...reveal his power (GW)

to let people see his power (NCV)

#### 9:22c

##### **bore with great patience the vessels of His wrath,**

- has waited calmly to show his anger concerning the containers of his anger?
- And so he patiently holds back his anger toward the people to whom he will one day show it.

**bore with great patience:** These words indicate that God waited with calmness in order to express his anger later. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

he has with great patience tolerated (REB)

he patiently put up with them (CEV)

waited with much calmness

**the vessels of His wrath:** The word vessels refers to things a potter makes, as in 9:21. Here it is a metaphor

for people with whom God is angry and to whom he will one day show that anger.

In some languages the meaning of the metaphor will not be clear. If that is true in your language, you may want to:

- Translate the literal meaning and explain it in a footnote. Here is an example footnote:

The words “vessels of His wrath” refers to people with whom God is angry and to whom he will one day show that anger.

- Translate without the metaphor. For example:

people to whom God will one day show his anger

- You may then want to indicate what the literal words are in a footnote. Here is an example footnote:

Literally “vessels of His wrath.”

#### **9:22d prepared for destruction?**

- They have been made ready to be destroyed/ruined.
- God/He has made them fit for him/he to destroy them.

**prepared for destruction:** This clause further describes the vessels of wrath. It does not separate these vessels of wrath from other vessels of wrath. For the correct meaning in some languages, translators must avoid the implied word “who.” For example:

and they are prepared for destruction

This clause is passive. Some languages must use an active clause. For example:

and God has prepared them for destruction

**prepared:** This word indicates that God has made these people ready for judgment day when he will destroy them. Here are other ways to translate this word:

made fit

made ready

**for destruction:** The word destruction refers to ruining something so much as to be completely useless and not repairable. The noun destruction refers to an event. Some languages must use a verb for this event. For example:

to be completely ruined

for God/him to destroy

### **Romans 9:23**

#### **Section 9:14–29: God always does what is right**

In this section, Paul began by asking if God acts unjustly when he chooses some people and not others. Paul answered his own question with a strong “No!” All God’s choices depend on his mercy and not on anything about the people he chooses. God made Pharaoh the way he was when he wanted the Jews to leave Egypt.

Paul spoke to a possible complaint about no one ultimately being able to resist God’s will. He said that complaining to God about that is futile.

God shows his anger and power against people he has hardened. He does this to show how great his mercy is to other people. Both Jews and Gentiles are eligible to receive his mercy.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

God’s choices/will are/is sovereign/supreme

God chooses whom he wants for both Jews and Gentiles

#### **9:23a**

#### **What if He did this to make the riches of His glory known to the vessels of His mercy,**

- God does that to make known his vast/great glory/majesty to the containers of his mercy,
- God is patient so that the people on whom he has mercy will know his splendor/greatness.

**What if He did this to:** The Greek begins with the word “and.” It shows that 9:23 is another purpose, in addition to showing his wrath (9:22a) and making known his power (9:22b). For example:

And that (KJV)

If you have ended 9:22 with a question mark or full stop, you should indicate that the thought from the main clause continues here. For example:

And he also wanted to.... (GNT)

As mentioned in the note on 9:22–24, this is one long question in the Greek. For example, the BSB makes 9:23–24 into a question too. But Paul was not questioning what he said in 9:23–24, so in some languages a statement would make the meaning more clear here. For example:

<sup>23</sup>This was to make known the riches of his glory to the vessels of mercy, which he has prepared previously for glory, <sup>24</sup>namely, us whom he has called, not only from the Jews but also from the Gentiles. (NABRE)

Note that the NABRE adds the words “This was” at the beginning of 9:23 to make the correct connection to 9:22.

**the riches of His glory:** Here the word riches refers to an abundance of God’s glory. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

his abundant glory (GNT)

his incomparable glory/praiseworthinessTag-banwa Back Translation on TW.

If you have translated Ephesians 1:18, 3:16, or Colossians 1:27, see how you translated this phrase there.

**glory:** The word glory refers literally to a very bright light. In this context it implies power, majesty, and greatness. Here are other ways to translate this word:

majesty

greatness

See how you translated this word in 3:23 or 9:4.

**to:** Here this Greek word indicates that God will make known his great glory to his people (here in this verse they are called “vessels of mercy”). For example:

upon vessels of mercy (NASB)

to the vessels of mercy (NABRE)

**the vessels of His mercy:** The word vessels refers to things a potter makes, as in 9:21–22. Here it is a metaphor for people upon whom God has mercy.

In some languages the meaning of the metaphor will not be clear. If that is true in your language, you may want to:

- Translate the literal meaning and explain it in a footnote. Here is an example footnote:

The words “vessels of His mercy” refers to people upon whom God has mercy.

- Translate without the metaphor. For example:

people to whom God has mercy

- You may then want to indicate what the literal words are in a footnote. Here is an example footnote:

Literally “vessels of His mercy.”

#### **9:23b whom He prepared in advance for glory—**

- and he has made them ready previously to be given glory/majesty.
- He prepared them earlier for the day when he will give splendor/greatness to them.

**whom He prepared in advance:** Here the word whom introduces something more Paul said about the vessels of mercy. In some languages a literal translation would wrongly indicate that God prepared only some vessels of mercy beforehand. If that is true in your language, translate in a way that indicates that God prepared all the vessels of mercy beforehand. For example:

and he has prepared them beforehand

He prepared them beforehand

**He prepared in advance:** In the metaphor of vessels, the phrase in advance refers to the potter making them some time before he planned to use them. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

he has prepared beforehand (ESV)

he made ready earlier

**for glory:** The word for introduces the purpose for God preparing the vessels of mercy beforehand. He will give them glory.

**glory:** This refers to the glory that God will give his people (for example, 2:10) and that his people will share in Jesus' glory (for example, 8:17). See how you translated this word in 8:17 or 9:23a.

## Romans 9:24

### Section 9:14–29: God always does what is right

In this section, Paul began by asking if God acts unjustly when he chooses some people and not others. Paul answered his own question with a strong “No!” All God's choices depend on his mercy and not on anything about the people he chooses. God made Pharaoh the way he was when he wanted the Jews to leave Egypt.

Paul spoke to a possible complaint about no one ultimately being able to resist God's will. He said that complaining to God about that is futile.

God shows his anger and power against people he has hardened. He does this to show how great his mercy is to other people. Both Jews and Gentiles are eligible to receive his mercy.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

God's choices/will are/is sovereign/supreme

God chooses whom he wants for both Jews and Gentiles

### 9:24a

#### including us, whom He has called

- It is us<sup>(incl)</sup>. He also called us,
- He/God chose those vessels/people, and I speak of us ourselves.

**including us, whom He has called:** The Greek is literally “whom also/even he called us.” The word us then explains whom He has called, which describes the vessels of mercy. Cranfield (pages 497–498) and Morris (page 369). All three words or phrases refer to believers in Jesus. Here are other ways to translate these words:

whom he also called, namely, us

He also called those vessels/people to faith. This refers to us

**called:** Here the word called means “chosen to be given a special benefit or purpose.” God invites people to believe in Jesus. Some of them have accepted and become believers in Jesus. See how you translated this word in 1:6 or 8:30.

### 9:24b

#### not only from the Jews, but also from the Gentiles?

- and he chose us not only from the Jew people but also from the non-Jewish people.
- Some of us believers are Jews, but some of us are non-Jews.

#### not only from the Jews, but also from the Gentiles:

This describes the pronoun “us” here. Some believers are Jews and some are Gentiles. The words not only... but also emphasizes that God called Gentiles too.

**from...from:** The word from indicates that God called some Jews and some Gentiles.

**Gentiles:** This word refers to people who are not Jews. See how you translated this word in 1:5 or 3:29.

## Romans 9:25

### Section 9:14–29: God always does what is right

In this section, Paul began by asking if God acts unjustly when he chooses some people and not others. Paul answered his own question with a strong “No!” All God's choices depend on his mercy and not on anything about the people he chooses. God made Pharaoh the way he was when he wanted the Jews to leave Egypt.

Paul spoke to a possible complaint about no one ultimately being able to resist God's will. He said that complaining to God about that is futile.

God shows his anger and power against people he has hardened. He does this to show how great his mercy is to other people. Both Jews and Gentiles are eligible to receive his mercy.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

God's choices/will are/is sovereign/supreme

God chooses whom he wants for both Jews and Gentiles

### 9:25a

#### As He says in Hosea:

- Just as he/God certainly said in the book of Hosea a long time ago,

- It/That is like what God said long ago in Hosea in God's Word,

**As:** This word introduces support for what Paul said in 9:24. Some languages must use a full clause here. For example:

It is as/like

That talk is like

The Greek has a word that is usually translated as "indeed" here. It probably emphasizes what follows. Here are other ways to translate this word:

in fact

certainly

But some English versions, such as the BSB, do not translate this word.

**He says:** The Greek and the BSB use the present tense here, as in 9:15. Greek scholars call it the historical present. In many languages the normal way of referring to a past event must be used. For example:

he said

**He:** Here this word refers to God.

**in Hosea:** Here the name Hosea refers to the Old Testament book of Hosea. In some languages all or some of that information will need to be made clear. For example:

in the book of Hosea

in the book of Hosea in Scripture

**Hosea:** The prophet Hosea lived about eight hundred years before Paul. In some languages a literal translation would imply that Hosea wrote about the same time as Paul. If that is true in your language, indicate that it was many years before Paul. For example:

Hosea long ago

#### 9:25b-c

These words are from Hosea 2:23, but it is not an exact quote. However, God spoke in 9:25b-c, so quote marks are needed in English. If you indicate the location of

quotes from the Old Testament with cross-references, you may want to do so here.

Paul used these words in Hosea to imply a promise for the Gentiles. In the context of the book of Hosea, these words refer to the ten clans of Israel who had rebelled against God. You should not add the word "Gentiles" in this quote.

#### 9:25b

**"I will call them 'My People' who are not My people,**

- "I will call those who are not my people that they are now my people.
- "The people who formerly did not belong to me, I will count them as belonging to me.

**I will call them 'My People':** Here God promised to begin or restart a relationship with the people who he formerly said were not his people. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

I will call them my people

I will now call my people Tagbanwa Back Translation on TW.

I will count them as my people Kankanaey Back Translation on TW.

**who are not My people:** This refers to people whom God did not consider to be his people. They did not have a relationship with him or that relationship was completely broken. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

The people who were not mine (GNT)

People who were formerly not my people Tagbanwa Back Translation on TW.

#### 9:25c

**and I will call her 'My Beloved' who is not My beloved,"**

- And I will call her who was not loved that she is now loved."
- And she/her whom formerly I did not love, I will call her my loved one."

**I will call her 'My Beloved' who is not My beloved:** In Hosea 2:23, the word her refers to Hosea's wife. Here it is used poetically to refer to the same group as "those who were not my people" in 9:25b. In some languages a literal translation would not refer to the same group

of people. If that is true in your language, you may want to explain the meaning in a footnote. Here is an example footnote:

Here, Paul used “her” to refer to the same group of people as “those who were not my people.”

**I will call her ‘My Beloved’:** Here God promised to love the people who he formerly did not love as his people.

**who is not My beloved:** The word beloved refers to someone who is loved. Here are other ways to translate this word:

who was unloved (NET)

whom I did not love before (NLT)

## Romans 9:26

### Section 9:14–29: God always does what is right

In this section, Paul began by asking if God acts unjustly when he chooses some people and not others. Paul answered his own question with a strong “No!” All God’s choices depend on his mercy and not on anything about the people he chooses. God made Pharaoh the way he was when he wanted the Jews to leave Egypt.

Paul spoke to a possible complaint about no one ultimately being able to resist God’s will. He said that complaining to God about that is futile.

God shows his anger and power against people he has hardened. He does this to show how great his mercy is to other people. Both Jews and Gentiles are eligible to receive his mercy.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

God’s choices/will are/is sovereign/supreme

God chooses whom he wants for both Jews and Gentiles

### 9:26a–c

This is a quote of the latter part of Hosea 1:10. If you indicate the location of quotes from the Old Testament with cross-references, you may want to do so here.

In some languages a new quote is introduced again as Scripture. For example:

And the Holy Book also says, “It will happen...

### 9:26a

**and, “It will happen that in the very place where it was said to them,**

- “And in the same location where this was said to them,
- Also, in God’s Book is this: “In the same place where God said to them,

**in the very place:** This refers to an exact location. In the context of Hosea, it might be Jerusalem, or the region of Judah, or the land of the ten northern tribes of Israel, or it might be the lands where the Assyrians took them. It is not important here which place this is. Use a word that can refer to a city or a piece of land or a region. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

in the same location

in the landYakan Back Translation on TW.

**it was said to them:** This clause is passive. Some languages must use an active clause. For example:

God said

### 9:26b

**‘You are not My people,’**

- ‘You<sup>(plur)</sup> are not my people,’
- ‘You do not belong to me,’

### 9:26c

**they will be called ‘sons of the living God.’”**

- they will be named there ‘children of the God who lives always.’”
- there God/people will name them, ‘children of the alive God.’”

### 9:26b–c

**they will be called:** This clause is passive. Some languages must use an active clause. It is not clear whether this refers to God calling them or people in general calling them “the sons of the living God.” For example:

people/God will call them

**sons:** Here this word refers to children, both sons and daughters. For example:

children (NJB)

**the living God:** The word living here refers to God being alive, as opposed to idols, which are not alive. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

the alive God This expression should not imply in your language that He is one of many “gods.”

the God who lives forever

## Romans 9:27

### Section 9:14–29: God always does what is right

In this section, Paul began by asking if God acts unjustly when he chooses some people and not others. Paul answered his own question with a strong “No!” All God’s choices depend on his mercy and not on anything about the people he chooses. God made Pharaoh the way he was when he wanted the Jews to leave Egypt.

Paul spoke to a possible complaint about no one ultimately being able to resist God’s will. He said that complaining to God about that is futile.

God shows his anger and power against people he has hardened. He does this to show how great his mercy is to other people. Both Jews and Gentiles are eligible to receive his mercy.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

God’s choices/will are/is sovereign/supreme

God chooses whom he wants for both Jews and Gentiles

### 9:27–28

These words are from Isaiah 10:22–23, but it is not an exact quote. However, Isaiah spoke in 9:27b–28b, so quote marks are needed in English. If you indicate the location of quotes from the Old Testament with cross-references, you may want to do so here.

### 9:27a

#### Isaiah cries out concerning Israel:

- And/But long ago Isaiah called out about the people of Israel,
- The prophet Isaiah said in Scripture about the Israelites,

The Greek of 9:27a begins with a word that can be translated “and” or “but.” A number of English versions want to indicate that Paul quoted the Old Testament again, so they use “and” (ESV). It is also possible to see contrast between God speaking of only

a remnant of Israel being saved and some Gentiles being called “sons of the living God.” For example:

But (REB)

In some languages it is more natural to omit this word and allow the context to indicate the correct meaning, as the BSB does.

**Isaiah cries out concerning Israel:** This clause introduces an Old Testament quote that Isaiah wrote hundreds of years before Paul wrote Romans. In some languages some or all of this must be explained. For example:

in Scripture Isaiah cried out about Israel long ago

**Isaiah:** Isaiah was an Old Testament prophet, and his book has many prophecies. In some languages it is more clear for the readers to indicate that Isaiah was a prophet. For example:

the prophet Isaiah (CEV)

**cries out:** The phrase cries out indicates speaking strongly with urgency. In some languages a literal translation would refer only to weeping or wailing. If that is true in your language, translate the correct meaning. For example:

exclaims (GNT)

makes this proclamation (REB)

said loudly/urgently

The Greek and the BSB use the present tense here, as in 9:15. Greek scholars call it the historical present. In many languages the normal way of referring to a past event must be used, as in the last example above.

**Israel:** Here this word refers to the people group called Israel.

### 9:27b

**“Though the number of the Israelites is like the sand of the sea,**

- “Even if the count of the people of Israel is as the count of the grains of sand of the seashore,
- “One day the Israelite people might become very many like the number of the grains of sand at the edges of the oceans.

**Though:** The form of this Greek clause expresses something that is possible but not certain. Here, in the case where the number of the people of Israel might become as much as the sand of the seashore, only a portion (the remnant) will be saved (9:27c).

**the number of the Israelites is like the sand of the sea:** This clause compares the number of the people of Israel to the number of grains of sand on the seashore. It is a poetic exaggeration to say “very, very many.” Here are other ways to translate this clause:

the people of Israel are as many as the grains of sand by the sea (GNT)

the people of Israel are as numerous as the grains of sand along every beach

the number (lit. manyness) of the descendants of Israel is like the sand on the edge of the oceanKankanaey Back Translation on TW.

**sand of the sea:** This refers to the sand on the ocean beaches around the world. See the above examples.

#### 9:27c

**only the remnant will be saved.**

- only a portion of them will be saved.
- But God will save only the remaining ones of them.

**only the remnant will be saved:** This clause is passive. Some languages must use an active clause. For example:

God will save only the remnant

**remnant:** This word means “the portion left behind” or “the portion still remaining.” God will save only some Israelites.

**saved:** This word refers to being rescued from something harmful or dangerous.

See how you translated this word in 5:10 or 8:24.

## Romans 9:28

### Section 9:14–29: God always does what is right

In this section, Paul began by asking if God acts unjustly when he chooses some people and not others. Paul answered his own question with a strong “No!” All God’s choices depend on his mercy and not on anything about the people he chooses. God made Pharaoh the way he was when he wanted the Jews to leave Egypt.

Paul spoke to a possible complaint about no one ultimately being able to resist God’s will. He said that complaining to God about that is futile.

God shows his anger and power against people he has hardened. He does this to show how great his mercy is to other people. Both Jews and Gentiles are eligible to receive his mercy.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

God’s choices/will are/is sovereign/supreme

God chooses whom he wants for both Jews and Gentiles

#### 9:28

**For the Lord will carry out His sentence on the earth thoroughly and decisively.”**

- For the Lord will fulfill his talk about that on the people of the earth thoroughly and abruptly.”
- For the Leader/Master will do what he said to the people of the world entirely and quickly.”

**For:** This word introduces an explanation about something Isaiah said in 9:27.

**Lord:** The word Lord refers to someone who has authority over people. See how you translated this word in 1:4 or 8:39.

In this Old Testament quote it refers to God. In some languages it is more natural to attach Lord to a name. For example:

Lord God

**will carry out His sentence:** The Greek is literally “will do (the) word.” It indicates that God will do what he had said earlier, that is, cause destruction on the earth. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

will do what he said earlier

will do what he warned that he would do

**on the earth:** This phrase implies the people of the whole world. In some languages a literal translation would only refer to the land and trees and such things. If that is true in your language, add the implied information. For example:

on the people of the earth



**thoroughly:** There are several ways to interpret the Greek word that the BSB translates as thoroughly:

1. It refers to doing something completely here. For example:

thoroughly (BSB) (BSB, RSV, GNT, NASB, ESV, KJV, GW, NET, REB, NCV)

1. It refers to doing something quickly here. For example:

with speed (NIV) (NIV, NLT, CEV)

1. It refers to doing something without waiting here. For example:

without hesitation (NJB) (NJB)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1), because word is formed from “with” and the verb “to complete.”

**decisively:** There is a textual issue in 9:28b: (1) Some Greek manuscripts have the word cutting-short (BSB, RSV, NIV, GNT, NJB, NASB, NABRE, ESV, NLT, GW, NET, REB, NCV). (2) Some Greek manuscripts have the words cutting-short in righteousness because a short work (KJV only). It is recommended that you follow option (1). The Greek NT 5 says that option (1) is certain. There are several ways to interpret the Greek word that the BSB translates as decisively:

1. It means quickly here. For example:

quickly (NASB) (GNT, NJB, NASB, ESV, NABRE, NRSV, NET, NCV)

1. It means to interrupt something that is happening here. For example:

cut [it] short (KJV) (KJV)

1. It means decisively here. For example:

with finality (NIV) (BSB, RSV, NIV, NLT, CEV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1), because the BDAG says it refers to putting a limit on something, often implying an abrupt ending of it. page 975.

## Romans 9:29

### Section 9:14–29: God always does what is right

In this section, Paul began by asking if God acts unjustly when he chooses some people and not others. Paul answered his own question with a strong “No!” All God’s choices depend on his mercy and not on anything about the people he chooses. God made Pharaoh the way he was when he wanted the Jews to leave Egypt.

Paul spoke to a possible complaint about no one ultimately being able to resist God’s will. He said that complaining to God about that is futile.

God shows his anger and power against people he has hardened. He does this to show how great his mercy is to other people. Both Jews and Gentiles are eligible to receive his mercy.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

God’s choices/will are/is sovereign/supreme

God chooses whom he wants for both Jews and Gentiles

### 9:29a–c

These words are an exact quote of an ancient Greek translation (about 200 BC) of the Hebrew in Isaiah 1:9. If you indicate the location of quotes from the Old Testament with cross-references, you may want to do so here.

### 9:29a

#### It is just as Isaiah foretold:

- It is also like what Isaiah had said long before,
- Isaiah also talked about this/that when he said long ago in Scripture:

The Greek of 9:29a begins with a word that is often translated as “and.” This verse supports 9:27b–c, like 9:28 supports it. So Paul used “and” here. In some language it may be more natural to omit this word and leave the connection to 9:28 implicit, as the BSB does.

**Isaiah foretold:** This clause introduces words from the Old Testament. In some languages such words are clearly shown to be from there. For example:

And as Isaiah foretold in God’s word

**Isaiah:** If you explained in your translation that Isaiah was a prophet in 9:27, you may not need to explain it again here. For example, the CEV does not add the words “the prophet” here.

**foretold:** This word indicates that Isaiah spoke about something that would happen later. The Greek tense indicates that Isaiah spoke before Paul's time and that his words are still in effect. For example:

had said before (GNT)

#### 9:29b–c

**Unless the Lord of Hosts had left us descendants, we would have become like Sodom, we would have resembled Gomorrah:** The Greek grammar indicates that God had left some Israelites alive after he punished them. The unless-clause asks what might have happened if he had not left some and then answers what might have been in that case. Some languages have a special grammar or word to indicate that. For example:

The Lord of only strength did not leave off with striking us had-that-happened, we became as Sodom and Gomora had-that-happenedA more literal rendering of the Yongkom NT, Papua New Guinea, of 9:29b–c.

If the Lord Almighty did not leave us<sup>(incl)</sup> his ancestors, they would have been destroyed like the people of Sodom, and they would have died also like the people from Gomorrah

English uses Unless...had in the first part and would have become in the second part to indicate this meaning.

#### 9:29b

**“Unless the Lord of Hosts had left us descendants,**

- “If the Lord of Armies, on our<sup>(incl)</sup> behalf, had not allowed some of our descendants to live,
- “Had it been that the Leader/Master of heaven's armies did not spare some of our descendants for us,

**the Lord of Hosts:** Here the word Hosts refers to armies. God has very many angels who would fight for him. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

the Lord of Armies (GW)

the Lord of heaven's armies

This phrase implies that God is very powerful. Some English versions like the NIV have “Lord Almighty” here, but “Almighty” is a different word in the Hebrew.

**had left us descendants:** This refers to God allowing some of the children of the Israelites to live. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

left us some descendants (GNT)

If the Lord of hosts had not left us offspring (ESV)

kept safe for us some of our descendants

**descendants:** The Greek here is literally “seed,” singular, but referring to plural seeds as a group. Some languages can use a literal translation for the correct meaning. For example:

seed

Some languages must use the plural and translate without the metaphor. See the examples above.

#### 9:29c

**we would have become like Sodom, we would have resembled Gomorrah.”**

- we would have become like Sodom, and we would have been made like Gomorrah.”
- we would have become destroyed/gone like the people of the city of Sodom and the city of Gomorrah.”

**we would have become like Sodom:** The Greek verb that the BSB literally translates as become means that Israel would have resembled Sodom. God destroyed the city of Sodom and all its people (Genesis 19:1–28). Here are other ways to translate this clause:

we would have been like Sodom (ESV)

we (incl) would be like the people in the town Sodom..., all deadYakan Back Translation on TW.

**we would have resembled Gomorrah:** The Greek is literally “and we would have been made like Gomorrah.” God also destroyed the city of Gomorrah and all its people (Genesis 19:1–28). Here are other ways to translate this clause:

and have been made like Gomorrah (NABRE)

and God would have made us to be like the people in the town of Gomorrah, also all dead

**Sodom...Gomorrah:** God destroyed these two cities and all the people in them because of the great evil that they were doing. If readers of your translation are not familiar with the story in Genesis about these cities, you may want to translate literally and explain the story briefly in a footnote. Here is an example footnote:

God destroyed the cities of Sodom and Gomorrah and all the people in them because of the great evil that they were doing. See Genesis 19:1-28.

Note that this is a quote, so you may not want to add implied words to it.

## Romans 9:30

### Section 9:30-10:4: Many Gentiles believe but many Jews do not

In this section Paul compared the Gentiles to the Jews. Some Gentiles believed in Jesus and God made them righteous, but the Jews tried to obey the law of Moses to become righteous. They stumbled over who Jesus was as the Messiah, because he did not fit their ideas of what the Messiah should be.

Paul explained that he wanted the Jews to believe in Jesus as the Messiah. The Jews were enthusiastic to follow God, but they did not understand the right way to become righteous.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

The Jews followed the wrong way to become righteous

The Jews followed the Laws of Moses but did not believe in Jesus as the Christ/Messiah

### 9:30a

#### What then will we say?

- ¶ So then, should we<sup>(incl)</sup> say this?
- ¶ Therefore, it is right to say
- ¶ And so, let's say

**What then will we say?:** The word then indicates a connection to previous verses. Here it introduces the question "What shall we say?" In some languages it is more natural to have the word then first. For example:

Then/Therefore, what shall we say?

**What...will we say?:** This is a rhetorical question. It draws attention to what Paul said next. Paul did not

expect the readers to answer this question. But he did expect the readers to agree with what he said next. Here are other ways to translate this question:

What...are we to say? (NRSV)

what does all this mean? (NCV)

In some languages the correct meaning is indicated by using a statement instead of a question. For example:

We should say this:

Our conclusion is this:

### 9:30b

#### That the Gentiles, who did not pursue righteousness, have obtained it,

- Gentiles do not usually strive/labor to be right with God, but now it is possible for them,
- that non-Jews, in general, do not seek a right relationship with God, but he has made it available to them.

**That:** This word implies that Paul suggested that he and the others would or should say what follows. In some languages the implicit information must be added to make the sentence a proper one. For example:

We will/should say that

**the Gentiles, who did not pursue righteousness, have obtained it:** There is no the before the word Gentiles in the Greek. Here it indicates that Paul spoke of Gentiles in general not pursuing righteousness. If possible, translate with that meaning. For example:

Gentiles, in general, do not pursue righteousness, but some attained it

the Gentiles do not generally/usually pursue righteousness, but some of them attained it

**Gentiles:** This word refers to people who are not Jews. See how you translated this word in 1:5 or 9:24.

**did not pursue:** The Greek here is present tense, indicating something that happens generally, past, present and future. For example:

do not pursue

**pursue righteousness:** Here this refers to trying hard to become righteous. For example:

trying to put themselves right with God (GNT)

**righteousness:** Here this word refers to a person's relationship with God being right. Moo (page 621) says it is "a right standing before God." Morris (page 374) calls it "a 'right standing' with God." Cranfield (page 506) calls it "righteous status in God's sight." Here are other ways to translate this word:

God's approval (GW)

being right with God

See how you translated this word in 4:3.

**have obtained it:** This indicates that righteousness is now available to Gentiles. Here are other ways to translate these words:

have attained it (ESV)

have achieved it (NABRE)

have been given it

Gentiles who did not pursue righteousness, God has given it to them

### 9:30c

#### a righteousness that is by faith;

- and that kind of being right with God comes from faith.
- Indeed, faith/believing in Jesus gives them that right relationship with God.

The Greek of 9:30c begins with a word that is often translated as "and" or "but." Here it introduces an explanation of how these Gentiles became right before God. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

namely, a righteousness that is by faith

That righteousness is the kind that comes from faith

**faith:** Here this word refers to believing in Jesus. In some languages a literal translation would not be clear as to which kind of faith Paul meant. If that is true in your language, you may want to explain in your translation. For example:

faith/believing in Jesus

## Romans 9:31

### Section 9:30–10:4: Many Gentiles believe but many Jews do not

In this section Paul compared the Gentiles to the Jews. Some Gentiles believed in Jesus and God made them righteous, but the Jews tried to obey the law of Moses to become righteous. They stumbled over who Jesus was as the Messiah, because he did not fit their ideas of what the Messiah should be.

Paul explained that he wanted the Jews to believe in Jesus as the Messiah. The Jews were enthusiastic to follow God, but they did not understand the right way to become righteous.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

The Jews followed the wrong way to become righteous

The Jews followed the Laws of Moses but did not believe in Jesus as the Christ/Messiah

### 9:31a

#### but Israel, who pursued a law of righteousness,

- But the people of Israel strove/labored to follow a law to become right with God
- But the people of Israel, even though they sought to obey their law in order to have a right relationship with God,

**but Israel:** Some English translation add the word "that" after but. This word would have the same meaning as the word "That" in 9:30b. It connects 9:31a–b to "we should say" as implied in 9:30b. Many languages will not need to repeat the word here. For example, the BSB does not include this word.

**Israel:** This word refers to the nation of Israel here, not the person of that name. For example:

the people of Israel (NIV11)

**a law of righteousness:** The Greek phrase that the BSB literally translates as a law of righteousness

is ambiguous. The meaning of of here is likely “for,” Schreiner (page 537). “as a means to,” Moo (page 626). or “as promising.” Dunn (page 581). Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

the law as the way of righteousness (NIV11)

get right with God by keeping the law (NLT)

to follow a law to make themselves right with God (NCV)

**a law:** Paul referred only generally to a law here, but he was talking about Israel so he implied the laws of Moses. It is best to keep it general and let the context suggest what a law refers to.

**righteousness:** This word has the same meaning as in 9:30.

**9:31b**  
**has not attained it.**

- but did not reach the goal of that law.
- were not able to obey perfectly as that law commands.

**has not attained it:** The Greek is literally “did not arrive to/at (that) law.” It indicates that the Jews did not achieve what they wanted when they used the goal of trying to obey the laws of Moses. They could not obey the law perfectly, so they could not become right with God in that way. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

have not attained their goal (NIV11)

never succeeded (NLT)

## Romans 9:32

### Section 9:30–10:4: Many Gentiles believe but many Jews do not

In this section Paul compared the Gentiles to the Jews. Some Gentiles believed in Jesus and God made them righteous, but the Jews tried to obey the law of Moses to become righteous. They stumbled over who Jesus was as the Messiah, because he did not fit their ideas of what the Messiah should be.

Paul explained that he wanted the Jews to believe in Jesus as the Messiah. The Jews were enthusiastic to follow God, but they did not understand the right way to become righteous.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

The Jews followed the wrong way to become righteous

The Jews followed the Laws of Moses but did not believe in Jesus as the Christ/Messiah

### 9:32a

#### Why not? Because their pursuit was not by faith,

- Why/Why-not? It was because they did not strive for it by means of believing,
- How can that be? They did not, because their basis for seeking to follow the law was not faith.

**Why not?:** Some English versions translate the Greek word here as Why not? as the BSB does. These translations add the word not because that same word occurs in 9:31b. In some languages it is more natural, in connection with 9:31b, to add that word here.

In some languages the question word Why alone in a question indicates a rebuke. If that is true in your language, use a question word or sentence that does not indicate a rebuke. For example:

What is the reason?

How might that be?

This is a rhetorical question. Paul immediately answered it himself. Some languages cannot use this word in that way. If that is true in your language, translate as a statement. For example:

Here is the reason: It is...

**Because:** Some languages do not start sentences with Because. If that is true in your language, repeat some or all of 9:31b or use the verb “do” instead. For example:

They did not succeed because

They did not because

**their pursuit was not by faith:** The Greek is literally just not by faith. Many scholars think that was is the correct verb to add here. Other scholars believe that the verb “pursue” is the correct verb to add. For exam-

ple: Morris, Longenecker, Cranfield, Dunn, Schreiner, and Jewett. For example:

they did not did pursue it by faith (ESV)

### 9:32b

#### but as if it were by works.

- but they strove by means of deeds, as if it was possible.
- Instead, as is not even possible, they made deeds their basis.

**but as if it were by works:** There is a textual issue in 9:32b: (1) Some Greek manuscripts have the word works (BSB, RSV, NIV, GNT, NJB, NASB, NABRE, ESV, NLT, GW, NET, REB, NCV). (2) Some Greek manuscripts have the words works of the law (KJV only). It is recommended that you follow option (1). The Greek word that the BSB translates as by is the same Greek word translated “by” in 9:32a. Translate it the same way here.

**as if it were:** Here the word as indicates that it is not possible to attain the goals of the law by works. Jewett (page 610). The BSB adds the words if it were to help with that meaning. Here are other ways to translate this Greek word:

as though it were (NASB)

as if it was possible to pursue it

**works:** Here this word refers to deeds. It implies deeds that God said the Jews must do. It does not refer to the outcome of someone’s paying job. For example:

what they do (GNT)

their own efforts (GW)

keeping the law (NLT)

### 9:32c

#### They stumbled over the stumbling stone,

- They tripped on the stone that people trip over.
- They are like people who stumbled over the stumbling stone.

**They stumbled over the stumbling stone:** This is a figure of speech. It implies that the Jews have difficulty accepting Jesus as the Christ. But 9:33 also uses the metaphor of stumbling over a stone, so the

metaphor should be kept here. But in some languages a literal translation would indicate only an actual stumbling over an actual stone, you may want to add the word “like” here. For example:

They are like those who have stumbled over the stumbling stone

**stumbled:** The Greek is the regular past tense. This word refers to someone losing his balance when walking because he hit his foot on something and nearly fell down.

**the stumbling stone:** This refers to a stone that causes people to stumble. For example:

the stone that causes stumbling (NABRE)

## Romans 9:33

### Section 9:30–10:4: Many Gentiles believe but many Jews do not

In this section Paul compared the Gentiles to the Jews. Some Gentiles believed in Jesus and God made them righteous, but the Jews tried to obey the law of Moses to become righteous. They stumbled over who Jesus was as the Messiah, because he did not fit their ideas of what the Messiah should be.

Paul explained that he wanted the Jews to believe in Jesus as the Messiah. The Jews were enthusiastic to follow God, but they did not understand the right way to become righteous.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

The Jews followed the wrong way to become righteous

The Jews followed the Laws of Moses but did not believe in Jesus as the Christ/Messiah

### 9:33a

#### as it is written:

- As someone wrote in Scriptures when God said,
- That is like what is written in God’s Word. Long ago God said,

**as it is written:** This phrase introduces a quote from the Old Testament. Paul quoted what God said to the nation of Israel. See how you translated this phrase in 1:17 or 9:13.

**9:33b–d**

Paul used words from the book of Isaiah in the Old Testament (Isaiah 8:14 and 28:16). It is not an exact quote, but God spoke in 9:33b–c, so quote marks are needed in English. If you indicate the location of quotes from the Old Testament with cross-references, you may want to do so here.

**9:33b****“See, I lay in Zion a stone of stumbling**

- “Look/Hey, I put in Zion a stone that causes stumbling,
- “Listen/Indeed, I put in the city on Mount Zion something like a stone that causes people to stumble.

**See:** This word means “look.” It emphasizes the following clause. It is not a command to look at something. Here are other ways to translate this word:

Behold (ESV)

Listen

Hey/Indeed

**I lay in Zion a stone of stumbling:** This is a metaphor. God put a stone in Zion that would cause the Jews to stumble. As 9:33c makes clear, Jesus is that stone. Jesus came as the Christ, but many Jews rejected him as the Christ. In that way they “stumbled.” But this is a quote from the Old Testament, so nothing should be put in the translation of this clause about Jesus.

In some languages a literal translation would indicate that God put an actual stone in Zion. If that is true in your language, use the word “like” here. For example:

I lay in Zion something like a stone of stumbling

**I lay:** Here the Greek word refers to putting something somewhere. For example:

I place (GNT)

**Zion:** This is the name of the hill in Jerusalem southwest of the temple. For example:

on Sion/Zion Hill

In the Old Testament, Mount Zion was symbolic for God’s holy city, Jerusalem. In many languages people will not know that Zion represents Jerusalem here. If that is true in your language, you may want to:

- Translate literally and explain its symbolic meaning in a footnote. Here are example footnotes:

That is, Jerusalem.

Zion is symbolic for Jerusalem.

- Use the name Jerusalem instead of Zion in your translation. For example:

Jerusalem (NLT) You may then want a footnote to give the Greek word. Here are example footnotes:

Literally “Zion.”

The Greek word here is Zion. Zion Hill is symbolic for Jerusalem.

**stone:** This word refers to a stone large enough to stumble over.

**9:33c****and a rock of offense;**

- a boulder that causes falling.
- It is something like a big rock that causes people to trip and fall.

In Greek, 9:33c starts with the word that is often translated as “and.” But the stone of 9:33b and the rock of 9:33c are metaphors and refer to the same person, the Messiah.

The English versions that translate the Greek with the word “and” probably imply poetic parallelism, where two phrases refer to the same thing. The NRSV and some English versions make that clear by omitting the word “and” and inserting a comma. Another way to indicate that connection is to insert “that is.” For example:

...a stone of stumbling, <sup>33c</sup>that is, a rock that will make them/people fall

**(NRSV:) a rock that will make them fall:** There are two ways to interpret the Greek word that the NRSV translates as make them fall:

1. It means here cause to fall or trip. In this interpretation this rock refers to the same thing as the a stone of 9:33b and so the meaning here is the same or similar as “stumbling.” For example:

a stone that will make people stumble, a rock that will make them fall (GNT) (RSV, NIV, GNT, NABRE, NLT, CEV, NET, NCV, REB, NCV)

1. It means here cause to feel insulted or be angry at something someone does or says. The Jews expected the Christ to start a revolt against the Romans instead of die on a Roman cross like a criminal. For example:

a rock...that people trip over, a large rock that people find offensive (GW) (BSB, ESV, NASB, KJV, GW)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). But if the major language version in your area follows interpretation (2), you may want to follow that.

The phrase a rock that will make them fall is a metaphor. If you added “like” before “a stone of stumbling,” you may want to add “like” here. For example:

something like a rock that will make them fall

But if you added “like” before “a stone of stumbling,” you may not need to repeat “like” here.

**rock:** This is a different word in the Greek. It usually refers to bedrock, a large continuous rock often underneath soil and perhaps sticking out in places. Here it probably refers more generally to any large rock. For example:

large rock (GW)

boulder See Liddell and Scott, *πετρα*, sense 3.

### 9:33d

**and the one who believes in Him will never be put to shame.”**

- And the one who believes in him will not be caused to be ashamed.”
- But God will not shame anyone who believes in him.”

**and:** Some languages will see “whoever believes in him” as contrasting to “I am laying in Zion a stone of stumbling.” For example:

but (NJB)

**the one who believes in Him:** A person who believes in someone is someone who agrees to what someone

stands for, trusts him, relies on him, and is committed to him. See how your translated this word in 1:16 or 6:8.

**Him:** This refers to the stone of stumbling and the rock of offense. But the meaning of those metaphors is the Christ. Use a pronoun that refers to a man, as the BSB does.

**will never be put to shame:** There are several ways to interpret the Greek word that the BSB translates as be put to shame:

1. It indicates that someone caused them to be ashamed. For example:

will never be disgraced (NLT) (BSB, RSV, NIV, NJB, ESV, NABRE, NET, REB, NLT)

1. It indicates that the people themselves will feel shame, without any focus on who or what caused it. For example:

will not be ashamed (GW) (KJV, GW)

1. It refers to being disappointed that things did not happen as one hoped. For example:

will not be disappointed (GNT) (GNT, NASB, CEV, NCV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1), because many scholars support it. No one discusses why they prefer one interpretation over the other. BDAG chooses interpretation (3), but L&N, Kittel, and L&S all define the word as in interpretation (1).

This clause is passive. Some languages must use an active clause. For example:

God will not shame him

## Romans 10:1

### Section 9:30–10:4: Many Gentiles believe but many Jews do not

In this section Paul compared the Gentiles to the Jews. Some Gentiles believed in Jesus and God made them righteous, but the Jews tried to obey the law of Moses to become righteous. They stumbled over who Jesus was as the Messiah, because he did not fit their ideas of what the Messiah should be.

Paul explained that he wanted the Jews to believe in Jesus as the Messiah. The Jews were enthusiastic to



follow God, but they did not understand the right way to become righteous.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

The Jews followed the wrong way to become righteous

The Jews followed the Laws of Moses but did not believe in Jesus as the Christ/Messiah

#### 10:1a

#### **Brothers, my heart's desire and prayer to God for the Israelites**

- ¶ My brothers and sisters, the desire of my insides and the prayer I make to God for them
- ¶ My fellow believers, I want deeply/greatly/truly and pray to God for my tribe/people-group

**Brothers:** Here this word refers to believers in Jesus, both men and women. The word indicates a close relationship between believers because God has made them his (adopted) children. It does not refer here to his fellow Israelites who did not believe in Jesus, as in 9:3. See how you translated this word in 1:13 or 8:12.

**my heart's desire:** This phrase indicates that Paul was about to speak of something that he really wanted to happen. The word heart refers to the inner person, where thoughts and feelings occur. In some languages people use a different part of the body. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

the desire of my insides/liver

My real desireUma Back Translation on TW.

I really want thatWestern Bukidnon Manobo Back Translation on TW.

**prayer to God:** Some languages must use a verb here. For example:

I pray to God

**for the Israelites:** There is a textual issue in 10:1a: (1) Some Greek manuscripts have the word of-them (RSV, GNT, NJB, NASB, NABRE, ESV, REB). (2) Some Greek manuscripts have the words of-the Israel (BSB, KJV, NIV, NLT, GW, NET, NCV). It is recommended that you follow option (1). The BSB, NIV, NLT, GW, NET, and NCV probably follow option (1), but explain “them” here as

referring to the Jews. The Greek word that the BSB translates as Israelites is literally “them.” It refers to the Jews. Some English versions explain the word, as the BSB, perhaps because a new chapter has begun.

#### 10:1b

#### **is for their salvation.**

- is for them to be saved.
- that God will rescue them from the penalty of sin/wrongdoing.

**is for their salvation:** The Greek is literally “for salvation.” Paul wanted his fellow Jews to believe in Jesus and therefore God would save them from going to hell for their sins. For example:

that they may be saved (ESV)

See how you translated salvation in 1:16 or “saved” in 5:9 or 8:24.

## Romans 10:2

### **Section 9:30–10:4: Many Gentiles believe but many Jews do not**

In this section Paul compared the Gentiles to the Jews. Some Gentiles believed in Jesus and God made them righteous, but the Jews tried to obey the law of Moses to become righteous. They stumbled over who Jesus was as the Messiah, because he did not fit their ideas of what the Messiah should be.

Paul explained that he wanted the Jews to believe in Jesus as the Messiah. The Jews were enthusiastic to follow God, but they did not understand the right way to become righteous.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

The Jews followed the wrong way to become righteous

The Jews followed the Laws of Moses but did not believe in Jesus as the Christ/Messiah

#### 10:2a

#### **For I testify about them**

- For I speak in truth about them
- I myself know and say truthfully about them

**For:** Here this word introduces the reason Paul prayed for the Jews.Schreiner (page 542).

**I testify about:** This phrase means “report what one saw.” The phrase is often used where the person is

expected to be truthful and accurate. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

I bear...witness (ESV)

I truthfully say about

See how you translated the phrase “attested” in 3:21.

**them:** Here the Greek grammar indicates that Paul spoke about them, rather than to them. Dunn (page 586). Some English translations can be taken either way, but the Greek only indicates the first meaning.

#### 10:2b

**that they are zealous for God,**

- that they have enthusiasm for God,
- that they eagerly work/labor to make their relationship with God good.

**they are zealous for God:** The word zealous refers to an eagerness to do something. The Jews were eager to follow God according to the Laws of Moses, and eager to speak for God in an argument, and eager to fight against those who oppose God. See Morris (page 378), Dunn (586), and Jewett (page 616). Here are other ways to translate this clause:

what enthusiasm they have for God (NLT)

they really strive to follow/obey God Yakan Back Translation on TW.

#### 10:2c

**but not on the basis of knowledge.**

- but their enthusiasm does not conform to knowledge of him.
- But what they do does not agree with what is known about him.

**but not on the basis of knowledge:** This indicates that the things that the Jews did in their zeal did not agree with what God said in the Old Testament. The Jews read and should have known what God wanted them to do. Instead they followed their own thinking.

Some languages must repeat all or part of the meaning of “they have zeal for God” for a natural translation. For example:

but their zeal is not according to knowledge

**knowledge:** This refers to things about God that people can know. In some languages a literal translation

would refer to knowledge in general. If that is true in your language, you may want to explain in your translation. For example:

knowledge of him

religious knowledge

### Romans 10:3

#### Section 9:30–10:4: Many Gentiles believe but many Jews do not

In this section Paul compared the Gentiles to the Jews. Some Gentiles believed in Jesus and God made them righteous, but the Jews tried to obey the law of Moses to become righteous. They stumbled over who Jesus was as the Messiah, because he did not fit their ideas of what the Messiah should be.

Paul explained that he wanted the Jews to believe in Jesus as the Messiah. The Jews were enthusiastic to follow God, but they did not understand the right way to become righteous.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

The Jews followed the wrong way to become righteous

The Jews followed the Laws of Moses but did not believe in Jesus as the Christ/Messiah

#### 10:3a–c

This verse begins with a Greek conjunction that is often translated as “for.” Here, this conjunction indicates that not submitting to God’s righteousness was the reason that the Jews had zeal without proper knowledge (10:2). The BSB leaves this connection implicit. Consider how you might introduce this kind of reason in your language.

**Because they were ignorant of God’s righteousness and sought to establish their own, they did not submit to God’s righteousness:** The main point here

is they did not submit to God’s righteousness. The rest of this verse (they were ignorant of God’s righteousness and sought to establish their own) are reasons that contributed to not submitting.

In some languages the connections will be more clear if the reason comes after the result. For example:

They did not submit to God's righteousness, because they were ignorant of God's righteousness and sought to establish their own

### 10:3a

#### Because they were ignorant of God's righteousness

- For, on the basis of them not knowing the righteousness from God
- For they did not know the way that God makes people right with himself.

**Because:** Here this word introduces the reason for the Jews' misguided zeal. Morris (page 379).

**they were ignorant of:** There are several ways to interpret the Greek word that the BSB translates as were ignorant of:

1. Here it means not knowing what something is. For example:

they did not know (NIV) (NIV, GNT, NASB, NCV)

1. Here it means seeing something but not being clear about what it is or what it does. For example:

don't understand (NLT) (NLT, GW, CEV)

1. Here it means seeing something but then paying no attention to it. For example:

ignoring (NET) (NET, REB)

1. Here it means seeing something but not knowing what it is. For example:

Not recognizing (NJB) (NJB)

1. Here it means not knowing that something exists. For example:

being ignorant of (RSV) (BSB, RSV, ESV, KJV, NABRE)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1), because it seems like the best fit here.

**God's righteousness:** There are several ways to interpret these words:

1. Here they refer to God giving someone the status of righteous. For example:

the righteousness that comes from God (NET) (RSV, NIV, NET, NABRE)

1. Here they refer to God being righteous. For example:

God's righteousness (NASB) (BSB, NIV11, NASB, KJV, ESV)

1. Here they refer to God making someone's relationship with him right. For example:

God's way of making people right with himself (NLT) (GNT, NJB, NLT, NCV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1), because it is opposite to the Jews trying to make themselves righteous (10:3b).

### 10:3b

#### and sought to establish their own,

- and on the basis of they seeking to inaugurate/begin their own righteousness,
- They worked hard to make their own way. They follow/obey the rule/law to being right with God according to their own rules.

**sought:** This word here refers to making an effort to accomplish something. BDAG (page 428), sense (3) says, "to devote serious effort to realize one's desire or objective." The Jews worked hard to establish a righteousness that they thought was right. Here are other ways to translate this word:

strove-after Tagbanwa Back Translation on TW.

worked hard

**establish their own:** Here the word establish refers to setting something up as permanent. Here the words their own refers to a righteousness that they decided was the right kind. Here are other ways to translate this word:

set up their own way (GNT)

make themselves right in their own way (NCV)

enact their own plan for that

make their own road/way to their own righteousness

**10:3c****they did not submit to God's righteousness.**

- they did not put themselves under the righteousness that God has.
- So they did not humble themselves to be under the righteousness from which God acts/behaves.

**submit:** This word refers to putting oneself under the command of another. Here are other ways to translate this word:

humbled (lit. lowered) themselvesKankanaey  
Back Translation on TW.

give themselvesBased on the Madak NT, Papua  
New Guinea.

**God's righteousness:** There are two ways to interpret these words:

1. Here they refer to God being righteous. For example:

God's righteousness (NET) (BSB, RSV, NIV, ESV,  
NASB, KJV, NET, REB, NABRE)

1. Here they refer to God making a person's relationship with him right. For example:

God's way of putting people right (GNT) (GNT, NJB,  
NCV, NLT, GW)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1), because it works best with the word "submit." This is a different meaning for righteousness than in 10:3a. Paul sometimes used the same word or phrase with different meanings (for example, "Israel" in 9:6).

This clause indicates that the Jews did not humble themselves under God's righteous ways.

In some languages the verb "submit" cannot naturally connect to a quality like God being right. If that is true in your language, you may want to explain the connection in your language. For example:

they did not submit to the right ways of God

they did not submit to God, who/he is always  
righteous

**Romans 10:4****Section 9:30–10:4: Many Gentiles believe but many Jews do not**

In this section Paul compared the Gentiles to the Jews. Some Gentiles believed in Jesus and God made them righteous, but the Jews tried to obey the law of Moses to become righteous. They stumbled over who Jesus was as the Messiah, because he did not fit their ideas of what the Messiah should be.

Paul explained that he wanted the Jews to believe in Jesus as the Messiah. The Jews were enthusiastic to follow God, but they did not understand the right way to become righteous.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

The Jews followed the wrong way to become  
righteous

The Jews followed the Laws of Moses but did not  
believe in Jesus as the Christ/Messiah

**10:4a****For Christ is the end of the law,**

- For the Christ/Messiah ends the law/Laws
- For Christ stops the use of the laws of Moses

**For:** Here this word introduces grounds or an explanationMoo (page 636) and Cranfield (page 520), respectively. of 10:3.

**Christ is the end of the law:** There are several ways to interpret the Greek word that the BSB translates as end:

1. It indicates that Christ has ended any role that the Laws of Moses had for gaining right standing before God. For example:

Christ has brought the Law to an end (GNT) (RSV,  
NIV, GNT, NCV)

1. It indicates that Christ is the goal of the Laws of Moses regarding gaining right standing before God. For example:

Christ is the end of the law for righteousness to  
everyone who believes (ESV) (BSB, NASB, KJV, ESV,  
NABRE, NLT, NET)

1. It indicates that Christ satisfies all the requirements of the Laws of Moses for the purpose of gaining right standing before God. For example:

the Law has found its fulfilment in Christ (NJB)  
(NJB, GW)

1. It indicates that Christ is the best (and final) expression of the Laws of Moses for the purpose of gaining right standing before God. For example:

Christ is the culmination of the law (NIV11) (NIV11)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1), because “For” probably connects this verse to the Jews working hard to establish their own righteousness (by using the Laws of Moses) (10:3). If the major language version in your area follows interpretation (2), you may want to follow that.

Here are other ways to translate this clause according to interpretation (1):

Christ ended the law (NCV)

Cristo is the ending-place of the lawKankanaey  
Back Translation on TW.

Christ has made it so that there is no value in obeying the LawWestern Bukidnon Manobo Back  
Translation on TW.

If you followed interpretation (2), here are other ways to translate this clause according to that:

Christ has already accomplished the purpose for which the law was given (NLT)

The goal of the Law is Christ

#### **10:4b to bring righteousness to everyone who believes.**

- so that righteousness exists for everyone who believes in him.
- so that God makes everyone who believes in Jesus as the Christ right with himself.

**(NIV:) so that there may be righteousness for everyone who believes:** There are several ways to interpret the Greek words that the NIV translates as so that:

1. It introduces the purpose of what Paul said in 10:4a. For example:

so that everyone who believes is put right with God (GNT) (RSV, NIV, GNT, NJB, GW, NCV)

1. It introduces the goal of what Paul said in 10:4a. For example:

for righteousness to everyone who believes (ESV)  
(BSB, NASB, KJV, ESV, NABRE, NLT, NET)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). But if the major language version in your area follows interpretation (2), you may want to follow that.

Here are other ways to translate this clause according to interpretation (1):

so that everyone who believes in him may be right with God (NCV)

so all those who believe in him are made-righteous in God’s sightKankanaey Back Translation on TW.

So that as for anybody it is only by believing in Christ that he is considered righteous by God.Western Bukidnon Manobo Back Translation on TW.

If you followed interpretation (2), here are other ways to translate this clause according to that:

As a result, all who believe in him are made right with God. (NLT)

for everyone who believes in him is made right with God

**(NIV:) there may be righteousness for everyone who believes:** This clause is more literally “righteousness to everyone believing.” It indicates that righteousness is available to every believer. (Other verses, such as 4:5, make it clear that God gives this righteousness to all of them.) Here are other ways to translate this clause:

righteousness is given to everyone who believes

everyone who believes is made righteous

God makes everyone who believes righteous

**righteousness:** Here the word righteousness refers to a person's relationship with God being right. See how you translated this word in 10:3a.

**believes:** Here this refers to believing in Jesus as the Christ/Messiah. For example:

believe in him (NLT)

believe that Jesus is the Christ

## Romans 10:5

### Section 10:5–15: Salvation for everyone is by faith not works

In this section Paul spoke about righteousness based on the Law of Moses and righteousness based on faith. The righteousness which comes from the Law is based on doing what the Law says. The righteousness which comes from faith is not based on what a person does but is instead a matter of the heart.

God rescues the person who believes in Jesus and announces that Jesus is his Lord. Paul said that this is true for both Jews and people who are not Jews. Jesus is Lord of all of them. and blesses them very much.

Paul then asked several questions for the believers in Rome to think about. He implied that someone must be sent and preach, and people must hear, believe, and call on Jesus. Paul ended the section with a quote from the Old Testament about how it is good to preach the good news.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

God saves anyone, Jew or Gentile, who believes in Jesus

Salvation by faith and the need for preaching near and far

#### 10:5a

#### For concerning the righteousness that is by the law, Moses writes:

- ¶ For Moses wrote about the righteousness that is/ comes from the law,
- ¶ This is what Moses wrote in the Holy Book about people who want to be right with God by obeying the Laws of Moses:

**For:** Here this word introduces an explanation or an elaboration on what Paul said about righteousness, works, and faith earlier. Dunn (page 600).

**the righteousness that is by the law:** This phrase refers to being right with God based upon the Law of Moses. The life of the Jews was governed by the Law which God had given them through Moses. Their obedience to it provided their understanding of being in right standing with God. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

the righteousness that comes from the law (NRSV)

the righteousness that is from the Laws of Moses

**Moses writes:** The verb is present tense, but Moses wrote the words of 10:5b over 1,500 years before Paul lived. Greek scholars call it the historical present. In many languages the normal way of referring to a past event must be used. For example:

Moses wrote (GNT)

In some languages a quote from the Old Testament is always clearly introduced as one. For example:

Moses wrote in Scripture

#### 10:5b

#### “The man who does these things will live by them.”

- “Anyone who obeys these things must live according to all of them.”
- “The person doing the things the Laws command must do all of them always.”

These words are from Leviticus 18:5.

#### “The man who does these things will live by them”:

The Greek of 10:5b begins with a word that is often translated as “that” (ESV). There are two ways to interpret this Greek word:

1. It introduces a direct quote here. For example:

“The man who does these things will live by them.” (BSB) (BSB, NIV, GNT, NRSV, NASB, NABRE, GW, CEV, NET, REB, NCV)

1. It introduces an indirect quote here. For example:

that the man who practices the righteousness which is based on the law shall live by it (RSV) (RSV, NJB, ESV, NLT)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1), because the words of 10:5a are very similar to that part of Leviticus 18:5.

**The man who does these things:** The Greek is literally “the man doing those things.” It refers to anyone, man or woman, who does as the commands in the laws of Moses say. It implies Jews who want to obey God. The words these things do not refer only to the Ten Commandments. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

Whoever obeys the commands of the Law (GNT)

the one who does all the Laws of Moses

**will live by them:** This phrase probably refers to having their whole life governed by the Laws of Moses. Lenski (page 647) says, “The only trouble with the law as a means for attaining righteousness is that it requires complete doing on our part.... ‘Shall live in (in connection with) them,’ (means that) all of them completely done.” The Greek future can imply a promise (as many scholars believe here), but it also can be an implied command (as this author and Lenski believe, and the RSV, ESV, and REB indicate with “shall,” and the NLT and CEV clearly make as a command). The English future “will” can also be an implied command. “Will live in them” is probably an implied command but it is not clear here. Only the NJB and the GW make it clearly a promise. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

requires obedience to all of its commands (NLT)

must do all that the Law commands (CEV)

**by them:** The word them refers to all of the commandments in the Law, as above.

## Romans 10:6

### Section 10:5–15: Salvation for everyone is by faith not works

In this section Paul spoke about righteousness based on the Law of Moses and righteousness based on faith. The righteousness which comes from the Law is based on doing what the Law says. The righteousness which comes from faith is not based on what a person does but is instead a matter of the heart.

God rescues the person who believes in Jesus and announces that Jesus is his Lord. Paul said that this is

true for both Jews and people who are not Jews. Jesus is Lord of all of them. and blesses them very much.

Paul then asked several questions for the believers in Rome to think about. He implied that someone must be sent and preach, and people must hear, believe, and call on Jesus. Paul ended the section with a quote from the Old Testament about how it is good to preach the good news.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

God saves anyone, Jew or Gentile, who believes in Jesus

Salvation by faith and the need for preaching near and far

### 10:6a

#### But the righteousness that is by faith says:

- But the status/position of being right with God because of believing in Jesus is like the Scriptures that say,
- But people who believe in Jesus and so God has said they are right with him say this, like God’s Word says:

**the righteousness that is by faith says:** In this clause righteousness speaks as if it is a person. It indicates that people who have a righteousness that is by faith have the attitude described in 10:6b–7b. That is, they would never think they have the power to bring Christ down to earth or to take him up to heaven. In some languages an abstract concept like righteousness cannot “speak.” If that is true in your language, refer to people who are righteous in this way. For example:

people who are righteous that is by faith have this attitude:

people whom God has made right with him because they believe in Jesus have thinking like this:

**the righteousness that is by faith:** Here the word by indicates that the people who have status as righteous people, God has given that status because they believe in Jesus. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

the righteousness based on faith (ESV)

the righteousness that comes from faith (NABRE)

being made right with God through faith

**righteousness:** This word refers to being right with God. It is the same meaning as in 10:3 and 10:5.

**faith:** This word refers to believing in Jesus, that he is the Christ, the one whom God sent to save people from his anger. In some languages a literal translation would refer to believing generally in anyone. If that is true in your language, indicate clearly that it refers to faith in Jesus. For example:

believing in Jesus

**says:** Here the present tense indicates what is said in 10:6-7 is something a person right with God would say at any time. It is not a habitual repeating of the words over and over.

This word introduces sayings from the Old Testament. In some languages the people prefer that the translation make that clear. For example:

says as the Scriptures say:

if God judges someone as being righteous by his faith, well, the thinking of that person is in accord with the word of God which says, Based on the Barok Back Translation, Papua New Guinea, unpublished manuscript.

#### 10:6b

**“Do not say in your heart,**

- “Do not ask in your insides/inner-being,
- “Do not say to yourself like this:

This is a quote from the first part of Deuteronomy 9:4.

**Do not say in your heart:** Paul used this clause to introduce what he said in 10:6c. Many English versions do not put in a cross-reference to that verse, probably because it only introduces the next words. Only the NET has a cross-reference for this quote.

**Do not say:** The Greek word that the BSB translates as say is singular, but refers generally to anyone. In some languages the plural is used to refer generally. For example:

Don't you(pl) think Nalik Back Translation, draft, Papua New Guinea.

10:6c is a question. In some languages “ask” would be better here. For example:

You<sup>(pl)</sup> must not ask

**in your heart:** This phrase refers to the inner person. Many languages use a different organ or a more general word. For example:

in your insides/liver/stomach

#### 10:6c-d

**‘Who will ascend into heaven?’ (that is, to bring Christ down):** Only the question is from Deuteronomy 30:12. If you indicate the location of quotes from the Old Testament with cross-references, you may want to do so here.

The words that is, to bring Christ down explain the purpose of ascending into heaven. They are also not a new sentence in the Greek. That is why the BSB has the parenthesis. Here are other ways to translate this connection:

But the saving justice of faith says this: Do not think in your heart, ‘Who will go up to heaven?’—that is to bring Christ down; (NJB) Notice that the NJB does not have a quote mark before “Do not think.” The NJB often does this.

‘Who will ascend into heaven?’,” that is, to bring Christ down.

#### 10:6c

**‘Who will ascend into heaven?’**

- ‘Who will go up and enter heaven?’,”
- ‘Who will go up to heaven?’”

**‘Who will ascend into heaven?’:** This question is a quote from part of Deuteronomy 30:12. Paul used this part for his own purpose here. In Deuteronomy it refers to going up to heaven to get God's Word, referring to any part of the first five books of what is now called the Old Testament.

This is a rhetorical question that the speaker is asking himself. It emphasizes that no one should ascend to heaven (to bring Christ down to the earth). Translate with that meaning. For example:

Who will go up into heaven? (NABRE)

Who can go up to heaven? (REB)

**heaven:** Here the word heaven refers to the place where God lives. See how you translated it in 1:18.



### 10:6d (that is, to bring Christ down)

- namely, to bring the Christ/Messiah down to earth.
- I, Paul, mean going up to bring the one/person whom God appointed to save/rescue people down here.

**(that is, to bring Christ down):** Here the phrase that is introduces what is to be brought down, from the question “Who will ascend into heaven.” It is not a part of the quote from Deuteronomy but how Paul wanted people to think of those words here. Here are other ways to translate these words:

and here I mean that it is to bring Christ down

in this case, to bring Christ down to earth

**Christ:** Here this word refers to Jesus as the Messiah, the one God sent to save people. It is not used as another name for Jesus. For example:

the Christ/Messiah

the person whom God chose to save people

See how you translated this word in 1:1 or 9:5.

**down:** Here this refers to bringing Jesus back to earth.

## Romans 10:7

### Section 10:5–15: Salvation for everyone is by faith not works

In this section Paul spoke about righteousness based on the Law of Moses and righteousness based on faith. The righteousness which comes from the Law is based on doing what the Law says. The righteousness which comes from faith is not based on what a person does but is instead a matter of the heart.

God rescues the person who believes in Jesus and announces that Jesus is his Lord. Paul said that this is true for both Jews and people who are not Jews. Jesus is Lord of all of them. and blesses them very much.

Paul then asked several questions for the believers in Rome to think about. He implied that someone must be sent and preach, and people must hear, believe, and call on Jesus. Paul ended the section with a quote from the Old Testament about how it is good to preach the good news.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

God saves anyone, Jew or Gentile, who believes in Jesus

Salvation by faith and the need for preaching near and far

### 10:7a or, ‘Who will descend into the Abyss?’

- Or, do not say, “‘Who will go down and enter the very deep place?’”
- Or, do not also ask yourself, “‘Who will go down to the place of dead people?’”

**or:** The words “the righteousness based on faith says, ‘Do not say in your heart,’ ” are implied here. In some languages all or part of these words will be needed to make the meaning clear. For example:

or do not say in your heart,

and the righteousness based on faith also says,  
‘Do not say in your heart,

**‘Who will descend into the Abyss?’:** This is a rhetorical question that the speaker is asking himself. It emphasizes that no one should descend into the abyss (to bring Christ up to the earth). Translate with that meaning. For example:

Who will go down into the abyss? (NABRE)

Who can go down to the abyss? (REB)

These words are a quote of Deuteronomy 30:13. If you indicate the location of quotes from the Old Testament with cross-references, you may want to do so here.

**the Abyss:** the Greek word that the BSB translates as Abyss refers to a very deep place. Here it implies the place where the spirits of dead people go. Here are other ways to translate this word:

the deep (NIV)

the world below (GNT)

the place of the dead (NLT)

### 10:7b (that is, to bring Christ up from the dead).”

- namely, to bring the Christ/Messiah up from the place of the dead.
- I, Paul, mean going down to bring the one/person whom God appointed to save/rescue people up from the place of dead people.

**that is:** Translate this as you did in 10:6.

**Christ:** Translate this as you did in 10:6.

## Romans 10:8

### Section 10:5–15: Salvation for everyone is by faith not works

In this section Paul spoke about righteousness based on the Law of Moses and righteousness based on faith. The righteousness which comes from the Law is based on doing what the Law says. The righteousness which comes from faith is not based on what a person does but is instead a matter of the heart.

God rescues the person who believes in Jesus and announces that Jesus is his Lord. Paul said that this is true for both Jews and people who are not Jews. Jesus is Lord of all of them. and blesses them very much.

Paul then asked several questions for the believers in Rome to think about. He implied that someone must be sent and preach, and people must hear, believe, and call on Jesus. Paul ended the section with a quote from the Old Testament about how it is good to preach the good news.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

God saves anyone, Jew or Gentile, who believes in Jesus

Salvation by faith and the need for preaching near and far

#### 10:8a

#### But what does it say?

- ¶ But what does it/he say? It/He says,
- ¶ But people who believe in Jesus and so God has said they are right with him, they say like God's word says,

**what does it say?:** This is a rhetorical question. It draws attention to what Paul said next. Paul did not expect the readers to answer this question. But he did expect the readers to agree with what he said next. Here are other ways to translate this question:

what else does it say? (GW)

what does it say next? (REB)

In some languages the correct meaning is indicated by using a statement instead of a question. For example:

it says, (NLT)

This clause introduces a quote from Scripture. Some language translations always note that in their translations. For example:

what does it say? It says as Scripture says,

**it:** The word it refers here to the righteousness based on faith (10:6). You should refer to that here.

#### 10:8b

#### “The word is near you;

- “The message is close to you<sup>(sing/plur)</sup>.
- “The statement/declaration is easy for you to find.

**The word is near you:** Here the word near indicates that the word is within reach. It is not hard to get, like going up to heaven or down to the place of the dead is hard to do. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

The message is very close at hand (NLT)

The word is not far from you

The message is easy to get/find

**word:** This Greek word refers to what was said. It implies many words, unified in some way. It does not refer to a single word. Here are other ways to translate this word:

message (NLT)

news/statement

Paul explained which word he meant in 10:8d. You should not explain it here.

**you:** The Greek word is singular, but refers in general to anyone. In some languages the plural is used for that meaning.

#### 10:8c

#### it is in your mouth and in your heart,”

- It is in your mind and in your insides/liver/stomach,”

- You are able to say it and it is already in your inner being.”

**in your mouth:** This is a figure of speech. It refers to the things a person knows and therefore he is able to talk about them. God’s words, either received through Moses or Paul, are known. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

on your lips/tongue

in your minds Kankanaey Back Translation on TW.

you are able to speak it

**heart:** This word refers to a person’s inner being. See how you translated it in 10:6.

#### General Comment on 10:8b–c

These words are a quote of Deuteronomy 30:14. If you indicate the location of quotes from the Old Testament with cross-references, you may want to do so here.

#### 10:8d

**that is, the word of faith we are proclaiming:**

- namely, the message concerning faith that we<sup>(excl)</sup> preach.
- I, Paul, mean the statement/declaration of believing in Jesus that we tell people.

**that is:** Translate this as you did in 10:6.

**the word of faith:** Here the word of indicates that God’s message calls people to have faith in God and the Christ/Messiah, as now known to be Jesus. Moo (page 656) and Cranfield say the word of means “that calls for.” Jewett (page 629) says, “When one follows the logic of the speech-in-character, however, this is clearly the word of missionaries that proclaims faith.” But this seems to divorce “the word of faith” from “the word (that) is near you.” Dunn (page 606) says the phrase means both “the word ‘which calls for (the response of) faith’ (and) the word which proclaims the faith that is believed.”

**the word:** Translate this as you did in 10:8b.

**proclaiming:** The Greek word that the BSB translates as proclaiming means “speak loudly in public important information or news.” Here are other ways to translate this word:

announce

preach (NJB)

See how you translated this word in 2:21, where the BSB translates it as “preach.”

## Romans 10:9

### Section 10:5–15: Salvation for everyone is by faith not works

In this section Paul spoke about righteousness based on the Law of Moses and righteousness based on faith. The righteousness which comes from the Law is based on doing what the Law says. The righteousness which comes from faith is not based on what a person does but is instead a matter of the heart.

God rescues the person who believes in Jesus and announces that Jesus is his Lord. Paul said that this is true for both Jews and people who are not Jews. Jesus is Lord of all of them. and blesses them very much.

Paul then asked several questions for the believers in Rome to think about. He implied that someone must be sent and preach, and people must hear, believe, and call on Jesus. Paul ended the section with a quote from the Old Testament about how it is good to preach the good news.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

God saves anyone, Jew or Gentile, who believes in Jesus

Salvation by faith and the need for preaching near and far

#### 10:9a

**that if you confess with your mouth, “Jesus is Lord,”**

- It is that if you<sup>(sing/plur)</sup> tell others aloud that Jesus is your Lord
- For if you declare to other people, “Jesus is my Leader/Master,”

**that:** There are several ways to interpret the Greek word that the BSB translates as that:

1. It introduces an explanation of “word of faith we are proclaiming” (10:8d). For example:

That if you confess with your mouth, “Jesus is Lord,” (NIV) (BSB, NIV, NJB, NASB, KJV)

1. It introduces more that Paul wanted to say about the “word of faith we are proclaiming” (10:8d). For example:

for (NABRE) (NABRE)

1. It introduces the reason for something Paul said earlier. For example:

because (ESV) (RSV, ESV, NET)

1. It is best to omit this word. For example:

If you confess... (GNT) (GNT, NIV11, NLT, GW, CEV, REB, NCV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1), because it is not clear what “because” (interpretation (3)) would connect to in earlier verses. Cranfield and Schreiner say this verse explains something in the prior verses, which this author would think that “for” would then be best. Morris says it introduces “the content of the preaching,” which this author would think that “that” would then be best. Interpretation (2) is possible for the Greek word and the context. Cranfield and Witherington translate that way. Interpretation (4) may imply the right meaning in some languages.

**if:** Paul used if here to cause the Roman believers to evaluate their own lives and determine if 10:9a–b applies to them. He probably expects most or all of them to say that they are like what he said here. Consider how to translate that meaning for the word if.

In the Greek text, this one if affects both 10:9a and 10:9b. Consider how to include all of 10:9a–b in the if clause in your language. Some languages may need to repeat the word if to make this clear. For example:

<sup>9a</sup>if you confess with your mouth that Jesus is Lord  
<sup>9b</sup>and if you believe in your heart that God raised him from the dead,

**you:** The Greek word is singular, but refers in general to anyone. In some languages the plural is used for that meaning.

**confess:** Here this word refers to acknowledging in front of others that you believe in Jesus as the Christ/Savior. Here are other ways to translate this word:

declare (NJB)

admit

**with your mouth:** This phrase indicates speaking aloud. Paul probably repeated your mouth to connect to the same words in 10:8c. But in some languages in connection with “confess,” it may not be necessary or natural to translate this phrase. For example, the GNT omits this phrase.

**“Jesus is Lord”:** In some languages, indirect speech would be more natural here. For example:

that Jesus is Lord (ESV)

This clause indicates that Jesus is ruler over this person’s life. See how you translated the word Lord in 1:4 or 9:28.

### 10:9b

**and believe in your heart that God raised Him from the dead,**

- and believe in your insides/liver/stomach that God raised him from the place of the dead people,
- and if you also believe in your inner being that God caused him to live again after he was dead,

**and believe in your heart:** The words “if you” are implied from 10:9a. In some languages one or both words must be repeated here. For example:

and you believe in your heart

and if you believe in your heart

**heart:** This word refers to a person’s inner being.

**raised Him from the dead:** This phrase refers to God making Jesus alive again after he died and was put in the tomb. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

raised him from death (GNT)

brought him back to life (GW)

See how you translated this phrase in 4:24 (“raised... from the dead”) or 8:11 (“raised...from the dead”).

### General Comment on 10:9a–b

Believing occurs before confessing. Paul probably had the order “confess with your mouth...and believe in your heart” to match the order of “in your mouth and in your heart” in 10:8c, or perhaps in a Greek poetical structure in opposite order to 10:10a–c. But in some

languages it will be less confusing or more natural to have believing before confessing. For example:

that <sup>9b</sup>if you believe in your heart that God raised him from the dead and <sup>9a</sup>confess with your mouth Jesus as Lord,

### 10:9c you will be saved.

- you will be rescued.
- God will save you.

**you will be saved:** This clause is passive. Some languages must use an active clause. For example:

God will save you

**saved:** This word refers to being rescued from something harmful or dangerous. Here it refers to God rescuing people from his anger. See how you translated this word in 5:9 or 9:27.

## Romans 10:10

### Section 10:5–15: Salvation for everyone is by faith not works

In this section Paul spoke about righteousness based on the Law of Moses and righteousness based on faith. The righteousness which comes from the Law is based on doing what the Law says. The righteousness which comes from faith is not based on what a person does but is instead a matter of the heart.

God rescues the person who believes in Jesus and announces that Jesus is his Lord. Paul said that this is true for both Jews and people who are not Jews. Jesus is Lord of all of them. and blesses them very much.

Paul then asked several questions for the believers in Rome to think about. He implied that someone must be sent and preach, and people must hear, believe, and call on Jesus. Paul ended the section with a quote from the Old Testament about how it is good to preach the good news.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

God saves anyone, Jew or Gentile, who believes in Jesus

Salvation by faith and the need for preaching near and far

### 10:10a For with your heart you believe

- For in a person's insides/liver/stomach he believes,
- For whoever believes in Jesus from their inner beings,

**For:** This word here introduces something more that Paul wanted to say about believing, confessing, and being saved. Here Paul used slightly different wording and added the idea of being made right with God, connecting to the same idea in 10:6. Moo (page 658) calls it “corroboration,” Morris (page 386) “further explanation,” Cranfield (page 530), that it “supports the previous verse,” and Dunn (page 609) calls it emphasis of “saving faith.”

**with your heart you believe:** The phrase with your heart is emphasized by being first in the clause both in the Greek and in the BSB. In some languages the phrase must be in its usual place. If that is true in your language, emphasize this phrase, if possible, in some other way. For example:

one believes with one's very own heart

**with your heart:** This phrase indicates the place where someone believes. It indicates truly believing something. For example:

in your heart (NLT)

**you believe:** The Greek verb here is passive, but the subject of the verb is not clear. Most English versions like the BSB change it into an active verb with a general subject. Others use a first or second person subject. For example:

one believes (ESV)

### 10:10b and are justified,

- which results in God making him right with himself.
- God says that they are right with him.

**and are justified:** The Greek is literally “into/resulting-in righteousness.” It shows that the outcome of a person's belief is that God will declare that he is righteous, like he did with Abraham (4:3). Here are other ways to translate this Greek phrase:

resulting in righteousness (NASB)

it is by believing in your heart that you are made right with God (NLT)

See how you translated this word in 2:13, where the BSB translates it as “declared righteous.”

### 10:10c and with your mouth you confess

- Also, with a person’s mouth/lips/tongue he tells aloud that Jesus is his Leader/Master,
- And whoever declares to others that he follows Jesus,

**with your mouth you confess:** The phrase with your mouth is emphasized by being first in the clause both in the Greek and in the BSB. In some languages the phrase must be in its usual place. If that is true in your language, emphasize this phrase, if possible, in some other way. For example:

one confesses with one’s very own mouth

**you confess:** The Greek verb here is passive, but the subject of the verb is not clear. Most English versions like the BSB change it into an active verb with a general subject. Others use a first or second person subject. For example:

one confesses (ESV)

### 10:10d and are saved.

- which results in God saving him.
- God will save him.

**and are saved:** The Greek is literally “into/resulting-in salvation.” It shows that the outcome of a person’s confession of Jesus as Lord (10:9) is that God will save him from his anger. Here are other ways to translate this Greek phrase:

resulting in salvation (NASB)

it is by confessing with your mouth that you are saved (NLT)

**are saved:** This clause is passive. Some languages must use an active clause. For example:

God saves

## Romans 10:11

### Section 10:5–15: Salvation for everyone is by faith not works

In this section Paul spoke about righteousness based on the Law of Moses and righteousness based on faith. The righteousness which comes from the Law is based on doing what the Law says. The righteousness which comes from faith is not based on what a person does but is instead a matter of the heart.

God rescues the person who believes in Jesus and announces that Jesus is his Lord. Paul said that this is true for both Jews and people who are not Jews. Jesus is Lord of all of them. and blesses them very much.

Paul then asked several questions for the believers in Rome to think about. He implied that someone must be sent and preach, and people must hear, believe, and call on Jesus. Paul ended the section with a quote from the Old Testament about how it is good to preach the good news.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

God saves anyone, Jew or Gentile, who believes in Jesus

Salvation by faith and the need for preaching near and far

### 10:11a It is just as the Scripture says:

- For God said in the Holy Book,
- Isaiah wrote in God’s Book,

**It is just as:** These words introduce support for what Paul said in 10:10.

**the Scripture says:** This clause introduces what God said in the Scripture. Some languages must refer to the actual speaker rather than a book for speaking. For example:

in Scripture God said

### 10:11b “Anyone who believes in Him will never be put to shame.”

- “Everyone who believes in him will not be caused to be ashamed.”
- “God will not shame anyone who believes in him.”

This is a quote of Isaiah 28:16. If you indicate the location of quotes from the Old Testament with cross-references, you may want to do so here.

**Anyone who believes in Him will never be put to shame:** This quote also occurs in 9:33d, but here Paul added the word Anyone. See how you translated the words believes in Him will never be put to shame in 9:33d.

## Romans 10:12

### Section 10:5–15: Salvation for everyone is by faith not works

In this section Paul spoke about righteousness based on the Law of Moses and righteousness based on faith. The righteousness which comes from the Law is based on doing what the Law says. The righteousness which comes from faith is not based on what a person does but is instead a matter of the heart.

God rescues the person who believes in Jesus and announces that Jesus is his Lord. Paul said that this is true for both Jews and people who are not Jews. Jesus is Lord of all of them. and blesses them very much.

Paul then asked several questions for the believers in Rome to think about. He implied that someone must be sent and preach, and people must hear, believe, and call on Jesus. Paul ended the section with a quote from the Old Testament about how it is good to preach the good news.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

God saves anyone, Jew or Gentile, who believes in Jesus

Salvation by faith and the need for preaching near and far

#### 10:12a

#### **For there is no difference between Jew and Greek:**

- For Jews and Greeks/Gentiles are the same before God,
- For Jews are the same as non-Jews regarding faith.

**For:** This word introduces an explanation about “anyone” in 10:11b.

**there is no difference between Jew and Greek:** This clause indicates that, regarding faith in Jesus and becoming God’s people, God’s promises are the same for Jews and people who are not Jews. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

there is no difference between Jews and Greeks (GW)

Jews and Greeks are the same in this regard

**Greek:** This word refers to people whose native language is Greek and to others who live according to Greek ways. Here it implies everyone who is not a Jew. Paul was not leaving out anyone in this verse. So in some languages it will be more clear to use the usual translation of the word “Gentile.” For example:

Gentile (NIV)

those who are Jews and those who are not (NCV)

You may then want to say what the literal word is and explain it here in a footnote. Here is an example footnote:

Literally: “Greek people.” But here Paul implied all people who are not Jews, because he was explaining the word “anyone” in 10:11.

If you translate the word Greek literally, you may want to explain Paul’s meaning here in a footnote. Here is an example footnote:

Here Paul implied all people who are not Jews, because he was explaining the word “anyone” in 10:11.

#### 10:12b

#### **The same Lord is Lord of all,**

- because the Lord is lord over all people,
- The Leader/Master Jesus is the one who rules over all believers.

The Greek of 10:12b begins with a word that is often translated as “for.” This word explains what Paul said in 10:12a. For example:

because the same Lord is Lord of all (REB)

In some languages omitting the word “for” and implying the connection is more natural, because of the word “For” in 10:12a. The BSB follows this approach.

**The same Lord is Lord of all:** This clause indicates that there is only one Lord, and he is Lord over all people. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

They all have the same Lord (GW)

the Lord is lord over everyone

There is just one Lord for all mankind  
Uma Back Translation on TW.

**Lord:** The word Lord refers to someone who has authority over people. Many scholars think it refers to Jesus here, but the GNT adds “God” here. If possible, do not say who this Lord is here.

Some languages must indicate who this Lord is. If that is true in your language, add “Jesus,” because Paul was clearly referring to Jesus in 10:11 (“believes in him”) and called him Lord in 10:9.

**10:12c**  
**and gives richly to all who call on Him,**

- and he gives generously to everyone who calls on him for help.
- And he gives great gifts to all who ask him for help.

**and gives richly to all:** Here the word richly refers to God’s generous gifts to those who believe, such as his kindness and patience (2:4), his glory (9:23) and his wisdom and knowledge (11:33). Here are other ways to translate this clause:

enriching all who call upon him (NABRE)

and richly blesses all who call on him (NIV)

who gives generously to all who call on him (NLT)

and he gives great gifts to the spirits/lives of everyone

**call on Him:** Here the Greek grammar called “middle voice” on the verb implies asking for help. For example:

asks for his help (CEV)

## Romans 10:13

**Section 10:5–15: Salvation for everyone is by faith not works**

In this section Paul spoke about righteousness based on the Law of Moses and righteousness based on faith. The righteousness which comes from the Law is based on doing what the Law says. The righteousness

which comes from faith is not based on what a person does but is instead a matter of the heart.

God rescues the person who believes in Jesus and announces that Jesus is his Lord. Paul said that this is true for both Jews and people who are not Jews. Jesus is Lord of all of them. and blesses them very much.

Paul then asked several questions for the believers in Rome to think about. He implied that someone must be sent and preach, and people must hear, believe, and call on Jesus. Paul ended the section with a quote from the Old Testament about how it is good to preach the good news.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

God saves anyone, Jew or Gentile, who believes in Jesus

Salvation by faith and the need for preaching near and far

**10:13**  
**for, “Everyone who calls on the name of the Lord will be saved.”**

- For it is also written in the Holy Book, “If someone calls out to the Lord in his name, he will save him.”
- And someone wrote in God’s Book, “The Leader/Master will save everyone who asks him.”

**for:** This word introduces an explanation of how the Lord provides riches to all who call on him.

**Everyone who calls on the name of the Lord will be saved:** This is a quote of Joel 2:32. If you indicate the location of quotes from the Old Testament with cross-references, you may want to do so here.

In some languages people prefer Old Testament quotes to be clearly introduced. For example:

as the Scripture says, “Anyone who calls on the Lord will be saved.” (NCV)

This clause is passive. Some languages must use an active clause. For example:

the Lord will save everyone who calls on his name

**calls on the name of the Lord:** The Greek word that the BSB translates as calls is in the middle voice, as in 10:12c. But here the help for which the people are calling is for God to save them. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:



ask the Lord for mercyKankanaey Back Translation on TW.

asks the Leader to be rescuedYakan Back Translation on TW.

**calls:** The present tense here refers to any time. It does not indicate continuing action here.

**the name of the Lord:** The phrase the name of refers to the person and the kind of person he is. People know that the Lord can save, so they call on him. See the examples above.

**the Lord:** This is a quote from the Old Testament, so the Lord refers to God. Do not add “Jesus” or “Jesus Christ” (as implied information) here. Also, if possible, do not add “God” here either, because Paul implied that the Lord applies to Jesus in 10:14.

## Romans 10:14

### Section 10:5–15: Salvation for everyone is by faith not works

In this section Paul spoke about righteousness based on the Law of Moses and righteousness based on faith. The righteousness which comes from the Law is based on doing what the Law says. The righteousness which comes from faith is not based on what a person does but is instead a matter of the heart.

God rescues the person who believes in Jesus and announces that Jesus is his Lord. Paul said that this is true for both Jews and people who are not Jews. Jesus is Lord of all of them. and blesses them very much.

Paul then asked several questions for the believers in Rome to think about. He implied that someone must be sent and preach, and people must hear, believe, and call on Jesus. Paul ended the section with a quote from the Old Testament about how it is good to preach the good news.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

God saves anyone, Jew or Gentile, who believes in Jesus

Salvation by faith and the need for preaching near and far

#### 10:14a

**How then can they call on the One in whom they have not believed?**

- ¶ Therefore, will they call on someone to save them if they do not believe in him? They will not.
- ¶ So, consider this: the people who do not believe in the Lord Jesus will not ask him to save them.

**How then can they call on the One in whom they have not believed?:** This is a rhetorical question. It

invites the reader to ponder how people would call on someone (to save them) if they do not believe in him. It implies that people must first believe in someone before calling on him to save them. Translate with that meaning. Here are some ways:

- As a rhetorical question. For example:

how can they call on him to save them unless they believe in him? (NLT)

How can people ask the Lord to save them, if they do not believe in him?

- As a statement. For example:

before people can ask the Lord for help, they must believe in him (NCV)

people must believe in the Lord before they can ask him to save them

**How then can:** The word then connects this question to what Paul just said. In some languages this word must be first in the clause. For example:

Therefore, how can

**they:** Here this word refers generally to anyone (“everyone,” 10:13).

**call:** This word has the same meaning as in 10:13.

**the One:** This word here refers to the Lord (10:13), implying Jesus.

**in whom they have not believed:** To “believe in” someone means to agree to what someone stands for, to trust him, to rely on him, to be committed to him. See how you translated this word in 1:16 or 10:11.

#### 10:14b–15a

The form of the Greek questions in 10:14b, 10:14c and 10:15a are the same as in 10:14a, where the BSB translates as “How...can they...?”

#### 10:14b

**And how can they believe in the One of whom they have not heard?**

- And will they believe in someone if they have not heard about him? They will not.
- And consider this: the people who have not heard about him cannot believe in him.

**And how can they believe in the One of whom they have not heard?:** This is a rhetorical question. It invites the reader to ponder how people would believe in someone if they have not heard of him. It implies that people must first hear of someone before they can believe in him. Translate with that meaning. Here are some ways:

- As a rhetorical question. For example:

how can they believe in him unless they hear about him?

how can they believe in him, if they have never heard about him?

- As a statement. For example:

before they can believe in him, they must hear about him (NCV)

people must hear about him before they can believe in him

#### 10:14c

#### **And how can they hear without someone to preach?**

- And will they hear about him if someone does not proclaim his message to them?
- And consider this: someone must preach about him for them to hear.

**And how can they hear without someone to preach?:** This is a rhetorical question. It invites the reader to ponder how people would hear about someone if no one has preached about him. It implies that someone must first preach about that person so that people can hear about him. Translate with that meaning. Here are some ways:

- As a rhetorical question. For example:

how can they hear about him unless someone tells them? (NLT)

how can they hear about him, if someone has not preached about him to them?

- As a statement. For example:

before they can hear about him, someone must preach about him

someone must preach about him before they can hear about him

**someone to preach:** The Greek word that the BSB translates as someone to preach means “someone who speaks important information or news loudly and in public.” Here are other ways to translate this word:

announce

proclaimed (GNT)

See how you translated this word in 2:21 or 10:8 (where the BSB translates it as “proclaiming”).

## Romans 10:15

### **Section 10:5–15: Salvation for everyone is by faith not works**

In this section Paul spoke about righteousness based on the Law of Moses and righteousness based on faith. The righteousness which comes from the Law is based on doing what the Law says. The righteousness which comes from faith is not based on what a person does but is instead a matter of the heart.

God rescues the person who believes in Jesus and announces that Jesus is his Lord. Paul said that this is true for both Jews and people who are not Jews. Jesus is Lord of all of them. and blesses them very much.

Paul then asked several questions for the believers in Rome to think about. He implied that someone must be sent and preach, and people must hear, believe, and call on Jesus. Paul ended the section with a quote from the Old Testament about how it is good to preach the good news.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

God saves anyone, Jew or Gentile, who believes in Jesus

Salvation by faith and the need for preaching near and far

#### 10:15a

#### **And how can they preach unless they are sent?**

- And will they preach there if someone does not send them?

- And consider this: someone must send them so that they will preach to that new group.

**And how can they preach unless they are sent?:** This is a rhetorical question. It invites the reader to ponder how preachers would preach to a new group of people if no one has sent them. It implies that someone must first send the preachers so that they can preach to this new group of people. Translate with that meaning. Here are some ways:

- As a rhetorical question. For example:

how will anyone go and tell them without being sent? (NLT)

how can they preach about him, if someone has not sent them?

- As a statement. For example:

before someone can go and tell them, that person must be sent (NCV)

someone must send people to preach

**they are sent:** The Greek word that the BSB translates as “preach” clearly implies that someone with authority sends them with a message to tell others. The preachers do not go on their own. In some languages that must be made clear. For example:

they are sent by their leader/Lord

This clause is passive. Some languages must translate it as an active clause. For example:

their leader/Lord sends them

#### General Comment on 10:14a–15a

The normal order is sending, preaching, hearing, believing, calling. Paul spoke of them in reverse order, probably to connect the quote of Isaiah 52:7a in Romans 10:15c to preaching at the end of his list (10:15a). In many languages the order that Paul spoke in can be translated naturally and be easily understood. In some languages it is much more natural to follow the normal order of things. For example:

<sup>14–15</sup>How then are they to preach unless they are sent? And how are they to hear without someone preaching? And how are they to believe in him of

whom they have never heard? And how will they call on him in whom they have not believed? As it is written, “How beautiful are the feet of those who preach the good news!”

<sup>14–15</sup>So then, if someone is not sent, how can he preach the Lord’s message? And if he does not preach, how can they hear? And if they do not hear, how can they believe in him? And if they do not believe, how can they call on him? As it is written, “How beautiful are the feet of those who preach the good news!”

#### 10:15b

##### As it is written:

- As someone wrote in Scriptures what God said,
- That is like what is written in God’s Word. Long ago God said,

**As it is written:** This phrase introduces a quote from the Old Testament. Paul quoted what God said to the nation of Israel. See how you translated this phrase in 1:17 or 9:33.

#### 10:15c

##### “How beautiful are the feet of those who bring good news!”

- “It is very wonderful when people come on foot bringing good news.”
- “When people arrive and announce good news, they are a blessing.”

These words are similar to the words in the first part of Isaiah 52:7. They are similar enough that the English versions put quote marks around it.

##### How beautiful are the feet of those who bring good news:

There is a textual issue in 10:15c: (1) Some Greek manuscripts have the words announce-good-news of-good (things) (BSB, RSV, NIV, GNT, NJB, NASB, NABRE, ESV, REB, NLT, GW, NET, NCV). (2) Some Greek manuscripts have the words announce-good-news of-peace and announce-good-news of-good (things) (KJV only). It is recommended that you follow option (1). Here the word How does not make this clause a question. It implies that the feet are very beautiful. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

it is a beautiful sight/thing when someone walks bringing good news

The coming of one who brings good news exceedingly causes-happiness!Kankanaey Back Translation on TW.

**How beautiful are the feet of those:** Here the word feet indicate that these people have traveled a long way on foot to bring good news. In some languages a literal translation would not indicate that. If that is true in your language, translate the correct meaning. For example:

The people who come on foot bringing good news  
are beautiful

**beautiful:** This is a figure of speech. It indicates that the arrival of such news is a blessing to the hearers. Here are other ways to translate this word:

wonderful (GNT)

welcome (REB)

are a blessing

See also the examples above.

**bring good news:** This is a quote from the Old Testament, so here the words good news do not refer to the gospel of Jesus. Do not use your key term for “gospel” here if it only refers to the gospel about Jesus. In some languages, not capitalizing the term is enough (good news versus “Good News”) to indicate the difference. In other languages, dropping the word “the” may help indicate the difference. For example:

preach good news (RSV)

The Greek can be translated literally as “announce-good-news of-good (things).” The verb “announce-good-news” here refers generally to any good news. The phrase “of-good (things)” also refers generally to any good news. Here is another way to translate these words:

comes with a good message/news

## Romans 10:16

### Section 10:16–21: The Jews do not believe and are stubborn

In this section Paul spoke about the Jews. They heard the good news about Jesus as the Christ/Messiah, but many did not believe it. God made some of them jealous of God bringing many non-Jews into his kingdom, even though they were not seeking him before they

heard the good news. Paul then quoted Isaiah about the Jews being disobedient and opposing God.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

Many Jews have rejected the gospel of Jesus

Gentiles accept Jesus but Jews reject him

### 10:16a

#### But not all of them welcomed the good news.

- ¶ But not all of them obeyed the good news about Jesus.
- ¶ But not all of the Jews believed the gospel and obeyed it.

**not all of them welcomed the good news:** Here the words not all indicate that some welcomed the good news and some did not. It does not say or imply how many of the total welcomed, only that it was not all. Some scholars think it means “few” here (for example, Moo and Cranfield). But Dunn (page 622) says that it does not specify how many, and Jewett (page 640) says, “ ‘only a very few’...would be (an) insult to the already large number of (Jewish) Roman converts.” This author thinks that “few” would apply today, but Paul probably did not think of the number of Jewish converts to Christianity as “few” when he wrote Romans. In some languages it is more natural to use or explain with “only some.” For example:

they have not all welcomed, only some of them did

only some of them welcomed

**them:** Many scholars say that Paul spoke of the Jews here. For example, Moo, Morris, Cranfield, Dunn, Schreiner, Jewett, and Lenski. The NIV makes that clear here:

the Israelites (NIV)

**good news:** The Greek word that the BSB translates as good news refers to the good news about God. Here are other ways to translate this word:

good/sweet news

good news about God

message/report that causes joy

See how you translated this word in 1:1 or 2:16.

#### 10:16b

**For Isaiah says,**

- For Isaiah said long ago,
- For/Indeed, the prophet Isaiah wrote long ago in God's word,

**For:** Here this word introduces support for what Paul said in 10:16a.

**Isaiah says:** This introduces a quote from the Old Testament. Isaiah spoke or wrote these words more than seven hundred years before Paul wrote Romans. Some languages make it clear the following words are from the Old Testament. For example:

In Scripture, Isaiah said long ago

**Isaiah:** Isaiah was one of the prophets of God. He wrote the book of Isaiah in the Old Testament. In some languages it is more clear to indicate that he was a prophet. For example:

the prophet Isaiah

**says:** The verb is present tense, but Isaiah wrote the words of 10:16c over seven hundred years before Paul lived. Greek scholars call it the historical present. In many languages the normal way of referring to a past event must be used. For example:

said (GNT)

#### 10:16c

**“Lord, who has believed our message?”**

- “Lord, who believed our<sup>(dual,incl)</sup> message to them?”
- “Leader/Master God, few people believed the message from us.”

This is a quote from Isaiah 53:1. If you indicate the location of quotes from the Old Testament with cross-references, you may want to do so here.

**Lord:** Here, this refers to God. Some languages must indicate who is lord. For example:

Lord God

**who has believed our message?:** This is a rhetorical question. It emphasizes that few people have believed

what Isaiah told them. Translate with that meaning. Here are some ways:

- As a rhetorical question. For example:

who has believed what he has heard from us?  
(ESV)

who believed what we told them? (NCV)

has anyone believed what we said? (CEV)

- As a statement. For example:

Few have believed our message.

Few people have believed what we told them.

Only a few believed what we said.

**our message:** This phrase is just three Greek words, “the report of-us.” The BDAG defines the main word as “account, report, message.” Sense 4.b (page 36). Here God told Isaiah what to say. For example:

what he has heard from us (ESV)

**our:** Here this word probably refers to Isaiah and God. God told him what to say to the Jews, and Isaiah told them that message.

## Romans 10:17

### Section 10:16–21: The Jews do not believe and are stubborn

In this section Paul spoke about the Jews. They heard the good news about Jesus as the Christ/Messiah, but many did not believe it. God made some of them jealous of God bringing many non-Jews into his kingdom, even though they were not seeking him before they heard the good news. Paul then quoted Isaiah about the Jews being disobedient and opposing God.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

Many Jews have rejected the gospel of Jesus

Gentiles accept Jesus but Jews reject him

#### 10:17a

**Consequently, faith comes by hearing,**

- Therefore, believing in Jesus happens from hearing about him,
- So, people must hear the message and then they can believe it.
- Therefore, people believe in Jesus as the Christ/Messiah because they have heard the message about him.

**faith comes by hearing:** The words comes by indicate that hearing is necessary before faith can begin. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

faith comes from what is heard (RSV)

all who did believe, believe because they heard the word they were told  
Otomi Back Translation on TW.

man[kind] must first hear the news and only then can they believe.  
Uma Back Translation on TW.

**faith:** This word refers to believing in Jesus, that he is the Christ, the one whom God sent to save people from his anger. See how you translated this word in 10:6.

#### **10:17b and hearing by the word of Christ.**

- and hearing about him happens by means of someone telling the message of Christ.
- And someone must preach the message about Christ so they can hear it.
- And people hear the/that message because someone preaches the talk about Christ.

**hearing by the word of Christ:** There is a textual issue in 10:17b: (1) Some Greek manuscripts have the word of-Christ (BSB, RSV, NIV, GNT, NJB, NASB, NABRE, ESV, REB, NLT, GW, NET, NCV). (2) Some Greek manuscripts have the word of-God (KJV only). It is recommended that you follow option (1). The word “comes” is implied here from 10:17a. Use the same word, phrase or grammar as you did there.

**by the word of Christ:** Here the word by indicates that someone speaks the word of Christ and others hear it. Jewett (page 642) says the word that the BSB translates as “by” “clearly indicates that the source of the hearing leading to faith is the preaching about Christ. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

through the word of Christ being spoken

through preaching Christ (GNT)

**the word of Christ:** This phrase refers to the teachings about Christ. Jewett (page 642) says it is the word “that Paul and other early missionaries have proclaimed.” In many languages the word of allows for that meaning. Other languages must translate without of for the correct meaning. For example:

the word about Christ (NIV11)

## **Romans 10:18**

### **Section 10:16–21: The Jews do not believe and are stubborn**

In this section Paul spoke about the Jews. They heard the good news about Jesus as the Christ/Messiah, but many did not believe it. God made some of them jealous of God bringing many non-Jews into his kingdom, even though they were not seeking him before they heard the good news. Paul then quoted Isaiah about the Jews being disobedient and opposing God.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

Many Jews have rejected the gospel of Jesus

Gentiles accept Jesus but Jews reject him

#### **10:18a But I ask, did they not hear?**

- But I ask this/that, have they heard it or not?
- But I ask, “Maybe people have not heard that message?”

**did they not hear?:** This is a rhetorical question. The Greek grammar indicates that Paul expected the readers to answer, “They have heard.” Paul answered the question himself in 10:18b. If possible, translate in a way that expects the answer “They have heard.” For example:

Is it perhaps possible that the Jews didn’t hear concerning Cristo? They indeed heard  
Kankanaey Back Translation on TW.

truly, it seems that they haven’t/didn’t hear, right? No. It is very true [that] they heard.  
Barok Back Translation, unpublished manuscript, Papua New Guinea.

Paul answered his own question in 10:18b, so you should translate this as a question.

**they:** Based on 10:18c–d, the word they probably refers to people in general. Moo (page 666) says, “Paul is speaking generally about all people but with special reference to Jews.”

### 10:18b

#### Indeed they did:

- Yes they have heard it.
- No, they certainly heard it!

**Indeed they did:** For an answer of they did (hear) to the question of 10:18a, some languages will preface it with “Yes” (or Indeed as the BSB) and some languages will preface it with “No.” Use the correct pattern for your language. For example:

Truly they heard  
Otomi Back Translation on TW.

But no. They definitely were told.  
Tagbanwa Back Translation on TW.

### 10:18c–d

**“Their voice has gone out into all the earth, their words to the ends of the world”:** This is a quote of the first two parts of Psalm 19:4. If you indicate the location of quotes from the Old Testament with cross-references, you may want to do so here.

### 10:18c

#### “Their voice has gone out into all the earth,

- For the Scriptures say, “Their spoken message has already spread throughout the earth,
- For it is as David wrote in God’s book, “They have taken the talk about God to people all over the world.

This is a quotation from the Old Testament. Some languages usually introduce Old Testament quotes in a certain way. For example:

Indeed, they did. As the Scriptures say,

Indeed, they did. It is as David said in the Holy Book,

**Their voice:** In Psalm 19:4, the word Their refers to the things in the sky like the sun and moon and stars. Here in this verse of Romans, Paul did not explain or indicate the meaning. He implied those taking the gospel of Jesus. But 10:18c–d is a quote from the Old Testament, so you should not explain Paul’s implied meaning in your translation of this verse. But you may want to explain the meaning in a footnote on this verse. Here is an example footnote:

In Psalm 19:4 the writer said that the heavens declare the glory of God even though they cannot speak. The shining of the sun, moon and stars is like a voice speaking about that glory to every part of the earth. Paul used that picture to assert that the gospel had gone out to everyone on earth, including the Jews.

Here, Paul spoke of those taking the gospel of Jesus to many places in the world.

**voice:** This word here refers to what people said, particularly the gospel about Jesus. In some languages a different word or phrase must be used for that meaning. For example:

message (NCV)

talk/news

**has gone out into all the earth:** This phrase indicates that the news of the gospel has spread into places other than where it started. So it refers to the gospel being heard in places all over the earth. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

has gone throughout the earth (NLT)

spread to the whole world  
Uma Back Translation on TW.

### 10:18d

#### their words to the ends of the world.”

- and their words have reached the farthest corners of the world.”
- They have taken it even to the farthest places.”

**their words to the ends of the world:** This phrase has a similar meaning to “Their voice has gone out to all the earth.” Hebrew poetry repeats similar meaning for emphasis. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

their words reached the ends of the earth (GNT)

<sup>18c</sup>for “Their voice has gone out to all the earth,  
<sup>18d</sup>their message has gone out to the farthest corners/places of the world

**the ends of the world:** This phrase refers to the farthest places in the world. See the above examples.

**General Comment on 10:18c–d**

In some languages repeating the same meaning is confusing or has a different meaning than emphasis. If that is true in your language, emphasize the meaning in another way. For example:

for “Their voice/message has gone out to all the earth, even the farthest places.”

**Romans 10:19****Section 10:16–21: The Jews do not believe and are stubborn**

In this section Paul spoke about the Jews. They heard the good news about Jesus as the Christ/Messiah, but many did not believe it. God made some of them jealous of God bringing many non-Jews into his kingdom, even though they were not seeking him before they heard the good news. Paul then quoted Isaiah about the Jews being disobedient and opposing God.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

Many Jews have rejected the gospel of Jesus

Gentiles accept Jesus but Jews reject him

**10:19a****I ask instead, did Israel not understand?**

- ¶ But I ask this/that, did the people of Israel understand it or not?
- ¶ But then I ask, “Maybe people have not understood that message?”
- ¶ I also say that the Israelites understood it.

**did Israel not understand?:** This is a rhetorical question. The Greek grammar, as in 10:18a, indicates that Paul expected the readers to answer, “They did understand.” If possible, translate in a way that expects the answer “They have heard.” Here are some ways:

- As a rhetorical question. For example:

Is it maybe possible that they didn’t understand what they heard? Kankanaey Back Translation on TW.

- As a statement. For example:

it is true that the Israelites understood. Barok Back Translation, abbreviated, unpublished manuscript, Papua New Guinea.

**Israel:** Here this name refers to the people of Israel, often called “the Jews.”

**understand:** Paul did not explicitly say here what was understood. He implies “the word of Christ” (10:17b) as he did in 10:18a. Some languages must say what is understood. For example:

understand it

understand that message

**10:19b****First, Moses says: “I will make you jealous by those who are not a nation;**

- First Moses said this: “I myself will cause you<sup>(plur)</sup> to resent a group of people who are not one people group,
- Moses wrote first about this. In Scripture God said to them, “I myself will cause you to be indignant against those who are not united as a nation/people-group.

The quote in 10:19b–c is from Deuteronomy 32:21. If you indicate the location of quotes from the Old Testament with cross-references, you may want to do so here.

**First, Moses says:** Here the word First indicates that Moses was the first one who wrote about God giving his message about the Christ/Messiah to non-Jews.

**Moses says:** The verb is present tense, but Moses wrote the words of 10:16c over 1,500 years before Paul lived. Greek scholars call it the historical present. In many languages the normal way of referring to a past event must be used. For example:

Moses said

The quote is Moses speaking on God’s behalf. The words are from God. The “I” in the quote refers to God, not Moses. For example:

Moses, for God, said

Moses, speaking for God, said

This clause introduces a quote from the Old Testament. Some languages usually introduce Old Testament quotes in a certain way. For example:

in the Scriptures Moses wrote what God said



Moses wrote in the Holy Book God saying this:

**I will make you jealous:** In the Greek the meaning of the word I is emphasized. For example:

I myself will make you jealous

**jealous:** Here this word refers to being resentful of someone for something they have. The Jews resent that Gentiles have attained the kingdom of God (and probably that they use Hebrew Scriptures, what many Christians now call the Old Testament). The Jews think that those things belong to them.

**those who are not a nation:** This refers to a variety of Gentiles. They come from many nations or people groups. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

people who are not even a nation (NLT)

a nation that is no nation (REB)

a group of people who are from all over

You should not translate this phrase with your key term for Gentiles.

#### 10:19c

**I will make you angry by a nation without understanding."**

- and I will make you angry using a nation/people-group that has little understanding/sense."
- I will cause you to become angry at a nation/people-group of foolish people."

**I will make you angry by a nation without understanding:** The Greek puts the phrase by a nation without understanding in the front of the clause as part of a Greek poetic form. In this case, two parts, having similar meaning to the two previous parts, are put in reverse order. They are: 1) I will make you jealous 2) of those who are not a nation; 3) with a foolish nation 4) I will make you angry. This poetic form puts the focus on the middle two parts. In some languages it must be in its usual place in the clause. For example:

I will make you angry with/using a nation without understanding

**without understanding:** The Greek word here refers to a lack of understanding, usually implying bad morals too. Here are other ways to translate this word:

that has no understanding (NIV)

without sense/thinking

#### General Comment on 10:19b–c

These words are a quote of Deuteronomy 32:21. If you indicate the location of quotes from the Old Testament with cross-references, you may want to do so here.

### Romans 10:20

#### Section 10:16–21: The Jews do not believe and are stubborn

In this section Paul spoke about the Jews. They heard the good news about Jesus as the Christ/Messiah, but many did not believe it. God made some of them jealous of God bringing many non-Jews into his kingdom, even though they were not seeking him before they heard the good news. Paul then quoted Isaiah about the Jews being disobedient and opposing God.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

Many Jews have rejected the gospel of Jesus

Gentiles accept Jesus but Jews reject him

#### 10:20a

**And Isaiah boldly says:**

- And Isaiah boldly said long ago,
- Also the prophet Isaiah, boldly wrote in God's word that he/God said this about the non-Jews,

**And:** The Greek word here is usually translated "and" or "but." Some English versions use "Then" to indicate that Isaiah spoke after Moses (10:19b). Isaiah lived many years after the time Moses lived.

**Isaiah boldly says:** The Greek is literally, "Isaiah is bold/daring and says." God spoke the words of 10:20b–c and Isaiah wrote them in Scripture. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

Isaiah is bold in/with writing these words of God:

Isaiah was fearless enough to tell that the Lord had said (CEV)

These words introduce a quote from the Old Testament. Some languages usually introduce Old Testament quotes in a certain way. For example:

in the Scriptures Isaiah boldly wrote what God said

Isaiah wrote in the Holy Book God boldly saying this

**says:** The Greek verb is present tense says, but Isaiah wrote the words of 10:20b–c over seven hundred years before Paul lived. Greek scholars call it the historical present. In many languages the normal way of referring to a past event must be used. For example:

to have said

Paul introduced the quote in 10:21b with the words “as for Israel,” which implies that the quote in 10:20b–c was about the Gentiles. If you want to make explicit who Paul spoke of in this verse, you should refer to the Gentiles. For example:

to say about the non-Jews

#### 10:20b

##### **“I was found by those who did not seek Me;**

- “I was discovered by people who were not seeking me,
- “People were not looking for me, but some of them found me.

The words of 10:20b–c are from Isaiah 65:1.

**I was found by those who did not seek Me:** This clause is passive. Some languages must translate with an active clause. For example:

those who did not seek me found me

**I was found:** Here the word found indicates that people learn who the true God is. It does not imply that God was lost or hiding. Translate with that meaning. For example:

I was discovered

they learned about me

**was found:** Here the word was indicates that in the past, at various times, people found God. Your translation should not indicate or imply that people found God all at the same time.

**those who did not seek Me:** The Greek verb here refers to seeking at any time. For example:

those not seeking me

#### 10:20c

##### **I revealed Myself to those who did not ask for Me.”**

- and I have made myself known to people who were not asking about me.”
- People were not asking others about who I was, but I revealed that/myself to them.”

**I revealed Myself:** There are numerous ways to interpret the Greek word that the BSB translates as revealed Myself. Here are the main ones:

1. Here it refers to God making himself manifest or revealing himself to people. For example:

I have shown myself (RSV) (BSB, RSV, NIV, NASB, KJV, ESV, NLT, NABRE, REB, NCV)

1. Here it refers to God making himself visible to people. For example:

I appeared (GNT) (GNT, NJB, CEV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1), because BDAG and L&N support it.

**those who did not ask for Me:** This phrase refers to people who asked others to tell them about the one true God. The Greek verb here refers to asking at any time. For example:

those not asking for me

## Romans 10:21

### **Section 10:16–21: The Jews do not believe and are stubborn**

In this section Paul spoke about the Jews. They heard the good news about Jesus as the Christ/Messiah, but many did not believe it. God made some of them jealous of God bringing many non-Jews into his kingdom, even though they were not seeking him before they heard the good news. Paul then quoted Isaiah about the Jews being disobedient and opposing God.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

Many Jews have rejected the gospel of Jesus

Gentiles accept Jesus but Jews reject him

### 10:21a

#### But as for Israel he says:

- But about Israel he/God said,
- But he/God said regarding/concerning the people of Israel,

**as for Israel:** Here the words as for mean “in reference to.” Jewett (page 648). Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

concerning Israel (NIV)

regarding Israel (NABRE)

**he:** God also spoke the quoted words of 10:21b, as in 10:20b–c, through Isaiah the prophet.

**says:** This is a historical present, as in 10:20a. In many languages the normal way of referring to a past event must be used. For example:

said

It also introduces a quote from the Old Testament. But you may not need to repeat “in Scripture” from 10:20a here.

### 10:21b

#### “All day long I have held out My hands to a disobedient and obstinate people.”

- “Every day I reached out to a people-group who always disobey and oppose me.”
- “I call out day and night to a people/nation who contradict me and do not obey.”

These words are from Isaiah 65:2. If you indicate the location of quotes from the Old Testament with cross-references, you may want to do so here.

**All day long:** This means “all the time.” God always reaches out to Israel, day and night. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

Day after day Otomi Back Translation on TW.

night and day Tagbanwa Back Translation on TW.

See how you translated this Greek phrase in 8:36 (“all the day long”).

**I have held out My hands:** This gesture indicates that God is inviting the Jews to turn back to him. Here are other ways to translate this clause with that meaning:

I held my arms open

I reached out

I offer my hand wanting to receive them Uma Back Translation on TW.

In some languages this gesture has a different meaning, or is not used. If that is true in your language, translate the correct meaning. For example:

I called Otomi Back Translation on TW.

I am always asking/begging them to return to me

**obstinate:** There are several ways to interpret the Greek word that the BSB translates as obstinate:

1. It means here opposing God either in thinking or with words. For example:

contentious (NABRE) (RSV, ESV, NABRE)

1. It means here being stubborn about something. For example:

stubborn (NET) (BSB, NIV, NASB, NET, CEV, NCV)

1. It means here rebelling against God’s authority. For example:

rebellious (GNT) (GNT, NJB, NLT, GW)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1), because the BDAG and the L&N support it.

## Romans 11:1

### Section 11:1–10: God has not rejected the Jews

In this section Paul, using a rhetorical question, said that God had certainly not rejected his chosen people, the Jews. Then he spoke of several ways that showed that God has not rejected them. Paul spoke again of God’s grace being the basis for him choosing who will be his people. The basis is not what people do.

Then Paul explained why only some Jews have accepted Jesus as the Christ/Messiah. God caused some

of them to reject Christ for his own purposes (which was so that many non-Jews would believe in Jesus (11:12)).

Here are other possible headings for this section:

God has kept a remnant of Jews as his people

At this time, in grace, God has chosen some Israelites/Jews

#### 11:1a

#### **I ask then, did God reject His people?**

- ¶ So am I saying that God has abandoned/disowned his people Israel?
- ¶ So I ask, Does this mean that God has ended his relationship with his people, the Jews?

**I ask then:** Here the word then introduces something someone might think based on what Paul said in 10:21 (“But as for Israel he says: ‘All day long I have held out My hands to a disobedient and obstinate people.’”). For example:

So I ask (NET)

In many languages the word then (or “so”) must be first in the clause, as in the above example.

**I ask:** The Greek is literally “I say,” but it is more natural in many languages to translate as I ask, because a question follows.

**did God reject His people?:** This is a rhetorical question. Paul answered it in 11:1b. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

God has not rejected His people, has He? (NASB)

is it possible that God abandoned his people? (NJB)

Am I saying that God has turned his back on his people? (CEV)

**reject:** This Greek word refers here to no longer calling the Jews his chosen people and not doing things for them as he had promised. See the above examples.

**His people:** This phrase refers to the people of Israel (10:21). In some languages people would think a literal translation refers to Christians. If that is true in your language, indicate the correct meaning. For example:

his people Israel (GW)

his own people, the nation of Israel (NLT)

#### 11:1b

#### **Certainly not!**

- Certainly not!
- No indeed!
- Indeed, he has not!

**Certainly not!:** The Greek is literally “May it not be.” It indicates a very strong “no.” People are not to think that God has rejected his people Israel. See how you translated this phrase in 3:4 or 9:14.

#### 11:1c

#### **I am an Israelite myself, a descendant of Abraham,**

- For I myself am one of the people of Israel, I am a descendant of Abraham,
- I say that because I belong to the people of Israel. I descend from Abraham,

**I am an Israelite myself:** The “-ite” ending in English means “a person of.” For example:

I am one of the people of Israel (CEV)

I am a man of Israel

**a descendant:** The Greek here is literally “seed.” Here it means descendant, like many English versions translate. Some languages can use a literal translation for the correct meaning. For example:

seed

Some languages must translate without the metaphor, as the BSB does.

#### 11:1d

#### **from the tribe of Benjamin.**

- I am from the clan of Benjamin.
- and I belong to the group/clan of Benjamin, the son of Israel.

**from the tribe of Benjamin:** The Greek is literally “of the tribe/clan of Benjamin.” Benjamin was a son of the man Jacob, whom God named Israel. Benjamin’s descendants are then the clan of Benjamin. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

from the clan of Benjamin

as for my ancestors, they came from the clan of the descendants of Benjamin  
Tagbanwa Back Translation on TW.

a descendant of Benjamin

The BDAG defines the Greek word as “a subgroup of a nation.” The Greek word does not refer to a whole nation/people-group. The Jews are the nation of Israel. One of the twelve clans of Israel was the clan of Benjamin.

## Romans 11:2

### Section 11:1–10: God has not rejected the Jews

In this section Paul, using a rhetorical question, said that God had certainly not rejected his chosen people, the Jews. Then he spoke of several ways that showed that God has not rejected them. Paul spoke again of God’s grace being the basis for him choosing who will be his people. The basis is not what people do.

Then Paul explained why only some Jews have accepted Jesus as the Christ/Messiah. God caused some of them to reject Christ for his own purposes (which was so that many non-Jews would believe in Jesus (11:12)).

Here are other possible headings for this section:

God has kept a remnant of Jews as his people

At this time, in grace, God has chosen some Israelites/Jews

### 11:2a

#### God did not reject His people, whom He foreknew.

- God has not abandoned/disowned his people Israel. Hey/Indeed, he knew at the beginning of time who they would be.
- God has not ended his relationship with his people, the Jews. No, he knew long ago that he would choose them.

**God did not reject His people:** This repeats the thought in 11:1a but in a statement rather than a question. Here the word not is explicit.

**His people, whom He foreknew:** The clause whom He foreknew further describes His people. It does not separate some of his people from other of his people. For the correct meaning in some languages, translators must avoid the word whom. For example:

his people. He foreknew them.

his people, indeed, he foreknew them

**foreknew:** This word refers to knowing about something before it exists or before it happens. Here it also implies that God chose Israel as his people before they existed. Moo (page 674) says, “the ‘know’ in the verb ‘foreknow’ refers to God’s election.... The temporal prefix, ‘fore-’ (pro-), indicates further that God’s choosing of Israel took place before any action or status on the part of Israel that might have qualified her for God’s choice.” Schreiner (page 580) says that the word “does not merely connote foreknowledge but also implies foreordination.” For example:

chose from the very beginning (NLT)

See how you translated this word in 8:29.

### 11:2b–c

**Do you not know what the Scripture says about Elijah, how he appealed to God against Israel:** This is a rhetorical question. It emphasizes that the believers in Rome should know what the Scripture says about what Elijah said against Israel (11:3) and God’s reply (11:4). Translate with that meaning. This question is not a rebuke. Here are some ways:

- As a rhetorical question. For example:

Do/Maybe you know what the Scripture says about Elijah and how he appealed to God against Israel?

Have you thought about the talk in Scripture about Elijah when he asked God to punish Israel?

- As a statement. For example:

You know what the scripture says in the passage where Elijah pleads with God against Israel. (GNT)

Think again about the talk in Scripture about Elijah when he asked God to punish Israel

Paul here only questioned their knowledge. He did not question what Elijah said to God. For example:

Do you realize what the Scriptures say about this? Elijah the prophet appealed to God about the people of Israel and said, (NLT)

**11:2b****Do you not know what the Scripture says about Elijah,**

- Do/Perhaps you know the Scripture that spoke about Elijah
- Think about what God's Book says about the prophet/spokesman Elijah.

**the Scripture:** This is more literally "the writing." But in the New Testament this word is always used for all or part of God's Holy written Word. At the time only Genesis to Malachi, what Christians now call the Old Testament, was called Scripture.

**Elijah:** Elijah was a prophet of God. Scripture talks about him in 1 Kings 17 – 2 Kings 2.

**11:2c****how he appealed to God against Israel:**

- and his words to God against the Israelites? He said,
- He complained to God about the people of Israel,

**appealed to God against Israel:** The Greek word that the BSB translates as appealed here refers to Elijah accusing Israel of wrongdoing. Jewett (page 655). Here are other ways to translate this word:

complained to God about the people of Israel  
(NLT)

blamed Israel before God

**Romans 11:3****Section 11:1–10: God has not rejected the Jews**

In this section Paul, using a rhetorical question, said that God had certainly not rejected his chosen people, the Jews. Then he spoke of several ways that showed that God has not rejected them. Paul spoke again of God's grace being the basis for him choosing who will be his people. The basis is not what people do.

Then Paul explained why only some Jews have accepted Jesus as the Christ/Messiah. God caused some of them to reject Christ for his own purposes (which was so that many non-Jews would believe in Jesus (11:12)).

Here are other possible headings for this section:

God has kept a remnant of Jews as his people

At this time, in grace, God has chosen some Israelites/Jews

**11:3a****"Lord, they have killed Your prophets**

- "Lord, they killed your prophets,
- "Leader/Master God, they have killed the other prophets/spokesmen of yours.

The quote in this verse is from 1 Kings 19:10, 14. If you indicate the location of quotes from the Old Testament with cross-references, you may want to do so here.

**Lord:** The word Lord refers to someone who has authority over people. This is a quote from the Old Testament, so this word refers to God. Do not add "Jesus" or "Jesus Christ" (as implied information) here. See how you translated this word in 4:8 or 10:16.

**Your prophets:** Elijah was also among the Lord God's prophets, so in some languages it will be more clear to indicate that. For example:

the other prophets of yours

A "prophet" is a person who speaks on behalf of God. God's message may be in words or visions. He then tells the people God's message. It may reveal something about a past, present, or future event, or it may reveal someone's thoughts, motives, or attitudes. It is not like a sermon, prepared by the preacher's study of the Bible, but God may inspire a preacher with a prophecy during a sermon. The person speaks the prophecy to the people or writes it down for their use. Here are other ways to translate the word prophets:

- Translate the meaning. For example:

spokespeople for you

those who speak/bring your message/words

your message-speakers

- If the translated meaning of prophets is unclear, use the major language word. For example:

porofets

It is good to use a general term that does not focus only on foretelling the future. Although prophets did foretell the future, they also gave people other messages from God. They especially told them to stop doing what is wrong and to obey God. See how you translated this word in 1:2.

**11:3b****and torn down Your altars.**

- and they have destroyed the altars where people worshiped you.
- They also have destroyed the platforms where people sacrificed to you.

**and torn down Your altars:** Although the Greek word that the BSB often translates as and is not in the Greek of 11:3b, many languages must have an and at the beginning of this clause to connect it properly to 11:3a, as the BSB does. Here is another way to translate this:

and they have demolished your altars

**torn down:** The Greek word that the BSB translates as torn down refers to forcefully taking something apart so it cannot be used again. Here are other ways to translate this word:

destroyed (CEV)

demolished (ESV)

**altars:** An “altar” is a platform on which people offer sacrifices to God. Below is an artist’s idea of what the small altar at the temple in Jerusalem looked like.

If possible you should translate altars in a general way. For example:

the place for putting things for God

the place for burning sacrifices to honor God

**11:3c****I am the only one left, and they are seeking my life as well?”**

- I myself am the last one alive/standing, and they seek to kill me.”
- I myself am the only prophet remaining/still alive. And they are trying/wanting to kill me also!”

**I am the only one left:** Elijah implied here that no one else in Israel followed God, or it could refer to Elijah being the last prophet of God. Morris (page 400) says that Elijah was thinking of people obeying God based on God’s answer in the next verse. But this author thinks that God could have changed to speaking of people in order to encourage Elijah if all the other prophets of God had been killed. It is more likely that Elijah was still thinking of prophets (11:3a) here rather

than anticipating what God would say in response. For example:

I am the only prophet left (NCV)

**I:** This word is emphasized in the Greek.

**they are seeking my life as well:** This is a figure of speech. It indicates that these people were looking for a way to kill Elijah. Some languages must translate without the figure of speech for the correct meaning. For example:

they seek a way to kill me

they want to kill me (NJB)

**Romans 11:4****Section 11:1–10: God has not rejected the Jews**

In this section Paul, using a rhetorical question, said that God had certainly not rejected his chosen people, the Jews. Then he spoke of several ways that showed that God has not rejected them. Paul spoke again of God’s grace being the basis for him choosing who will be his people. The basis is not what people do.

Then Paul explained why only some Jews have accepted Jesus as the Christ/Messiah. God caused some of them to reject Christ for his own purposes (which was so that many non-Jews would believe in Jesus (11:12)).

Here are other possible headings for this section:

God has kept a remnant of Jews as his people

At this time, in grace, God has chosen some Israelites/Jews

**11:4a****And what was the divine reply to him?**

- But what was the divine/heavenly response to him?
- But what did God say to him in return/reply? He said this:
- But God said this to him:

**And what was the divine reply to him?:** This is a rhetorical question. Paul answered this question in 11:4b–c. Some languages must translate this as a statement. For example:

God replied to him like/with this:

In Greek, this is a historical present. In many languages the normal way of referring to a past event must be used, which is what the BSB does here. Here is another way to translate this:

what did God say/reply to him?

**the divine reply:** The Greek is literally “the divine-answer.” Here it refers to the words God spoke in response to Elijah’s complaint. For example:

the divine response (NASB)

God’s answer (NIV)

#### 11:4b

##### “I have reserved for Myself seven thousand men

- “I have reserved for myself seven thousand (7,000) men,
- “No, not you only. I have seven thousand other men whom I have set apart to remain faithful to me.

##### **I have reserved for Myself seven thousand men:**

Here the words reserved for Myself refers to holding a part/portion of something for future use. For example, a farmer eats or sells most of his grain but holds back some grain for next year’s planting. Here God allowed many Israelites to worship the false god Baal, but caused some of the Israelites to remain faithful to him. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

I have kept for myself (ESV)

I have separated out seven thousand men to remain my people

I have prevented seven thousand men from falling away and they remain faithful to me

**seven thousand men:** The Greek word that the BSB translates as men usually refers to adult human males. That is probably its meaning here.

**seven thousand:** Some languages do not have large numbers like thousand. If that is true in your language, you may want to:

- Use numerals. For example:

7,000 (GW)

- Use the major language word. For example:

seven tausen

#### 11:4c

##### **who have not bowed the knee to Baal.”**

- and they have not knelt in worship to Baal.”
- They have not worshiped the false god Baal.”

**have not bowed the knee to Baal:** The phrase bowed the knee means “kneel.” This action indicates submitting to the person or god before whom they bow. It implies honoring that person or god and is a common action used in worship. That is the implied meaning here. For example:

have not knelt to worship Baal (GW)

In some languages kneeling has a different meaning. If that is true in your language, you may want to:

- Use the action in your language that implies worship. For example:

have not bowed-at-the-waist in worship to Baal

- Translate the implied meaning without any explicit action. For example:

have not worshiped Baal (CEV)

**Baal:** This word means “lord” in the Canaanite languages of the peoples living near Israel. It was often used like a name for the chief god of the Canaanite peoples. To the Jews who followed Yahweh, the God of Israel, Baal was a false god. In some languages this name will need to be explained. You may want to:

##### **General Comment on 11:4b–c**

- Explain it in your translation. For example:

the false god Baal (GNT)

- Explain it in a footnote. Here is an example footnote:

This name refers to the chief false god of the peoples living near Israel.

These words are a quote of 1 Kings 19:18. If you indicate the location of quotes from the Old Testament with cross-references, you may want to do so here.



## Romans 11:5

### Section 11:1–10: God has not rejected the Jews

In this section Paul, using a rhetorical question, said that God had certainly not rejected his chosen people, the Jews. Then he spoke of several ways that showed that God has not rejected them. Paul spoke again of God's grace being the basis for him choosing who will be his people. The basis is not what people do.

Then Paul explained why only some Jews have accepted Jesus as the Christ/Messiah. God caused some of them to reject Christ for his own purposes (which was so that many non-Jews would believe in Jesus (11:12)).

Here are other possible headings for this section:

God has kept a remnant of Jews as his people

At this time, in grace, God has chosen some Israelites/Jews

#### 11:5a

### In the same way, at the present time there is a remnant

- Therefore, today also the chosen portion exists,
- And it is also like that now. God has chosen only some of the Jews to believe in Jesus.

**In the same way:** The Greek words here are “in-that-manner therefore also.” The word “in-that-manner” indicates that what is happening now is like what happened in the past. God chose a remnant in the time of Elijah and he chose a remnant in the time of Paul. The word “therefore” indicates that Paul said something based on what he said earlier. The word “also” indicates that something happened again that was similar to what happened earlier. Here are other ways to translate this Greek phrase:

So too (ESV)

In just the same way (REB)

What it is like now in our time is like that, Kankanaey Back Translation on TW.

**there is a remnant:** The Greek is more literally “a remnant has begun existing.” God chose a small number of Jews to believe in him in the time of Elijah, and he chose a small number of Jews to believe in Jesus as

the Christ/Messiah in Paul's time. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

there are not many Jews who have been chosen

God has chosen a few people only among all the people Nalik Back Translation, draft, Papua New Guinea.

**remnant:** This word means “the portion left behind” or “the portion still remaining.” God will save only some Israelites. See how you translated this word in 9:27.

#### 11:5b

### chosen by grace.

- according to God choosing to be kind to them.
- God chose them as a gift to them.

**chosen by grace:** The Greek is more literally “according to a choice of grace.” God chose these Jews because he wanted to bless them, not because of anything that they had done. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

whom God has chosen because of his grace (GNT)

his undeserved kindness in choosing them (NLT)

because he was kind and chose them

**grace:** This word refers to kindness that is given to people without requiring anything in return. This kindness is not given because they have done anything to deserve it. See how you translated this word in 1:5 or 6:15.

## Romans 11:6

### Section 11:1–10: God has not rejected the Jews

In this section Paul, using a rhetorical question, said that God had certainly not rejected his chosen people, the Jews. Then he spoke of several ways that showed that God has not rejected them. Paul spoke again of God's grace being the basis for him choosing who will be his people. The basis is not what people do.

Then Paul explained why only some Jews have accepted Jesus as the Christ/Messiah. God caused some of them to reject Christ for his own purposes (which was so that many non-Jews would believe in Jesus (11:12)).

Here are other possible headings for this section:

God has kept a remnant of Jews as his people

At this time, in grace, God has chosen some Israelites/Jews

### 11:6a

#### And if it is by grace,

- But if they are chosen because of kindness,
- And/Yes, God chose them as a gift to them,

**if it is by grace:** Here the word if introduces a situation that is true. If this first part is true, that supports the second part (“it is no longer by works”) to also be true.

In some languages, using an if-clause would have a different meaning. If that is true in your language, translate the correct meaning. For example:

should it be by grace, and it is,

the basis of God choosing is grace, so

See how you translated this kind of if in 3:5 or 9:22.

**it is by grace:** The Greek is literally “by-grace.” The BSB and many English versions add the words it is for a natural English translation.

### 11:6b

#### then it is no longer by works.

- then that choosing is not based on their deeds,
- so no one can say that God chose them because of something they did.

**it is no longer by works:** The words no longer indicate that someone might have considered that God’s choosing was based on what that person did, but God has made it clear that it is not. These words do not imply that at one time God did choose people based on what they did. For example, see Moo (page 678), where he says that it is a logical distinction and not a distinction in time, that is, before and after some point in time. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

it is therefore not on the basis of works

**by works:** Here this phrase indicates that a person’s deeds are what is looked at when deciding something. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

based on works/deeds

**works:** Here this word refers generally to deeds. It does not refer to things done in a job or for business.

### 11:6c

#### Otherwise, grace would no longer be grace.

- or grace would cease to be grace. (REB)
- But if it was true that it was based on their deeds, God’s kindness would be worthless/meaningless in this case.
- But if had it been because of something they did, then grace is gone here.

**Otherwise, grace would no longer be grace:** There is a textual issue in 11:6c: (1) Some Greek manuscripts have the words grace no-more becomes grace (BSB, RSV, NIV, GNT, NJB, NASB, NABRE, ESV, REB, NLT, GW, NET, NCV). (2) Some later Greek manuscripts have the words grace no-more becomes grace, but if of works, then is it no more grace: otherwise work is no more work (KJV only). It is recommended that you follow option (1). The word Otherwise introduces what might be true if God did choose people based on what they did. In this case, grace would accomplish nothing. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

For in that case, God’s grace would not be what it really is—free and undeserved. (NLT)

God’s gift of grace would not really be a gift (NCV)

if the good they had done were the cause, it would not be possible for us to say it was graceKankanaey Back Translation on TW.

If they had been chosen through what they themselves have done, his grace would be meaninglessYongkom Back Translation, unpublished manuscript, Papua New Guinea.

## Romans 11:7

### Section 11:1–10: God has not rejected the Jews

In this section Paul, using a rhetorical question, said that God had certainly not rejected his chosen people, the Jews. Then he spoke of several ways that showed that God has not rejected them. Paul spoke again of God’s grace being the basis for him choosing who will be his people. The basis is not what people do.

Then Paul explained why only some Jews have accepted Jesus as the Christ/Messiah. God caused some of them to reject Christ for his own purposes (which was so that many non-Jews would believe in Jesus (11:12)).

Here are other possible headings for this section:

God has kept a remnant of Jews as his people

At this time, in grace, God has chosen some Israelites/Jews

### 11:7a

#### What then?

- ¶ What do we/I conclude?
- ¶ So/Well then, in conclusion I say this:

**What then?:** This is a rhetorical question. It introduces what Paul said in 11:7b. Translate it with that meaning. Here are some ways:

- As a rhetorical question. For example:

What does all this mean?

What shall we conclude then?

What then will we say?

- As a statement. For example:

This means that... (CEV)

What all these things mean to say is thatKankanaey Back Translation on TW.

See how you translated this question in 3:9 or 6:15, but note that in those verses another question follows.

### 11:7b

#### What Israel was seeking, it failed to obtain,

- The Israelites did not achieve what they were seeking to achieve.
- The people of Israel did not succeed in becoming right with God, even though they were trying to.

**What Israel was seeking, it failed to obtain:** Here the word What may refer to righteousness (9:31, 10:3–5) For example, Barrett (page 210), Lenski (page 685), and Alford (page 427). or something else. Your translation should imply righteousness or something similar.

**seeking:** There are several ways to interpret the Greek word that the BSB translates as seeking:

1. It means to search for something, as in the BSB. (BSB, RSV, GNT, NJB, NASB, KJV, ESV, NABRE, CEV, REB)

2. It means to search hard for something. For example:

sought so earnestly (NIV) (NIV, NLT, NET)

1. It means to strive for something. For example:

striving for (GW) (GW)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1), because many Greek lexicons and scholars support it.

**obtain:** Here this word refers to becoming the people they wanted to be. They wanted to be right with God and looked for the way to do that, but they did not achieve it. Here are other ways to translate this word:

attain (NABRE)

achieve (GW)

succeed (NCV)

### 11:7c

#### but the elect did.

- The people who were chosen have achieved what the Israelites were seeking,
- Only those whom God chose have succeeded in becoming right with God.

**the elect:** The word elect refers to the people who are chosen. Here it refers to those whom God has chosen to save. Here are other ways to translate this word:

those who were chosen (NJB)

the ones God has chosen (NLT)

Here this word probably refers only to the Jews whom God has chosen to believe in Jesus as the Christ/Messiah. See Moo (page 679).

### 11:7d

#### The others were hardened,

- but the others were made close-minded.
- But as for the rest, God made them stubborn.
- But God made the others unable to accept the truth.

**The others were hardened:** This clause is passive. Some languages must translate with an active clause. For example:

God hardened the rest

**The others:** Here the word others refers to those who are not the elect (11:7c).

**hardened:** This word means “to cause someone to have difficulty in understanding (something),” BDAG (page 900). or “to cause someone to be completely unwilling to learn and to accept new information.” L&N §27.51. Here are other ways to translate this word:

made stubborn and refused to listen to God (NCV)

made their minds closed

## Romans 11:8

### Section 11:1–10: God has not rejected the Jews

In this section Paul, using a rhetorical question, said that God had certainly not rejected his chosen people, the Jews. Then he spoke of several ways that showed that God has not rejected them. Paul spoke again of God’s grace being the basis for him choosing who will be his people. The basis is not what people do.

Then Paul explained why only some Jews have accepted Jesus as the Christ/Messiah. God caused some of them to reject Christ for his own purposes (which was so that many non-Jews would believe in Jesus (11:12)).

Here are other possible headings for this section:

God has kept a remnant of Jews as his people

At this time, in grace, God has chosen some Israelites/Jews

### 11:8a–b

**God gave them a spirit of stupor, eyes that could not see, and ears that could not hear:** There are several ways to interpret the connection of eyes that could not see, and ears that could not hear (11:8b) to God gave them a spirit of stupor (11:8a):

1. It is an additional description of the Jews, as with the comma in the BSB. (BSB, REV, NIV, ESV, NABRE, KJV, NASB, NET, NLT, GW)
2. Both parts describe the same thing. The semi-colon implies this in English. For example:

God has infused them with a spirit of lethargy; until today they have not eyes to see or ears to hear (NJB) (GNT, NJB, REB)

1. The stupor is the cause for the eyes not seeing and ears not hearing. For example:

God made them so stupid that their eyes are blind, and their ears are still deaf (CEV) (CEV, NCV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1), because many scholars also use a comma here.

In some languages adding an “and” would be more natural. For example:

God gave them a spirit of stupor, and eyes that would not see and ears that would not hear

### 11:8a

**as it is written: “God gave them a spirit of stupor,**

- As someone wrote in Scripture, “God made them unable to think,
- That is like what is written in God’s Word: God caused them to become unable to understand his truth.

11:8a–c is a quote from parts of Isaiah 29:10 and Deuteronomy 29:4. If you indicate the location of quotes from the Old Testament with cross-references, you may want to do so here.

**as it is written:** This phrase introduces a quote from the Old Testament. Paul quoted what God said to the nation of Israel. See how you translated this phrase in 1:17 or 10:15.

**God gave them a spirit of stupor:** Here the word spirit refers to a condition or state of being. The Jews would always be in a stupor until the time God takes that stupor away. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

God made their minds and hearts dull (GNT)

**stupor:** This word refers to being unable to respond, like when someone cannot think well or is deeply asleep. The KJV, NABRE, NLT, and GW translate this word as “deep sleep” or “slumber,” but the BDAG, L&N, Kittel, and L&S Greek lexicons all translate this word as “stupor” or “stupefaction.” Here the Jews could not understand God’s truth, in particular about his Christ/Messiah, Jesus. Here are other ways to translate this word:

being unable to think Yongkom Back Translation, unpublished manuscript, Papua New Guinea.

not able to sense/be-aware-of (anything)Tagbanwa Back Translation on TW.

God made their minds to become numb so that they might not understandWestern Bukidnon Manobo Back Translation on TW.

### 11:8b

**eyes that could not see, and ears that could not hear,**

- and their eyes could not see, and their ears could not hear,
- And they became like blind and deaf people,
- And regarding his truth they became as if blind and deaf to it.

**eyes that could not see, and ears that could not hear:** The Greek is literally “eyes of-the not seeing and ears of-the not hearing.” It is a figure of speech. It indicates that the Jews could not see or understand God’s truth, in particular about his Christ/Messiah, Jesus. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

eyes that could not see and ears that could not hear (NIV11)

they have not eyes to see or ears to hear (NJB)

he has shut their eyes so they do not see, and closed their ears so they do not hear (NLT)

they could not understand (NCV)

### 11:8c

**to this very day.”**

- even to today.”
- and they continue to be like that even today.
- And the Jews are still like that.

**to this very day:** The Greek is literally “until the today day.” In the passage Paul quoted from, it referred to the forty years that the Jews wandered in the desert before reaching the promised land, going to the day Moses spoke these words. Paul implied that it was still true over a thousand years later when he wrote this letter to the Roman believers. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

down to this very day (ESV)

and so it is to this day (REB)

This continues until today. (NCV)

## Romans 11:9

### Section 11:1–10: God has not rejected the Jews

In this section Paul, using a rhetorical question, said that God had certainly not rejected his chosen people, the Jews. Then he spoke of several ways that showed that God has not rejected them. Paul spoke again of God’s grace being the basis for him choosing who will be his people. The basis is not what people do.

Then Paul explained why only some Jews have accepted Jesus as the Christ/Messiah. God caused some of them to reject Christ for his own purposes (which was so that many non-Jews would believe in Jesus (11:12)).

Here are other possible headings for this section:

God has kept a remnant of Jews as his people

At this time, in grace, God has chosen some Israelites/Jews

### 11:9a

**And David says:**

- And David said,
- And it is like what King David said long ago in Scripture. He said,

**David says:** This is a historical present. In many languages the normal way of referring to a past event must be used. For example:

David said (NLT)

This clause introduces a quote from Scripture. Some language translations always note that in their translations. For example:

David, in Scripture, said long ago

But 11:8 was also a quote from Scripture, so it may not be necessary to make it explicit again here that the following words are Scripture.

**David:** This name refers to King David, king of the Israelites. He lived about a thousand years before Paul wrote this letter. Some language translations always indicate that he was king. For example:

king DavidTagbanwa Back Translation on TW.

**11:9b****“May their table become a snare and a trap,**

- “Their table must become a bird-trap or an animal-trap
- “May the time they sit at the table to eat become the time that God traps them or captures them

**May their table become a snare and a trap:** Here David asked God to make the table of his enemies become a snare and a trap.

Paul applied this to a different group of people than David did. You should not explain who their refers to in your translation. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

Let their table become a snare and a trap (ESV)

Turn their table into a snare and a trap

**table:** Here the word table refers to the meal table. It represents the meals eaten there and in particular the fellowship of the people at the table. Here are other ways to translate this word:

place of eating

meals (CEV)

fellowship at the table

**snare:** The Greek word here refers to a thing for trapping animals, often birds.

**trap:** The Greek word here refers to a net or similar device for catching animals, usually not birds.

**General Comment on 11:9b**

The words “snare” and “trap” are figures of speech here. They imply harm to those snared or trapped. In some languages a literal translation would refer only to an actual snare and an actual trap. If that is true in your language, you may want to:

- Add the word “like” or a word or phrase of similar meaning. For example:

Let their table become something like a snare and a trap/net

- Translate the meaning without the figure of speech. For example:

Let their own feasts trap them and cause their ruin (NCV)

**11:9c****a stumbling block and a retribution to them.**

- or a trigger-trap or retaliation to them.
- or causes them to fall or avenges/pays-back their evil deeds.

The Greek has the word usually translated “and” or “but.” Here it continues the list of bad things that David wanted to happen to his enemies. For example:

and a stumbling block...

**a stumbling block:** This refers to something that causes a person to trip or fall. See how you translated this Greek word in 9:33 (“that will make them fall” (NRSV)) or Matthew 16:23 (“a stumbling block” (NIV)) or 1 Corinthians 1:23 (“stumbling block”) or 1 Peter 2:8 (“of stumbling”).

**a retribution:** Here the word retribution refers to what is paid back. Here it refers to bad consequences back to themselves for their evil deeds or punishment for them. Here are other ways to translate this word:

punishment (GW)

be paid back (NCV)

**Romans 11:10****Section 11:1–10: God has not rejected the Jews**

In this section Paul, using a rhetorical question, said that God had certainly not rejected his chosen people, the Jews. Then he spoke of several ways that showed that God has not rejected them. Paul spoke again of God’s grace being the basis for him choosing who will be his people. The basis is not what people do.

Then Paul explained why only some Jews have accepted Jesus as the Christ/Messiah. God caused some of them to reject Christ for his own purposes (which was so that many non-Jews would believe in Jesus (11:12)).

Here are other possible headings for this section:

God has kept a remnant of Jews as his people

At this time, in grace, God has chosen some Israelites/Jews

**11:10a****May their eyes be darkened so they cannot see,**

- Their eyes must become dark/blind so they do not see,
- May you<sup>(sing)</sup> make them as if blind.

**May their eyes be darkened so they cannot see:**

Here David asked God to make his enemies as if blind.

Paul applied this to a different group of people than David did. You should not explain who their refers to in your translation. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

let their eyes be darkened so that they cannot see (ESV)

May their eyes be blinded so that they cannot see (GNT)

Make their eyes as if blind so they cannot see

**11:10b****and their backs be bent forever.”**

- and make their backs always bent.”
- And may you<sup>(sing)</sup> bend their backs with difficulties/troubles.”

**(NET:) make their backs bend:** David asked God to bend the backs of his enemies. The scholars offer many suggestions as to what it might mean as a figure of speech. For example, Cranfield (page 552) lists as possibilities: “being bowed down under oppressive slavery, being bent under a heavy burden, cowering with fear, being bowed down by grief, being too weak to stand upright, or stooping to grope on the ground because one’s sight is bad or one is blind.” Other scholars say that Paul was not aiming for a specific meaning here, only that God will cause difficulties for the Jews who do not believe in Jesus. Moo (page 683) says, “Paul probably did not intend to apply the details in the quotation to the Jews of his own day. Thus it is fruitless to inquire about what the ‘table’ might stand for, or what ‘bending the backs’ might connote.” You should translate the meaning literally.

But in some languages a literal translation would not imply any figurative meaning. If that is true in your language, add a general idea of the figurative meaning. For example:

bend their backs with many difficulties/troubles

**(NET:) continually:** There are two ways to interpret the Greek words here:

1. It means continuously for an unstated amount of time. For example:

unceasingly (REB) (GNT, NET, REB)

1. It means continuously for all time to come. For example:

forever (ESV) (RSV, BSB, NIV, NJB, NASB, ESV, NABRE, NLT, GW, CEV, NCV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1), because 11:25–32 indicates that God has not made the Jews resistant to the gospel of Jesus forever. Many scholars suggest the Greek words are an idiom that means “continuously.” For example, Moo, Cranfield, Dunn, Schreiner, Jewett, Nicoll, and Fitzmyer follow interpretation (1). The Jews who do not believe in Jesus are to have difficulties and troubles until such time that God takes away those things.

**General Comment on 11:9b–10b**

These words are a quote from Psalm 69:22–23. If you indicate the location of quotes from the Old Testament with cross-references, you may want to do so here.

**Romans 11:11****Section 11:11–24: Do not be arrogant toward Jews who do not believe in Jesus**

In this section, Paul asked his readers if God has rejected the Jews forever. He answered his own question, indicating that God has not. At that time many Jews rejected Jesus as the Christ/Messiah. As a result, God made the message about Jesus known to people who were not Jews. But God will one day include the Jews and save them through Jesus too.

Paul then spoke directly to the believers who were not Jews. He said that he boasted about his ministry to the non-Jews so as to make the Jews jealous of the results of his ministry among the Gentiles. Then maybe some would be curious and begin believing in Jesus. When God accepts their faith in Jesus, it will be like they rose from the dead.

Paul then used some metaphors to illustrate his point that God has not rejected forever the Jews who, at that time, did not believe in Jesus as the Christ. He showed that if some Jews were holy, then all were, in the same way that a part of a batch of dough represents the whole batch. And the branches of a tree that is holy

are themselves holy, even if they have been broken off to allow branches from a different tree to be joined into the trunk. He used the picture of the branches of that different tree to represent the believers who were not Jews.

He reminded the believers who were not Jews of God's kindness toward them. He told them to always be mindful of that kindness rather than being proud of themselves. He warned them that God is able to do to them as he did to the Jews who do not believe in Jesus, if they became proud of themselves.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

Do not look down on Jews who have not accepted Jesus as the Christ

Many Gentiles believing in Jesus will make the Jews want that blessing too

#### 11:11a

**I ask then, did they stumble so as to fall beyond recovery?**

- ¶ Therefore, I ask you<sup>(plur)</sup>, have they have stumbled and fallen so as to not rise again?
- ¶ So then, I ask this: Those Jews have stumbled badly by not believing in Jesus, so will they fall completely and be abandoned by God?

**I ask then:** Here the word then means “therefore.”

**did they stumble so as to fall beyond recovery?:** This is a rhetorical question that Paul himself answered in 11:11b. Translate it as a question.

**stumble...fall:** These two clauses are figures of speech. Here stumble refers to having difficulty believing that Jesus is the Christ, and fall refers to the consequences of destruction as a result of the Jews rejecting Jesus as the Christ.

In many languages the meaning here will be clear. But in some languages a literal translation would have a different meaning. If that is true in your language, you may want to:

- Translate literally and explain the meaning in a footnote. Here is an example footnote:

This indicates that the Jews sinned when they rejected Jesus but God has not abandoned them.

- Explain the meaning in your translation. For example:

did they stumble in sin so as to fall away completely from God's promises

did they fall in sin so as to be unable to stand again and God accept them

**so as to:** Here this introduces the result. It is not purpose here. For example, Morris (page 406) says, “obviously it was not their purpose that they would fall.”

#### 11:11b

**Certainly not!**

- Certainly not!
- No indeed!

**Certainly not!:** The Greek is literally “May it not be.” It indicates a very strong “no.” They did not fall. See how you translated this phrase in 3:4 or 11:1.

#### 11:11c

**However, because of their trespass, salvation has come to the Gentiles**

- Instead, they sinned, and so God has begun saving Gentiles
- They stumbled, but their sin of rejecting Jesus has caused the message of salvation to come to the non-Jews,

**However:** The Greek word here is often translated “but.” Here it indicates contrast to the implied statement “they stumbled.” It does not contrast to “By no means.” In some languages what contrasts in 11:11c must be made clear. For example:

They stumbled but

**because of their trespass:** Here the word trespass refers to doing something wrong or bad against God. BDAG (page 770), sense b.β. Here are other ways to translate this word:

they sinned (GNT)

their failure (NJB)

It is implied here that the Jews trespassed by rejecting Jesus as the Christ/Messiah. In some languages a literal translation would refer to any trespass. If that is true in your language, you may want to:

- Translate literally and explain the meaning in a footnote. Here is an example footnote:



This refers to the Jews rejecting Jesus as their Messiah.

- Explain in your translation. For example:

their trespass against God

their sin of rejecting Jesus

**salvation has come to the Gentiles:** There is no verb in the Greek. The BSB and many English versions have added the words *has come to* to make the English natural. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

their failure has brought salvation for the gentiles (NJB)

so God made salvation available to the Gentiles (NLT)

**salvation:** This word refers to being rescued from something harmful or dangerous. In Scripture it generally refers to rescue from God's anger at the final judgment. Here are other ways to translate this word:

to save (GNT)

to save/rescue people from his anger

See how you translated salvation in 1:16 or "saved" in 10:10.

**Gentiles:** This word refers to people who are not Jews. See how you translated this word in 1:5 or 9:30.

### 11:11d to make Israel jealous.

- and will make the Jews envious.
- so that they will be jealous of that.

**to make Israel jealous:** This is a purpose for salvation coming to the Gentiles. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

in order to stir them to envy (NJB)

to make Israel envious (NIV)

**Israel:** The Greek is literally "them." It continues to refer to the Jews who do not believe in Jesus.

**jealous:** Here this word refers to being resentful of what someone else has. It implies here that the Jews resent that Gentiles have attained the kingdom of God. Here are other ways to translate this word:

envious (NIV)

they indeed also want to be saved Kankanaey Back Translation on TW.

## Romans 11:12

### Section 11:11–24: Do not be arrogant toward Jews who do not believe in Jesus

In this section, Paul asked his readers if God has rejected the Jews forever. He answered his own question, indicating that God has not. At that time many Jews rejected Jesus as the Christ/Messiah. As a result, God made the message about Jesus known to people who were not Jews. But God will one day include the Jews and save them through Jesus too.

Paul then spoke directly to the believers who were not Jews. He said that he boasted about his ministry to the non-Jews so as to make the Jews jealous of the results of his ministry among the Gentiles. Then maybe some would be curious and begin believing in Jesus. When God accepts their faith in Jesus, it will be like they rose from the dead.

Paul then used some metaphors to illustrate his point that God has not rejected forever the Jews who, at that time, did not believe in Jesus as the Christ. He showed that if some Jews were holy, then all were, in the same way that a part of a batch of dough represents the whole batch. And the branches of a tree that is holy are themselves holy, even if they have been broken off to allow branches from a different tree to be joined into the trunk. He used the picture of the branches of that different tree to represent the believers who were not Jews.

He reminded the believers who were not Jews of God's kindness toward them. He told them to always be mindful of that kindness rather than being proud of themselves. He warned them that God is able to do to them as he did to the Jews who do not believe in Jesus, if they became proud of themselves.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

Do not look down on Jews who have not accepted Jesus as the Christ

Many Gentiles believing in Jesus will make the Jews want that blessing too

### 11:12a

#### **But if their trespass means riches for the world,**

- And/But if it is true that their fall/sin causes the world to have abundant blessings,
- The Jews sinned, and so God blessed the other peoples/people-groups in the world very much.

11:12a is very similar in meaning to 11:12b. After translating them, see the General Comment on 11:12a-b below.

**But:** Here the word But introduces another thing that Paul wanted to say. For example:

And (NJB)

Now (ESV)

The sin... (GNT)

**if their trespass means riches for the world:** Here the word if introduces a situation that is true. If this first part is true, that supports the second part (God fully including the Jews will mean much more (11:12c)) to also be true.

In some languages, using an if-clause would have a different meaning. If that is true in your language, translate the correct meaning. For example:

if you agree that their trespass means riches for the world

their trespass means riches for the world, so

See how you translated this kind of if in 3:5 or 11:6.

**trespass:** This word refers to doing something wrong or bad against God. See how you translated this word in 11:11c.

**means:** There is no verb in the Greek here. Usually, “be/is” is implied. Here “their trespass” leads to “riches for the world.” So some English versions add a verb like means. Here are other words that can be added here:

brought (GNT)

caused

**riches for:** Here the word riches refers to an abundance of blessings related to salvation. It does not refer to earthly money or treasure. Here are other ways to translate this word:

a great gain to (NJB)

an abundance for

great blessings to

greatly helps

See how you translated this word in 2:4 or 9:23.

**world:** Here this word refers to all people in the world, not the ground itself. Some languages must refer to the people rather than just the earth. For example:

the collective-people on this earthKankanaey  
Back Translation on TW.

all mankindWestern Bukidnon Manobo Back  
Translation on TW.

### 11:12b

#### **and their failure means riches for the Gentiles,**

- and if it is true that they have failed, and it causes the Gentiles to have abundant blessings,
- Indeed, the Jews fell regarding Jesus, and so God blessed the non-Jews very much.

**failure:** There are several ways to interpret the Greek word that the BSB translates as failure:

1. It means failure here, as in the BSB. The word here refers to a lack of success in doing something. (BSB, RSV, NASB, ESV, GW)
2. It means loss here, as in the NIV. The word here refers to losing something or failing to keep it. (NIV, GNT, NJB, CEV, NCV)
3. It means defeat here. Israel was defeated in the sense that in their spiritual battle to get right with God, they did not attain that goal because they rejected Jesus as the Messiah. For example:

defeat (NRSV) (NRSV, NET)

1. It means a decrease in number here. For example:

diminished number (NABRE) (KJV, NABRE)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1), because:

1. The Greek lexicons do not support interpretation (4).
2. Some scholars support interpretation (3), but it is hard to understand how the meaning of “defeat” applies here unless the idea of spiritual battle is introduced into this verse.
3. The meaning of “loss” is supported in the Greek lexicons but a more active sense of failure is preferable here. Moo (page 689) says, “Greek words ending in -μα usually denote the result of an action.” In this case, Israel failed to do something, which probably refers to becoming righteous (10:3, 11:7).

Paul did not say what the Jews failed at. It is implied that they failed to accept Jesus as their Messiah/Savior. In some languages a literal translation would have the wrong meaning. If that is true in your language, you may want to:

- Translate literally and explain the meaning in a footnote. Here is an example footnote:

Paul implied/meant that the Jews failed to accept Jesus as their Messiah/Savior.

- Explain the meaning in your translation. For example:

failed regarding Jesus

failed to believe in Jesus

**riches:** This word has the same meaning as in 11:12a.

**Gentiles:** Here this word refers to all people-groups except the Jews.

#### General Comment on 11:12a–b

11:12a is very similar in meaning to 11:12b. It is a Hebrew poetic form. The second line helps explain the first line. The two lines together strengthen the meaning. In some languages saying something again with similar words has a different meaning/function. If that is true in your language, indicate the correct meaning in one line. For example:

Now if their sin and failure means riches for the Gentiles of this world

Now if their sin of failing to accept Jesus as the Messiah/Christ/Savior means abundant blessings for the world, that is, the Gentiles

#### 11:12c

#### how much greater riches will their fullness bring!

- then when their fullness/inclusion occurs, the abundant blessings will be even greater!
- Therefore, God will bless them/the-non-Jews much more when the full number of Jews believe in Jesus.

#### how much greater riches will their fullness bring:

The phrase how much greater indicates that if the failure of the Jews produced a good result in the world, their inclusion will mean an even better result. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

So the inclusion of Jewish people will make the world even richer. (GW)

So surely the world will receive much richer blessings... (NCV)

**how:** Here this word strengthens the phrase “much more.” It does not make this clause a question here. See the above examples.

**fullness:** The basic meaning of the Greek word that the BSB translates as fullness is “a full measure of something.” Here are the four main ways to interpret the Greek word:

1. The fullness refers to being completely included in God’s kingdom of faith in Jesus. For example:

full inclusion (ESV) (RSV, NIV11, ESV, GW)

1. The fullness refers to the number of Jews who will believe in Jesus as many as could be. For example:

complete number (GNT) (GNT, NABRE)

1. Translate in a way that allows these various interpretations. For example:

fullness (NIV84) (BSB, NIV84, KJV)

1. The full-ness refers to restoring the Jews to their previous position, fully accepted. For example:

full restoration (NET) (NJB, CEV, NET)

The Greek word can mean both interpretations (1) and (2). But many languages do not have a word that would cover both. So it is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). But some languages have a word that can imply both interpretations (1) and (2). In that case you may want to follow interpretation (3). The lexicons and scholars do not support interpretation (4). Moo, Longenecker, Cranfield, Dunn, and Schreiner translate following interpretation (3). Jewett translates following interpretation (2). Morris (page 408) says, “The meaning of fullness is not clear. Either the fulfilling of God’s will or the bringing in of the full number of the Jews gives good sense and marks a contrast with the situation in which Paul found himself.”

**bring:** The BSB adds this word for natural English, just as it adds the word “means” in 11:12a–b. Use the same word or meaning here as there.

## Romans 11:13

### Section 11:11–24: Do not be arrogant toward Jews who do not believe in Jesus

In this section, Paul asked his readers if God has rejected the Jews forever. He answered his own question, indicating that God has not. At that time many Jews rejected Jesus as the Christ/Messiah. As a result, God made the message about Jesus known to people who were not Jews. But God will one day include the Jews and save them through Jesus too.

Paul then spoke directly to the believers who were not Jews. He said that he boasted about his ministry to the non-Jews so as to make the Jews jealous of the results of his ministry among the Gentiles. Then maybe some would be curious and begin believing in Jesus. When God accepts their faith in Jesus, it will be like they rose from the dead.

Paul then used some metaphors to illustrate his point that God has not rejected forever the Jews who, at that time, did not believe in Jesus as the Christ. He showed that if some Jews were holy, then all were, in the same way that a part of a batch of dough represents the whole batch. And the branches of a tree that is holy are themselves holy, even if they have been broken off to allow branches from a different tree to be joined into the trunk. He used the picture of the branches of that different tree to represent the believers who were not Jews.

He reminded the believers who were not Jews of God’s kindness toward them. He told them to always be mindful of that kindness rather than being proud of themselves. He warned them that God is able to do

to them as he did to the Jews who do not believe in Jesus, if they became proud of themselves.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

Do not look down on Jews who have not accepted Jesus as the Christ

Many Gentiles believing in Jesus will make the Jews want that blessing too

### 11:13a

#### I am speaking to you Gentiles.

- ¶ Now/Look, it is to you Gentiles that I am talking/writing.
- ¶ You believers who are not Jews, it is to you that I speak/write.

The Greek of 11:13a begins with a word that is often translated as “but” and “and.” There is a textual issue in 11:13a: (1) Some Greek manuscripts have the word and/but (BSB, RSV, NIV, GNT, NJB, NASB, NABRE, ESV, REB, NLT, GW, NET, NCV). (2) Some later Greek manuscripts have the word for (KJV only). It is recommended that you follow option (1). The BSB has not translated this word. Here the word introduces another thing that Paul wanted to say. For example:

But (NASB)

I am... (GNT)

**I am speaking to you Gentiles:** In the Greek, the word you is emphasized. Here are some ways to translate the emphasis:

You Gentiles, I speak to you

It is to you Gentiles that I am speaking

**I am speaking:** This clause refers to what Paul had been saying and what he said next. See the above examples.

**speaking:** The Roman believers read this letter. So in some languages the word “writing” would be more natural here.

**Gentiles:** Paul implied here believers who are not Jews. In some languages a literal translation would indicate or imply people who do not believe in Jesus. If that is true in your language, indicate the correct meaning. For example:

Gentile believers

believers who are not Jews

### 11:13b

#### **Inasmuch as I am the apostle to the Gentiles,**

- So/Then, as far as I am an apostle whom God sent to Gentiles,
- Am I truly an apostle to the people who are not Jews? Yes, and so

**Inasmuch as:** The Greek of 11:13b has a word that is often translated as “then” or “therefore” after the phrase Inasmuch as. In many languages it is more natural to have it in front. For example:

Then, inasmuch as

There are two ways to translate this Greek phrase:

1. It bases his right to act in this way on the fact that he is an apostle to the Gentiles. For example:

as far as (NJB) (BSB, RSV, NIV, NJB, KJV, NASB, ESV, NABRE, REB, NCV)

1. It bases his right to act on how much time Paul had been an apostle to the Gentiles. For example:

As long as (GNT) (GNT, GW, CEV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1), because the Greek lexicons do not support interpretation (2).

**the apostle:** The Greek does not have the word that the BSB has translated as the. There are two ways to interpret this:

1. It indicates that the word an should be added in English. For example:

an apostle (ESV) (RSV, GNT, NJB, NASB, ESV, GW, CEV, NET, REB, NCV)

1. It implies that the word the should be added in English. For example:

the apostle (NIV) (BSB, NIV, KJV, NLT, NABRE)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1), because it is unlikely that Paul claimed to be the only apostle to Gentiles, as interpretation (2) implies.

**apostle:** The Greek word that the BSB translates as apostle means a “representative” or “messenger.” God chose Paul and sent him to tell the gospel about Jesus. See how you translated this word in 1:1.

**to the Gentiles:** This phrase indicates that Paul had a ministry as an apostle with people who were not Jews.

### 11:13c

#### **I magnify my ministry**

- I tell people about this great work that God has given me to do.
- I praise this work of mine to others,

**magnify:** The Greek word here is often translated “glorify.” Paul told others that his ministry is important. He boasted about it. Here are other ways to translate this word:

glorify (NRSV)

make much of (NIV)

I go around telling to the Yuus the talk of what God has done amongst the non-Yuus through meYongkom Back Translation, by this author, unpublished manuscript, Papua New Guinea.

**ministry:** The Greek word here refers to the work of helping others. It refers to Paul being an apostle, not another work of his. Paul’s work as an apostle helped others. Here are other ways to translate this word:

work of service (NJB)

this work of helping others

## **Romans 11:14**

### **Section 11:11–24: Do not be arrogant toward Jews who do not believe in Jesus**

In this section, Paul asked his readers if God has rejected the Jews forever. He answered his own question, indicating that God has not. At that time many Jews rejected Jesus as the Christ/Messiah. As a result, God made the message about Jesus known to people who were not Jews. But God will one day include the Jews and save them through Jesus too.

Paul then spoke directly to the believers who were not Jews. He said that he boasted about his ministry to the non-Jews so as to make the Jews jealous of the results of his ministry among the Gentiles. Then maybe some would be curious and begin believing in Jesus. When

God accepts their faith in Jesus, it will be like they rose from the dead.

Paul then used some metaphors to illustrate his point that God has not rejected forever the Jews who, at that time, did not believe in Jesus as the Christ. He showed that if some Jews were holy, then all were, in the same way that a part of a batch of dough represents the whole batch. And the branches of a tree that is holy are themselves holy, even if they have been broken off to allow branches from a different tree to be joined into the trunk. He used the picture of the branches of that different tree to represent the believers who were not Jews.

He reminded the believers who were not Jews of God's kindness toward them. He told them to always be mindful of that kindness rather than being proud of themselves. He warned them that God is able to do to them as he did to the Jews who do not believe in Jesus, if they became proud of themselves.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

Do not look down on Jews who have not accepted Jesus as the Christ

Many Gentiles believing in Jesus will make the Jews want that blessing too

#### **11:14a** **in the hope that I may provoke my own people to jealousy**

- In doing so, I make my kinsmen jealous in some way of what they have
- in hope that what God is doing among the non-Jews would make my own people jealous. Then they would want that for themselves,

**in the hope that:** The Greek is literally “if somehow.” These words introduce something that Paul hoped would happen based on magnifying his ministry (11:13c), but he was not certain that it would happen. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

in order somehow (ESV)

Perhaps (NJB)

for I want somehow (NLT)

**I may provoke my own people to jealousy:** The phrase provoke...to jealousy refers to wanting some-

thing that someone else has, or being resentful of what someone else has. It implies here that the Jews will one day want the same relationship with God that the Christians have. See how you translated the words “to make...jealous” in 11:11.

**my own people:** The Greek is literally “my flesh.” But here it refers to people of the same ethnic group as Paul, the Jews.

#### **11:14b** **and save some of them.**

- and rescue some of them.
- and I would save some of them.

**and save some of them:** There are two ways to interpret the Greek word that the BSB translates as and:

1. It indicates a sequence (first action then second action), as in the BSB. (BSB, NIV, KJV, NASB, GW, NET)
2. It indicates a reason-result connection. For example:

and so saving some of them (REB) (RSV, GNT, NJB, ESV, NABRE, REB, NLT, CEV, NCV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1), because “make jealous” seems an odd reason for saving people. Moo, Longenecker, Dunn, Schreiner, and Jewett support interpretation (1). Cranfield and Barrett support interpretation (2) but do not explain their choice.

**save:** This word refers to being rescued from something harmful or dangerous. Here it refers to God rescuing people from going to hell for their sins. See how you translated this word in 5:9 or 10:9.

**some of them:** Here the word some has a general meaning. It does not mean “few” or “many.”

## **Romans 11:15**

### **Section 11:11–24: Do not be arrogant toward Jews who do not believe in Jesus**

In this section, Paul asked his readers if God has rejected the Jews forever. He answered his own question, indicating that God has not. At that time many Jews rejected Jesus as the Christ/Messiah. As a result, God made the message about Jesus known to people who were not Jews. But God will one day include the Jews and save them through Jesus too.

Paul then spoke directly to the believers who were not Jews. He said that he boasted about his ministry to the non-Jews so as to make the Jews jealous of the results of his ministry among the Gentiles. Then maybe some

would be curious and begin believing in Jesus. When God accepts their faith in Jesus, it will be like they rose from the dead.

Paul then used some metaphors to illustrate his point that God has not rejected forever the Jews who, at that time, did not believe in Jesus as the Christ. He showed that if some Jews were holy, then all were, in the same way that a part of a batch of dough represents the whole batch. And the branches of a tree that is holy are themselves holy, even if they have been broken off to allow branches from a different tree to be joined into the trunk. He used the picture of the branches of that different tree to represent the believers who were not Jews.

He reminded the believers who were not Jews of God's kindness toward them. He told them to always be mindful of that kindness rather than being proud of themselves. He warned them that God is able to do to them as he did to the Jews who do not believe in Jesus, if they became proud of themselves.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

Do not look down on Jews who have not accepted Jesus as the Christ

Many Gentiles believing in Jesus will make the Jews want that blessing too

### 11:15a

**For if their rejection is the reconciliation of the world,**

- For if it is true that God rejecting them for a short time leads him to make peace with the people living on this world,
- Indeed, God rejected them, and so he made it possible for many other people of the/world to end the hostility and become friends with him/himself.

**For:** Here this word introduces an explanation of 11:13–14. Schreiner (page 596).

**if:** Here the word if introduces a situation that is true. If this first part is true, that supports the second part (acceptance of the Jews would mean life from the dead (11:15c)) to also be true.

In some languages, using an if-clause would have a different meaning. If that is true in your language, translate the correct meaning. For example:

if it is true that their rejection means the reconciliation of the world, and it is true,

their rejection means the reconciliation of the world, so

See how you translated this kind of if in 3:5 or 11:12.

**their rejection:** This phrase could mean “someone has rejected them” or “they have rejected someone or something.” Many English versions, like the BSB here, translate in a way that allows for either interpretation. If you can translate in a way that allows both interpretations, you may want to do so.

A few English versions choose “someone has rejected them.” For example:

they were rejected (GNT)

God turned away from the Jews (NCV)

Many scholars support this interpretation. If you must choose, you may want to follow this interpretation.

**is:** There is no verb in the Greek here. Usually, “be/is” is implied. Here “their trespass” leads to “riches for the world.” So some English versions add a verb like “means” (as in the ESV). You may be able to translate this as you did in 11:12.

**reconciliation:** This word refers to causing two people or two groups of people, who have been enemies, to be at peace with one another. Jesus, by his death and resurrection, has made a way for people to be reconciled to God. Some languages use a phrase for this meaning. For example:

he made peace

he brought us back to be God's friends

See how you translated this word in 5:11.

**the world:** This phrase implies that reconciliation with God is available to all people, and in particular to the people who are not Jews. See Moo (page 693). It does not imply that all people will be reconciled with God. People must believe in Jesus to be reconciled in this way.

In some languages a literal translation would refer only to the physical world. If that is true in your language, you may want to:

- Explain the meaning in your translation. For example:

people throughout the whole world

all other people (GNT)

other people in the world (NCV)

- Translate literally and explain the meaning in a footnote. Here is an example footnote:

This phrase implies that reconciliation with God is available to all people, and in particular to the people who are not Jews.

#### 11:15b–c

**what will their acceptance be but life from the dead?:** Here the word *but* introduces the answer to the question *what will their acceptance be?* In many languages the answer will need to be separated from the question. For example:

what will their acceptance be? It can only be life from the dead for them.

what will their acceptance be? It will be that they will gain life from the dead.

This is a rhetorical question. In some languages people will see this as a real question. If that is true in your language, translate it as a statement. For example:

their acceptance will be this: life from the dead.

#### 11:15b

**what will their acceptance be**

- what will God accepting them back into relationship with him mean?
- So, what will happen when they accept the gospel?
- So, this is what will happen when they accept the gospel:

**acceptance:** If you translated “their rejection” in 11:15a as someone rejecting them, then this word would refer to that same someone accepting them back into a relationship with him. Scholars generally see that here it is God who accepts them.

**be:** There is no verb in the Greek here. Usually, “be/is” is implied. Here “their trespass” leads to “riches for the world.” So some English versions add a verb like “mean” (as in the ESV). You may be able to translate this as you did in 11:15a.

#### 11:15c

**but life from the dead?**

- It means that they will receive life rather than death.
- God will give them eternal life instead of death.

**life from the dead:** This phrase refers to life after the resurrection of the dead. It implies that God’s promises apply to the Jews when they believe in Jesus. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

bring them life after death (NCV)

they will receive the thing for being taken from death and given lifeYongkom Back Translation, by this author, unpublished manuscript, Papua New Guinea.

The dead [ones] will get life!Barok Back Translation, unpublished manuscript, Papua New Guinea.

### Romans 11:16

**Section 11:11–24: Do not be arrogant toward Jews who do not believe in Jesus**

In this section, Paul asked his readers if God has rejected the Jews forever. He answered his own question, indicating that God has not. At that time many Jews rejected Jesus as the Christ/Messiah. As a result, God made the message about Jesus known to people who were not Jews. But God will one day include the Jews and save them through Jesus too.

Paul then spoke directly to the believers who were not Jews. He said that he boasted about his ministry to the non-Jews so as to make the Jews jealous of the results of his ministry among the Gentiles. Then maybe some would be curious and begin believing in Jesus. When God accepts their faith in Jesus, it will be like they rose from the dead.

Paul then used some metaphors to illustrate his point that God has not rejected forever the Jews who, at that time, did not believe in Jesus as the Christ. He showed that if some Jews were holy, then all were, in the same way that a part of a batch of dough represents the whole batch. And the branches of a tree that is holy are themselves holy, even if they have been broken off to allow branches from a different tree to be joined into the trunk. He used the picture of the branches of that different tree to represent the believers who were not Jews.

He reminded the believers who were not Jews of God’s kindness toward them. He told them to always be mindful of that kindness rather than being proud of



themselves. He warned them that God is able to do to them as he did to the Jews who do not believe in Jesus, if they became proud of themselves.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

Do not look down on Jews who have not accepted Jesus as the Christ

Many Gentiles believing in Jesus will make the Jews want that blessing too

### 11:16a–b

**If the first part of the dough is holy, so is the whole batch:** This is a figure of speech. It indicates that if part of something is holy, then the whole thing is holy. The whole batch refers to the people of Israel. Scholars have various ideas about the part of the whole lump of dough that is offered:

1. It refers to Jewish Christians.
2. It refers to the patriarchs: Abraham, Isaac, and Jacob.
3. It refers to Jesus.
4. It refers to Adam.

Many English versions translate literally and so do not interpret this figure of speech in their translation. But part of the lump probably refers to Jewish Christians because Paul had been talking about saving his fellow Jews. The scholars also translate literally. Cranfield, Dunn, Witherington, Barrett, Fitzmyer, and Stott support interpretation (1) in their discussion of this issue. Moo, Morris, Schreiner, Kruse, Lenski, Alford, Nicoll, Sanday and Headlam, and Hodge support interpretation (2) in their discussion. Moo lists interpretations (3) and (4) as other scholars' opinions.

In many languages the meaning of the figure of speech will not be understood here. If that is true in your language, you may want to:

- Translate literally and explain the meaning of the figure of speech in a footnote. Here is an example footnote:

In this figure of speech, the “whole batch” refers to the people of Israel. The “dough” refers to either (1) the Jewish Christians of that time, or (2) Abraham, Isaac, and Jacob.

- Explain the meaning in your translation. It says:

The people of Israel are like a lump of dough, of which part of it has been offered to God as first-fruits and so all of it is holy

And since Abraham and the other patriarchs were holy, their descendants will also be holy—just as the entire batch of dough is holy because the portion given as an offering is holy. (NLT) Note that the NLT adds a complete explanation following interpretation (2), in addition to a literal translation.

### 11:16a

**If the first part of the dough is holy,**

- ¶ If the dough that is offered to God as a first offering of the harvest is holy,
- ¶ Suppose a person offers to God the first part of his grain/wheat harvest as the beginning-of-the-harvest offering. If that first part is dedicated/consecrated to God,
- ¶ People offer the first part of a lump of dough to God as a thank offering, and that offering is holy.

**If the first part of the dough is holy:** Here the word *If* introduces a situation that is true. If this first part is true, that supports the second part (the whole lump of dough (11:16b) is holy) to also be true.

In some languages, using an *if*-clause would have a different meaning. If that is true in your language, translate the correct meaning. For example:

if it is true that the first part of the dough is holy

the first part of the dough is holy, so

See how you translated this kind of *If* in 3:5 or 11:15.

**the first part of the dough:** This phrase refers to a part of the whole lump of dough mentioned in 11:16b. It also refers to the Jewish practice of giving part of a lump of dough to God as a gift offering (Numbers 15:17–21). Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

first piece of dough (NASB)

the part of the dough offered as first fruits (NRSV)

part of a batch of dough is made holy by being offered to God (CEV)

**the dough:** This refers to the mixture of flour, water, and other things for making bread. It is called dough before people cook it. When it is cooked, it becomes bread. Here are other ways to translate this word:

water and flour mixture

uncooked bread

Here this word refers to a part of the larger lump of dough (11:16b). In some languages that information needs to be added here to make the sentence clear. For example:

portion of the dough

**holy:** Here this word means “dedicated to God” or “set apart to serve God.” BDAG (page 10) and L&N (on TW) have “consecrated to the service of God.” This is the most likely sense here. The KBT (on TW) is similar: “dedicated to God.” Priests and people will eat the cooked dough and thank God for it. As a figure of speech, the Jews are set apart as God’s special people, because he made promises to them and some of those promises are in effect for the whole future of this earth. Here are other ways to translate this word:

offered to God (NCV)

belongs to God Otomi Back Translation on TW.

made holy by being offered to God (CEV)

### 11:16b

#### so is the whole batch;

- then the rest of the dough is holy also.
- then all of the grain/wheat harvest is dedicated/consecrated to God.
- And so the whole lump is holy.

**so is the whole batch:** This phrase indicates that the whole batch is holy like the first part of it is. In some languages the implied words must be explicit. For example:

then the whole batch is holy (NIV)

#### General Comment on 11:16a–b

There are several interpretations of this metaphor. See the first note at 11:16a–b above, if you have not already.

It is recommended that you do not put these interpretations in your translation. If you want to make the meaning of the metaphor more clear, you may want to explain it in a footnote. Here is an example footnote:

This metaphor indicates that the Jews are God’s special people. He has not abandoned them even if only a few Jews believe in him and his Messiah, Jesus, at this time.

### 11:16c–d

**if the root is holy, so are the branches:** This is a figure of speech. It indicates that if the source or beginning of something is holy, then the other parts are holy. The branches refer to the people of Israel. Many scholars believe the root refers to Abraham or perhaps Abraham, Isaac, and Jacob. Only a few scholars believe it refers to Jewish Christians.

Many English versions translate literally and so do not interpret this figure of speech in their translation. Many scholars also translate literally.

In many languages the meaning of the figure of speech will not be understood here. If that is true in your language, you may want to:

- Translate literally and explain the meaning of the figure of speech in a footnote. Here is an example footnote:

In this figure of speech, the “branches” refers to the people of Israel. The “root” probably refers to either (1) Abraham or (2) Abraham, Isaac, and Jacob.

- Explain the meaning in your translation. It says:

The people of Israel are like the branches of a tree and Abraham is like its root. The root is holy, therefore the branches are holy.

And since Abraham was holy, his descendants, the people of Israel, will also be holy—just as the branches are holy because the root is holy.

or, just as, for example, the branches are holy because the root is holy

### 11:16c

#### if the root is holy,

- Also, if the main root of a tree is holy,

- Suppose that the root of a tree is dedicated/consecrated to God,
- If, as another example, the root of a tree is holy,

The Greek of 11:16c begins with a word that is usually translated as “and.” The BSB does not translate this word but instead places a semicolon between 11:16c and 11:16a and b to indicate the connection. This word introduces a second metaphor. In some languages a new sentence would be more natural. For example:

And

If the root is holy... (GW)

**if:** Here the word if introduces a situation that is true. If this first part is true, that supports the second part. See how you translated it in 11:16a.

**the root is holy:** 11:16d refers to branches, so here the word root refers to the main root of a tree.

#### 11:16d

**so are the branches.**

- then the branches are too.
- then its branches are holy as well.

**so are the branches:** This phrase indicates that the branches are holy like the main root is. In some languages the implied words must be explicit. For example:

then the branches are holy

## Romans 11:17

### Section 11:11–24: Do not be arrogant toward Jews who do not believe in Jesus

In this section, Paul asked his readers if God has rejected the Jews forever. He answered his own question, indicating that God has not. At that time many Jews rejected Jesus as the Christ/Messiah. As a result, God made the message about Jesus known to people who were not Jews. But God will one day include the Jews and save them through Jesus too.

Paul then spoke directly to the believers who were not Jews. He said that he boasted about his ministry to the non-Jews so as to make the Jews jealous of the results of his ministry among the Gentiles. Then maybe some would be curious and begin believing in Jesus. When God accepts their faith in Jesus, it will be like they rose from the dead.

Paul then used some metaphors to illustrate his point that God has not rejected forever the Jews who, at that

time, did not believe in Jesus as the Christ. He showed that if some Jews were holy, then all were, in the same way that a part of a batch of dough represents the whole batch. And the branches of a tree that is holy are themselves holy, even if they have been broken off to allow branches from a different tree to be joined into the trunk. He used the picture of the branches of that different tree to represent the believers who were not Jews.

He reminded the believers who were not Jews of God’s kindness toward them. He told them to always be mindful of that kindness rather than being proud of themselves. He warned them that God is able to do to them as he did to the Jews who do not believe in Jesus, if they became proud of themselves.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

Do not look down on Jews who have not accepted Jesus as the Christ

Many Gentiles believing in Jesus will make the Jews want that blessing too

#### 11:17a

**Now if some branches have been broken off,**

- And if some of the/those branches have been broken off,
- God has broken some of the branches at the trunk of the tree and removed them.

**Now:** Beginning with this verse, Paul made a new point using the metaphor of a tree. In some languages an “and,” another connecting word or phrase, or no conjunction would better indicate that meaning. For example:

And

It is as if... (NCV)

If... (NIV)

**if:** Here the word if introduces a situation that is true. If this first part is true, that supports the second part. See how you translated this word in 11:16a.

**some branches have been broken off:** This clause is passive. 11:20–21 indicate that God broke them off. Some languages must use an active clause. For example:

someone broke off some of the branches

God broke off some of the branches

**some branches:** In the figure of speech here, these branches represent Jews who did not believe in Jesus. If a literal translation would refer only to actual branches, you may want to:

- Translate this phrase literally and explain it in a footnote. Here is an example footnote:

In this verse, these branches represent Jews who did not believe in Jesus.

- Explain the meaning in your translation. For example:

some of the branches, namely, the unbelieving Jews

**have been broken off:** This phrase refers to breaking the branch at or near the trunk of the tree so that it is no longer attached to the tree. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

were broken away

were broken at the trunk and removed

#### 11:17b

**and you, a wild olive shoot, have been grafted in among the others**

- and you<sup>(sing)</sup>, as wild olive branches, were joined to that tree among the remaining branches,
- And he took you<sup>(plur)</sup>, like someone cutting and tying wild olive branches into that cultivated tree, and joined you to God's people.

**you, a wild olive shoot, have been grafted in:** This clause is passive. Some languages must use an active clause. For example:

someone/God grafted you in, even though you were a wild olive shoot

**you:** This pronoun is singular. Paul used it to speak to each believer, and he implied believers who are not Jews. In some languages a singular you would only be used in a letter addressed to one person. If that is true in your language, use the plural you.

The meaning of this word is emphasized in the Greek. For example:

you yourself/yourselves

You now who are GentilesKankanaey Back Translation on TW.

as for you who are not JewsWestern Bukidnon Manobo Back Translation on TW.

**a wild olive shoot:** This phrase describes the word "you," referring here to Gentile believers. It also indicates a contrast to the other branches of this olive tree. In this figure of speech, the olive tree is God's chosen people.Schreiner (page 604). Before Jesus came to earth as the Christ/Messiah, God's chosen people were the Jews and they believed in God because of their culture, history, prophecies, stories, and instruction written in their holy book, what we now call the Old Testament. Jews who do not believe in Jesus are like the branches broken off. The Gentiles who believe in Jesus are like wild olive tree branches, in that in the past they were not nurtured by God and his Word. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

being a wild olive (NASB)

even though you are from a wild olive tree

**wild olive shoot:** Here the word wild refers to something that people do not usually plant and take care of. Here it is in contrast to the same kind of plant that people plant and take care of. A wild olive tree grows well but produces few olives. A cultivated olive produces many olives but is easily damaged. But the word wild indicates that the Gentiles did not have the same relationship with God as the Jews did, where he taught, encouraged, and corrected them. Here are other ways to translate this word:

untamed olive tree

olive tree from the wilderness

**olive:** The olive tree produces a small oval fruit. The fruit contains oil, which was used in cooking and burned in lamps for light.

Many languages will borrow this name and spell it as the people who speak their language would say it.

**shoot:** The Greek word refers to the olive tree in a general way. Normally a branch is grafted. But separating the branch from the wild olive tree is not the focus of the figure of speech here. That is probably why the BSB uses the word shoot. Here the word shoot refers to a new growth on a plant, but the fact that it is new is not important here. Use the usual word for the part of the plant that is grafted here. For example:

branch (GNT)

piece of a wild olive tree

**have been grafted in:** This phrase refers to taking part of one plant and connecting it to another plant so that the new piece will continue to live and grow. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

joined to (NCV)

stuck on Uma Back Translation on TW.

caused it to grow there Western Bukidnon Manobo Back Translation on TW.

**among the others:** There are two ways to interpret the Greek phrase that the BSB translates as among the others:

1. It refers to the branches that were not broken off from the cultivated olive tree (11:16). For example, the Kankanaey Back Translation says:

you would join the original branches that were left (BSB, NIV, NJB, ESV, NASB, KJV, NET, REB)

1. It indicates that the wild olive shoots replace the branches of the cultivated olive tree which were broken off. For example:

in their place (RSV) (RSV, NABRE, GW, CEV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1), because it fits the context better. Moo, Longenecker, Cranfield, Dunn, Schreiner, and Jewett support interpretation (1).

#### 11:17c

**to share in the nourishment of the olive root,**

- and you are sharing with them in the rich root of the olive tree,

- And so you share in the abundantly providing root of the olive tree with the other branches.

**to share:** The Greek word here refers to someone who participates in something with someone else. Here grafted wild olive branches and the natural branches all receive sap from the tree and its roots.

**in the nourishment of the olive root:** The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as the nourishment is more literally “the root of the richness.” There is a textual issue here about this phrase:

1. Some Greek manuscripts have the words of-the root of-the richness. It indicates that there is one part of the olive tree, which is also described as having nourishment. (BSB, NIV, NJB, NASB, NRSV, NABRE, ESV, NLT, GW, NET)
2. Some Greek manuscripts have the words of-the root and of-the richness. It indicates that there are two parts of the olive tree mentioned here. For example:

the root and fatness of the olive tree (KJV) (KJV, REB)

1. Some Greek manuscripts have the words of-the richness. For example:

the richness of the olive tree (RSV) (RSV, NJB)

It is recommended that you follow option (1), because the Greek NT 5 recommends it as most likely the original text here.

**nourishment of the olive root:** The Greek text is literally “root of the richness.” It indicates that the root of the tree abundantly supplies what the branches need. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

rich root (NABRE)

the growth-causing sap which comes from its root Kankanaey Back Translation on TW.

**root:** Many scholars believe the root refers to Abraham or perhaps Abraham, Isaac, and Jacob, as in 11:16.

Many English versions translate literally and so do not interpret this figure of speech in their translation. Many scholars also translate literally. If you explained this word in 11:16, you should not need to explain it again here.

## Romans 11:18

### Section 11:11–24: Do not be arrogant toward Jews who do not believe in Jesus

In this section, Paul asked his readers if God has rejected the Jews forever. He answered his own question, indicating that God has not. At that time many Jews rejected Jesus as the Christ/Messiah. As a result, God made the message about Jesus known to people who were not Jews. But God will one day include the Jews and save them through Jesus too.

Paul then spoke directly to the believers who were not Jews. He said that he boasted about his ministry to the non-Jews so as to make the Jews jealous of the results of his ministry among the Gentiles. Then maybe some would be curious and begin believing in Jesus. When God accepts their faith in Jesus, it will be like they rose from the dead.

Paul then used some metaphors to illustrate his point that God has not rejected forever the Jews who, at that time, did not believe in Jesus as the Christ. He showed that if some Jews were holy, then all were, in the same way that a part of a batch of dough represents the whole batch. And the branches of a tree that is holy are themselves holy, even if they have been broken off to allow branches from a different tree to be joined into the trunk. He used the picture of the branches of that different tree to represent the believers who were not Jews.

He reminded the believers who were not Jews of God's kindness toward them. He told them to always be mindful of that kindness rather than being proud of themselves. He warned them that God is able to do to them as he did to the Jews who do not believe in Jesus, if they became proud of themselves.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

Do not look down on Jews who have not accepted Jesus as the Christ

Many Gentiles believing in Jesus will make the Jews want that blessing too

#### 11:18a

#### do not boast over those branches.

- then do<sup>(sing)</sup> not boast against/over the branches.
- And so, you<sup>(plur)</sup> must not boast and put down the branches.

This verse is the then-clause (after the if-clauses of 11:17a–c). For example:

then it is not... (NJB)

**do not boast over those branches:** There are two ways to interpret the Greek word that the BSB translates as boast:

1. It refers to boasting in a way that scorns someone else. For example:

do not boast against the branches (NABRE) (BSB, RSV, NIV, NABRE, KJV, NLT, GW, NET, NCV)

1. It refers to being arrogant toward someone else. For example:

do not consider yourself to be superior to those other branches (NIV11) (NIV11, GNT, NJB, ESV, NASB, CEV, REB)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1), because the BDAG supports it. Moo, Longenecker, Dunn, Schreiner, and Jewett support it in their translations.

#### 11:18b

#### If you do,

- But/And if you<sup>(sing)</sup> are boasting against them,
- If you<sup>(plur)</sup> are doing that,

This verse begins with the conjunction that is often translated as “and” or “but.” Here it introduces something more that Paul said to those who might boast about the branches (11:18a). Some languages will see contrast to what Paul said in 11:18a, but other languages will not. For example:

But/Otomi Back Translation on TW.

And

**If you do:** The Greek is literally “if you boast.” For example:

If you do boast (RSV)

If the Roman believers were boasting over the branches (11:18a), then they needed to heed the warning Paul wrote in 11:18c–d.

#### 11:18c

#### remember this: You do not support the root,

- you yourself do not provide for the root,

- think of this: you yourselves do not enable the root to continue living.

**11:18d****but the root supports you.**

- but the root provides for you.
- No. The root enables you<sup>(plur)</sup> to continue living.

**11:18c–d**

**remember this: You do not support the root, but the root supports you:** The BSB adds the word remember. For example:

You are just a branch, not the root. (NLT)

But in some languages it is more natural to introduce the rest of these words with something like the BSB. For example:

consider this: (NIV11)

think: (NJB)

**You do not support the root:** The Greek emphasizes the word You. Here are other ways to emphasize this word:

as for you, you do not support the root

you yourself do not support the root

**support:** Here this word refers to providing for the needs of someone or something. Here are other ways to translate this word:

sustain (NJB)

care for

help to live

**Romans 11:19****Section 11:11–24: Do not be arrogant toward Jews who do not believe in Jesus**

In this section, Paul asked his readers if God has rejected the Jews forever. He answered his own question, indicating that God has not. At that time many Jews rejected Jesus as the Christ/Messiah. As a result, God made the message about Jesus known to people who were not Jews. But God will one day include the Jews and save them through Jesus too.

Paul then spoke directly to the believers who were not Jews. He said that he boasted about his ministry to the non-Jews so as to make the Jews jealous of the results of his ministry among the Gentiles. Then maybe some would be curious and begin believing in Jesus. When God accepts their faith in Jesus, it will be like they rose from the dead.

Paul then used some metaphors to illustrate his point that God has not rejected forever the Jews who, at that time, did not believe in Jesus as the Christ. He showed that if some Jews were holy, then all were, in the same way that a part of a batch of dough represents the whole batch. And the branches of a tree that is holy are themselves holy, even if they have been broken off to allow branches from a different tree to be joined into the trunk. He used the picture of the branches of that different tree to represent the believers who were not Jews.

He reminded the believers who were not Jews of God's kindness toward them. He told them to always be mindful of that kindness rather than being proud of themselves. He warned them that God is able to do to them as he did to the Jews who do not believe in Jesus, if they became proud of themselves.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

Do not look down on Jews who have not accepted Jesus as the Christ

Many Gentiles believing in Jesus will make the Jews want that blessing too

**11:19a****You will say then,**

- So, you<sup>(sing)</sup> will/might say,
- Perhaps one of you<sup>(plur)</sup> will say,

**You:** The word You is singular in the Greek. This letter is addressed to the whole church in Rome. So, here the singular You refers to someone in a general way and does not accuse the whole church in Rome of saying what Paul quoted in 11:19b–c. Some languages must translate differently for the correct meaning. For example:

one of you<sup>(plur)</sup>

someone among you<sup>(plur)</sup>

**will say:** Paul anticipated what an incorrectly proud Gentile believer might say (a possibility), so that he

could respond here in this letter. He is not predicting with a prophecy (a certainty). Some languages use different grammar or word for those two kinds of statements. If that is true in your language, use the one that indicates a probable future statement.

**then:** The word then probably introduces what someone might say in response to what Paul said in 11:17–18.

#### 11:19b

##### **“Branches were broken off**

- “Those branches were broken off of the tree
- “God broke off those branches,

**Branches were broken off:** This clause is passive. 11:20–21 indicates that God broke them off. Some languages must use an active clause. For example:

God broke off branches

**Branches:** In English, not using “the” here indicates that some branches were broken off. But the word here refers to the same branches as in 11:17, so it may be more clear in your language to add “those” here. For example:

Those branches

#### 11:19c

##### **so that I could be grafted in.”**

- so that I could be joined to the/that tree.”
- and so he tied me into that tree.”

**so that I could be grafted in:** The BSB uses the word could to go with so that to indicate that this is a purpose clause. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

so that I might be grafted in (ESV)

for me to be grafted in (NJB)

This purpose has already been accomplished. In some languages a purpose clause always indicates an unfulfilled purpose. If that is true in your language, use a result clause. For example:

and so I was grafted in

**I could be grafted in:** This clause is passive. In some languages an active clause must be used. For example:

God might graft me in

**grafted in:** This phrase refers to taking part of one plant and connecting it to another plant so that the new piece will continue to live and grow. See how you translated this phrase in 11:17.

## Romans 11:20

### **Section 11:11–24: Do not be arrogant toward Jews who do not believe in Jesus**

In this section, Paul asked his readers if God has rejected the Jews forever. He answered his own question, indicating that God has not. At that time many Jews rejected Jesus as the Christ/Messiah. As a result, God made the message about Jesus known to people who were not Jews. But God will one day include the Jews and save them through Jesus too.

Paul then spoke directly to the believers who were not Jews. He said that he boasted about his ministry to the non-Jews so as to make the Jews jealous of the results of his ministry among the Gentiles. Then maybe some would be curious and begin believing in Jesus. When God accepts their faith in Jesus, it will be like they rose from the dead.

Paul then used some metaphors to illustrate his point that God has not rejected forever the Jews who, at that time, did not believe in Jesus as the Christ. He showed that if some Jews were holy, then all were, in the same way that a part of a batch of dough represents the whole batch. And the branches of a tree that is holy are themselves holy, even if they have been broken off to allow branches from a different tree to be joined into the trunk. He used the picture of the branches of that different tree to represent the believers who were not Jews.

He reminded the believers who were not Jews of God’s kindness toward them. He told them to always be mindful of that kindness rather than being proud of themselves. He warned them that God is able to do to them as he did to the Jews who do not believe in Jesus, if they became proud of themselves.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

Do not look down on Jews who have not accepted Jesus as the Christ

Many Gentiles believing in Jesus will make the Jews want that blessing too

#### 11:20a

##### **That is correct:**

- Good.



- I say yes, but,
- My answer is this: What you<sup>(plur)</sup> say is true. But think of this:

**That is correct:** The Greek word here means “good” or “well” or “appropriate.” Scholars believe it indicates here agreeing in part. See Moo (page 704), Dunn (page 663), or Schreiner (page 607). Cranfield (page 568) calls it “a dangerous half-truth,” that is, something true but misleading if taken by itself. Morris (page 414) says it is somewhat ironic, but BDAG (page 506) does not list this verse under its “in irony” sense. 11:20b–d then explains what he means by saying That is correct. Here are other ways to translate the Greek word:

Yes, but remember— (NLT)

Admittedly Tagbanwa Back Translation on TW.

Yes, those words are true.

This is true but Yongkom Back Translation, by author, Papua New Guinea, unpublished manuscript.

With these words Paul began his response to the quoted words in 11:19. In some languages this must be made explicit for clear and natural communication of the meaning. For example:

My answer/response is this:

That is indeed true, relatives. But remember: Uma Back Translation on TW.

### 11:20b

#### **They were broken off because of unbelief,**

- They were broken off of the tree because they did not believe,
- they did not believe in Christ, and so God broke them off.

**They were broken off:** This clause is passive. Some languages must use an active clause. For example:

God broke them off

**because of unbelief:** The words because of introduce the reason why the branches were broken off. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

because they did not believe (GNT)

because they did not have faith (CEV)

**unbelief:** The word “their” is clearly implied here. Because of this, some English versions add this word. For example:

their unbelief (ESV)

It may be more natural in your language to follow the ESV or the examples in the previous note. The word unbelief refers to not believing in Jesus as the Christ, the one appointed by God to save his people. Some languages must say what the belief is in. For example:

did not believe in Jesus

didn’t believe in Christ (NLT)

### 11:20c

#### **but you stand by faith.**

- but you yourself stand strong because you believe.
- But as for you<sup>(plur)</sup>, you stand/remain well in your faith because you continue to believe in Jesus.

**you:** The Greek word is emphatic here. For example:

as for you, you

**stand by faith:** Here this phrase refers to remaining strong in what the person believes. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

stand fast (ESV)

are established (NJB)

stand strong in faith

**by faith:** This phrase indicates that this person is able to stand strong because they continue believing in Jesus. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

because you do believe (GNT)

because of faith (NABRE)

### 11:20d

#### **Do not be arrogant, but be afraid.**

- You must not be proud about yourself. Instead, be afraid.

- Therefore, do<sup>(plur)</sup> not be proud. Fear that for yourselves,

**Do not be arrogant:** The connection of “therefore/so” is implied here. For example:

So, do not become proud (ESV)

**be afraid:** Here it is unclear what the object of this be afraid might be. Many scholars think it means “respect/revere God.” For example, Moo (page 705), Morris (page 415), and Cranfield (page 569). But some scholars think it means “be afraid of being broken off like them.” For example, see Jewett (page 688), who says the next verse make this clear. The BSB and other English versions are perhaps more clear that it means be afraid, but many versions are not clear with just the word “fear.” On the whole it seems like this interpretation is more likely, because 11:21 seems to explain what to fear.

## Romans 11:21

### Section 11:11–24: Do not be arrogant toward Jews who do not believe in Jesus

In this section, Paul asked his readers if God has rejected the Jews forever. He answered his own question, indicating that God has not. At that time many Jews rejected Jesus as the Christ/Messiah. As a result, God made the message about Jesus known to people who were not Jews. But God will one day include the Jews and save them through Jesus too.

Paul then spoke directly to the believers who were not Jews. He said that he boasted about his ministry to the non-Jews so as to make the Jews jealous of the results of his ministry among the Gentiles. Then maybe some would be curious and begin believing in Jesus. When God accepts their faith in Jesus, it will be like they rose from the dead.

Paul then used some metaphors to illustrate his point that God has not rejected forever the Jews who, at that time, did not believe in Jesus as the Christ. He showed that if some Jews were holy, then all were, in the same way that a part of a batch of dough represents the whole batch. And the branches of a tree that is holy are themselves holy, even if they have been broken off to allow branches from a different tree to be joined into the trunk. He used the picture of the branches of that different tree to represent the believers who were not Jews.

He reminded the believers who were not Jews of God’s kindness toward them. He told them to always be mindful of that kindness rather than being proud of

themselves. He warned them that God is able to do to them as he did to the Jews who do not believe in Jesus, if they became proud of themselves.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

Do not look down on Jews who have not accepted Jesus as the Christ

Many Gentiles believing in Jesus will make the Jews want that blessing too

### 11:21a

#### For if God did not spare the natural branches,

- For if God did not protect the original/first branches,
- because God removed some of the branches belonging to the tree,

**For:** This word introduces a reason that a believer should fear.

**if:** Here the word if introduces a situation that is true. If this first part is true, that supports the second part (God will not spare the readers if they no longer believe in Jesus (11:20b)) to also be true.

In some languages, translating literally here would have a different meaning. If that is true in your language, translate the correct meaning. For example:

if it is true that God did not spare the natural branches

God did not spare the natural branches, so he will not spare you, if you stop believing in him

**spare:** The word spare refers to preventing harm or trouble coming to someone. Here this phrase indicates that God did not protect the Jews who did not believe in Jesus from the consequences of that unbelief. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

did not hold back from harm

did not protect

See how you translated this word in 8:32.

**the natural branches:** This refers to the same branches as in 11:19. These branches are natural because they belonged to the tree. They grew from the tree. They are not the grafted-in branches. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

the original branches (NLT)

the true branches

the branches belonging to the tree

### 11:21b

**He will certainly not spare you either.**

- in the same way he will not protect you<sup>(sing)</sup>.
- so similarly he will remove you<sup>(plur)</sup>, if you stop believing in Christ.

**He will certainly not spare you:** This clause implies the same condition as the natural branches. If the readers of this letter become unbelieving like some Jews were, God will not spare these readers either. In some languages all or some of that information needs to be explicit to make the translation clear. For example:

if you do not believe in Christ he will part from you  
Otomi Back Translation on TW.

he certainly will break you off too if you abandon  
(lit. drop) your belief-in/obeying-of him  
Tagbanwa Back Translation on TW.

**either:** Here this word means “similarly not.” In the same way that God did not spare the Jews who did not believe, he will also not spare Gentile believers if they stop believing.

## Romans 11:22

**Section 11:11–24: Do not be arrogant toward Jews who do not believe in Jesus**

In this section, Paul asked his readers if God has rejected the Jews forever. He answered his own question, indicating that God has not. At that time many Jews rejected Jesus as the Christ/Messiah. As a result, God made the message about Jesus known to people who were not Jews. But God will one day include the Jews and save them through Jesus too.

Paul then spoke directly to the believers who were not Jews. He said that he boasted about his ministry to the non-Jews so as to make the Jews jealous of the results of his ministry among the Gentiles. Then maybe some would be curious and begin believing in Jesus. When God accepts their faith in Jesus, it will be like they rose from the dead.

Paul then used some metaphors to illustrate his point that God has not rejected forever the Jews who, at that

time, did not believe in Jesus as the Christ. He showed that if some Jews were holy, then all were, in the same way that a part of a batch of dough represents the whole batch. And the branches of a tree that is holy are themselves holy, even if they have been broken off to allow branches from a different tree to be joined into the trunk. He used the picture of the branches of that different tree to represent the believers who were not Jews.

He reminded the believers who were not Jews of God’s kindness toward them. He told them to always be mindful of that kindness rather than being proud of themselves. He warned them that God is able to do to them as he did to the Jews who do not believe in Jesus, if they became proud of themselves.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

Do not look down on Jews who have not accepted Jesus as the Christ

Many Gentiles believing in Jesus will make the Jews want that blessing too

### 11:22a

**Take notice, therefore, of the kindness and severity of God:**

- ¶ Therefore, look/listen<sup>(sing)</sup>. God is kind to people and he is also strict with them.
- ¶ So see<sup>(plur)</sup> that God does good to people, and he follows his laws/rules exactly to them.
- ¶ So pay attention to the fact that at times God is nice to people, but at other times he shows no mercy to them.

**Take notice, therefore:** In Greek, the connecting word that the BSB translates as therefore occurs after the first word of this sentence. In many languages, this word must be first. For example:

Then take notice

**Take notice:** The Greek word is the command, “Look.” It introduces what Paul wanted the readers to pay attention to. Here are other ways to translate this word:

See

Listen

Consider (NIV)

you see that (NCV)

See how you translated this in 9:33 (“See”).

**kindness:** This word refers to doing good to someone because you want to. The intent of kindness is to help the person, rather than require him to repay the kindness in some way. God does many good things for people. See how you translated this word in 2:4.

**severity:** The Greek word refers to following a law or rule strictly. It indicates that no mercy is given. Here are other ways to translate this word:

harshness (NET)

God is...very strict (NCV)

#### 11:22b severity to those who fell,

- He was strict to those who have fallen in their faith,
- He followed his laws/rules exactly concerning those Jews who stopped believing.
- He showed no mercy to those who rejected his Christ/Messiah,

**those who fell:** Here Paul used the word fell figuratively to refer to Jews who followed the Jewish religion but did not believe Jesus was God’s Messiah (11:20b). For example:

those who fell in their faith

In some languages the word fell cannot be used in this way. If that is true in your language, translate the correct meaning. For example:

those who stop believing in him

the ones who turn-their-backs-on/reject him  
Yakan Back Translation on TW.

#### 11:22c but kindness to you,

- but he is kind to you,
- But God does good to you Gentiles when you believed.
- but he is nice to you non-Jewish believers.

**kindness to you:** Here the word kindness refers to salvation and other things that God gives to someone when he believes in Jesus. For example:

he gave to you the favor because you believed  
O-tomi Back Translation on TW.

**you:** This word is singular and continues to refer to a non-Jewish believer.

#### 11:22d if you continue in His kindness.

- if you persevere in that kindness.
- That is true as long as you<sup>(plur)</sup> live according to his kindness.

**if:** The Greek word that the BSB literally translates as if introduces what must happen for God to continue to be kind to Gentile believers. Here are other ways to translate this word:

provided (ESV)

as long as (NJB)

**you continue in His kindness:** This clause indicates that the Gentile believer must live according to God’s kindness to him, that is, he must continue to believe in Jesus as the Christ/Messiah. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

you remain in his kindness (NABRE)

you persevere in it (NJB)

#### 11:22e Otherwise you also will be cut off.

- Otherwise you<sup>(sing)</sup> will also be cut off.
- But if you reject that kindness, he will remove you too.

**Otherwise:** This word introduces what will happen if the Gentile believer does not continue in God’s kindness. Here are other ways to translate this word:

But if you do not, (GNT)

But if you don’t continue, Kankanaey Back Translation on TW.

But if you turn away from his kindness,

**you also will be cut off:** This clause is passive. Some languages must use an active clause. For example:

God will cut you off also

**cut off:** This continues the metaphor about the branches and the tree. In 11:20, the natural branches were broken off, but here the grafted-in branches could be cut off.

## Romans 11:23

### Section 11:11–24: Do not be arrogant toward Jews who do not believe in Jesus

In this section, Paul asked his readers if God has rejected the Jews forever. He answered his own question, indicating that God has not. At that time many Jews rejected Jesus as the Christ/Messiah. As a result, God made the message about Jesus known to people who were not Jews. But God will one day include the Jews and save them through Jesus too.

Paul then spoke directly to the believers who were not Jews. He said that he boasted about his ministry to the non-Jews so as to make the Jews jealous of the results of his ministry among the Gentiles. Then maybe some would be curious and begin believing in Jesus. When God accepts their faith in Jesus, it will be like they rose from the dead.

Paul then used some metaphors to illustrate his point that God has not rejected forever the Jews who, at that time, did not believe in Jesus as the Christ. He showed that if some Jews were holy, then all were, in the same way that a part of a batch of dough represents the whole batch. And the branches of a tree that is holy are themselves holy, even if they have been broken off to allow branches from a different tree to be joined into the trunk. He used the picture of the branches of that different tree to represent the believers who were not Jews.

He reminded the believers who were not Jews of God's kindness toward them. He told them to always be mindful of that kindness rather than being proud of themselves. He warned them that God is able to do to them as he did to the Jews who do not believe in Jesus, if they became proud of themselves.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

Do not look down on Jews who have not accepted Jesus as the Christ

Many Gentiles believing in Jesus will make the Jews want that blessing too

### 11:23a–b

**And if they do not persist in unbelief, they will be grafted in:** The clause if they do not persist in unbelief interrupts the clause And...they will be grafted in. It will be more clear or more natural in some languages to translate without the interruption. For example:

if they do not persist in unbelief, even they will be grafted in

even they will be grafted in, if they do not persist in unbelief

**they will be grafted in:** This clause is passive. Some languages must translate it with an active clause. For example:

God will graft them in

### 11:23a

**And if they do not persist in unbelief,**

- But/And for/about them, if they do not remain/stay not believing,
- And if the Jews begin to believe in Jesus,

**if they do not persist in unbelief:** This clause has two negatives, not and “un”(belief). This clause means “if they start to believe.” Here are other ways to translate this clause:

if the people of Israel turn from their unbelief (NLT)

if they stop their unbelieving

It will be more clear or more natural in some languages to translate without the two negatives. For example:

if they begin believing

### 11:23b

**they will be grafted in,**

- they will be joined to the/that tree,
- God will tie them into that tree,

**they:** The Jews who do not believe in Jesus, if they begin believing, God will graft in them too. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

they also (NABRE)

as for even these Jews Tagbanwa Back Translation on TW.

**grafted in:** See how you translated this phrase in 11:19.

#### 11:23c

**for God is able to graft them in again.**

- for God is able to join them to the/that tree again.
- because God is able to tie them into it again.

**for:** Here this word introduces a reason or basis for Jews being grafted in, once they believe in Jesus.

### Romans 11:24

#### Section 11:11–24: Do not be arrogant toward Jews who do not believe in Jesus

In this section, Paul asked his readers if God has rejected the Jews forever. He answered his own question, indicating that God has not. At that time many Jews rejected Jesus as the Christ/Messiah. As a result, God made the message about Jesus known to people who were not Jews. But God will one day include the Jews and save them through Jesus too.

Paul then spoke directly to the believers who were not Jews. He said that he boasted about his ministry to the non-Jews so as to make the Jews jealous of the results of his ministry among the Gentiles. Then maybe some would be curious and begin believing in Jesus. When God accepts their faith in Jesus, it will be like they rose from the dead.

Paul then used some metaphors to illustrate his point that God has not rejected forever the Jews who, at that time, did not believe in Jesus as the Christ. He showed that if some Jews were holy, then all were, in the same way that a part of a batch of dough represents the whole batch. And the branches of a tree that is holy are themselves holy, even if they have been broken off to allow branches from a different tree to be joined into the trunk. He used the picture of the branches of that different tree to represent the believers who were not Jews.

He reminded the believers who were not Jews of God's kindness toward them. He told them to always be mindful of that kindness rather than being proud of themselves. He warned them that God is able to do to them as he did to the Jews who do not believe in Jesus, if they became proud of themselves.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

Do not look down on Jews who have not accepted Jesus as the Christ

Many Gentiles believing in Jesus will make the Jews want that blessing too

#### 11:24a

**For if you were cut from a wild olive tree,**

- For if it is true that you<sup>(sing)</sup> were cut from a wild olive tree, your very own tree,
- For you<sup>(plur)</sup> are like the natural branches of a wild olive tree. God cut you from it/there,

**For:** Here this word introduces a second reason or basis for Jews being grafted in, once they believe in Jesus.

**if:** Here the word if introduces a situation that is true. If this first part is true, that supports the second part (God will graft in Jews, if they believe in Jesus (11:24c)) to also be true.

In some languages, translating literally here would have a different meaning. If that is true in your language, translate the correct meaning. For example:

if it is true that

you were cut from what is by nature a wild olive tree, and grafted, contrary to nature, into a cultivated olive tree, therefore how much more...

**you were cut from:** The clause you were cut is passive. Some languages must use an active clause. For example:

God cut you from

**you:** This word is emphatic in the Greek. For example:

you yourself

as for you, if you...

**a wild olive tree:** The phrase indicates that the tree from which the person was cut was by nature a wild olive tree, as opposed to a cultivated one. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

the wild olive tree to which you belonged

your parent/own wild olive tree

**11:24b**

**and contrary to nature were grafted into one that is cultivated,**

- and you were joined to a domestic olive tree, which is not your very own tree,
- and he tied you into a planted olive tree, a tree of which you are not a natural branch.

**and contrary to nature were grafted into one that is cultivated:** The phrase contrary to nature indicates that grafting of a branch from the wild olive tree into the cultivated olive is contrary to nature. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

grafted to a cultivated tree to which you did not belong

grafted to a cultivated olive tree that was not your own tree

**were grafted:** The word “you” is implied from 11:24a. This clause is passive. Some languages must use an active clause. For example:

God grafted you

**one that is cultivated:** The word cultivated indicates that people planted this olive tree and took care of it. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

a domestic olive tree

the planted oliveKankanaey Back Translation on TW.

the cared-for treeYakan Back Translation on TW.

**11:24c**

**how much more readily will these, the natural branches,**

- then it is even more fitting/proper that these branches, the ones belonging to the cultivated tree,
- So it is right indeed for God to tie these branches, the branches of the cultivated olive tree,

**11:24d**

**be grafted into their own olive tree!**

- be joined back to their very own olive tree.
- back to their own tree.

**11:24c-d**

**how much more readily will these, the natural branches, be grafted into their own olive tree!:** The phrase how much more indicates that it is more fitting for God to graft the natural branches back to the cultivated olive tree, than to graft wild olive branches to it. Morris (page 417) says, “We are not to think of one thing as more easy than another for omnipotence. Paul is talking about what is fitting, not about what is easy.” Here are other ways to translate this clause:

it is much more fitting/proper that these, the natural branches, will be grafted back into their own olive tree

it is right indeed for God to graft these, the natural branches, back into their own tree

**will these, the natural branches, be grafted into their own olive tree:** This clause is passive. Some languages must use an active clause. For example:

God will graft these, the natural branches, into their own olive tree

**these, the natural branches:** The Greek is more literally “these (ones), the (ones) according-to nature.” The last part (“according-to nature”) here refers to the branches of the cultivated tree. The word these emphasizes that Paul was talking here about the branches of the cultivated olive tree. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

these branches, to the tree to which they belong

these ones, the branches of their parent/own cultivated tree

**Romans 11:25**

**Section 11:25–32: God will be merciful to Jews and Gentiles**

In this section, Paul warned the Gentile believers in Rome to not think of themselves as better than the Jews who have not believed in Jesus. God has caused many Jews to not believe until the time the full number of Gentiles will believe. Then all Israel will be saved.

Many Jews have rejected the gospel of Jesus, but God still loves them because he chose them long ago. God will not change his mind about his promises to them and his calling of them.

Both Jew and Gentile are alike in that both have been disobedient and God will be merciful to both.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

God still has a plan for Israel (JBP)

All Israel Will Be Saved (NIV)

### 11:25a

**I do not want you to be ignorant of this mystery, brothers, so that you will not be conceited:**

- ¶ For, my brothers and sisters, I do not want you to think of yourselves as wise, and so I do not want you to be ignorant of this secret/hidden truth:
- ¶ For, my fellow believers, I want you<sup>(plur)</sup> to know something that God has now revealed, so that you will not think about yourselves as being wise. It is this:

This verse begins with the Greek word that is usually translated “for.” It introduces something more that Paul wanted to say about Israel connected to what he has been saying in 11:1–24. For example:

For (KJV)

Now (JBP)

Furthermore

**I do not want you to be ignorant of this mystery, brothers, so that you will not be conceited:** The word brothers occurs in the middle of the main clause. In many languages it is more natural to have this word first in the clause. For example:

Brothers, lest you be conceited, I want you to understand this mystery,

**I do not want you to be ignorant:** The Greek phrase that the BSB literally translates as I do not want you to be ignorant emphasizes what he was about to say. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

I do not want you to be unaware

my desire is that you know

See how you translated this in 1:13.

**this mystery:** This phrase refers to the words of 11:25b–26a.

**mystery:** The Greek word that the BSB translates as mystery refers to truth or knowledge that people have not discovered on their own. Someone else reveals it to them. God revealed to Paul what he wrote in 11:25b–26a. Here are other ways to translate this word:

secret (NCV)

hidden truth

something that was not made-known previously  
Kankanaey Back Translation on TW.

**brothers:** Here this word refers to believers in Jesus, both men and women. The word indicates a close relationship between believers because God has made them his (adopted) children. It does not refer here to his fellow Israelites who did not believe in Jesus, as in 9:3. See how you translated this word in 1:13 or 10:1.

**so that you will not be conceited:** The Greek is more literally “in-order-that you might not be wise in yourselves.” This clause is a warning to the Gentile believers in Rome not to think of themselves as wise. In this letter, Paul encouraged them, that they were like branches that God had grafted into the holy tree and that Jews who have not believed in Jesus have been broken away. But here he warned them not to think that God had favored them rather than the Jews, and therefore they were wiser than the Jews. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

so that you will not be wise in your own estimation (NASB)

to keep you from thinking yourselves wise (REB)

### 11:25b

**A hardening in part has come to Israel,**

- the hearts/insides of some of the Israelites have been made closed/stubborn,
- God has caused some of the people of Israel to be stubborn regarding believing in Jesus.

**A hardening in part has come to Israel:** The Greek is more literally “hardness in part has happened in/ to Israel.” It indicates that some Jews do not believe in Jesus, and implies that God caused that to happen. Here are other ways to translate this clause:



a hardening has come upon part of Israel (RSV)

part of Israel had its mind hardened (NJB)

the hearts of some of the Israelites have been made hard/stubborn

God has caused the insides/mind of some of the people of Israel to be hard/unyielding

**hardening:** Here this word means “stubbornness.” It refers to someone unwilling to accept something as the truth or having difficulty understanding something. Here are other ways to translate this word:

made stubborn (NCV)

making their minds closed

See how you translated “hardened” in 11:7.

**in part:** Here this word indicates that only some Jews were hardened. It does not indicate that all Jews were hardened a little. See Morris (page 420) or Cranfield (page 575). See the above examples.

**Israel:** This is the name for the Jews as a nation. It is God’s name for them in connection with his covenant with them.

**11:25c**  
**until the full number of the Gentiles has come in.**

- until the complete number of Gentiles have entered his kingdom.
- It will be that way until after all the non-Jews whom God has called have believed in Jesus.

**until the full number of the Gentiles has come in:** This clause describes the extent of time Paul was talking about. The hardening of Israel in part takes place during that time period.

**the full number of the Gentiles has come in:** The Greek word that the BSB translates as full number means “a full measure” of something. Here the whole clause probably refers to the number of Gentiles that God has decided to bring into his kingdom. When that number is reached, the partial hardening of Israel will end. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

the fullness of the Gentiles has come in (ESV)

until all of God’s non-Jewish people are included (GW)

until the full number of Gentiles comes to Christ (NLT)

**the Gentiles:** Here this word refers to all people-groups except the Jews. See how you translated this in 11:12.

**has come in:** Here these words have a figurative meaning. It implies entering the kingdom of God. See the examples above.

## Romans 11:26

### Section 11:25–32: God will be merciful to Jews and Gentiles

In this section, Paul warned the Gentile believers in Rome to not think of themselves as better than the Jews who have not believed in Jesus. God has caused many Jews to not believe until the time the full number of Gentiles will believe. Then all Israel will be saved.

Many Jews have rejected the gospel of Jesus, but God still loves them because he chose them long ago. God will not change his mind about his promises to them and his calling of them.

Both Jew and Gentile are alike in that both have been disobedient and God will be merciful to both.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

God still has a plan for Israel (JBP)

All Israel Will Be Saved (NIV)

### 11:26a

#### And so all Israel will be saved,

- And in that way all of the Israelites will be saved,
- When that happens, God will save the whole nation of Israel from their sins.

**And so:** This phrase indicates that the full number of Gentiles must come in for all of Israel to be saved.

**all Israel will be saved:** This clause is passive. Some languages must use an active clause. For example:

God will save all Israel

**all Israel:** This phrase probably refers to the people of Israel as a nation. See Moo (pages 720–723), Morris (page 420), or Cranfield (page 576).

**saved:** This word refers to being rescued from something harmful or dangerous. Here it refers to rescue from God's anger at the final judgment. See how you translated this word in 5:10 or 11:14.

#### 11:26b

**as it is written: "The Deliverer will come from Zion;**

- just like the words that were written long ago, "The one who saves will come from Zion.
- It will be as Scripture says: "The Savior/Rescuer will come from Mount Zion,

**as it is written:** This clause introduces quotes from Scripture. The verses he quoted were written hundreds of years before Paul wrote the letter to the Romans. In some languages a literal translation would wrongly indicate the words were written at the same time as Paul wrote here. If that is true in your language, indicate it was long before Paul wrote. For example:

as it was written long ago

This clause refers to what was written in the Old Testament. Some languages must make that explicit to make that clear. For example:

As scripture says (GNT)

This clause is passive. The prophet wrote what God told him to write. Some languages must use an active clause here. For example:

the prophet wrote long ago

what God caused-to-be-written saying, Kankanaey Back Translation on TW.

It is like it says in the Holy Book

See how you translated this clause in 1:17 or 11:8.

**The Deliverer:** This title refers to someone who would save others from danger. Here are other ways to translate this title:

The Savior (GNT)

The one who rescues (NLT)

Since this is an Old Testament quote, you should not name Jesus here.

**Zion:** Zion is the name of the hill in Jerusalem southwest of the temple. In the Old Testament, Mount Zion was symbolic for God's holy city, Jerusalem. See how you translated this word in 9:33.

#### 11:26c

**He will remove godlessness from Jacob.**

- He will remove all behavior that disrespects God from Jacob's descendants,"
- and he will cause the descendants of Jacob to stop doing things that insult God.

**He will remove godlessness from Jacob:** There is no conjunction to begin this clause. In some languages an "and" would be more natural. For example:

and shall turn away ungodliness from Jacob (KJV)

Or you may want to use a full stop instead of a comma at the end of 11:26b and start a new sentence here.

**remove:** There are two ways to interpret the Greek word that the BSB translates as remove:

1. It refers to removing something. (BSB, RSV, GNT, NJB, NASB, ESV, GW, NET, REB, NCV)
2. It refers to turning aside something. For example:

turn...away (NIV) (NIV, NABRE, NLT)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1), because it seems unlikely that Paul claimed here that Israel was mostly unaffected by ungodliness and God turned it aside to keep them that way.

**godlessness:** This word refers to doing or saying things that show no reverence or respect for God. Here are other ways to translate this word:

impiety

doing or saying things that dishonor/disrespect God

See how you translated this word in 1:18.

**Jacob:** Here this name is symbolic for his descendants, the Jews. For example:

Jacob's descendants (CEV)

## Romans 11:27

### Section 11:25–32: God will be merciful to Jews and Gentiles

In this section, Paul warned the Gentile believers in Rome to not think of themselves as better than the Jews who have not believed in Jesus. God has caused many Jews to not believe until the time the full number of Gentiles will believe. Then all Israel will be saved.

Many Jews have rejected the gospel of Jesus, but God still loves them because he chose them long ago. God will not change his mind about his promises to them and his calling of them.

Both Jew and Gentile are alike in that both have been disobedient and God will be merciful to both.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

God still has a plan for Israel (JBP)

All Israel Will Be Saved (NIV)

#### 11:27a

#### And this is My covenant with them

- “and that will be the agreement from me to them
- That is contract I will fulfill for them

**And this is My covenant with them:** Here the word this refers to the promises in 11:26b–c. Jewett (page 705) says, “the focus here is on the future transformation of Israel.” Some languages must use “that” for the correct meaning. For example:

that will be my covenant with them

**My covenant:** The Greek is more literally “the covenant from me.” It indicates that the covenant originates from God.

**covenant:** The word covenant refers to an agreement or contract. See how you translated this word in 9:4.

#### 11:27b

#### when I take away their sins.”

- when I remove their sins.”
- when I cause their wrongdoings to cease to exist.”

**when I take away their sins:** The Greek indicates that I take away their sins will happen at the same time as fulfilling the covenant (11:27a). L&N § ὅταν (b).

**I take away their sins:** This clause refers to the removal of the guilt and penalty for sin. Those sins

will no longer be counted against them. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

I will remove all their sins Yakan Back Translation on TW.

I will clear their sins Otomi Back Translation on TW.

**sins:** This word refers to doing something that God said is wrong to do, or not doing something that God said they should do. See how you translated this word in 3:9 or 8:10.

#### General Comment on 11:25b–27b

Some English versions like the ESV have a quote mark at the end of 11:26c and at the beginning of 11:27a, even though 11:26b–27b is punctuated as one sentence. They probably did this to indicate that the quote comes from two different verses in the book of Isaiah. But in some languages it is more natural to not have the extra quote marks, as in the BSB.

#### General Comment on 11:26b–27b

These words are a near quote of parts of Isaiah 59:20–21 and a part of Isaiah 27:9. If you indicate the location of quotes from the Old Testament with cross-references, you may want to indicate these three verses here.

## Romans 11:28

### Section 11:25–32: God will be merciful to Jews and Gentiles

In this section, Paul warned the Gentile believers in Rome to not think of themselves as better than the Jews who have not believed in Jesus. God has caused many Jews to not believe until the time the full number of Gentiles will believe. Then all Israel will be saved.

Many Jews have rejected the gospel of Jesus, but God still loves them because he chose them long ago. God will not change his mind about his promises to them and his calling of them.

Both Jew and Gentile are alike in that both have been disobedient and God will be merciful to both.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

God still has a plan for Israel (JBP)

All Israel Will Be Saved (NIV)

**11:28a****Regarding the gospel,**

- ¶ Concerning the good news,
- ¶ About the good news about Jesus,

The Greek does not have a conjunction to connect to the previous verses. This probably indicates that 11:28 does not continue the sequence of thoughts from the previous verses. Many scholars see 11:28–32 as a summary of chapters 9–11. See Moo (page 729) or Cranfield (page 579). Consider how to indicate that in your language, or follow the Greek and do not begin this verse with a conjunction.

**Regarding the gospel:** The words Regarding mean here “with reference to.” When considering the gospel of Jesus and the Jews, the Jews are enemies (see notes below). Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

As concerning the gospel (KJV)

with respect to the gospel of Jesus

**the gospel:** The Greek word that the BSB translates as gospel means “good news.” Here this word refers to God’s good news about Jesus Christ. See how you translated this word in 1:1 or 10:16.

**11:28b****they are enemies on your account;**

- they are enemies of/with God, and this has benefited you.
- God is their enemy, which helped you Gentiles.

**they are enemies:** Some English versions add the words “of God.” For example, Moo (page 730), Morris (page 422), and Dunn (page 693) connect the word “enemies” to being enemies of God. The context implies that God is an enemy to them.

**they:** Here this word refers to the Jews who do not believe in Jesus.

**on your account:** This phrase indicates that the Gentile believers in Rome (and implying all Gentile believers) benefited from the Jews being enemies with God (see also 11:11). Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

which helped you

and this benefits you Gentiles (NLT)

**11:28c****but regarding election,**

- But concerning being chosen,
- But about God choosing them to be his people,

**election:** Here this word refers to God choosing the Jews to be his people. For example:

God’s choice (GNT)

**11:28d****they are loved on account of the patriarchs.**

- they are loved by him because of their ancestors.
- he still loves them because he made promises to their ancestors long ago.

**they are loved:** This clause indicates that God loves them. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

they are still well loved (NJB)

they are still the people he loves (NLT)

**on account of the patriarchs:** This phrase indicates that God had made promises to the forefathers of the Jews, and he will keep those promises, even if the fact that many of the Jews do not accept Jesus as the Messiah makes it seem like he should not. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

for the sake of their forefathers (ESV)

because of the promises he made to their ancestors (NCV)

**the patriarchs:** Here this phrase refers to Abraham, Isaac, and Jacob. Jacob was the founder of the nation of Israel. They lived about two thousand years before the time Paul wrote this letter. Indicate or imply that patriarchs refers to many, many generations before this time. For example:

the forefathers of the nation of Israel  
Tagbanwa Back Translation on TW.

because of His promise long ago to their ancestors  
Western Bukidnon Manobo Back Translation on TW.

## Romans 11:29

### Section 11:25–32: God will be merciful to Jews and Gentiles

In this section, Paul warned the Gentile believers in Rome to not think of themselves as better than the Jews who have not believed in Jesus. God has caused many Jews to not believe until the time the full number of Gentiles will believe. Then all Israel will be saved.

Many Jews have rejected the gospel of Jesus, but God still loves them because he chose them long ago. God will not change his mind about his promises to them and his calling of them.

Both Jew and Gentile are alike in that both have been disobedient and God will be merciful to both.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

God still has a plan for Israel (JBP)

All Israel Will Be Saved (NIV)

#### 11:29

#### For God's gifts and His call are irrevocable.

- For God does not regret the gifts he gave to them and his calling of them.
- For God never wishes he had not chosen them or had not given the good things that he gave them.

**For:** Here this word introduces the basis for what Paul said in 11:28c–d. Israel is still the chosen people of God, even if they are undergoing a partial hardening, because God will never change his mind about calling them to be his chosen people nor about his promises to them.

**gifts:** Here this word refers to the good things that God has done for the Israelites. 9:4–5 lists some of those gifts: “the adoption as sons; theirs the divine glory and the covenants; theirs the giving of the law, the temple worship, and the promises. Theirs are the patriarchs, and from them proceeds the human descent of Christ.”

**call:** Like God called Paul to be his apostle (1:1), God called the Israelites to be his people.

**irrevocable:** The Greek word here refers to not regretting doing something. BDAG, L&N, Kittel, and L&S. God does not wish that he had not called the Israelites to be his chosen people. Here are other ways to translate this word:

no change of mind (NJB)

God does not regret

This word is probably emphasized in the Greek clause. For example:

indeed, unregretted

## Romans 11:30

### Section 11:25–32: God will be merciful to Jews and Gentiles

In this section, Paul warned the Gentile believers in Rome to not think of themselves as better than the Jews who have not believed in Jesus. God has caused many Jews to not believe until the time the full number of Gentiles will believe. Then all Israel will be saved.

Many Jews have rejected the gospel of Jesus, but God still loves them because he chose them long ago. God will not change his mind about his promises to them and his calling of them.

Both Jew and Gentile are alike in that both have been disobedient and God will be merciful to both.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

God still has a plan for Israel (JBP)

All Israel Will Be Saved (NIV)

#### 11:30a

#### Just as you who formerly disobeyed God

- ¶ For just as in the past you yourselves disobeyed God,
- ¶ For you Gentile believers always disobeyed God at an earlier time,

**Just as:** This word introduces an explanation here. Moo (page 732) and Cranfield (page 582).

**you:** Here this word refers to Gentile believers in Rome, and implies all Gentile believers. In the Greek, the word is emphatic. For example:

you yourselves

**who formerly:** Here this phrase refers to the time before the readers of this letter believed in Jesus.

**11:30b**

**have now received mercy through their disobedience,**

- but now you have been given mercy because they disobeyed him,
- but in this present time the Jews disobey and so God had mercy on you. In the same way,

**have:** The “just as” comparison continues from 11:30a. In English, to help indicate that, no comma is used at the end of 11:30a.

But in some languages a pause would be more natural here. For example:

Just as formerly you were disobedient to God, but now have received mercy because of their disobedience, (REB)

**now:** Here this word refers generally to this new period of time where the gospel of Jesus is proclaimed.

**received mercy:** The word “you” is implied from 11:30a. This clause indicates that God was merciful to the Gentile believers. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

you have been shown mercy (NJB)

This clause is passive. Some languages must use an active clause. For example:

God was merciful to you (NLT)

**their:** Here, as in 11:28b, this word refers to the Jews who do not believe in Jesus.

**Romans 11:31****Section 11:25–32: God will be merciful to Jews and Gentiles**

In this section, Paul warned the Gentile believers in Rome to not think of themselves as better than the Jews who have not believed in Jesus. God has caused many Jews to not believe until the time the full number of Gentiles will believe. Then all Israel will be saved.

Many Jews have rejected the gospel of Jesus, but God still loves them because he chose them long ago. God will not change his mind about his promises to them and his calling of them.

Both Jew and Gentile are alike in that both have been disobedient and God will be merciful to both.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

God still has a plan for Israel (JBP)

All Israel Will Be Saved (NIV)

**11:31a–b**

**so they too have now disobeyed, in order that they too may now receive mercy through the mercy shown to you:** There are two ways to interpret how to connect the phrase that the BSB translates as through the mercy shown to you to the rest of the verse.

1. It connects to they also may now receive mercy. For example:

so they too have now become disobedient in order that they too may now receive mercy as a result of God’s mercy to you (NIV) (BSB, ESV, RSV, NIV, NJB, NABRE, NASB, KJV, GW, NET)

1. It connects to they too have now been disobedient. For example:

In the same way, because of the mercy that you have received, the Jews now disobey God, in order that they also may now receive God’s mercy (GNT) (GNT, REB, NCV)

Many English versions follow interpretation (1). However, many scholars (for example, Moo (page 734). and Dunn (page 688).) make a strong case for interpretation (2). The GNT’s “because of” makes little sense here to this author. Moo (page 711) and Schreiner (page 624) translate the Greek as, “for the sake of mercy for you.” You should follow whatever interpretation the major language version does. If you follow interpretation (2), see also note on through the mercy shown to you below.

**11:31a**

**so they too have now disobeyed,**

- in the same way they are now disobedient also
- then, at this present time they do not obey God

**so:** The Greek word here means “in the same way.” L&N. It does not mean “therefore” here. Here are other ways to translate this word:

In the same way (GNT)

Thus also Uma Back Translation on TW.

**they too have now disobeyed:** Here Paul spoke in summary about the disobedience of the Jews. Wallace (page 554). Here are other ways to translate this clause:

they are disobedient now (NJB)

the Jews now disobey God (GNT)

**now:** Here this word refers generally to this new period of time where the gospel of Jesus is proclaimed.

#### 11:31b

**in order that they too may now receive mercy through the mercy shown to you.**

- so that they may now be shown mercy through the mercy that was shown to you<sup>(plur)</sup>.
- for the sake of God/he being merciful to you, so that he may now also be merciful to them.

**now:** There is a textual issue here:

1. Some Greek manuscripts have the word now in the middle of this phrase. For example:

they also may now receive mercy (ESV) (BSB, ESV, NIV, GNT, NRSV, NASB, NET)

1. Some manuscripts do not have this word. (RSV, NJB, KJV, GW, NLT, CEV, NCV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1), because the UBS Greek NT 5 supports it, although they had difficulty in deciding.

**through the mercy shown to you:** The Greek is literally “for the (thing) to you mercy.” If you followed interpretation (1) up in 11:31a–b, the meaning of “to/with/for” probably indicates that God’s mercy to the Gentiles helped accomplish the mercy to the Jews. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

for mercy to you

for God showing mercy to you

If you followed interpretation (2) up in 11:31a–b, the meaning of “to/with/for” probably indicates that the Jews disobeying helped accomplish God’s mercy to the Gentiles. For example:

for the sake of mercy for you Moo (page 734).

because God showed mercy to you (NCV)

**mercy:** The Greek word that the BSB translates as mercy refers to being concerned for someone in a bad situation and helping him in some way, including even forgiving him for something bad he did. See how you translated this word in 9:15.

## Romans 11:32

### Section 11:25–32: God will be merciful to Jews and Gentiles

In this section, Paul warned the Gentile believers in Rome to not think of themselves as better than the Jews who have not believed in Jesus. God has caused many Jews to not believe until the time the full number of Gentiles will believe. Then all Israel will be saved.

Many Jews have rejected the gospel of Jesus, but God still loves them because he chose them long ago. God will not change his mind about his promises to them and his calling of them.

Both Jew and Gentile are alike in that both have been disobedient and God will be merciful to both.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

God still has a plan for Israel (JBP)

All Israel Will Be Saved (NIV)

#### 11:32a

### For God has consigned everyone to disobedience

- For God has enclosed/trapped all people in the habit of being disobedient,
- For God has caused all people to disobey him,

**For:** Here this word introduces an explanation of 11:30–31. Cranfield (page 586).

**God has consigned everyone to disobedience:** The Greek word that the BSB translates as has consigned is literally “enclosed.” God caused all people to be trapped in the situation of being disobedient. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

God has caused all people to be trapped in disobedience

God has imprisoned all human beings in their own disobedience (NJB)

**disobedience:** Here this word probably implies not obeying what God says to do, as in 11:30. Some languages must say what or who people are disobeying. For example:

do not obey/follow God  
Yakan Back Translation on TW.

**11:32b**  
**so that He may have mercy on everyone.**

- in order that he could show mercy to all.
- so that he may be merciful to them all.

**so that:** Here this word introduces the purpose for enclosing all people in disobedience.

## Romans 11:33

### Section 11:33–36: Paul praised God

In this section, Paul praised God for his wisdom, knowledge, judgment, thinking, greatness, and power. He ended with acknowledging God's glory.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

Doxology (NIV)

Words of praise to God

**11:33a**  
**O, the depth of the riches of the wisdom and knowledge of God!**

- ¶ Oh, God's riches and wisdom and knowledge are deep/great indeed!
- ¶ Wow/Hey! God's great and good things, his wise thinking, and his knowledge are truly abundant!

**O:** This word expresses awe here. Paul was amazed at God's wisdom, knowledge, and such things. Some languages have a word that can be used in that way here. For example:

Hey!...

Truly,...

Wow!

Other languages would translate this meaning without a special word at the beginning. For example:

God's riches and wisdom and knowledge are deep indeed!

God's riches and wisdom and knowledge are very truly deep!

**the depth of the riches of the wisdom and knowledge of God:** There are two issues:

Issue 1: Interpretation

There are two ways to interpret this Greek phrase:

1. There are three things. For example:

the depth of the riches and wisdom and knowledge of God (NABRE) (RSV, GNT, NABRE, NLT, ESV, GW, CEV, NET, REB, NCV)

1. There are two things. For example:

the depth of the riches of the wisdom and knowledge of God (NIV) (BSB, NIV, NASB, KJV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1), because many scholars have a strong case for it. Moo (page 740) in support of interpretation (1) says, "But, recognizing that πλούτος ("riches") is used absolutely already in Rom. 11 (v. 11), it makes better sense to view πλούτου ("riches"), σοφίας ("wisdom"), and γνώσεως ("knowledge") as coordinate, each dependent on the word βάθος ("depth")."

Issue 2: Clause structure

This clause does not have a verb. Some languages must have a verb. For example:

God's riches and wisdom and knowledge are deep indeed!

Also, the word depth applies to each of the riches, the wisdom, and knowledge of God. Some languages must repeat the word for each of the three for the correct meaning or repeat the meaning of of God. For example:

the depth of God's riches and the depth of his wisdom and the depth of his knowledge

And some languages must use different words for the large amount of each. For example:



How great are God's riches! How deep are his wisdom and knowledge! (GNT)

the depth of God's riches and the height of his wisdom and the width of his knowledge

**depth:** This word indicates that God's riches, wisdom, and knowledge are very great. Here are other ways to translate this word:

is very great

abundance

**riches:** This word refers to the good and great things that God has. He has an endless supply. This word does not refer to money. In some languages a literal translation would refer only to money. If that is true in your language, translate the correct meaning. For example:

very many good things

great heavenly/spiritual things

**wisdom:** The word wisdom means "the ability to understand events and know the right action."

In some languages it is more natural to translate wisdom as a phrase. For example:

wise words and actions

right and just thinking

### 11:33b

#### How unsearchable are His judgments,

- His decisions cannot be searched/explained by people,
- People are not able to discern the ways he decides things.

**How unsearchable are His judgments:** Here the word How expresses amazement that his judgments are indeed unsearchable by us. It does not indicate a question here. For example:

his judgments are beyond our understanding

No one can explain the things God decides (NCV)

**unsearchable:** This word indicates that people cannot study God's judgments and learn what he based those judgments on.

**His judgments:** This refers to the decisions that God makes. Here the word judgments generally refers to more than what a judge does in court. Moo (page 742) says the word refers here to " 'executive' decisions about the direction of salvation history." Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

his decisions (GNT)

the things God decides (NCV)

### 11:33c

#### and untraceable His ways!

- and the things he does cannot be tracked!
- People are not able to understand why he does what he does.

**and:** The meaning of 11:33c is similar to 11:33b. The similarity strengthens the meaning in a poetic way. In some languages omitting the word and would help better with that meaning.

**untraceable:** The Greek word here means "not able to follow the tracks." People are not able to understand why God does what he does.

**His ways:** Here the word ways refers to the things that God does.

## Romans 11:34

### Section 11:33–36: Paul praised God

In this section, Paul praised God for his wisdom, knowledge, judgment, thinking, greatness, and power. He ended with acknowledging God's glory.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

Doxology (NIV)

Words of praise to God

### 11:34a–b

This verse is a quote from Isaiah 40:13. If you indicate the location of quotes from the Old Testament with cross-references, you may want to do so here.

Some languages use a standard way to introduce Scripture quotes. For example:

For, as the Holy Book says, "Who...

Note that “For” is not a part of the words from Isaiah.

**Who has known the mind of the Lord? Or who has been His counselor?:** This verse has two questions connected with the word Or. In some languages it is more natural to punctuate them as a single question. For example:

For who has known the mind of the Lord, or who has been his counselor?

#### 11:34a

##### “Who has known the mind of the Lord?”

- For, “who knows the thoughts of the Lord?”
- For Scripture says, “No one knows the Leader/Master God’s thinking,

**Who has known the mind of the Lord?:** This is a rhetorical question. It emphasizes that no one knows what the Lord is thinking. Translate with that meaning. Here are some ways:

- As a rhetorical question. For example:

who can know the Lord’s thoughts? (NLT)

Who knows how the Lord thinks? (GW)

Has anyone known the thoughts of the Lord(?) (CEV)

- As a statement. For example:

No one knows the mind/thoughts of the Lord.

**has known:** The Greek tense on the verb indicates that Paul spoke in summary about knowing. In some languages the present tense would better indicate that meaning. For example:

knows (GNT)

**the Lord:** The word Lord refers to someone who has authority over people. Here this phrase refers to God. In some languages it is more natural to indicate who this Lord is. For example:

the Lord God

See how you translated the word Lord in 4:8 or 11:3.

#### 11:34b

##### Or who has been His counselor?”

- Or who became his adviser?”
- and no one advises him.”

**Or who has been His counselor?:** This is a rhetorical question. It emphasizes that God has never needed the advice of someone. Translate with that meaning. Here are some ways:

- As a rhetorical question. For example:

Who has ever been his adviser? (NJB)

Who advises him?

Has anyone...given him advice? (CEV)

- As a statement. For example:

No one has become his adviser.

No one is able to advise him.

**has been His counselor:** The Greek tense on the verb indicates that Paul spoke in summary about becoming God’s counselor. Translate with that meaning. For example:

became His counselor (NASB)

is his counselor

**counselor:** This word refers to a person who gives advice. He tells someone else what he thinks is the best decision for him to make. See the examples above.

## Romans 11:35

### Section 11:33–36: Paul praised God

In this section, Paul praised God for his wisdom, knowledge, judgment, thinking, greatness, and power. He ended with acknowledging God’s glory.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

Doxology (NIV)

Words of praise to God

#### 11:35a–b

These words are from Job 41:11a, but it is not an exact quote. However, some English versions put quote marks around Romans 11:35. If you indicate the

location of quotes from the Old Testament with cross-references, you may want to do so here.

**Who has first given to God, that God should repay him?:** This is a rhetorical question. It emphasizes that no one, by giving something to God, has forced God to give him something in return. Translate with that meaning. Here are some ways:

- As a rhetorical question. For example:

Who has ever given him anything, so that he had to pay it back? (GNT)

Has anyone first given a gift to him/God so that he/God must give a gift in return?

- As a statement. For example:

No one has first given a gift to him so that he had to repay him.

No one gave something to him/God, thus requiring him/God to give something in return

#### 11:35a

**“Who has first given to God,**

- Or, “who first gave a gift to him,
- And Scripture also says, “No one has first given something to him

**Who:** This word introduces another quote from Scripture. Some languages use a standard way to introduce Scripture quotes. For example:

As the Holy Book also says, “Who...

**has first given to God:** The Greek word here means “gave (something) beforehand.” Here are other ways to translate this Greek word:

has given to God first

gave a gift to him so that he must repay that giving

#### 11:35b

**that God should repay him?”**

- and he must repay?”
- so that he has to give something to that person in return.”

**that:** This is the Greek word usually translated as “and.” The context implies that a result follows here. Some languages can use “and” and imply that meaning. For example:

and

**God should repay him:** The Greek is more literally “it will be repaid to him.” It implies that God must give something in return for the gift given to him. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

he might be repaid (ESV)

to receive a gift in return (NRSV)

### Romans 11:36

#### Section 11:33–36: Paul praised God

In this section, Paul praised God for his wisdom, knowledge, judgment, thinking, greatness, and power. He ended with acknowledging God’s glory.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

Doxology (NIV)

Words of praise to God

#### 11:36a

**For from Him and through Him and to Him are all things.**

- For everything is from him and remains through him and goes to him.
- For he made/created all things and he takes care of all things and all things are for him.

**For:** This word introduces a reason Morris (page 429). or support for what Paul said in 11:33–35.

**from Him and through Him and to Him are all things:** In the Greek, the phrase all things is the subject of this clause. The phrase from Him and through Him and to Him is what is said about that subject. For example:

Everything is from him and by him and for him (GW)

all things come from him and exist through him and go to him

There is no verb in the Greek. The BSB and many other English versions add the verb *are*. See the above examples.

**from Him:** This phrase indicates that God is the source of all things. He created everything.

**through Him:** This phrase indicates that God is the one who causes everything to continue to exist.

**to Him:** This phrase indicates that God will cause everything to achieve its proper goal, God himself.

#### 11:36b

**To Him be the glory forever! Amen.**

- To him should go glory for all time! Amen.
- May glory belong to him eternally! It is true.

**To Him be the glory:** The Greek words are literally “to him glory.” There is no verb in the Greek. The BSB and many other English versions add the verb *be*. This phrase indicates that Paul declared that God should have glory. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

may there be glory to him

glory should go to him

may glory belong to him

**glory:** The word glory refers literally to a very bright light. In this context it implies power, majesty, and greatness. Here are other ways to translate this word:

splendor

radiance

greatness

See how you translated this word in 1:23 or 9:23.

**Amen:** The word Amen is a Hebrew word that means “even so” or “it is true.” The Greek borrowed the Hebrew word. English borrowed this word as well. It is used to agree with what was said. Paul wrote this expecting his readers to agree as well.

In some languages people are not familiar with this word. If that is true in your language, you may want to:

- Translate the meaning. For example:

It is so.

True!

- Borrow this word and spell it as people in your language would say it. You may then want to explain its meaning in a footnote. Here is an example footnote:

The word “amen” means “even so” or “it is true.”

In this division, Paul gave many rules on how to live as Christians.

Here are other possible headings for this division:

How/The-way to live as Christians

Paul taught about living as Christians

## Romans 12:1

### Section 12:1–21: Paul taught about our body, love, and revenge

In this section, Paul taught that believers should use their bodies in ways that are holy and acceptable to God. Our thinking must change so that it follows the will of God and not the thinking of the people of this world.

Paul also taught that believers should not be more proud of themselves than what is right before God. We all have different gifts from the Holy Spirit, and we should use them.

Believers should love in a genuine way, avoid evil deeds, honor others, be full of eagerness to serve the Lord. They should rejoice, be patient, pray, help others, and show hospitality.

Believers should bless the people who persecute them, and live in sympathy and harmony with other believers. They are not to be proud such that they avoid people with no status in society. They are not to think of themselves as wise.

Believers are not to take revenge, but leave that for God to do something about the evil done to them. They are to do things that are honorable and live at peace with others, if they can. They are to bless their enemies by doing good to them.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

The New Life in Christ (NRSV)

Our bodies, thinking, and deeds must be holy and good

**12:1a****Therefore I urge you, brothers,**

- ¶ Therefore, my brothers and sisters, I urge you
- ¶ So, thinking about all those things, my fellow believers, I advise you,

**Therefore I urge you, brothers:** In many languages the word brothers must be first in the clause. But also in many languages the word Therefore must be first in the clause. Order the words in a way that is natural in your language. For example:

Therefore, brothers, I appeal to you

Brothers, I therefore appeal to you

**Therefore:** This word introduces a result of what Paul said in earlier chapters, not just 11:36. Moo (page 748) connects it to all previous chapters. Morris (page 432) says, “Paul is...telling the Romans what their conduct must be in the light of what God has done.” For example:

considering all those things

**I urge you:** The Greek word that the BSB translates as urge has a wide range of meaning. Many scholars believe it means “exhort” here, rather than “command” or “beg.” For example, Cranfield (page 597), Dunn (page 708), or Jewett (page 726). Here are other ways to translate this clause:

I appeal to you (ESV)

I encourage you (GW)

**brothers:** Here this word refers to all the believers living in Rome, both men and women. The word indicates a close relationship between believers because God has made them his (adopted) children. See how you translated this word in 1:13 or 11:25.

**12:1b****on account of God’s mercy,**

- by God’s compassion
- through God having compassion in various ways on you,

**on account of God’s mercy:** There are several ways to interpret the Greek word that the BSB translates as on account of:

1. It introduces the means or instrument by which Paul urged them. For example:

by the mercies of God (ESV) (ESV, RSV, NABRE, KJV, NASB, NET, REB)

1. It introduces the circumstances in which Paul urged them. For example:

in view of God’s mercy (NIV) (NIV, NJB)

1. It introduces the reason why Paul urged them. For example:

because of God’s great mercy to us (GNT) (GNT, BSB, GW, NCV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1), because the BDAG supports both (1) and (2), and (1) seems more likely here.

**mercy:** The Greek word that the BSB translates as mercy refers to concern for someone with troubles and here implies helping that person. It is one of the ways a father feels toward his children when they are in trouble and need help. (It is not the usual Greek word translated mercy.) Here are other ways to translate this word:

compassion (GW)

sympathy Kittel (page 680).

**12:1c****to offer your bodies as living sacrifices, holy and pleasing to God,**

- to offer your bodies as a sacrifice that is alive, holy to God, and it pleases him.
- that you should give your bodies completely to him. It should be as if it was a sacrifice, but alive, belonging to him alone, which will make God happy.

**to offer your bodies as living sacrifices:** This is a figure of speech. It indicates that believers should allow God to say what they should do with their bodies. So the BSB and other English versions add the word as. In some languages it will be more clear to:

- Explain the figure of speech in your translation. For example:

give your life to serving God as if a sacrifice

- Translate literally and explain the meaning in a footnote. Here is an example footnote:

These words indicate that we are to wholly serve God.

**to offer:** Here the word offer refers to putting something in front of someone, either as a gift or for that person to do something with it. Here are other ways to translate this word:

present (ESV)

give (NLT)

**as living sacrifices, holy and pleasing to God:** The Greek is more literally “a sacrifice, living, holy, pleasing to God.” The words living and holy and the phrase pleasing to God all describe what kind of sacrifice this is. For example:

a sacrifice—alive, holy, and pleasing to God (NET)

a sacrifice that is living and holy and pleases God

**living:** Here this word indicates that this sacrifice still lives and therefore is able to do God’s will. This is unlike usual sacrifices, which are killed at the altar and therefore not able to do anything.

**sacrifices:** As a part of the Jewish religion, people would kill an animal, put it over a fire, then offer it to God. They sometimes burnt the animal whole and sometimes they or the priests ate it, depending on the type of “sacrifice” that they were offering. This was done to honor and worship God. The Greeks and Romans did something similar for their gods.

Here are other ways to translate this word:

offering

gift for God to use

**holy:** Here this word means “set apart for God’s use.” It also implies that it is special, because it belongs to God. See how you translated this word in 11:16.

**pleasing to God:** The Greek word that the BSB translates as pleasing also means “acceptable.” Presenting one’s body has to be the proper kind of sacrifice, so that God accepts it.

## **12:1d which is your spiritual service of worship.**

- That is your worship in your thoughts/heart.
- That is a way for you to worship him in your mind/inner-being.

**which is your spiritual service of worship:** These words further describe presenting your bodies as a sacrifice. It does not separate this presenting from other presentings. For the correct meaning in some languages, translators must avoid the word which. For example:

This is the way to worship him in your mind

That is your worship custom that is appropriateUma Back Translation on TW.

**spiritual:** The Greek word here was used to describe a human being’s ability to think, an action that makes us different from animals. Paul probably used it here to describe worship that is true and proper. Here are other ways to translate this word:

the worship offered by mind and heart (REB)

intelligent (JBP)

**service of worship:** This word refers to religious activities done for the purpose of honoring God.

## **Romans 12:2**

### **Section 12:1–21: Paul taught about our body, love, and revenge**

In this section, Paul taught that believers should use their bodies in ways that are holy and acceptable to God. Our thinking must change so that it follows the will of God and not the thinking of the people of this world.

Paul also taught that believers should not be more proud of themselves than what is right before God. We all have different gifts from the Holy Spirit, and we should use them.

Believers should love in a genuine way, avoid evil deeds, honor others, be full of eagerness to serve the Lord. They should rejoice, be patient, pray, help others, and show hospitality.

Believers should bless the people who persecute them, and live in sympathy and harmony with other believers. They are not to be proud such that they

avoid people with no status in society. They are not to think of themselves as wise.

Believers are not to take revenge, but leave that for God to do something about the evil done to them. They are to do things that are honorable and live at peace with others, if they can. They are to bless their enemies by doing good to them.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

The New Life in Christ (NRSV)

Our bodies, thinking, and deeds must be holy and good

### 12:2a

#### **Do not be conformed to this world,**

- Do not allow others to change your thinking so that it is like the thinking of the people of this age.
- Others must not make your thinking to be like the thinking of the people of this time/world.

**Do not be conformed to this world:** This clause is passive. It indicates that the believer should not allow the things of this world to change his thinking so that it goes against what God would want. The verb is a negated present command. This grammar sometimes indicates to stop doing something. Here that would be “stop being conformed.” But Moo (page 755) says, “Paul’s generally positive attitude toward the Romans’ spirituality (cf. 15:14) makes this doubtful.” Some languages must use an active clause. For example:

Others must not conform you to this world

Do not allow/let this world to conform you to its way of thinking

**conformed:** This word refers generally to making something into the shape someone desires. Here it refers to changing someone’s thinking and behavior to be like another’s thinking and behavior. Here are other ways to translate this word:

model (NJB)

made like

**this world:** The Greek words are literally “this age.” It refers to the situation of life at the time of Paul and at this present time. It implies the thinking and behavior

of people who do not believe, therefore thinking and behavior that does not honor God.

### 12:2b

#### **but be transformed by the renewing of your mind.**

- But/And allow God to make your thinking different through making your mind new,
- God must change your thinking to something else/other than that kind of thinking, and he will do that by making your thinking new.

**but:** Some languages would not naturally see contrast between “do not be conformed to this world” and “be transformed by the renewal of your mind.” For example:

andYongkom Back Translation, by author, unpublished manuscript, Papua New Guinea.

The Otomi and Tagbanwa Back Translations on TW omit this word.

**be transformed:** This clause is passive. It refers to allowing God to make their thinking different than before. It follows God’s will rather than the thinking of the people of this world. Some languages must use an active clause. For example:

allow God to transform

The Greek word refers generally to changing the form or nature of something. Jesus was transformed on the high mountain (Matthew 17:2) from an ordinary looking person to one filled with light. Here transformed refers to changing your outlook, thinking, and way of life to something completely new to you. Here are other ways to translate this word:

change (CEV)

changed within (NCV)

The Greek present tense indicates that this transformation occurs over time; it does not happen all at once.

**by:** Here the word by indicates that the way to be transformed is having your mind renewed. Here is another way to translate that word:

through

**renewing:** This word refers to making something as if new again.

**mind:** This word refers to the faculty of thinking.

### 12:2c

**Then you will be able to test and approve what is**

- so that you will be approving and learning
- So then you are examining what God wants you to do and seeing that it is right/good.

**Then:** This word introduces the purpose of being transformed by the renewal of the mind. Here are other ways to translate this word:

so that (NJB)

that (ESV)

**you will be able to test and approve:** The Greek is more literally “the testing-approving (by) you<sup>(plur)</sup>.” The Greek verb refers to examining something under conditions that show what kind of thing it is and deciding if it is the right or genuine thing. Here the believer discerns what is God’s will and what is not, and so approves and does his will. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

you will approve

you will analyze and seeYongkom Back Translation, by author, unpublished manuscript, Papua New Guinea.

you will come-to-know and agree-withKankanaey Back Translation on TW.

See how you translated the Greek verb (“approve”) in 2:18.

**will be able to:** The Greek tense indicates an ongoing action. The context indicates that Paul expected the readers to test and approve God’s will.

**what is:** Here the word what indicates that this process of testing and approving helps the believer to learn what God’s will is.

### 12:2d

**the good, pleasing, and perfect will of God.**

- God’s will, things/deeds that are good and pleasing and without fault.
- What he wants you to do is good and acceptable and has nothing wrong in it.

**the...will of God:** Here the word will refers to what God wants to see happen or what he wants his people to do. See how you translated this word in 1:10 or 2:18.

**good, pleasing, and perfect:** This clause further describes the things that God wants to happen. This clause does not separate some of the will of God from other parts of the will of God.

**good:** The Greek word refers to what is morally good. But many languages only have one word and it covers both morally good (for example, deeds that are good for others) and good qualities (for example, a good house).

**pleasing:** The Greek word that the BSB translates as pleasing also means “acceptable” (as in 12:1). Here it probably indicates that the person finds God’s will acceptable or pleasing.

**perfect:** This word means “without fault.” There is nothing at all wrong with God’s will.

## Romans 12:3

**Section 12:1–21: Paul taught about our body, love, and revenge**

In this section, Paul taught that believers should use their bodies in ways that are holy and acceptable to God. Our thinking must change so that it follows the will of God and not the thinking of the people of this world.

Paul also taught that believers should not be more proud of themselves than what is right before God. We all have different gifts from the Holy Spirit, and we should use them.

Believers should love in a genuine way, avoid evil deeds, honor others, be full of eagerness to serve the Lord. They should rejoice, be patient, pray, help others, and show hospitality.

Believers should bless the people who persecute them, and live in sympathy and harmony with other believers. They are not to be proud such that they avoid people with no status in society. They are not to think of themselves as wise.

Believers are not to take revenge, but leave that for God to do something about the evil done to them. They are to do things that are honorable and live at peace with others, if they can. They are to bless their enemies by doing good to them.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

The New Life in Christ (NRSV)



Our bodies, thinking, and deeds must be holy and good

### 12:3a

#### For by the grace given me

- ¶ For through the grace/gift that was given to me
- ¶ For example, God gave to me the gift to be his apostle, and so

**For:** Here this word introduces a way to be renewed in the mind (12:2b).

**by the grace given me:** There are two ways to interpret the Greek word that the BSB translates as by:

1. It introduces the means or instrument by which Paul spoke to them. For example:

through the grace that I have been given (NJB)  
(BSB, RSV, NIV, NJB, ESV, NABRE, KJV, NASB, NET, REB)

1. It introduces the reason why Paul urged them. For example:

because of God's gracious gift to me (GNT) (GNT, NLT, GW, NCV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1), because the BDAG supports it.

**the grace given me:** This clause is passive. Some languages must use an active clause. For example:

the grace that God gave to me

**grace:** Here this word refers to God's gift of power to Paul that made him an apostle. Moo (page 760), Morris (page 437), and Cranfield (page 611). See how you translated this word in 1:5.

### 12:3b

#### I say to every one of you:

- I say to each of you that
- I say to everyone in your group:

**every one of you:** This phrase refers to every person in the group of believers at Rome. For example:

everyone among you (ESV)

### 12:3c

#### Do not think of yourself more highly than you ought,

- you<sup>(sing)</sup> should not think you are a better person than it is right for you to think.
- you must think of yourself in the right way and not think you are better than you really are.

**Do not think of yourself more highly than you ought:** This clause indicates that a believer should think about himself in a way that does not go beyond what God says about him. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

not to think of himself more highly than he ought to think (ESV)

never pride yourself on being better than you really are (NJB)

Don't think you are better than you really are (NLT)

### 12:3d

#### but think of yourself with sober judgment,

- But you should think properly/sensibly of yourself,
- Instead, you must think about yourself using good/reasonable thinking,

**with sober judgment:** This phrase refers to thinking in a reasonable or sensible way. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

Use good sense (CEV)

with proper/good thinking

### 12:3e

#### according to the measure of faith God has given you.

- to each corresponding to the amount of faith that God has given to you.
- in accordance with the amount of faith that God gave to each of you.

**according to the measure of faith God has given you:** This phrase indicates that a believer should think of himself according to the amount of faith that God has given to him. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

in accordance with the measure of faith God has given you (NIV)

based on how much faith God has given to each of you

## Romans 12:4

### Section 12:1–21: Paul taught about our body, love, and revenge

In this section, Paul taught that believers should use their bodies in ways that are holy and acceptable to God. Our thinking must change so that it follows the will of God and not the thinking of the people of this world.

Paul also taught that believers should not be more proud of themselves than what is right before God. We all have different gifts from the Holy Spirit, and we should use them.

Believers should love in a genuine way, avoid evil deeds, honor others, be full of eagerness to serve the Lord. They should rejoice, be patient, pray, help others, and show hospitality.

Believers should bless the people who persecute them, and live in sympathy and harmony with other believers. They are not to be proud such that they avoid people with no status in society. They are not to think of themselves as wise.

Believers are not to take revenge, but leave that for God to do something about the evil done to them. They are to do things that are honorable and live at peace with others, if they can. They are to bless their enemies by doing good to them.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

The New Life in Christ (NRSV)

Our bodies, thinking, and deeds must be holy and good

#### 12:4a

#### Just as each of us has one body with many members,

- For, just as we<sup>(incl)</sup> each have one body but many parts,
- For each of us has one body, and it has many parts,

**Just as:** Here these words introduce an explanation of the individual measures of faith (12:3e). Together with the word “so” in 12:5a, they indicate that 12:5 is being compared to 12:4. Another way to show a comparison in English is to just use a single phrase between the two verses. For example:

<sup>4</sup>Each of us has one body with many members, and not all members have the same function. <sup>5</sup>In the same way, we who are many are one body and each member belongs to another in Christ. (GNT)

**each of us has one body with many members:** Paul used the phrase each of us to refer to believers in general. We all have the same kind of body. In some languages a literal translation would indicate or imply that we all share a single body in some way. If that is true in your language, indicate that Paul spoke in general of the human body. For example:

in our bodies we each have many members/parts

**members:** Here this word refers to the various parts of the body, like the head and arms and so forth.

#### 12:4b

#### and not all members have the same function,

- and the parts do not all do the same thing,
- and each part does something different. Similarly,

**not all members have the same function:** Here the word function refers to what each part of the body does. Each part does something different. The eyes see, the hand holds, and the legs walk and kick. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

the members/parts do not all have the same work

each part has a different duty/purpose

## Romans 12:5

### Section 12:1–21: Paul taught about our body, love, and revenge

In this section, Paul taught that believers should use their bodies in ways that are holy and acceptable to God. Our thinking must change so that it follows the will of God and not the thinking of the people of this world.

Paul also taught that believers should not be more proud of themselves than what is right before God. We all have different gifts from the Holy Spirit, and we should use them.

Believers should love in a genuine way, avoid evil deeds, honor others, be full of eagerness to serve the Lord. They should rejoice, be patient, pray, help others, and show hospitality.

Believers should bless the people who persecute them, and live in sympathy and harmony with other

believers. They are not to be proud such that they avoid people with no status in society. They are not to think of themselves as wise.

Believers are not to take revenge, but leave that for God to do something about the evil done to them. They are to do things that are honorable and live at peace with others, if they can. They are to bless their enemies by doing good to them.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

The New Life in Christ (NRSV)

Our bodies, thinking, and deeds must be holy and good

#### **12:5a** **so in Christ we who are many are one body,**

- we<sup>(incl)</sup> many believers are one body in Christ,
- even though we believers are many, we are one group like one body.

#### **12:5a–b**

**so:** Here this word introduces the comparison. See also the note on “Just as” in 12:4a.

**in Christ we who are many are one body, and each member belongs to one another:** Here the words body and member are metaphors. All believers are one group, the church of Christ. We have a united purpose and goal. We belong to the group and we also belong to each other in the group.

In some languages to say we...are one body will have the wrong meaning. If that is true in your language, you may want to:

- Add the word “like.” For example:

we, though many, are like one body in Christ, and individually like members one of another

- Explain the metaphor in your translation. For example:

we, though many, are one group in Christ, and individually belong to one another like a body and its members/parts

- Translate literally and explain the metaphor in a footnote. Here is an example footnote:

This talk of a body and its members/parts indicates that believers all belong to one group and individually belong to one another.

#### **12:5b** **and each member belongs to one another.**

- and we, as parts of the body, belong to each other.
- And each of us belong to each other.

**each member belongs to one another:** The Greek is more literally “each one members of one another.” It indicates that each believer belongs to the body and to each other.

### **Romans 12:6**

#### **Section 12:1–21: Paul taught about our body, love, and revenge**

In this section, Paul taught that believers should use their bodies in ways that are holy and acceptable to God. Our thinking must change so that it follows the will of God and not the thinking of the people of this world.

Paul also taught that believers should not be more proud of themselves than what is right before God. We all have different gifts from the Holy Spirit, and we should use them.

Believers should love in a genuine way, avoid evil deeds, honor others, be full of eagerness to serve the Lord. They should rejoice, be patient, pray, help others, and show hospitality.

Believers should bless the people who persecute them, and live in sympathy and harmony with other believers. They are not to be proud such that they avoid people with no status in society. They are not to think of themselves as wise.

Believers are not to take revenge, but leave that for God to do something about the evil done to them. They are to do things that are honorable and live at peace with others, if they can. They are to bless their enemies by doing good to them.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

The New Life in Christ (NRSV)

Our bodies, thinking, and deeds must be holy and good

#### **12:6a–b** **We have different gifts according to the grace given us. If one’s gift is prophecy, let him use it in propor-**

**tion to his faith:** The BSB adds the words let him use it. Many scholars and English versions agree that the Greek implies a command to use the gifts properly. For example, the ESV adds the words of a command in the last part:

Having gifts that differ according to the grace given to us, let us use them (ESV)

#### 12:6a

**We have different gifts according to the grace given us.**

- We each have different gifts according to the grace given to each of us.
- God gave to each of us different gifts according to his kindness to us.

**We have different gifts:** This clause indicates that all believers do not have the same gift. Paul listed seven of the gifts in 12:6b–8. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

Having gifts that differ (ESV)

the gifts that we have differ (NJB)

**gifts:** This word refers to something that is given without cost to the person receiving it. Paul listed seven of the gifts in 12:6b–8. See how you translated this word in 1:11 or 11:29.

**the grace given us:** This clause is passive. Some languages must use an active clause. For example:

the grace that God gave to us

**grace:** This word refers to being kind to people without requiring anything in return. This kindness is not given because they have done anything to deserve it. See how you translated this word in 3:24 or 11:6.

#### 12:6b–8

Each gift in the list has a phrase that begins with the Greek word that means “in.” Each phrase describes how each gift is to be used. Many languages must add a verb each time for a natural translation. See the note on 12:6a–b above or the individual notes below in 12:6b–8.

#### 12:6b

**If one’s gift is prophecy, let him use it in proportion to his faith;**

- If prophecy, each of us must prophesy in accordance with the amount of faith we have.

- If you<sup>(sing)</sup> have the gift of messages of revelation, then you must speak those messages in the amount that your faith says is right.

**prophecy:** The word prophecy refers to a message that God gives to someone. The message may include a vision, as in Ezekiel 1 and Daniel 8. A prophecy may reveal something about past events, current events, or future events. The prophet speaks the prophecy to the people or writes it down for their use.

Some languages do not have a word for prophecy. If that is true in your language, you may want to:

- Use a descriptive phrase. For example:

direct message from God

God’s new message

a message that God has revealed

- Use the major language word. If people are not familiar with this word, you may want to explain it in a footnote. Here is an example footnote:

The word “prophecy” refers to a message that God gives to someone. The message may include a vision. A prophecy may reveal something about past events, current events, or future events.

**let him use it:** The BSB adds these words. See the note at 12:6a–b about that.

These gifts are given to each believer. They are not shared like someone might share a tool. Some languages must continue referring to the individual for the correct meaning, as the BSB does. Here is another way to translate this:

let each of us use them

**in proportion to his faith:** Here the word his refers to each of us who have the gift of prophecy. Each of us with the gift of prophecy must use it according to how much faith we have. One cannot speak true prophecies when he does not have the faith for it. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

measured to the amount of faith each of us have

sized to our faith

**proportion:** This word refers to the relative sizes or amounts of different sorts of things. In this context, in relation to a small amount of faith, the amount of prophecy would be small, but in relation to a large amount of faith, the amount of prophecy would also be large. See the examples above.

## Romans 12:7

### Section 12:1–21: Paul taught about our body, love, and revenge

In this section, Paul taught that believers should use their bodies in ways that are holy and acceptable to God. Our thinking must change so that it follows the will of God and not the thinking of the people of this world.

Paul also taught that believers should not be more proud of themselves than what is right before God. We all have different gifts from the Holy Spirit, and we should use them.

Believers should love in a genuine way, avoid evil deeds, honor others, be full of eagerness to serve the Lord. They should rejoice, be patient, pray, help others, and show hospitality.

Believers should bless the people who persecute them, and live in sympathy and harmony with other believers. They are not to be proud such that they avoid people with no status in society. They are not to think of themselves as wise.

Believers are not to take revenge, but leave that for God to do something about the evil done to them. They are to do things that are honorable and live at peace with others, if they can. They are to bless their enemies by doing good to them.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

The New Life in Christ (NRSV)

Our bodies, thinking, and deeds must be holy and good

### 12:7a

#### if it is serving, let him serve;

- Or if your<sup>(sing)</sup> gift is serving, then serve.
- Or if you have the gift of being a servant to others, then you should serve them.

**if:** The Greek word here includes the meaning of “or.” A believer may not have the gift of prophecy, but he or she may have the gift of service. For example:

or if

**serving:** The Greek word here originally focused on giving food to others at meals. It then included helping others in similar ways. Eventually the word became defined by the office of “deacon,” but this definition probably does not apply here. Here are other ways to translate this word:

serving others (NLT)

be a servant to your companions Tagbanwa Back Translation on TW.

**let him serve:** Here this phrase indicates that the believer with the gift of serving should actually serve others. They should do as they are gifted to do. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

to serve

then serve (NIV11)

he/she must serve

serve properly Kankanaey Back Translation on TW.

### 12:7b

#### if it is teaching, let him teach;

- Or if you are the one teaching, then teach.
- Or if you have the gift of being a teacher of the gospel, then you should teach it.

**if it is teaching:** 12:7b begins with the same Greek word that means “or if” as in 12:7a. For example:

or if you are the one teaching

The BSB indicates a connection with its semi-colon at the end of 12:7a.

**teaching:** Here this word implies teaching related to religion, which includes the Old Testament, the gospel of Jesus, faith, Christian living, and so forth. In some languages a literal translation would only refer to teaching as a school teacher, not a religious teacher. If that is true in your language, explain the correct meaning in your translation. For example:

teaches religion

teaches about Jesus

But the context may be enough in imply teaching religion.

**let him teach:** Here this phrase indicates that the believer with the gift of teaching should actually teach others. They should do as they are gifted to do. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

to teach

then teach (NIV11)

he/she must teach

teach properly

## Romans 12:8

### Section 12:1–21: Paul taught about our body, love, and revenge

In this section, Paul taught that believers should use their bodies in ways that are holy and acceptable to God. Our thinking must change so that it follows the will of God and not the thinking of the people of this world.

Paul also taught that believers should not be more proud of themselves than what is right before God. We all have different gifts from the Holy Spirit, and we should use them.

Believers should love in a genuine way, avoid evil deeds, honor others, be full of eagerness to serve the Lord. They should rejoice, be patient, pray, help others, and show hospitality.

Believers should bless the people who persecute them, and live in sympathy and harmony with other believers. They are not to be proud such that they avoid people with no status in society. They are not to think of themselves as wise.

Believers are not to take revenge, but leave that for God to do something about the evil done to them. They are to do things that are honorable and live at peace with others, if they can. They are to bless their enemies by doing good to them.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

The New Life in Christ (NRSV)

Our bodies, thinking, and deeds must be holy and good

### 12:8a if it is encouraging, let him encourage;

- Or if you<sup>(sing)</sup> are the one encouraging others, then encourage them.
- Or if you have the gift of encouragement, then you should encourage others.

The Greek here has the word that means “or if,” as in 12:7a and 12:7b. For example:

or if

**encouraging:** There are two ways to interpret the Greek word that the BSB translates as encouraging:

1. It means “encourage” or “comfort” here. (BSB, NIV11, GNT, NJB, NLT, GW, CEV, NCV)
2. It means “urge strongly” here. For example:

he who exhorts (RSV) (RSV, NASB, KJV, ESV, NABRE, NET)

The Greek word possibly implies both meanings here. But many languages will not have a word that has both meanings and will need to decide which meaning to translate. If that is true in your language, it is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). But if the major language version follows interpretation (2), you may want to follow that.

### 12:8b if it is giving, let him give generously;

- Or if you<sup>(sing)</sup> are the one sharing your things with others, then share with them much.
- Or if you have the gift of giving some of your things to others, then you should give well.

The Greek word that can mean “or if” (as in 12:7a–b) does not occur here, but it is clearly implied. In some languages it is more natural to continue with the same introduction as before. For example:

Or if you are/have

**giving:** The Greek word refers to sharing a part of what one has with others, to help with their needs. Here are other ways to translate this word:

shares (GNT)

give (NJB)

**give generously:** This word refers to someone giving freely because he wants to help. Here are other ways to translate this word:

without restraint

in full measure

happily/greatly/much

### 12:8c

**if it is leading, let him lead with diligence;**

- Or if you<sup>(sing)</sup> are the one leading, then lead without ceasing.
- Or if you have the gift of leading others, then do not ignore/forsake your duties as leader.

The Greek word that can mean “or if” (as in 12:7a–b) does not occur here, but it is clearly implied. In some languages it is more natural to continue with the same introduction as before. For example:

Or if you are/have

**leading:** There are several ways to interpret the Greek word that the BSB translates as leading:

1. It means lead here. Paul referred to those with the gift of leadership. (BSB, NIV, NJB, ESV, NASB, NRSV, KJV, NABRE, NLT, GW, CEV, NET, REB, NCV)
2. It means have authority here. For example:

has authority (GNT) (GNT)

1. It means give help here. For example:

gives aid (RSV) (RSV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1), because many English versions support it. Jewett (page 753) says, “the more general sense of ‘the one giving care’ also seems unlikely because it would then become completely redundant with regard to the gifts of serving and exhorting.” The GNT’s “has authority” is unclear if leadership is included in the meaning, so that interpretation should be avoided.

**with diligence:** There are several ways to interpret the Greek word that the BSB translates as diligence:

1. It means leading earnestly, without stopping here. A leader should not become lazy and ignore his duties. For example:

diligently (NIV) (BSB, NIV, GNT, NASB, KJV, NRSV, NABRE, NLT, NET, NCV)

1. It means leading with enthusiasm here. For example:

enthusiastically (GW) (RSV, ESV, GW, REB)

The Greek word can mean either (1) or (2). It is hard to choose which sense Paul meant here. Some languages may have a word that allows both meanings, but many languages must choose one or the other. If that is true in your language, it is recommended that you follow interpretation (1), because many English versions support it. But if the major language version follows interpretation (2), you may want to follow that.

### 12:8d

**if it is showing mercy, let him do it cheerfully.**

- Or if you<sup>(sing)</sup> are the one being merciful to others, then be happy when you are being merciful.
- Or if you have the gift of helping others when they are in need/trouble, then happily help them.

**showing mercy:** The scholars generally agree that the meaning here is to help people who are sick, hurt, poor, unable to work, or old. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

compassionate (NRSV)

helping people in need (GW)

help others in distress (REB)

helping the unfortunate  
Kankanaey Back Translation on TW.

**do it cheerfully:** This word refers to being happy. A believer should be happy when he or she is helping others.

## Romans 12:9

**Section 12:1–21: Paul taught about our body, love, and revenge**

In this section, Paul taught that believers should use their bodies in ways that are holy and acceptable to

God. Our thinking must change so that it follows the will of God and not the thinking of the people of this world.

Paul also taught that believers should not be more proud of themselves than what is right before God. We all have different gifts from the Holy Spirit, and we should use them.

Believers should love in a genuine way, avoid evil deeds, honor others, be full of eagerness to serve the Lord. They should rejoice, be patient, pray, help others, and show hospitality.

Believers should bless the people who persecute them, and live in sympathy and harmony with other believers. They are not to be proud such that they avoid people with no status in society. They are not to think of themselves as wise.

Believers are not to take revenge, but leave that for God to do something about the evil done to them. They are to do things that are honorable and live at peace with others, if they can. They are to bless their enemies by doing good to them.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

The New Life in Christ (NRSV)

Our bodies, thinking, and deeds must be holy and good

### 12:9a–19a

In the Greek, this list of commands does not have connecting words between each command. Consider what is most natural in your language.

### 12:9a

#### Love must be sincere.

- ¶ Your<sup>(plur)</sup> love must be sincere/real.
- ¶ Truly love other people. Do not only pretend to love others.

**Love:** The word Love refers to a strong affection and concern for a person. In some languages an idiom such as “give/put heart/liver” is used for the meaning of Love.

**sincere:** This Greek word refers to not pretending to be other than you really are. Here are other ways to translate this word:

genuine (ESV)

real (NCV)

Don't just pretend to love others (NLT)

### 12:9b

#### Detest what is evil;

- Hate evil things.
- You<sup>(plur)</sup> should/must detest/despise/loathe doing anything that is evil,

**Detest:** This word means “to dislike very much,” “hate strongly.” For example:

Hate (NIV)

**what is evil:** The Greek is more literally “the evil.” Here it refers to anything that is evil. The word what is not a question word here. For example:

everything that is evil (CEV)

**evil:** The Greek word refers to things that are very bad or worthless, including deeds and thoughts. The meaning here does not focus on evil people, but rather evil deeds and thoughts.

### 12:9c

#### cling to what is good.

- Cling to good things/deeds.
- and/but you should/must think much on anything that is good and be doing it.

**cling to what is good:** Here the word cling means “hold tightly.” For example:

hold fast to what is good (ESV)

The phrase cling to is a figure of speech. It refers to being focused on what is good and doing it. Some languages cannot use this phrase for that meaning. If that is true in your language, you may want to:

- Explain the meaning in your translation and add “like.” For example:

concentrate on what is good and do it like clinging to something

be thinking on the things that are good and be doing them like you are clinging to them

- Translate the meaning without the figure of speech. For example:

concentrate on what is good and do it



be thinking on the things that are good and be doing them

## Romans 12:10

### Section 12:1–21: Paul taught about our body, love, and revenge

In this section, Paul taught that believers should use their bodies in ways that are holy and acceptable to God. Our thinking must change so that it follows the will of God and not the thinking of the people of this world.

Paul also taught that believers should not be more proud of themselves than what is right before God. We all have different gifts from the Holy Spirit, and we should use them.

Believers should love in a genuine way, avoid evil deeds, honor others, be full of eagerness to serve the Lord. They should rejoice, be patient, pray, help others, and show hospitality.

Believers should bless the people who persecute them, and live in sympathy and harmony with other believers. They are not to be proud such that they avoid people with no status in society. They are not to think of themselves as wise.

Believers are not to take revenge, but leave that for God to do something about the evil done to them. They are to do things that are honorable and live at peace with others, if they can. They are to bless their enemies by doing good to them.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

The New Life in Christ (NRSV)

Our bodies, thinking, and deeds must be holy and good

### 12:10a

#### Be devoted to one another in brotherly love.

- Family-love<sup>(plur)</sup> one another with true friendship.
- Love one another as brothers/sisters/siblings as dear friends.

**Be devoted to one another:** The Greek word that the BSB translates as Be devoted is similar to but different than the Greek word translated as “love” in 12:9a. This Greek word refers to affection and concern as among people in your own family. As brothers and sisters in faith in Jesus, believers should have this kind of family love for each other.

Some languages have a word with the above meaning. For example:

Family-love one another

Many languages do not have a separate word as the Greek does. Some languages will translate this word with a phrase. For example:

Love one another as brothers/sisters/siblings

Many English versions use the word “love” here and explain the kind of love in the next phrase. See next note.

**in brotherly love:** The Greek refers to affection for someone who is a good friend, often implying affection as among brothers and sisters. Here the word brotherly implies sisters as well.

### 12:10b

#### Outdo yourselves in honoring one another.

- Honor each other more than yourselves.
- Give each other more honor than you want for yourselves. (NCV)

**(NIV:) Honor one another above yourselves:** The Greek is more literally “About the honoring of one another, going-first-and-leading-the-way.” The BDAG says this last word in the Greek has as its first sense “to go first and lead the way,” but lists this verse as a third sense, “consider better, esteem more highly,” calling the passage difficult. It is difficult because there is no other clear example of this last meaning in the NT or any Greek literature of that time. There are several ways to interpret the Greek word that means “going-first-and-leading-the-way” here. Here are the main ones:

1. It means more than here. For example:

honor others more than you do yourself (CEV)  
(NIV, NJB, CEV, REB, NCV)

1. It means strive to do more than here. For example:

outdo one another in showing honor (RSV) (BSB, RSV, ESV)

1. It means allowing others to go first here. For example:

give preference to one another in honor (NASB)  
(NASB, KJV)

1. It means be eager here. For example:

be eager to show respect for one another (GNT)  
(GNT, NET)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1), because the BDAG supports it. However, this author finds the first sense in the BDAG, “to go first and lead the way,” to be best. But few English versions follow that interpretation. For example, the Christian Standard Bible says, “Take the lead in honoring one another,” and the Darby says, “as to honour, each taking the lead in paying it to the other.” Jewett (page 761) translates this word as “taking the lead in,” in other words, not waiting for others to honor someone. He says that interpretations (1), (2), and (3) are not supported in Greek literature. Witherington (page 293) translates 12:10b as, “go first and lead the way in showing honor to one another.” This author can also find no scholar who supports interpretation (4).

## Romans 12:11

### Section 12:1–21: Paul taught about our body, love, and revenge

In this section, Paul taught that believers should use their bodies in ways that are holy and acceptable to God. Our thinking must change so that it follows the will of God and not the thinking of the people of this world.

Paul also taught that believers should not be more proud of themselves than what is right before God. We all have different gifts from the Holy Spirit, and we should use them.

Believers should love in a genuine way, avoid evil deeds, honor others, be full of eagerness to serve the Lord. They should rejoice, be patient, pray, help others, and show hospitality.

Believers should bless the people who persecute them, and live in sympathy and harmony with other believers. They are not to be proud such that they avoid people with no status in society. They are not to think of themselves as wise.

Believers are not to take revenge, but leave that for God to do something about the evil done to them. They are to do things that are honorable and live at peace with others, if they can. They are to bless their enemies by doing good to them.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

The New Life in Christ (NRSV)

Our bodies, thinking, and deeds must be holy and good

### 12:11a

#### Do not let your zeal subside;

- Continue serving<sup>(plur)</sup> the Lord without ceasing. Don't become lazy in your serving.
- Don't ignore/forsake your duties for/to the Lord, and do not become lazy in them.

**(NASB:) not lagging behind in diligence:** The Greek is more literally “About the diligence/zeal, not lazy.” It indicates that we should not become lazy in regard to the diligent serving we do for God. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

Never be lacking in zeal (NIV)

About your enthusiasm for the Lord, do not let it become laziness

**(NASB:) diligence:** There are several ways to interpret the Greek word that the NASB translates as diligence:

1. It means doing something earnestly, without stopping here. It has the same meaning as in 12:8 (NIV11: “diligently”). For example:

diligence (NASB) (GNT, NASB, NLT, NCV) The RSV, ESV and REB also translate the Greek here consistently with the same word in 12:8, but choose “zeal,” interpretation (2).

1. It means zeal here, “enthusiastic devotion to something.” Believers should be eager to do what the Lord wants them to do. For example:

zeal (RSV) (BSB, RSV, NIV, ESV, NABRE, NET, REB)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1), because 12:11b has the Greek word that clearly means “having zeal,” so it would not be fitting to have the meaning of “zeal” again here.

Some languages must say in what one is diligent. For example:

be diligent in what you do for him

### 12:11b

#### keep your spiritual fervor,

- Be energetic in your spirit.

- Be excited/enthusiastic in your insides/heart/liver.

**keep your spiritual fervor:** There are two ways to interpret the Greek word that the BSB translates as spiritual:

1. It refers to the spirit of a person here. (BSB, NIV, GNT, NJB, NASB, KJV, NRSV, ESV, NABRE, GW, NET, NCV)
2. It refers to the Holy Spirit here. The clause indicates that the Holy Spirit gives us fervor. For example:

be aglow with the Spirit (RSV) (RSV, CEV, REB)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1), because the other commands in these verses are human-centered. Fitzmyer (page 654).

The Greek is more literally “boiling.” Here it indicates that our spirits should be “stirred up” or excited. For example:

be enthusiastic (NET)

**spiritual fervor:** Here this word spiritual refers to the inner being of a person. For example:

Your insides Nalik Back Translation, draft, Papua New Guinea.

heart/liver

### 12:11c serving the Lord.

- Do the work of the Lord.
- Do the things that the Lord God has told you to do.

**serving:** Here this word refers to working for someone because you were told to do it. It refers to doing whatever work that God has given to you, including worshiping, praying, giving tithes, and helping others. This word refers to every believer, not just those who have a job in the church such as pastor or elder. Here are other ways to translate this word:

be a servant of

do the things commanded of us to do

See how you translated this word in 1:9 or 9:12.

**the Lord:** The word Lord refers to someone who has authority over people. Here this phrase refers to Jesus

or God. In some languages it is more natural to indicate who this Lord is. For example:

the Lord Jesus/God

See how you translated the word Lord in 4:8 or 11:34.

## Romans 12:12

### Section 12:1–21: Paul taught about our body, love, and revenge

In this section, Paul taught that believers should use their bodies in ways that are holy and acceptable to God. Our thinking must change so that it follows the will of God and not the thinking of the people of this world.

Paul also taught that believers should not be more proud of themselves than what is right before God. We all have different gifts from the Holy Spirit, and we should use them.

Believers should love in a genuine way, avoid evil deeds, honor others, be full of eagerness to serve the Lord. They should rejoice, be patient, pray, help others, and show hospitality.

Believers should bless the people who persecute them, and live in sympathy and harmony with other believers. They are not to be proud such that they avoid people with no status in society. They are not to think of themselves as wise.

Believers are not to take revenge, but leave that for God to do something about the evil done to them. They are to do things that are honorable and live at peace with others, if they can. They are to bless their enemies by doing good to them.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

The New Life in Christ (NRSV)

Our bodies, thinking, and deeds must be holy and good

### 12:12a Be joyful in hope,

- Be happy in the hope that you<sup>(plur)</sup> have.
- Be joyful in the fact that you are confidently waiting for God to fulfill his promises to you.

**Be joyful in hope:** There are several ways to interpret the Greek grammar that the BSB translates as in:

1. It indicates what we are to feel joy about, as in the BSB. (BSB, RSV, NIV, NJB, ESV, NABRE, NASB, KJV, NLT, GW, NET)
2. It indicates what makes our rejoicing possible. Hope helps us to rejoice. For example:

Let your hope keep you joyful (GNT) (GNT, CEV, REB)

1. It indicates what the source of our rejoicing is. For example:

Be joyful because you have hope (NCV) (NCV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1), because many English versions and the BDAG support it. Jewett, Longenecker, Schreiner, and Nicoll support interpretation (1). Morris supports interpretation (2), and Alford supports interpretation (3). But no scholar this author has explains why he chooses the interpretation he does.

**Be joyful:** The Greek word here refers to being happy and feeling well. BDAG (sense (1)) and L&N (sense (a)).

**hope:** The word hope means “the looking forward to something happening with some reason for confidence that it will indeed happen.” See BDAG (page 319–320). Here this hope is probably the general hope of a believer, that God will fulfill his promises in Scriptures to him. See how you translated this word in 5:4 or 8:24.

In some languages hope must include the thing hoped in. For interpretations (2) and (3) above, something must be added for these languages. For example:

hope in God

hope in the fulfillment of God’s promises

#### 12:12b

##### patient in affliction,

- Persevere during troubles/hardship.
- When difficulty/suffering comes, endure it.

**patient:** The Greek word here refers to continuing to believe (or hope) or to do as planned in the midst of opposition or difficulty. Here are other ways to translate this Greek word:

persevere (NJB)

endure (NABRE)

**in:** Here this word means “during” or “while experiencing.”

**affliction:** The Greek word here refers to any kind of trouble, oppression, suffering, or persecution.

trouble

hardship (NJB)

difficulty

See how you translated this word in 2:9 or 8:35 (BSB: “distress”).

#### 12:12c

##### persistent in prayer.

- Persist in praying.
- Be praying to God often.

**persistent:** The Greek word refers to making the effort to continue doing something. Here are other ways to translate this Greek word:

persevere (NABRE)

keep praying regularly (NJB)

**in prayer:** Here the word in indicates that praying is what the believer is supposed to constantly do.

**prayer:** This word refers to talking to God, praising him, thanking him, and asking him to do something. See how you translated this word in 1:10.

## Romans 12:13

### Section 12:1–21: Paul taught about our body, love, and revenge

In this section, Paul taught that believers should use their bodies in ways that are holy and acceptable to God. Our thinking must change so that it follows the will of God and not the thinking of the people of this world.

Paul also taught that believers should not be more proud of themselves than what is right before God. We all have different gifts from the Holy Spirit, and we should use them.

Believers should love in a genuine way, avoid evil deeds, honor others, be full of eagerness to serve the Lord. They should rejoice, be patient, pray, help others, and show hospitality.

Believers should bless the people who persecute them, and live in sympathy and harmony with other believers. They are not to be proud such that they avoid people with no status in society. They are not to think of themselves as wise.

Believers are not to take revenge, but leave that for God to do something about the evil done to them. They are to do things that are honorable and live at peace with others, if they can. They are to bless their enemies by doing good to them.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

The New Life in Christ (NRSV)

Our bodies, thinking, and deeds must be holy and good

### 12:13a

#### Share with the saints who are in need.

- Share<sup>(plur)</sup> your belongings with God's holy people who have needs.
- Help people whom God has made holy who lack things for daily living.

**Share with:** The Greek word that the BSB translates as Share is more literally "share in." Here it refers to sharing one's possessions (including money) with poor believers. Here are other ways to translate this Greek word:

Contribute to (ESV)

Share your belongings with (GNT)

**the saints:** The Greek word that the BSB translates as saints is literally "holy (ones)." It can mean "holy people," "people dedicated/consecrated to God," or "people whom God has made holy." Here it probably implies all of these meanings. In the New Testament, this word refers to all Christians, not to any special group of Christians. Here are other ways to translate this word:

God's holy people

his very own people (NLT96)

those whom God has made holy

Translate this word in a way that will refer to all Christians, and that people will use to refer to themselves as Christians. See how you translated this word in 1:7 or 8:27.

**who are in need:** Here this word refers to lacking something that a person requires. For example, someone may lack food or clothing.

### 12:13b

#### Practice hospitality.

- Pursue opportunities to invite strangers to your home.
- Seek visitors/travelers to welcome into your homes.

**Practice hospitality:** Here the word Practice refers to looking for opportunities to show hospitality to others and then show hospitality when there is opportunity. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

pursue hospitality (NET)

look for opportunities to be hospitable (NJB)

**hospitality:** The Greek word here means "to love a stranger." It usually refers to welcoming a stranger or someone arriving from another town and giving them food and a place to stay for the night or more than one night. Here are other ways to translate this Greek word:

invite to your houses whoever has no certain place to stay Tagbanwa Back Translation on TW.

be befriending whomever comes

## Romans 12:14

### Section 12:1-21: Paul taught about our body, love, and revenge

In this section, Paul taught that believers should use their bodies in ways that are holy and acceptable to God. Our thinking must change so that it follows the will of God and not the thinking of the people of this world.

Paul also taught that believers should not be more proud of themselves than what is right before God. We all have different gifts from the Holy Spirit, and we should use them.

Believers should love in a genuine way, avoid evil deeds, honor others, be full of eagerness to serve the Lord. They should rejoice, be patient, pray, help others, and show hospitality.

Believers should bless the people who persecute them, and live in sympathy and harmony with other believers. They are not to be proud such that they avoid people with no status in society. They are not to think of themselves as wise.

Believers are not to take revenge, but leave that for God to do something about the evil done to them. They are to do things that are honorable and live at peace with others, if they can. They are to bless their enemies by doing good to them.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

The New Life in Christ (NRSV)

Our bodies, thinking, and deeds must be holy and good

#### 12:14a

##### **Bless those who persecute you.**

- ¶ Bless the people who make you<sup>(plur)</sup> suffer because you believe.
- ¶ When people cause you to suffer, ask God to do something good to them.

**Bless:** This word refers to asking God to do good things to or for someone. Here are other ways to translate this word:

pray that God will be gracious/merciful to them-  
Tagbanwa Back Translation on TW.

you must give goodness [bless] themNalik Back  
Translation, draft, Papua New Guinea.

**persecute:** Here this word refers to people causing trouble or suffering for a believer because he or she follows Jesus. Here are other ways to translate this word:

harm us because we believe in Jesus

give us pain because of our faith

cause us who believe to suffer

#### 12:14b

##### **Bless and do not curse.**

- Bless them! Do not curse them.
- Yes/Indeed, ask God to do something good to them. Do not ask God to do something bad to them.

**Bless:** This word is repeated from 12:14a to emphasize its meaning. The word “them” is implied after this word. For example:

bless them

In some languages repeating a word for emphasis is not natural or has the wrong meaning. If that is true in your language, indicate the emphasis in another way, if possible. For example:

Bless those who persecute you. Indeed, do that!  
Do not curse them.

Ask for good/blessing from God to go to everyone who persecutes you. Yes! Don't curse them.

**curse:** This word refers to asking God to do something bad to someone. It does not refer to using swear words. Here are other ways to translate this word:

pray that God will do bad things to them

say a badness to themNalik Back Translation,  
draft, Papua New Guinea.

### Romans 12:15

#### **Section 12:1–21: Paul taught about our body, love, and revenge**

In this section, Paul taught that believers should use their bodies in ways that are holy and acceptable to God. Our thinking must change so that it follows the will of God and not the thinking of the people of this world.

Paul also taught that believers should not be more proud of themselves than what is right before God. We all have different gifts from the Holy Spirit, and we should use them.

Believers should love in a genuine way, avoid evil deeds, honor others, be full of eagerness to serve the Lord. They should rejoice, be patient, pray, help others, and show hospitality.

Believers should bless the people who persecute them, and live in sympathy and harmony with other believers. They are not to be proud such that they avoid people with no status in society. They are not to think of themselves as wise.

Believers are not to take revenge, but leave that for God to do something about the evil done to them.

They are to do things that are honorable and live at peace with others, if they can. They are to bless their enemies by doing good to them.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

The New Life in Christ (NRSV)

Our bodies, thinking, and deeds must be holy and good

#### 12:15a

##### **Rejoice with those who rejoice;**

- When people rejoice, you<sup>(plur)</sup> must rejoice together with them.
- When others are happy, you should be happy along with them.

**Rejoice with those who rejoice:** When a fellow believer is happy about something, we should be happy for him.

#### 12:15b

##### **weep with those who weep.**

- And when they cry, you must cry together with them.
- When others are sad and crying, you should be sad and cry along with them.

**weep with those who weep:** When a fellow believer is crying about something because he is sad, we should cry with or for him.

**weep:** This word refers to crying. It implies that one cries because one is sad. Here are other ways to translate this word:

cry

have tears because of sadness

## **Romans 12:16**

### **Section 12:1–21: Paul taught about our body, love, and revenge**

In this section, Paul taught that believers should use their bodies in ways that are holy and acceptable to God. Our thinking must change so that it follows the will of God and not the thinking of the people of this world.

Paul also taught that believers should not be more proud of themselves than what is right before God. We all have different gifts from the Holy Spirit, and we should use them.

Believers should love in a genuine way, avoid evil deeds, honor others, be full of eagerness to serve the Lord. They should rejoice, be patient, pray, help others, and show hospitality.

Believers should bless the people who persecute them, and live in sympathy and harmony with other believers. They are not to be proud such that they avoid people with no status in society. They are not to think of themselves as wise.

Believers are not to take revenge, but leave that for God to do something about the evil done to them. They are to do things that are honorable and live at peace with others, if they can. They are to bless their enemies by doing good to them.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

The New Life in Christ (NRSV)

Our bodies, thinking, and deeds must be holy and good

#### 12:16a

##### **Live in harmony with one another.**

- Live<sup>(plur)</sup> in general agreement with one another.
- Live in unity with one another.

**Live in harmony with one another:** The Greek clause is literally “thinking the same thing toward one another.” There are several ways to interpret it. Here are the main ways:

1. It means to agree in opinion with one another here. It does not mean thinking exactly the same thing, but to have similar opinions on big issues. Differences of opinion on other things do not affect their love for their fellow believers. For example:

Live in agreement with one another (REB)

Be of the same mind toward one another (NASB) (BSB, RSV, NIV, NASB, KJV, ESV, NLT, GW, NET, REB)

1. It means to be concerned for each believer in the same amount here. For example:

Have the same concern for everyone (GNT) (GNT, NJB, NABRE)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1), because interpretation (2) is not really fitting to the Greek idiom. Cranfield (page 643) calls it “forced.”

**12:16b****Do not be proud,**

- Do not be arrogant/conceited.
- Do not think you are better than others.

**Do not be proud:** This clause refers to not thinking you are better than other people. Someone of high social status should not think they are a better person than someone of low social status. Someone who has lots of knowledge should not think they are a better person than someone who does not have much knowledge. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

Do not be haughty (ESV)

Don't be arrogant (GW)

**12:16c****but enjoy the company of the lowly.**

- But/And be friends with people of low social status.
- Be friendly with unimportant people.

**but:** Some languages would not consider “enjoy the company of the lowly” as contrasting with “do not be proud” (12:16b). If that is true in your language, do not translate this as contrast. For example, the Otomi Back Translation omits this word and the Tagbanwa Back Translation says:

and

**enjoy the company of the lowly:** There are two ways to interpret the Greek phrase here:

1. It means adjust your thinking and have a relationship with people of low social status here. For example:

make friends with those who seem unimportant (NCV) (BSB, REV, NIV, NJB, ESV, NABRE, NASB, KJV, NLT, GW, CEV, NET, REB, NCV)

1. It means adjust your thinking and accept that you should do deeds of low social status here. For example:

accept humble duties (GNT) (GNT)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1), because many English versions support it. Cranfield (page 644) supports interpretation (1), as do Moo,

Longenecker, Cranfield, Dunn, Schreiner, and Jewett in their translations.

**12:16d****Do not be conceited.**

- Do not think that you are wise/insightful people.
- Do not be thinking, “I am a wise person.”

**Do not be conceited:** This clause indicates that believers should not think that they are wise people. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

Do not think of yourselves as wise (GNT)

Don't regard yourselves as being wise people

**conceited:** This word means “to understand events and know the right action.” See how you translated the word “wise” in 1:14 or the word “wisdom” in 11:33.

**Romans 12:17****Section 12:1–21: Paul taught about our body, love, and revenge**

In this section, Paul taught that believers should use their bodies in ways that are holy and acceptable to God. Our thinking must change so that it follows the will of God and not the thinking of the people of this world.

Paul also taught that believers should not be more proud of themselves than what is right before God. We all have different gifts from the Holy Spirit, and we should use them.

Believers should love in a genuine way, avoid evil deeds, honor others, be full of eagerness to serve the Lord. They should rejoice, be patient, pray, help others, and show hospitality.

Believers should bless the people who persecute them, and live in sympathy and harmony with other believers. They are not to be proud such that they avoid people with no status in society. They are not to think of themselves as wise.

Believers are not to take revenge, but leave that for God to do something about the evil done to them. They are to do things that are honorable and live at peace with others, if they can. They are to bless their enemies by doing good to them.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

The New Life in Christ (NRSV)



Our bodies, thinking, and deeds must be holy and good

### 12:17a

#### Do not repay anyone evil for evil.

- ¶ Do not do evil in response/reply to someone doing evil to you<sup>(plur)</sup>.
- ¶ When someone does something bad to you, do not do something bad to him in return.

**Do not repay anyone evil for evil:** This clause indicates that the believer should not do something evil to someone because that person did something evil to him. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

Never pay back evil with evil (NJB)

Don't pay people back with evil for the evil they do to you (GW)

**evil:** The Greek word here it refers to harm that someone has done to you. Here are other ways to translate this word:

do wrong/harm

mistreat (CEV)

It is different from the Greek word that the BSB translates as “evil” at 12:9b. But some languages will translate it with the same word as there.

### 12:17b

#### Carefully consider what is right in the eyes of everybody.

- Before you do something, think about what deeds are good/right to do in the eyes/sight of everyone.
- Plan ahead to do deeds that all people think are good/beautiful.

**consider:** The Greek word refers to thinking ahead about what you are going to do. Here are other ways to translate this Greek word:

give thought to (ESV)

plan ahead to do

**right:** The Greek word here refers to what is beautiful or good. Here it refers to what is morally good. Here are other ways to translate this word:

noble (RSV)

good (NET)

**in the eyes of everybody:** Here the word everybody refers to all people, believers and non-believers. For example:

before all people (NET)

## Romans 12:18

### Section 12:1-21: Paul taught about our body, love, and revenge

In this section, Paul taught that believers should use their bodies in ways that are holy and acceptable to God. Our thinking must change so that it follows the will of God and not the thinking of the people of this world.

Paul also taught that believers should not be more proud of themselves than what is right before God. We all have different gifts from the Holy Spirit, and we should use them.

Believers should love in a genuine way, avoid evil deeds, honor others, be full of eagerness to serve the Lord. They should rejoice, be patient, pray, help others, and show hospitality.

Believers should bless the people who persecute them, and live in sympathy and harmony with other believers. They are not to be proud such that they avoid people with no status in society. They are not to think of themselves as wise.

Believers are not to take revenge, but leave that for God to do something about the evil done to them. They are to do things that are honorable and live at peace with others, if they can. They are to bless their enemies by doing good to them.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

The New Life in Christ (NRSV)

Our bodies, thinking, and deeds must be holy and good

### 12:18a

#### If it is possible on your part,

- If possible, about the things for which you<sup>(plur)</sup> are responsible,
- As far as it is possible for you to do something about it,

**If it is possible:** This phrase indicates that it is not always possible to be at peace with other people. Someone might be an enemy to you no matter what you do or say. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

If possible (ESV)

As much as possible (NJB)

Whenever you can

**on your part:** This phrase refers to what you say and what you do. You should not, on purpose, break the peace with those words and deeds. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

as far as it depends on you (ESV)

to the utmost of your ability (NJB)

#### 12:18b

#### **live at peace with everyone.**

- live at peace with everyone.
- live in a way that you are not fighting or arguing with anyone.

**live at peace:** This phrase refers to living in a way that you are at peace with others, that is, no fighting or angry arguments.

### **Romans 12:19**

#### **Section 12:1–21: Paul taught about our body, love, and revenge**

In this section, Paul taught that believers should use their bodies in ways that are holy and acceptable to God. Our thinking must change so that it follows the will of God and not the thinking of the people of this world.

Paul also taught that believers should not be more proud of themselves than what is right before God. We all have different gifts from the Holy Spirit, and we should use them.

Believers should love in a genuine way, avoid evil deeds, honor others, be full of eagerness to serve the Lord. They should rejoice, be patient, pray, help others, and show hospitality.

Believers should bless the people who persecute them, and live in sympathy and harmony with other believers. They are not to be proud such that they

avoid people with no status in society. They are not to think of themselves as wise.

Believers are not to take revenge, but leave that for God to do something about the evil done to them. They are to do things that are honorable and live at peace with others, if they can. They are to bless their enemies by doing good to them.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

The New Life in Christ (NRSV)

Our bodies, thinking, and deeds must be holy and good

#### 12:19a

#### **Do not avenge yourselves, beloved,**

- People whom I love, never take revenge on anyone.
- The ones I love, when someone hurts you, do not take revenge.

**avenge yourselves:** This phrase refers to hurting someone because they hurt you. For example:

take revenge (NIV)

Do not pay back someone who hurt you by hurting him

**beloved:** This word indicates that Paul loved the believers in Rome. See Morris (page 453). Cranfield (page 646) implies that the affection here is Paul's, and Jewett (page 774) says the word is "personal." But Moo (page 786) connects this to the love of God for the believers. However, overall it seems best to see this as Paul's love for the believers in Rome. For example:

my dear friends (NJB)

#### 12:19b

#### **but leave room for God's wrath.**

- But/And let God's anger take revenge at his time,
- No, allow God to act in anger against that person when he chooses.

**but:** Some languages will not see contrast between "never avenge yourselves" and "leave it to the wrath of God." For example the Uma Back Translation and the Otomi Back Translation (both on TW) omit this word.

**leave room for God's wrath:** The Greek word that the BSB translates as leave room for refers to waiting for someone else to do something. Believers should let God be angry with that person and do something to him, when and where God chooses to. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

leave it to the wrath of God (ESV)

wait for God to punish them with his anger (NCV)

allow the opportunity for God's anger to avenge you

#### 12:19c

**For it is written: "Vengeance is Mine; I will repay, says the Lord."**

- for some words that were written long ago say, "The Lord says, 'It is mine to take revenge. I myself will pay him back.'"
- For the Scripture says, "The Lord God says, 'Taking revenge belongs to me. I myself will retaliate/repay for someone's wrongdoing.'"

**For:** Here this word introduces support for what Paul said in 12:19a–b.

**it is written:** This clause introduces a quote from Scripture. The quote is from Deuteronomy 32:35. If you indicate the location of quotes from the Old Testament with cross-references, you may want to do so here.

This quote was written hundreds of years before Paul wrote the letter to the Romans. In some languages a literal translation would wrongly indicate the quote was written at the same time as Paul wrote here. If that is true in your language, indicate it was long before Paul wrote. For example:

it was written long ago

This clause refers to what was written in the Old Testament. Some languages must make that explicit to make that connection clear. For example:

the scripture says (GNT)

This clause is passive. Moses wrote what God told him to write. Some languages must use an active clause here. For example:

Moses/someone wrote long ago

what God caused-to-be-written saying,

it says in the Holy Book

See how you translated this clause in 1:17 or 11:26.

**Vengeance is Mine; I will repay, says the Lord:** In many languages it is more natural to have who speaks before what is spoken. For example:

The Lord says, 'Vengeance is mine, I will repay.'

**Vengeance is Mine:** The word Vengeance refers to refers to hurting someone because they hurt you, as "avenge" does in 12:19a. Some languages must use a verb here. For example:

Deeds of revenge are mine to do

The Greek word that the BSB translates as Mine is emphasized in the Greek by being first in the clause. For example:

It is mine to avenge

**I will repay:** This word refers to doing something in return to someone for what he did to you. For example:

I will pay back (GNT)

The meaning of I is emphasized in the Greek. For example:

I myself will repay

**the Lord:** The word Lord refers to someone who has authority over people. Here this phrase refers to God. In some languages it is more natural to indicate who this Lord is. For example:

the Lord God

See how you translated the word Lord in 4:8 or 12:11.

## Romans 12:20

### Section 12:1–21: Paul taught about our body, love, and revenge

In this section, Paul taught that believers should use their bodies in ways that are holy and acceptable to God. Our thinking must change so that it follows the will of God and not the thinking of the people of this world.

Paul also taught that believers should not be more proud of themselves than what is right before God. We all have different gifts from the Holy Spirit, and we should use them.

Believers should love in a genuine way, avoid evil deeds, honor others, be full of eagerness to serve the Lord. They should rejoice, be patient, pray, help others, and show hospitality.

Believers should bless the people who persecute them, and live in sympathy and harmony with other believers. They are not to be proud such that they avoid people with no status in society. They are not to think of themselves as wise.

Believers are not to take revenge, but leave that for God to do something about the evil done to them. They are to do things that are honorable and live at peace with others, if they can. They are to bless their enemies by doing good to them.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

The New Life in Christ (NRSV)

Our bodies, thinking, and deeds must be holy and good

#### 12:20a

#### On the contrary, “If your enemy is hungry, feed him;

- Instead, as the Scripture says, “If your<sup>(sing)</sup> enemy hungers, give him food.

**On the contrary:** There is a textual issue in 12:20a: (1) Some Greek manuscripts have the word but (BSB, RSV, NIV, GNT, NJB, NASB, NABRE, ESV, REB, NLT, GW, NET, NCV). (2) Some later Greek manuscripts have the word therefore. (KJV only). It is recommended that you follow option (1). Some scholars believe these words indicate contrast to allowing God to take vengeance. Instead of just allowing God to take vengeance, a believer is supposed to help his enemy with food or something to drink. The English versions that indicate

contrast do not say what they are contrasting to. For example:

No (RSV)

Instead (GNT)

Other scholars see this as indicating contrast to a believer taking vengeance. But in 12:19 Paul told the believers to not take vengeance. Some languages would not see that as contrasting. For example:

And more: (NJB)

And Kankanaey Back Translation in TW.

The Western Bukidnon Manobo Back Translation omits this word.

**“If your enemy is hungry...”:** This quote is from Proverbs 25:21–22. Some languages always introduce quotes from Scripture in a clear way. For example:

as the Scripture says, “if your enemy is hungry...”

**feed him;** The semi-colon (;) after the word him indicates in English that there is a connection to the words that follow but does not say what that connection is. Some languages can use a semi-colon here. For example, the Kankanaey Back Translation says:

feed him; if...

In some languages a comma and a connecting word are most natural here. For example, the Ramoaina Back Translation says:

you should feed him, and if...

In some languages a full stop is most natural. For example, the Tagbanwa Back Translation says:

feed (him). If...

#### 12:20b

#### if he is thirsty, give him a drink.

- Or if he thirsts, give him a drink.

**give him a drink:** Some English versions add the words “something to,” perhaps because a drink often

refers to an alcoholic beverage in English. In many languages a drink will not imply an alcoholic beverage.

**a drink.:** In some English versions, there is a semi-colon (;) after the word drink. This indicates in English that there is a connection to the words that follow but does not say what that connection is. But the connecting word “for” begins 12:20c. You should use a comma or a full stop here, as the BSB does.

#### 12:20c

**For in so doing, you will heap burning coals on his head.”**

- For when you do that to him, it will be as if you heap hot coals on his head.”

**For:** Here this word introduces the reason for feeding a hungry enemy or giving a drink to a thirsty enemy.

**in so doing:** This phrase refers to feeding a hungry enemy or giving a drink to a thirsty enemy. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

In doing this (NIV)

when you do that

**you will heap burning coals on his head:** This is a figure of speech. The scholars have several opinions about what it means:

1. It refers to causing the enemy to be ashamed for the bad things he has done to the believer (Cranfield and others).
2. It refers to adding more punishment for God to give the enemy at the final judgment (Schreiner and others).
3. It refers to a rite, originally Egyptian, of repentance, so implies the enemy repents (Dunn and others).
4. It refers to hospitality, inviting the enemy to join in the Christian love feast (Jewett).

The scholars argue for and against each of the options, except interpretation (4), which no one other than Jewett speaks to.

It is recommended that you translate literally, because it is not clear which interpretation is best. Many English versions translate literally here. For example:

you will be heaping red-hot coals on his head (NJB)

If you translate literally you may want to explain its possible meanings in a footnote. Here is an example footnote:

Heaping burning coals on someone’s head is a figure of speech. Here are the three ways it is usually interpreted: (1) it refers to causing the person to be ashamed, (2) it refers to added, later punishment that God will give this person, or (3) it refers to the person repenting. It is not clear which meaning is correct.

However, if you must choose an interpretation, it is recommended that you follow interpretation (1), because a few English versions follow it. For example:

you will make them burn with shame (GNT)

you will heap burning coals of shame on their heads (NLT)

you will make him feel guilty and ashamed (GW)

If you translate according to interpretation (1), you may want to give a literal translation in a footnote. Here is an example footnote:

Literally: “you will heap burning coals on his head.”

#### General Comment on 12:20a–c

These words are a quote of Proverbs 25:21–22. If you indicate the location of quotes from the Old Testament with cross-references, you may want to do so here.

### Romans 12:21

#### Section 12:1–21: Paul taught about our body, love, and revenge

In this section, Paul taught that believers should use their bodies in ways that are holy and acceptable to God. Our thinking must change so that it follows the will of God and not the thinking of the people of this world.

Paul also taught that believers should not be more proud of themselves than what is right before God. We all have different gifts from the Holy Spirit, and we should use them.

Believers should love in a genuine way, avoid evil deeds, honor others, be full of eagerness to serve the Lord. They should rejoice, be patient, pray, help others, and show hospitality.

Believers should bless the people who persecute them, and live in sympathy and harmony with other believers. They are not to be proud such that they

avoid people with no status in society. They are not to think of themselves as wise.

Believers are not to take revenge, but leave that for God to do something about the evil done to them. They are to do things that are honorable and live at peace with others, if they can. They are to bless their enemies by doing good to them.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

The New Life in Christ (NRSV)

Our bodies, thinking, and deeds must be holy and good

#### 12:21a

##### **Do not be overcome by evil,**

- Evil must not be victorious over you<sup>(sing)</sup>,
- When someone does harm to you, do not allow that to defeat you<sup>(plur)</sup>.

**Do not be overcome by evil:** This clause is passive. Some languages must use an active clause. For example:

Evil must not overcome you

Do not let evil defeat you (GNT)

**overcome:** This word refers to winning a fight or contest. Here it indicates that evil could become the ruler over our deeds and words, and so we do and say evil things. Here are other ways to translate this word:

conquered (NABRE)

gain victory

**evil:** The Greek word here refers to harm that someone has done to you. See how you translated this word at 12:17.

#### 12:21b

##### **but overcome evil with good.**

- but/and you<sup>(sing)</sup> must be victorious over evil by doing and saying good things.
- Do<sup>(plur)</sup> good deeds and say good things, and in that way you will overcome the harm done to you.

**but:** Some languages will not see “overcome evil with good” as contrasting with “do not be overcome

by evil.” For example, the Western Bukidnon Manobo Back Translation omits this word.

**overcome evil with good:** The believer is to do and say good things. That defeats the evil that tries to rule his life.

**evil:** The Greek word here refers to harm that someone has done to you, as in 12:21a.

## Romans 13:1

### **Section 13:1-7: Paul taught about government officials/leaders**

In this section, Paul told believers that they must submit to government officials, because God gave the officials the authority to rule. Fighting the government is fighting the thing that God put in place. Only people who do evil need to fear the government. The believer must do good. The government will approve those deeds. But if the believer does what is wrong, he or she should fear the government. It makes happen God’s anger against those who do evil. Submitting to the government helps avoid God’s anger and keeps our conscience clear.

Believers also should pay government taxes and fees. They should respect and honor the leaders.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

Our attitude toward the government

Our relationship with the government

#### 13:1a

##### **Everyone must submit himself to the governing authorities,**

- ¶ Everyone must submit to government authorities.
- ¶ You should all submit to anyone with authority in the government,

**Everyone must submit himself to:** There are two ways to interpret the Greek word that the BSB translates as submit...to:

1. It means to submit here. (BSB, RSV, NIV, NASB, KJV, NABRE, ESV, NLT, NET, REB, NCV)
2. It means to obey here. For example:

Everyone must obey (GNT) (GNT, NJB, GW, CEV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1), because the scholars clearly indicate the Greek word means “to submit” here. All the scholars this author has follow interpretation (1); only Lenski (page 785)

speaks of “proper subjection and obedience.” His translation has “range himself under,” which has the sense of submitting here. While obedience is implied when one submits to authorities, obedience is not the focus of the meaning.

**Everyone must submit himself:** This is a third person (as in “he” or “she”) command to submit to governing authorities as their leaders. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

Every person must submit (REB)

Everyone must be underneath

This last example is a figure of speech in some languages for being in submission to someone.

**Everyone:** Paul wrote to the believers in Rome. This phrase refers to them. Cranfield (page 656). Some scholars want to include non-believers here, but that seems to go beyond the purpose of this letter. In general, all governments expect all its people to submit, but Paul did not write to all people, only to believers. If possible, avoid a phrase that purposely indicates all the people of a country, such as “all people.”

**must submit:** This refers to being under the authority of someone. He or she has the power to tell us what we should do. See the examples above.

**the governing authorities:** The Greek is more literally “superior/higher authorities.” It refers in general to people in the government who have the power to tell you what to do or what not to do. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

higher authorities (NABRE)

those with authority in the government

### 13:1b

**for there is no authority except that which is from God.**

- For no authority exists except authority that God gives,
- because all authority comes from God.

**for:** Here this word introduces a reason for submitting to governing authorities.

**there is no authority except that which is from God:** The words there is introduce something that exists. No authority exists except (authority that comes) from God. Some languages cannot introduce such things

with there is. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

no authority exists without God giving it

all authority comes from God (NLT)

Only God can give authority to anyone (CEV)

### 13:1c

**The authorities that exist have been appointed by God.**

- and the authority that exists has been put in place by God.
- And God has caused that authority to exist.

**The authorities that exist have been appointed by God:** This clause is passive. Some languages must use an active clause. For example:

God has instituted those that exist

**The authorities that exist:** The Greek is more literally “the existing ones.” It refers to the authorities that Paul mentioned in 13:1a. For example:

the existing authorities (GNT)

This verse is true at any time, not just when Paul wrote it. Your translation should not limit it to only “at that time.”

**appointed:** This word refers to putting something in its place. In this case it refers to causing the authority to exist. Here are other ways to translate this word:

established (NIV)

put there (GNT)

instituted (ESV)

## Romans 13:2

### Section 13:1–7: Paul taught about government officials/leaders

In this section, Paul told believers that they must submit to government officials, because God gave the officials the authority to rule. Fighting the government is fighting the thing that God put in place. Only people who do evil need to fear the government. The believer

must do good. The government will approve those deeds. But if the believer does what is wrong, he or she should fear the government. It makes happen God's anger against those who do evil. Submitting to the government helps avoid God's anger and keeps our conscience clear.

Believers also should pay government taxes and fees. They should respect and honor the leaders.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

Our attitude toward the government

Our relationship with the government

### 13:2a

**Consequently, whoever resists authority is opposing what God has set in place,**

- Therefore, someone fighting those authorities rebels against the command of God to establish their authority,
- So then, if a person rebels against someone with that authority, he rebels/fights against the command of God that caused it to exist.

**Consequently:** Here this word introduces a consequence of God instituting all government authority (13:1b–c). One should not resist government authority, because God caused that authority to exist.

**whoever resists authority is opposing what God has set in place:** Here the Greek words that the BSB translates as resists and opposing are words with similar meanings. The Greek lexicons use similar definitions for these words. They both refer to opposing something or someone. The scholars who say the two words mean nearly the same thing do not say how they differ in meaning. Dunn (page 762) suggests that Paul used two different words here only for good Greek style.

Some languages may have two words that mean nearly the same thing here. For example:

whoever resists authority opposes what God has appointed (NABRE)

people who oppose the government are rejecting what God made-certainUma Back Translation on TW.

In other languages it will be more natural to use the same word both times. For example:

whoever resists the authorities resists what God has appointed (ESV)

**whoever:** The Greek is singular but refers to anyone. For example:

he who (NIV)

**resists:** Here this word refers to opposing something or someone. It implies more than a difference of opinion. It implies here that someone refuses to do what the government requires. Here are other ways to translate this word:

rebels (NIV)

fight

rejectsOtomi Back Translation on TW.

**authority:** The Greek is singular, but it refers to any of the governing authorities in 13:1a. For example:

those authorities

**what God has set in place:** The Greek is more literally “the command/order of God.” It refers to the system of government implied by “the authorities” above. God put it there. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

what God has commanded (NCV)

God is the one who placed/put them in that their workYakan Back Translation on TW.

that which God had establishedBarok Back Translation, unpublished manuscript, Papua New Guinea.

### 13:2b

**and those who do so will bring judgment on themselves.**

- and the person fighting them will receive the judge's decision and its punishment upon his own self.
- And if people rebel/fight the government authorities, God or the authorities will judge and punish them.



**those who do so:** This refers to people who are doing the same thing as the person resisting the authorities in 13:2a.

**will bring judgment on themselves:** The Greek is more literally “will receive judgment upon-themselves.” The phrase “upon-themselves” is emphasized in the Greek by being first in the clause.

This phrase indicates that someone will judge the people who resist the government. Some scholars think that Paul was thinking of both God and government leaders judging these people. Other scholars think that Paul was thinking mostly of God here. It is probably best to think that Paul was thinking of both God and government leaders here.

In some languages one word translates both the English word “receive” and “take.” But “take” does not imply that someone gave. Your translation should indicate or imply that someone gave this judgment. For example:

will be given judgment

will experience judgment and punishment from them

**judgment:** Here this word refers to deciding someone has done something bad and what the punishment should be. For example:

condemnation (NJB)

## Romans 13:3

### Section 13:1–7: Paul taught about government officials/leaders

In this section, Paul told believers that they must submit to government officials, because God gave the officials the authority to rule. Fighting the government is fighting the thing that God put in place. Only people who do evil need to fear the government. The believer must do good. The government will approve those deeds. But if the believer does what is wrong, he or she should fear the government. It makes happen God’s anger against those who do evil. Submitting to the government helps avoid God’s anger and keeps our conscience clear.

Believers also should pay government taxes and fees. They should respect and honor the leaders.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

Our attitude toward the government

Our relationship with the government

### 13:3a

**For rulers are not a terror to good conduct, but to bad.**

- For leaders are not people who cause fear in people who do good things/deeds, but those who do bad.
- For those leaders are a source of fear for people doing bad deeds, not to people doing good deeds.

**For:** This word introduces an explanation of incurring judgment in 13:2b.

**rulers:** This word refers to the governing authorities in 13:1–2. Using this new word, some languages might need to explicitly connect it to those people in 13:1–2. For example:

those rulers

**are not a terror:** This refers to not being someone that people are afraid of. Some languages must explain how the word terror is used here. For example:

are not a cause of fear (NABRE)

are not people to be feared

**terror:** This word generally means “fear.” Here it refers to the fear of being caught and punished for doing something bad.

**to good conduct:** Here the word conduct refers to what one does. For example:

to good deeds/behavior

In some languages it will be more natural to make explicit that it is people doing this good conduct. For example:

to people who do good things

**but to bad:** This indicates that rulers are a terror to people who have bad conduct. Some languages must add some or all of the words missing from the Greek and the English. For example:

but to bad conduct

but to the one who does evil

but he is a terror to the person who has bad conduct

### 13:3b

#### **Do you want to be unafraid of the one in authority?**

- Do you<sup>(sing)</sup> want to not fear someone with authority?
- If you<sup>(plur)</sup> do not want to be afraid of a government authority,

#### **Do you want to be unafraid of the one in authority?:**

The Greek is more literally “Do you<sup>(sing)</sup> want to not fear the authority?” It is a rhetorical question. It introduces the topic of how to have no fear of people in authority. Paul himself answered how in 13:3c. Here are other ways to translate these words:

Do you want to have no fear of authority?

Do you want to be free from fear of the one in authority? (NIV)

if you want to live with no fear of authority (NJB)

### 13:3c

#### **Then do what is right,**

- Then do<sup>(sing)</sup> good deeds,
- you<sup>(plur)</sup> must do good things,

**Then do what is right:** The Greek is more literally “Do the good.” It is the answer to how to not fear people in authority. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

Do good (NET)

Then you must do good deeds/things

**right:** The Greek word refers to what is morally good. For example, helping the poor is morally good, but stealing is not, even though the thief might think it is good for himself.

### 13:3d

#### **and you will have his approval.**

- and you will have praise from him.
- and the leader will say you are good.

**you will have his approval:** The Greek is literally “you<sup>(sing)</sup> will have praise from it.” The word “it” refers to the authority in 13:3b and implies the person holding that authority. Here the word his refers in general

to that person. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

he will commend you (NIV)

they will praise you (GNT)

**approval:** This word refers to words saying someone is good. Here it is praise for doing good.

## Romans 13:4

### **Section 13:1-7: Paul taught about government officials/leaders**

In this section, Paul told believers that they must submit to government officials, because God gave the officials the authority to rule. Fighting the government is fighting the thing that God put in place. Only people who do evil need to fear the government. The believer must do good. The government will approve those deeds. But if the believer does what is wrong, he or she should fear the government. It makes happen God’s anger against those who do evil. Submitting to the government helps avoid God’s anger and keeps our conscience clear.

Believers also should pay government taxes and fees. They should respect and honor the leaders.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

Our attitude toward the government

Our relationship with the government

### 13:4a

#### **For he is God’s servant for your good.**

- For he is a servant of God himself to lead you<sup>(sing)</sup> for good.
- For they are God’s servants to benefit you<sup>(plur)</sup>.

**For:** Here this word introduces something more that Paul wanted to say about the government leader.

**God’s:** In the Greek this word is emphasized by being first in the clause. If possible, emphasize this word in your translation.

**servant:** This word refers to a person who works for someone else. God has appointed these government authorities (13:2a) to govern, so in that way they are God’s servants.

**for your good:** The Greek is more literally “to you for the good.” Government leaders are to benefit believers

(and all people) by the way they govern and lead the people so that they do good. See Morris (page 463–464). Here are other ways to translate this word:

to do you good (NIV)

to you for good (NASB)

#### 13:4b

##### **But if you do wrong, be afraid,**

- But if you do something bad, have fear,
- But if you do evil, you will have reason to fear them,

**do wrong:** Here the word wrong refers to deeds that are morally wrong. For example, hurting others or stealing is morally wrong. It does not refer to mistakes here (for example, he folded the paper in the wrong way).

**be afraid:** Some languages must say what one is afraid of. For example:

fear the authority Otomi Back Translation on TW.

Some languages cannot command someone to be afraid. If that is true in your language, use another way to indicate the correct meaning. For example:

it is fitting/right that you fear

you will have cause to fear them (REB)

#### 13:4c

##### **for he does not carry the sword in vain.**

- because he does not carry a sword/weapon for no reason/purpose.
- for he has a purpose in wearing the symbol of the authority to punish.
- because they have the power to punish lawbreakers.

**for:** Here this word introduces the reason why a believer who does wrong should be afraid of government leaders.

**he does not carry the sword in vain:** Here the phrase in vain refers to having no purpose. BDAG and L&N. With the word not, this clause indicates that the government leader has a purpose for bearing the sword. That purpose is to punish those who do wrong. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

rulers do not bear the sword for no reason (NIV11)

he has a purpose in bearing the sword

they have the power to punish you (NLT)

**carry the sword:** This is a figure of speech that means here “to have the authority to punish.” In some languages a literal translation will not have the correct meaning. If that is true in your language, you may want to:

- Translate literally and explain its meaning in a footnote. Here is an example footnote:

This means “to have the authority to punish.” Or write a footnote explaining it means the same thing as the weapon or symbol in your language.

- Use the weapon or symbol of authority in your language that is used to punish. You may then want to write a footnote describing the literal words. Here is an example footnote:

Literally “bear the sword.”

**carry:** Here this word means to have in the hand or on a belt or attached to the clothing.

**sword:** A sword is a hand-held weapon that is used to cut or stab. The swords of that time were 60–120 centimeters (2–4 feet) long and made of metal. The picture shows some of the various kinds of swords used at that time.

In some languages people are not familiar with swords. If that is true in your language, you may want to:

- Translate the meaning in your translation. For example:

long knife

cutting/sharp weapon

war machete/bush-knife

- Use the major language word. If people are not familiar with this word, you may want to explain it in a footnote. Here is an example footnote:

A sword is a hand-held weapon that is used to cut or stab. The swords of that time were 60–120 centimeters long and made of metal.

**13:4d****He is God's servant,**

- For he is a servant of God himself
- For they are God's servants

**13:4e****an agent of retribution to the wrongdoer.**

- and one who takes vengeance; he causes his anger to fall/occur on the people who do evil.
- and punish wrongs done to others. For they bring their anger/punishment to evil people.

**an agent of retribution to the wrongdoer:** This phrase further describes the government leader. In some languages it would be more natural to add connecting words or to translate this phrase as a full clause. For example:

that is, he is an agent who brings retribution to the wrongdoer

he is an avenger who applies wrath on the wrongdoer

**agent:** The Greek word that the BSB translates as agent is more literally “avenger.” This word refers to a person who punishes people for the evil that they did to someone else. BDAG. For example, if Tom hurt Bill, Sam could “avenge” Bill by punishing Tom. Here is another way to translate this word:

one who avenges

**of retribution to the wrongdoer:** There are two ways to interpret whose retribution this is:

1. It is the retribution/wrath of the avenger. For example:

to execute wrath on (NRSV) (BSB, NIV, NJB, NRSV, KJV, NASB, NET, NABRE, NLT, REB, NCV)

1. It is the retribution/wrath of God. For example:

God's wrath (RSV) (RSV, GNT, ESV, GW, CEV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1), because the subject here is the government authority, here called “an avenger.”

The same issue occurs at 13:5. This author follows the same interpretation there.

**of retribution to:** The Greek is literally “to/for wrath to.” Here it indicates the goal of avenging; the government leader causes wrath, in the form of punishment, to come to the wrongdoer. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

for wrath to be applied to

to cause wrath to fall on

to punish

**retribution:** The Greek word is more literally “wrath.” It refers generally to strong emotion, usually anger or passion, depending on the context. Sometimes, as here, it focuses on the actions taken in that anger. Here it implies that the government authorities punish the evildoer for his evil deeds, which is why the BSB translates it as retribution.

In some languages a literal translation would imply evil deeds done to this evildoer rather than punishment. If that is true in your language, you may want to:

- Translate the implied meaning here. For example:

punishment (NIV)

- Explain the implied meaning in your translation. For example:

wrath, that is, punishment,

wrath in the form of punishment

wrath of punishment

- Translate literally and explain the meaning in a footnote. Here is an example footnote:

This refers to punishment for the evil deeds of the evildoer.

**the wrongdoer:** Here the Greek phrase that BSB translates as the wrongdoer refers to people who habitually do what is evil. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

the people who are doing evil

evil people

## Romans 13:5

### Section 13:1–7: Paul taught about government officials/leaders

In this section, Paul told believers that they must submit to government officials, because God gave the officials the authority to rule. Fighting the government is fighting the thing that God put in place. Only people who do evil need to fear the government. The believer must do good. The government will approve those deeds. But if the believer does what is wrong, he or she should fear the government. It makes happen God's anger against those who do evil. Submitting to the government helps avoid God's anger and keeps our conscience clear.

Believers also should pay government taxes and fees. They should respect and honor the leaders.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

Our attitude toward the government

Our relationship with the government

#### 13:5a

#### Therefore it is necessary to submit to authority,

- So then, it is necessary that any/every one of us submit to the authorities,
- Therefore you all must submit to anyone with authority in the government,

**Therefore:** Here this word introduces a logical conclusion to what Paul said earlier.

**it is necessary:** The Greek is literally “it-is-necessary to.” It indicates that the only right thing to do is to be in subjection.

**to submit to authority:** This refers to being under the authority of someone. He or she can tell believers what they should do, and they should do it. See how you translated this Greek word at 13:1 (“submit”).

The context implies that believers are to be subject to government authorities (13:1–4). For example:

to submit to the authorities (NIV)

#### 13:5b

#### not only to avoid punishment, but also as a matter of conscience.

- not only because of that wrath but also because of sparing our consciences.
- not only because he/they will be angry with you if you do what is wrong, but also because you know that it is the right thing for you to do.

The same interpretation issue about whose wrath this is occurs here as it does in 13:4e. This author follows the same interpretation here.

**not only to avoid punishment, but also as a matter of conscience:** The grammar of the words not only... but also acknowledges the importance of the first part and emphasizes the importance of the second part. In some languages it is more natural for the not only part to be second. For example:

as a matter of conscience, not only to avoid punishment

**to avoid punishment:** This implies not doing things that cause the government authorities to be angry. For example:

because of the wrath of the authorities (NET)

because you might be punished (NCV)

**punishment:** The Greek word that the BSB translates as punishment is more literally “wrath.” It refers to the same thing as in 13:4e, where the BSB translates it as “retribution.” See how you translated this word there.

**conscience:** Here this word refers to someone's internal record of past deeds, as in 2:15 and 9:1. It probably also implies that the person knows that doing evil will cause him to feel guilty or ashamed, so it is best not to do evil. See Jewett (page 797).

See how you translated this word in 2:15 or 9:1.

## Romans 13:6

### Section 13:1–7: Paul taught about government officials/leaders

In this section, Paul told believers that they must submit to government officials, because God gave the officials the authority to rule. Fighting the government is fighting the thing that God put in place. Only people who do evil need to fear the government. The believer must do good. The government will approve those deeds. But if the believer does what is wrong, he or she should fear the government. It makes happen God's anger against those who do evil. Submitting to the

government helps avoid God's anger and keeps our conscience clear.

Believers also should pay government taxes and fees. They should respect and honor the leaders.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

Our attitude toward the government

Our relationship with the government

### 13:6a

**This is also why you pay taxes.**

- For, because of that, you pay tax money too,
- For, because of your conscience, you also pay taxes to them,

**This is also why:** Here this word introduces something more that Paul wanted to say about government leaders. This phrase refers to being in subjection for the sake of conscience (13:5a–b). In some languages “that” would be more clear. For example:

because of that

**taxes:** This word refers to money that the government requires from the people they govern.

### 13:6b

**For the authorities are God's servants,**

- for they are administrators who work for God,
- because they are God's servants,

**For:** Here this word introduces a reason for paying taxes.

**the authorities:** The Greek is literally the word ending on the verb that means “they.” But the government authorities have not been mentioned, except for using “he,” since 13:3a. So the BSB makes it clear here who “they” refers to.

In some languages “they” would clearly refer to the government authorities here. For example:

they (KJV)

**God's servants:** Here the Greek word that the BSB translates as servants refers to an administrator in government. It refers to the same group that Paul called “God's servant” in 13:4, “rulers” in 13:3, and “authorities” in 13:1. God has given these people the authority to do their work for the government. Here are other ways to translate this word:

officials working for God

those workers/administrators, they work for God,

The meaning is similar to “servant” in 13:4. It may be clearer in your language to refer to the them using the word you used there.

### 13:6c

**who devote themselves to their work.**

- being busy doing that.
- and they work every day at it.

**who devote themselves to their work:** The word who indicates here that this phrase further describes the authorities and what they do (13:6b). In some languages a different grammar must be used for the correct meaning. For example:

and attend to this very thing

**who devote themselves to:** Here the word devote refers to continually working at something. The government authorities are busy doing their work. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

give their full time to (NIV)

are busily occupied with (NJB)

**their work:** This refers to the work of administration indicated in the Greek word that the BSB translates as “servants” in 13:6b. Here are other ways to translate this word:

that particular task (NJB)

their duties (GNT)

governing (NIV)

## Romans 13:7

**Section 13:1–7: Paul taught about government officials/leaders**

In this section, Paul told believers that they must submit to government officials, because God gave the officials the authority to rule. Fighting the government is fighting the thing that God put in place. Only people who do evil need to fear the government. The believer must do good. The government will approve those deeds. But if the believer does what is wrong, he or she

should fear the government. It makes happen God's anger against those who do evil. Submitting to the government helps avoid God's anger and keeps our conscience clear.

Believers also should pay government taxes and fees. They should respect and honor the leaders.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

Our attitude toward the government

Our relationship with the government

### 13:7a

#### Pay everyone what you owe him:

- Pay, as you<sup>(plur)</sup> should/ought, the things you owe.
- Whatever is your duty/obligation toward them, do it.
- Things that are required of you to give, give them.

**Pay:** This Greek word refers to giving something because one is required to give. BDAG, sense 2.c. Here are other ways to translate this word:

Give (NIV)

Pay, as you should,

The NIV allows the context to imply giving something you should give. The BSB does a similar thing with Pay.

**everyone:** Considering the list of things to do in 13:7b–e, the word everyone here refers to all government authorities, not everyone in the world. For example:

all of them (RSV)

**what you owe him:** The Greek word refers to things that someone should repay or give. 13:7b–e has four examples of what you owe him. Your translation should clearly allow taxes, revenue, respect, and honor to be examples of the word or phrase you translate here.

#### General Comment on 13:7a

With the colon (:) after the word “him” and not repeating the word “pay,” the BSB indicates that 13:7b–e are four things that the believer should pay. In some languages a different way to translate that meaning must be used. For example:

Pay everyone what you owe him. So, pay taxes to whom taxes are due, and pay revenue to whom

revenue is due, and pay respect to whom respect is due, and pay honor to whom honor is due.

Pay everyone what you owe him. That is, pay taxes to whom taxes are due, and revenue to whom revenue is due, and respect to whom respect is due, and honor to whom honor is due.

### 13:7b

#### taxes to whom taxes are due,

- So, pay taxes to the person you owe taxes to,
- When the rulers tell you that you must pay taxes, then pay them.

**taxes to whom taxes are due:** The word “pay” is implied here. In some languages that word must be explicit here. For example:

pay taxes to whom taxes are owed

You may want to use the same word here for “pay” as you did in 13:7a.

**taxes:** See how you translated this word in 13:6.

### 13:7c

#### revenue to whom revenue is due,

- and pay duties/fees to the person you owe duties/fees to.
- When they tell you that you must pay duties or fees, then pay them.

**revenue to whom revenue is due:** The word “pay” is implied here. In some languages that word must be explicit here. For example:

pay revenue to whom revenue is owed

This is the second item in a list. In some languages an “and” must begin this phrase. For example:

and revenue to whom revenue is owed

**revenue:** The Greek word refers to money other than taxes that government authorities ask people to pay. This includes duty, fees, and other such things. Here are other ways to translate this word:

duty

fees

**13:7d****respect to whom respect is due,**

- And fear the person you should fear,
- They should be feared/respected, so fear/respect them.

**respect to whom respect is due:** The word “pay” is implied here. In some languages that word must be explicit here. But in many languages a different word than “pay” must be used for the correct meaning. For example:

pay/give/show respect to whom respect is owed

respect the person/leader you should respect

This is the third item in a list. In some languages an “and” must begin this phrase. For example:

and respect to whom respect is owed

**respect:** The Greek word that the BSB translates as respect is more literally “fear.” It refers to a necessary attitude to have toward powerful people because their power can put us in danger. People of lower status and power must act in ways that do not make powerful people angry or feel humiliated. For example:

fear (NASB)

But many English versions translate the Greek word as respect here.

**13:7e****honor to whom honor is due.**

- and honor the person you should honor.
- They should be honored, so honor them.

**honor to whom honor is due:** The word “pay” is implied here. In some languages that word must be explicit here. But in many languages a different word than “pay” must be used for the correct meaning. For example:

pay/give/show honor to whom honor is owed

honor the person/leader you should honor

This is the fourth item in a list. In some languages an “and” must begin this phrase. For example:

and honor to whom honor is owed

**honor:** This word refers to showing that you respect someone. BDAG, sense 2. This may be praising him or speaking highly of him to others. Here are other ways to translate this word:

praise

lift up the name

**Romans 13:8****Section 13:8–10: Love one another**

In this section, Paul urged believers to love each other. This requirement to love is like a debt that they always owe, so they must always be loving each other. Loving others fulfills the Old Testament law.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

Love fulfills the Laws of Moses

We must love our fellow believers

**13:8a****Be indebted to no one,**

- ¶ Do not owe anyone anything,
- ¶ Do not have a debt with anyone.

**Be indebted to no one:** The Greek text literally says: “To no one owe nothing.” The two negatives (“no one” and “nothing”) strengthen the command in Greek to not owe anything to others. Dunn (page 776). Some languages can follow the Greek and have the correct meaning. For example:

Owe no one nothing!

But many languages translating both negatives would have the wrong meaning. If that is true in your language, translate the correct meaning. For example:

Owe nothing to anyone (NABRE)

Let us not be in debt to others Uma Back Translation on TW.

**Be indebted:** Here this word refers to a requirement to repay something, not just money. The word you use should allow for any requirement to repay something.

**13:8b****except to one another in love.**



- but owe this one thing: always love one another.
- But one thing you must do, and that is you must love one another.

**except to one another in love:** In contrast to having no requirements to repay anything (13:8a), these words indicate that we have the requirement to always love each other. Here are other ways to translate these words:

but for this one: Love one another

But actually there is always a debt of ours to others. That debt of ours is to always love each other

Even if you no longer have a debt, you have yet a different debt. This debt is your love to your fellows  
Yakan Back Translation on TW.

but we are always required to do this: Love each other

But actually there is something we must always do. It is loving each other

**one another:** Here this phrase refers to other believers. Jewett (page 807) says, “‘One another’ clearly refers to fellow believers, as Zahn, Lietzmann, and others have shown.”

**love:** The word love refers to a strong affection and concern for a person. In some languages an idiom such as “give/put heart/liver” is used for the meaning of love. See how you translated this word in 12:9.

### 13:8c

**For he who loves his neighbor has fulfilled the law.**

- For the person who loves someone else has accomplished the demands of the laws of Moses.
- For when someone loves another person, then he has fulfilled the requirements of the Law.

**For:** Here this word introduces something that supports Paul’s words to love each other.

**his neighbor:** Here this word refers to someone other than yourself.

**has fulfilled the law:** Here the Greek word that the BSB translates as fulfilled refers to accomplishing what the law demands for us to do. See Dunn (page 777) or Jewett (page 809). Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

will fulfill the requirements of God’s law (NLT)

have done all that the Law demands (CEV)

has met every requirement of the law (REB)

## Romans 13:9

### Section 13:8–10: Love one another

In this section, Paul urged believers to love each other. This requirement to love is like a debt that they always owe, so they must always be loving each other. Loving others fulfills the Old Testament law.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

Love fulfills the Laws of Moses

We must love our fellow believers

### 13:9a–c

These commands use “you<sup>(sing)</sup>.” But God expected all of the people of Israel to obey them.

**“Do not commit adultery,” “Do not murder,” “Do not steal,” “Do not covet,” and any other commandments:** These commandments occur in Exodus 20:13–15, 17 and Deuteronomy 5:17–19, 21. Some language translations always introduce Old Testament quotes with a phrase indicating that they are from there. For example:

in the Scriptures , “Do not commit adultery...

Some languages must add an “and” before the second, third, and fourth items in this list. For example:

“Do not commit adultery, and do not murder, and do not steal, and do not covet,” and any other commandment

This whole phrase is the subject of the verb phrase “are summed up” in 13:9d. So the BSB and many other English versions use commas or semi-colons, rather than full stops, to indicate that. In some languages it will be more clear to separate the list from verb phrase and then clearly indicate the connection in the translation. For example:

For God said in Scripture, “Do not commit adultery. Do not murder. Do not steal. Do not covet.”

Those commandments and any other commandment

### 13:9a

#### The commandments “Do not commit adultery,”

- For the commands/laws, “Do not have sex with someone who is not your<sup>(sing)</sup> spouse,
- For God said, “Do not sleep/lie with someone to whom you are not married.”

The Greek of 13:9a begins with a word that is often translated as “for.” The BSB does not translate this word. Here this word introduces a sentence that supports Paul saying that loving others fulfills the laws of Moses.

**The commandments:** The BSB and many English versions add the word commandments, as implied from the list of four commandments that follow.

**commit adultery:** This phrase refers to having sex with someone to whom you are not married.

In some languages people will want to use the polite expression to refer to this deed here. This might be an idiom. For example:

lie/sleep with someone who is not your wife or husband

See how you translated this phrase in 2:22.

### 13:9b

#### “Do not murder,” “Do not steal,”

- and do not murder, and do not steal,
- “Do not kill people.” “Do not steal other people’s things.”

**murder:** This word refers to killing another person. It implies killing someone on purpose and against the law. See how you translate this word in 1:29.

**steal:** There is a textual issue in 13:9b: (1) Some Greek manuscripts have the word steal (BSB, RSV, NIV, GNT, NJB, NASB, NABRE, ESV, REB, NLT, GW, NET, NCV). (2) Some later Greek manuscripts have the words steal, do not give false-witness. (KJV only). It is recommended that you follow option (1). This refers to taking other people’s possessions when they do not want you to. It usually implies taking them secretly. See how you translated this word in 2:21.

### 13:9c

#### “Do not covet,” and any other commandments,

- and do not desire/want the things of someone else,” and any other commands/laws,

- “Do not desire what belongs to someone else.” About those commands/laws and any other commands/laws,

**covet:** This word refers to desiring to possess for oneself something that belongs to someone else. See how you translated this word in 7:7.

**any other commandments:** This refers to any of the commands in the Old Testament directed to the Israelites, except the four that Paul already wrote.

#### General Comment on 13:9a–c

These words are a quotes from Exodus 20:13–15,17. If you indicate the location of quotes from the Old Testament with cross-references, you may want to do so here.

### 13:9d

#### are summed up in this one decree: “Love your neighbor as yourself.”

- are wrapped up in this one saying/command, “Love your neighbor as you love yourself.”
- there is one law that covers/includes them all. It is this: “Love the person who lives/is near you in the same way that you love yourself.”

**are summed up:** This phrase refers to stating the main point of all the things previously mentioned. The main point of the laws that Paul just stated is to love one’s neighbor as yourself. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

are all concentrated in Kankanaey Back Translation on TW.

are included here in Otomi Back Translation on TW.

come back to Tagbanwa Back Translation on TW.

This clause is passive. It is not important who does the summing up. Some languages do not have a passive construction. If that is true in your language, translate without a passive. See the above examples.

**one decree:** Here these words mean “a group of words.” Here it refers to “Love your neighbor as yourself.” Here are other ways to translate this word:

saying (NABRE)

command (GNT)

**neighbor:** This word refers to someone who lives near you. Here it does not have any qualifications, so refers to anyone who lives near you, or anyone who happens to be near you at the time. You should not translate this word as “friend” if that word excludes someone who lives near you but is not your friend.

**as yourself:** The words “you love” are implied after the word as here. For example:

as you love yourself

### General Comment on 13:9d

These words are a quote of Leviticus 19:18. If you indicate the location of quotes from the Old Testament with cross-references, you may want to do so here.

## Romans 13:10

### Section 13:8–10: Love one another

In this section, Paul urged believers to love each other. This requirement to love is like a debt that they always owe, so they must always be loving each other. Loving others fulfills the Old Testament law.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

Love fulfills the Laws of Moses

We must love our fellow believers

### 13:10a

#### Love does no wrong to its neighbor.

- Loving others means that that person does nothing evil to a neighbor,
- When you<sup>(sing/plur)</sup> love a neighbor, you do not do evil to him or her.

**Love:** This is a noun. It speaks of love in general. Some languages must use a different way to translate this noun. For example:

Loving others

To love is to do no wrong...

When you love others, you do no wrong

**does no wrong:** Here the word wrong refers to deeds that are morally wrong. For example, hurting others or stealing is morally wrong. It does not refer to mistakes here (for example, he folded the paper wrong). See

how you translated this phrase (“do wrong”) in 13:4b. Remember that the word no is included here.

### 13:10b

#### Therefore love is the fulfillment of the law.

- so loving others accomplishes the demands of the laws of Moses.
- Therefore the person who loves others has fulfilled the requirements of the Law.

**the fulfillment of the law:** Here the Greek word that the BSB translates as fulfillment refers to accomplishing what the law demands for us to do, as in the word “fulfilled” in 13:8. Moo (page 817), Cranfield (page 678). See how you translated that word there.

## Romans 13:11

### Section 13:11–14: Live the right way

In this section, Paul used several metaphors to encourage the Roman believers to live properly. He said they should live decent lives in the present time as they waited for their final salvation to arrive. He compared them to people sleeping at night, and said the time had arrived for them to wake up. He also said they should stop following behavior that belongs to the darkness and which only satisfies their sinful nature. Instead they should put on the qualities of the Lord Jesus Christ like putting on clothing. He described those qualities as “the armor of light.”

Here are other possible headings for this section:

Live/Walk in the light and power of God

Be active in your faith and serve God through his power

### 13:11a

#### And do this, understanding the occasion.

- ¶ Do<sup>(plur)</sup> that, knowing this time in which we live.
- ¶ Do those things. You know what kind of time we live in.

**And do this, understanding the occasion:** The Greek is more literally “And this, knowing the time.” There are several ways to interpret the Greek words:

1. The words “and this” imply do, a command to love your neighbor (13:8–10) or possibly all the commands of 12:1–13:10, and “knowing the time” indicates why believers should love their neighbors. See Moo (pages 819–820). For example:

And do this because you know the time (NABRE)  
(BSB, NIV, GNT, NASB, KJV, NABRE, NLT, NET, NCV)

1. The words “and this” introduce a new topic: “knowing the time.” For example:

Besides this you know what hour it is (RSV) (ESV, RSV, NJB)

1. The words “and this” do not contribute to the meaning and can be omitted. For example:

You know what sort of times we live in (CEV) (GW, CEV, REB)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1), because that seems to fit the context best. The scholars do not discuss why one interpretation is better than the other.

**And do this:** Here the word this refers to what Paul said in 13:8-10. In many languages the word “that” would be more clear. For example:

do that

**understanding the occasion:** The Greek word that the BSB translates as occasion refers to a period of time, often a time when it is right for something to happen or be done. Paul explained part of what should happen in 13:11b, and 13:11c-12a explain parts of what the current situation is like. Here are other ways to translate this Greek word:

the kind of time it is

what kind of era/age it is

### 13:11b

**The hour has come for you to wake up from your slumber,**

- Indeed, it is already the time for you to wake up from sleep.
- Yes, you need to stop being lazy like someone asleep.

**The hour has come:** The Greek is more literally “the hour already.” It indicates that it was presently the time for believers in Rome to “wake up” from their “sleep,” that is, to be doing things that God wants them to do. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

it is already the hour (NASB)

the time is now

It is now time (NCV)

**hour:** The Greek word here refers to the time when something happens. Here are other ways to translate this word:

moment (NJB)

time (GNT)

**for you to wake up from your slumber:** This is a figure of speech that refers to stop being unaware or lazy. In some languages a literal translation will have this figurative meaning. In other languages a literal translation would refer only to actually waking from sleep. If that is true in your language, you may want to:

- Translate literally and explain its meaning in a footnote. Here is an example footnote:

This is a figure of speech that refers to stop being unaware or lazy.

- Add the word “like” in your translation. For example:

for you to be like someone waking up from your slumber

- Explain its meaning in your translation. For example:

for you to wake from your slumber, that is, stop being lazy about serving God!

- Translate without the figure of speech. For example:

for you to stop being lazy about serving God You may then want to indicate the literal words in a footnote. Here is an example footnote:

Literally: for you to wake from sleep.

### 13:11c

**for our salvation is nearer now than when we first believed.**

- For the day God will finish saving us has come nearer to us now than when we first believed.

- For from now to when God will fully rescue us is shorter than from the day we started to believe in Jesus to then.

**for:** Here this word introduces an explanation why believers are to “wake up from...slumber” (13:11b). Jewett (page 820).

**our salvation is nearer now than when we first believed:** Paul spoke of salvation as something that can be near or far. In some languages it is not natural to talk in that way. If that is true in your language, speak of the day of salvation approaching. For example:

the day of our salvation is nearer now than when we first believed

**our salvation is nearer now:** God saves us when we first believe. The final part of what he has done for us will happen at the great judgment day. While the rest of the world will be condemned, we will receive a blessing, the result of our salvation. The time for that to happen is always getting closer. For example:

the final part of God saving us is nearer to us

the time in the future when God will finish His setting us free is nearer  
Western Bukidnon Manobo  
Back Translation on TW.

**salvation:** This word refers to being rescued from something harmful or dangerous. In Scripture it generally refers to rescue ahead of time from God’s anger at the final judgment. See the above examples. Also see how you translated this word in 1:16.

## Romans 13:12

### Section 13:11–14: Live the right way

In this section, Paul used several metaphors to encourage the Roman believers to live properly. He said they should live decent lives in the present time as they waited for their final salvation to arrive. He compared them to people sleeping at night, and said the time had arrived for them to wake up. He also said they should stop following behavior that belongs to the darkness and which only satisfies their sinful nature. Instead they should put on the qualities of the Lord Jesus Christ like putting on clothing. He described those qualities as “the armor of light.”

Here are other possible headings for this section:

Live/Walk in the light and power of God

Be active in your faith and serve God through his power

### 13:12a

#### The night is nearly over; the day has drawn near.

- The night is almost over, and the day is about to begin.
- The evil time we live in is like a night that is nearly ended. The good time we will live in is like a day that is almost here.

#### The night is nearly over; the day has drawn near:

The semi-colon (;) indicates that there is a connection between the two parts of this saying but does not say what that connection is. Here “and” is implied. For example:

The night is almost gone, and the day is near  
(NASB)

**The night is nearly over:** The night is a metaphor for the present evil age in which we live. That it is nearly over means that it is coming to an end. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

The night is far gone (ESV)

The night has almost ended

In some languages a literal translation would refer only to actual night or would not imply a time of evil. If that is true in your language, you may want to:

- Translate literally and explain its meaning in a footnote. Here is an example footnote:

This indicates that the time of evil will soon end.

- Explain its meaning in your translation. For example:

The night, that is, this time of evil, is nearly over

**the day has drawn near:** The phrase the day is a metaphor for the blessed time that begins after Jesus returns. That it is near means that it will soon happen. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

the day is almost here (NIV)

the day has almost begun

In some languages a literal translation would refer only to actual day or would not imply a time of special goodness. If that is true in your language, you may want to:

- Translate literally and explain its meaning in a footnote. Here is an example footnote:

This indicates that the time of blessedness/goodness will soon begin.

- Explain its meaning in your translation. For example:

The day, that is, the time of blessedness/goodness, is nearly here

### 13:12b

#### So let us lay aside the deeds of darkness

- Therefore we<sup>(incl)</sup> must stop doing deeds of the dark
- So, we must not do evil deeds of the dark.

**So let us lay aside the deeds of darkness:** The phrase the deeds of darkness refers to deeds that are consistent with darkness. The phrase lay aside indicates that we must stop doing them. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

let us cast off the works of darkness (ESV)

we should get rid of the things that belong to the dark (GW)

In some languages a literal translation would refer only to anything done in the dark. If that is true in your language, you may want to:

- Translate literally and explain its meaning in a footnote. Here is an example footnote:

This indicates that we must stop doing evil deeds.

- Explain its meaning in your translation. For example:

let us cast off the works of darkness that is, evil deeds

**deeds:** This word refers to deeds, not to something related to work. See the above examples.

### 13:12c

#### and put on the armor of light.

- and use the spiritual things of fighting that are of the light.

- Instead, we must start using the things of war of the light, that is, the things that God gives.

**put on the armor of light:** The words “let us” are implied from 13:12b. This clause is a figure of speech that indicates that believers must use the things of God that help us in our struggles with evil.

In some languages a literal translation would refer only to actual armor. If that is true in your language, you may want to:

- Translate literally and explain its meaning in a footnote. Here is an example footnote:

This indicates that we must use the things that God gives to us to fight spiritual battles.

- Explain its meaning in your translation. For example:

let us put on the armor of light that is, things that God gives us to fight our spiritual battles

let us put on the armor of light that is, things that God gives us to strengthen our lives

**armor:** The Greek is more literally “weapons.” For example:

the things of fighting/war

**light:** Paul used this word as an opposite to the word “darkness” in 13:12b. Here it implies good things, things that God gives us. See examples in the note on “put on the armor of light” above.

## Romans 13:13

### Section 13:11–14: Live the right way

In this section, Paul used several metaphors to encourage the Roman believers to live properly. He said they should live decent lives in the present time as they waited for their final salvation to arrive. He compared them to people sleeping at night, and said the time had arrived for them to wake up. He also said they should stop following behavior that belongs to the darkness and which only satisfies their sinful nature. Instead they should put on the qualities of the Lord Jesus Christ like putting on clothing. He described those qualities as “the armor of light.”

Here are other possible headings for this section:

Live/Walk in the light and power of God

Be active in your faith and serve God through his power

### 13:13a

#### Let us behave decently, as in the daytime,

- We<sup>(incl)</sup> must walk correctly, as people walk in the daytime.
- We must live/behave appropriately/right, as people/those who live/behave in the light of day.

**Let us behave decently:** The Greek word that the BSB translates as behave is literally “walk.” It used as a figure of speech to indicate how one lives. Believers must live decently. They must live as God wants them to live.

**as in the daytime:** This phrase indicates that believers should do the good deeds that people do during the day, not the evil deeds that people do during the night. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

as in the light of day (NJB)

as in the daylight

### 13:13b

#### not in carousing and drunkenness,

- For example, we must not go to drinking parties, and we must not get drunk.
- We must not live/behave like this: going to parties with much eating of food and much drinking of alcoholic drinks or any other way of getting drunk,

**not in carousing and drunkenness:** The words “Let us walk/behave” are implied from 13:13a. In some languages they must be repeated here for the correct meaning. For example:

Let us not live in orgies and drunkenness

**carousing:** The Greek word here refers to excessive feastingBDAG. or parties with much drinking of alcoholic beverages.L&N. This Greek word focuses less on sexual immorality during these parties than the usual Greek word that is translated carousing. Here are other ways to translate this word:

reveling (RSV)

drinking parties

**drunkenness:** This word refers generally to drinking too many alcoholic beverages so that the person becomes drunk.

### 13:13c

#### not in sexual immorality and debauchery,

- And we must not have sex with someone who is not our spouse, and we must not do anything we want.
- or sleeping with others outside of marriage or obeying any desire with no self-control,

**not in sexual immorality and debauchery:** The list of evil deeds continues from 13:13b.

In some languages, the sentence in 13:13a–d may get too long. If you start a new sentence here you may want to repeat the words “Let us walk/live” from 13:13a. For example:

Let us walk not in sexual immorality and sensuality

Let us not walk in sexual immorality and sensuality

**sexual immorality:** The Greek word refers generally to sexual intercourse. It implies here sex outside of marriage.

**debauchery:** The Greek word refers to allowing oneself to do anything, including bad or evil behavior. Here are other ways to translate this word:

licentiousness (NABRE)

doing anything you want

indulging of disgusting desires with no self control whatsoeverTagbanwa Back Translation on TW.

See how you translated this word in Mark 7:22 or 2 Corinthians 12:21 (“debauchery” in the BSB both times).

### 13:13d

#### not in dissension and jealousy.

- And we must not argue and we must not dislike someone because we want what he has.
- or fighting or envy.

**not in dissension and jealousy:** The words “Let us walk/behave” are implied from 13:13a. In some languages they must be repeated here for the correct meaning.

**disension:** The Greek word refers to conflict of any kind: arguments, fighting over a difference of opinion, or rivalry over a job or position. Here are other ways to translate this word:

fighting (GNT)

arguing

rivalry (NABRE)

See how you translated this word in 1:29 (“strife”).

**jealousy:** This refers to having bad feelings toward a person because that person has something that you want for yourself.

## Romans 13:14

### Section 13:11–14: Live the right way

In this section, Paul used several metaphors to encourage the Roman believers to live properly. He said they should live decent lives in the present time as they waited for their final salvation to arrive. He compared them to people sleeping at night, and said the time had arrived for them to wake up. He also said they should stop following behavior that belongs to the darkness and which only satisfies their sinful nature. Instead they should put on the qualities of the Lord Jesus Christ like putting on clothing. He described those qualities as “the armor of light.”

Here are other possible headings for this section:

Live/Walk in the light and power of God

Be active in your faith and serve God through his power

### 13:14a

**Instead, clothe yourselves with the Lord Jesus Christ,**

- But/And put on the thinking and behavior of the Lord Jesus Christ like putting on clothes,
- Instead of doing those evil things, think and behave like the Lord Jesus Christ.

**Instead:** This word indicates contrast to orgies, drunkenness, sexual immorality, sensuality, quarreling, and jealousy. But 13:13 says we are not to do those things. Some languages would not see contrast here to not doing those things. For example:

Let your armour... (NJB)

Rather than doing those things,

**clothe yourselves with the Lord Jesus Christ:** This is a figure of speech that indicates that a believer should have the same thinking and behavior as Jesus.

In some languages a literal translation would have the wrong meaning. If that is true in your language, you may want to:

- Translate literally and explain the meaning in a footnote. Here is an example footnote:

This indicates that a believer should have the same thinking and behavior as Jesus.

- Explain the meaning in your translation. For example:

clothe yourselves with the characteristics of the Lord Jesus Christ

- Translate the meaning without using a figure of speech. For example:

think and behave like the Lord Jesus Christ You may then want to give the literal words in a footnote. Here is an example footnote:

Literally: clothe yourselves with the Lord Jesus Christ

### 13:14b

**and make no provision for the desires of the flesh.**

- and make no plans to satisfy the old nature, to fulfill its lusts.
- And stop thinking of ways to satisfy the lusts of the body.

**make no provision:** This phrase refers to thinking about something ahead of time and plan what you will do about it. Here it indicates planning ways to fulfill the desires of the body. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

make no plans

do not think about how to make happy



**for the desires:** The Greek is literally “for desires/lusts.” It indicates that the goal of the plans is to satisfy the desires of the body. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

in regard to its lusts (NASB)

may be fulfilled (NJB)

**the flesh:** Here this word refers to the natural way people live. Here are other ways to translate this word:

human nature

our natural inclinations

our old nature

our own desires

See how you translated this word in 8:3.

## Romans 14:1

### Section 14:1–12: Do not judge/criticize fellow believers and do not despise them

In this section, Paul told his readers that they must accept other believers who are not strong in their faith. These other believers do things that are not based in their faith, hence they are “weak” in their faith. One example that Paul gave of this “weak” faith is someone who avoids meat because it has been devoted to the Roman gods.

Paul also told his readers to not argue over differences of opinion (14:1). In 14:5, he gave an example of this: some believers hold the holy days as something special but other believers do not. Paul reminded his readers that they all belong to the Lord Jesus.

Paul told his readers that they must not judge other believers to be bad people or despise them. He reminded them that they all will stand before God as their judge, and give an account of their deeds.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

Do not consider other believers to be bad people

Do not look down on other believers

### 14:1a

#### Accept him whose faith is weak,

- ¶ Concerning people/believers who have weaknesses/problems in their faith, accept<sup>(plur)</sup> them into your group/fellowship.
- ¶ But if someone believes in Jesus but is weak/immature in certain areas, you must welcome him.

This verse begins with the Greek conjunction that introduces a new topic that is related to the previous one. In many languages, no conjunction would imply that.

Some scholars see contrast here to 13:14. For example, Dunn translates the Greek word as:

But

**Accept him whose faith is weak:** In the Greek, the phrase translated him whose faith is weak occurs before the verb Accept to emphasize it. Some languages can put this phrase in front without those added words. For example:

the one who is weak in faith, welcome him

Some English versions add words to introduce this phrase. Some languages can follow these versions or use other words to introduce this phrase. For example:

Concerning the believer who does not yet understand well about the word he believes, there where you meet together give him a welcome. Otomi Back Translation on TW.

If there is a person whose faith is not yet mature or is weak, accept him. Kankanaey Back Translation on TW.

Other languages must put this phrase in its normal place for a natural translation. For example:

welcome the one whose faith is weak

**Accept:** The Greek word refers to bringing in someone into your group of friends and accepting him or her. Here are other ways to translate this word:

welcome (ESV)

receive well. Uma Back Translation on TW.

**him whose faith is weak:** This phrase refers to someone who has faith but believes that his faith limits what he can do. Paul called it weak because this person limits what he can do more than someone whose faith is not weak. Paul gave an example of this difference in faith in 14:2. Here is another way to translate this:

the one who is not strong in faith

#### 14:1b

**without passing judgment on his opinions.**

- But do not accept them just to argue with them about their thoughts that are different than yours.
- But do not welcome him into your group only so that you can argue with him about his thoughts on religious practices that are different than yours.

**without passing judgment on his opinions:** This is a purpose clause. Believers should not accept others into their group for the purpose of passing judgment on them.

There are two ways to interpret the Greek word that the BSB translates as passing judgment:

1. It means argue here. For example:

do not argue with them about their personal opinions (GNT) (RSV, NIV11, GNT, NJB, ESV, NABRE, NLT, GW, NET, NCV)

1. It means judge (as bad) here. For example:

criticize them for having beliefs that are different from yours (CEV) (BSB, NIV84, NASB, CEV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1), because the BDAG and L&N support it.

**opinions:** This word refers to an idea or belief about something based on personal preference or an interpretation of something true. For example, there may be many opinions about who should be Prime Minister or about why a car crashed. Here are other ways to translate this word:

thoughts/opinionsKankanaey Back Translation on TW.

their different thinkingsKamula Back Translation, PNG, unpublished manuscript.

## Romans 14:2

### Section 14:1–12: Do not judge/criticize fellow believers and do not despise them

In this section, Paul told his readers that they must accept other believers who are not strong in their faith. These other believers do things that are not based in their faith, hence they are “weak” in their faith. One example that Paul gave of this “weak” faith is someone who avoids meat because it has been devoted to the Roman gods.

Paul also told his readers to not argue over differences of opinion (14:1). In 14:5, he gave an example of this: some believers hold the holy days as something special but other believers do not. Paul reminded his readers that they all belong to the Lord Jesus.

Paul told his readers that they must not judge other believers to be bad people or despise them. He reminded them that they all will stand before God as their judge, and give an account of their deeds.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

Do not consider other believers to be bad people

Do not look down on other believers

#### 14:2a

**For one person has faith to eat all things,**

- One person/believer is convinced that he can eat any food,
- For example, some people truly/strongly think that God allows them to eat all kinds of foods.

This verse is an example of how strong believers are not to dispute with other believers who are weak in their faith about something (14:1). Moo (page 837) and Morris (page 478). In some languages it will be more clear to introduce this verse explicitly as an example. For example:

As an example, one person...

**For one person has faith to eat all things:** There are two ways to interpret the Greek here:

1. It refers to being convinced that it is OK to eat any food. For example:

Some people believe that they can eat all kinds of food (GW) (RSV, ESV, NABRE, KJV, NLT, GW, CEV, NET, NCV)

1. It indicates that his faith in God allows him to eat any food. For example:

Some people's faith allows them to eat anything (GNT) (BSB, NIV, GNT, NJB, REB)

The Greek to eat after faith supports interpretation (1), but the Greek "being weak" (14:1a, 2b) supports interpretation (2). Perhaps Paul intended both meanings, as Moo (page 837) suggests. If you must choose one interpretation, it is recommended that you follow interpretation (1), because the phrase to eat suggests this interpretation here.

**For one person has faith to eat:** The Greek and English here refers generally to anyone, man or woman. In some languages, the plural would more clearly refer to believers in general. For example:

Some people believe that they may eat anything

**has faith to eat:** Many Gentile believers did not feel compelled to follow the Jewish food restrictions.

**eat all things:** This phrase implies any food. It does not refer to items that are not food, like rocks and wood. For example:

any kind of food (GNT)

#### 14:2b

**while another, who is weak, eats only vegetables.**

- but a/another person/believer is weak in his faith and eats only garden food.
- But other people are not strong in the same way and eat only food from the garden.

**while another, who is weak:** The Greek is literally "but the one being weak." It contrasts to the person who believes in 14:2a. In some languages weak refers only to lack of physical strength. If that is true in your language, indicate the correct meaning. For example:

but the person who is not strong in faith

**another, who is weak:** If you translated with the plural for "one person" in 14:2a, you should use the plural here as well. See the above examples.

**vegetables:** The Greek word refers to any of the plants that people grew in their gardens, excluding trees and shrubs.

#### General Comment on 14:2a–b

By using the Greek word that means "vegetables," Paul went far beyond Jewish Christian concerns about meat from pagan meat markets. "Vegetables" may be an exaggeration for their position, but it is best not to mention "weak" Jewish Christians in this verse. This verse is an example of "strong" believers not disputing with "weak" believers about their "problem." Explaining the exact situation (even if we were certain what it was) is not important here.

#### Romans 14:3

##### Section 14:1–12: Do not judge/criticize fellow believers and do not despise them

In this section, Paul told his readers that they must accept other believers who are not strong in their faith. These other believers do things that are not based in their faith, hence they are "weak" in their faith. One example that Paul gave of this "weak" faith is someone who avoids meat because it has been devoted to the Roman gods.

Paul also told his readers to not argue over differences of opinion (14:1). In 14:5, he gave an example of this: some believers hold the holy days as something special but other believers do not. Paul reminded his readers that they all belong to the Lord Jesus.

Paul told his readers that they must not judge other believers to be bad people or despise them. He reminded them that they all will stand before God as their judge, and give an account of their deeds.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

Do not consider other believers to be bad people

Do not look down on other believers

#### 14:3a

**The one who eats everything must not belittle the one who does not,**

- The person/believer who eats all foods must not scorn the person/believer who does not eat all foods.
- One person/believer eats everything and another person/believer avoids certain foods. The first one must not think of the second one as being of little/no worth.

**The one who eats everything must not belittle:** This is a command to The one who eats. He or she must not despise those who think they must not eat certain foods. For example:

The one who eats must not despise (NABRE)

**The one who eats everything:** This phrase refers to the person who believes he can eat any food (14:2a). In some languages a literal translation would not make that meaning clear. If that is true in your language, make it clear. For example:

the one who eats anything

**belittle:** This word refers to considering someone to be worthless. Here are other ways to translate this word:

have contempt for

look down on (NLT)

call worthless

**the one who does not:** The Greek is literally “the one not eating.” It refers to the person who believes it is not right for him to eat certain foods, so he does not eat them. In some languages a literal translation would not make that meaning clear. If that is true in your language, make it clear.

the one who does not eat certain foods

the one who avoids some kinds of food

#### General Comment on 14:3a

The words “eats” and “does” are in the English present tense. They indicate what is usually done by these two people. In some languages using the way to indicate habitual action would be the best translation.

#### 14:3b

**and the one who does not eat everything must not judge the one who does,**

- And the person/believer who does not eat all foods must not condemn the person/believer who eats all foods,
- And the second one must not think that the first one is a bad person.

**judge:** Here this phrase refers to considering someone to be a bad person. It does not refer here to what a judge does in a courtroom. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

condemn (NIV)

consider as a bad person

criticize (GW)

#### 14:3c

**for God has accepted him.**

- because God has accepted that person.
- For God has welcomed them both into his kingdom.

**for:** Here this word introduces the reason why believers should not despise or pass judgment on other believers. For example:

because (NJB)

**accepted:** The Greek word refers to bringing in someone into your group of friends and accepting him or her. See how you translated this word in 14:1.

**him:** Here this word refers to both the believer who eats all foods and the believer who does not eat certain foods. It refers to both men and women. For example:

them (NIV11)

### Romans 14:4

**Section 14:1–12: Do not judge/criticize fellow believers and do not despise them**

In this section, Paul told his readers that they must accept other believers who are not strong in their faith. These other believers do things that are not based in their faith, hence they are “weak” in their faith. One example that Paul gave of this “weak” faith is someone who avoids meat because it has been devoted to the Roman gods.

Paul also told his readers to not argue over differences of opinion (14:1). In 14:5, he gave an example of this: some believers hold the holy days as something special but other believers do not. Paul reminded his readers that they all belong to the Lord Jesus.

Paul told his readers that they must not judge other believers to be bad people or despise them. He reminded them that they all will stand before God as their judge, and give an account of their deeds.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

Do not consider other believers to be bad people

Do not look down on other believers

#### 14:4a

#### Who are you to judge someone else's servant?

- Who do you<sup>(sing)</sup> think you are to condemn someone else's servant?
- It is not right for any of you<sup>(plur)</sup> to think that somebody else's worker is a bad person.

**Who are you to judge someone else's servant?:** This is a rhetorical question. It rebukes any believer who considers another believer to be bad because that believer does something that this believer does not do. It implies that the person this question is addressed to does not have the authority to judge the other believer. Here are some other ways to translate this:

- As a rhetorical question. For example:

Why do you think that you are someone with the authority to judge someone else's servant?

What right do you have to consider someone else's servant as a bad person?

- As a statement. For example:

You do not have the authority to judge someone else's servant!

You have no right to consider someone else's servant as a bad person.

- As a command. For example:

Do not think that you have the authority to judge someone else's servant!

Do not think that you have a right to consider someone else's servant as a bad person.

**you:** This word is emphatic in the Greek. It emphasizes that the person does not have that right, only God does. For example:

As for you, who are you...

**to judge:** See how you translated this phrase in 14:3b.

**someone else's servant:** It was well known that only the master had any authority over a servant. Here someone else refers to the Lord (14:4). A fellow

believer is the Lord's servant. If that is not clear in a literal translation, you may want to explain this in a footnote. Here is an example footnote:

Here the phrase "someone else" refers to the Lord (14:4).

**servant:** The Greek word here refers to a servant whom the master considers to be one of the household. A slave was not usually considered one of the household. Your language may have a word for this special kind of servant.

#### 14:4b

#### To his own master he stands or falls.

- To his own lord/leader he stands or falls.
- His own boss is the one who says he has done right or not.

**To his own master he stands or falls:** The phrase To his own master is emphasized by being first in the clause. Some languages can emphasize this phrase in the same way as the Greek. For example:

before his own master he stands or falls

But some languages cannot move this phrase to the front of the clause. If that is true in your language, if possible, emphasize the clause in a natural way. For example:

If he stands or falls, it is to his own master

he stands or falls indeed only to his own master

**master:** The Greek word here is usually translated "lord." It refers to someone who has authority over someone else, like a ruler or the leader of the family living in that house.

Paul here was referring generally to masters and servants. He explained in particular who he was referring to in 14:4d, so you should not need to explain it here.

**he stands or falls:** Here the word stands is a figure of speech that refers to the master saying the servant has done right. Here the word falls is a figure of speech that refers to the master saying the servant has done wrong. Moo (page 857) and Schreiner (page 718).

In some languages a literal translation would not have the correct meaning. If that is true in your language, you may want to:

- Translate the meaning without the figures of speech. For example:

he is told he has done right or not

his master says that he has done right or he has done wrong

- Translate literally and explain it in a footnote. Here is an example footnote:

Here the word “stands” refers to the master saying that the servant has done right and the word “falls” refers to the master saying that the servant has done wrong.

#### 14:4c

##### **And he will stand,**

- And he will be considered to have stood,
- And his own boss, the Lord, will say to him that he is approved/accepted,

**And he will stand:** In Greek, this clause is passive. Some languages must use an active clause. For example:

his master will uphold him

the Lord will uphold him

**will:** It is not clear when in the future the Lord would uphold his servant. It could be at some time in the life of the servant on earth, or it could be when God judges believers in the great judgment. Use the grammar in your language that indicates generally a future time.

**stand:** Here this phrase refers to indicating that someone is accepted or approved. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

what he is doing will of course be approved as right  
Kankanaey Back Translation on TW.

be established as approved

#### 14:4d

##### **for the Lord is able to make him stand.**

- for the Lord can make him stand.
- because the Lord Jesus has the ability/power to help him so that he is approved/accepted.

**the Lord:** There is a textual issue in 14:4d: (1) Some Greek manuscripts have the word Lord (BSB, RSV, NIV, GNT, NJB, NASB, NABRE, ESV, REB, NLT, GW, NET, NCV). (2) Some later Greek manuscripts have the word God (KJV only). It is recommended that you follow option (1). See how you translated the word Lord in 1:4 or 13:14. It is not clear whether it refers to God or Jesus here. It probably refers to Jesus, since God is mentioned in 14:3 using the Greek word for God.

**to make him stand:** The Greek word that the BSB translates as to make...stand is the same word that the BSB translates as “stand” in 14:4c. You should translate it similarly to how you translated it there. For example:

to approve as right what he is doing

to establish as approved

## Romans 14:5

### **Section 14:1–12: Do not judge/criticize fellow believers and do not despise them**

In this section, Paul told his readers that they must accept other believers who are not strong in their faith. These other believers do things that are not based in their faith, hence they are “weak” in their faith. One example that Paul gave of this “weak” faith is someone who avoids meat because it has been devoted to the Roman gods.

Paul also told his readers to not argue over differences of opinion (14:1). In 14:5, he gave an example of this: some believers hold the holy days as something special but other believers do not. Paul reminded his readers that they all belong to the Lord Jesus.

Paul told his readers that they must not judge other believers to be bad people or despise them. He reminded them that they all will stand before God as their judge, and give an account of their deeds.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

Do not consider other believers to be bad people

Do not look down on other believers

#### 14:5a–c

**One person regards a certain day above the others, while someone else considers every day alike. Each one should be fully convinced in his own mind:** Paul wrote here about believers. At least, the command,

Each one should be fully convinced in his own mind (14:5c), is to believers. For example:

Some of the Lord's followers think one day is more important than another. Others think all days are the same. But each of you should make up your own mind. (CEV)

Some people think that a certain day is more important than other days, while others think that all days are the same. We each should firmly make up our own minds. (GNT)

#### 14:5a

**One person regards a certain day above the others,**

- ¶ One person thinks/believes that one day is more important than another day,
- ¶ Some believers consider some days are more holy than others.

**regards:** Here the Greek word refers to deciding that one thing is better than another. For example, some believers said that the Sabbath was more holy than the other days. Here are other ways to translate this word:

prefers

think...more important (GNT)

considers...more sacred (NIV)

#### 14:5b

**while someone else considers every day alike.**

- and another person thinks/believes that every day is important.
- But other believers consider that all days are equally important.

**while:** The Greek word here is usually translated “and” or “but.” The connection indicates that the two different things both occur. Use whatever is most natural in your language. For example:

and (NJB)

but

Another person... (GW)

**considers every day alike:** The Greek is literally “esteems every day.” This kind of believer believes each day is equally important.

#### 14:5c

**Each one should be fully convinced in his own mind.**

- Each person must be certain of what they think about it.
- I want each one of you to be completely sure of his opinion.

**Each one should be fully convinced in his own mind:**

The Greek is a command to be fully convinced. For example:

Each person must be fully convinced in his own mind. (NASB)

And they must make their thinking strong about these things.

In some languages it is not natural to command someone to think a certain way. In that case, use the words or grammar to indicate or imply a command here. For example:

Let every one be fully convinced in his own mind. (RSV)

Each person's mind must/should be fully convinced.

So, each of them must be in the state of firmly believing that it is right for them to think like that.

**be fully convinced in his own mind:** Being convinced of something occurs in the mind. In some languages, it is more natural to not translate the phrase in his own mind. For example:

be fully convinced (NLT)

**be fully convinced:** This phrase means “completely sure about something.” Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

be absolutely sure

be certain

See how you translated “fully persuaded” in 4:21.

## Romans 14:6

### Section 14:1–12: Do not judge/criticize fellow believers and do not despise them

In this section, Paul told his readers that they must accept other believers who are not strong in their faith. These other believers do things that are not based in their faith, hence they are “weak” in their faith. One example that Paul gave of this “weak” faith is someone who avoids meat because it has been devoted to the Roman gods.

Paul also told his readers to not argue over differences of opinion (14:1). In 14:5, he gave an example of this: some believers hold the holy days as something special but other believers do not. Paul reminded his readers that they all belong to the Lord Jesus.

Paul told his readers that they must not judge other believers to be bad people or despise them. He reminded them that they all will stand before God as their judge, and give an account of their deeds.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

Do not consider other believers to be bad people

Do not look down on other believers

#### 14:6a

#### He who observes a special day does so to the Lord;

- The person who regards those days as special/important, when he does that, he honors the Lord.
- Some believers put high status on some days. When they put high status on them, that honors the Lord.

**observes:** The Greek verb means “acknowledging the importance of something” (BDAG) or “to acknowledge the high status of (an) event” (L&N). Here are other ways to translate this word:

regards...as special (NIV)

think highly of (GNT)

**a special day:** This refers to the days that some believers think are more important than other days (14:5a). Your translation should refer to that day. For example:

that day

those special days

**does so to the Lord:** There is a textual issue in 14:6b: (1) Some Greek manuscripts have the words observes to the Lord (BSB, RSV, NIV, GNT, NJB, NASB, NABRE, ESV, REB, NLT, GW, NET, NCV). (2) Some later Greek manuscripts have the words observes to the Lord, and the one who does not observe the day, does not observe it to the Lord (KJV only). It is recommended that you follow option (1). This clause indicates that these believers honor the Lord by observing the days they think are special.

**the Lord:** This probably refers to Jesus. In some languages it is more natural to put a name to this title. For example:

the Lord Jesus

#### 14:6b

#### he who eats does so to the Lord,

- And the one who eats any food, when he does that, he honors the Lord,
- And, some believers eat all kinds of food. When they eat, that honors the Lord.

#### 14:6c

#### for he gives thanks to God;

- because he thanks God for it.
- For they thank God for that food.

#### 14:6b–c

**he who eats:** This refers to the believer who eats all foods (14:2a). In some languages a literal translation here would refer to anyone who eats, that is, everyone. If that is true in your language, make the connection to 14:2 clear. For example:

The one who eats anything

The one who eats all kinds of food

You may want to translate here in the same way you translated “eat all things” in 14:2a.

#### 14:6d

#### and he who abstains does so to the Lord

- And the one who does not eat some foods, when he avoids those foods, he honors the Lord
- And, some believers avoid certain foods. When they avoid them, that honors the Lord,

#### 14:6e

#### and gives thanks to God.

- and thanks God.
- and they thank God for the foods they eat.



**14:6d–e**

**and:** The Greek word here is usually translated and or “but.” The connection indicates that the two different things both occur. Use whatever is most natural in your language. For example:

while (ESV)

but

Another person...

**he who abstains:** The Greek is literally “the one not eating.” It refers to the person who eats only vegetables (14:2b–3b). See how you translated this phrase in 14:3.

**Romans 14:7****Section 14:1–12: Do not judge/criticize fellow believers and do not despise them**

In this section, Paul told his readers that they must accept other believers who are not strong in their faith. These other believers do things that are not based in their faith, hence they are “weak” in their faith. One example that Paul gave of this “weak” faith is someone who avoids meat because it has been devoted to the Roman gods.

Paul also told his readers to not argue over differences of opinion (14:1). In 14:5, he gave an example of this: some believers hold the holy days as something special but other believers do not. Paul reminded his readers that they all belong to the Lord Jesus.

Paul told his readers that they must not judge other believers to be bad people or despise them. He reminded them that they all will stand before God as their judge, and give an account of their deeds.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

Do not consider other believers to be bad people

Do not look down on other believers

**14:7a****For none of us lives to himself alone,**

- For not one of us lives merely to benefit himself,
- For none of us lives for ourselves,

**14:7b****and none of us dies to himself alone.**

- and not one of us can die to benefit himself.

- and not one of us dies for ourselves.

**14:7a–b**

**For:** Here this word introduces an explanation of 14:6 or introduces support for it. Moo (page 844) and Cranfield (page 707), respectively.

**none of us lives to himself alone, and none of us dies to himself alone:**

Here the phrase to himself refers to regarding his own will. Here are other ways to translate these clauses:

not one person among us lives only for his own sake. Like that, not one person among us will die only for his own sake

Not one of us lives for the sake of himself/herself, and not one of us will die for the sake of himself/herself either

**Romans 14:8****Section 14:1–12: Do not judge/criticize fellow believers and do not despise them**

In this section, Paul told his readers that they must accept other believers who are not strong in their faith. These other believers do things that are not based in their faith, hence they are “weak” in their faith. One example that Paul gave of this “weak” faith is someone who avoids meat because it has been devoted to the Roman gods.

Paul also told his readers to not argue over differences of opinion (14:1). In 14:5, he gave an example of this: some believers hold the holy days as something special but other believers do not. Paul reminded his readers that they all belong to the Lord Jesus.

Paul told his readers that they must not judge other believers to be bad people or despise them. He reminded them that they all will stand before God as their judge, and give an account of their deeds.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

Do not consider other believers to be bad people

Do not look down on other believers

**14:8a****If we live, we live to the Lord,**

- For when we remain alive, we benefit the Lord,
- That is true because, while we live, we live for the Lord,

**If:** Here this word introduces an explanation of 14:7. Moo (page 844).

**we live, we live to the Lord:** Here the phrase to the Lord refers to benefiting the Lord. When we are alive, we do what the Lord tells us to do. This honors him. Here are other ways to translate these clauses:

while we are alive, we are living for the Lord (NJB)

If we live, we honor the Lord (GW)

when we live, we live for the sake of the Lord

Translate the word to in a similar way to how you translated it in 14:7.

#### 14:8b

**and if we die, we die to the Lord.**

- and when we die, we benefit the Lord.
- and when we die, we die for the Lord.

**if we die, we die to the Lord:** This refers to the end of our life on earth. The phrase to the Lord again refers to benefiting the Lord. When we die, this honors the Lord, because we die believing in him. Here are other ways to translate these clauses:

when we die, we die for the Lord (NJB)

if we die, we honor the Lord (GW)

when we die, we die for the sake of the Lord

If possible, translate the word to in a similar way to how you translated it in 14:8a.

#### 14:8c

**So whether we live or die, we belong to the Lord.**

- Therefore, if we live or die, we belong to the Lord.
- So if we live or if we die, we are the Lord Jesus's very own possession.

**So whether:** The Greek word here is usually translated as "therefore," as the NASB does.

**we belong to the Lord:** This clause indicates that we belong to the Lord Jesus. For example:

we are the Lord's (ESV)

## Romans 14:9

### Section 14:1–12: Do not judge/criticize fellow believers and do not despise them

In this section, Paul told his readers that they must accept other believers who are not strong in their faith. These other believers do things that are not based in their faith, hence they are "weak" in their faith. One example that Paul gave of this "weak" faith is someone who avoids meat because it has been devoted to the Roman gods.

Paul also told his readers to not argue over differences of opinion (14:1). In 14:5, he gave an example of this: some believers hold the holy days as something special but other believers do not. Paul reminded his readers that they all belong to the Lord Jesus.

Paul told his readers that they must not judge other believers to be bad people or despise them. He reminded them that they all will stand before God as their judge, and give an account of their deeds.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

Do not consider other believers to be bad people

Do not look down on other believers

#### 14:9a

**For this reason Christ died and returned to life,**

- For Christ died and then lived again for this goal,
- And we are the Lord's on the basis of Christ dying and living again,

This verse begins with a Greek conjunction that is often translated as "for." Here this word introduces the basis for what Paul said in 14:8. Witherington (page 337). Some translations, such as the BSB, leave this word implicit and allow the context to imply the connection.

**For this reason Christ died and returned to life:**

There is a textual issue in 14:9a: (1) Some Greek manuscripts have the words died and lived (BSB, RSV, NIV, GNT, NJB, NASB, NABRE, ESV, REB, NLT, GW, NET, NCV). The Greek grammar indicates that the word "lived" refers to his life after his death. (2) Some later Greek manuscripts have the words died and arose and lived again (KJV only). It is recommended that you follow option (1). The Greek is more literally "to/for this Christ died and lived." The phrase "to/for this" indicates that the purpose of Jesus dying and living again was so that he would be lord of all believers, both those living and those who die. The purpose of Jesus dying and

living again was accomplished at that time. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

Christ died and then lived so that

Christ died and then lived, and so

#### 14:9b

**that He might be the Lord of both the dead and the living.**

- that he would rule over both the people who have died and those who live.
- and so he rules both people who have died and people who live.

**that He might be the Lord of both the dead and the living:** This is a purpose clause. This purpose was fulfilled when Jesus died and God resurrected him. In some languages a result clause must be used to indicate that the purpose was fulfilled. For example:

and so he became Lord both of the dead and of the living

**be the Lord:** This phrase refers to ruling over someone. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

establish his lordship over (REB)

rule Western Bukidnon Manobo Back Translation on TW.

is our Leader Yakan Back Translation on TW.

## Romans 14:10

**Section 14:1–12: Do not judge/criticize fellow believers and do not despise them**

In this section, Paul told his readers that they must accept other believers who are not strong in their faith. These other believers do things that are not based in their faith, hence they are “weak” in their faith. One example that Paul gave of this “weak” faith is someone who avoids meat because it has been devoted to the Roman gods.

Paul also told his readers to not argue over differences of opinion (14:1). In 14:5, he gave an example of this: some believers hold the holy days as something special but other believers do not. Paul reminded his readers that they all belong to the Lord Jesus.

Paul told his readers that they must not judge other believers to be bad people or despise them. He reminded them that they all will stand before God as their judge, and give an account of their deeds.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

Do not consider other believers to be bad people

Do not look down on other believers

#### 14:10a

**Why, then, do you judge your brother?**

- ¶ Why then, do you<sup>(sing)</sup> condemn your fellow believer?
- ¶ None of you<sup>(plur)</sup> should think of your brother or sister in Christ as a bad person.

**Why, then, do you judge your brother?:** This is a rhetorical question. It emphasizes that believers should not judge another believer. It is a rebuke to anyone who does that. Here are some ways to translate that meaning:

- As a rhetorical question. For example:

why do you judge your brother or sister? (NIV11)

Why do you think it is right to consider a fellow believer to be a bad person?

- As a statement. For example:

You have no reason to judge your brother or sister as a bad person!

You have no reason to consider a fellow believer to be a bad person.

- As a command. For example:

Do not think that you have a good reason to judge your brother or sister as a bad person!

Do not think that you have a good reason to consider a fellow believer to be a bad person.

**then:** The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as then is often translated as “but” or “and.” However, this verse uses some of the wording from 14:3 and exhorts believers to not pass judgment on a fellow

believer or despise him or her. So, the BSB uses then to indicate that Paul is returning to those thoughts. Here is another way to express the idea:

You, then, why... (NIV)

**do you judge:** Here this phrase refers to considering someone to be a bad person. It does not refer here to what a judge does in a courtroom. See how you translated this phrase in 14:3b.

**you:** This word is emphasized in the Greek by being first in the clause. If possible, emphasize this word. For example:

As for you, why do you...

Hey you, why do you...

**brother:** Here this word refers to any believer living in Rome, either man or woman. See how you translated this word in 1:13 or 12:1.

By using the singular brother, Paul referred generally to any believer, where the plural might imply all the believers in Rome. In some languages a simple singular might indicate that Paul was thinking of one specific person. If that is true in your language, translate in a way that can refer generally to one or a few. For example:

some of you, brothers,

#### 14:10b

##### Or why do you belittle your brother?

- Or why do you scorn your fellow believer?
- And none of you should think of your brother or sister in Christ as being of little/no worth.

**Or why do you:** The Greek is more literally “Or and/ indeed why do you.” The word “and/indeed” emphasizes the following question.

**you:** This word is emphasized in the Greek, as it is in 14:10a.

**why do you belittle your brother?:** This is a rhetorical question with the same emphasis as the rhetorical question in 14:10a, except that the word belittle is used here instead of “pass judgment.” Translate this rhetorical question in the same way you did in 14:10, except for the word belittle here.

**belittle:** This word refers to considering someone to be worthless. See how you translated this word in 14:3a.

#### 14:10c

##### For we will all stand before God’s judgment seat.

- For we will all stand before God, and he will judge us.
- For, one day, when the time comes for God to judge everyone, we will all stand before him, and he will judge our lives.

**For:** Here this word introduces the reason for not despising or passing judgment on a brother.

**we will all stand before God’s judgment seat:** There is a textual issue in 14:10c: (1) Some Greek manuscripts have the word God (BSB, RSV, NIV, GNT, NJB, NASB, NABRE, ESV, REB, NLT, GW, NET, NCV). (2) Some later Greek manuscripts have the word Christ (KJV only). It is recommended that you follow option (1). This refers to standing before God when he will judge us on the final judgment day. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

All of us will stand before God to be judged by him. (GNT)

The day is coming when God will judge all of us. (CEV)

## Romans 14:11

### Section 14:1–12: Do not judge/criticize fellow believers and do not despise them

In this section, Paul told his readers that they must accept other believers who are not strong in their faith. These other believers do things that are not based in their faith, hence they are “weak” in their faith. One example that Paul gave of this “weak” faith is someone who avoids meat because it has been devoted to the Roman gods.

Paul also told his readers to not argue over differences of opinion (14:1). In 14:5, he gave an example of this: some believers hold the holy days as something special but other believers do not. Paul reminded his readers that they all belong to the Lord Jesus.

Paul told his readers that they must not judge other believers to be bad people or despise them. He reminded them that they all will stand before God as their judge, and give an account of their deeds.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

Do not consider other believers to be bad people

Do not look down on other believers

#### 14:11a

**It is written: “As surely as I live, says the Lord,**

- For some words that were written long ago say, “The Lord says, ‘Just as it is certain that I live,
- For the Scripture says, “The Lord God says, ‘In the same way that it is true that I live,

**It is written:** Here these words introduce support for what Paul said in 14:10c. This clause also introduces a quote from Scripture. The main part of the quote is from Isaiah 45:23, with “As I live, says the Lord” possibly from Isaiah 49:18 or a number of other places in the Old Testament.

The book of Isaiah was written hundreds of years before Paul wrote the letter to the Romans. In some languages a literal translation would wrongly indicate the quote was written at the same time as Paul wrote here. If that is true in your language, indicate that the quote was written long before Paul wrote. For example:

It was written long ago

This clause refers to what was written in the Old Testament. Some languages must make that explicit to be clear. For example:

The scripture says (GNT)

This clause is passive. Some languages must use an active clause here. For example:

Isaiah/someone wrote long ago

What God caused to be written saying,

It says in the Holy Book

See how you translated this clause in 1:17 or 12:19.

**As surely as I live, says the Lord:** In the Greek, the phrase says the Lord occurs in the middle of spoken words. In many languages this phrase must occur before the spoken words. For example:

The Lord says, ‘As I live,

**As surely as I live:** This is an oath. It indicates that in the same way that it is true that God lives, what he

says after is also true. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

As I live (ESV)

As certainly as I live (GW)

**the Lord:** The word Lord refers to someone who has authority over people. Here this phrase refers to God. In some languages it is more natural to indicate who this Lord is. For example:

the Lord God

See how you translated the word Lord in 4:8 or 12:19.

#### 14:11b

**every knee will bow before Me;**

- it will be to me that every knee shall bow,
- I am the one to whom every person will bow down,

14:11b–c is a quote from Isaiah 45:23. If you indicate the location of quotes from the Old Testament with cross-references, you may want to do so here.

**every knee will bow before Me:** This clause is more literally “every knee will bend to me.” This refers to kneeling. Here kneeling indicates that these people submit to God. In some languages a literal translation would indicate a different meaning. If that is true in your language, you may want to:

- Explain in the text. For example:

everyone shall bow in submission to me

- Translate literally and explain the meaning in a footnote. Here is an example footnote:

This clause indicates that people will kneel in submission to God.

**every knee:** This phrase implies every person. For example:

everyone (GNT)

**will:** The Greek is the future tense. It is a prophecy and implies that this will certainly happen.

**bow:** This word implies that the person bowing acknowledges that the person he is bowing to has greater status, power, or authority. Use a word or phrase with that meaning.

**before Me:** This phrase is emphasized in the Greek by being first in the clause. If possible emphasize this phrase. For example:

to me every knee shall bow

every knee shall bow, behold/hey, to me

every knee shall bow to me and me alone

#### 14:11c

**every tongue will confess to God.”**

- and every mouth will praise God.”
- and every person will praise God.”

**(RSV:) and every tongue shall give praise to God:**

There are three ways to interpret the Greek word that the RSV translates as give praise:

1. It means to praise here. For example:

everyone will praise God (GW) (RSV, NJB, NABRE, NASB, NLT, GW, CEV, NET)

1. It means to confess something here. For example:

every tongue will confess to God (NIV) (BSB, NIV, ESV, KJV)

1. It means to acknowledge that God is the one and only true God. For example:

every tongue will acknowledge God (NIV11) (NIV11, GNT, REB, NCV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1), because BDAG chooses it. Cranfield, Dunn, and Moo also support interpretation (1) in their translations.

**(RSV:) every tongue:** This phrase implies every person. For example:

everyone (GNT)

**(RSV:) shall:** The Greek is the future tense. As a prophecy it is implied here that this will certainly happen.

## Romans 14:12

**Section 14:1–12: Do not judge/criticize fellow believers and do not despise them**

In this section, Paul told his readers that they must accept other believers who are not strong in their faith. These other believers do things that are not based in their faith, hence they are “weak” in their faith. One example that Paul gave of this “weak” faith is someone who avoids meat because it has been devoted to the Roman gods.

Paul also told his readers to not argue over differences of opinion (14:1). In 14:5, he gave an example of this: some believers hold the holy days as something special but other believers do not. Paul reminded his readers that they all belong to the Lord Jesus.

Paul told his readers that they must not judge other believers to be bad people or despise them. He reminded them that they all will stand before God as their judge, and give an account of their deeds.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

Do not consider other believers to be bad people

Do not look down on other believers

#### 14:12

**So then, each of us will give an account of himself to God.**

- Therefore, every one of us<sup>(incl)</sup> will have to tell God why we did what we did.
- So each of us will answer to God when he judges our lives.

**So then:** This phrase introduces the logical conclusion of what Paul wrote in 14:10–11.

**give an account of himself to God:** This refers to explaining to God why you did what you did in this life. Here are other ways to translate these words:

each of us will have to give answers for our lives to God

every one of us must answer God’s questions about our behaviorUma Back Translation on TW.

each one of us will face God and tell him what we have done

He will check up on us and we will have to tell Him about everything that we did here on the earthWestern Bikidnon Manobo Back Translation on TW.

## Romans 14:13

### Section 14:13–23: Do not cause others to sin

In this section, Paul told the believers in Rome to stop considering some of their fellow believers as bad people. Instead they should choose not to hinder them. He told them that God does not consider any kind of food or any other kind of thing as not acceptable, but people who think that that food or thing is unacceptable, they should not eat it or use it. But those who find those things acceptable, they should not hurt the faith of those who find those things unacceptable. Righteousness, peace, and joy are the important things in God's kingdom, not what you eat or drink. God is pleased when those who follow Jesus live in that way.

Paul encouraged the believers to do things that bring peace and encouragement for each other. They are not to hurt other believers over what they eat. They are not to cause other believers to stumble in their faith because of what they eat. Foods that might cause problems for other believers are to be eaten privately. A believer should not eat food if he has doubts about whether he should eat it or not. Everything that is not done in faith is sin.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

Do Not Cause Another to Stumble (ESV)

Don't Cause Problems for Others (CEV)

### 14:13a

#### Therefore let us stop judging one another.

- ¶ So, we<sup>(incl)</sup> must stop condemning each other.
- ¶ So then, we must no longer think that other believers are bad people.

**Therefore:** Here the Greek word introduces a summary of 14:1–12.

**let us stop judging one another:** This clause indicates that Paul wanted the believers to stop passing judgment on other believers. He included himself in this command. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

we<sup>(incl)</sup> must no longer condemn one another

we must stop considering each other as bad people

let's stop criticizing each other (GW)

**us:** Here this word refers to Paul and all the believers in Rome. It does not refer to only one group of believers in Rome, as it did in 14:2a or 14:2b.

**judging:** Here this phrase refers to considering someone to be a bad person. See how you translated this phrase in 14:3 or 14:10.

### 14:13b

#### Instead, make up your mind

- Instead, we must choose to do this:
- We must think like this:

**Instead:** This indicates contrast to passing judgment on one another. But the command in 14:13a is to stop passing judgment. So in some languages indicating contrast would confuse the connection. If that is true in your language, translate without the contrast. For example:

And/Also

Like-that, studiously make the mindset...Yongkom Back Translation, by author, unpublished manuscript, Papua New Guinea.

We-inc should thinkRamoaina Back Translation, Lisbeth Fritzell & Robyn Davies, unpublished manuscript, Papua New Guinea.

**make up your mind:** This word refers to thinking about something and choosing a way to think about it or do something about it. Here are other ways to translate this word:

choose

be determined

decide (ESV)

The Greek here has the word "this" as well. It refers to 14:13c and emphasizes that meaning. For example:

decide this: never put a stumbling block or hindrance in the way of a brother

**14:13c****not to put any stumbling block or obstacle in your brother's way.**

- Do not put in front of a fellow believer something like a rock/root to make him stumble or something like a trap to make him sin.
- We must not do anything that will cause a brother or sister in Christ to have trouble in their faith or to sin.

**not to:** The Greek is simply the word not.

**any stumbling block:** This phrase refers to something that causes someone to stumble or trip. Here it is a metaphor that refers to doing anything that causes someone else to sin. Translate in a way that clearly indicates the meaning. Here are some ways:

- Change the metaphor to a simile. For example:

something like a stumbling block

- Translate the meaning without the figure of speech. For example:

upset anyone's faith (CEV)

- Your language may have a cultural item that will have the same meaning as this metaphor.

a root/rock to stumble on

**obstacle:** The Greek word here refers to a trap. Here it is a metaphor that refers to doing anything that causes someone to do the wrong thing. Translate in a way that clearly indicates the meaning. Here are some ways:

**General Comment on 14:13c**

- Use the literal sense of the Greek word. For example:

a trap (NET)

- Change the metaphor to a simile and possibly explain why they are similar in your translation. For example:

something like a trap that causes temptation

- Translate the meaning without the figure of speech. For example:

temptation

The meaning of the metaphor of a stumbling block is similar to the meaning of the metaphor of a obstacle/trap. In some languages it is more natural to translate the meaning with one word or phrase. For example:

Let us earnestly see to it that it is not our fault that our brothers should sin.Otomi Back Translation on TW.

caused to sinYakan Back Translation on TW.

**Romans 14:14****Section 14:13–23: Do not cause others to sin**

In this section, Paul told the believers in Rome to stop considering some of their fellow believers as bad people. Instead they should choose not to hinder them. He told them that God does not consider any kind of food or any other kind of thing as not acceptable, but people who think that that food or thing is unacceptable, they should not eat it or use it. But those who find those things acceptable, they should not hurt the faith of those who find those things unacceptable. Righteousness, peace, and joy are the important things in God's kingdom, not what you eat or drink. God is pleased when those who follow Jesus live in that way.

Paul encouraged the believers to do things that bring peace and encouragement for each other. They are not to hurt other believers over what they eat. They are not to cause other believers to stumble in their faith because of what they eat. Foods that might cause problems for other believers are to be eaten privately. A believer should not eat food if he has doubts about whether he should eat it or not. Everything that is not done in faith is sin.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

Do Not Cause Another to Stumble (ESV)

Don't Cause Problems for Others (CEV)

**14:14a****I am convinced and fully persuaded in the Lord Jesus**

- In the Lord Jesus I understand and am certain
- The Lord Jesus has given me knowledge and I am convinced

**I am convinced and fully persuaded:** The word I is not repeated in English for a natural translation. In some



languages the word must be repeated for a natural translation. For example:

I know and I believe in my heartUma Back Translation on TW.

**convinced:** The Greek word refers to understanding something.

**fully persuaded:** The Greek word here refers to being certain something is true. It implies that the person is certain based on his own thinking about it. See BDAG, sense 4, as opposed to sense (3). Paul thought about what believers should call unclean and became convinced that they should not call anything unclean. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

am convinced (NASB)

am certain

**in the Lord Jesus:** Here the word in indicates that Paul's knowledge and certainty are connected to the Lord Jesus. In particular, that knowledge and certainty came from his relationship to Jesus.

#### 14:14b

**that nothing is unclean in itself.**

- that there is no thing that is wrong/evil in its nature.
- that no thing can make us bad before God.

**nothing is unclean in itself:** Here the word nothing refers to food. There is no food that is unclean in itself. There is nothing in the characteristics of some foods that makes them unclean. For example:

no food, in and of itself, is wrong to eat (NLT)

**unclean:** Here this word refers to something which is not fitting for use in serving or worshiping God. Here are other ways to translate this word:

ritually unclean (GNT)

unacceptable (GW)

impure (REB)

#### 14:14c

**But if anyone regards something as unclean, then for him it is unclean.**

- But if someone thinks something is wrong/evil in its nature, then that thing is wrong for him.
- But if some believers think something will make them bad, then it is bad for them to use it or do it.

**But if anyone regards something as unclean, then**

**for him it is unclean:** If a believer thinks that a kind of food would make them bad before God, he should not eat it. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

if anyone regards something as unclean, then for him it is unclean (NIV)

it is unacceptable to a person who thinks it is (GW)

**unclean:** Here this word has the same meaning as in 14:14b.

## Romans 14:15

### Section 14:13–23: Do not cause others to sin

In this section, Paul told the believers in Rome to stop considering some of their fellow believers as bad people. Instead they should choose not to hinder them. He told them that God does not consider any kind of food or any other kind of thing as not acceptable, but people who think that that food or thing is unacceptable, they should not eat it or use it. But those who find those things acceptable, they should not hurt the faith of those who find those things unacceptable. Righteousness, peace, and joy are the important things in God's kingdom, not what you eat or drink. God is pleased when those who follow Jesus live in that way.

Paul encouraged the believers to do things that bring peace and encouragement for each other. They are not to hurt other believers over what they eat. They are not to cause other believers to stumble in their faith because of what they eat. Foods that might cause problems for other believers are to be eaten privately. A believer should not eat food if he has doubts about whether he should eat it or not. Everything that is not done in faith is sin.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

Do Not Cause Another to Stumble (ESV)

Don't Cause Problems for Others (CEV)

#### 14:15a

**If your brother is distressed by what you eat,**

- Don't be a hindrance for/because if your brother or sister is upset because of what you eat,
- If a fellow believer sees you<sup>(sing)</sup> eating certain kinds of food and that makes him feel sad and hurt,

The Greek of 14:15a begins with a word that is often translated as “for.” There is a textual issue in 14:15: (1) Some Greek manuscripts have the word for (NASB, ESV, NET). (2) Some later Greek manuscripts have the word and/but (KJV only). It is recommended that you follow option (1). Many English versions chose not to translate this word here, and a few chose a different word or phrase, perhaps because of the context. This word introduces an explanation of 14:13b–c. See Moo (page 853), Morris, (page 487), Cranfield (page 714), or Dunn (page 820). But with 14:14 occurring in between, some English versions omit this word, as the BSB does.

**brother:** Here this word refers to another believer, either man or woman. Here are other ways to translate this word:

another believer (NLT)

others (GNT)

**is distressed:** This word refers to being sad and distressed about something. It does not refer here to being sad because someone has died.

#### 14:15b

**you are no longer acting in love.**

- you are no longer walking according to the ways of loving people.
- then in this life you live, you<sup>(sing)</sup> have stopped loving people.

**you are no longer acting in love:** Here the Greek word that the BSB translates as acting is literally “walking/ living.” It is a figure of speech that refers to all that a person does, thinks, and says. Here are some ways to translate this clause:

- Use the figure of speech, if it has the correct meaning. For example:

you are no longer walking according to the behavior of loving others

- Translate the meaning without the figure of speech, as the BSB does. For example:

your conduct is no longer in accord with love (NABRE)

you are no longer living your life according to love

you are no longer loving others as you live on this earth

**you are no longer acting:** The words no longer indicate that earlier the person was walking in love but now is not doing that. The present tense indicates that this is how the person lives at this time. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

you have stopped acting

you stopped living your life

you have stopped loving others as you live on this earth

**in love:** The Greek word that the BSB translates as in is literally “according to.” The phrase refers to loving others. See the examples above.

#### 14:15c

**Do not by your eating destroy your brother, for whom Christ died.**

- Do not destroy the one for whom Christ died by the things he sees you eat.
- Jesus Christ died for that believer to save him. So, do not ruin his faith by eating foods in front of him which he thinks are forbidden.

**Do not by your eating destroy your brother, for whom Christ died:** In the Greek of 14:15c, the phrase by your eating is in the front of the clause to emphasize it (see the ESV). If possible, emphasize this phrase in a natural way in your language.

**by your eating:** This refers to food that some believers think it is not right for believers to eat. In particular, some Jewish believers in Jesus still followed the Jewish rules about food. So there were many foods in Rome that they believed it was not right to eat. But Roman believers did not follow the Jewish rules about food and ate those foods. Paul just said it was okay to eat such foods, but we must think of the Jewish believers because it would be a sin for them to eat those foods. Paul probably wrote about the weekly meal the believers ate together at their worship time. Jewett (page 861). So all believers would see all the various kinds of food that everyone brought.

Some of this information may be needed to make the meaning clear in your translation. For example:

By what you eat in front of other believers

**destroy:** Here this refers to ruining a believer's faith so that he falls at the final judgment of God. Here are other ways to translate this word:

cause the ruin of (RSV)

be the ruin of (REB)

destroy the faith of Kankanaey Back Translation on TW.

**your brother, for whom Christ died:** This indicates that Jesus died to save this believer. In some languages the purpose of dying would make the meaning more clear. For example:

your brother, for whom Christ died so that he could save him

## Romans 14:16

### Section 14:13–23: Do not cause others to sin

In this section, Paul told the believers in Rome to stop considering some of their fellow believers as bad people. Instead they should choose not to hinder them. He told them that God does not consider any kind of food or any other kind of thing as not acceptable, but people who think that that food or thing is unacceptable, they should not eat it or use it. But those who find those things acceptable, they should not hurt the faith of those who find those things unacceptable. Righteousness, peace, and joy are the important things in God's kingdom, not what you eat or drink. God is pleased when those who follow Jesus live in that way.

Paul encouraged the believers to do things that bring peace and encouragement for each other. They are not to hurt other believers over what they eat. They are not to cause other believers to stumble in their faith because of what they eat. Foods that might cause problems for other believers are to be eaten privately. A believer should not eat food if he has doubts about whether he should eat it or not. Everything that is not done in faith is sin.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

Do Not Cause Another to Stumble (ESV)

Don't Cause Problems for Others (CEV)

### 14:16

**Do not allow what you consider good, then, to be spoken of as evil.**

- Therefore, do not let others, by what you do, say that that good thing of yours is bad.
- Therefore, do not do that bad thing so that others will call your freedom, which is a good thing, a bad thing.

The Greek of 14:16 begins with a word that is often translated as "so" or "therefore." The BSB omits this word. Here it introduces a conclusion, an idea coming from thinking about what Paul said previously. For example:

Therefore (NIV11)

**Do not allow:** This command indicates that believers must not do things that cause people to say such deeds are bad even though the believers say they are good deeds. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

do not let (ESV)

Do not give occasion for

**what you consider good, then, to be spoken of as evil:** This clause is passive. In some languages an active clause must be used. For example:

people speak of what you regard as good as evil

people say that the thing you regard as good is evil

**what you consider good:** In the Greek this is literally "your<sup>(plur)</sup> good thing." It probably refers to the freedom believers have to eat anything they want. But if you use that freedom to hurt other believers, then people will say that that freedom is a bad thing. See Moo (page 855) or Jewett (page 862). Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

what you know is good (NIV11)

what you think is good (NCV)

**be spoken of as evil:** The freedom we have in Christ is good. But if we hurt others when living according to that freedom, some people might say that that free-

dom is a bad thing. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

be reviled (NABRE)

be called a bad thing

## Romans 14:17

### Section 14:13–23: Do not cause others to sin

In this section, Paul told the believers in Rome to stop considering some of their fellow believers as bad people. Instead they should choose not to hinder them. He told them that God does not consider any kind of food or any other kind of thing as not acceptable, but people who think that that food or thing is unacceptable, they should not eat it or use it. But those who find those things acceptable, they should not hurt the faith of those who find those things unacceptable. Righteousness, peace, and joy are the important things in God's kingdom, not what you eat or drink. God is pleased when those who follow Jesus live in that way.

Paul encouraged the believers to do things that bring peace and encouragement for each other. They are not to hurt other believers over what they eat. They are not to cause other believers to stumble in their faith because of what they eat. Foods that might cause problems for other believers are to be eaten privately. A believer should not eat food if he has doubts about whether he should eat it or not. Everything that is not done in faith is sin.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

Do Not Cause Another to Stumble (ESV)

Don't Cause Problems for Others (CEV)

### 14:17a

**For the kingdom of God is not a matter of eating and drinking,**

- For life under God's rule is not about eating and drinking.
- You see, when God rules us, what is important is not what we eat or drink.

**For:** Here this word introduces the reason for not destroying a fellow believer or letting people speak evil of your freedom in what you eat (14:15–16).

**the kingdom of God:** This phrase refers to God's rule over his people. It does not refer to a land or country

that he rules over. It also refers to the relationship that he has with his people. He leads, protects, and cares for them. They trust him and obey him as their king. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

God's rule/reign

God's kingship

the way God rules his people

the way God cares for his people as their king

**a matter of eating and drinking:** This phrase indicates that the important topics in the kingdom of God are not about eating or not eating certain foods or about drinking or not drinking certain beverages. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

about eating and drinking (CEV)

In the kingdom of God, eating and drinking are not important. (NCV)

### 14:17b

**but of righteousness, peace, and joy in the Holy Spirit.**

- But it is about doing deeds that are right to do and having peace and joy in the power of the Holy Spirit.
- What is important is doing things that are upright/straight to do and living with others in peace and having joy which the Holy Spirit gives us.

**but of righteousness:** The words "a matter" are implied from 14:17a but not repeated here. In some languages it is more natural to repeat these words. For example:

but a matter of righteousness

**righteousness:** Here this word refers to deeds and thoughts that God says are right to do or think. See BDAG, sense 3, or Moo (page 857). See how you translated this word in 6:13.

**peace:** Here this word refers to well-being and being free from troubles. See BDAG, sense 2.

**joy:** This word refers to a continuing experience of being happy or glad. BDAG defines the Greek word as "the experience of gladness" (sense 1).

**in the Holy Spirit:** This phrase connects to righteousness, peace, and joy, not just joy. Moo (page 857) and Morris (page 489). If possible, make that clear.

**in:** Here this word refers to being righteous and having peace and joy because the power of the Holy Spirit enables us to do or have those things. Here are other ways to translate this word:

in the power of

brought by the Holy Spirit (NJB)

which the Holy Spirit gives (GNT)

**the Holy Spirit:** This phrase refers to God's Spirit. The word Spirit is used in a similar way to when a person refers to his own spirit. The word Holy here means "clean" or "sacred." But it also refers to "coming from God." See how you translated this phrase in 5:5 or 9:1.

## Romans 14:18

### Section 14:13–23: Do not cause others to sin

In this section, Paul told the believers in Rome to stop considering some of their fellow believers as bad people. Instead they should choose not to hinder them. He told them that God does not consider any kind of food or any other kind of thing as not acceptable, but people who think that that food or thing is unacceptable, they should not eat it or use it. But those who find those things acceptable, they should not hurt the faith of those who find those things unacceptable. Righteousness, peace, and joy are the important things in God's kingdom, not what you eat or drink. God is pleased when those who follow Jesus live in that way.

Paul encouraged the believers to do things that bring peace and encouragement for each other. They are not to hurt other believers over what they eat. They are not to cause other believers to stumble in their faith because of what they eat. Foods that might cause problems for other believers are to be eaten privately. A believer should not eat food if he has doubts about whether he should eat it or not. Everything that is not done in faith is sin.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

Do Not Cause Another to Stumble (ESV)

Don't Cause Problems for Others (CEV)

### 14:18a

**For whoever serves Christ in this way is pleasing to God**

- For anyone who serves Christ in that way is pleasing to God
- For God is pleased with the person who does the will of Christ,

**For:** Here this word introduces a consequence of living in the Holy Spirit with righteousness and peace and joy (14:17). See Cranfield (page 719).

**whoever serves Christ in this way is pleasing to God:** The Greek word that the BSB translates as pleasing can also mean "acceptable." Many languages must choose one meaning or the other:

1. It means pleasing here, as in the BSB. (BSB, GNT, NIV, NLT, GW, CEV, NET, NCV, NABRE)
2. It means acceptable here, as in the ESV. (RSV, KJV, NASB, ESV, REB)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1), because many English versions and scholars choose it. But this author found no scholar who explains their choice. If the major language version in your area follows interpretation (2), you may want to follow that.

Here are other ways to translate this clause according to interpretation (1):

the one who serves Christ in that way, by those deeds pleases God

God is pleased with the one who serves Christ in that way

**serves Christ:** The word serves refers to doing the things that Jesus commands us to do. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

lives as a servant of Christ

lives doing the will of Christ

**in this way:** There is a textual issue in 14:18a: (1) Some Greek manuscripts have the word to/in-this (BSB, RSV, NIV, GNT, NASB, NABRE, ESV, REB, NLT, GW, NET, NCV). (2) Some later Greek manuscripts have the word to/in-these (KJV and possibly the NJB). It is recommended that you follow option (1). This phrase refers back to the previous verse. Some languages must use "that" here for the correct meaning. For example:

in that way

Here this phrase probably refers to living in the Holy Spirit with righteousness and peace and joy (14:17). See Dunn (page 824) or Jewett (page 864). For example:

by living this way (NCV)

#### **14:18b and approved by men.**

- and is respected by people.
- and people regard him as a very good person too.

**approved by men:** This clause indicates that these men approve of the believers who serve Christ in that way. Some languages must use an active clause. For example:

men/people approve him

**approved:** The Greek word refers to considering someone worthy of high regard. BDAG, sense 2. Here are other ways to translate this word:

respected (NJB)

highly regarded

**men:** Here the word men refers to men and women. See the example above.

## **Romans 14:19**

### **Section 14:13–23: Do not cause others to sin**

In this section, Paul told the believers in Rome to stop considering some of their fellow believers as bad people. Instead they should choose not to hinder them. He told them that God does not consider any kind of food or any other kind of thing as not acceptable, but people who think that that food or thing is unacceptable, they should not eat it or use it. But those who find those things acceptable, they should not hurt the faith of those who find those things unacceptable. Righteousness, peace, and joy are the important things in God's kingdom, not what you eat or drink. God is pleased when those who follow Jesus live in that way.

Paul encouraged the believers to do things that bring peace and encouragement for each other. They are not to hurt other believers over what they eat. They are not to cause other believers to stumble in their faith because of what they eat. Foods that might cause

problems for other believers are to be eaten privately. A believer should not eat food if he has doubts about whether he should eat it or not. Everything that is not done in faith is sin.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

Do Not Cause Another to Stumble (ESV)

Don't Cause Problems for Others (CEV)

#### **14:19a So then, let us pursue what leads to peace**

- ¶ Therefore, we<sup>(incl)</sup> must work hard at the deeds that bring/cause peace with others
- ¶ And so, we must always do the things that lead to peace with others.

**So then:** The Greek here means “as a result” or “therefore.” BDAG and NIV, respectively.

**let us pursue what leads to peace:** The word pursue indicates that we are to work hard at making peace. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

we must pursue the things that cause peace with others

we must make every effort to do the things that bring peace

**what leads to peace:** The Greek is literally “the (things) of peace.” It refers to doing things that cause peace with others. See the above examples.

#### **14:19b and to mutual edification.**

- and at the deeds that strengthen one another.
- And we must always do the things that help one another do better in living by faith.

**to mutual edification:** The words “Let us pursue what leads” are implied here. In some languages it is more natural or more clear to repeat them. For example:

let us pursue what leads to mutual edification

**mutual:** This word refers to doing things for each other.

**edification:** Here this word refers to strengthening or encouraging others so that they live in faith better. Here are other ways to translate this word:

upbuilding (ESV)

help strengthen (GNT)

help each other have a strong faith (CEV)

## Romans 14:20

### Section 14:13–23: Do not cause others to sin

In this section, Paul told the believers in Rome to stop considering some of their fellow believers as bad people. Instead they should choose not to hinder them. He told them that God does not consider any kind of food or any other kind of thing as not acceptable, but people who think that that food or thing is unacceptable, they should not eat it or use it. But those who find those things acceptable, they should not hurt the faith of those who find those things unacceptable. Righteousness, peace, and joy are the important things in God's kingdom, not what you eat or drink. God is pleased when those who follow Jesus live in that way.

Paul encouraged the believers to do things that bring peace and encouragement for each other. They are not to hurt other believers over what they eat. They are not to cause other believers to stumble in their faith because of what they eat. Foods that might cause problems for other believers are to be eaten privately. A believer should not eat food if he has doubts about whether he should eat it or not. Everything that is not done in faith is sin.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

Do Not Cause Another to Stumble (ESV)

Don't Cause Problems for Others (CEV)

### 14:20a

#### Do not destroy the work of God for the sake of food.

- Do not tear to pieces what God has made because you want to eat certain foods.
- Do not ruin the thing that God has made there among you, just because you insist on eating certain foods in front of others.

**Do not destroy the work of God for the sake of food:** In the Greek, the phrase for the sake of food is emphasized by being near the front of the clause. If possible emphasize this phrase in a natural way in your language.

**destroy:** Here this word is a figure of speech that refers to tearing a building apart. It is opposite the figure of speech of building something in 14:19b. If possible use a figure of speech that is opposite building something. For example:

tear down (NASB)

wreck (GNT)

Some languages cannot use a figure of speech here. If that is true in your language, translate the meaning without a figure of speech. For example:

ruin (GW)

damageWestern Bukidnon Manobo Back Translation on TW.

**the work of God:** This probably refers to an individual believer or the believers in Rome as a group. See Dunn (page 825), Jewett (page 866), or Moo (pages 859–860). God has made every believer into his child and has put them together into the group. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

what God has done (GNT)

the thing that God has made/accomplished

**for the sake of food:** This phrase refers to the foods one chooses to eat. Do not choose to eat food in front of a believer who thinks that eating that food is forbidden by God. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

because of what you eat (GW)

because of our eating what others say shouldn't be eatenUma Back Translation on TW.

### 14:20b

#### All food is clean,

- God says it is acceptable to use all things,
- God permits us to use all things of this earth.

**All food:** Here the Greek word that the BSB translates as All food is literally "everything." This word refers to any kind of food. For example:

## Everything (ESV)

**clean:** Here this word refers to something which is fitting for use in serving or worshiping God. God sees that thing as acceptable for use by believers.

### 14:20c

**but it is wrong for a man to let his eating be a stumbling block.**

- but it is evil/bad for someone to cause someone else to stumble because of the foods he eats.
- But, if a believer eats something in front of someone that causes that person to stumble in his faith, then he has done wrong.

**a man to let his eating be a stumbling block:** The Greek is literally “the one eating through stumbling/offense.” There are three ways to interpret it:

1. It is addressed to the believer who eats all foods. Other believers think that God still forbids some foods, and this believer causes them to stumble in their faith by eating those foods. For example:

a person to eat anything that causes someone else to stumble (NIV11) (BSB, RSV, NIV11, GNT, ESV, NABRE, NASB, NLT, GW, CEV, NET, REB, NCV)

1. It is addressed to the believer who thinks that God forbids some foods. He sees other believers eating those foods and decides to eat them, which causes him to stumble in his faith. For example:

someone to whom it is an offence to eat it (NJB) (NJB)

1. It is addressed to both kinds of believers. For example:

that man who eateth with offence (KJV) (KJV)

The Greek perhaps allows for interpretation (3), but it is recommended that you follow interpretation (1), because the context seems to support it best. Moo, Longenecker, Kruse, Lenski, Alford, Nicoll, and Fitzmyer support interpretation (1). Dunn leans this way in his prose but his translation supports interpretation (2). Witherington supports interpretation (1) in his prose but his translation is like the KJV. Barrett’s translation supports interpretation (1) but he says in his prose that it could be either. Schreiner supports interpretation (2). Many explain their clues to support their opinion, but none are conclusive. But the reasons to

support interpretation (1) seem better than those for interpretation (2).

**let...be a stumbling block:** There are two ways to interpret the Greek word here:

1. It refers to causing someone to have difficulties and implies difficulties in their faith. For example:

causes...to sin (NCV) (BSB, RSV, NIV, GNT, ESV, NABRE, NLT, GW, CEV, NET, REB, NCV)

1. It refers to being offended. For example:

someone to whom it is an offence to eat it (NJB) (NJB, NASB, KJV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1), because that is its meaning in 14:13 (“put any stumbling block”). Moo, Longenecker, Cranfield, Schreiner, Jewett, and BDAG support interpretation (1).

## Romans 14:21

### Section 14:13–23: Do not cause others to sin

In this section, Paul told the believers in Rome to stop considering some of their fellow believers as bad people. Instead they should choose not to hinder them. He told them that God does not consider any kind of food or any other kind of thing as not acceptable, but people who think that that food or thing is unacceptable, they should not eat it or use it. But those who find those things acceptable, they should not hurt the faith of those who find those things unacceptable. Righteousness, peace, and joy are the important things in God’s kingdom, not what you eat or drink. God is pleased when those who follow Jesus live in that way.

Paul encouraged the believers to do things that bring peace and encouragement for each other. They are not to hurt other believers over what they eat. They are not to cause other believers to stumble in their faith because of what they eat. Foods that might cause problems for other believers are to be eaten privately. A believer should not eat food if he has doubts about whether he should eat it or not. Everything that is not done in faith is sin.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

Do Not Cause Another to Stumble (ESV)

Don’t Cause Problems for Others (CEV)



**14:21a****It is better not to eat meat or drink wine or to do anything**

- It is good to avoid eating meat or drinking wine or doing anything,

**wine:** This word refers to the juice of a fruit called grapes, usually allowed to ferment (convert the sugar to alcohol).

In some areas, people may not be familiar with grapes or with wine. If that is true in your area, here are some other ways to translate wine:

- Use a general term for an alcoholic drink.
- Use a specific term that can also be used to refer to alcoholic drinks in general. For example:

millet beer

palm wine

something like palm wine You may then want to indicate the literal word in a footnote. Here is an example footnote:

Literally “wine.” Wine is the juice of the fruit called grapes that is allowed to ferment.

- Use a descriptive phrase. For example:

fermented grape juice

**14:21b****to cause your brother to stumble.**

- if doing those things causes your brother or sister in Christ to stumble.

**brother:** Here this word refers to another believer, either man or woman. Here are other ways to translate this word:

another believer (NLT)

other believers (GNT)

**stumble:** There is a textual issue in 14:18a: (1) Some Greek manuscripts have the word stumbles (BSB, RSV, NIV, GNT, NASB, NABRE, ESV, REB, NLT, GW, NET, NCV). (2) Some Greek manuscripts have the words stumbles or weakens (KJV, NJB). It is recommended that you follow option (1). The meaning here is the same as

in 14:20c (interpretation (1)). See how you translated it there, where the BSB translates it as “stumbling block.”

**Romans 14:22****Section 14:13–23: Do not cause others to sin**

In this section, Paul told the believers in Rome to stop considering some of their fellow believers as bad people. Instead they should choose not to hinder them. He told them that God does not consider any kind of food or any other kind of thing as not acceptable, but people who think that that food or thing is unacceptable, they should not eat it or use it. But those who find those things acceptable, they should not hurt the faith of those who find those things unacceptable. Righteousness, peace, and joy are the important things in God’s kingdom, not what you eat or drink. God is pleased when those who follow Jesus live in that way.

Paul encouraged the believers to do things that bring peace and encouragement for each other. They are not to hurt other believers over what they eat. They are not to cause other believers to stumble in their faith because of what they eat. Foods that might cause problems for other believers are to be eaten privately. A believer should not eat food if he has doubts about whether he should eat it or not. Everything that is not done in faith is sin.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

Do Not Cause Another to Stumble (ESV)

Don’t Cause Problems for Others (CEV)

**14:22a****Keep your belief about such matters between yourself and God.**

- The beliefs that you have/hold, they are for you to have/hold before God.
- What you believe about those things, only you and God need to talk about it/them.

**Keep your belief about such matters:** There is a textual issue in 14:22a: (1) Some Greek manuscripts have a word that is often translated as which (BSB, RSV, NIV, GNT, NJB, NASB, NABRE, ESV, REB, NLT, GW, NET, NCV). (2) Some Greek manuscripts omit this word (KJV only). It is recommended that you follow option (1). Here the Greek is more literally “Keep your belief.” The word belief refers to faith or deeply held views about such things as what food to eat or whether one should follow the OT rules or not. See Moo (page

861) or Jewett (page 870). In some languages a literal translation would have the wrong meaning. If that is true in your language, you may want to:

- Explain it in your translation, as the BSB does. For example:

Keep your faith/beliefs in those things that you have

Your beliefs about these things (NCV)

- Translate the literal meaning and explain it in a footnote. Here is an example footnote:

Here the word “belief” refers to the things someone believes about such things as what food to eat or whether one should follow the OT rules or not.

**between yourself and God:** This command indicates that a believer should not share his beliefs about what to eat and so forth. It implies that believer should not cause problems by what he says or does with other believers who have different beliefs about those things. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

have as your own conviction before God (NASB)

we can hold in our heart that belief of ours in front of GodUma Back Translation on TW.

it should only be you (pl) and God who are the ones who know itYakan Back Translation on TW.

#### 14:22b

**Blessed is the one who does not condemn himself by what he approves.**

- The person who does not condemn himself for the things he has decided are good/right to do, he is blessed.
- When believers have decided certain deeds are right/acceptable to do and do not condemn themselves when they do those deeds, God has blessed/favored them.

**Blessed:** The Greek word that the BSB translates as Blessed describes a person who is in a good situation. In the Bible, the good situation results from God showing favor/kindness to the person. It includes the inner happiness a person feels when God forgives him

and accepts him. See how you translated this word in 4:7.

**the one who does not condemn himself by what he approves:** The Greek is more literally “the one not judging himself in what he approves.” It indicates that this person does not cause himself to be condemned because he does what he considers to be good things. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

the one who does not condemn himself by what he approves (NIV11)

those who have no reason to condemn themselves because of what they approve (NRSV)

they can do what they think is right without feeling guilty (NCV)

**condemn:** Here this phrase refers to acting as a judge. In this context it suggests condemning someone as having done evil. See how you translated this phrase in 14:3 or 14:13 (BSB: “judge”).

**approves:** Here this word refers to thinking about something and deciding it is good or acceptable. Here it includes, for example, decisions about eating certain foods or not. Here are other ways to translate this word:

judge is right (GNT)

they have decided is right (NLT)

he has decided is the right thing for him to doKankanaey Back Translation on TW.

## Romans 14:23

### Section 14:13–23: Do not cause others to sin

In this section, Paul told the believers in Rome to stop considering some of their fellow believers as bad people. Instead they should choose not to hinder them. He told them that God does not consider any kind of food or any other kind of thing as not acceptable, but people who think that that food or thing is unacceptable, they should not eat it or use it. But those who find those things acceptable, they should not hurt the faith of those who find those things unacceptable. Righteousness, peace, and joy are the important things in God’s kingdom, not what you eat or drink. God is pleased when those who follow Jesus live in that way.

Paul encouraged the believers to do things that bring peace and encouragement for each other. They are not to hurt other believers over what they eat. They are not to cause other believers to stumble in their faith because of what they eat. Foods that might cause problems for other believers are to be eaten privately. A believer should not eat food if he has doubts about whether he should eat it or not. Everything that is not done in faith is sin.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

Do Not Cause Another to Stumble (ESV)

Don't Cause Problems for Others (CEV)

#### 14:23a

**But the one who has doubts is condemned if he eats,**

- But the person who doubts about eating those foods and eats them anyway, he will certainly be punished,
- But if believers are not sure whether it is right to eat certain foods but eat them anyway, God has decided he will punish them.

**the one who has doubts is condemned:** This clause is passive. Some languages must use an active clause. For example:

God has condemned whoever has doubts

**doubts:** This word refers to not being certain about something. A person thinks that maybe it is good but maybe it is bad. Or a person thinks that maybe it is right or maybe wrong.

**is condemned:** The Greek tense indicates that God has already condemned this person and that condemnation remains in effect. But the actual punishment may occur later. The present tense does not indicate that the punishment is occurring at this moment.

**condemned:** This word usually indicates that a judge has decided how to punish the guilty person. Here are other ways to translate this word:

determined the punishment

will give him pain/punishment

However, here it does not refer to God sending someone to hell, so your translation should not indicate that. See how you translated this word in 2:1 or 8:34.

**he eats:** It is implied here that this person eats food that he doubts it is right for him to eat. In some languages a literal translation would refer generally to any food. If that is true in your language, you may want to:

- Explain in your translation. For example:

he eats those foods he is not sure that they are clean before God

- Translate the literal meaning only and explain the meaning in a footnote. Here is an example footnote:

This person eats food that he thinks it is wrong for him to eat. He thinks that maybe God has forbidden him to eat it.

#### 14:23b

**because his eating is not from faith;**

- because for him eating those foods is not through faith.
- For they are not basing that deed on their faith when they eat.

**his eating:** This refers to the person with doubts about eating certain foods but he eats those foods anyway. Some languages cannot use the noun eating here. If that is true in your language, use a verb. For example:

when he eats like that

**faith:** The meaning is the same as “belief” in 14:22a.

#### 14:23c

**and everything that is not from faith is sin.**

- And anything he does that is not based in his faith is sin.
- Something you do, if you do not do it because you believe in Jesus, you are sinning.

**and:** The Greek word here is usually translated as and or “but.” It introduces a general principle related to what Paul wrote about in 14:23a–b. Introduce the rest of 14:23c in a way that indicates that. For example:

For (ESV)

Anything that is... (GW)

**that is not from:** The Greek is literally “(is) not out of.” If a believer does something because he doubts rather than because he believes in Jesus, then he is sinning. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

does not come from (NIV)

anything that is not based on faith is sin (GNT)

**faith:** In this general principle, the word faith would refer generally to all that one believes about Jesus and God.

## Romans 15:1

### Section 15:1–13: Believers should help one another

In this section, Paul said that believers who are strong, as he defined “strong” in 14:1–9, should help believers who are weak (also as in 14:1–9). The strong are to encourage the weak, with the result that all may have hope in God.

Paul prayed that God would help the believers, strong and weak, to live in unity and glorify God.

Paul urged the believers to always welcome one another, because doing that glorifies God. Jesus served the Jews to show that God’s word was true and confirm his promises, which in turn encourages the non-Jews to glorify God for his mercy to them.

Then Paul prayed that God would fill them with joy and peace in their faith, with the result that the Holy Spirit would fill them with hope.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

Carry weak believers, encourage them and accept them

Help believers who are not strong

### 15:1a

#### We who are strong ought to bear with the shortcomings of the weak

- ¶ We<sup>(incl)</sup> who are strong in our freedom have a duty to carry the weaknesses of those who are weak in that freedom.
- ¶ We who have a full freedom must help believers who are weak in that area.

**We who are strong ought to:** The word ought refers to something that is required to be done. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

We who are strong have a duty to

it is necessary that we who are strong

We who are strong are required to

We who are strong must

**We who are strong:** Here the word strong refers to believers who are strong in the freedom of behavior we have as believers. Kruse (page 527) says it refers to “their understanding of Christian freedom.” Longenecker (page 1012) says, “it seems most likely...that the group that spoke of itself as “the Strong” was made up largely (if not entirely) of Gentile Christians, who had no commitment to any Jewish scruples about the propriety or impropriety of certain foods, the sanctity of certain days, and the drinking of wine.” The “weak” believers restrict their freedom by only following Jewish behavior (chapter 14).

This clause does not refer to physical strength. In some languages a literal translation would refer only to physical strength. If that is true in your language, you may want to:

- Explain the meaning in your translation. For example:

We who are strong in our freedom

- Translate literally and explain the meaning in a footnote. Here is an example footnote:

This refers to being strong in the freedom we have as believers. The weak here are tied to Jewish behaviors.

**bear with:** The Greek word refers to carrying something heavy. Here it refers to coming alongside the weak believers and helping them. It does not imply trying to change their minds about their weaknesses. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

help the weak to carry their burdens (GNT)

bear the weaknesses of (NASB)

**shortcomings:** The Greek word is literally “weaknesses.” It refers here to any weakness that a believer might have. The main example in chapter 14 was eating only vegetables, perhaps out of fear of being

influenced by idols should he eat meat dedicated to them. The word does not refer to sins or physical weaknesses here. Here are other ways to translate this word:

weaknesses (NASB)

whose freedom is not strong

### 15:1b and not to please ourselves.

- And we have a duty to not please ourselves.
- And we must not just please ourselves.

**and not to please ourselves:** The words “we who are strong ought” are implied from 15:1a. Some languages must repeat all or some of those words for a natural translation. For example:

and we have an obligation not to please ourselves

## Romans 15:2

### Section 15:1–13: Believers should help one another

In this section, Paul said that believers who are strong, as he defined “strong” in 14:1–9, should help believers who are weak (also as in 14:1–9). The strong are to encourage the weak, with the result that all may have hope in God.

Paul prayed that God would help the believers, strong and weak, to live in unity and glorify God.

Paul urged the believers to always welcome one another, because doing that glorifies God. Jesus served the Jews to show that God’s word was true and confirm his promises, which in turn encourages the non-Jews to glorify God for his mercy to them.

Then Paul prayed that God would fill them with joy and peace in their faith, with the result that the Holy Spirit would fill them with hope.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

Carry weak believers, encourage them and accept them

Help believers who are not strong

### 15:2a Each of us should please his neighbor for his good,

- Each of us<sup>(incl)</sup> must make his neighbor happy by doing things that benefit him,

- Each of us must do the deeds that please and help our neighbors

**Each of us should please:** This is a command that Each of us must please his neighbor. For example:

Each of us must please (NRSV)

**Each of us:** Some scholars think the word us refers only to the strong believers (15:1) but others think it refers to all believers. Do not try to explain it in your translation.

**please:** Here this word refers to doing things that help the neighbor so that he is happy.

**neighbor:** Some scholars think this word refers only to other believers but other scholars think it refers to anyone who lives nearby. Do not try to explain it in your translation.

**for his good:** The Greek is literally “to/for the good.” This probably refers generally to the church, that is, all believers in Rome. See Dunn (page 837) or Jewett (page 879). (The next phrase, literally “toward building up,” is also probably general.) For example:

for the good (NABRE)

But many English versions translate as the BSB does. This interprets the Greek as “for the good of the neighbor.” With this interpretation, this command refers only to pleasing the neighbor.

### 15:2b to build him up.

- that is, to strengthen him in his faith.
- to do better in living by faith.

**to build him up:** The Greek is literally “toward building up.” This purpose clause explains what Paul meant by “to/for the good” (15:2a). This probably refers generally to the church, that is, all believers in Rome. For example:

for building up (NABRE)

But many English versions translate as the BSB does. This interprets the Greek as building up the neighbor only.

**build him up:** Here the words build...up refer to strengthening or encouraging others so that they live in faith better. Here are other ways to translate this word:

edification

help strengthen him

help him in his faith

See how you translated the word “edification” in 14:19.

## Romans 15:3

### Section 15:1–13: Believers should help one another

In this section, Paul said that believers who are strong, as he defined “strong” in 14:1–9, should help believers who are weak (also as in 14:1–9). The strong are to encourage the weak, with the result that all may have hope in God.

Paul prayed that God would help the believers, strong and weak, to live in unity and glorify God.

Paul urged the believers to always welcome one another, because doing that glorifies God. Jesus served the Jews to show that God’s word was true and confirm his promises, which in turn encourages the non-Jews to glorify God for his mercy to them.

Then Paul prayed that God would fill them with joy and peace in their faith, with the result that the Holy Spirit would fill them with hope.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

Carry weak believers, encourage them and accept them

Help believers who are not strong

### 15:3a

#### For even Christ did not please Himself, but as it is written:

- For even Christ did not make himself happy by what he did. Indeed, it was as the Scriptures say,
- For Christ did not do deeds that pleased himself. No/ Instead, he lived as King David wrote in the Holy Book,

**For:** Here this word introduces the reason why believers should please others (15:2).

**even:** The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as even is often translated as “and” or “also.” Here it emphasizes the word “Christ.”

**Christ did not please Himself:** This clause indicates that Jesus did not do things that were selfish and

would make only himself happy by doing them. Rather, he did things that pleased God.

**but:** Here this word introduces what Christ did instead of pleasing himself. Some languages will not see contrast here. For example:

Instead (GNT)

indeed (NJB)

**as it is written:** This clause introduces a quote from Scripture. The words that Paul quoted were written hundreds of years before he wrote the letter to the Romans. In some languages a literal translation would wrongly indicate these words were written at the same time as Paul wrote here. If that is true in your language, indicate it was long before Paul wrote. For example:

as it was written long ago

This clause refers to what was written in the Old Testament. Some languages must make that explicit to make that clear. For example:

As scripture says (GNT)

This clause is passive. Some languages must use an active clause here. For example:

the songwriter wrote long ago

It is like it says in the Holy Book

See how you translated this clause in 1:17 or 11:26.

### 15:3b

#### “The insults of those who insult You have fallen on Me.”

- “The insults of the people who insulted you, they have come completely to me.”
- “People insulted you, and those words hurt me.”

This quote is from Psalm 69:9. If you indicate the location of quotes from the Old Testament with cross-references, you may want to do so here.

**The insults of those who insult You:** The word insults refers to saying something that indicates you do not approve of the person or deed. You criticize him for what he did. Here are other ways to translate this word:

The reproaches of those who reproach you (ESV)

When people insult you (NCV)

The people's despising of you (sg)Kankanaey Back Translation on TW.

their belittling words to you

**You:** In the psalm this word refers to God. Paul probably also implied God here. See Moo (page 868), Morris (page 499), or Cranfield (page 733). But you should not explain who this word refers to in your translation.

**have fallen on Me:** Here the phrase have fallen refers to the insults affecting the person speaking (called here: Me) more than the person referred to as "you." The person speaking takes those insults as really being directed to him. He takes them personally. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

came to me

I am the one who was hit (by it)Tagbanwa Back Translation on TW.

have struck/hit meUma Back Translation on TW.

hurt me also

**Me:** In the psalm this word refers to the writer of the psalm, King David. But as an Old Testament quote, you should not explain who this word refers to in your translation.

## Romans 15:4

### Section 15:1–13: Believers should help one another

In this section, Paul said that believers who are strong, as he defined "strong" in 14:1–9, should help believers who are weak (also as in 14:1–9). The strong are to encourage the weak, with the result that all may have hope in God.

Paul prayed that God would help the believers, strong and weak, to live in unity and glorify God.

Paul urged the believers to always welcome one another, because doing that glorifies God. Jesus served the Jews to show that God's word was true and confirm his promises, which in turn encourages the non-Jews to glorify God for his mercy to them.

Then Paul prayed that God would fill them with joy and peace in their faith, with the result that the Holy Spirit would fill them with hope.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

Carry weak believers, encourage them and accept them

Help believers who are not strong

### 15:4a

**For everything that was written in the past was written for our instruction,**

- For the things that were written long ago were written to teach us<sup>(incl)</sup>,
- For the words that people wrote long ago in the Scriptures, people wrote them to teach us.
- For when God had someone write in his Holy Book, he did that to teach us about him and us.

**For:** Here this word introduces an explanation of why he uses Scripture to support his teaching about pleasing others.

**everything that was written in the past was written:** There are two passive clauses here. In some languages active clauses must be used. For example:

whatever God had someone write in former days, he did that

**everything that was written in the past:** This phrase implies all of the Scriptures, what is now called the Old Testament. In some languages, a literal translation would imply all things written down, not just the Scriptures. If that is true in your language, you may want to:

- Explain the correct implied meaning in your translation. For example:

whatever was written in the Holy Book in former days

- Translate literally and explain the correct implied meaning in a footnote. Here is an example footnote:

This refers to all of the Scriptures, what is now called the Old Testament.

**for our instruction:** Here the word for introduces the purpose of the things “written in former days.” For example:

to teach us (GNT)

**our instruction:** This refers to the purpose for the words written in Scripture, which is to teach us.

#### 15:4b

**so that through endurance and the encouragement of the Scriptures, we might have hope.**

- so that, by us enduring troubles and by the Scriptures encouraging us, we might hope.
- God’s purpose is that we might hope in him by us standing strong in faith when troubles come and by the Scriptures encouraging us.
- His goal/aim for us is to hope in his promises because we live in faith despite difficulties and because his Holy Word encourages us.

**so that through endurance and the encouragement of the Scriptures, we might have hope:** The words

through endurance and the encouragement of the Scriptures are put in front of the words we might have hope to emphasize them. In some languages those words must be in their normal place. For example:

that we might have hope through endurance and through the encouragement of the Scriptures

If possible, emphasize these words in a natural way in your language.

**so that:** Here this word introduces the purpose of “our instruction” (15:4a).

**through endurance:** Here the word through indicates that one of the ways to make ourselves hopeful is to endure. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

by endurance (NABRE)

if we endure

**endurance:** This word refers to continuing to do or think something despite problems or troubles in their lives. Here it probably refers to remaining strong in faith even though we are persecuted or have other troubles. Here are other ways to translate this word:

perseverance (NJB)

enduring troubles

continue on despite troubles

See how you translated this word in 5:3, where the BSB translates it as “perseverance.”

**encouragement:** This word refers to helping someone have hope, courage, or confidence. Some languages use an idiom for this meaning. For example:

strengthen our insides Nalik Back Translation, unpublished manuscript, Papua New Guinea.

**of the Scriptures:** This phrase probably connects only to “encouragement.” See Moo (page 869, footnote 38), Morris (page 500), or Cranfield (page 735).

The word of indicates here that the Scriptures are the source of encouragement. For example:

from the Scriptures

which the Scriptures give us (GW)

**Scriptures:** Here this would refer to the books of the Bible now called the Old Testament. But today we also get encouragement from the New Testament. You should use your key term that refers generally to the Bible. For example:

God’s Word

the Holy Book

**hope:** This word has the same meaning as it does in 5:4, with the object of the hope here generally God or his promises. See how you translated this word there.

## Romans 15:5

### Section 15:1–13: Believers should help one another

In this section, Paul said that believers who are strong, as he defined “strong” in 14:1–9, should help believers who are weak (also as in 14:1–9). The strong are to encourage the weak, with the result that all may have hope in God.

Paul prayed that God would help the believers, strong and weak, to live in unity and glorify God.

Paul urged the believers to always welcome one another, because doing that glorifies God. Jesus served the Jews to show that God’s word was true and confirm



his promises, which in turn encourages the non-Jews to glorify God for his mercy to them.

Then Paul prayed that God would fill them with joy and peace in their faith, with the result that the Holy Spirit would fill them with hope.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

Carry weak believers, encourage them and accept them

Help believers who are not strong

#### 15:5a

**Now may the God who gives endurance and encouragement grant you**

- ¶ I pray to God, the one who enables us to endure troubles and who encourages us. I pray that he will give to you the ability/power
- ¶ God is the one who gives us the power to stand strong and causes us to be encouraged. I ask him to cause/enable you

**may...God...grant you:** Here Paul prayed that God might enable the believers in Rome to live in unity. Here are other ways to translate these words:

May...God...give to you

I now ask...God...to give to you

I am praying that...God...will cause you

**grant you:** Here the word you refers to the person receiving what is given. It does not refer to the thing given. For example:

grant to you

**grant:** The Greek word here is usually translated “give.” The word grant has that meaning here.

**the God who gives endurance and encouragement:** This phrase indicates that God is the source of endurance and encouragement for believers. It connects to “endurance” and “encouragement” in 15:4 but here refers generally to any kind of endurance and encouragement. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

the God of endurance and encouragement (ESV)

God, the source of all perseverance and all encouragement (REB)

This description of God occurs in the middle of Paul asking him to do something. In some languages it is more natural to separate those two things. For example:

God is the one who makes us patiently endure and encouraged. I pray that he will...

The ability to endure troubles and the ability to be encouraged come from God. And I pray that he will...

#### 15:5b

**harmony with one another**

- to be of the same mind/thinking among each other,
- to be united with one another,

**harmony with one another:** The Greek is more literally “to think the same thing among one another.” Here it refers to living in unity and thinking that other believers are good people. Paul wrote about differences of opinion in chapter 14 that were causing problems among the believers. Here he implied that those differences were not important compared to serving God with one purpose, helping and encouraging each other. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

to be of the same mind with one another (NASB)

the same attitude of mind toward each other (NIV11)

unity with one another (NET)

**one another:** This refers to all the believers in Rome. Your translation should not limit it to the “strong” group or the “weak” group.

#### 15:5c

**in Christ Jesus,**

- according to the will of Christ/Messiah Jesus.
- as Jesus, the one/person whom God appointed to save/rescue people, wants you to.

**in Christ Jesus:** This phrase indicates that Jesus wants believers to live in unity. What Paul said in 15:5b agrees with that. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

according to Christ Jesus (NASB)

the way Christ Jesus wants (NCV)

**Christ Jesus:** The order of the words Christ Jesus emphasizes that Jesus is the Christ/Messiah. However, in some languages the order Christ Jesus is not natural. See how you translated this phrase in 8:34.

## Romans 15:6

### Section 15:1–13: Believers should help one another

In this section, Paul said that believers who are strong, as he defined “strong” in 14:1–9, should help believers who are weak (also as in 14:1–9). The strong are to encourage the weak, with the result that all may have hope in God.

Paul prayed that God would help the believers, strong and weak, to live in unity and glorify God.

Paul urged the believers to always welcome one another, because doing that glorifies God. Jesus served the Jews to show that God’s word was true and confirm his promises, which in turn encourages the non-Jews to glorify God for his mercy to them.

Then Paul prayed that God would fill them with joy and peace in their faith, with the result that the Holy Spirit would fill them with hope.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

Carry weak believers, encourage them and accept them

Help believers who are not strong

### 15:6

**so that with one mind and one voice you may glorify the God and Father of our Lord Jesus Christ.**

- Be of the same mind/thinking in order that you<sup>(plur)</sup> will praise God with one heart and one voice, who/ he is God and Father to our Lord Jesus Christ.
- And so, united in spirit and united in the things you say, you will praise and honor God. He is God and heavenly Father of Jesus Christ our Lord.

**so that...you may:** The word that introduces the purpose of believers being in unity (15:5). For example:

that...you may (ESV)

**with one mind:** The Greek word here is literally “with-the-same-emotion.” It indicates that they are united

emotionally. Here are other ways to translate this word:

it’s like your minds/inner-beings...will-be-all-one-Tagbanwa Back Translation on TW.

you will be one-heartUma Back Translation on TW.

your(pl) insides...will be one onlyNalik Back Translation, unpublished manuscript, Papua New Guinea.

**and one voice:** This phrase indicates that the things the believers said agreed with each other, or that they did not contradict each other in what they said. It does not refer to speaking in unison. Translate with that meaning. For example:

with one...mouth (NIV)

you will be...one-speechUma Back Translation on TW.

**glorify:** This word indicates that the believers acknowledge God’s glory, that they honor him and praise him. Here are other ways to translate this word:

how great/wonderful (God) is

giving praise and glory to (NLT)

praise (GW)

**the God and Father of our Lord Jesus Christ:** This phrase indicates that God is both God and Father of Jesus. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

God, he is God to our Lord Jesus Christ and his Father

God who is God and Father of Jesu Cristo our LordKankanaey Back Translation on TW.

If you have translated 2 Corinthians 1:3, Ephesians 1:3, or 1 Peter 1:3, you may want to see how you translated this phrase there.

**Father:** When referring to God as Father, the word indicates that God has a relationship with Jesus like a father to a son.

In some languages a literal translation would not have the correct meaning. If that is true in your language, you may want to explain the meaning in your translation. For example:

heavenly Father

## Romans 15:7

### Section 15:1–13: Believers should help one another

In this section, Paul said that believers who are strong, as he defined “strong” in 14:1–9, should help believers who are weak (also as in 14:1–9). The strong are to encourage the weak, with the result that all may have hope in God.

Paul prayed that God would help the believers, strong and weak, to live in unity and glorify God.

Paul urged the believers to always welcome one another, because doing that glorifies God. Jesus served the Jews to show that God’s word was true and confirm his promises, which in turn encourages the non-Jews to glorify God for his mercy to them.

Then Paul prayed that God would fill them with joy and peace in their faith, with the result that the Holy Spirit would fill them with hope.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

Carry weak believers, encourage them and accept them

Help believers who are not strong

### 15:7a

#### Accept one another, then,

- ¶ Therefore accept each other,
- ¶ So, in summary, welcome each other,

**Accept:** The Greek word refers to bringing in someone into your group of friends and accepting him or her. Here are other ways to translate this word:

welcome (ESV)

receive wellUma Back Translation on TW.

See how you translated this word in 14:1.

**one another:** This refers to all the believers in Rome. See how you translated this phrase in 15:5.

### 15:7b

#### just as Christ accepted you, in order to bring glory to God.

- which honors God, in the same way that the Messiah has accepted you<sup>(plur)</sup>.
- in the same way as Christ welcomed you into his family. By doing that, God receives glory.

#### just as Christ accepted you, in order to bring glory to God:

The phrase to bring glory to God probably connects to “welcome one another.” That is why many English versions put a comma before the phrase in order to, because that separates the phrase from just as Christ accepted you. The connection may be more clear if this phrase occurs after “welcome one another.” For example:

Accept one another...for the glory of God, as Christ has accepted you (GNT)

**just as Christ accepted you:** There is a textual issue in 15:7b: (1) Some Greek manuscripts have the word you<sup>(plur)</sup> (BSB, RSV, NIV, GNT, NJB, NABRE, ESV, NLT, GW, NET, NCV). (2) Some Greek manuscripts have the word us (KJV, NASB, REB). It is recommended that you follow option (1). Here the words just as indicate that believers are to welcome each other in the same way that Jesus welcomed them. For example:

in the same way that Christ accepted you (GW)

**Christ:** The Greek has the word “the” before this word. Paul also did not include the name “Jesus” here. Both things emphasize that it is the Messiah who has welcomed the believers in Rome.

**in order to bring glory to God:** This phrase indicates that when believers welcome each other, those deeds bring glory to God. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

which brings glory to God

which honors God

## Romans 15:8

### Section 15:1–13: Believers should help one another

In this section, Paul said that believers who are strong, as he defined “strong” in 14:1–9, should help believers who are weak (also as in 14:1–9). The strong are to encourage the weak, with the result that all may have hope in God.

Paul prayed that God would help the believers, strong and weak, to live in unity and glorify God.

Paul urged the believers to always welcome one another, because doing that glorifies God. Jesus served the Jews to show that God's word was true and confirm his promises, which in turn encourages the non-Jews to glorify God for his mercy to them.

Then Paul prayed that God would fill them with joy and peace in their faith, with the result that the Holy Spirit would fill them with hope.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

Carry weak believers, encourage them and accept them

Help believers who are not strong

### 15:8a

#### **For I tell you that Christ has become a servant of the circumcised**

- For I tell you that Christ became a servant to the nation who has the rite of circumcision.
- For I tell you this: Christ became a servant to the circumcised people group, that is, the Jews.

**For:** Here this word introduces a reason for welcoming other believers. See Morris (page 503) or Alford (page 459).

**I tell you that Christ has become a servant:** The words I tell you indicate that the words that follow are important. The word that introduces what Paul wanted to tell them.

**a servant of the circumcised:** The Greek is more literally "a servant of the circumcision." There are two ways to interpret the Greek word ending that often means of:

1. It indicates that Jesus served the circumcised, that is, the Jews. For example:

serve the circumcised (NJB) (BSB, RSV, NIV, NJB, NASB, NABRE, KJV, ESV, NLT, NET, CEV, REB, NCV)

1. It indicates that Jesus served others on behalf of the circumcised. For example:

life of service was on behalf of the Jews (GNT) (GNT, GW)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1), because it fits better with showing God's truthfulness (15:8b) and confirming the promises to the Jewish ancestors (15:8c). See also Moo (page 877) or Morris (page 503).

**a servant:** The work of a servant was to help another person with his needs and wants. This other person tells him what he needs or wants, and the servant helps him with that need or want.

Jesus was a servant by doing things for the Jews that showed God's truthfulness (15:8b). He did not take orders from the Jews as a servant usually would. Consider if your usual word or phrase for servant is fitting in this context.

**the circumcised:** Here this phrase refers to the Jews. In some languages a literal translation may not clearly indicate that. If that is true in your language, you may want to:

- Explain in the text. For example:

the circumcised, that is, the Jews

- Translate literally and explain the meaning in a footnote. Here is an example footnote:

This refers to the Jews.

**circumcised:** The word circumcised refers to cutting off the loose skin at the end of a boy's or man's penis. See how you translated this word in 2:25 or 4:12.

### 15:8b

#### **on behalf of God's truth,**

- He did that to show that what God says is true,
- In that way he showed that God is true when he speaks,

**God's truth:** There are several ways to interpret the Greek word that the BSB translates as truth. Here are the two main ones:

1. It means the characteristic or habit of speaking the truth. God always speaks the truth. For example:

the truthfulness of God (NJB) (RSV, ESV, NJB, NABRE)

1. It means truth. The words of God are true. For example:

God's truth (NIV) (BSB, NIV, NASB, KJV, NRSV, GW, NET)

1. It means being true to one's promises. For example:

God is faithful (GNT) (GNT, REB)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1), because the BDAG supports it. The BDAG does not list interpretation (3) as a sense of this Greek word.

### General Comment on 15:8b

The Greek is translated as a purpose clause. Jesus fulfilled this purpose during his time on earth. In some languages purpose clauses are always unfulfilled. If that is true in your language, indicate that Jesus fulfilled this purpose. For example:

and showed God's truthfulness

and showed that what God says is true

Often fulfilled purpose clauses are translated as result clauses. But here it was not only Christ becoming a servant that showed God's truthfulness but also his deeds as that servant. So the above examples only imply the result connection. Consider what the best connection is in your language.

### 15:8c

#### to confirm the promises made to the patriarchs,

- and to make certain the promises that were given to the forefathers,
- which caused people to know that the things that God promised to the Jewish ancestors were certain.

**to:** This phrase introduces a second purpose clause. The first purpose clause, to show that God is truthful (15:8b), is a general statement. This purpose clause, to confirm God's promises, is a part of that more general statement.

Jesus fulfilled this purpose of confirming the promises during his time on earth. In some languages purpose clauses are always unfulfilled. If that is true in your language, indicate that Jesus fulfilled this purpose. For example:

and confirmed...

**confirm:** There are several ways to interpret the Greek word here. Here are the two main ones:

1. It means to cause something to be known as certain (L&N). The English word confirm indicates that meaning here. (BSB, RSV, NIV, ESV, NABRE, NASB, KJV, NET)
2. It means to cause something that was promised to happen. For example:

make...come true (GNT) (GNT, NJB, GW, REB)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1), because the BDAG and L&N both support it.

**the promises made:** This is a passive clause. In some languages an active clause must be used. For example:

the promises that God made

**patriarchs:** Here this word refers to Abraham, Isaac, and Jacob. Here are other ways to translate this word:

forefathers

Jewish ancestors (NCV)

See how you translated this word in 9:5 or 11:28 ("patriarchs").

## Romans 15:9

### Section 15:1-13: Believers should help one another

In this section, Paul said that believers who are strong, as he defined "strong" in 14:1-9, should help believers who are weak (also as in 14:1-9). The strong are to encourage the weak, with the result that all may have hope in God.

Paul prayed that God would help the believers, strong and weak, to live in unity and glorify God.

Paul urged the believers to always welcome one another, because doing that glorifies God. Jesus served the Jews to show that God's word was true and confirm his promises, which in turn encourages the non-Jews to glorify God for his mercy to them.

Then Paul prayed that God would fill them with joy and peace in their faith, with the result that the Holy Spirit would fill them with hope.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

Carry weak believers, encourage them and accept them

Help believers who are not strong

### 15:9a

**so that the Gentiles may glorify God for His mercy.**

- and so that Gentiles would praise God for his mercy.
- It also caused non-Jews to honor God because God had compassion on them and helped them.

**so that:** This phrase introduces another purpose for Christ becoming a servant to the Jews to show God's truthfulness (15:8a–b). Not only do the Jews see that Jesus has confirmed the promises to the patriarchs (15:8c), but the Gentiles also glorify God because of him.

**the Gentiles:** Not all Gentiles will glorify God because of Jesus. Your translation should not indicate or imply that all Gentiles will do that. In English, dropping the word the implies some Gentiles. For example:

Gentiles

**Gentiles:** Here this word refers to all people groups except the Jews. See how you translated this word in 1:13 or 11:25.

**glorify God:** Here the word glorify refers to praising and honoring God, which adds to his glory. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

give glory to God (NJB)

praise God (GNT)

**mercy:** This word refers to being concerned for someone who is in a bad situation and helping him in some way, including even forgiving him for something bad he did. See how you translated this word in 9:15 or 11:31.

### General Comment on 15:9a

15:9a is a purpose clause. Some Gentiles have already praised God for Jesus and more later will praise him for the same reason. So this purpose is already partly fulfilled. Consider how to translate this clause indicating or implying that meaning.

### 15:9b

**As it is written: “Therefore I will praise You among the Gentiles;**

- It is as the Scriptures say, “Therefore I will tell the Gentiles that you<sup>(sing)</sup> are good,
- That is like what David wrote in God's Book, “And so, when I am with non-Jews, I will praise you

### 15:9c

**I will sing hymns to Your name.”**

- and sing songs of praise to your name.”
- and I will sing songs that honor you.”

### 15:9b–c

**As it is written:** This clause introduces quotes from Scripture. The quotes were written hundreds of years before Paul wrote the letter to the Romans. In some languages a literal translation would wrongly indicate the quote was written at the same time as Paul wrote here. If that is true in your language, indicate it was written long before Paul wrote this letter. For example:

As it was written long ago

This clause is passive. Some languages must use another kind of clause here. For example:

As the writer of Scripture wrote long ago

It is like it says in the Holy Book

See how you translated this clause in 1:17 or 15:3.

**Therefore I will praise You among the Gentiles;**

**I will sing hymns to Your name:** These words are quoted from either Psalm 18:49 or 2 Samuel 22:50. If you indicate the location of quotes from the Old Testament with cross-references, you may want to do so here.

**praise:** This word refers to this person saying that God is good and other such things.

**sing hymns to Your name:** This phrase indicates that the songs honored and praised God. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

sing praises of/to your name

I will praise you (sg) with my songsKankanaey  
Back Translation on TW.

## Romans 15:10

**Section 15:1–13: Believers should help one another**

In this section, Paul said that believers who are strong, as he defined “strong” in 14:1–9, should help believers who are weak (also as in 14:1–9). The strong are to encourage the weak, with the result that all may have hope in God.

Paul prayed that God would help the believers, strong and weak, to live in unity and glorify God.

Paul urged the believers to always welcome one another, because doing that glorifies God. Jesus served the Jews to show that God's word was true and confirm his promises, which in turn encourages the non-Jews to glorify God for his mercy to them.

Then Paul prayed that God would fill them with joy and peace in their faith, with the result that the Holy Spirit would fill them with hope.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

Carry weak believers, encourage them and accept them

Help believers who are not strong

### 15:10

**Again, it says: "Rejoice, O Gentiles, with His people."**

- And the Scriptures also say, "Gentiles, rejoice with his people."
- Also, in another place in God's Book, Moses said, "You non-Jews, be happy together with God's people."

This quote is from Deuteronomy 32:43. If you indicate the location of quotes from the Old Testament with cross-references, you may want to do so here.

**Again, it says:** The Greek is more literally "And again he/she/it says." Probably it is Scripture speaking here. For example:

And in another place it says (NJB)

The Scripture also says (NCV)

**Rejoice, O Gentiles, with His people:** The reference to the people spoken to occurs in the middle of what was said to them. In some languages it is more natural to have it first. For example:

O Gentiles, rejoice with his people

**O Gentiles:** The word O introduces who is spoken to. Some languages would use a different kind of word. For example:

you Gentiles (NIV11)

You who are GentilesKankanaey Back Translation on TW.

Some languages will not use a word like this here. For example:

Gentiles! Rejoice...

Nations, rejoice... (NJB)

**His people:** Here this phrase refers to the Jews.

## Romans 15:11

### Section 15:1-13: Believers should help one another

In this section, Paul said that believers who are strong, as he defined "strong" in 14:1-9, should help believers who are weak (also as in 14:1-9). The strong are to encourage the weak, with the result that all may have hope in God.

Paul prayed that God would help the believers, strong and weak, to live in unity and glorify God.

Paul urged the believers to always welcome one another, because doing that glorifies God. Jesus served the Jews to show that God's word was true and confirm his promises, which in turn encourages the non-Jews to glorify God for his mercy to them.

Then Paul prayed that God would fill them with joy and peace in their faith, with the result that the Holy Spirit would fill them with hope.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

Carry weak believers, encourage them and accept them

Help believers who are not strong

### 15:11a

**And again: "Praise the Lord, all you Gentiles,**

- And the Scriptures also say, "All Gentiles, praise the Lord,
- Also, in another place in God's Book, someone said, "All you non-Jews, praise the Lord God.

This quote is from Psalm 117:1. If you indicate the location of quotes from the Old Testament with cross-references, you may want to do so here.

**And again:** The phrase "it says" is implied from 15:10. In some languages it is more natural to repeat it here. For example:

And again it says

See how you translated “it says” in 15:10.

**Praise the Lord, all you Gentiles:** Naming the people spoken to occurs after what was said to them. In some languages it is more natural to have it first. For example:

All you Gentiles, praise the Lord

**the Lord:** The word Lord refers to someone who has authority over people. Here this phrase refers to God. In some languages it is more natural to indicate who this Lord is. For example:

the Lord God

See how you translated the word Lord in 4:8 or 14:11.

**15:11b**  
**and extol Him, all you peoples.”**

- and all people groups must lift his name high.”
- May all of you praise him.”

**extol Him, all you peoples:** This is a command to a group that expresses what they must do. Here is another way to translate this clause:

all peoples must extol him

**extol Him:** The English word extol is very similar in meaning to “praise” in 15:11a, as are the two words in the Greek. Some languages have a second way to translate “praise.” For example:

lift up his nameLevatbura Lamusong (Notsi Mandak) Back Translation, draft, Papua New Guinea.

make-big his nameNalik Back Translation, unpublished manuscript, Papua New Guinea.

But some languages have only one way to translate “praise.” For example:

praise himKankanaey Back Translation on TW.

**all you peoples:** This phrase refers to all people groups. It is similar in meaning to “Gentiles” in 15:11a. If possible translate this phrase in a different way than how you translated “Gentiles” but still having the same or similar meaning. For example:

All people groups

all tribes

## Romans 15:12

### Section 15:1–13: Believers should help one another

In this section, Paul said that believers who are strong, as he defined “strong” in 14:1–9, should help believers who are weak (also as in 14:1–9). The strong are to encourage the weak, with the result that all may have hope in God.

Paul prayed that God would help the believers, strong and weak, to live in unity and glorify God.

Paul urged the believers to always welcome one another, because doing that glorifies God. Jesus served the Jews to show that God’s word was true and confirm his promises, which in turn encourages the non-Jews to glorify God for his mercy to them.

Then Paul prayed that God would fill them with joy and peace in their faith, with the result that the Holy Spirit would fill them with hope.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

Carry weak believers, encourage them and accept them

Help believers who are not strong

### 15:12a

**And once more, Isaiah says: “The Root of Jesse will appear,**

- And also in the Scriptures Isaiah said, “The shoot of Jesse will arise,
- Also, in another place in God’s Book Isaiah said, “The special/foretold descendant of Jesse will arrive/appear.

This quote is from Isaiah 11:10. If you indicate the location of quotes from the Old Testament with cross-references, you may want to do so here.

**And once more, Isaiah says:** This refers to what Isaiah wrote in Scripture. If you added the implied information about the quotes in 15:9–11 being from Scripture, you may want to include it here too. For example:

And also in the Scriptures Isaiah said



**(alt:) the shoot of Jesse:** There are two ways to interpret the Greek word that is translated as shoot:

1. It refers to a shoot from the root and it is a figure of speech for a descendant. For example:

descendant (GNT) (GNT, REB, NLT)

1. It refers to a root. (BSB, RSV, NIV, NJB, ESV, NABRE, NASB, KJV, GW, NET)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1), because the BDAG supports it. Either way this phrase is a title for the Messiah/Christ.

**Jesse:** Jesse was King David's father. The phrase "the shoot of Jesse" is used in the book of Isaiah as a reference to the Messiah. If readers of your translation will not be familiar with who Jesse is or this title for the Messiah, you may want to explain it in a footnote. Here are some example footnotes:

Jesse was King David's father.

The words "the shoot of Jesse" are a title for the Messiah. Jesse was King David's father.

**will appear:** The Greek word is more literally "will be." It indicates that, in the future to when this was first said, the shoot of Jesse will exist. In English "there is" is the most natural translation. For example:

There will be the shoot of Jesse

But in many languages following this English translation would not indicate the correct meaning. A verb other than "be" may be needed. For example:

will arrive

will come (ESV)

In some languages continuing the figurative language from "the shoot of Jesse" would be more natural. For example:

The shoot of Jesse will arise

### 15:12b

#### **One who will arise to rule over the Gentiles;**

- indeed, he will stand and begin to rule the Gentiles.
- Hey/Look, he will go and start ruling the non-Jews.

**One who will arise to rule over the Gentiles:** The Greek of 15:12b begins with a word that is often translated "and" or "also." Here the word introduces something more about the shoot of Jesse. It emphasizes the words that follow and says they are as important or possibly more important than what was just said. For example:

indeed, one who will arise to rule

**One who will arise to rule:** The Greek is present tense here, but this event occurs at the same time as the future event of "there will be the shoot of Jesse" (15:12a). You should probably use the same tense here as you did in the clause about the shoot of Jesse.

**will arise to rule:** The words will arise refers to standing up from sitting or lying down. Here it is a figure of speech that means "comes to do" something. The purpose of this man arising is to rule. Here are other ways to translate this word:

appears and begins to rule

takes on the work of ruling

### 15:12c

#### **in Him the Gentiles will put their hope."**

- In him Gentiles will hope."
- Non-Jews will confidently expect that he will do as he has promised."

**in Him the Gentiles will put their hope:** The phrase in Him is emphasized by being first in the clause. In some languages the phrase must be in its normal place. For example:

the Gentiles will put their hope in him

Some of these languages can emphasize this phrase in another way. For example:

the Gentiles will put their hope in him indeed

the Gentiles will put their hope, hey, in him

**in Him...hope:** These Gentiles will believe in God and his Messiah, and so they will have hope that he will fulfill his other promises in Scripture.

Some languages must say what is hoped for, more than just hoping in Him. If that is true in your lan-

guage, refer to fulfillment of God's promises that are not yet fulfilled. For example:

hope in his promises

hope that he will fulfill his promises

This is a quote from what is now called the Old Testament. You should not refer to anything that is specifically Christian or from the New Testament.

**the Gentiles:** Here this refers to Gentiles as a kind of person. It does not imply all Gentiles. In English omitting the word the refers to the kind of person called Gentiles but does not imply all of them. For example:

Gentiles

## Romans 15:13

### Section 15:1–13: Believers should help one another

In this section, Paul said that believers who are strong, as he defined “strong” in 14:1–9, should help believers who are weak (also as in 14:1–9). The strong are to encourage the weak, with the result that all may have hope in God.

Paul prayed that God would help the believers, strong and weak, to live in unity and glorify God.

Paul urged the believers to always welcome one another, because doing that glorifies God. Jesus served the Jews to show that God's word was true and confirm his promises, which in turn encourages the non-Jews to glorify God for his mercy to them.

Then Paul prayed that God would fill them with joy and peace in their faith, with the result that the Holy Spirit would fill them with hope.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

Carry weak believers, encourage them and accept them

Help believers who are not strong

### 15:13a

**Now may the God of hope fill you with all joy and peace as you believe in Him,**

- ¶ I ask God, the one who gives hope, to fill you<sup>(plur)</sup> with all kinds of joy and peace within your believing in him.

- ¶ God is the one who causes you to have hope. I pray to him that he will make you completely happy and completely at peace, in your habit of believing in him.

**Now may the God of hope fill you:** This indicates that Paul wanted God to fill the Roman believers. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

I pray that God...will fill you (NLT)

I request that he give youUma Back Translation on TW.

I-desire-that...God...will graciously-favor youTagbanwa Back Translation on TW.

**the God of hope:** Here the word of indicates that God enables us to hope. See Moo (page 880), Cranfield (pages 747–748), or Dunn (page 851). As believers we also hope in God, but that does not seem to be the main reason why Paul wrote of hope here. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

God, the source of hope, (GNT)

God, who gives hope, (CEV)

**hope:** This word refers to wanting something to happen or even confident expectation that something will happen. The meaning is “confident expectation” here. See how you translated this word in 4:18 or 12:12.

**fill:** Here this word is a figure of speech that indicates that God will give completely the ability to have joy and peace. Some languages can use fill in that way. Some languages must translate with a different word or phrase for the correct meaning. For example:

give in/an abundance

cause that you may completely rejoice...Otomi Back Translation on TW.

give you happiness and peace...that is completeUma Back Translation on TW.

**all joy and peace:** The word all connects to both joy and peace. In some languages it is more clear or natural to repeat this word. For example:

all joy and all peace

**all:** Here this word refers to all kinds of joy and all kinds of peace. In some languages the word all cannot be placed with a singular item like joy or peace. If that is true in your language, translate the correct meaning. For example:

all kinds of joy and all kinds of peace

**joy:** This word refers to a continuing experience of being happy or glad. See how you translated this word in 14:17.

**peace:** Here this word refers to well-being and being free from troubles. See how you translated this word in 1:7 or 14:17.

**as you believe in Him:** There are several ways to interpret the Greek words here. Here are the three main ones:

1. It means within the sphere or influence of believing. Joy and peace are experienced within the sphere or influence of believing. For example:

in your faith (NJB) (RSV, NJB, ESV, NABRE, NASB, KJV)

1. It indicates that believing is the way in which one experiences or gets joy and peace. For example:

by means of your faith in him (GNT) (GNT, GW)

1. It indicates that joy and peace are experienced at the same time as one believes. For example:

as you believe in him (NET) (BSB, NIV, NET, REB, NCV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1), because it seems the most fitting definition here.

**believe in Him:** There are two ways to interpret the Greek word that the BSB translates as believe:

1. It refers to faith, as in the BSB. (BSB, RSV, GNT, NJB, NABRE, ESV, NASB, KJV, GW, CEV, NET, REB)
2. It refers to trust. For example:

trust (NIV) (NIV, NLT, NCV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1).

The Greek is in the present tense, which indicates an ongoing faith.

#### 15:13b

**so that you may overflow with hope by the power of the Holy Spirit.**

- May that filling with joy and peace give to you great hope by the power of God's Holy Spirit.
- If God fills you in that way, the Holy Spirit, by his power, will give you much hope.

**so that:** These words introduce the purpose of Paul praying for God to give them joy, peace, and hope.

**you may overflow with hope by the power of the Holy Spirit:** Some English versions place by the power of the Holy Spirit first in the clause to emphasize it. However, in the Greek it is a place that does not normally indicate emphasis. Place this phrase wherever is most natural in your language.

**overflow with hope:** Here the word overflow refers to having very much hope. The Greek word is the verb related to the word that means "abundant." Paul wanted them to have abundant hope. Here are other ways to translate this word:

be rich in hope (NJB)

filled full of hope

have very great hope

hope in God in complete sufficiency

hope very strongly/much

**the Holy Spirit:** This phrase refers to God's Spirit. The word Spirit is used in a similar way that a person refers to his spirit. The word Holy here means "clean" or "sacred." But it also refers to "coming from God." See how you translated this phrase in 5:5 or 14:17.

In this division, Paul encouraged the believers in Rome and explained the purpose of his letter. He said that he was proud of his work as an apostle. He explained why he usually went to places where people had not heard about Christ.

Then Paul explained his plans to come to Rome on his way to Spain. He asked for their prayers, that God would protect him from Jews who did not believe in Jesus, that he would help the believers in Jerusalem

and that God would allow him to visit the believers in Rome.

Then he commended and greeted various believers there in Rome.

Here are other possible headings for this division:

Conclusion and personal greetings (GNT)

Conclusion/Ending of the letter

## Romans 15:14

### Section 15:14–21: Paul encouraged them and said he was happy with his work/ministry

In this section, Paul told the believers in Rome that he was convinced that they were good, had knowledge, and were able to teach each other. He reminded them that he had been very bold in this letter. He wanted the Gentiles to be acceptable to God regarding their faith.

He told the believers in Rome that he was proud of his work for God. His work was to help Gentiles to believe in Jesus. He told them that he always wanted to preach the gospel where people did not know about Christ.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

Paul was an apostle to the Gentiles

Paul's Reason for Writing (NLT)

#### 15:14a

#### **I myself am convinced, my brothers,**

- ¶ I My brothers and sisters, as for me, I myself am convinced about you
- ¶ I My fellow believers, I myself am certain

**I myself am convinced, my brothers:** Naming the people to whom he spoke is in the middle of what Paul said to them. In some languages these words must be first. For example:

My brothers, I myself am satisfied about you

**I myself am convinced:** The Greek is more literally “I am convinced, even I myself, about you.” Paul doubly emphasized the word I. Here it indicates that Paul was sincere when he said this. Moo (page 887). It does not indicate surprise But it may be in contrast to his rebukes in this letter: “Despite me being critical of

you earlier, I am convinced...” See Morris (page 508). or superiority. Dunn (page 857). Some languages can doubly emphasize the word I, other languages can emphasize it once. For example:

I am convinced, indeed, I myself, about you

I am convinced, yes, me, about you

As for me, I am convinced about you

**convinced:** The Greek word indicates that Paul was certain in what he thought about the believers in Rome. Here are other ways to translate this word:

satisfied (ESV)

I am certain

**my brothers:** The word my indicates that Paul felt he had a relationship with the believers in Rome even though he had never been there.

**brothers:** This word refers to all the believers living in Rome, both men and women. The word indicates a close relationship between believers because God made them his (adopted) children. See how you translated this word in 1:13 or 12:1.

#### 15:14b

#### **that you yourselves are full of goodness,**

- that you yourselves are always good,
- that, as for you, you are completely good.

**that:** Here this word introduces what Paul was convinced of. It connects to 15:14c–d as well as 15:14b.

**full of goodness:** The word full indicates that the goodness in believers is complete. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

completely good

really good people Yakan Back Translation on TW.

#### 15:14c

#### **brimming with knowledge,**

- that you know all things,
- I am also certain that you already know all about our<sup>(incl)</sup> faith

**brimming with:** This phrase is similar in meaning to “full of” in 15:14b.

**knowledge:** Here the word knowledge mostly refers to things to be known about the gospel of Christ. In some languages that implied information will be clear from what Paul had been saying up until now. But in some languages it would indicate or imply knowledge of everything in the world. If that is true in your language, you may want to:

- Explain in your translation. For example:

knowledge about our faith

knowledge about the gospel

- Translate literally and explain the meaning in a footnote. Here is an example footnote:

This refers to all knowledge about the gospel of Christ.

#### **15:14d and able to instruct one another.**

- and that you are able to teach one another to stop your/their bad behavior.

**instruct:** The Greek word refers to directing someone to stop doing something bad. Here are other ways to translate this word:

admonish (NABRE)

correct (NJB)

## **Romans 15:15**

### **Section 15:14–21: Paul encouraged them and said he was happy with his work/ministry**

In this section, Paul told the believers in Rome that he was convinced that they were good, had knowledge, and were able to teach each other. He reminded them that he had been very bold in this letter. He wanted the Gentiles to be acceptable to God regarding their faith.

He told the believers in Rome that he was proud of his work for God. His work was to help Gentiles to believe in Jesus. He told them that he always wanted to preach the gospel where people did not know about Christ.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

Paul was an apostle to the Gentiles

### Paul's Reason for Writing (NLT)

#### **15:15a**

**However, I have written you a bold reminder on some points,**

- But I have been very bold when I wrote to you<sup>(plur)</sup> about some things to remind you of them.
- In some parts of this letter I have written quite/rather boldly to you in order that you would think about those things again.

**However:** Here this word introduces that Paul wrote boldly. Some languages will not see contrast to Paul being satisfied with the believers in Rome. For example:

I have written... (NIV84)

Here in this letter...Yakan Back Translation on TW.

#### **I have written you a bold reminder on some points:**

Some English versions place the phrase on some points in the front of the clause to emphasize it, but the Greek does not emphasize it. The Greek puts the word “rather/very-boldly” in the front of the clause to emphasize it. If possible, emphasize this word or phrase in your translation. For example:

very boldly I have written to you on some points

**I have written you:** There is a textual issue in 15:15a: (1) Some Greek manuscripts have the word to-you (BSB, RSV, NIV, GNT, NJB, NASB, NABRE, ESV, REB, NLT, GW, NET, NCV). (2) Some Greek manuscripts have the words to-you, brothers (KJV only). It is recommended that you follow option (1). This refers to what Paul had written so far in this letter. In some languages a literal translation would refer to a previous letter. If that is true in your language, indicate that Paul spoke of this letter here. For example:

I have written to you in this letter

**a bold:** The Greek word here is more literally “more-boldly.” It is not clear what is being compared here. Probably the part of the Greek word indicating “more” just means “much” or “very” here. The Greek does that sometimes. For example:

quite boldly (NIV11)

rather boldly (NRSV)

**bold:** This word refers to having courage and not being afraid to do or say something.

**reminder:** This phrase indicates that Paul wrote those things to remind the believers in Rome of them. For example:

to remind you (NABRE)

**on some points:** This refers to some of the topics in this letter. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

about certain subjects (GNT)

I've written you a letter, parts of which are rather bold (NLT)

I have...written...at times (REB)

in some of what I have said in this letter  
Kankanaey Back Translation on TW.

### 15:15b because of the grace God has given me

- For the blessing that God gave to me
- For God freely gave to me the strength to do the work of an apostle.

**because of:** This phrase introduces the thing that is the reason why something happened. God's gift of apostleship to Paul was the reason why he wrote so boldly to the believers in Rome.

**the grace God has given me:** Here the word grace refers to the strength and knowledge that God gave to Paul, enabling him to do his ministry. See Morris (page 510). Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

the gift I have from God (REB)

my authority as an apostle that God freely gave to me

## Romans 15:16

### Section 15:14–21: Paul encouraged them and said he was happy with his work/ministry

In this section, Paul told the believers in Rome that he was convinced that they were good, had knowledge,

and were able to teach each other. He reminded them that he had been very bold in this letter. He wanted the Gentiles to be acceptable to God regarding their faith.

He told the believers in Rome that he was proud of his work for God. His work was to help Gentiles to believe in Jesus. He told them that he always wanted to preach the gospel where people did not know about Christ.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

Paul was an apostle to the Gentiles

Paul's Reason for Writing (NLT)

### 15:16a to be a minister of Christ Jesus to the Gentiles

- was that I became a servant of Christ/Messiah Jesus to help the Gentiles.
- And that work was to work for Jesus, the one/person whom God appointed to save/rescue people, to help the non-Jews believe in him.

**to be a minister of Christ Jesus to the Gentiles:** Here the word to introduces the purpose for God giving Paul the ability to do the work of an apostle. For example:

so that I would be a minister of Christ Jesus to the Gentiles

God already fulfilled this purpose before Paul wrote this letter. In some languages all purpose clauses are unfulfilled. If that is true in your language, translate that this is a result or imply that. For example:

and so I became a minister of Christ Jesus to the Gentiles

and I became a minister of Christ Jesus to the Gentiles

**a minister of Christ Jesus to the Gentiles:** The Greek word that the BSB translates as minister refers to a servant in religious work. See BDAG. Paul here said that he did the work that Jesus gave to him. That work was to help Gentiles believe in Jesus and to help them grow in their faith. For example:

a servant of Christ Jesus to work for the Gentiles (GNT)

**Christ Jesus:** There is a textual issue in 15:16a: (1) Some Greek manuscripts have the words Christ Jesus (BSB, RSV, NIV, GNT, NJB, NASB, NABRE, ESV, REB, NLT, GW, NET, NCV). (2) Some Greek manuscripts have the words Jesus Christ (KJV only). It is recommended that you follow option (1). The order of the words Christ Jesus emphasizes that Jesus is the Christ/Messiah. However, in some languages the order Christ Jesus is not natural. See how you translated this phrase in 15:6.

#### 15:16b

**in the priestly service of the gospel of God,**

- It is like the work of a priest to make known the good news of God.
- And that work is God's work, to tell his good news,

**in the priestly service:** Here the word in introduces the way that Paul was a servant. He acted like a priest, helping people come near to God. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

do the work of a priest in the service of (CEV)

I serve like a priest (GNT)

ministering as a priest (NASB)

**priestly service:** Paul used the Greek word as a figure of speech to indicate that his work was religious work, like a priest. He was thinking generally of priestly duties, such as helping people to worship. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

priestly duty (NIV)

The word or phrase you use here should not refer primarily to animal sacrifice.

In some languages a literal translation would not have the correct meaning. If that is true in your language, you may want to:

- Add the word "like" or "as." For example:

serve like a priest (GNT)

- Translate the meaning without the figure of speech. For example:

do God's work

**the gospel:** The Greek word that the BSB translates as gospel means "good news." Here this word refers

to God's good news about Jesus Christ. See how you translated this word in 1:1 or 11:28.

#### 15:16c

**so that the Gentiles might become an offering acceptable to God,**

- In doing that, the Gentiles are like a gift/sacrifice that God accepts,
- so that I might bring/present the non-Jews to God, and they will be acceptable to him.

**so that the Gentiles might become an offering acceptable to God:** The words so that introduce the purpose for Paul's work. At the time of this letter, his work was not yet complete but he had helped many Gentiles believe in Jesus.

The word might does not imply that Paul was not certain that God would accept the Gentiles. Your translation should not imply that Paul was not certain.

**the Gentiles might become an offering acceptable to God:** This phrase is a figure of speech that speaks of the Gentiles as being like an offering to God. It indicates that Paul hoped that the lives (or faith) of the Gentiles would be acceptable to God because they believed in Jesus.

In some languages a literal translation would not have the correct meaning. If that is true in your language, you may want to:

the word might does not imply that Paul was not certain that God would accept the Gentiles. Your translation should not imply that Paul was not certain.

- Add the word "like" or "as." For example:

the Gentiles, like an offering,

- Translate the meaning without the figure of speech. For example:

the Gentiles, presented to God,

#### 15:16d

**sanctified by the Holy Spirit.**

- for they have been made holy by God's Holy Spirit.
- For the Holy Spirit has set them apart to live for God.

**sanctified by the Holy Spirit:** This is more information about the Gentiles who believe in Jesus. In some languages it is more natural to have this as a separate sentence. For example:

The Holy Spirit has sanctified them.

This clause is passive. Some languages must use an active clause, as in the above example.

**sanctified:** This refers to the Holy Spirit making believers holy. He has changed them from being sinners to being holy. Here the word “holy” refers to being chosen to serve God and obey him. KBT, holy, sense B.1. Here are other ways to translate this word:

made holy (NCV)

made-into his holy people Kankanaey Back Translation on TW.

## Romans 15:17

### Section 15:14–21: Paul encouraged them and said he was happy with his work/ministry

In this section, Paul told the believers in Rome that he was convinced that they were good, had knowledge, and were able to teach each other. He reminded them that he had been very bold in this letter. He wanted the Gentiles to be acceptable to God regarding their faith.

He told the believers in Rome that he was proud of his work for God. His work was to help Gentiles to believe in Jesus. He told them that he always wanted to preach the gospel where people did not know about Christ.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

Paul was an apostle to the Gentiles

Paul's Reason for Writing (NLT)

### 15:17

#### Therefore I exult in Christ Jesus in my service to God.

- ¶ Therefore, I boast about the things I do in Christ Jesus for God.
- ¶ So I am proud of the work I do for God because of my relationship with Jesus, the one/person whom God appointed to save/rescue people.

#### Therefore I exult in Christ Jesus in my service to

**God:** Some English versions place the phrase in Christ Jesus first in the clause to emphasize it or perhaps to separate it from my service to God to be more clear. It is not emphasized in the Greek. Put it in its usual place in your language.

**Therefore...in Christ Jesus:** The word Therefore is at the beginning of the words it introduces. In some languages, the word must be somewhere else in the clause. For example:

In Christ Jesus, then (ESV)

**Therefore:** The Greek word here introduces a consequence of the Gentiles being an acceptable gift to God, sanctified by the Holy Spirit. For example:

then (ESV)

**in Christ Jesus:** Here the word in indicates that Paul was joined with Jesus in a close relationship. See how you translated this phrase in 6:11 or 8:39.

**I exult...in my service to God:** The Greek is literally “I have the boasting of the (things) toward/pertaining-to God.” It indicates that Paul was able to boast in his work as an apostle of God. He could boast because all that he accomplished was by God's power. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

I can be proud of my service for God (GNT)

I am proud of what I have done for God in Christ Jesus (NCV)

## Romans 15:18

### Section 15:14–21: Paul encouraged them and said he was happy with his work/ministry

In this section, Paul told the believers in Rome that he was convinced that they were good, had knowledge, and were able to teach each other. He reminded them that he had been very bold in this letter. He wanted the Gentiles to be acceptable to God regarding their faith.

He told the believers in Rome that he was proud of his work for God. His work was to help Gentiles to believe in Jesus. He told them that he always wanted to preach the gospel where people did not know about Christ.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

Paul was an apostle to the Gentiles

Paul's Reason for Writing (NLT)

### 15:18a

#### I will not presume to speak of anything except

- For I will not be bold enough to talk about anything except
- For I will be only brave enough to tell others about



The Greek of 15:18a begins with a word that is often translated as “for.” Here it introduces an explanation of Paul being proud of his work for God. He was proud of what Jesus had done through him. The BSB does not translate this word, but some English versions include it. For example:

For (ESV)

**I will not presume to speak of anything except:** The Greek word that the BSB translates as presume refers to being bold enough to do something. Paul was bold enough to tell others what Jesus did through him. He was not bold enough to tell others what he did by his own power. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

I will not dare to speak of anything except  
(NABRE)

I will be bold and speak only about (GNT)

See how you translated this Greek word in 5:7 (“dare”). This Greek word is also related to the one translated “bold” in 15:15.

**to speak of anything except:** This indicates that Paul would only be bold when he spoke about certain things. See the GNT example above.

#### 15:18b

**what Christ has accomplished through me in leading the Gentiles to obedience**

- the things that Christ did when he used me to cause/make Gentiles obey him/God.
- the things that Jesus Christ did by my hand. The result/outcome of that work is that some non-Jews now obey him/God,

**what Christ has accomplished through me:** This refers to all the things Paul did as an apostle, and perhaps other things as well. Jesus told him what to do and gave him the power and authority to do those things. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

the things Christ did using me to do them

the deeds that Christ caused to happen by my hand

**accomplished:** This word means “did” or “caused to happen.”

**in leading the Gentiles to obedience:** The Greek is more literally “to the obedience of the Gentiles.” The first word introduces the result of things that Christ did through Paul. The result is that some Gentiles obeyed God. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

to lead the Gentiles to obedience (NABRE)

with the result that the/some Gentiles obey him

**obedience:** This word refers to doing what someone else tells you to do. See how you translated this word in 1:5.

#### 15:18c

**by word and deed,**

- These things I said and did
- because of the things I said and I did.

**by word and deed:** Here this phrase refers to the things that Paul said and did as an apostle.

### Romans 15:19

**Section 15:14–21: Paul encouraged them and said he was happy with his work/ministry**

In this section, Paul told the believers in Rome that he was convinced that they were good, had knowledge, and were able to teach each other. He reminded them that he had been very bold in this letter. He wanted the Gentiles to be acceptable to God regarding their faith.

He told the believers in Rome that he was proud of his work for God. His work was to help Gentiles to believe in Jesus. He told them that he always wanted to preach the gospel where people did not know about Christ.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

Paul was an apostle to the Gentiles

Paul’s Reason for Writing (NLT)

#### 15:19a

**by the power of signs and wonders, and by the power of the Spirit of God.**

- by the power of miraculous signs and amazing miracles, and by the power of God’s Spirit.
- Jesus Christ also accomplished that work by the power of amazing miracles that showed that my ministry/message was from him. And he also accom-

plished that work by the power that the Holy Spirit of God has.

**by the power of signs and wonders:** This indicates that Paul's work as an apostle was supported by signs and wonders. God enabled Paul to do signs and wonders, which showed that God had made him an apostle and these signs and wonders were also a part of this work. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

in the power of signs and wonders (NASB)

and also by using amazing signs and miracles  
Kankanaey Back Translation on TW.

**signs and wonders:** Both signs and wonders refer to miracles. See the definitions of both below. Both terms tell us something that Paul wanted us to know about these miracles. These miracles both had a symbolic meaning and amazed people.

In some languages a literal translation would wrongly refer to two different kinds of things. If that is true in your language, indicate that both terms describe miracles. For example:

miracles that were signs and that amazed people

the signs which were amazing things done by God

**signs:** This refers to miracles that have a symbolic meaning. They suggest or point to something other than themselves. These miracles showed that the God about whom Paul preached was powerful and empowered Paul, and the message about Jesus that Paul preached was true. Here are other ways to translate this word:

great signs

omens/portents

miracles that showed that my message was from God

**wonders:** This word refers to miracles that amaze people. Here are other ways to translate this word:

marvels

amazing miracles

**by the power of the Spirit of God:** This phrase indicates that the power of the Spirit of God enabled Paul to say and do the things he did, his "word and deed" of 15:18c. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

in the power of the Spirit of God

through the power of the Spirit of God

**the Spirit of God:** There is a textual issue here.

1. The words are spirit of-god, as the BSB translates. (BSB, GNT, NJB, ESV, NIV11, NRSV, KJV, NLT, GW, NET)
2. The word is spirit. For example:

the Spirit (NASB) (NIV84, NASB)

1. The words are spirit of-holy. For example:

the Holy Spirit (RSV) (RSV, REB, NCV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1), because the UBS5 supports it, although they indicate that they had difficulty deciding which option was most likely correct.

Either way, this phrase refers to the Holy Spirit. Some languages may need to make that clear. For example:

God's Holy Spirit

the Holy Spirit (RSV)

#### 15:19b

**So from Jerusalem all the way around to Illyricum,**

- Therefore, from Jerusalem and all along the way around to Illyricum
- And so, including Jerusalem, the province of Illyricum, and the places between them,

**So:** This introduces a result of Paul's work as an apostle (15:18b–19a).

**from Jerusalem all the way around to Illyricum:** This refers in general to the regions between Jerusalem and Illyricum that Paul and other apostles had visited at that time. The words all the way around indicate that the area is not a straight figure. Below is the author's general idea of the included regions.

Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

from Jerusalem and round about as far as Illyricum (NASB)

from Jerusalem going around as far as Illyricum

**Illyricum:** This is the name for a Roman province to the east of Italy and northwest of Greece. In Greek it is spelled Illurikon. In some languages translators will want to:

- Explain in the translation. For example:

the Roman province of Illyricum

the land of Illyricum

- Spell the name as people in your area would say it and explain it in a footnote. Here is an example footnote:

This is the name for a Roman province to the east of Italy and northwest of Greece.

### 15:19c

#### **I have fully proclaimed the gospel of Christ.**

- I have done all my work regarding the gospel of/about the Christ/Messiah.
- I completed the work that God gave to me about the good news of Jesus Christ.

**I have fully proclaimed the gospel of Christ:** This indicates that Paul had proclaimed the gospel of Christ in the regions between Jerusalem and Illyricum. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

I have completed my work for the gospel of Christ

I have done all that God told me to do for the gospel of Christ

**fully proclaimed:** This includes, as he did in many cities, preaching, helping people accept Jesus as Savior, praying, establishing churches, and (probably) choosing leaders for those churches, as well as explaining his ministry, as he did in Jerusalem. See the examples above.

**the gospel of Christ:** The word of here indicates that the gospel is about the Christ, that is, Jesus.

### **General Comment on 15:19b–c**

In some languages it will be more natural to have the main part of the clause in front of the locations. For example:

so that I have fulfilled the ministry of the gospel of Christ from Jerusalem and all the way around to Illyricum

## **Romans 15:20**

### **Section 15:14–21: Paul encouraged them and said he was happy with his work/ministry**

In this section, Paul told the believers in Rome that he was convinced that they were good, had knowledge, and were able to teach each other. He reminded them that he had been very bold in this letter. He wanted the Gentiles to be acceptable to God regarding their faith.

He told the believers in Rome that he was proud of his work for God. His work was to help Gentiles to believe in Jesus. He told them that he always wanted to preach the gospel where people did not know about Christ.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

Paul was an apostle to the Gentiles

Paul's Reason for Writing (NLT)

### **15:20a**

#### **In this way I have aspired to preach the gospel**

- In that way my goal is to preach the good news
- In this/that way I always desire to announce the good news of Jesus

**In this way:** These words introduce why Paul preached in many places between Jerusalem and Illyricum. Here is another way to translate this word:

and thus (ESV)

thus

**I have aspired:** Here the word aspired refers to a continuing desire to do something. At that time Paul always wanted to preach the gospel where people did not know about Jesus. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

I make it my ambition (ESV)

I desire (NET)

The Greek tense indicates an ambition at the present time (the time he wrote this letter). It does not say anything about how long in the past he has had this ambition. Translate as an ambition at the present time.

**preach the gospel:** The Greek word here means “announce good news” or “proclaim the gospel.” Preaching is often done before a group of people. Here it refers to telling others the good news of Jesus as Messiah/Christ. Here are other ways to translate this Greek word:

declare the gospel (REB)

preach the Good News (GNT)

See how you translated this phrase in 1:15.

### 15:20b

#### where Christ was not known,

- where the Christ/Messiah has not already been preached,
- in towns/places where no one has yet gone and told the people that he is the Deliverer whom God promised to send.

**where Christ was not known:** This clause refers to places where someone has not told the people there about Jesus being the Christ, the one to save people from their sins. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

not where Christ has already been named (ESV)

where Christ has not been heard of (GNT)

where the name of Christ has not already been heard (NJB)

### 15:20c

#### so that I would not be building on someone else's foundation.

- so that I am not like someone building on someone else's foundation.
- In this/those way I am not the second person strengthening a group of believers like someone building on someone else's foundation.
- For I do not want to come after someone has established the church/group of believers and do further work/ministry there.

**so that I would not be building on someone else's foundation:** The phrase so that...not means “in order that...not.” It introduces a purpose for avoiding something. For example:

lest I build on someone else's foundation (ESV)

**I would not be building on someone else's foundation:** This is a figure of speech that refers to Paul being the second apostle to do what a previous apostle did in that town/place: preach the gospel, help people believe in Jesus, encourage believers and help them grow in their faith. This “builds” the group of believers. The first person “builds” the foundation and the second person “builds” on top of the foundation.

In some languages a literal translation would not have the correct meaning. If that is true in your language, you may want to:

- Add the word “like.” For example:

I would be like a person building on someone else's foundation

- Explain the metaphor in your translation. For example:

I strengthen a group of believers like someone building on someone else's foundation

- Translate literally and explain in a footnote. Here is an example footnote:

This refers to being the second person to help people believe and encourage them in their faith

- Translate the meaning without the figure of speech. For example:

I am the second person to preach and teach in a town. If you follow this option, your translation should not indicate or imply that Paul might have started a group of believers separate from the first group.

This is not talking about a physical building that believers meet in.

**foundation:** This word refers to the first layer of a house or building. The floors and walls are built on top of the foundation. Some languages do not have a

general word like foundation but must name the material of which the foundation is made. For example:

base stones

bricks

posts

## Romans 15:21

### Section 15:14–21: Paul encouraged them and said he was happy with his work/ministry

In this section, Paul told the believers in Rome that he was convinced that they were good, had knowledge, and were able to teach each other. He reminded them that he had been very bold in this letter. He wanted the Gentiles to be acceptable to God regarding their faith.

He told the believers in Rome that he was proud of his work for God. His work was to help Gentiles to believe in Jesus. He told them that he always wanted to preach the gospel where people did not know about Christ.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

Paul was an apostle to the Gentiles

Paul's Reason for Writing (NLT)

### 15:21a

#### Rather, as it is written:

- It is as the Scriptures say,
- That is like what Isaiah wrote in God's Book,

**Rather:** The Greek word indicates strong contrast. But the quote (15:21b–c) contrasts to “building on someone else's foundation.” The quote supports “I would not be building on someone else's foundation” (15:20c) rather than contrasts with it.

In some languages indicating contrast would indicate the correct meaning of the connection. But in some languages omitting the contrast would indicate the correct connection. For example:

As the scripture says (GNT)

in accordance with scripture: (NJB)

It is just as the Scriptures say (CEV)

**as it is written:** This clause introduces a quote from Scripture. See how you translated this clause in 15:9, except that here the prophet Isaiah wrote instead of King David.

### 15:21b

#### “Those who were not told about Him will see,

- “The ones to whom no one has spoken about him, they will see/understand,
- “The people, no one has told them about him, they will hear and understand his message.

This quote is from Isaiah 52:15. If you indicate the location of quotes from the Old Testament with cross-references, you may want to do so here.

**Those who were not told:** This is a passive clause. It implies someone telling these people rather than just overhearing the message. Some languages must use an active clause. For example:

Those whom someone has not told

Some languages can use “hear” and still imply that someone told them rather than just overhearing. For example:

Those who have not heard

**about Him:** Here the word about means “concerning.” For example:

of him (ESV)

The word Him refers to the person whom God called “my servant” in Isaiah 52:13. Jews of Paul's time understood this as a reference to the Messiah. This is a quote from the Old Testament. You should not explain to whom Him refers in your translation, or add the name Jesus. You may want to explain the meaning in a footnote. Here is an example footnote:

This refers to the Messiah, whom God called “my servant” just a few verses earlier, in Isaiah 52:13.

**will see:** Here the word see is a figure of speech that means “perceive/understand.” These people will understand the gospel of Jesus even though they had not heard it before. Some languages cannot use see in that way. If that is true in your language, translate the correct meaning. For example:

perceive/understand

### 15:21c

#### and those who have not heard will understand.”

- and the ones who have not yet heard about him will understand this new thing.”
- Those who have not heard it will understand its challenging message.”

**have not heard:** The phrase “about Him” is implied from 15:21b. In some languages it is more natural or clear to repeat it here. For example:

have never heard of him

**will understand:** The Greek word here refers to understanding something that challenges one’s thinking or way of life. BDAG. Many languages would need to translate this meaning with more than one word. For example:

understand the new idea/ideas

understand this new news

#### General Comment on 15:21b–c

The meaning of 15:21c is very similar to 15:21b. This is a common feature of Hebrew poetry. If possible, use words of similar meaning when translating these two lines. For example:

Those who have never been told of him will see/understand, and those who have never heard will be clear about it.

Those who have never been told of him will see/understand, and those who have never heard will be grasp its meaning.

## Romans 15:22

### Section 15:22–33: Paul planned to visit Rome

In this section, Paul explained his plan to go to Spain and visit the believers in Rome on the way. He also explained that he was currently going to Jerusalem with a gift of money for the poor believers there from the believers in Macedonia and Achaia. Once he was finished with that, he planned to go to Spain.

Paul asked the believers in Rome to pray for him. Paul wanted to avoid being blocked in his ministry by Jews who did not believe in Jesus. He also asked them to pray that the gift he was taking to Jerusalem would

be acceptable to the believers there. If it was, he would have joy and be able to enjoy his visit with the believers in Rome.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

Paul wanted to visit the believers in Rome on his way to Spain

Paul’s Plan to Visit Rome (NIV)

### 15:22

#### That is why I have often been hindered from coming to you.

- ¶ Therefore things often blocked my way so that I could not come to visit you.
- ¶ I had work in other areas, which often blocked my way so that I could not come to visit you.

**That is why:** This phrase probably introduces a result of God causing him to be the apostle who preaches in new places among the Gentiles (15:18–20). Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

For this/that reason

Therefore

You may want to make the connection to 15:18–20 clear:

- Explain the connection in your translation. For example:

God has caused me to work/minister in that way, therefore

- Translate the literal meaning and explain it in a footnote. Here is an example footnote:

The word “therefore” indicates that God caused Paul to be the apostle who preached in new places, therefore he had been unable to go to Rome.

But if the major language translation translates without explaining in any way, you may want to do the same.

**I have often been hindered:** This clause is passive. Probably included in what hindered him are the needs of the ministry. See Moo (page 899). Similarly Cranfield (page 766) calls it “the demands of his mis-

sionary labours,” and Dunn (page 871) calls it “Paul’s busyness.” negative circumstances, Jewett (page 922) begins his list with “imprisonments, injuries, shipwrecks....” or God’s will. Schreiner (page 744). Some languages must use an active clause. Use a general term for what hindered Paul. For example:

Things/Situations have often hindered me

**hindered:** This word refers to preventing something from happening. Here are other ways to translate this word:

prevented (NJB)

stopped/blocked

## Romans 15:23

### Section 15:22–33: Paul planned to visit Rome

In this section, Paul explained his plan to go to Spain and visit the believers in Rome on the way. He also explained that he was currently going to Jerusalem with a gift of money for the poor believers there from the believers in Macedonia and Achaia. Once he was finished with that, he planned to go to Spain.

Paul asked the believers in Rome to pray for him. Paul wanted to avoid being blocked in his ministry by Jews who did not believe in Jesus. He also asked them to pray that the gift he was taking to Jerusalem would be acceptable to the believers there. If it was, he would have joy and be able to enjoy his visit with the believers in Rome.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

Paul wanted to visit the believers in Rome on his way to Spain

Paul’s Plan to Visit Rome (NIV)

### 15:23a–b

**(REB:) But now I have no further scope in these parts, and I have been longing for many years to visit you:** The two Greek verbs that the REB translates as I have are literally “having.” There is no verb phrase in this sentence that makes this sentence complete. There are several ways to interpret the Greek sentence structure here:

1. Take both “having” verbs as “I have.” Greek sometimes uses an -ing ending for a verb with a normal ending. For example:

But now I have no new opportunities for work in this region. For many years I have wanted to visit you (GW) (REB, NET, GW, CEV, NLT)

1. Take the second “having” verb as “I have.” For example:

But now, with no further place for me in these regions, I desire, as I have for many years, to come to you (NRSV) (NRSV)

1. Keep both verbs as “having” and add “I plan.” For example:

But now that there is no more place for me to work in these regions, and since I have been longing for many years to see you, <sup>24</sup>I plan to do so (NIV) (NIV)

1. Keep both verbs as “having” and pull “I hope” from later in 15:24. For example:

But now that I have finished my work in these regions and since I have been wanting for so many years to come to see you, <sup>24</sup>I hope to do so now (GNT) (BSB, RSV, GNT, NJB, ESV, NCV, NABRE)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1), because it is a fairly common process in Greek to take a verb with the -ing ending and drop the meaning of -ing. It seems better to treat both “having” verbs equally (interpretation 1) rather than differently (interpretation 2). And interpreting the verse here as having this process occurring seems better than adding words to the text (interpretation 3). And it is better than pulling “I hope” out of its “for” clause (interpretation 4).

### 15:23a

**But now that there are no further opportunities for me in these regions,**

- But at the present time I no longer have new places within those regions to preach.
- But these days I have no new opportunity in those regions to do my apostle work.

**But now:** This phrase indicates contrast to being hindered in the past. The word now refers to the time that Paul wrote the letter.

**there are no further opportunities for me in these regions:** This indicates that Paul had preached where no one had yet preached throughout the area between

Jerusalem and Illyricum (15:19). He must now find new places. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

there is no more place for me to work in these regions (NIV)

I have finished my work in these regions (GNT)

**there are no further opportunities for me:** The word opportunities refers to having enough space in which to do something. There were no new areas between Jerusalem and Illyricum where Paul could preach where someone had not already preached. For example:

there is no more place for me (NIV)

The Greek word that the BSB translates as opportunities has its figurative sense here, “a favorable circumstance for doing something” (BDAG, sense 4). Here are other ways to translate according to that meaning:

I no longer have any opportunity (NABRE)

there is nothing left for me to do (CEV)

I have finished my work (GNT)

**these regions:** This refers to the area between Jerusalem and Illyricum (15:19). In some languages the word “those” would be more natural to refer back to the regions Paul talked about in 15:19. For example:

those regions

**regions:** The singular Greek word refers to an area the size of a Roman province or smaller, but larger than a city and its surrounding area.

#### 15:23b

**and since I have longed for many years to visit you,**

- I have wanted/desired for many years to go/come to you

**I have longed:** This Greek phrase is more literally “I have had a desire.” Paul had wanted to go to Rome for a long time.

**for many years:** Here the word many refers to probably twenty or less. It does imply a long time, not just one or two years. Do not use a word that indicates or implies much more than twenty years.

## Romans 15:24

### Section 15:22–33: Paul planned to visit Rome

In this section, Paul explained his plan to go to Spain and visit the believers in Rome on the way. He also explained that he was currently going to Jerusalem with a gift of money for the poor believers there from the believers in Macedonia and Achaia. Once he was finished with that, he planned to go to Spain.

Paul asked the believers in Rome to pray for him. Paul wanted to avoid being blocked in his ministry by Jews who did not believe in Jesus. He also asked them to pray that the gift he was taking to Jerusalem would be acceptable to the believers there. If it was, he would have joy and be able to enjoy his visit with the believers in Rome.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

Paul wanted to visit the believers in Rome on his way to Spain

Paul’s Plan to Visit Rome (NIV)

#### 15:24a

**I hope to see you on my way to Spain.**

- when I go to the land of Spain. For I hope to visit you for a short time,

Following interpretation (1) on 15:23a–b, Translator’s Notes uses the REB translation in the Display and the Notes for this verse part. This keeps the order of phrases following the Greek order and keeps the usual sense of the Greek word that the REB translates as “for.”

**(REB:) on my way to Spain:** There is a textual issue in 15:24a: (1) Some Greek manuscripts have the word Spain (BSB, RSV, NIV, GNT, NJB, NASB, NABRE, ESV, REB, NLT, GW, NET, NCV). (2) Some Greek manuscripts have the words Spain, I will come to you (KJV only). It is recommended that you follow option (1). The Greek words that the REB translates as on my way here mean “when” or “as soon as.” Jewett (page 923). They indicate that Paul planned to go to Spain, but did not know yet exactly when. For example:

when I go to Spain (NIV)

**(REB:) to Spain:** Spain is west of Rome, and its nearest point from Rome is 800–1,000 kilometers (500–600 miles) away, depending on the route the ship took. This was at least a five day journey by ship.



**(REB:) Spain:** This name refers here to a group of several Roman provinces that today is the land of the nations of Spain and Portugal. The old meaning does not exactly match the meaning today, so you may want to:

- Explain in your translation the old meaning. For example:

the province of Spain

- Explain only in a footnote. Here is an example footnote:

This name refers to the Roman province that today is the land of the nations of Spain and Portugal.

**(REB:) for:** Here this word introduces an explanation of something about Paul's journey to Spain.

**(REB:) I hope to see you in passing:** The Greek word that the REB translates as in passing is more literally "go/travel through." Here it indicates that Paul would travel to Rome but quickly continue on to Spain. Paul, in 15:24c, explained that he would remain only a short time in Rome. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

I hope to visit you while passing through (NIV)

I hope to see you while traveling through (TLV)

#### 15:24b

**And after I have enjoyed your company for a while,**

- and after I have enjoyed visiting with you for a while,

**after:** Paul hoped that after he stayed with them a little while they would help him travel to Spain.

**I have enjoyed your company:** This refers to being happy with his visit with the believers in Rome. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

I have enjoyed being with you (NABRE)

I have enjoyed visiting you (GNT)

#### 15:24c

**you can equip me for my journey.**

- I hope that you will help me on my journey there.

**you can equip me for my journey:** This clause indicates that Paul hoped that the believers in Rome would help him with the cost of going to Spain from Rome. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

you can provide for my journey (NLT)

I hope you can help me on my trip (NCV)

#### General Comment on 15:24b–c

In the Greek, Paul mentions being helped on his journey (15:24c) before enjoying their company (15:24b). However, since enjoying their company would occur before being helped on his journey, the BSB has reversed these clauses. In some languages it is acceptable to follow the Greek and have 15:24c first. For example:

<sup>24c</sup>and to be helped on my journey there by you,  
<sup>24b</sup>once I have enjoyed your company for a while  
(ESV)

### Romans 15:25

#### Section 15:22–33: Paul planned to visit Rome

In this section, Paul explained his plan to go to Spain and visit the believers in Rome on the way. He also explained that he was currently going to Jerusalem with a gift of money for the poor believers there from the believers in Macedonia and Achaia. Once he was finished with that, he planned to go to Spain.

Paul asked the believers in Rome to pray for him. Paul wanted to avoid being blocked in his ministry by Jews who did not believe in Jesus. He also asked them to pray that the gift he was taking to Jerusalem would be acceptable to the believers there. If it was, he would have joy and be able to enjoy his visit with the believers in Rome.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

Paul wanted to visit the believers in Rome on his way to Spain

Paul's Plan to Visit Rome (NIV)

#### 15:25a

**Now, however, I am on my way to Jerusalem**

- ¶ But now, I am ready to go to Jerusalem
- ¶ But at this present time, I am first going to Jerusalem.

**Now, however:** This is a translation of the same two words that the BSB translates as “But now” in 15:23. Here it introduces going to Jerusalem, which is in contrast to his hope to visit Rome on the way to Spain. For example:

But now (NJB)

**I am on my way to Jerusalem:** The present tense here probably indicates that soon after Paul sent this letter, he would leave Corinth on his journey to Jerusalem. See Moo (page 902), Cranfield (page 770), or Dunn (page 873). The English *am on my way* allows for this meaning. He probably did not write this letter while he was traveling. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

I am about to go to Jerusalem

I am going first to the village of Yerusalema  
Back Translation on TW.

#### 15:25b to serve the saints there.

- to help God’s holy people.
- I will help the people whom God has made holy.

**to serve:** The Greek word refers to helping others in some way. Here Paul implied the collection of money from the churches in Greece. The money would help the poor believers in Jerusalem. For example:

to help (NCV)

**the saints:** The Greek word that the BSB translates as saints is literally “holy (ones).” It can mean “holy people,” “people dedicated/consecrated to God,” or “people whom God has made holy.” Here it probably implies all of these meanings. In the New Testament, this word refers to all Christians, not to any special group of Christians. See how you translated this word in 1:7 or 12:13.

## Romans 15:26

### Section 15:22–33: Paul planned to visit Rome

In this section, Paul explained his plan to go to Spain and visit the believers in Rome on the way. He also explained that he was currently going to Jerusalem with a gift of money for the poor believers there from the believers in Macedonia and Achaia. Once he was finished with that, he planned to go to Spain.

Paul asked the believers in Rome to pray for him. Paul wanted to avoid being blocked in his ministry by Jews who did not believe in Jesus. He also asked them to pray that the gift he was taking to Jerusalem would be acceptable to the believers there. If it was, he would have joy and be able to enjoy his visit with the believers in Rome.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

Paul wanted to visit the believers in Rome on his way to Spain

Paul’s Plan to Visit Rome (NIV)

#### 15:26a

#### For Macedonia and Achaia were pleased to make a contribution

- For the believers in Macedonia and Achaia have gladly chosen to help
- For the churches in the provinces of Macedonia and Achaia willingly decided to share their money

**For:** Here this word introduces an explanation of “to serve the saints” in 15:25b.

**Macedonia and Achaia:** These two names were Roman provinces of Greek people and their land. In some languages it is more natural or informative to explain these names. For example:

the Roman provinces of Macedonia and Achaia

The believers in Rome would know what these names refer to. You may want to explain them in a footnote instead. Here is an example footnote:

These two names were the Roman provinces of Greek people and their land.

Here it implies the believers in Macedonia and Achaia, not all the people there. In some languages it is more clear to indicate that. For example:

the believers of Macedonia and Achaia

**were pleased:** The Greek here refers to thinking that something is good to do and so good to choose to do. BDAG, sense 1. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

decided it was good

gladly decided

**a contribution:** Here the word a, in front of the singular word contribution, indicates that Paul referred generally to this contribution while also not saying what kind of contribution it was. For example:

some contribution (ESV)

**contribution:** The Greek word refers to something that is shared because of the good relationship one has with someone else. Here it refers to the sharing of money from the churches in Macedonia and Achaia with the poor believers in Jerusalem. Here are other ways to translate this word:

share their resources (NRSV)

money (CEV)

#### **15:26b for the poor among the saints in Jerusalem.**

- the poor people among God's holy people in Jerusalem.
- with the people whom God has made holy who are poor and live in Jerusalem.

**saints:** See how you translated this word in 15:25b.

### **Romans 15:27**

#### **Section 15:22–33: Paul planned to visit Rome**

In this section, Paul explained his plan to go to Spain and visit the believers in Rome on the way. He also explained that he was currently going to Jerusalem with a gift of money for the poor believers there from the believers in Macedonia and Achaia. Once he was finished with that, he planned to go to Spain.

Paul asked the believers in Rome to pray for him. Paul wanted to avoid being blocked in his ministry by Jews who did not believe in Jesus. He also asked them to pray that the gift he was taking to Jerusalem would be acceptable to the believers there. If it was, he would have joy and be able to enjoy his visit with the believers in Rome.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

Paul wanted to visit the believers in Rome on his way to Spain

Paul's Plan to Visit Rome (NIV)

#### **15:27a**

**They were pleased to do it, and indeed they owe it to them.**

- For they have gladly chosen to help, and they are indebted to them.
- For they were willing, but they also have a duty/obligation to help the Jewish believers there.

The Greek of 15:27a begins with a word that is often translated as “for.” The BSB omits this word. It introduces an explanation of “make a contribution” in 15:26a.

**They were pleased to do it, and indeed:** The phrase They were pleased to do it translates one Greek word, which the BSB translates as were pleased in 15:26a. The phrase and indeed translates one Greek word, usually translated as and or “but,” and sometimes indeed. Together in this situation the two Greek words indicate in addition to being pleased to help the poor believers in Jerusalem, they are also indebted to them. Here are other ways to translate these words:

they were pleased to do so, and (NASB)

they were pleased to do that, but also

**they owe it to them:** The Greek is more literally “they are their debtors.” The Savior of the world, Jesus, was born a Jew, and God worked in the history of the Jews to bring about his coming. The spiritual blessings from those things require Gentile believers to help the Jewish believers in Jerusalem with material things in return. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

they are in debt to them (RSV)

they have an obligation to help them (GNT)

#### **15:27b**

**For if the Gentiles have shared in their spiritual blessings,**

- For if the Gentiles have begun to share in God's blessings to their spirits, and that is true,
- For the non-Jews now share in the blessings that God gave to the Jews, blessings of/in the spirit. Therefore

**For:** Here this word introduces an explanation of “they owe it to them” in 15:27a.

**if the Gentiles have shared in their spiritual blessings:** Here the word if introduces a situation that is

true. If this first part is true, that supports the second part to also be true (they ought also to be of service to the Jews in material blessings (15:27c)).

In some languages, translating literally here would have a different meaning. If that is true in your language, translate the correct meaning. For example:

if it is true that the Gentiles have come to share in their spiritual blessings

the Gentiles have come to share in their spiritual blessings, therefore

**have shared:** Long ago the Gentiles did not share in the spiritual blessings of the Jews but in the more recent past they began to share in them. Sharing in the blessings began when Gentiles such as Cornelius (Acts 10) began believing in Jesus as the Christ/Messiah. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make that idea more explicit. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

have begun to share

have come to share (ESV)

The Greek tense is often translated by the English past tense, but it does not imply that the sharing has stopped, as the English past tense sometimes does.

**their spiritual blessings:** This phrase refers to the blessings that God gave to the Jews, including his promises to them and him calling them his people. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

their blessings in their spirits

the blessings that God gave to their spirits

**spiritual:** Here this word refers to things of the spirit and religion, rather than physical things such as crops and houses. See the above examples.

#### 15:27c

**they are obligated to minister to them with material blessings.**

- then they must also serve them with God's blessings to their needs.
- the non-Jews have a duty/obligation to help them with the things they have for their physical needs, blessings of the things of this earth.

**they are obligated:** Here the phrase indicates that the Gentiles should be of service to the Jews. The Greek has the same root as "owe" in 15:27a.

**to minister to them with material blessings:** Here the words to minister to them refers to doing things that benefit others. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

use their material blessings to help (GNT)

to serve them in material blessings (NABRE)

**material blessings:** This refers to physical things that God has blessed people with, implying all the things a person has, including money, food, and homes. In this case the believers only send money, but Paul here spoke generally. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

blessings that are physical/things

the blessings that God gave for their physical needs

## Romans 15:28

### Section 15:22–33: Paul planned to visit Rome

In this section, Paul explained his plan to go to Spain and visit the believers in Rome on the way. He also explained that he was currently going to Jerusalem with a gift of money for the poor believers there from the believers in Macedonia and Achaia. Once he was finished with that, he planned to go to Spain.

Paul asked the believers in Rome to pray for him. Paul wanted to avoid being blocked in his ministry by Jews who did not believe in Jesus. He also asked them to pray that the gift he was taking to Jerusalem would be acceptable to the believers there. If it was, he would have joy and be able to enjoy his visit with the believers in Rome.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

Paul wanted to visit the believers in Rome on his way to Spain

Paul's Plan to Visit Rome (NIV)

#### 15:28a

**So after I have completed this service**

- So, when I complete that deed

- Therefore, I will finish doing that

**So after:** In many languages the word So must be first in the clause. For example:

Therefore, when (NASB)

**this service:** Here this word refers to taking the money to the poor believers in Jerusalem (15:25–26). For example:

this task (NIV)

In some languages “that” or “those things” would indicate the correct reference.

**15:28b**  
**and have safely delivered this bounty to them,**

- and give to them the guaranteed full amount,
- and give to them all of the money I collect.

**have safely delivered:** The Greek word here is literally “having sealed.” It indicates that the full amount of the money was given to the believers in Jerusalem. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

officially turned over (GW)

in full

**this bounty:** The Greek is literally “this fruit.” It refers to the money that Greek churches are sending to the poor believers in Jerusalem. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

this harvest (NJB)

this contribution (NABRE)

this money (NLT)

**15:28c**  
**I will set off to Spain by way of you.**

- I will go to Spain and stop to visit you.
- Then I will leave Jerusalem and visit you on my way to Spain.

**I will set off to Spain by way of you:** It is implied here that Paul would leave Jerusalem to go to Spain. The phrase by way of you indicates that Paul planned to stop in Rome on his way to Spain. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

I will go to Spain and visit you on the way (NIV)

I shall visit you on the way to Spain (NJB)

## Romans 15:29

### Section 15:22–33: Paul planned to visit Rome

In this section, Paul explained his plan to go to Spain and visit the believers in Rome on the way. He also explained that he was currently going to Jerusalem with a gift of money for the poor believers there from the believers in Macedonia and Achaia. Once he was finished with that, he planned to go to Spain.

Paul asked the believers in Rome to pray for him. Paul wanted to avoid being blocked in his ministry by Jews who did not believe in Jesus. He also asked them to pray that the gift he was taking to Jerusalem would be acceptable to the believers there. If it was, he would have joy and be able to enjoy his visit with the believers in Rome.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

Paul wanted to visit the believers in Rome on his way to Spain

Paul’s Plan to Visit Rome (NIV)

### 15:29a

**I know that when I come to you,**

- And I know that, coming to you,
- I know that I will travel there to you,

**when I come to you:** The Greek is more literally “coming to you.” Here it implies when rather than “if.” (Morris (page 522).

### 15:29b

**I will come in the fullness of the blessing of Christ.**

- I will come with the full blessing of Christ.
- and I will come because Jesus Christ has blessed that work.

**in the fullness of the blessing of Christ:** There is a textual issue in 15:29b: (1) Some Greek manuscripts have the word blessing (BSB, RSV, NIV, GNT, NJB, NASB, NABRE, ESV, REB, NLT, GW, NET, NCV). (2) Some Greek manuscripts have the words blessing of the gospel (KJV only). It is recommended that you follow option (1). Here the word fullness indicates that, like a basket that is full of good things, the blessing of Christ will be great, rather than small. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

with a full measure of the blessing of Christ (GNT)

with the fullest blessing of Christ (NJB)

very great will be the blessing of Christ  
Western Bukidnon Manobo Back Translation on TW.

**in:** Here this word indicates either means or instrument (BDAG, sense 5), or accompaniment (L&N, §89.80). For example:

with (GNT)

**the blessing of Christ:** The word of here indicates that Jesus would bless Paul. For example:

Christ's blessing (NABRE)

Paul would go to Rome with that blessing, which probably implies that Jesus would bless the believers in Rome also.

## Romans 15:30

### Section 15:22–33: Paul planned to visit Rome

In this section, Paul explained his plan to go to Spain and visit the believers in Rome on the way. He also explained that he was currently going to Jerusalem with a gift of money for the poor believers there from the believers in Macedonia and Achaia. Once he was finished with that, he planned to go to Spain.

Paul asked the believers in Rome to pray for him. Paul wanted to avoid being blocked in his ministry by Jews who did not believe in Jesus. He also asked them to pray that the gift he was taking to Jerusalem would be acceptable to the believers there. If it was, he would have joy and be able to enjoy his visit with the believers in Rome.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

Paul wanted to visit the believers in Rome on his way to Spain

Paul's Plan to Visit Rome (NIV)

### 15:30a

#### Now I urge you, brothers,

- ¶ Brothers and sisters, I urge you
- ¶ And so/now, my fellow believers, I encourage you,

**Now:** The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as Now introduces a new but related topic. It is not a time word. Translate it in a way that is natural for starting to write about a new topic or theme.

**I urge you, brothers:** The word brothers is in the end of what Paul said to them, both in the Greek and in the BSB. In some languages this word must be first. For example:

Brothers, I appeal to you

**I urge you:** The Greek word that the BSB translates as urge has a wide range of meaning. Many scholars believe it means “exhort” here. Moo (page 909) and Dunn (page 878) both say it does not mean “ask.” Here are other ways to translate this clause:

I appeal to you (ESV)

I encourage you (GW)

**brothers:** This word refers to all the believers living in Rome, both men and women. The word indicates a close relationship between believers because God has made them his (adopted) children. See how you translated this word in 1:13 or 15:14.

### 15:30b

#### by our Lord Jesus Christ and by the love of the Spirit,

- through our relationship with our<sup>(incl)</sup> Lord Jesus Christ and because of the love from the Spirit,
- because we belong to our Lord Jesus Christ and the Holy Spirit causes us to love one another,

**by our Lord Jesus Christ:** This phrase indicates that Paul appealed to the Roman believers in the name of Jesus Christ. See Moo (page 909). Paul asked them to pray for him because they all believed in Jesus and this is something that Jesus wanted them to do. For example:

in the name of our Lord Jesus Christ (NLT)

**by the love of the Spirit:** This phrase indicates that love from the Holy Spirit is the basis for Paul appealing to them to pray for him. Moo (page 909) and Cranfield (page 776) call it “ground,” which has the same meaning as “basis” here. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

by the love that the Spirit creates (GW)

on the basis of the love from the Spirit

because of...the love that the Holy Spirit gives us (NCV)

### 15:30c

**to join me in my struggle by praying to God for me.**

- to work hard together with me in praying before God for me.
- to pray before God with much effort, together with me, for me.

**to join me in my struggle by praying:** Here the Greek word that the BSB translates as struggle refers to working hard at helping someone. Here it refers to earnestly praying for Paul, as Paul prayed for himself in taking the collection of money to Jerusalem. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

to join me in earnest prayer to God on my behalf (NRSV)

to join fervently with me in prayer to God on my behalf (NET)

**for me:** This phrase indicates that Paul wanted the Roman believers to pray for him, as he explained in 15:31a–b.

## Romans 15:31

### Section 15:22–33: Paul planned to visit Rome

In this section, Paul explained his plan to go to Spain and visit the believers in Rome on the way. He also explained that he was currently going to Jerusalem with a gift of money for the poor believers there from the believers in Macedonia and Achaia. Once he was finished with that, he planned to go to Spain.

Paul asked the believers in Rome to pray for him. Paul wanted to avoid being blocked in his ministry by Jews who did not believe in Jesus. He also asked them to pray that the gift he was taking to Jerusalem would be acceptable to the believers there. If it was, he would have joy and be able to enjoy his visit with the believers in Rome.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

Paul wanted to visit the believers in Rome on his way to Spain

Paul's Plan to Visit Rome (NIV)

### 15:31a

**Pray that I may be delivered from the unbelievers in Judea,**

- Pray<sup>(plur)</sup> that I may be protected from the Jews in Judea who do not believe,
- Pray that God will keep me safe from the Jews in the province of Judea who do not believe that Jesus is the Christ/Messiah.

**Pray that:** Here this phrase introduces what Paul wanted the Roman believers to strive in praying for (15:30c).

**I may be delivered:** Here the word delivered refers to God preventing the unbelievers in Judea from harming Paul. It does not mean “rescue” here, since Paul was not in their hands when he wrote this letter. See Morris (page 523). Here are other ways to translate this clause:

I may be kept safe (NIV11)

I may be protected

This clause is passive. Some languages must use an active clause. For example:

God may deliver/protect

**the unbelievers in Judea:** Here the word unbelievers refers to Jews who did not believe in Jesus as the Christ/Messiah. They may believe in God and follow the Jewish religion. In some languages a literal translation would indicate that they do not believe in God. If that is true in your language, you may want to:

- Explain the correct meaning in your translation. For example:

the people of Judea who do not believe in Jesus

- Translate literally and explain in a footnote. Here is an example footnote:

This refers to Jews who did not believe in Jesus as the Christ/Messiah.

### 15:31b

**and that my service in Jerusalem may be acceptable to the saints there,**

- and that my work of helping the poor in Jerusalem may be accepted by God's holy people.

- And pray that the people whom God has made holy will accept this help from me for the poor believers in Jerusalem,

**and that:** Here these words introduce the second thing that Paul wanted the Roman believers to strive in praying for (15:30c).

**my service in Jerusalem may be acceptable to the saints there:** This clause is passive. Some languages must use an active clause. For example:

the saints may accept my service for Jerusalem

**my service:** The Greek word that the BSB translates as service refers to helping others. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

my ministry (NABRE)

my work as a/their servant

See how you translated the word “serving” in 12:7.

**in Jerusalem:** The money was to go to the poor believers who lived in Jerusalem. By just saying Jerusalem here, Paul may have implied that this money indirectly would help all people of Jerusalem. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

to Jerusalem (NIV)

for Jerusalem (ESV)

Your translation should not indicate or imply that the money would go to all the people of Jerusalem. This may already be clear from earlier verses. But if it does indicate or imply all the people of Jerusalem, you may want to:

- Explain the meaning in your translation. For example:

for the poor believers/ones in Jerusalem

- Explain in a footnote. Here is an example footnote:

Here Paul referred to the poor believers in Jerusalem.

**saints:** See how you translated this word in 15:25b.

## Romans 15:32

### Section 15:22–33: Paul planned to visit Rome

In this section, Paul explained his plan to go to Spain and visit the believers in Rome on the way. He also explained that he was currently going to Jerusalem with a gift of money for the poor believers there from the believers in Macedonia and Achaia. Once he was finished with that, he planned to go to Spain.

Paul asked the believers in Rome to pray for him. Paul wanted to avoid being blocked in his ministry by Jews who did not believe in Jesus. He also asked them to pray that the gift he was taking to Jerusalem would be acceptable to the believers there. If it was, he would have joy and be able to enjoy his visit with the believers in Rome.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

Paul wanted to visit the believers in Rome on his way to Spain

Paul’s Plan to Visit Rome (NIV)

### 15:32a

#### so that by God’s will I may come to you with joy

- In that way, if God chooses, I will come to you with joy,
- so that, if God wants me to journey to Rome, I may go/come to you, feeling happy,

**so that:** This phrase introduces the purpose for Paul to be delivered from unbelievers (15:31a) and for the believers in Jerusalem to accept his service (15:31b).

**by God’s will I may come to you with joy:** The phrase by God’s will is emphasized by being first in the clause in the BSB. But it is not first in the Greek. Put this phrase in its usual position in your translation. For example:

I may come to you with joy by God’s will

**by God’s will:** This indicates that God would decide if Paul would go or not. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

that God will decide/choose that

that God will allow

if God wants it (NCV)



See how you translated this in 1:10.

### 15:32b

#### and together with you be refreshed.

- and we<sup>(incl)</sup> together will restore/regain our strength.
- and so that I together with you<sup>(plur)</sup> may get our strength back.

**together with you:** This phrase indicates that Paul and the Roman believers would be together and they would all experience being refreshed. For example:

together with you (NABRE)

**be refreshed:** The word refreshed refers to resting and getting one's strength back again. Here it would refer mostly to mental, motivational, and emotional strength, rather than physical strength. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

find refreshing rest (NASB)

I will have a time of rest (NCV)

## Romans 15:33

### Section 15:22–33: Paul planned to visit Rome

In this section, Paul explained his plan to go to Spain and visit the believers in Rome on the way. He also explained that he was currently going to Jerusalem with a gift of money for the poor believers there from the believers in Macedonia and Achaia. Once he was finished with that, he planned to go to Spain.

Paul asked the believers in Rome to pray for him. Paul wanted to avoid being blocked in his ministry by Jews who did not believe in Jesus. He also asked them to pray that the gift he was taking to Jerusalem would be acceptable to the believers there. If it was, he would have joy and be able to enjoy his visit with the believers in Rome.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

Paul wanted to visit the believers in Rome on his way to Spain

Paul's Plan to Visit Rome (NIV)

### 15:33

#### The God of peace be with all of you. Amen.

- ¶ I ask God, the one who gives peace, to be with you all. Amen.

- ¶ God is the one who causes you to have peace. I pray to him that he will be with all of you. It is true.

**The God of peace be with all of you:** This indicates that Paul wanted God to be with the Roman believers. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

I pray that the God of peace will be with you all

I request that God, who gives peace, be with you all

I desire that God, the one who enables us to have peace, will be with you all

See how you translated a similar clause ("May the God of hope fill you") in 15:13.

**The God of peace:** The word of indicates that God is the source of peace.

**peace:** This word refers to having no conflicts with other people or with God. The Greek word may also indicate wholeness or well-being. See how you translated this word in 1:7 or 15:13.

**Amen:** The word Amen is a Hebrew word that means "even so" or "it is true." The Greek borrowed the Hebrew word. English borrowed this word as well. It is used to agree with what was said. Paul wrote this expecting his readers to agree as well.

See how you translated this word in 1:25 or 11:36.

## Romans 16:1

### Section 16:1–24: Paul greeted the believers in Rome

In this section, Paul told the believers to welcome Phoebe when she arrived in Rome and to help her. It is likely that Phoebe carried this letter to Rome.

Then Paul greeted a number of believers whom he had already met. He often used an encouraging description of the person he was greeting.

Then he encouraged the believers in Rome to welcome one another. He warned them to watch out for people who cause divisions or create problems among the believers. He told them to avoid such people. He reminded them that such people only do things for their own selfish interests. He reminded the believers in Rome that people in many places know that the believers obey God well. He encouraged them by saying that God would soon defeat Satan. He blessed them with the grace of Jesus.

He relayed greetings to them from people who were there with him.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

Final Instructions and Greetings (ESV)

He greeted them and instructed them one last time

Paul greeted the believers there

### 16:1

**I commend to you our sister Phoebe, a servant of the church in Cenchrea.**

- ¶ Phoebe is our sister in Christ and a deacon of the community of believers at/of Cenchreae. I introduce her to you<sup>(plur)</sup>
- ¶ Phoebe is a deacon among the believers in the town of Cenchreae. I present her to you.

**commend:** This word refers to introducing or recommending one person to another person or to a group. Someone known to the group encourages them to accept the new person. Here are other ways to translate this word:

recommend (GNT)

With this letter I'm introducing Phoebe to you (GW)

**our sister Phoebe:** Here the word sister indicates that Phoebe was a fellow believer who was a woman.

In some languages sister would be understood as a literal sister of Paul. If that is true in your language, use the normal word or phrase for a fellow believer. For example:

our sister who believes in Jesus/Christ

our<sup>(incl)</sup> fellow female believer

our friend

**(NIV11:) deacon:** There are several ways to interpret the Greek word that the NIV11 translates as deacon:

1. This word refers to the ministry in the church of helping others in need. For example:

deacon (NRSV) (RSV, NIV11, NJB, NLT, GW)

1. This word refers to any kind of servant role in the church. For example:

servant (ESV) (BSB, NIV84, GNT, KJV, NASB, ESV, NET)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1), because the L&N lexicon and many scholars support it. Moo says, "'of the church' suggests...that Phoebe held at Cenchreae the 'office' of 'deacon' as Paul describes it in 1 Tim. 3:8-12 (cf. Phil. 1:1)." Longenecker, Cranfield, Dunn, Schreiner, and Jewett also support interpretation (1).

**the church:** Here the Greek word that the BSB translates as church refers to all the people in Cenchreae who believe in Jesus.

**Cenchrea:** This refers to a town near the Greek city of Corinth. This Greek name is spelled Cenchrea in English letters. (The Greek sound spelled 'ch' here is similar to a "k" but without making the air stop in the mouth.)

## Romans 16:2

### Section 16:1-24: Paul greeted the believers in Rome

In this section, Paul told the believers to welcome Phoebe when she arrived in Rome and to help her. It is likely that Phoebe carried this letter to Rome.

Then Paul greeted a number of believers whom he had already met. He often used an encouraging description of the person he was greeting.

Then he encouraged the believers in Rome to welcome one another. He warned them to watch out for people who cause divisions or create problems among the believers. He told them to avoid such people. He reminded them that such people only do things for their own selfish interests. He reminded the believers in Rome that people in many places know that the believers obey God well. He encouraged them by saying that God would soon defeat Satan. He blessed them with the grace of Jesus.

He relayed greetings to them from people who were there with him.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

Final Instructions and Greetings (ESV)

He greeted them and instructed them one last time

Paul greeted the believers there

#### 16:2a

**Welcome her in the Lord in a manner worthy of the saints,**

- so that you will welcome her in the name of the Lord as is right/proper for God's holy people.
- I want you to welcome her as the/our<sup>(incl)</sup> Lord Jesus would, in the way that the people whom God has made holy should look after one another.

**Welcome:** The Greek word refers to bringing in someone into your group of friends and accepting him or her.

accept (NCV)

receive (RSV)

**in the Lord:** Here this phrase refers to the relationship that believers have with each other because they are Christians. They all are connected because they are in the Lord. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

in the fellowship of the Lord (REB)

like your relative in the Lord JesusUma Back Translation on TW.

**in a manner worthy of the saints:** This phrase indicates that the believers are to welcome Phoebe in a way that is appropriate for believers to welcome other believers. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

as one who is worthy of honor among God's people (NLT)

in a way that is proper for...one of God's own people (CEV)

**saints:** The Greek word that the BSB translates as saints is literally "holy (ones)." It can mean "holy people," "people dedicated/consecrated to God," or "people whom God has made holy." Here it probably implies all of these meanings. In the New Testament, this word refers to all Christians, not to any special group of Christians. See how you translated this word in 1:7 or 15:31.

#### 16:2b

**and assist her with anything she may need from you.**

- And stand with her in whatever matter she may need assistance from you,
- Also, if she needs you to help her with anything, help her,

**assist her with anything she may need from you:**

The Greek text is more literally "stand with her in whatever matter she may need of you." Paul wanted the believers in Rome to assist Phoebe in something she needed to do in Rome, if she asked them for help. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

help her in any way she may need you to

help her with anything she needs from you

#### 16:2c

**For she has been a great help to many people, including me.**

- because she became a supporter/benefactor of many, including myself.
- since she has routinely/regularly helped many people very much, and me too.

**For:** This introduces the reason Paul wanted the believers in Rome to help Phoebe.

**a great help:** This word refers to someone who supports someone or a cause. He supports them regularly and with a large amount (not just a little bit of money here and there).

### Romans 16:3

**Section 16:1-24: Paul greeted the believers in Rome**

In this section, Paul told the believers to welcome Phoebe when she arrived in Rome and to help her. It is likely that Phoebe carried this letter to Rome.

Then Paul greeted a number of believers whom he had already met. He often used an encouraging description of the person he was greeting.

Then he encouraged the believers in Rome to welcome one another. He warned them to watch out for people who cause divisions or create problems among the believers. He told them to avoid such people. He reminded them that such people only do things for their own selfish interests. He reminded the believers in Rome that people in many places know that the believers obey God well. He encouraged them by saying

that God would soon defeat Satan. He blessed them with the grace of Jesus.

He relayed greetings to them from people who were there with him.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

Final Instructions and Greetings (ESV)

He greeted them and instructed them one last time

Paul greeted the believers there

### 16:3

**Greet Prisca and Aquila, my fellow workers in Christ Jesus,**

- ¶ I Greet<sup>(plur)</sup> for me Prisca and Aquila, co-workers with me working for Christ Jesus.
- ¶ I Give my greetings of respect to Prisca and Aquila. They do the same work as I do for Jesus, he/who is the Deliverer whom God promised to send.

**Greet Prisca and Aquila:** In 16:3–15, the people Paul named lived in Rome and were a part of the group of believers there. Paul used the word Greet to indicate that he greeted the people named here. See Dunn (page 891). The named people were likely all people whom Paul already knew. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

My greetings to Prisca and Aquila (NJB)

Give greetings of my respect to Prisca and Aquila

**Prisca and Aquila:** Prisca was the wife of Aquila (Acts 18:2).

**Prisca:** Paul used this form of the name. Luke (in Acts) used “Priscilla,” which means “little Prisca,” probably a nickname. Some English versions note the other form of the name in a footnote. Here is an example footnote:

Luke (in Acts) called this woman “Priscilla,” a nickname that means “little Prisca.”

**my fellow workers in Christ Jesus:** This phrase indicates that Prisca and Aquila did the same work as Paul, evangelizing in various places and helping the believers there. Sometimes they worked together with Paul in the same place and sometimes they worked

in some other place. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

my co-workers in Christ Jesus (NIV11)

they do the same work in Christ Jesus as me

**in Christ Jesus:** Here the word in indicates that the work was for Jesus and his gospel and done by his power.

**Christ Jesus:** The order of the words Christ Jesus emphasizes that Jesus is the Christ/Messiah. However, in some languages the order Christ Jesus is not natural. If that is true in your language, emphasize, if possible, the fact that Jesus is the Christ in a natural way. For example:

Jesus, who/he is the Christ

Jesus, the Messiah,

See how you translated this phrase in 1:1 or 15:17.

## Romans 16:4

### Section 16:1–24: Paul greeted the believers in Rome

In this section, Paul told the believers to welcome Phoebe when she arrived in Rome and to help her. It is likely that Phoebe carried this letter to Rome.

Then Paul greeted a number of believers whom he had already met. He often used an encouraging description of the person he was greeting.

Then he encouraged the believers in Rome to welcome one another. He warned them to watch out for people who cause divisions or create problems among the believers. He told them to avoid such people. He reminded them that such people only do things for their own selfish interests. He reminded the believers in Rome that people in many places know that the believers obey God well. He encouraged them by saying that God would soon defeat Satan. He blessed them with the grace of Jesus.

He relayed greetings to them from people who were there with him.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

Final Instructions and Greetings (ESV)

He greeted them and instructed them one last time

Paul greeted the believers there

#### 16:4a

**who have risked their lives for me.**

- They put themselves in danger of dying in order to save my life.
- They endangered their own lives to rescue me from death.

**who have risked their lives for me:** Here this clause further describes Prisca and Aquila. It does not separate this Prisca and Aquila from other couples with the same names. For the correct meaning in some languages, translators must avoid the word who. For example:

and they risked their lives for my life

They risked their lives for my life

**have risked their lives for me:** The phrase that the BSB translates as risked their lives is literally “risked their necks.” The phrase is a figure of speech that refers to putting oneself in danger of being killed. We do not know what situation this refers to. But Prisca and Aquila put themselves at risk of losing their own lives in order to save Paul from someone or something trying to kill him. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

risked their own necks to save my life (NJB)

risked their lives for me (NIV)

they risked dying to rescue me from dying

#### 16:4b

**Not only I but all the churches of the Gentiles are grateful to them.**

- Not only I thank them, but all the communities of Gentile believers also thank them.
- I tell them thank you. But not only me, all the groups of believers in non-Jewish towns tell them thank you as well.

**Not only I but all the churches of the Gentiles are grateful to them:** The word them refers to Prisca and Aquila. It may be more natural in some languages

for the translator to avoid the word them here. For example:

Not only I but all the churches of the Gentiles are grateful to Prisca and Aquila.

The phrases Not only I and but all the churches of the Gentiles indicate that Paul gave thanks and these churches gave thanks as well. They also emphasize that Paul was not the only person to give thanks. Here are other ways to translate these words:

I am thankful to them, and so are all the Gentile churches (NLT)

I thank them. And that’s not all, all groups of believers who are not Jews thank them also.

**the churches:** See how you translated the word “church” in 16:1.

**Gentiles:** The word Gentiles refers to non-Jewish people. See how you translated this word in 1:13 or 15:27.

**are grateful:** This refers to saying words of appreciation to someone. For example:

say thanks

thank

### Romans 16:5

#### Section 16:1-24: Paul greeted the believers in Rome

In this section, Paul told the believers to welcome Phoebe when she arrived in Rome and to help her. It is likely that Phoebe carried this letter to Rome.

Then Paul greeted a number of believers whom he had already met. He often used an encouraging description of the person he was greeting.

Then he encouraged the believers in Rome to welcome one another. He warned them to watch out for people who cause divisions or create problems among the believers. He told them to avoid such people. He reminded them that such people only do things for their own selfish interests. He reminded the believers in Rome that people in many places know that the believers obey God well. He encouraged them by saying that God would soon defeat Satan. He blessed them with the grace of Jesus.

He relayed greetings to them from people who were there with him.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

Final Instructions and Greetings (ESV)

He greeted them and instructed them one last time

Paul greeted the believers there

#### 16:5a

**Greet also the church that meets at their house.**

- And greet<sup>(plur)</sup> for me the believers who meet in their<sup>(dual)</sup> house.
- Also, give my greetings of respect to the believers who go to their house to worship God.

**Greet also the church that meets at their house:**

Here the word church refers to the group of believers that met in the house of Prisca and Aquila. It is implied that this group met every week to worship God. It is not known if they met more than once a week. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

Also greet the believers who meet in their house

announce my greeting to all the believers in the Lord Jesus who hold-services in their houseUma Back Translation on TW.

Greet also all of the believers who meet together in their house to worship GodWestern Bukidnon Manobo Back Translation on TW.

**Greet:** Translate this word as you did in 16:3. This word is used with the same meaning in 16:6-15.

#### 16:5b

**Greet my beloved Epenetus, who was the first convert to Christ in the province of Asia.**

- Greet for me Epenetus, the one I love. He was the first person in Asia to believe in Christ.
- Give my greetings of respect to Epenetus. He is my dear brother in Christ. He was the first person in the province of Asia to believe in Jesus Christ.

**my beloved Epenetus:** This phrase indicates that Paul loved Epenetus as a Christian brother. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

Epenetus, whom I love

my dear brother in Christ, Epenetus

my dear friend Epenetus (NIV)

**who was the first convert to Christ in the province of Asia:** This further describes Epenetus. It does not separate this Epenetus from other men named Epenetus. For the correct meaning in some languages, the word who must be replaced with something else and possibly a new sentence started. For example:

and he was the first convert to Christ in the province of Asia

He was the first convert to Christ in the province of Asia

**the first convert to Christ in the province of Asia:** This means that Epenetus was the first person in Asia to leave his previous religious beliefs and believe in Jesus.

**the province of Asia:** There is a textual issue in 16:5b: (1) Some Greek manuscripts have the word Asia (BSB, RSV, NIV, GNT, NJB, NASB, NABRE, ESV, REB, NLT, GW, NET, NCV). (2) Some Greek manuscripts have the word Achaia (KJV only). It is recommended that you follow option (1). At that time the name Asia referred to a region in what is now the western part of the country of Turkey. But in English the name now refers to a much larger region very far east of Turkey that includes the country of China.

The BSB adds the phrase the province of to indicate the old meaning. You may also want to explain its meaning in a footnote. Here is an example footnote:

At that time, the name Asia referred to a province under Roman rule that was across the Aegean Sea east of Greece. It was in the western part of what is now the country of Turkey.

## Romans 16:6

**Section 16:1-24: Paul greeted the believers in Rome**

In this section, Paul told the believers to welcome Phoebe when she arrived in Rome and to help her. It is likely that Phoebe carried this letter to Rome.

Then Paul greeted a number of believers whom he had already met. He often used an encouraging description of the person he was greeting.

Then he encouraged the believers in Rome to welcome one another. He warned them to watch out for people

who cause divisions or create problems among the believers. He told them to avoid such people. He reminded them that such people only do things for their own selfish interests. He reminded the believers in Rome that people in many places know that the believers obey God well. He encouraged them by saying that God would soon defeat Satan. He blessed them with the grace of Jesus.

He relayed greetings to them from people who were there with him.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

Final Instructions and Greetings (ESV)

He greeted them and instructed them one last time

Paul greeted the believers there

#### 16:6

##### **Greet Mary, who has worked very hard for you.**

- Greet Mary for me. She has labored much for you<sup>(plur)</sup>.
- Give my greetings of respect to Mary. She worked very hard for Christ in order to help you.

**Mary:** This woman is not otherwise known. This name probably does not refer to any other Mary in the Bible. The Greek spelling of this name, using English letters, is Maria.

**who has worked very hard for you:** This further describes this Mary. It does not separate this Mary from other Marys. For the correct meaning, some languages must avoid the word who, or start a new sentence. For example:

She has worked very hard for you.

**has worked very hard:** The Greek is more literally “labored much.” It is implied that Mary had worked hard for the gospel of Jesus. But it is not known what kind of gospel work she did.

**for you:** This indicates that Mary’s work benefited the believers in Rome.

## Romans 16:7

### **Section 16:1–24: Paul greeted the believers in Rome**

In this section, Paul told the believers to welcome Phoebe when she arrived in Rome and to help her. It is likely that Phoebe carried this letter to Rome.

Then Paul greeted a number of believers whom he had already met. He often used an encouraging description of the person he was greeting.

Then he encouraged the believers in Rome to welcome one another. He warned them to watch out for people who cause divisions or create problems among the believers. He told them to avoid such people. He reminded them that such people only do things for their own selfish interests. He reminded the believers in Rome that people in many places know that the believers obey God well. He encouraged them by saying that God would soon defeat Satan. He blessed them with the grace of Jesus.

He relayed greetings to them from people who were there with him.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

Final Instructions and Greetings (ESV)

He greeted them and instructed them one last time

Paul greeted the believers there

#### 16:7a

##### **Greet Andronicus and Junia, my fellow countrymen and fellow prisoners.**

- Greet<sup>(plur)</sup> Andronicus and Junia for me, people of my country/people-group, and they were prisoners like me.
- Give my greetings of respect to Andronicus and Junia. They are Jews just as I am. They spent time in prison, like I did.

**Andronicus:** This name refers to a man.

**Junia:** There are two ways to interpret the Greek word that the BSB translates as Junia:

1. It is the Roman woman’s name Junia, as in the BSB. (BSB, NIV11, GNT, NRSV, KJV, ESV, NABRE, NLT, NET, REB, NCV)
2. It is the Roman man’s name Junias, as in the RSV. (RSV, NIV84, NJB, NASB, GW, CEV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1), because the UBS5 supports it. Moo, Longenecker, Cranfield, Dunn, and Jewett also support it.

**fellow countrymen:** Here this word refers to people (men and women) who are Jews, like Paul. The BDAG defines the word here as “belonging to the same

people group.” Here are other ways to translate this word:

fellow Jews (NIV11)

compatriots (NET)

**fellow prisoners:** This phrase indicates either that:

1. Andronicus and Junia were in prison together with Paul.
2. They were in prison for the same reason as Paul (that is, preaching the gospel), but not at the same time.

There is no record or tradition about this. If possible, translate in a way that allows both meanings, as fellow prisoners does in English. Otherwise translate following one or the other meanings. For example:

they were prisoners as I was

who were in prison with me (GNT)

#### 16:7b

**They are outstanding among the apostles,**

- They are prominent/notable among the apostles,
- They are very good apostles among all the apostles.

**They are outstanding:** There are several ways to interpret the Greek word that the BSB translates as outstanding:

1. It indicates that Andronicus and Junia were really good apostles. For example:

they are prominent (NRSV) (BSB, RSV, NIV, NJB, KJV, NASB, NRSV, NABRE, GW, REB, NCV)

1. It indicates that other believers respected them as much or more than the other apostles. For example:

They are highly respected (NLT) (NLT, CEV)

1. It indicates that other believers knew of them as much as the other apostles. For example:

they are well known (GNT) (GNT, ESV, NET)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1), because the BDAG supports the Greek word meaning “very good” in comparison to others.

**among:** There are several ways to interpret the Greek word that the BSB translates as among:

1. It indicates that Andronicus and Junia were apostles. For example:

among the apostles (NRSV) (BSB, RSV, NIV, GNT, NJB, KJV, NASB, NRSV, NABRE, NLT, GW, REB, NCV)

1. It indicates that Andronicus and Junia were not apostles. For example:

by the apostles (CEV) (CEV, ESV, NET)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1), because Moopage 923. and other scholars say that the Greek word that is often translated “in” means among here.

**apostles:** The Greek word that the BSB translates as apostles means “representatives” or “messengers.” It refers to people whom someone sends with his authority. They are sent to give a message or accomplish a particular task. Here, the word apostles refers to the original eleven plus others, like Paul, Andronicus, and Junia, to whom Jesus gave the work of apostle. See how you translated the word “apostle” in 1:1.

#### 16:7c

**and they were in Christ before I was.**

- and they were believers in Christ before I was.
- They believed in Jesus Christ before I did.

**they were in Christ before I was:** This indicates that Andronicus and Junia believed in Jesus before Paul believed in Jesus. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

became followers of Christ before I did (NLT)

They were in Christ before me (ESV)

**Christ:** This is a title for God’s chosen one. See how you translated it in 1:1 or 16:5.

This refers to Jesus. In some languages, including the name Jesus is more natural or more clear. For example:

Jesus Christ



## Romans 16:8

### Section 16:1–24: Paul greeted the believers in Rome

In this section, Paul told the believers to welcome Phoebe when she arrived in Rome and to help her. It is likely that Phoebe carried this letter to Rome.

Then Paul greeted a number of believers whom he had already met. He often used an encouraging description of the person he was greeting.

Then he encouraged the believers in Rome to welcome one another. He warned them to watch out for people who cause divisions or create problems among the believers. He told them to avoid such people. He reminded them that such people only do things for their own selfish interests. He reminded the believers in Rome that people in many places know that the believers obey God well. He encouraged them by saying that God would soon defeat Satan. He blessed them with the grace of Jesus.

He relayed greetings to them from people who were there with him.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

Final Instructions and Greetings (ESV)

He greeted them and instructed them one last time

Paul greeted the believers there

### 16:8

#### Greet Ampliatus, my beloved in the Lord.

- Greet<sup>(plur)</sup> Ampliatus, one whom I love in the name of the Lord.
- Give my greetings of respect to Ampliatus. He is my dear brother in our<sup>(incl)</sup> Lord Jesus.

**Ampliatus:** There is a textual issue in 16:8: (1) Some Greek manuscripts have the word Ampliatus (BSB, RSV, NIV, GNT, NJB, NASB, NABRE, ESV, REB, NLT, GW, NET, NCV). (2) Some Greek manuscripts have the word Amplias (KJV only). It is recommended that you follow option (1). This name refers to a man.

**my beloved in the Lord:** See how you translated my beloved in 16:5.

**in the Lord:** See how you translated this phrase in 16:2a.

## Romans 16:9

### Section 16:1–24: Paul greeted the believers in Rome

In this section, Paul told the believers to welcome Phoebe when she arrived in Rome and to help her. It is likely that Phoebe carried this letter to Rome.

Then Paul greeted a number of believers whom he had already met. He often used an encouraging description of the person he was greeting.

Then he encouraged the believers in Rome to welcome one another. He warned them to watch out for people who cause divisions or create problems among the believers. He told them to avoid such people. He reminded them that such people only do things for their own selfish interests. He reminded the believers in Rome that people in many places know that the believers obey God well. He encouraged them by saying that God would soon defeat Satan. He blessed them with the grace of Jesus.

He relayed greetings to them from people who were there with him.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

Final Instructions and Greetings (ESV)

He greeted them and instructed them one last time

Paul greeted the believers there

### 16:9a

#### Greet Urbanus, our fellow worker in Christ,

- Greet Urbanus, a co-worker with us<sup>(excl)</sup> working for Christ,
- Give my greetings of respect to Urbanus. He does the same work as we do for Jesus Christ.

**Urbanus:** This name refers to a man.

**our fellow worker in Christ:** See how you translated the similar phrase (“my fellow workers in Christ Jesus”) in 16:3.

### 16:9b

#### and my beloved Stachys.

- and Stachys, one whom I love.
- Also give my greetings of respect to Stachys. He is my dear brother in the Lord.

**my beloved:** See how you translated this phrase in 16:8.

**Stachys:** This name refers to a man.

## Romans 16:10

### Section 16:1–24: Paul greeted the believers in Rome

In this section, Paul told the believers to welcome Phoebe when she arrived in Rome and to help her. It is likely that Phoebe carried this letter to Rome.

Then Paul greeted a number of believers whom he had already met. He often used an encouraging description of the person he was greeting.

Then he encouraged the believers in Rome to welcome one another. He warned them to watch out for people who cause divisions or create problems among the believers. He told them to avoid such people. He reminded them that such people only do things for their own selfish interests. He reminded the believers in Rome that people in many places know that the believers obey God well. He encouraged them by saying that God would soon defeat Satan. He blessed them with the grace of Jesus.

He relayed greetings to them from people who were there with him.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

Final Instructions and Greetings (ESV)

He greeted them and instructed them one last time

Paul greeted the believers there

### 16:10a

#### Greet Apelles, who is approved in Christ.

- Greet<sup>(plur)</sup> Apelles, whom God has approved in Christ.
- Give my greetings of respect to Apelles. He was tested in his faith in Christ and God approved him.

**Apelles, who is approved in Christ:** The words who is approved in Christ further describe Apelles. To make it a description, some languages must avoid the word who. For example:

Apelles. He is approved in Christ

**Apelles:** This name refers to a man.

**who is approved in Christ:** This clause is passive. Some languages must use an active clause. For example:

whom God approved in Christ

Apelles. God approved him in Christ

**approved in Christ:** The Greek word that the BSB translates as approved refers to accepting something as genuine or good based on testing it. BDAG, sense 1. The words in Christ probably imply that Apelles was tested in his faith in Jesus and stayed faithful to him and so God approved of him. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

tested and approved in Christ (NIV84)

who was tested and proved that he truly loves Christ (NCV)

### 16:10b

#### Greet those who belong to the household of Aristobulus.

- Greet the household of Aristobulus.
- Give my greetings of respect to the family of Aristobulus.

#### those who belong to the household of Aristobulus:

The Greek is more literally “the ones of the ones of Aristobulus.” This refers to his family, but probably not Aristobulus himself. For example:

who belong to the family of Aristobulus (ESV)

the household of Aristobulus (REB)

**Aristobulus:** This name refers to a man.

## Romans 16:11

### Section 16:1–24: Paul greeted the believers in Rome

In this section, Paul told the believers to welcome Phoebe when she arrived in Rome and to help her. It is likely that Phoebe carried this letter to Rome.

Then Paul greeted a number of believers whom he had already met. He often used an encouraging description of the person he was greeting.

Then he encouraged the believers in Rome to welcome one another. He warned them to watch out for people who cause divisions or create problems among the believers. He told them to avoid such people. He reminded them that such people only do things for their own selfish interests. He reminded the believers in Rome that people in many places know that the believers obey God well. He encouraged them by saying that God would soon defeat Satan. He blessed them with the grace of Jesus.

He relayed greetings to them from people who were there with him.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

Final Instructions and Greetings (ESV)

He greeted them and instructed them one last time

Paul greeted the believers there

#### 16:11a

##### **Greet Herodion, my fellow countryman.**

- Greet<sup>(plur)</sup> Herodion, a person/man of my country/people-group.
- Give my greetings of respect to Herodion. He is a Jew just as I am.

**Herodion:** This name refers to a man.

**fellow countryman:** See how you translated this phrase in 16:7.

#### 16:11b

##### **Greet those from the household of Narcissus who are in the Lord.**

- Greet the people of the household of Narcissus who believe in the Lord.
- Give my greetings of respect to the family of Narcissus.

**those from the household of Narcissus who are in the Lord:** Like at 16:10, the words from the household of refers to the family of Narcissus but not Narcissus himself. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

those in the Lord who belong to the family of Narcissus (ESV)

those of the household of Narcissus who are in the Lord's fellowship (REB)

the believers in the Lord living in the house of Narcissus

**Narcissus:** This name refers to a man.

**who are in the Lord:** The phrase in the Lord indicates here that only some of the family and slaves of Narcissus believed in the Lord Jesus. See the above examples.

## Romans 16:12

### **Section 16:1–24: Paul greeted the believers in Rome**

In this section, Paul told the believers to welcome Phoebe when she arrived in Rome and to help her. It is likely that Phoebe carried this letter to Rome.

Then Paul greeted a number of believers whom he had already met. He often used an encouraging description of the person he was greeting.

Then he encouraged the believers in Rome to welcome one another. He warned them to watch out for people who cause divisions or create problems among the believers. He told them to avoid such people. He reminded them that such people only do things for their own selfish interests. He reminded the believers in Rome that people in many places know that the believers obey God well. He encouraged them by saying that God would soon defeat Satan. He blessed them with the grace of Jesus.

He relayed greetings to them from people who were there with him.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

Final Instructions and Greetings (ESV)

He greeted them and instructed them one last time

Paul greeted the believers there

#### 16:12a

##### **Greet Tryphena and Tryphosa, women who have worked hard in the Lord.**

- Greet Tryphaena and Tryphosa, laborers in the Lord.
- Give my greetings of respect to Tryphaena and Tryphosa. They work hard for our<sup>(incl)</sup> Lord.

**Tryphena and Tryphosa:** These names refer to women.

**women who have worked hard in the Lord:** The Greek is more literally “the ones presently working hard in the Lord.” It indicates that Tryphaena and Tryphosa were working hard for the gospel of Jesus when Paul wrote this letter. But it is not known what kind of work they did.

**women who have worked hard:** This word is based on the same Greek word translated “worked-hard/labored” in 16:6. The word here means “people who work-hard/labor.”

**in the Lord:** Here this phrase indicates that the work is for the Lord.

### 16:12b

**Greet my beloved Persis, who has worked very hard in the Lord.**

- Greet Persis, one whom we love. She has labored much in the Lord.
- Give my greetings of respect to Persis, loved by many. She worked very hard for our<sup>(incl)</sup> Lord.

**my beloved:** This indicates that Paul and others loved Persis as a Christian sister. Translate the word beloved as you did in 16:5 or 16:9. Note that Paul did not use my here, but the BSB has added it to make the meaning clearer.

**Persis:** This name refers to a woman.

**who has worked very hard in the Lord:** This further describes Persis. For the correct meaning in some languages, the translator must avoid the word who here. For example:

She has worked very hard in the Lord

**has worked very hard:** The Greek is more literally “labored much.” See how you translated this phrase in 16:6.

**in the Lord:** This phrase indicates that Persis’ work was through the Lord and for him. It was Christian ministry of some kind.

## Romans 16:13

### Section 16:1–24: Paul greeted the believers in Rome

In this section, Paul told the believers to welcome Phoebe when she arrived in Rome and to help her. It is likely that Phoebe carried this letter to Rome.

Then Paul greeted a number of believers whom he had already met. He often used an encouraging description of the person he was greeting.

Then he encouraged the believers in Rome to welcome one another. He warned them to watch out for people who cause divisions or create problems among the believers. He told them to avoid such people. He reminded them that such people only do things for their own selfish interests. He reminded the believers in Rome that people in many places know that the believers obey God well. He encouraged them by saying that God would soon defeat Satan. He blessed them with the grace of Jesus.

He relayed greetings to them from people who were there with him.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

Final Instructions and Greetings (ESV)

He greeted them and instructed them one last time

Paul greeted the believers there

### 16:13a

**Greet Rufus, chosen in the Lord,**

- Greet Rufus. He is an excellent believer in the Lord.
- Give my greetings of respect to Rufus. He is a very good follower of the Lord.

**Rufus:** This name refers to a man.

**chosen:** There are several ways to interpret the Greek word that the BSB translates as chosen:

1. It means excellent here. For example:

outstanding (GNT) (RSV, GNT, NASB, GW, REB, CEV, NCV)

1. It means chosen here, as in the BSB. (BSB, NIV, ESV, NJB, NABRE, NRSV, KJV, NLT, NET)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). But if the major language version follows interpretation (2), you may want to follow that.

**in the Lord:** This phrase indicates that Rufus was chosen because of a connection to the Lord. The exact kind of connection in this case is not stated.

### 16:13b

**and his mother, who has been a mother to me as well.**

- Greet his mother also. She has been like a mother to me.
- Give my greetings of respect to his mother. She is like a mother to me.

**his mother, who has been a mother to me as well:**

The word who further describes Rufus’ mother. To make it a description, some languages must avoid the word who. For example:

his mother. She has been a mother to me as well.

**who has been a mother to me as well:** The Greek is literally “and mine.” It indicates that Rufus’ mother was like a mother to Paul as well. Your translation should indicate or imply that Rufus’ mother was not

Paul's actual mother. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

who has been like a mother to me also (NCV)

whom I also count as my mother Kankanaey Back Translation on TW.

This woman is like a mother to me too. Otomi Back Translation on TW.

## Romans 16:14

### Section 16:1–24: Paul greeted the believers in Rome

In this section, Paul told the believers to welcome Phoebe when she arrived in Rome and to help her. It is likely that Phoebe carried this letter to Rome.

Then Paul greeted a number of believers whom he had already met. He often used an encouraging description of the person he was greeting.

Then he encouraged the believers in Rome to welcome one another. He warned them to watch out for people who cause divisions or create problems among the believers. He told them to avoid such people. He reminded them that such people only do things for their own selfish interests. He reminded the believers in Rome that people in many places know that the believers obey God well. He encouraged them by saying that God would soon defeat Satan. He blessed them with the grace of Jesus.

He relayed greetings to them from people who were there with him.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

Final Instructions and Greetings (ESV)

He greeted them and instructed them one last time

Paul greeted the believers there

### 16:14a

**Greet Asyncritus, Phlegon, Hermes, Patrobas, Hermas,**

- Greet Asyncritus and Phlegon and Hermes and Patrobas and Hermas
- Give my greetings of respect to Asyncritus, Phlegon, Hermes, Patrobas, Hermas,

### Asyncritus, Phlegon, Hermes, Patrobas, Hermas:

These five names refer to men.

### 16:14b

**and the brothers with them.**

- and the brothers and sisters with them.
- and the fellow believers who meet with them to worship.

**the brothers with them:** This indicates that the five men named in 16:14a and these brothers are all part of one group of believers. They probably met in someone's house to worship. These words probably do not indicate that they all lived in one house.

**brothers:** This word refers to believers, both men and women. The word indicates a close relationship between believers because God has made them his (adopted) children. See how you translated this word in 1:13 or 15:30.

## Romans 16:15

### Section 16:1–24: Paul greeted the believers in Rome

In this section, Paul told the believers to welcome Phoebe when she arrived in Rome and to help her. It is likely that Phoebe carried this letter to Rome.

Then Paul greeted a number of believers whom he had already met. He often used an encouraging description of the person he was greeting.

Then he encouraged the believers in Rome to welcome one another. He warned them to watch out for people who cause divisions or create problems among the believers. He told them to avoid such people. He reminded them that such people only do things for their own selfish interests. He reminded the believers in Rome that people in many places know that the believers obey God well. He encouraged them by saying that God would soon defeat Satan. He blessed them with the grace of Jesus.

He relayed greetings to them from people who were there with him.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

Final Instructions and Greetings (ESV)

He greeted them and instructed them one last time

Paul greeted the believers there

**16:15a****Greet Philologus and Julia, Nereus and his sister,**

- Greet Philologus and Julia and Nereus and his sister
- Give my greetings of respect to Philologus, Julia, Nereus, his sister,

**Philologus:** This is a man's name.

**Julia:** This is a woman's name.

**Nereus and his sister:** Here the word sister refers to Nereus' actual sister.

**16:15b****and Olympas and all the saints with them.**

- and Olympas and all God's holy people with them.
- Olympas, and all the other people whom God has made holy who meet with them to worship.

**Olympas:** This is a man's name.

**all the saints with them:** This indicates that the people named in 16:15a and these saints are all part of one group of believers. They probably met in someone's house to worship. These words probably do not indicate that they all lived in one house.

**saints:** The Greek word that the BSB translates as saints is literally "holy (ones)." It can mean "holy people," "people dedicated/consecrated to God," or "people whom God has made holy." Here it probably implies all of these meanings. In the New Testament, this word refers to all Christians, not to any special group of Christians. See how you translated this word in 1:7 or 16:2.

Paul did not imply here that this group was more holy than the group of believers he mentions in 16:14b. Your translation should not indicate or imply that this group was more holy than the group of believers in 16:14b.

**Romans 16:16****Section 16:1–24: Paul greeted the believers in Rome**

In this section, Paul told the believers to welcome Phoebe when she arrived in Rome and to help her. It is likely that Phoebe carried this letter to Rome.

Then Paul greeted a number of believers whom he had already met. He often used an encouraging description of the person he was greeting.

Then he encouraged the believers in Rome to welcome one another. He warned them to watch out for people who cause divisions or create problems among the believers. He told them to avoid such people. He reminded them that such people only do things for their own selfish interests. He reminded the believers

in Rome that people in many places know that the believers obey God well. He encouraged them by saying that God would soon defeat Satan. He blessed them with the grace of Jesus.

He relayed greetings to them from people who were there with him.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

Final Instructions and Greetings (ESV)

He greeted them and instructed them one last time

Paul greeted the believers there

**16:16a****Greet one another with a holy kiss.**

- ¶ Greet each other with a kiss that is holy.
- ¶ Whenever you meet, greet each other in a way that shows you are God's people.

**a holy kiss:** The word kiss refers to the kind of kiss between relatives or friends. See Jewett (pages 972–974). This kiss is holy because it is a gesture of friendship and unity, it is done between God's holy people, and it does not have any sexual connotations.

If the word kiss is not known in your area, or if it is only a gesture of a sexual nature, you may want to:

- Translate literally and explain its meaning in a footnote. For example:

This kiss is holy because it was a gesture of friendship and unity. It was done between God's holy people, and it was not sexual.

- Use the common gesture of friendship or unity in your area. You may then want to explain the literal word in a footnote. For example:

Literally "holy kiss." This kiss is holy because it was a gesture of friendship and unity, it was done between God's holy people, and it was not sexual.

- Translate the meaning of the gesture in a general way. For example:

Greet each other sincerely as loving brothers and sisters in God's family. You may then want to explain the literal word in a footnote. For example:

Literally “holy kiss.” This kiss is holy because it was a gesture of friendship and unity, it was done between God’s holy people, and it was not sexual.

### 16:16b

#### All the churches of Christ send you greetings.

- All the communities of believers greet you<sup>(plur)</sup>.
- The other groups of believers send greetings to you.

**All the churches of Christ:** Paul spoke in general here.

**the churches:** See how you translated the word “church” in 16:1.

## Romans 16:17

### Section 16:1–24: Paul greeted the believers in Rome

In this section, Paul told the believers to welcome Phoebe when she arrived in Rome and to help her. It is likely that Phoebe carried this letter to Rome.

Then Paul greeted a number of believers whom he had already met. He often used an encouraging description of the person he was greeting.

Then he encouraged the believers in Rome to welcome one another. He warned them to watch out for people who cause divisions or create problems among the believers. He told them to avoid such people. He reminded them that such people only do things for their own selfish interests. He reminded the believers in Rome that people in many places know that the believers obey God well. He encouraged them by saying that God would soon defeat Satan. He blessed them with the grace of Jesus.

He relayed greetings to them from people who were there with him.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

Final Instructions and Greetings (ESV)

He greeted them and instructed them one last time

Paul greeted the believers there

### 16:17a

#### Now I urge you, brothers, to watch out for those who create divisions

- ¶ Brothers and sisters, I urge you to be watching for people who cause believers to divide/separate over arguments

- ¶ My fellow believers, I encourage you to beware of people who start quarrels to make you divide into groups/factions.

**Now:** This Greek conjunction introduces a new topic. Some English versions leave it implicit.

**I urge you, brothers:** In some languages it is more natural to begin with the term of address brothers. For example:

Brothers and sisters, I urge you (GW)

**I urge you:** The Greek word that the BSB translates as urge has a wide range of meaning. Many scholars believe it means “exhort” here, rather than “command” or “beg.” Here are other ways to translate this clause:

I appeal to you (ESV)

I encourage you (GW)

See how you translated this clause in 12:1 or 15:30.

**brothers:** Here this word refers to all the believers living in Rome, both men and women. The word indicates a close relationship between believers because God has made them his (adopted) children. See how you translated this word in 1:13 or 15:30.

**watch out for:** This is a warning to be looking for people who cause divisions among the believers in Rome. If they see such people, they are to avoid them (16:17c). Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

be on your guard against (NJB)

beware of Kankanaey Back Translation on TW.

**those who create divisions:** This refers to people who come into the group of believers and start arguments about the way people should live as Christians. They cause the believers to separate from believers who have a different opinion about the issue. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

those who cause people to be against each other (NCV)

divides the church (CEV)

people who cause-you-to-separateKankanaey  
Back Translation on TW.

This is a general warning. Paul did not imply here that these kind of people were already doing this in Rome.

#### 16:17b

**and obstacles that are contrary to the teaching you have learned.**

- and put stumbling blocks that go against the teachings that you learned earlier.
- They cause hindrances/difficulties in your faith that oppose the teachings of Christ that you have already learned.

**and obstacles:** This is a second thing that these people “who create divisions” (16:17a) cause.

**obstacles:** The Greek word that the BSB translates as obstacles is often translated “stumbling block(s).” Here (and in those places) it refers to something that causes someone to have problems in their faith. It is like someone stumbling over a root and perhaps falling. In this case it could be a false teaching or something similar causing someone to have problems with their faith. Here are other ways to translate this word:

difficulties (RSV)

hindrances (NASB)

upset people’s faith (GNT)

See how you translated the word obstacles in 14:13 (“stumbling block”).

**the teaching you have learned:** This Greek phrase refers to teachings of the gospel of Jesus Christ, as taught by the apostles and other church leaders.

#### 16:17c

**Turn away from them.**

- Stay/Keep away from them.
- If you see them, have nothing to do with them.

**Turn away from them:** If the believers see the kind of people described in 16:17a–b, they must not associate with them. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

Stay away from them (CEV)

Distance yourselves from themKankanaey Back  
Translation on TW.

### Romans 16:18

#### Section 16:1–24: Paul greeted the believers in Rome

In this section, Paul told the believers to welcome Phoebe when she arrived in Rome and to help her. It is likely that Phoebe carried this letter to Rome.

Then Paul greeted a number of believers whom he had already met. He often used an encouraging description of the person he was greeting.

Then he encouraged the believers in Rome to welcome one another. He warned them to watch out for people who cause divisions or create problems among the believers. He told them to avoid such people. He reminded them that such people only do things for their own selfish interests. He reminded the believers in Rome that people in many places know that the believers obey God well. He encouraged them by saying that God would soon defeat Satan. He blessed them with the grace of Jesus.

He relayed greetings to them from people who were there with him.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

Final Instructions and Greetings (ESV)

He greeted them and instructed them one last time

Paul greeted the believers there

#### 16:18a

**For such people are not serving our Lord Christ, but their own appetites.**

- For people like them do not serve our Lord Christ; no, they serve their own appetites.
- For that kind of people do not work for our Lord Jesus Christ. Rather, they work only to satisfy the desires of their own bodies.

**For:** This Greek word introduces an explanation for the command to “avoid them” (16:17c). Some English versions omit this word and leave the connection with 16:17 implicit.

**serving:** Here this word refers to doing what a leader tells someone to do. These men do not do what the Lord Jesus says to do. Instead they do what their own appetites tell them to do. Here are other ways to translate this word:



do his will

do the things that he commands us to do

See how you translated this word in 7:6.

**our Lord Christ:** This refers to Jesus. It emphasizes that he is the Christ, the Savior. In some languages the name Jesus must be included to make it natural. For example:

our Lord Jesus Christ

**but their own appetites:** The words “they serve” is implied here. Some languages must make those words explicit. For example:

instead, they serve their own appetites

**appetites:** Here this word refers to natural desires of the body. Paul implied that these appetites were unworthy to serve because he contrasted it to serving Christ.

The Greek is literally “stomach.” Other languages may similarly use an idiom. For example:

belly (TLV)

bodiesKankanaey Back Translation on TW.

heartsUma Back Translation on TW.

#### 16:18b

**By smooth talk and flattery they deceive the hearts of the naive.**

- They talk really well and flatter others and so deceive the hearts of people who do not suspect others of lying to them.
- They speak with fine/fair words, and they praise people and so deceive those who do not expect others to be bad people.

**smooth talk:** This refers to the speech of someone who talks well and people enjoy listening to him talk. Here it implies talk that easily sways people to believe his bad ideas.

**flattery:** The Greek word here refers to praising someone for selfish purposes.

**the hearts:** Here the word hearts refers to where emotions, will, and desires occur. Some languages use a different place in the body for this. For example:

the liver

the insides

In some languages it is the mind that is deceived, rather than the heart. For example:

the minds (NIV)

the thinking

**naive:** The Greek word refers to people who do not suspect that others are trying to deceive them. Here are other ways to translate this word:

unsuspecting (NASB)

unwary (NJB)

easily deceived

### Romans 16:19

#### Section 16:1–24: Paul greeted the believers in Rome

In this section, Paul told the believers to welcome Phoebe when she arrived in Rome and to help her. It is likely that Phoebe carried this letter to Rome.

Then Paul greeted a number of believers whom he had already met. He often used an encouraging description of the person he was greeting.

Then he encouraged the believers in Rome to welcome one another. He warned them to watch out for people who cause divisions or create problems among the believers. He told them to avoid such people. He reminded them that such people only do things for their own selfish interests. He reminded the believers in Rome that people in many places know that the believers obey God well. He encouraged them by saying that God would soon defeat Satan. He blessed them with the grace of Jesus.

He relayed greetings to them from people who were there with him.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

Final Instructions and Greetings (ESV)

He greeted them and instructed them one last time

Paul greeted the believers there

### 16:19a

**Everyone has heard about your obedience, so I rejoice over you.**

- For news of your<sup>(plur)</sup> obedience has reached everyone; therefore, I rejoice concerning you.
- People everywhere have heard that you are obedient, and so I am happy about you.

Here the Greek word that is often translated as “for” occurs at the beginning of 16:19a. The BSB omits this word. It introduces an explanation or a basis for something in 16:18, Moo (page 931). or supports the exhortation in 16:17–18. Cranfield (page 802).

**Everyone has heard about your obedience:** The Greek is literally “your obedience has reached to all.” It implies news of their obedience reaching all people. For example:

everyone knows that you are obedient to the Lord (NLT)

**so:** The Greek word here usually means “therefore.” Here is another way to translate this:

therefore (NASB)

### 16:19b

**But I want you to be wise about what is good**

- I want you to be wise regarding good things
- I want you to be wise in what things are good,

**But:** This introduces contrast between Paul’s concern about wanting them to be wise and him rejoicing over them (16:19a).

**be wise about what is good:** The word wise refers to skillful application of knowledge to a situation or deed. Paul wanted these people to discern what is truly good.

### 16:19c

**and innocent about what is evil.**

- and be completely uninvolved with evil deeds.
- and let your life be not contaminated with evil deeds.

**innocent about what is evil:** The Greek word that the BSB translates as innocent refers to being pure in their thinking and actions. The phrase indicates that these

people should not let their purity get contaminated by evil in any way. Here are other ways to translate this word:

not have anything to do with evil (CEV)

let your deeds be not contaminated with evil

## Romans 16:20

### Section 16:1–24: Paul greeted the believers in Rome

In this section, Paul told the believers to welcome Phoebe when she arrived in Rome and to help her. It is likely that Phoebe carried this letter to Rome.

Then Paul greeted a number of believers whom he had already met. He often used an encouraging description of the person he was greeting.

Then he encouraged the believers in Rome to welcome one another. He warned them to watch out for people who cause divisions or create problems among the believers. He told them to avoid such people. He reminded them that such people only do things for their own selfish interests. He reminded the believers in Rome that people in many places know that the believers obey God well. He encouraged them by saying that God would soon defeat Satan. He blessed them with the grace of Jesus.

He relayed greetings to them from people who were there with him.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

Final Instructions and Greetings (ESV)

He greeted them and instructed them one last time

Paul greeted the believers there

### 16:20a

**The God of peace will soon crush Satan under your feet.**

- So have nothing to do with the false teachers. Then in that way God who causes us to live in peace with each other will soon destroy Satan’s power.

**The God of peace:** The word of indicates here that God gives peace. He causes others to have peace. The whole phrase describes the one true God. It does not imply that there are many gods and there is one that gives peace.

**peace:** This word refers to having no conflicts with other people or with God. The Greek word may also indicate wholeness or well-being. The BDAG (pages 287–288) has two main senses: (1), “a state of concord, peace, harmony”; (2), “a state of well-being, peace.” They list this verse under (2) but as a specialized sense: “nearly synonymous with messianic salvation.” But neither Louw-Nida nor Liddell-Scott have such a specialized sense.

See how you translated this word in 1:7 or 15:33.

**crush Satan under your feet:** The word crush is used figuratively to refer to completely defeating Satan. The words under your feet indicate that believers will also gain victory over Satan by this deed of God.

In some languages a literal translation will not have the correct meaning. If that is true in your language, translate the meaning. For example:

completely defeat Satan for you

**Satan:** The word Satan is the Hebrew name of the leader of all the evil spirits. In Hebrew his name means “enemy.” He is the enemy of God and God’s people. Here are some ways to translate Satan:

- Use a local name or idiom that refers to the chief of all demons.
- Use a descriptive phrase. For example:

the chief/leader of the evil spirits

the spirit enemy of God

- Borrow the common language word and spell it as someone in your area would say it. If this word is not already known in your area, you may also want to add a descriptive phrase. For example:

Satanas, the ruler of demons

Saitan

If you have translated the gospels, see how you translated this word in Matthew 4:10, Mark 1:13, Luke 10:18, or John 13:27.

## 16:20b

**The grace of our Lord Jesus Christ be with you.**

- I ask that the grace of our Lord Jesus be with you.
- I pray that the kindness of our Lord Jesus will continue to be with you.

**(NIV:) The grace of our Lord Jesus be with you:** There is a textual issue here. Some Greek manuscripts add the word “Christ” after the name Jesus:

1. Do not include this word here. (NIV, GNT, NASB, NLT, GW, CEV, NET, REB, NCV)
2. Include this word here. For example:

The grace of our Lord Jesus Christ be with you  
(RSV) (BSB, RSV, NJB, ESV, KJV)

It is recommended that you follow option (1), because the UBS Greek NT 5 says it is certain that option (1) is the correct reading.

This is an indirect request. Paul asked God to give this grace to the believers in Rome while speaking to them. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

I pray that the grace of our Lord Jesus will be with you all

I request that grace of our Lord Jesus be with you all

I desire that grace of our Lord Jesus will be with you all

See how you translated a similar clause in 15:13 or 15:33.

**grace:** This word refers to kindness that is given to people without requiring anything in return. This kindness is not given because they have done anything to deserve it. See how you translated this word in 1:5 or 12:6.

## Romans 16:21

**Section 16:1–24: Paul greeted the believers in Rome**

In this section, Paul told the believers to welcome Phoebe when she arrived in Rome and to help her. It is likely that Phoebe carried this letter to Rome.

Then Paul greeted a number of believers whom he had already met. He often used an encouraging description of the person he was greeting.

Then he encouraged the believers in Rome to welcome one another. He warned them to watch out for people who cause divisions or create problems among the believers. He told them to avoid such people. He reminded them that such people only do things for their own selfish interests. He reminded the believers in Rome that people in many places know that the be-

lievers obey God well. He encouraged them by saying that God would soon defeat Satan. He blessed them with the grace of Jesus.

He relayed greetings to them from people who were there with him.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

Final Instructions and Greetings (ESV)

He greeted them and instructed them one last time

Paul greeted the believers there

### 16:21a

**Timothy, my fellow worker, sends you greetings,**

- ¶ My co-worker Timothy greets you<sup>(plur)</sup>,
- ¶ Timothy, who works together with me, gives greetings to you.

**Timothy, my fellow worker, sends you greetings:**

There is a textual issue in 16:21: (1) Some Greek manuscripts have the word he-greets (BSB, RSV, NIV, GNT, NJB, NASB, NABRE, ESV, REB, NLT, GW, NET, NCV). (2) Some Greek manuscripts have the word they-greet (KJV only). It is recommended that you follow option (1). This phrase indicates that Timothy did the same work as Paul, evangelizing in various places and helping the believers there. Sometimes they worked together in the same place and sometimes they worked separately. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

my co-worker (NIV11)

he does the same work in Christ Jesus as me

See how you translated my fellow worker in 16:9.

### 16:21b

**as do Lucius, Jason, and Sosipater, my fellow countrymen.**

- and my kinsmen Lucius, Jason, and Sosipater do too.
- Lucius, Jason and Sosipater, my relatives/fellow-Jews, also give greetings to you.

**fellow countrymen:** The Greek word, can mean either (1) relatives, or (2) fellow citizens.

Some languages must choose one or the other meaning. It is not clear which meaning is more appropriate

here. You may want to follow the major language version here.

## Romans 16:22

**Section 16:1–24: Paul greeted the believers in Rome**

In this section, Paul told the believers to welcome Phoebe when she arrived in Rome and to help her. It is likely that Phoebe carried this letter to Rome.

Then Paul greeted a number of believers whom he had already met. He often used an encouraging description of the person he was greeting.

Then he encouraged the believers in Rome to welcome one another. He warned them to watch out for people who cause divisions or create problems among the believers. He told them to avoid such people. He reminded them that such people only do things for their own selfish interests. He reminded the believers in Rome that people in many places know that the believers obey God well. He encouraged them by saying that God would soon defeat Satan. He blessed them with the grace of Jesus.

He relayed greetings to them from people who were there with him.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

Final Instructions and Greetings (ESV)

He greeted them and instructed them one last time

Paul greeted the believers there

### 16:22

**I, Tertius, who wrote down this letter, greet you in the Lord.**

- It is I, Tertius, who wrote the words of Paul in this letter. I greet you<sup>(plur)</sup> in the Lord.
- I, Tertius, wrote this letter from Paul to you. I also give greetings to you in the Lord.

**I, Tertius, who wrote down this letter, greet you in the Lord:**

The words who wrote down this letter further describe Tertius. In some languages it is more natural or more clear to translate without using who. For example:

I, Tertius, wrote down this letter, and I greet you in the Lord

**I, Tertius, who wrote down this letter:** This implies that Tertius wrote what Paul spoke/dictated.

**I:** In Greek this is emphatic. For example:

I myself, Tertius, who wrote this letter

**greet you in the Lord:** This indicates that Tertius greeted the believers in Rome as a fellow believer.

## Romans 16:23

### Section 16:1–24: Paul greeted the believers in Rome

In this section, Paul told the believers to welcome Phoebe when she arrived in Rome and to help her. It is likely that Phoebe carried this letter to Rome.

Then Paul greeted a number of believers whom he had already met. He often used an encouraging description of the person he was greeting.

Then he encouraged the believers in Rome to welcome one another. He warned them to watch out for people who cause divisions or create problems among the believers. He told them to avoid such people. He reminded them that such people only do things for their own selfish interests. He reminded the believers in Rome that people in many places know that the believers obey God well. He encouraged them by saying that God would soon defeat Satan. He blessed them with the grace of Jesus.

He relayed greetings to them from people who were there with him.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

Final Instructions and Greetings (ESV)

He greeted them and instructed them one last time

Paul greeted the believers there

### 16:23a

**Gaius, who has hosted me and all the church, sends you greetings.**

- Gaius greets you<sup>(plur)</sup>. He is my host, and he is host to the whole church here.
- Gaius gives greetings to you. He accommodates me in his home. He also accommodates all the believers for worship.

**Gaius, who has hosted me and all the church, sends you greetings:** The words who has hosted me and all

the church further describe Gaius. In some languages it is more natural or more clear to translate without using who. For example:

Gaius has hosted me and all the church, and he greets you

**Gaius, who has hosted me:** This indicates that Paul stayed in Gaius's house at that time.

**hosted...all the church:** This phrase refers to Gaius providing a room for all the believers in Corinth to meet. For example:

in whose house the church meets (GNT)

the whole church into his home (CEV)

host of the whole congregation (REB)

### 16:23b

**Erastus, the city treasurer, sends you greetings, as does our brother Quartus.**

- Erastus, the treasurer of this city, greets you. Our brother Quartus also greets you.
- The one who takes care of the money of this city, Erastus, gives greetings to you. A fellow believer, Quartus, also gives greetings to you.

**the city treasurer:** This refers to someone who manages the money of a city. He receives taxes, fees, and payments and pays for work done such as buildings and roads.

**our brother:** The Greek is more literally “the brother.” Here in this list of fellow believers, it probably indicates that Quartus is also a fellow believer.

## Romans 16:24

### Section 16:1–24: Paul greeted the believers in Rome

In this section, Paul told the believers to welcome Phoebe when she arrived in Rome and to help her. It is likely that Phoebe carried this letter to Rome.

Then Paul greeted a number of believers whom he had already met. He often used an encouraging description of the person he was greeting.

Then he encouraged the believers in Rome to welcome one another. He warned them to watch out for people who cause divisions or create problems among the believers. He told them to avoid such people. He reminded them that such people only do things for their own selfish interests. He reminded the believers

in Rome that people in many places know that the believers obey God well. He encouraged them by saying that God would soon defeat Satan. He blessed them with the grace of Jesus.

He relayed greetings to them from people who were there with him.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

Final Instructions and Greetings (ESV)

He greeted them and instructed them one last time

Paul greeted the believers there

#### 16:24

**The grace of our Lord Jesus Christ be with you all. Amen.]**

- [I ask that the grace of our Lord Jesus be with you. Amen.]
- [I pray that the kindness of our Lord Jesus will continue to be with you. It is true.]

**[The grace of our Lord Jesus Christ be with you all. Amen.]:** There is a textual issue here. 16:24 was added in some of the later Greek manuscripts. It is similar to 16:20b. It is good to include this verse only as a footnote, as many English versions do. Here is an example footnote:

Only some of the later Greek manuscripts include 16:24, which reads: The grace of our Lord Jesus Christ be with you all. Amen.

If the major language version in your area includes this verse in the text, you may want to include it in brackets. The NASB does that. The Display also does that.

If you put 16:24 in a footnote, here are several ways to number the verses:

- Put the number 24 after the number 23. Put the footnote marker after the last sentence. For example:

<sup>23-24</sup>Gaius, who is host to me and to the whole church, greets you. Erastus, the city treasurer, and our brother Quartus, greet you.\*

- Put in the number 24 after the last sentence of 16:23, and put the footnote marker after the number. For example:

<sup>23</sup>Gaius, who is host to me and to the whole church, greets you. Erastus, the city treasurer, and our brother Quartus, greet you. <sup>24\*</sup>

- Do not include the number 24. Put the footnote marker after the last sentence. For example:

<sup>23</sup>Gaius, who is host to me and to the whole church, greets you. Erastus, the city treasurer, and our brother Quartus, greet you.\*

For notes on how to translate “The grace of our Lord Jesus be with you,” see 16:20b. For a note on how to translate Amen, see 15:33.

## Romans 16:25

### Section 16:25–27: Paul glorified God

In this section, Paul finished his letter by describing how God is able to strengthen the believers in Rome, and the purpose of that strengthening. Lastly, he said that God should have glory, as a praise to him.

In the Greek these verses are all one long sentence. It may be more clear for your readers if you break it up into shorter sentences. There is an example of this in the second meaning lines in the Display. See also the General Comment at the end of 16:27 below.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

Paul’s Closing Prayer (CEV)

Doxology (ESV)

Concluding Prayer of Praise (GNT)

#### 16:25a–27

In 16:25–27 there is no main verb. The form of the sentence indicates that Paul was declaring that God should get glory (16:27). The rest of the sentence (16:25–26) describes how God strengthens believers. It is also a reason for declaring that God should have glory (16:27). See the General Comment on 16:25a–27 about how to translate this praise to God which was interrupted by a long description.

#### 16:25a

#### Now to Him who is able to strengthen you

- ¶ Now glory should go to him who is able to make you stronger in faith,
- ¶ So then, there is one who is able to cause you to stand strong even more in your believing.

**Now:** This introduces Paul's words of 16:25–27. It does not mean “at the present time.”

**to Him:** The verb that normally goes before a to-phrase in English does not occur until 16:27: “be glory.” See the General Comment note there.

**strengthen:** This refers to making the believers in Rome strong in their faith. See how you translated this word in 1:11.

#### 16:25b

**by my gospel and by the proclamation of Jesus Christ,**

- which is in accordance with my gospel, that is, the preaching about Jesus Christ.
- What I just said is in agreement with the good news that I preach. That good news is the preaching about Jesus Christ.

**by my gospel:** There are two ways to interpret the Greek word that the BSB translates as by:

1. It indicates that the gospel tells us that God strengthens believers. For example:

in accordance with the gospel that I preach (NJB)  
(RSV, NIV11, GNT, NJB, ESV, NABRE, KJV, NASB, NET, REB)

1. It indicates that the gospel is the means by which God strengthens believers. For example:

by the Good News that I tell people (NCV) (BSB, NIV, GW, CEV, NCV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1), because many English versions support it.

Here are other ways to translate this phrase according to interpretation (1):

just as my gospel says

**my gospel:** This refers to the gospel that Paul preached. It is the gospel (“good news”) about Jesus Christ. This phrase does not imply that Paul preached something different from the other apostles. For example:

the Good News that I tell people (NCV)

**and by the proclamation of Jesus Christ:** The Greek word that the BSB translates as and can also mean “that is.” The word of can mean that Jesus Christ

proclaimed or that someone proclaimed about Jesus Christ. These two interpretation issues relate to each other. Here are the two main options:

1. That Greek word means that is here and the word of means that someone proclaimed about Jesus Christ. For example:

which is the message about Jesus Christ (CEV)  
(NIV11, GNT, CEV)

1. That Greek word means and here and the word of means that Jesus Christ proclaimed. This seems to be the natural way to take the phrase “preaching of,” which many translations use here. (RSV, ESV, KJV, NASB)

Some English versions, like the BSB, have the proclamation of Jesus Christ here (See also NIV, NJB, NABRE, NET, REB). This phrase is similar to “the preaching of Jesus Christ,” but it is not very clear which way to take the of when following proclamation.

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). But if the major language version follows interpretation (2), you may want to follow that.

#### 16:25c

**according to the revelation of the mystery concealed for ages past**

- It is in accordance with the now-revealed mystery that was secret for a very long time
- It is in agreement with the ages-old secret that

**according to the revelation of the mystery:** Here the words according to indicate that “my gospel” and “the proclamation of Jesus Christ” is in agreement with this mystery that has now been revealed. For example:

in keeping with the revelation of the mystery  
(NIV11)

**the revelation of the mystery:** The word revelation indicates that what was a mystery has now been understood. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

the mystery...that has now been revealed

the mystery...that God has now revealed

**mystery:** The Greek word that the BSB translates as mystery refers to truth or knowledge that people have not discovered on their own. Someone else reveals it to them. Here are other ways to translate this word:

secret (NCV)

hidden truth

something that was not made known previously

See how you translated this word in 11:25.

**concealed for ages past:** This clause is passive. Some languages must use an active clause. For example:

that God concealed for ages past

**ages past:** Here the word ages refers to long periods of time. An “age” is often characterized by something. For example: the Bronze Age was the period of time when bronze was the common metal used. The ages here are not named, so just refer to long periods of time, hundreds or even thousands of years. For example:

long, long periods of time

very big groups of years

Your translation should not use number words like “hundreds” or “thousands,” because this word should be allowed to be very general.

## Romans 16:26

### Section 16:25–27: Paul glorified God

In this section, Paul finished his letter by describing how God is able to strengthen the believers in Rome, and the purpose of that strengthening. Lastly, he said that God should have glory, as a praise to him.

In the Greek these verses are all one long sentence. It may be more clear for your readers if you break it up into shorter sentences. There is an example of this in the second meaning lines in the Display. See also the General Comment at the end of 16:27 below.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

Paul’s Closing Prayer (CEV)

Doxology (ESV)

Concluding Prayer of Praise (GNT)

### 16:26a but now revealed

- but which has now been revealed.
- God has now revealed.

**but now revealed:** This clause is passive. Some languages must use an active clause. For example:

he has now revealed

**now:** Here this word refers generally to this new period of time where the revelation of Jesus as the Christ/Messiah is known.

**revealed:** The Greek word here refers to making something visible. God has caused the knowledge that was unknown (16:25c: the mystery) to now be known. Here are other ways to translate this word:

disclosed (ESV)

brought out into the open (GNT)

### 16:26b and made known through the writings of the prophets

- It has now been made known to people through the writings with their prophecies.
- God has now made this/that mystery known through the holy writings and the prophecies in them.

**and:** This word connects “now revealed” (16:26a) and “made known” (16:26b).

**made known through the writings of the prophets:** In some English versions, the phrase through the writings of the prophets is first in the clause to emphasize it. For example:

through the prophetic writings has been made known (ESV)

Some languages must have it in its usual place, as the BSB models.

**made known:** This clause is passive. Some languages must use an active clause. For example:

he has made known

**through the writings of the prophets:** Here the word through introduces how the mystery was made known to the nations. God revealed it in these writings.



**the writings of the prophets:** This refers to the prophecies that were written in the Hebrew Bible, what many Christians now call the Old Testament. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

the holy writings with its prophecies

the writings/books of God and their prophecies

In some languages a literal translation would not clearly imply the Old Testament. If that is true in your language, you may want to explain in a footnote. Here is an example footnote:

This refers to the prophecies in the Old Testament.

#### **16:26c by the command of the eternal God,**

- It is in accordance with what the eternal God commanded,
- The forever-existing God commanded it to be made known in that way,

**by the command of the eternal God:** The Greek word that the BSB translates as by means both:BDAG κατά 5.a.δ.

1. that the event of God making the mystery known happened as the command of God said it would.
2. that the event of God making the mystery known happened because God commanded it to happen.

Some languages may be able to indicate both meanings. But many languages will have to choose to translate one or the other meaning. For example:

as the eternal God commanded (NJB)

because the eternal God commanded it

**the eternal God:** The word eternal indicates that God always existed in the past and will always exist in the future.

#### **16:26d in order to lead all nations to the obedience that comes from faith—**

- for all people groups to obey because of their faith.
- so that all tribes obey him because they believe in him.

**in order to lead...to the obedience that comes from faith:** The words in order to introduce the purpose

of Paul's gospel and the preaching of Jesus Christ (16:25b) being made known (16:26b). The purpose was that the people would obey Jesus because they believe in him. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

for the obedience of faith (KJV)

to the obedience that is associated with faith (GW)

so that...obey in faith (NJB)

**in order to:** Here the phrase in order to introduce the purpose of God making known the mystery that was "concealed for ages past" (16:25c).

**the obedience that comes from faith:** See how you translated this phrase in 1:5.

**all nations:** The singular word "nation" here refers to a group of people united by a common language and culture. It is also sometimes used to refer a group of these groups organized under one government. Use a word that allows both meanings.

Some languages must choose between those two meanings. If that is true in your language, refer to the first kind of group, a group of people united by a common language and culture.

## **Romans 16:27**

### **Section 16:25–27: Paul glorified God**

In this section, Paul finished his letter by describing how God is able to strengthen the believers in Rome, and the purpose of that strengthening. Lastly, he said that God should have glory, as a praise to him.

In the Greek these verses are all one long sentence. It may be more clear for your readers if you break it up into shorter sentences. There is an example of this in the second meaning lines in the Display. See also the General Comment at the end of 16:27 below.

Here are other possible headings for this section:

Paul's Closing Prayer (CEV)

Doxology (ESV)

Concluding Prayer of Praise (GNT)

**16:27**

**to the only wise God be glory forever through Jesus Christ! Amen.**

- To the only God who is wise should go glory forever through Jesus Christ! Amen.
- He is the only wise God. May glory belong to him because of what Jesus Christ did! It is true.

**to the only wise God be glory forever:** This resumes what Paul was about to say concerning God at 16:25 (“to Him...”). See the examples at the General Comment below for ways to translate with that meaning in mind.

**to the only wise God be glory:** This phrase indicates that Paul declared that God should get glory. With this saying Paul praised God. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

may there be glory to the only wise God

glory should go to the only wise God

may glory belong to the only wise God

See how you translated be glory in 11:36.

**the only wise God:** The word only indicates that the God of the Jews and Christians is the only god who is wise. It also does not claim that there are other gods.

**wise:** The word wise refers to skillful application of knowledge to a situation or deed. See how you translated this word in 1:14 or 16:19.

**glory:** The word glory refers literally to a very bright light. In this context it implies power, majesty, and greatness. Here are other ways to translate this word:

splendor

radiance

greatness

See how you translated this word in 1:23 or 11:36.

**through Jesus Christ:** The word through here indicates that God has glory because of what Jesus Christ did on earth.

**Amen:** The word Amen is a Hebrew word that means “even so” or “it is true.” The Greek borrowed the Hebrew word. English borrowed this word as well. It

is used to agree with what was said. Paul wrote this expecting his readers to agree as well. See how you translated this word in 1:25 or 15:33.

**General Comment on 16:25a–27**

16:25b–26d is a description of how God is able to strengthen believers and also says things about the gospel, its revelation and purpose. It interrupts Paul declaring that God should get glory (“to him...to the only wise God be glory”).

This is one sentence of 52 words in the Greek (and one sentence of 73 words in the BSB). In some languages it is not natural to interrupt the main point with a long description. In some languages a sentence over 50 words long will be hard to understand. If either is true in your language, you may want to translate 16:25a–27 as a number of sentences. You may also want to avoid interrupting the main point. For example:

<sup>25–27</sup>Now, he is able to strengthen you by my gospel and by the proclamation of Jesus Christ. That gospel and proclamation are according to the revelation of the mystery that was concealed for ages past but now is revealed. That gospel and proclamation have been made known through the writings of the prophets, by the command of the eternal God. The purpose is to lead all nations to the obedience that comes from faith. To him, the only wise God, be glory forever through Jesus Christ! Amen.

<sup>25–27</sup>Now, to God be glory! He is able to strengthen you by my gospel and by the proclamation of Jesus Christ. Those two things are according to the revelation of the mystery that was concealed for ages past but now is revealed. They have been made known through the writings of the prophets, by the command of the eternal God. The purpose is to lead all nations to the obedience that comes from faith. To him, the only wise God, be glory forever through Jesus Christ! Amen.